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Daniel

Daniel 1:1

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

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The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:1–2

Daniel 1:1–2 gives the setting for the first section of Daniel. It tells how God allowed the king of Babylon to defeat the king of Judah.

In Daniel 1:1–2 there are several names of people and places that may be new to your readers. Introduce this new information in a way that is natural in your language. English versions transliterate these names in different ways. It may be helpful to consult how the national translation translates them. It is good to include a map with your translation, showing the location of Babylon and Judah.

1:1a

In the third year of the reign of Jehoiakim king of Judah,

- ¶ In the third year that Jehoiakim was the king of the country of Judah,
- ¶ There was a king of Judah named Jehoiakim. When/After Jehoiakim had reigned/ruled for more than two years,
- ¶ The land of Judah had a king named Jehoiakim. He was king for almost three years,

In the third year of the reign of Jehoiakim king of Judah:

This phrase tells when the events of this chapter happened. The third year of the reign of Jehoiakim was 605 B.C. The Babylonian Chronicles record that in 605 B.C., Nebuchadnezzar won a battle at Carchemish and defeated the whole “region of Hamath” (northern Syria). He then conquered all the “Hatti country.” It was probably at that time that Judah and Jerusalem came under Nebuchadnezzar’s control. During that same year Nebuchadnezzar’s father died, and he returned to Babylon and became king in his father’s place. In those days people dated events by referring to the kings who were ruling at that time. You should translate according to this custom. For example:

During the third year of King Jehoiakim’s reign in Judah (NLT)

In the third year that Jehoiakim was king of Judah (CEV)

In the third year: Jehoiakim had ruled over Judah for more than two full years when the Babylonian army came and surrounded the city of Jerusalem. Jehoiakim’s father Josiah had died at the battle of Megiddo in 609 B.C. Jehoahaz became king in his place. Three months later, the Egyptians decided to make Jehoiakim the king of Judah in the place of Jehoahaz. Daniel 1:1 says that the story began in the third year of Jehoiakim’s reign. However Jeremiah 25:1, 9 and 46:2 indicate that Nebuchadnezzar became king in the fourth year of Jehoiakim’s reign. The difference between these two texts is probably due to the different ways people counted the first year a king began to reign. In Egypt and Palestine, the months between the king’s accession to the throne and the following New Year were counted as “year one.” In Babylonia, the months between the king’s accession to the throne until the New Year were not counted as part of the first year. The first year of a king’s reign started at the New Year. (See Lucas, pp. 50–51.) So Daniel may have been following the Babylonian way of counting, while Jeremiah followed the Palestinian way of counting.

the reign: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as reign refers to the period of time when a king rules. In some languages it may be natural to translate this using a verb. For example:

Jehoiakim reigned/ruled over Judah

Jehoiakim king of Judah: In some languages it may be natural to place Jehoiakim's title before his name. For example:

King Jehoiakim, the ruler of Judah

the king of Judah, Jehoiakim

Jehoiakim is also mentioned in 2 Kings 23:34–24:6 and 2 Chronicles 36:4–8. See how his name is spelled there. He had a son named Jehoiachin (2 Kings 24:8 and 2 Chronicles 36:9). You should be careful how you spell these two names so that people do not confuse them.

king: The title king normally refers to the hereditary ruler of a country. If your culture is not familiar with the word king, you may have to use a different word. In some languages people use the word “chief” or “big man” to describe a person who fills this role.

Judah: The tribe of Judah was originally one of the twelve tribes that had formed the united kingdom of Israel. But several hundred years before, Judah and another tribe (Benjamin) had left the united kingdom and formed a new kingdom with their own king. Their kingdom was called Judah.

1:1b

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came to Jerusalem

- Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, came/marched against the city of Jerusalem.
- the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, led his army to Jehoiakim's city, Jerusalem.
- and then King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylonia and his soldiers/men attacked its capital city Jerusalem.

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came to Jerusalem: The text implies that Nebuchadnezzar came to Jerusalem with his army in order to attack it. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this by saying:

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came to Jerusalem with his army

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon marched on Jerusalem

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon: Nebuchadnezzar was the ruler of Babylonia from 605 to 562 B.C. Babylonia was a large nation to the east of Israel. In some languages it may be natural to put the king's title before his name. For example:

the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar

King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon

Nebuchadnezzar: The name Nebuchadnezzar also occurs in 2 Kings 24:1, Ezra 1:7, Esther 2:6, and Jeremiah 21:2. If you have translated any of those books, translate it as you did there.

king of Babylon: Babylon was the capital city of Babylonia and the Babylonian Empire. Nebuchadnezzar ruled from the city of Babylon over the whole of Babylonia. In some languages it may be more natural to name the country rather than the city. For example:

King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylonia (GNT)

Both terms, Babylon and Babylonia, are correct. Sometimes, as here, people used the name of the city as a political term to refer to the whole country. In many cases it will be best to use the same name that the majority language translation uses.

The ancient land of Babylonia included the southern part of the modern country called Iraq. This land extended approximately from the city Baghdad in the north to the city of Basra in the south. In the west, it extended approximately to the modern border of Saudi Arabia. On the east, it bordered the modern country of Iran. You may want to include a map to help your readers locate this ancient country.

The ancient city of Babylon was located in what is today the suburbs of the city of Baghdad. This is where Nebuchadnezzar built his palace. The city had many temples and beautiful gardens. The city was so beautiful that people called it one of the Seven Wonders of the World.

Babylon: In the Hebrew language, Babylon is called Babel. The Bible mentions Babel in Genesis 10:10 and 11:9, when the people of the east tried to build a tower that would reach up to heaven. The name of the city Babylon also occurs in Psalm 137:1. The name of the country Babylonia occurs in Joshua 7:21 and Isaiah 11:11.

came to Jerusalem: Jerusalem was the capital city of the kingdom of Judah. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit in some way. There are at least two options:

- Supply this information in the text. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar came to the capital city of Jerusalem

- Include the information in a footnote or book introduction.

Use the appropriate option for your language situation.

The city of Jerusalem is mentioned many times in the Bible. See how you referred to it in Psalm 51:18, Mark 1:5, Luke 2:22, or John 1:19.

1:1c and besieged it.

- His soldiers surrounded it.
- They camped around the city in order to force its people to surrender.

besieged it: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as besieged means “encircled, blockaded.” In those days, armies often surrounded a city before they attacked it. In this way they could stop the people in the city from getting food and supplies. They wanted the people to surrender without fighting. Other ways to translate this include:

surrounded it with his army (NCV)

laid siege (NET)

surrounded it in order to make the inhabitants surrender
Translator’s Handbook on Daniel.

In some languages it may not be necessary to use two separate verbs (“came” and besieged) to describe this action. It may be more natural to use just one. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar and his armies besieged Jerusalem.

General Comment on 1:1

Daniel 1:1 may contain a lot of new information for your readers. Some languages introduce new information and new characters in a certain way. Introduce them in a way that is natural in your language. You may choose to reorder some of the information and to have shorter sentences. For example:

A long time ago, there was a king of Judah named Jehoiakim. In the third year of his reign, the king of the country of Babylon decided to attack Judah. That king’s name was Nebuchadnezzar. King Nebuchadnezzar sent his soldiers to Jerusalem, the

capital of Judah. They surrounded the city and prepared to attack it.

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1:2a

And the Lord delivered into his hand Jehoiakim king of Judah,

- The Lord gave Nebuchadnezzar victory/power over Jehoiakim, the king of Judah,
- Then the Lord God allowed Nebuchadnezzar to defeat/conquer Jehoiakim and the people of Judah.

And the Lord delivered into his hand Jehoiakim king of Judah:

The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates literally as the Lord delivered into his hand Jehoiakim king of Judah is a figure of speech. It

indicates that God allowed Nebuchadnezzar to defeat Jehoiakim and gain power over him. Some other ways to translate this are:

the Lord delivered King Jehoiakim of Judah into his power (NET)

The Lord gave him victory over King Jehoiakim (NLT)

This verse does not mean that Nebuchadnezzar personally defeated or captured Jehoiakim. His soldiers did the actual fighting under his command. So in some languages it may be necessary to say something like:

And the Lord allowed his men/soldiers to defeat Jehoiakim

the Lord: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the Lord is one of the titles that the Bible uses to refer to the God of Israel. It means “master.” This title is different from the personal name for God, Yahweh, which the BSB usually spells as “the LORD,” with all capital letters. See how you translated this title in Genesis 4:4b, 6a.

Jehoiakim king of Judah: The author also used the phrase king of Judah to refer to Jehoiakim in 1:1a. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat this information here. If that is true in your language, you can refer to him in a different way, for example:

King Jehoiakim (GNT)

Jehoiakim (CEV)

1:2b

along with some of the articles from the house of God.

- and the Lord gave Nebuchadnezzar control/possession of some of the things/objects that were in the temple of God.
- And he allowed Nebuchadnezzar’s men/soldiers to take/steal some treasures from the temple/building where the people of Judah worshiped God.

along with some of the articles from the house of God: This phrase indicates that the Lord also allowed Nebuchadnezzar power over some religious items used in the worship of God. This happened when Nebuchadnezzar’s army looted or stole some of the valuable objects that were in the temple of God in

Jerusalem. In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea with another verb. For example:

The Lord gave him victory over King Jehoiakim of Judah and permitted him to take some of the sacred objects from the Temple of God. (NLT)

The Lord let him capture King Jehoiakim and seize some of the Temple treasures. (GNT)

some of the articles: The Babylonians took possession of some of the things that were in the Jewish temple. For the kinds of articles see 2 Chronicles 36:7, 10, 18; Jeremiah 52:17–23 (586 B.C.); Ezra 1:9–11 (537 BC). They did not take them all, and the Hebrews continued to worship at the temple. However, about twenty years later (in 586/7 B.C.) the Babylonians attacked the city again. At that time they took all the things that were left in the temple and carried them away to Babylon. They also destroyed the temple itself.

articles: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as articles is a general word that can refer to a variety of items. In this context, the word is used to refer to objects the Jewish people used in worship rituals. These objects included cups, bowls, lampstands, altars, and tables. These articles were very valuable. The Israelites had made some of them from gold or silver. Some other ways to describe these things in English are:

Temple treasures (GNT)

the things (NCV)

objects

vessels (RSV)

the house of God: Here the phrase the house of God refers to the building where Jewish people worshiped God in Jerusalem. Here is another way to translate this:

the temple of God (NIV)

See the key term “temple” in KBT.

1:2c

He carried these off to the land of Shinar, to the house of his god,

- Nebuchadnezzar brought these things back to the temple/house of his god in the city of Babylon, in the land of Shinar.
- When they went back to their own land Shinar, they carried these things with them to the temple/building of the false god whom Nebuchadnezzar worshiped.

He carried these off: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as carried...off can mean “brought” or “carried,” depending on the context. Here is another way to translate this:

he brought them (RSV)

King Nebuchadnezzar did not bring or carry anything himself. He ordered his servants and soldiers to transport everything back to his country. So it may be natural to say:

He ordered that these be taken

He caused them to be brought

He caused his men to bring them

these: Scholars differ about what the Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as these refers to:

1. The pronoun these refers to the valuable articles from the temple in Jerusalem. For example:

which he carried to Babylon and put... (NCV) (BSB, NCV)

1. The pronoun these refers to the human captives. For example:

He took some prisoners back with him (GNT)

Most English translations leave the pronoun ambiguous. It is not clear whether the Babylonian army took Jehoiakim with them back to Babylon at this time. So it is recommended that you leave this ambiguous, referring to either the captives or the treasures or both.

to the land of Shinar, to the house of his god: Nebuchadnezzar’s men brought what they had taken from Jerusalem to their own temple in Babylon.

to the land of Shinar: The word Shinar is an ancient name for the land that later became the country of Babylonia. This land is now part of modern Iraq,

south of the city of Baghdad. Genesis 10:10 and 11:1–9 mention that the tower of Babel was in the land of Shinar. See how you translated the name there. There are several possibilities:

- Transliterate Shinar, the old name for this area. For example:

the land of Shinar (RSV)

- Use Babylonia, a later name for that land. For example:

the land of Babylonia (NLT)

- Use the name Babylon, the capital city of that land, because that is where the king’s temple was. For example:

in Babylon (GNT)

- Use the two names Shinar and Babylonia. For example:

the land of Shinar, that is, Babylonia

It is important that people do not think that Shinar was a different place from Babylonia. If this is not clear from your translation, you may want to include a footnote that mentions this information.

to the house of his god: The phrase the house of his god refers to the building where the Babylonian people worshiped their god.

There is a textual problem here. Scholars disagree about whether the phrase to the house of his god was part of the original Hebrew text:

1. Some versions include the phrase to the house of his god. For example:

to the temple of his god (NIV) (NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, BSB, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NJPS)

1. Some versions do not include the phrase to the house of his god, since they consider that this phrase was not in the original Hebrew text. For example:

These he brought to the land of Shinar, and placed the vessels in the treasury of his god. (NRSV) (NRSV, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The author probably intended to contrast the phrase house of his god (1:2c) with “house of God” (1:2b).

his god: The Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as his god here refers to the god or gods of a different, non-Jewish religion. In some languages it may not be possible to use the same word to describe the true God and other gods. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel notes that in some languages it is very difficult to use the word for God for anything other than the true God. The authors suggest that in this case translators may have to translate “the place where he worshipped” or “the house of his religion.” If that is true in your language, there are at least two possibilities:

- Use a different expression in your language that describes idols or spirits that some people worship.
- Use a general expression that refers to a supernatural being or beings that some people worship. For example:

the one they worshiped

A decision about this expression is very important, so you may need to consult with church and community leaders. When you choose an expression, check it in this context with other speakers of your language.

god: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as god is plural in form but can be either singular or plural in meaning. English versions disagree about whether they choose singular or plural:

1. god (BSB, KJV, RSV, GW, REB, CEV, NLT)
2. gods (NJB, GNT, NCV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), although the second view is also acceptable. The Babylonians did worship many different gods. Here the text probably refers to the god Marduk, the main god of the city of Babylon.

1:2d

where he put them in the treasury of his god.

- He put them in the place where he kept valuable objects. This was in the temple of the god whom he served.
- Nebuchadnezzar ordered/caused them to be placed with his other treasures in the temple of his god.

where he put them in the treasury of his god: The Babylonian king put the valuable articles mentioned in 1:2b into the treasure house of his god. In some languages it may be natural to refer to them explicitly so that readers will understand that they are the same vessels. For example:

putting the vessels in the treasury of his own gods (NJB)

put: Nebuchadnezzar ordered his servants or soldiers to place these articles in the Babylonian temple treasury. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that he did not do this personally. For example:

caused them to be put

ordered his men to place them

in the treasury of his god: The treasury was the place where the king kept the valuable objects of the kingdom of Babylon. It may be possible to indicate its purpose without saying what sort of place it was. For example:

temple treasury (GW)

The treasures or valuable objects were connected with the people’s religion or dedicated to their god. The treasury was probably in their temple. Some ways to say this in English are:

temple storerooms (GNT)

the treasury of/for the temple of his god

his god: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as his god is the same as in 1:2d. Refer back to the god or gods worshiped by the Babylonians in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 1:2c–d

In some languages it may be more natural to express this in a different way, combining 1:2c–d to avoid some of the repetition. For example:

He had them placed in the temple of his gods where the treasures were kept.

Daniel 1:3

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

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The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:3–5

King Nebuchadnezzar decided to train some of the Israelite captives to serve him in his royal court.

1:3a

Then the king ordered Ashpenaz, the chief of his court officials,

- ¶ The head of the palace staff was a man named Ashpenaz. Nebuchadnezzar commanded him
- ¶ After this the king gave orders to his head servant Ashpenaz:
- ¶ Then the king said to Ashpenaz, his chief minister,

Then: The common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces some additional information. Introduce this information in a way that is natural in your language. Some translations, such as the GNT, do not include a connector here.

the king ordered Ashpenaz, the chief of his court officials: This clause introduces Ashpenaz, a new character in the story. In some languages it may be natural to introduce him in a separate sentence. For example:

The chief of the royal officials was Ashpenaz. The king ordered him...

the king: This refers to King Nebuchadnezzar. The text has previously mentioned two kings, so in some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly:

the Babylonian king

Nebuchadnezzar

the chief of his court officials: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the chief of his court officials refers to a high official in the king’s court. The word for court officials originally referred to eunuchs (men who cannot have sexual relations). The Babylonian kings employed eunuchs to work in the palace, especially around the women of the court. But the word came to refer to any court official, and this is probably how it is used here. Other ways to translate this include:

his chief official (GNT)

the chief of staff (GW)

who was in charge of his palace officials (NLT)

1:3b

to bring in some Israelites from the royal family and the nobility—

- to choose for his service some of the Israelite youths from the king’s family and the other noble/leading families.
- “Select^(sing) some of the captives from Israel to serve me. They should/must be members of the ruling family or of other important families of Judah.
- “I want some of the members of the best families of Israel to work for me—men belonging to the king’s family and the ruling clans. Choose/Find^(sing) some men for me,

to bring in some Israelites: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as to bring in is more literally “to cause to come.” This is the same verb used in 1:2c where it describes bringing the vessels to Babylon. The king wanted his chief official to choose some Israelite men to come to his court and serve him in the government. The Hebrew text does not explicitly state where Ashpenaz was to bring the men. In some languages it may be necessary to specify a place. If that is true in your language, you may refer to the king’s palace or court. Here is another way to translate this:

to bring some of the Israelite men into his palace (NCV) Other versions specify the purpose for which the king ordered them to be brought in. For example:

to bring into the king’s service some of the Israelites (NIV)

Other ways to translate this verse part include:

to select from among the Israelite exiles some young men (GNT)

to choose some of the Israelites (NET)

some Israelites: The text literally says “from the sons of Israel.” The king wanted Ashpenaz to choose a certain number of males from any of the twelve tribes of Israel. The age of these “sons of Israel” is not stated here, but the context indicates they were to be young, probably teenagers. In some languages it may be natural to specify that these Israelites were to be males. For example:

some of the Israelite men (NCV)

From the Israelites...a certain number of boys (NJB)

The text does not explicitly say if these young men were still in Jerusalem or if they were already exiles in Babylon. There are two views:

1. Ashpenaz was to select young men from among the exiles whom the army had already brought to Babylon. Some English versions add this implied information. For example:

to select from among the Israelite exiles (GNT)

to bring to the palace some of the young men of Judah’s royal family...who had been brought to Babylon as captives (NLT) (GNT, NLT, REB)

1. The king told Ashpenaz to take these young men from their homeland to the palace in Babylon. (RSV, NRSV, KJV, GW, and NCV allow for this interpretation.)

Both interpretations are acceptable. If it is natural in your language, leave it ambiguous. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1).

from the royal family and the nobility: This phrase describes the kind of Israelites the king wanted Ashpenaz to bring to the king’s palace. The king told Ashpenaz to take young men from two groups: from the royal family of Judah and from the other important families. Other ways to translate this include:

of the royal family and of the noble families (GNT)

who were of royal and noble descent (NET)

In some languages the royal family may be considered part of the nobility. In those languages you may need to say something like:

from important families, including the family of the king of Judah (NCV)

of Judah’s royal family and other noble families (NLT)

the royal family: Ashpenaz was to choose young men who were members of the royal family of Judah. That is, he was to choose those who were closely related to the king of Judah. Some versions make it explicit that the reference is to the royal family of Judah. For example:

from the royal family of Judah (CEV)

the nobility: This refers to families of high status among the people of Judah. Other ways to translate this include:

leading Jewish families (CEV)

important families (NCV)

the clans of the elders

General Comment on 1:3

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king’s command as direct speech. For example:

Then the king gave orders to Ashpenaz, the chief of his court officials. “Bring to me some of the Israelite youths from the royal family and the other important families,” he said.

Daniel 1:4

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Paragraph 1:3–5

King Nebuchadnezzar decided to train some of the Israelite captives to serve him in his royal court.

1:4

The king told Ashpenaz to choose only qualified young men to serve in his palace. This verse lists the qualities the young men were required to have. Translate this list in a way that is natural in your language. You may use either indirect or direct speech (see also the General Comments on 1:3 and 1:4–5). It may be natural to start a new sentence here and to use two or more sentences in your translation. For example:

^{4a-b}They had to be handsome, intelligent, well-trained, quick to learn, and free from physical defects, ^{4c}so that they would be qualified to serve in the royal court. (GNT)

^{4a}King Nebuchadnezzar wanted only young Israelite men who had nothing wrong with them. They were to be handsome ^{4b}and well educated, capable of learning and understanding, ^{4c}and able to serve in his palace. (NCV)

^{4a}“Select only strong, healthy, and good-looking young men,” he said. ^{4b}“Make sure they are well versed in every branch of learning, are gifted with knowledge and good sense, ^{4c}and have the poise needed to serve in the royal palace.” (NLT)

1:4a

young men without blemish, handsome,

- He told Ashpenaz these young men should be without any physical defects and good-looking.
- Choose^(sing) only handsome and healthy young men,
- young, strong, handsome,

young men without blemish: The king wanted these young men to be in good physical condition, without any problems or handicaps that would make it hard for them to serve him.

young men: The exact age of the young men who were chosen is uncertain. This word can refer to boys from the time they were born to the time they were married. It is likely that they were from about fourteen to twenty years old. Here is another way to translate this:

youths (RSV)

without blemish: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as without blemish indicates that the young men should have no physical handicaps or weakness. See 2 Samuel 14:25, where the same Hebrew word for blemish is used. The phrase without blemish can be translated in two major ways:

- Using a positive expression. For example:

strong, healthy (NLT)

- Using a negative expression:

free from physical defects (GNT)

who had nothing wrong with them (NCV)

without any physical defect (NIV)

handsome: Each culture describes physical beauty in its own way. It is best to use a general term for a male whose appearance is considered pleasant, pleasing, or praiseworthy. For example:

good-looking (GW)

attractive (NET)

1:4b

gifted in all wisdom, knowledgeable, quick to understand,

- They should be intelligent and knowledgeable. They should also be quick/sharp-witted
- young men who are wise, well educated, and quick to learn.
- smart, educated, teachable,

In this verse part the author used three expressions that are similar in meaning.

gifted in all wisdom: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as gifted in all wisdom is more literally “having insight in all wisdom.” It probably emphasizes natural ability. Other ways to translate this include:

skilful in all wisdom (RSV)

intelligent (GNT)

smart (CEV)

knowledgeable: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as knowledgeable is more literally “knowing knowledge.” It probably refers to someone who has learned a lot of information. Other ways to translate this include:

well-trained (GNT)

well informed (NIV)

well-educated (NET)

quick to understand: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as quick to understand is more literally “discerning/understanding of knowledge.” It probably refers to the ability to quickly perceive and understand something. Other ways to translate this include:

having keen insight (NET)

quick to learn (GNT)

discerning (NJB)

1:4c

and qualified to serve in the king’s palace—

- and capable of serving in the royal palace.
- They must be able to serve in my court.
- and competent to work for me.

and qualified to serve in the king’s palace: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as qualified to serve in the king’s palace indicates that these men were to be capable of serving in Nebuchadnezzar’s court. Other ways to translate this include:

suited to serve in the royal palace (NLT)

competent to serve in the king’s palace (NRSV)

able to serve in his palace (NCV)

to serve in the king’s palace: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as to serve in the king’s palace is literally “to stand in the king’s palace,” as in the KJV. It is an idiom that refers to serving the king in some official way. Other ways to translate this include:

to serve in the royal court (GNT)

serving in the royal palace (NJPS)

entering the king’s royal service (NET)

palace: The palace was not simply the king’s house. It included a throne room where the king met ambassadors and other official visitors. There was also a large courtyard in front of the throne room and a special hall for banquets. Living quarters and storage rooms surrounded these main parts of the palace. If such palaces are not known in your area, you may be able to use a word or phrase that describes the residence of an important person. Here is another way to translate this:

royal court (GNT)

1:4d

and to teach them the language and literature of the Chaldeans.

- The king ordered Ashpenaz to teach these young men the Babylonian language. He wanted them to study the books that the Babylonians had written.
- Teach^(sing) them how to read and write our^(incl) language. Then have them study what our^(incl) people have written in books.”
- Make/Have^(sing) them learn to read and write our^(incl) Chaldean/Chaldee language, and also make/have them study Chaldean/Chaldee literature.

and to teach them the language and literature of the Chaldeans: The Hebrew text refers first to literature and then to language. The BSB reverses the order of the two words. This is more natural in English. Order these words in the way that is most natural in your language.

language: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as language is literally “tongue.” Here it is probably used as a figure of speech to refer to speaking, reading, and writing in a particular language. The Babylonian language, Akkadian, used a different writing system than Hebrew did.

literature: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as literature is literally “book.” Those who advised the king had to study and know the Babylonian texts. Other ways to translate this include:

the learning (KJV)

the writings (REB)

the Chaldeans: The Hebrew name that the BSB translates as Chaldeans can indicate different groups, depending on the context. Here it apparently refers to the people of Babylonia in general. Your language may have a special way to refer to an ethnic group of people. Translate this group name in a way that is natural in your language.

There are several possibilities for translating this name:

- Use a name that refers to the Babylonian people. For example:

the Babylon people

the Babylonians (GW)

- Use a name that is based on the name Chaldeans. For example, “the Chald people” or “Chaldea people.” Here is another way to translate this:

the Chaldeans (NRSV)

- Include a reference to both of the names above. For example,

the Chaldeans, that is, the Babylonians

- Use a pronoun referring to the Babylonians. Use the appropriate pronoun for direct or indirect speech. For example:

their language

our language (CEV)

Since Babylon was already mentioned in 1:1, translating the word Chaldeans as “Babylonians” here may be the best choice. However, if the church in your area prefers the name Chaldeans, you may want to include a footnote. The footnote should explain that these two names refer to the same people.

Daniel 1:5

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:3–5

King Nebuchadnezzar decided to train some of the Israelite captives to serve him in his royal court.

1:5a

The king assigned them daily provisions of the royal food and wine.

- The king also commanded his servants to give the young men each day the same kind of special food and wine that he himself ate and drank.
- The king also arranged for the young men to receive good food and wine from the royal table/kitchens every day.
- Every day give^(sing) them the same food and wine that I receive.

The king assigned them daily provisions of the royal food and wine:

King Nebuchadnezzar arranged for the young men to receive the same food and drink as he and his court received. The palace servants prepared food and drink for the use of the king’s family and courtiers. The king ordered them to give this same

food and drink to the Hebrew captives. Other ways to translate this include:

The king assigned them a daily ration of food and wine from his own kitchens (NLT)

The king also gave orders that every day they were to be given the same food and wine as the members of the royal court (GNT)

The king: This refers to King Nebuchadnezzar.

assigned: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as assigned indicates that the king ordered his servants to give the food to the Hebrew youths. See the General Comment on 1:4-5 for a suggestion as to how to translate this order using direct speech.

them: The pronoun them refers to the young men that Ashpenaz had chosen in 1:3-4.

daily provisions: The young men were to receive royal food and wine each day. The Hebrew text does not emphasize the amount or quantity. It was not necessarily rationed or limited. Here is another way to translate this:

every day (GNT)

the royal food and wine: This refers to food and wine of the same type that the king ate and drank. It does not refer to food that the king left on his plate for them. Other ways to translate this include:

they were to be given the same food and wine as the members of the royal court (GNT)

from his royal delicacies and from the wine that he himself drank (NET)

This food and wine was probably more expensive and delicious than the food that other people ate. Try to use an expression that refers to such food. For example:

special food and wine from the royal table/kitchens

food: The word that the BSB translates as food is an unusual Persian loan-word that here refers to high-quality food such as wealthy people might eat. Another way to translate this is:

delicacies (NET)

wine: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wine refers to an alcoholic drink that people make from a fruit called “grapes.” People usually drank wine on special occasions, especially when there was a celebration or feast.

In some areas, there is no wine that is made from grapes. In that case, there are several options for translation:

- Use a general term for “fermented drink.” To distinguish wine from beer, “fermented (fruit) juice” is a possibility.

Avoid a word that would contradict the qualities of real wine. For example, do not use a word referring to a drink made from a different fruit or a drink made from grain.

- Use a word for imported bottled wine. If there is no local word for this, you may use the word from the national or trade language.
- Use a descriptive phrase, for example: “drink/juice made from the fruit called grapes.”

Use the option that is most appropriate for your language in this context.

1:5b

They were to be trained for three years,

- The king told Ashpenaz to train the young men for three years.
- The young men were to continue their training for three years.
- Educate/Train^(sing) them in this way for three years,

They were to be trained for three years: The king wanted the young men from Judea to receive teaching for three years. He ordered Ashpenaz to arrange for this education.

They were to be trained is a passive verb. It may be more natural in your language to use an active verb and supply the subject. The subject might be Ashpenaz himself or, more likely, teachers he chose. Ashpenaz or these other teachers were to educate the young men for a period of three years. The goal was that after three years the young men would be competent enough to become the king’s officials and serve him in his court. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

They were to be educated for three years. (ESV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

They were to receive an education lasting for three years. (NJB)

Teachers were to teach them for three years.

1:5c

after which they were to enter the king's service.

- At the end of that time, they would be ready to serve the king.
- After that, they would be ready to serve the king as his special advisors.
- and then they can begin to serve me in my court."

after which: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as after which here refers to the completion of the three years of training. Other ways to translate this include:

and then (CEV)

At the end of that time (NET)

they were to enter the king's service: This is literally "they were to stand before the king," as in the RSV. This is an idiom. See the note on "serve in the king's palace" in 1:4c. The idiom has at least two possible meanings in this context:

1. It means "they were to become court officials." These men would advise the king when he had important decisions to make. Here is another way to translate this:

advisors in the royal court (NLT) (BSB, NASB, GW, REB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NIV, CEV, NLT, NET, NRSV)

1. It means "they were to present themselves to the king," that is, to be tested. For example:

to appear before the king (GNT) (GNT)

The ESV, RSV, and KJV translate the idiom literally. It is recommended that you follow option (1), as do most English versions.

General Comment on 1:5b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine 1:5b–c into one clause with one main verb. For example:

After three years of this training they were to enter the king's service.

General Comment on 1:4–5

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's commands as a direct quotation. For example:

^{4a}The king said, "They must be healthy, handsome, ^{4b}smart, wise, educated, ^{4c}and fit to serve in the royal palace. ^{4d}Teach them how to speak and write our language, ^{5a}and give them the same food and wine that I am served. ^{5b}Train them for three years, ^{5c}and then they can become court officials." (CEV)

Daniel 1:6

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase "the Lord delivered" ("Adonay gave" in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase "God had granted" ("Elohim had given" in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase "God gave" ("Elohim gave" in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:6–7

In this paragraph the author introduces the main characters of this chapter, Daniel and his three friends.

1:6

Among these young men were some from Judah: Daniel, Hananiah, Mishaël, and Azariah.

- ¶ In the group selected for this training were some young men of Judah named Daniel, Hananiah, Mishaël, and Azariah.
- ¶ Among these young men were some from the tribe of Judah. These included Daniel, Hananiah, Mishaël, and Azariah.

- ¶ So Ashpenaz chose some young men to train. Four of them were the Judeans Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.

The Hebrew text introduces 1:6 with a word that means “And it happened.” This word introduces some important information, the identities and names of the main characters in the narrative. Some English versions leave this word untranslated. You should introduce these new important characters in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Now (NASB)

As it turned out (CEV)

Among these young men were some from Judah: Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah: Ashpenaz chose some young men in accordance with the king’s instructions. Among these young men were four Judeans named Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. These four were not the only ones from Judea who were chosen. See the General Comment at the end of 1:6. These four men are the main characters in the following narrative. Other ways to introduce them include:

Among these were Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah of the tribe of Judah (ESV)

Among them were the Judaeans Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah. (NJB)

Four of the young Jews chosen were Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, all from the tribe of Judah. (CEV)

Among these young men: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Among these young men more literally means “among them.” The pronoun “them” refers to the young men from Israel whom Ashpenaz chose to serve King Nebuchadnezzar. The NIV adds that these were “were chosen” and the BSB adds that they were young men. You may wish to supply one or both of these ideas in your translation but it is not necessary if the meaning is clear without supplying that. Some possible ways to translate this phrase are:

Four of the young Jews chosen (CEV)

Among those who were chosen (NIV)

among these young men (NET)

some from Judah: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as some from Judah is more literally “from the sons of Judah.” These were young men from the tribe of Judah. The NJB refers to them as “Judeans.”

Your language may have a special way of referring to a people group or tribe. For example, some languages can say something like “Juda people.” Translate the name of this people group in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel: In Hebrew, people’s names often have meanings. This name means “God is my judge.” You may want to put this meaning in a footnote.

Hananiah: In Hebrew this name means “Yahweh has acted graciously.” You may put this meaning in a footnote.

Mishael: Scholars are uncertain about the meaning of this name. Most think it means “Who is what God is?” Again, you may suggest this meaning in a footnote.

Azariah: In Hebrew this name means “Yahweh has helped.” You may want to put the meaning of this name in a footnote.

General Comment on 1:6

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information describing the young men. This may help to indicate that these four young men were not the only ones chosen from the tribe of Judah. For example:

Among them were Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, from the tribe of Judah. (NRSV)

Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah were four of the young men chosen, all from the tribe of Judah. (NLT)

Daniel 1:7

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among

these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:6–7

In this paragraph the author introduces the main characters of this chapter, Daniel and his three friends.

1:7a

The chief official gave them new names:

- The chief of the royal staff changed their names.
- The chief of staff, Ashpenaz, gave each of them new/different names.
- He gave them all Babylonian names.

The chief official: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as chief in this verse is different from the word that it translates as chief in 1:3a. However, the meaning is similar, and the title probably refers to the same person (Ashpenaz). See the note on 1:3a. Other ways to translate this include:

the commander of the officials (NASB)

The chief of staff (NLT)

the head of the palace staff

gave them new names: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as gave them new names is literally “gave them names.” The four men already had Hebrew names, so the BSB has supplied the word new. You may wish to follow the BSB or say:

gave them Babylonian names (CEV)

gave them other names (NRSV)

1:7b

To Daniel he gave the name Belteshazzar; to Hananiah, Shadrach;

- He changed Daniel’s name to Belteshazzar and Hananiah’s name to Shadrach.

- He gave Daniel the name Belteshazzar. He gave Hananiah the name Shadrach.
- Daniel received the name Belteshazzar, and Hananiah received the name Shadrach.

The Babylonians gave the young men Babylonian names as a symbol of their authority over them. They wanted the Israelites to forget about their land and their God and adopt a new identity as Babylonians. The new names probably referred to Babylonian gods. But the meaning of the new names is not always clear. The Jewish scribes who copied the Hebrew text sometimes changed names that praised pagan gods.

To Daniel he gave the name Belteshazzar: The chief official gave each of the Hebrew captives Babylonian names. The name he gave to Daniel was Belteshazzar. You should distinguish the spelling of Belteshazzar from the similar sounding name “Belshazzar” in Daniel 5. Daniel’s new name means “may Bel protect his life” or “protect the life of the prince.” Bel was the name of one of the Babylonian gods. You may put the meaning of this name in a footnote.

to Hananiah, Shadrach: Hananiah received the Babylonian name of Shadrach. Scholars are uncertain about the meaning of this new name.

1:7c

to Mishael, Meshach; and to Azariah, Abednego.

- He changed Mishael’s name to Meshach, and Azariah’s name to Abednego.
- He gave Mishael the name Meshach, and he gave Azariah the name Abednego.
- Mishael received the name Meshach, and Azariah received the name Abednego.

to Mishael, Meshach: Mishael received the Babylonian name of Meshach. The commentators also disagree about the meaning of the name Meshach. Some think that it is connected with the Babylonian god Marduk. You may put this information in a footnote.

and to Azariah, Abednego: The name may mean “servant of Nego” or “servant of the shining one.” Nego was the name of another Babylonian god. You may put this information in a footnote.

General Comment on 1:7

Consider how it is natural to indicate that the action of “giving a new name” refers to each of the four young men. In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb for each individual. For example:

^{7a}And the chief of the eunuchs gave them names:

^{7b}Daniel he called Belteshazzar, Hananiah he

called Shadrach,^{7c} Mishaël he called Meshach, and Azariah he called Abednego. (ESV)

Daniel 1:8

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:8–10

Daniel decided not to eat the royal food. He did not want to become ritually impure or unclean.

1:8a

But Daniel made up his mind that he would not defile himself with the king’s food or wine.

- ¶ But Daniel did not want to become ritually unclean. So he decided not to eat the same kind of food that the king ate or drink the same kind of wine that the king drank.
- ¶ Daniel, however, made the decision to refuse the food and the wine that the king provided for him. He wanted to remain pure/clean to worship God.

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* here indicates a contrast between what the king planned in 1:5a and what Daniel decided to do. However, the two verses are separated by other information. In some languages there may be a different way of contrasting ideas that are not immediately next to each other. Indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel made up his mind: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as *made up his mind* is literally

“set in his heart.” This is an idiom. It means to make a firm decision. Some ways to say this in English are:

Daniel determined (REB)

Daniel made up his mind (GNT)

Daniel decided (CEV)

he would not defile himself: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *defile himself* refers here to religious defilement. A Jewish person became defiled when he came into contact with anything impure and forbidden by the Law of Moses. A person who was defiled was considered ritually unclean. He could not worship God with the rest of the community.

Scholars are not certain why Daniel believed that eating the king’s food would defile him. Jewish laws forbade them to eat certain foods, such as the meat of pigs. For example, Leviticus 3:17; 11:1–47. See Collins, p. 142. He explains that “Daniel’s objection to the royal food is in the spirit of the biblical laws insofar as it is concerned with purity and defilement, even though it goes beyond the specific prohibitions of the Torah.” The Babylonians, however, cooked and ate such foods. For example, the Babylonians ate pork and horse meat (Baldwin, p. 83), but according to Jewish law it was taboo to eat the flesh of these animals. The Jews also required that all the blood be drained from meat (Lev. 17:10–14). However, Baldwin (p. 83) argues that there was no law against wine. Also, the Babylonians offered their food to idols. The servants probably offered the king’s food and wine to their Babylonian gods before they served it to the king.

Also, Daniel knew that if he ate the king’s food, it would imply that he agreed to obey the king and his policies. He believed that if he ate the king’s food, it would not please the one true God.

- Consider how to communicate the idea of religious impurity or defilement for your culture. In some languages it may be necessary to say something like:

not to let himself become ritually unclean (GNT)

to eat and drink only what God had approved for his people to eat (CEV)

Use an expression that communicates this idea in your language. Avoid expressions that people would apply only to the worship of pagan gods or spirits. You

will probably need to check your translation carefully with different speakers to be sure you have communicated the correct idea.

with the king's food or wine: This is almost the same expression that was used in 1:5a, and you should translate in a similar way here. See the notes on 1:5a. For example:

with the royal rations of food and wine (NRSV)

with the king's food, or with the wine that he drank (ESV)

with the royal delicacies or the royal wine (NET)

General Comment on 1:8a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 1:8a–b. For example:

Daniel decided not to eat the king's food or drink his wine because that would make him unclean. (NCV)

1:8b

So he asked the chief official for permission not to defile himself.

- So he/Daniel asked the chief of staff to allow him to avoid the food and drink that would make him ritually unclean.
- So Daniel appealed to Ashpenaz, "Please excuse^(sing) me from eating or drinking anything that would make me impure/unclean in our^(excl) religion/worship."

So he asked the chief official for permission not to defile himself: Daniel asked Ashpenaz to excuse him from eating the king's food and drinking the king's wine. He said he did not want to make himself unclean by doing this. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

He asked the chief official for permission not to defile himself by doing this.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces the result of 1:8a. Because Daniel had decided not to defile himself, he asked the chief official for permission not to eat the king's food. Other ways to translate this include:

therefore (RSV)

and (NIV)

Express the connection in a natural way in your language.

he asked the chief official for permission not to defile himself: Daniel asked for permission not to do something. That is, he asked permission to avoid something. Other ways to translate this include:

He asked the chief of staff for permission not to eat these unacceptable foods (NLT)

he asked the chief official to excuse him from eating the defiling food (see REB)

he asked permission from the chief official to refrain from eating food that would make him unclean

asked: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as asked literally means "to seek." Daniel was seeking permission to avoid something that he believed to be wrong or harmful.

the chief official: This expression is also used in 1:7a. See the note there. Here again it refers to Ashpenaz. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. Here is another way to translate this:

Ashpenaz (NCV)

not to defile himself: This is the same expression that was used in 1:8a. See the note there.

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the expression in exactly the same way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a slightly different expression with the same meaning. For example:

not to make himself unclean in this way (NCV)

not to eat the food and wine served in the royal palace (CEV)

General Comment on 1:8b

In some languages it may be more natural to ask for permission to perform some positive action. For example:

He asked the chief official for permission to eat other things instead. (NLT96)

Daniel asked to be allowed to eat only food that was clean/permitted for Jewish people.

Daniel 1:9

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:8–10

Daniel decided not to eat the royal food. He did not want to become ritually impure or unclean.

1:9

Now God had granted Daniel favor and compassion from the chief official,

- God helped Daniel. He caused the chief of staff to act kindly and compassionately to him.
- God made Ashpenaz very sympathetic toward Daniel.

Now: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information. God caused the chief official to be sympathetic toward Daniel. He was not hostile. We do not know if this good attitude began at this time or if Ashpenaz had always been sympathetic to Daniel. Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

God had granted Daniel favor and compassion from the chief official: The Hebrew text more literally says,

“God gave Daniel favor and compassion before the official.” The same Hebrew verb is used in 1:2, in the phrase “the Lord delivered” where it is translated as “delivered” 1:2a. It indicates that God was controlling events in the life of Daniel and his people.

In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea in a different way. For example:

God made...the chief officer want to be kind and merciful to Daniel. (NCV)

God influenced the chief official’s attitude toward Daniel, and so the official regularly acted kindly to Daniel.

favor and compassion: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as favor and compassion indicates that the chief official was sympathetic to Daniel. The two words favor and compassion have similar meanings and together they emphasize this idea. In some languages it may be more natural to use one expression for this idea. For example:

God made Ashpenaz sympathetic to Daniel (GNT)

Now God had given the chief official great respect for Daniel (NLT)

favor: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as favor here indicates that the chief official liked Daniel and treated him well. The same Hebrew word occurs many times in the Old Testament and is often translated as “love” or “kindness” (see, for example, Psalm 23:6 and Genesis 24:27.)

compassion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as compassion means “mercy” or “sympathy.” The chief official understood that Daniel was in a difficult situation and tried to be helpful and kind to him.

the chief official: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates here as official is the same as that translated as “of his court officials” in 1:3a. See the note there. Some ways English versions translate this Hebrew phrase here are:

palace master (NRSV)

chief of staff (GW)

Ashpenaz (GNT)

Ashpenaz, the chief officer, (NCV)

Refer back to Ashpenaz in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel 1:10

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:8–10

Daniel decided not to eat the royal food. He did not want to become ritually impure or unclean.

1:10a

but he said to Daniel, “I fear my lord the king,

- But the chief/man said to Daniel, “I am afraid to disobey my master the king.
- However, he said to Daniel, “The king is my master. I am afraid that he would punish me.

but: There are two ways to understand the Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as but:

1. It introduces contrast. For example:

however (GNT) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NET, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. In introduces continuation. For example:

and (ESV) (KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB)

The NRSV and GW leave this conjunction untranslated.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Although Ashpenaz was sympathetic toward Daniel, he was still afraid of disobeying the king. Other ways to translate this connection include:

Nevertheless...

In spite of this...

Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

he: Here, the pronoun he refers to Ashpenaz, the chief of the king's court officials mentioned in 1:3 and 1:7. See the note on 1:3a.

I fear my lord the king: These words introduce Ashpenaz's fear. Ashpenaz's fear was that the king would kill him if he disobeyed his orders. The situation that Ashpenaz feared never actually happened. Languages have different ways to express fears like this. Use a natural way in your language. It may be necessary to make explicit that Ashpenaz was afraid of the king's reaction to his request. For example:

I am afraid what my lord the king will do

I am afraid that my lord the king will be angry if I ask that

I am afraid he will kill me (CEV)

See also the General Comment on 1:10, which discusses reordering the verse, as the CEV has done.

my lord the king: Ashpenaz used two titles to refer to the king. In this way, he emphasized the authority that the king had over him. In some languages it may not be natural to use both of these titles here. If that is true in your language, there are at least two possibilities for translation:

- Use only the title king. For example:

The king (GNT)

- Use a descriptive phrase to translate my lord. For example:

the king, who has authority over me

1:10b**who has assigned your food and drink.**

- He has decided what you^(plur) should eat and drink
- He is the one who determined what food you^(plur) young men are to eat and what you are to drink.

who has assigned your food and drink: Nebuchadnezzar had given orders concerning what Daniel and the other young Jewish men were to eat and drink. The chief official had not made the decision himself.

In some languages it may be more natural to make this clause a complete sentence or an independent clause. For example:

The king has decided what you are to eat and drink (GNT)

the king determined what you should eat and drink (GW)

your food and drink: The expression your food and drink means “the food you should eat and the drink you should drink.”

your: This reference is plural. It refers to Daniel and all the other young men in the group who were chosen to serve the king.

General Comment on 1:10b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder this, giving the background information first. For example:

^{10b-c}My lord the king has ordered your food and drink, and I am afraid that...

1:10c**For why should he see your faces looking thinner than those of the other young men your age?**

- If I allow you^(plur) to eat other food, the king will see that you^(plur) are not as healthy as the other young men of your^(plur) age.
- What will happen if I do not obey him, and then you^(plur) do not thrive/grow as well as the other youths? If/When the king sees that,

For why should he see your faces looking thinner than those of the other young men your age?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a strong statement that it would not be good for the king to see Daniel and his friends looking unhealthy. Ashpenaz was implying that the king's food was nutritious and good for the young men. If Daniel and his companions did not eat it, they would not thrive. They would not

look as healthy as the other young men who were training to become court officials. This would make the king angry.

There are several ways to translate this verse part:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What is the good/benefit of letting him see you looking worse than the other young men?

For what will happen if he sees you looking less healthy than the other young men?

- Translate it as a statement of possibility or a conditional clause:

He may see that you do not look as healthy as the other young men.

If he sees that you look worse than the other young men your age (GW)

If you become pale and thin compared to the other youths your age (NLT)

- Translate it as a statement of result. For example:

If you do not eat the king's food, he will see that you look worse than the other young men.

- Translate it as a statement of fear that is connected to 1:10a.

I am afraid that he will see that you look worse than the other young men. See the French Common Language translation 1997.

Express this in a way that is natural in your language. It may be natural to include the implied information as to why it would be bad for the king to see Daniel and his friends in an unhealthy state. It would make the king angry. For example:

If the king sees that you look worse than the other young men, he will become angry.

If you do not eat the king's food, you will get haggard/unhealthy. The king will see it and will be angry.

looking thinner than those of the other young men your age: This is a comparison. It compares Daniel and his three friends to the other Jewish youths Ashpenaz had chosen. Ashpenaz did not want Nebuchadnezzar to see Daniel and his friends appearing less healthy than the other Jewish youths. Consider how to indicate such a comparison in your language. For example:

less strong and healthy than the other youths

the other young men look healthy but you look unhealthy

not strong like the other young men

In your translation, be careful to avoid suggesting that the other young men looked a little unhealthy and Daniel and his friends more so. The other young men were not going to appear unhealthy at all. Ashpenaz assumed they would become strong and healthy on the king's diet.

your faces looking thinner: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as your faces looking thinner is more literally "your faces looking gaunt/haggard." See also Genesis 40:6, where the same word meaning "gaunt/haggard" is used. Other ways to translate this include:

pale and thin (NLT)

looking miserable (REB)

looking weak

your: This pronoun is plural. It refers to Daniel and his three companions. Daniel's friends had also decided not to eat the king's special food and wine.

those of the other young men your age: The phrase probably refers to the other captives who were in the same general age group as Daniel. These young men would have eaten the king's diet and grown strong and healthy. Some translations omit the phrase your age since it is implied in the phrase other young men. For example:

the other young men (GNT)

1:10d

You would endanger my head before the king!"

- Then he will command his servants to cut my head off."
- he will be angry about it and have me killed/executed."

This verse part connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction. Many versions translate it as "then." The RSV translates as "So." Here it introduces the result of the king seeing Daniel and his friends looking unhealthy. The BSB does not translate this conjunction explicitly. You should introduce this verse part in a way that is natural in your language.

You would endanger my head before the king!: The Hebrew is more literally "you (plural) would make guilty my head with the king." This is an idiom that probably refers to execution. Ashpenaz was afraid that the king would blame him for the poor appearance of his servants. He knew that the king might have him put to death for failing to take good care of the young men.

We do not know what method of execution the king would have used. The king might have ordered Ashpenaz's head cut off, but not necessarily. It is good to translate this in a general way referring to any kind of execution.

Other ways to translate this include:

my head will be in danger with the king (NJB)

you would endanger my life with the king (NET)

he may kill me (GNT)

he will hold me responsible and I will pay with my life because of you La Bible du Semeur.

General Comment on 1:10

In Hebrew, this verse is a long, complex sentence. The main point is that Ashpenaz was afraid to agree to Daniel's request. In some languages it may be more natural to separate the information into shorter sentences. It may also be more natural to change the order of some of the information. For example:

^{10a}But the man still told him, ^{10c}"The king has decided what you must eat and drink. ^{10b}And I am afraid ^{10e}he will kill me, ^{10d}if you eat something else and end up looking worse than the other young men." (CEV)

Daniel 1:11

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:11–14

Daniel decided to go to a different official to ask his permission. He went to the man whom Ashpenaz had appointed to supervise them.

1:11a

Then Daniel said to the steward

- ¶ So Daniel spoke to the guard/warden
- ¶ After that conversation, Daniel went to speak to another official, the man/warden

Then Daniel said to the steward: Daniel turned from the chief official and went and spoke to the steward. The text implies that this was a different conversation. In some languages it may be necessary to include a verb of motion here to indicate this. For example:

So Daniel went to the guard.... (GNT)

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces what Daniel did next. Since Ashpenaz was afraid to help him, he spoke to someone else. Here is another way to translate this:

So (GNT)

Introduce what Daniel chose to do next in a way that is natural in your language.

the steward: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as steward occurs only here in the Old Testament. Its exact meaning is uncertain. It probably refers to a man who is responsible for taking care of others. This man worked under the authority of Ashpenaz. He was in charge of the young men. English versions translate this word in various ways:

supervisor (GW)

steward (RSV)

attendant (NLT, REB)

1:11b

whom the chief official had appointed over Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah,

- whom the chief of staff had appointed to take charge of him, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. Daniel said to him,
- whom Ashpenaz had appointed to supervise him and his three friends. Daniel made this request:

whom the chief official had appointed over Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah:

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the chief official is the same one that was used in 1:7a. See the note there. In some languages it may be natural to name him. For example:

Ashpenaz (NCV)

had appointed: This verb refers to an event that had already happened before Daniel went to talk to the official. Some time before, Ashpenaz had appointed a man to supervise Daniel and his three friends. Most English versions make this explicit by the verb tense they use. For example:

had put in charge of (REB)

had ordered a guard to watch (NCV)

Languages have different ways of indicating that certain events happened before the main events of the story. Do this in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment at the end of 1:11.

Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah: In some languages it may be unnatural to repeat the names of the three friends. If that is true in your language, here is another way to translate this:

him and his three friends (GNT)

General Comment on 1:11

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the information in this verse in the order in which it happened. For example:

^{11b}The king's official had put a guard in charge of Daniel and his three friends. ^{11a}So Daniel said to the guard.... (CEV)

Daniel 1:12

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:11–14

Daniel decided to go to a different official to ask his permission. He went to the man whom Ashpenaz had appointed to supervise them.

1:12a

“Please test your servants for ten days.

- “Please test us^(excl) your servants for the next ten days.
- “Sir, please allow us^(excl) to try a new diet for the next ten days.

Please test your servants for ten days: This verse part expresses a polite request. Translate this request in a way that is polite and natural in your language. For example:

Kindly allow your servants to show/demonstrate what we want

Be so good as to give your servants a trial period.

test your servants for ten days: In this context the verb test means to give a test or trial. Daniel wanted the official to allow Daniel and his friends to do as they requested for a short period of time. That time would act as a trial period. At the end of the time, the official would observe the results of their actions. Here is another way to translate this:

Allow your servants a ten days' trial (NJB)

your servants: Daniel referred to himself and his three companions as your servants. This was a Hebrew way of showing respect and submission. In some languages it may not be clear to whom Daniel was referring. If that is true in your language, there are other possibilities for translation:

- Use a first-person exclusive pronoun meaning “us.” For example:

Please give us this test for ten days. (NCV)

- Use both a pronoun reference like “us” and an expression like your servants. For example:

Please give us, your servants, a test....

Express respect for the man in authority in a way that is natural in your language.

1:12b

Let us be given only vegetables to eat and water to drink.

- Give us^(excl) only vegetables to eat and water to drink.
- We^(excl) would like to eat only plant foods and drink only water.

Let us be given only vegetables to eat and water to drink: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as Let us be given is passive. There are two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

we are given only vegetables to eat and water to drink (NJB)

- Using an active verb. This verb may be negative or positive. For example:

Don't give us anything but vegetables to eat and water to drink. (NCV)

Please allow us to eat only vegetables and drink only water.

Let us be given only vegetables...and water: The Hebrew text is more literally "Give us vegetables to eat and water to drink." The BSB has supplied the word only. The young men did not want to eat any meat or drink any wine. So Daniel asked the guard not to give them any. In some languages it may be natural to say:

Give us nothing but vegetables...and water

Do not give us anything except vegetables...and water

vegetables to eat: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as vegetables is related to the Hebrew word for "seed." Here it probably refers generally to plants that people grow, including grains, beans, and lentils. It is good to translate this with a general expression referring to plant-based foods.

In some languages it may be natural to express the verbs to eat and "to drink" by saying:

Give us no food except plants/vegetables and no drink except water.

Daniel 1:13

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase "the Lord delivered" ("Adonay gave" in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase "God had granted" ("Elohim had given" in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase "God gave" ("Elohim gave" in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over

the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:11–14

Daniel decided to go to a different official to ask his permission. He went to the man whom Ashpenaz had appointed to supervise them.

1:13a

Then compare our appearances with those of the young men who are eating the royal food,

- After the ten days, you^(sing) can decide who looks better, us^(excl) or the other young men, who are eating the king's food.
- At the end of the ten days, you^(sing) can compare us^(excl) with the young men who ate the king's food.

Then: The word Then refers to the end of the trial period. Some English versions make the time period explicit:

When the ten days are up (CEV)

After ten days... (NCV)

compare our appearances with those of the young men who are eating the royal food: Daniel asked the guard to compare him and his three friends with the other men who ate the king's food. He wanted the guard to judge who looked the most healthy and strong.

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as compare is literally "be seen." This is a passive verb. Ways to translate it include:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

let our appearance and the appearance of the youths who eat the king's rich food be observed by you (RSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

compare how we look with how the other young men look who eat the king's food (NCV)

examine us and examine the other young men who have been eating the king's food, in order to see who looks better

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the royal food: See the note on 1:5a, where the same phrase occurs.

1:13b

and deal with your servants according to what you see.”

- On the basis of what you^(sing) see, you can decide if we^(excl) may continue eating only vegetables and drinking only water.”
- You^(sing) can then judge/decide whether we^(excl) may continue eating only plant foods and drinking only water.”

and deal with your servants according to what you see: Again Daniel referred to himself and his three friends as your servants. This was a polite way to speak to someone in authority. See the note on 1:12. In some languages it may be more natural to use a first-person pronoun. For example:

See for yourself and then decide how you want to treat us, your servants (NCV)

Decide how to treat us on the basis of how we look (GW)

General Comment on 1:13b

The text does not indicate in what way Daniel wanted the guard to treat him and his friends. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Then you can decide whether or not to let us continue eating our diet. (NLT96)

Daniel 1:14

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9,

and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:11–14

Daniel decided to go to a different official to ask his permission. He went to the man whom Ashpenaz had appointed to supervise them.

1:14a

So he consented to this

- The guard/warden agreed to do this.
- Then the warden/supervisor agreed to Daniel’s plan.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces the result of the request in 1:13. It is also possible to use a time connector such as “then” or to omit a connector. Introduce the guard’s positive reaction to Daniel’s request in a way that is natural in your language.

he consented to this: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as consented is more literally “listened.” Here it indicates that the guard/steward accepted Daniel’s request. Other ways to translate this include:

he accepted Daniel’s idea

He agreed to this plan of theirs (NJPS)

The guard said “yes” to this/Daniel.

he: The pronoun he refers to the official whom the BSB refers to as “the steward.” See the note on 1:11a. Refer back to him in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

The man (NJB)

The attendant (NLT)

1:14b

and tested them for ten days.

- He allowed the four young men to try eating in this way for ten days.
- He let Daniel and his three friends eat and drink as they had requested for ten days.

and tested them for ten days: See the note on “test” in 1:12. The pronoun them refers to Daniel and his three

companions. It may be necessary to make this explicit in some languages. Translation models include:

and put them on ten days' trial (NJB)

and gave the four young men a ten-day trial period

General Comment on 1:14a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the verbs in 1:14a–b and translate these verse parts as one clause. For example:

So the guard agreed to test them for ten days.
(NCV)

He agreed to let them try it for ten days. (GNT)

Daniel 1:15

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:15–16

The four young men successfully passed the test. At the end of the ten days, Daniel and his companions looked healthier than the other young men. So they were allowed to continue eating only plant foods and drinking only water.

1:15a

And at the end of ten days, they looked healthier and better nourished

- ¶ At the end of that time, Daniel and his friends looked healthier and better fed
- ¶ After ten days, the warden/supervisor saw that Daniel and his three companions were healthy and strong.

And at the end of ten days: The phrase ten days refers back to the test period mentioned in 1:14b. Ways to translate this include:

After ten days (GW)

When the time was up (GNT)

At the end of the trial/test period

they looked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they looked is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

it was seen that (RSV)

it was observed that (NRSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

they appeared

the guard saw that

they: In some languages, it may be natural to be more specific. For example:

Daniel and his three friends (NLT)

healthier and better nourished: In this context these two expressions are very similar in meaning. Daniel and his friends looked stronger and better fed than the young men who ate the king's food. Some ways to say this in English are:

they looked healthier and stronger (GNT)

they looked healthier and better fed (NCV)

healthier: The Hebrew expression that BSB translates as healthier is based on the general word that means “good.” Another way to translate this is:

better in appearance (RSV)

better nourished: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as better nourished is more literally “fatter in flesh,” as in the RSV. Genesis 41:2 uses the same Hebrew expression to describe the cows in Pharaoh’s dream. This does not mean that the young men were overweight. They were in good physical condition and thriving on their vegetarian diet. Use a positive expression indicating a desirable outcome. For example:

better fed (NCV)

stronger (GNT)

gained weight (FrCL (1988)). In some cultures this would be a negative idea, indicating an undesirable result. It is important to avoid such a suggestion.

1:15b

than all the young men who were eating the king’s food.

- than all the young men who had eaten the king’s fine food.
- The young men who were eating the royal foods did not look good like them.

than all the young men who were eating the king’s food: This verse part indicates that the other young men looked less healthy and less well-nourished than Daniel and his friends.

than all the young men: See the note on young men in 1:4.

who were eating the king’s food: See the note on king’s food in 1:5. This refers to the same type of food that the king ate, the food the king had ordered that they receive. Other ways to translate this include:

who had been served food from the royal palace (CEV)

who ate the food the king assigned to them

General Comment on 1:15a–b

These verse parts compare the way Daniel and his friends looked to the way the other young men looked. There are various ways of making such a comparison. For example:

Daniel and his friends looked more healthy and well nourished than the young men who had been eating the palace food.

Daniel and his three friends looked very healthy and well fed. The young men who ate the palace food did not.

Daniel 1:16

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:15–16

The four young men successfully passed the test. At the end of the ten days, Daniel and his companions looked healthier than the other young men. So they were allowed to continue eating only plant foods and drinking only water.

1:16a

So the steward continued to withhold their choice food and the wine they were to drink,

- So each day the guard/warden took away their special food and their wine,

- So after that the warden/supervisor no longer gave Daniel and his friends/companions the good food and drink the king provided.

So the steward continued to withhold their choice food and the wine they were to drink: The guard permanently stopped serving Daniel and his friends the palace food and drink. He allowed them to continued eating a vegetarian diet and drinking water.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces what happened next, as the result of the test. It may also indicate a time reference, “So after this....” Some ways to express this transition in English are:

So after that.... (NLT)

So from then on.... (GNT)

After this (CEV)

the steward: This refers to the official whom Ashpenaz had appointed to supervise the men. See the note on 1:13.

continued to withhold: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as continued to withhold uses a verb form indicating that the action was repeated over a period of time. Each day a servant brought the special food from the king to Daniel and his three friends, and each day the guard removed it.

You should translate in a way that shows that this action continued from that time on.

their choice food and the wine they were to drink: See the notes on food and wine at 1:5.

1:16b

and he gave them vegetables instead.

- and instead, he gave them vegetables and water.
- He only gave them plant foods and water.

and he gave them vegetables instead: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as gave also indicates repeated action. It is implied that the guard also continued to give them water to drink. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

and continued to give them vegetables and water

vegetables: See the note on vegetables in 1:12. The Hebrew word is spelled differently here but refers to the same foods.

General Comment about 1:16

This verse is a conclusion to the situation. Daniel and his friends were able to remain faithful to God and did not have to defile themselves with the king's food. The problem was resolved. Conclude this part of the story in a way that is natural in your language. Some versions reverse the order of these two clauses, putting the positive statement before the negative. For example:

So from then on the guard let them continue to eat vegetables instead of what the king provided (GNT)

so after that the attendant fed them only vegetables instead of the rich foods and wines.... (NLT)

After this the guard let them eat vegetables instead of the rich food and wine. (CEV)

Daniel 1:17

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:17–21

Some English versions include verse 17 with the previous paragraph (for example, the NRSV and NJB).

However, it seems appropriate to begin a new paragraph at this verse, as the GNT and BSB do. Daniel 1:17 introduces the climax of the chapter. God blessed Daniel and his three friends. The king was very pleased with their wisdom and he accepted them into his service.

1:17a

To these four young men God gave knowledge and understanding in every kind of literature and wisdom.

- ¶ God helped these four young men to learn many/ varied subjects, all the knowledge and writings of the Babylonians.
- ¶ God gave to each of these four youths the ability to study and understand every different topic/aspect of Babylonian literature and learning.

To these four young men God gave knowledge and understanding in every kind of literature and wisdom: God helped Daniel and his three friends to benefit from their Babylonian education. They learned easily and well.

In some languages it may be more natural to choose a different verb. For example:

God made all four of these young men smart and able to understand all different kinds of literature and learning

God caused these four young men to be wise and to understand all kinds of literature and learning.

To these four young men: The BSB follows the Hebrew by putting the phrase these four young men first in the sentence for emphasis. In this context, the phrase these four young men is the topic that the author wants to focus on. See the General Comment on 1:17a for a way to reorder this verse part.

God gave: This is the third time that the Hebrew verb, translated as gave here, occurs in the chapter with God as the one doing the action. This key phrase divides the chapter into three parts. It emphasizes that God was in control of the events that happened in the life of Daniel.

gave knowledge: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as knowledge also occurs in the phrase “quick to understand” in 1:4b. See the note there. God gave the four young men the ability the king was looking for. Some ways that English versions have translated this include:

gave them learning (RSV)Goldingay, p. 4.

made...intelligent (NJPS)

made them smart (CEV)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

understanding: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as understanding can mean “insight, understanding, good sense.” Some ways that English versions have translated this are:

skill (RSV)

wisdom (CEV)

every kind of literature and wisdom: This phrase explains what kinds of things the young men could understand.

literature: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as literature means “scroll, book” or “writing.” Here it refers to the written works of the Babylonians.

and wisdom: The young men also understood all kinds of intellectual studies. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wisdom is the same as in 1:4b.

General Comment on 1:17a

In some languages it may be natural to reorder this verse part with the subject at the beginning. For example:

God gave these four men... (GW)

Consider if there is another way to indicate the topic of the sentence.

1:17b

And Daniel had insight into all kinds of visions and dreams.

- And as for Daniel, God also gave him the ability to understand the various kinds of dreams and visions.
- God also gave Daniel special ability to explain any dream. He could also interpret any vision.

And Daniel had insight into all kinds of visions and dreams: As well as the knowledge and understanding that the four friends received, Daniel received a special ability. He could interpret the meaning of visions and dreams. Other ways to translate this include:

And God gave Daniel the special ability to interpret the meanings of visions and dreams (NLT)

And Daniel could understand visions and dreams of all kinds (NIV)

Daniel could also tell the meaning of dreams and visions. (CEV)

And Daniel had insight into: The four men were the topic of 1:17a. Daniel alone is the topic of 1:17b. Introduce this shift in topic in a way that is natural in your language.

had insight: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as had insight means “discerned, had insight.” See the note on “quick to understand” in 1:4b. Not only did God help Daniel understand all kinds of literature and learning, but he also gave him insight into the meaning of dreams. Other ways to translate this are:

Daniel also could understand...

God gave Daniel special ability in understanding... (NLT)

God gave Daniel the ability to understand and explain...

all kinds of visions and dreams: The Hebrew says more literally “all visions and dreams.” The Babylonians studied and classified different kinds of dreams. Other ways to translate this include:

every kind of vision and dream (NJB)

visions and dreams (GNT)

visions and dreams: Prophets often had visions. A vision is like a dream, except that a person is usually awake. Sometimes he may be in a trance. In visions, people see and hear things that they would not ordinarily see and that other people cannot see or hear. In the Bible, God often gave a prophet a special vision when he had something important to communicate to his people.

In contrast to visions, dreams usually occur at night when people are asleep. However, in the book of Daniel, these two words overlap in meaning. If your language has a word for dreams but it does not have a word for visions, you may have to use a descriptive

phrase to translate the meaning of visions. For example:

dreams and other special messages from God

Daniel 1:18

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:17–21

Some English versions include verse 17 with the previous paragraph (for example, the NRSV and NJB). However, it seems appropriate to begin a new paragraph at this verse, as the GNT and BSB do. Daniel 1:17 introduces the climax of the chapter. God blessed Daniel and his three friends. The king was very pleased with their wisdom and he accepted them into his service.

1:18a

Now at the end of the time specified by the king,

- When the young men had completed the three years of study which King Nebuchadnezzar had ordered/commanded,
- After the three years of training had ended,

Now at the end of the time specified by the king:

This verse part indicates the time of the next action in the story. Three years passed, and the training period that the king had ordered came to an end (see 1:5). Other ways to translate this include:

When the time appointed by the king arrived (NET)

At the end of the three-year training period (GW)

At the end of the three years set by the king (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent sentence. For example:

The training period that the king had spoken of came to an end.

The young men completed the three years of training that the king had ordered.

Now at the end of the time: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as at the end of the time is literally “at the end of the days” (as in the KJV). This phrase refers to the period of three years that King Nebuchadnezzar had set to train the young men (1:5b). It is not a reference to the ten-day testing period.

In some languages it may be necessary to make that explicit. For example:

at the end of the three-year training period (GW)

When the three year training period ordered by the king was completed (NLT)

specified by the king: This refers to the king’s command in 1:5b.

the king: The phrase the king refers to King Nebuchadnezzar. He is mentioned by name at the end of this verse. See the General Comment on 1:18a–b.

1:18b

the chief official presented them to Nebuchadnezzar.

- the head/chief of staff led them into the king’s presence.
- Ashpenaz brought all the young men to King Nebuchadnezzar.

the chief official presented them to Nebuchadnezzar: Ashpenaz brought the young men into the king’s presence so that he could decide if he wanted them to serve him. Other ways to translate this include:

Ashpenaz took all the young men to Nebuchadnezzar (GNT)

his chief palace official brought all the young men to him (CEV)

the chief official: This refers to Ashpenaz. See the note on 1:7.

presented them to Nebuchadnezzar: The phrase presented them indicates that the official told the young men to go with him to meet the king. The king wanted to see and interview them.

In your translation, it is good to use an expression that refers to coming before a person of high rank and importance.

Some translations add implied information that tells the purpose of the meeting:

brought them to Nebuchadnezzar so he could evaluate them

General Comment on 1:18a–b

King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon is referred to as “the king” in 1:18a and as “Nebuchadnezzar” in 1:18b. In your translation, make it clear that the two expressions refer to the same person. In some languages it may be more natural to use the name and title first, and then a pronoun. For example:

At the end of the three-year period set by King Nebuchadnezzar, his chief palace official brought all the young men to him. (CEV)

Daniel 1:19

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over

the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:17–21

Some English versions include verse 17 with the previous paragraph (for example, the NRSV and NJB). However, it seems appropriate to begin a new paragraph at this verse, as the GNT and BSB do. Daniel 1:17 introduces the climax of the chapter. God blessed Daniel and his three friends. The king was very pleased with their wisdom and he accepted them into his service.

1:19a

And the king spoke with them,

- The king talked with all of them,
- The king spoke with them all,

And the king spoke with them: The pronoun them refers to all the young men whom Ashpenaz had trained. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit in some way. For example:

The king talked with them all (GNT)

The king talked with each of them (NLT)

The king interviewed all the young men

1:19b

and among all the young men he found no one equal to Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.

- and he realized that none of them was as wise/skilled as Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.
- and he concluded that Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah were superior to all the rest/others.

and among all the young men he found no one equal to Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah:

After talking to the young men, the king realized that Daniel and his three friends were superior to the others. Specifically, they were more capable of serving the king. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

he discovered that none of them was as capable/skilled as Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah

The king realized that none of them could serve him as well as Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.

he found no one equal: In the Hebrew this is a passive clause: “no one equal...was found.” There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive clause. For example:

and among them all none was found like Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah (RSV)

- Using an active verb. The subject could be the king, as in the BSB, or Daniel and his friends. For example:

and Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah impressed him more than any of the others (GNT)

1:19c

So they entered the king’s service.

- So they began to serve the king.
- So these four men became advisers to the king.

So they entered the king’s service: The Hebrew more literally says “therefore they stood before the king,” as in the RSV. The idiom “stand before the king” means “serve the king.” See the note on 1:5b. Some ways to express this in English are:

So these four men served the king (GW)

so the king accepted these four men to serve as his advisors

so they became members of the king’s court (GNT, NJB)

so they became members of his regular staff of advisors

Daniel 1:20

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

This section forms the introduction to the first division and to the book of Daniel as a whole. It tells how some Hebrew boys came to live in Babylon and serve the Babylonian king.

God allowed the king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, to defeat the king of Judah. King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his chief official to choose some boys from Judah and to train them to work in the government of Babylon. Daniel and his three friends were among these boys. They excelled in their studies and the king was pleased with the wise advice they gave.

The phrase “the Lord delivered” (“Adonay gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:2, the phrase “God had granted” (“Elohim had given” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:9, and the phrase “God gave” (“Elohim gave” in Hebrew) occurs in 1:17. (1:2a, 1:9, 1:17a). The author used these phrases to emphasize that the Lord is sovereign over the events of history and the lives of his people. God has authority over what happens to Gentile nations and also what happens to his people. This is the theme of this chapter.

Paragraph 1:17–21

Some English versions include verse 17 with the previous paragraph (for example, the NRSV and NJB). However, it seems appropriate to begin a new paragraph at this verse, as the GNT and BSB do. Daniel 1:17 introduces the climax of the chapter. God blessed Daniel and his three friends. The king was very pleased with their wisdom and he accepted them into his service.

1:20a

In every matter of wisdom and understanding about which the king consulted them,

- Whenever the king asked them about a difficult problem or question,
- The king asked them about various challenging issues,

Nebuchadnezzar asked the young men questions to test their wisdom and understanding. The Hebrew text connects this verse to the previous verse with a common conjunction that several English versions translate as “And.” Here it introduces a clause that adds to the praises of Daniel and his friends in 1:19. The BSB does not explicitly translate this conjunction. Introduce this clause in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Whenever the king asked for advice (CEV)

Every time the king asked them about something important (NCV)

No matter what question the king asked or what problem he raised (GNT)

In every matter of wisdom and understanding: This refers to any question or problem that a person needed wisdom to answer or solve. In some languages it may be necessary to make this connection between matter and wisdom and understanding more explicit. For example:

about things that required wisdom and insight (GW)

all the things that only a wise person could understand and advise him about

matter: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as matter is very general. It can refer to any kind of question or problem that the king might have had. In some languages it may be necessary to use a more specific expression. For example:

inquiry

subject/topic

wisdom and understanding: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as wisdom and understanding is literally “wisdom of understanding.” Most English versions connect the two nouns with the word and.

wisdom: The Hebrew word for wisdom is the same word that is translated as “wisdom” in 1:4b. It is good to use the same word to indicate that the king found the qualities he was looking for.

understanding: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as understanding is the same as in 1:4b, in the phrase “quick to understand.” Other ways to translate this word are:

insight (GW)

balanced judgment (NLT)

about which the king consulted them: This clause expresses an action that the king repeated many times. He asked the four men many questions over a period of time. In some languages it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

Whenever the king asked them about things that required knowledge or insight... (GW)

No matter what question the king asked or what problem he raised... (GNT)

1:20b

he found them ten times better than all the magicians and enchanters in his entire kingdom.

- they proved/showed to him that they were many times wiser than all the magicians and religious/occult experts in his entire kingdom/empire.
- and they always answered well/wisely, giving advice much/far better than that of all the experts in magic and pagan scholars in Babylonia.

he found them ten times better than all the magicians and enchanters in his entire kingdom: The king judged or evaluated Daniel and his friends. He also judged or evaluated his own magicians and enchanters. Daniel and his friends proved to be better advisors. They were wiser, more capable, competent, and knowledgeable. Here is another way to translate this:

he found them ten times more capable than any of the magicians and enchanters in his entire kingdom (NLT)

he found them: This introduces the results of the king's evaluation. Languages have different ways to introduce this kind of information. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb. For example:

the king realized that they were....

he saw that they were

they showed themselves to be

they proved to be

them: The pronoun them refers to Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. Here is another way to translate this:

These four (GNT)

ten times better than all the magicians and enchanters: This expresses a comparison. It compares Daniel and his friends to all the magicians and enchanters. Specifically, the king compared their advice and their wisdom. In some languages it may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

the king found the advice of these young men to be ten times better than that of all the magicians and enchanters in his entire kingdom (NLT)

he found their wisdom was ten times better than that of his other advisors and magicians (CEV)

ten times better: Here ten times is used as a figure of speech. It is an emphatic way to say "very much better." In some languages it may not be natural to use this figure of speech about a quality like wisdom that cannot be measured. If that is true in your language, there are several other possible ways to translate this:

- Indicate that the four men knew ten times as much as the others. For example:

knew ten times more than... (GNT)

- Use a different idiom to express the comparison. For example:

were head and neck above the others

- Express the meaning directly. For example:

were much, much better/wiser

magicians: The same Hebrew word is used to describe the Egyptian magicians in the story of Joseph and Moses (Genesis 41:8; Exodus 7:11). It is good to use a word that refers to someone who predicts the future and has other unusual or supernatural powers. It should not indicate that these powers are from God.

Most versions translate this in a general way as magicians. But it is also possible to translate more specifically, referring to what a magician in those days did. For example:

fortuneteller (GNT)

diviners

dream interpreters

enchanters: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as enchanters refers to people who know how to speak magical words (incantations, charms, or spells). Other ways to translate this include:

soothsayers (NJB)

spell makers/speakers

in his entire kingdom: The word kingdom refers both to the country and the people that the king ruled. See “kingdom” in KBT.

General Comment on 1:20

It may be natural to translate this as two or more separate sentences. For example:

Every time the king asked them about something important, they showed much wisdom and understanding. They were ten times better than all the fortune-tellers and magicians in his kingdom! (NCV)

Daniel 1:21

Section 1:1–21: Daniel and his friends began to serve King Nebuchadnezzar

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1:21

And Daniel remained there until the first year of King Cyrus.

- ¶ Daniel served the Babylonian kings until Cyrus began to rule over the kingdom/empire.
- ¶ So Daniel stayed there to advise the king of Babylon. He was still there when Cyrus began to rule.

And Daniel remained there until the first year of King Cyrus: This verse may indirectly refer to Jeremiah’s prophecy that the Jews would remain in exile for seventy years. Daniel stayed in Babylon throughout all that time.

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces the ending of the episode. The clause explains what happened later. Use a natural way to express this kind of ending in your language.

Daniel remained there until the first year of King Cyrus:

The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as Daniel remained there until is literally “Daniel was until.” This indicates that Daniel remained there at the Babylonian court for a long time. He was still serving the king of Babylonia (but not Nebuchadnezzar, a different king) when King Cyrus began to rule.

This clause does not indicate that Daniel left Babylon at this time. It also does not mean that he died in this year. See 6:28; 10:1.

Other ways to translate this include:

So Daniel continued to be the king’s servant until the first year Cyrus was king. (NCV)

Daniel served there until the first year of King Cyrus. (CEV)

Daniel was still there at the court when Cyrus became king.

until the first year of King Cyrus: Cyrus was the king of Persia. The first year of King Cyrus refers to the year when Cyrus and his army conquered the Babylonian empire (538 BC). Some ways to express the clause in English are:

until the first year that Cyrus ruled over Babylon

until Cyrus, the emperor of Persia, conquered Babylonia (GNT)

Daniel 2:1

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may

be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1-13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14-23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24-45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46-49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1-13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14-23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24-49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20-23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry

also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20-23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36-45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:1-3

This paragraph introduces the problem that is resolved in this section. Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, was troubled by his dreams. He asked his advisers to explain them to him.

2:1a

In the second year of his reign, Nebuchadnezzar had dreams

- ¶ During Nebuchadnezzar's second year as king, he began to have/see dreams
- ¶ Two years after Nebuchadnezzar had become king, he dreamed strange/unusual dreams.

In the second year of his reign: This clause tells when the events of this section took place. Some commentators see an apparent contradiction between this reference and the reference to "three years" in 1:5 and in 1:18 ("the time specified by the king" in 1:18 means "three years"). One way to explain this

problem is to consider the way the Hebrews counted the years a king reigned. They counted the fraction of the first calendar year as a full year. Thus the second year according to the Babylonian way of counting would have been the third year according to the way the Hebrews counted. Baldwin (p. 85) explains that Nebuchadnezzar's second year would have been March/April 603 BC. Others who take a similar view are Driver, Lucas, Showers, Wiseman, Walvoord, Wood, and Young. Goldingay explains that if this view is correct, then the "denouements in 1:18-20 and 2:45-49 might then refer to the same events." This would solve a number of other apparent problems, including the fact that the king does not seem to know Daniel in chapter 2. It was about the year 603 BC, when Nebuchadnezzar had been reigning more than a year but less than three years. Other ways to translate this include:

Two years after he became king

During the second year that Nebuchadnezzar was king (CEV)

During Nebuchadnezzar's second year as king (NCV)

his reign: The pronoun his here refers to Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylonia. In the Hebrew text the name is explicit. See the General Comment on 2:1.

Nebuchadnezzar had dreams: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Nebuchadnezzar had dreams is literally "Nebuchadnezzar dreamed dreams." Use the idiom that is natural in your language. For example:

as Nebuchadnezzar lay in bed, he dreamed.

as he was sleeping, dreams came to him

Nebuchadnezzar: See how you spelled this name in 1:1b. In some languages it may be natural to include Nebuchadnezzar's title here:

King Nebuchadnezzar

dreams: In some languages there may be special words for certain types of dreams. Nebuchadnezzar's dreams were of unusual and disturbing events. He thought they must have some supernatural meaning.

Use the word or phrase that is natural to refer to such dreams. For example:

strange dreams

The BSB, following the Hebrew, uses the plural form dreams. However, the context focuses on one specific dream. Nebuchadnezzar perhaps dreamed the same dream several times. Another way to translate this is:

had a series of dreams (NJB)

In some languages it may be more natural to use a singular form. For example:

he had a dream (GNT)

General Comment on 2:1a

In the Hebrew text the name "Nebuchadnezzar" is used twice in this verse part. In many languages it will be more natural to use a pronoun in one of these two references. For example:

In the second year that Nebuchadnezzar was king, he had a dream. (GNT)

In the second year of his reign Nebuchadnezzar was troubled by dreams. (REB)

2:1b that troubled his spirit, and sleep escaped him.

- that disturbed him. He could not sleep,
- They made him so worried that he was unable to sleep.

In the Hebrew text this verse part connects to the previous verse part with the common connector that several English versions translate as "and." In this context the connector introduces a result. The king's dreams caused him to worry and not be able to sleep. Use a natural form in your language to express this meaning. For example:

dreamed such dreams that his spirit was troubled (NRSV)

that troubled his spirit: The clause that the BSB translates as that troubled his spirit indicates that King Nebuchadnezzar felt anxious or worried. Other ways to translate this clause are:

his mind was troubled (NIV)

It worried him so much (GNT)

that bothered him (NCV)

he became very anxious

his spirit: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as his spirit here refers to Nebuchadnezzar's thoughts and emotions.

and: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the second result of the dream. Use a form that is natural in your language to express this idea.

sleep escaped him: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as sleep escaped him probably indicates that Nebuchadnezzar was no longer able to sleep. It implies that the dream frightened Nebuchadnezzar so much that it woke him up. He could not go back to sleep again. Some ways to translate this in English are:

his sleep left him (RSV)

kept him awake (NCV)

General Comment on 2:1a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 2:1a and 2:1b. For example:

^{1a-b}One night during the second year of his reign, Nebuchadnezzar had such disturbing dreams that he could not sleep. (NLT)

Daniel 2:2

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)

6. The GNT has three sections:

- (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
- (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
- (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. **Repetition:** Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36-45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:1-3

This paragraph introduces the problem that is resolved in this section. Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, was troubled by his dreams. He asked his advisers to explain them to him.

2:2a

So the king gave orders to summon the magicians, enchanters, sorcerers, and astrologers

- so he ordered the magicians, religious/occult experts, sorcerers, and other pagan experts
- So he/Nebuchadnezzar commanded his servants to bring to him all his experts/advisers, that is, the experts in magic, the pagan scholars, the enchanters, and the wizards.

So: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces a result clause. Use a form that naturally expresses this meaning in your language.

the king gave orders to summon: The king gave orders to his servants to summon his advisers. Other ways to translate this include:

The king sent for... (GW)

He called in... (NLT)

In some languages it may be necessary to mention who the king commanded to summon the officers. If that is true in your language, you can say:

He commanded his servants to summon...

the king: This refers to King Nebuchadnezzar. Refer to him in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

he summoned

the magicians, enchanters, sorcerers, and astrologers: The author referred to these experts in two other lists in this chapter. The names vary in each list. This probably indicates that the lists are only giving examples of the various experts whom the king summoned. Lucas, p. 70; Goldingay, p. 46. Lucas explains that the author was not using the terms in order to give an exact list of those who came, but instead, he wanted to show the impressive group of people that Daniel had to compete with. Their failure gave even greater prominence to Daniel's success.

In some languages you may not have specific terms for each of the experts in this list. If you only have two or three terms, you may use those here.

the magicians: See the Notes on "magicians" at Daniel 1:20b. Translate it here the way you did there. Either:

- Use a general term for a person who uses the occult to determine the future or to learn secrets. Most English versions have magicians. However, in this context, the word "magician" does not have the modern meaning of someone who performs illusions or tricks for entertainment. Use a word that avoids this idea. For example:

magicians

- Translate this term more specifically, describing what the magicians did. For example:

fortunetellers (GNT)

dream interpreters (Collins)

diviners

enchanters: See the Notes on enchanters at 1:20b. These were men who were skilled at interpreting signs

when people were sick. They were also skilled at performing rituals in order to influence people's futures. The English word enchanter refers to people who cast a spell on someone by using a charm or magic (enchantment). Use an expression that communicates this idea as closely as possible. For example:

soothsayers A soothsayer is a person who claims to be able to foretell the future. (NJB)

witchdoctors

sorcerers: This is the only place in Daniel where this term occurs. It refers to experts who were skilled in using charms and incantations. Here is another way to translate this:

wizards (REB)

astrologers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as astrologers is literally "Chaldeans." This word has different meanings in Daniel, depending on the context (see 1:4d). In this context, the term refers to people who were experts in the occult and magical rites. They were people who were skilled at solving mysteries. For example:

wizards (GNT)

wise men (CEV)

General Comment on 2:2a

In some languages it may be helpful to introduce this list with a general expression like "The king summoned all the experts who interpreted dreams, including...." Some languages may prefer to list the four groups in a different order. For example:

counselors, advisors, magicians, and wise men (CEV)

2:2b to explain his dreams.

- to come and explain his dream.
- He wanted them to tell him the meaning of his dream.

to explain his dreams: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as to explain his dreams:

1. The king wanted the experts to interpret his dream. For example:

to come and explain the dream to him (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NJB, NET, CEV, NJB, REB)

1. The king wanted the experts to tell him the content of his dream. For example:

to tell the king his dreams (ESV) (NIV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NCV, NLT, GW)

If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you focus on option (1). Nebuchadnezzar wanted his advisers to tell him the meaning of his dream. He believed that it signified or warned of events that were to take place in the real world. Of course, interpreting the dream involved knowing what the dream was. It is probable that the king did in fact remember the dream but wanted to test his advisers.

2:2c

When they came and stood before the king,

- After they had arrived and stood before him,
- And so they all entered the king's presence.

When they came and stood before the king: The Hebrew text connects this verse part to the previous verse part with a common conjunction that many versions translate as "so." Here it introduces what the king's advisers did when they received his command to come: they came. Introduce this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

so they came to the king (GW)

They arrived and stood before the king. (NJB)

As they stood before the king (NLT)

they came: The king's advisers entered the king's palace or court.

and stood before the king: The phrase stood before is an idiom that indicates that they approached someone who had higher status. In some languages there may be a different idiom that expresses this idea. If the idea is not clear from using an idiom, it may be best to leave it implicit. For example:

So they came to the king. (GW)

Daniel 2:3

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example to:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote

using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:1–3

This paragraph introduces the problem that is resolved in this section. Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, was troubled by his dreams. He asked his advisers to explain them to him.

2:3a

he said to them, "I have had a dream, and my spirit is anxious

- he said to them, "I had a strange/disturbing dream.
- Then the king declared: "I am worried about the dream I had.

2:3a–b

In the Hebrew text this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a common conjunction that many English versions translate as “and.” In this context it introduces the next event in the narrative. Introduce what happened next in a way that is natural in your language. If the meaning is implied by the context, you may not have to use a connector.

he said to them: This clause introduces a quotation. The king spoke to his advisors. Each language has its own way to introduce and refer to people in a conversation. You should follow the form that is most natural in your language.

I have had a dream, and my spirit is anxious to understand it: The Hebrew text more literally says, “I have dreamed a dream and my spirit is troubled to know the dream.” Nebuchadnezzar was anxious to know the meaning or significance of a certain dream. Other ways to translate this include:

I have had a dream, and I am anxious to understand the dream (NET)

I’m worried about a dream I’ve had. I want to know what it means (GNT)

I have dreamed something that I am anxious to understand

I have had a dream: Nebuchadnezzar introduces his command to his advisers by telling them that he had been dreaming. This is a reference to the event or events of 2:1a. Use the same or a similar expression so that this is clear to your readers.

a dream: Previously in Daniel 2:1–2 the king referred to “dreams,” in the plural. The king probably had the same dream or variations of the same dream many times. See the Note on “dreams” at 2:1a.

my spirit is anxious: Nebuchadnezzar was anxious or worried. Use an expression that is natural for a context where someone is unable to sleep because they are disturbed or worried about something. See the note on “that troubled his spirit” at 2:1b. Other ways to translate this include:

my spirit is troubled by (NRSV)

my mind is troubled by (NJB)

I am disturbed by (NCV)

2:3b**to understand it.”**

- I want to understand its meaning.”
- Explain^(plur) to me what it means.”

to understand it: The king was troubled by the dream and thought it must have some special significance. He wanted his experts to tell him what that was.

There are two ways to understand the Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as to understand it:

1. The king wanted to know the meaning of the dream. For example:

desire to understand it (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NRSV, NET, NLT, NASB, NJB)

1. The king wanted them to tell him what the dream was. That is, the king wanted them to tell him the content of the dream. The king either could not remember his dream or pretended not to remember it. For example:

I want to know what the dream was (GW) (GW, RSV, ESV, NCV, REB)

Interpretation (1) is recommended.

Daniel 2:4**Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream**

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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
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3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be

important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:4

The king's advisers or dream experts responded to his command. In this verse the original text changes from the Hebrew language to the Aramaic language. This verse forms the transition. After 2:4a and until 7:28, the text is written in the Aramaic language.

2:4a

Then the astrologers answered the king in Aramaic,

- ¶ Then the advisers said to the king,
- ¶ The divination experts answered the king,

Then: The word Then in the BSB translates the common Hebrew connector *w-*. In this context it introduces the next event in the narrative. Introduce the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

the astrologers answered the king: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as astrologers is literally "Chaldeans," as in 2:2a. See the notes there. In this context it refers in general to all the dream experts and other advisers that the king had summoned to him. It is good to refer back to this group in general. For example:

They (GNT)

the wise men (NCV)

the experts/advisers

in Aramaic: These words are in Hebrew, like the rest of the text up to this point. But at this point there is a change and the source text from 2:4b until 7:28 is written in the Aramaic language.

In the Hebrew text, this verse part contains a word meaning in Aramaic, that is, in the Aramaic language. Scholars disagree as to whether this word formed part of the original text of Daniel:

1. Some scholars think that this word was not originally in the Hebrew text. They suggest that it is an editorial note added by scribes at a later time. It indicates that the text that follows (up to 7:28) is written in Aramaic, not Hebrew. For example:

The wise men said to the king: [What follows is in Aramaic] (NET) (NIV11, RSV, NJB, NET)

1. Some scholars think that this word was part of the original text. The Hebrew text then indicates that the experts spoke to the king in the Aramaic language. For example:

The Chaldeans, speaking in Aramaic, said (REB) (BSB, NASB, KJV, ESV, NIV84, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV, REB, NJPS)

Option (1) is recommended. It is recommended that you do not translate the words in Aramaic in the text itself. Instead, you could put a footnote that reads something like:

From this point until 7:28, the source text is written in the Aramaic language.

See the discussion in the Introduction to the Notes. Aramaic was the common second language in the Ancient Near East at that time. Government officials especially used this language.

2:4b

“O king, may you live forever!”

- “Your Majesty, may you^(sing) live and rule forever!
- “Our^(excl) King, we^(excl) pray that you^(sing) will live forever.

O king, may you live forever!: The experts addressed the king with respect. Languages often have special ways to address a king or other important people in authority. Some examples in English are:

Your Majesty, may you live forever! (GW)

May Your Majesty live forever! (GNT)

Long live the king! (NLT)

May the king live forever! (NIV)

This was a common way people greeted the king. It is a figure of speech that means that they wished the king a long and healthy life. Express this meaning in a way that is natural in your language. See also 1 Kings 1:31.

2:4c

Tell your servants the dream,

- We^(excl) are your^(sing) servants. Tell^(sing) us^(excl) your dream,
- Please tell^(sing) us^(excl) what happened in your^(sing) dream.
- What happened in your^(sing) dream, sir/master? Tell us^(excl) that,

Tell your servants the dream: The advisers were speaking respectfully, requesting the king to tell them what he had dreamed. In some languages the imperative Tell may sound rude or too direct for speaking to the king. Express the request in a way that is polite in your language. For example:

We are your servants. Please tell us your dream... (CEV)

your servants: See the Notes at 1:12a. The experts referred to themselves in the third person. People spoke this way when they wanted to show respect to someone who had higher status. Your language may have other ways to show this. In some languages it may be necessary to use a first-person plural pronoun here. For example:

Tell us the dream (NET)

2:4d

and we will give the interpretation.”

- and we^(excl) will explain/reveal its meaning to you^(sing).”
- Then we^(excl) will tell you^(sing) what it means.”
- and we^(excl) will tell/give you^(sing) its interpretation.”

and we will give the interpretation: The Aramaic text literally says “and we will show the interpretation.” This expression refers to revealing something that is not known or to interpreting something that is not understood. The dream experts told the king they would explain to him the meaning or significance of the details of his dream. Like Nebuchadnezzar, they

believed that the gods sometimes revealed the future to people in dreams. Some ways to translate this in English are:

and we will reveal its meaning to you (NJB)

and we will tell you what it means (NLT)

we: This refers to the advisers, experts, and dream interpreters in general (the “astrologers” from 2:2a). If your language distinguishes between we inclusive and we exclusive, you should use we exclusive here.

General Comment on 2:4

The dream experts indicated that they would tell the king the meaning of his dream if and when he told them what he had dreamed. They said this politely. In some languages it may be natural to say more directly:

If you tell us the dream, we will interpret it for you.

When you tell us what you dreamed, we will tell you what it meant.

Daniel 2:5

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel

then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:5–6

The king insisted that his expert advisers must both tell him what he had dreamed and interpret it for him.

2:5a

The king replied to the astrologers, “My word is final:

- ¶ The king answered his advisers: “My decision/intention is firm:
- ¶ The king declared: “I have made my decision:

The king replied to the astrologers: The BSB uses one verb, replied, but the Aramaic phrase uses two verbs that can be translated as “answered and said.” The king denied his advisers’ request. Introduce Nebuchadnezzar’s response in the way that is most natural in your language. For example:

The king declared

The king made this reply:

the astrologers: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the astrologers is literally “the Chaldeans.” See the Notes on this same word at 2:4a. The term here again probably refers back to all the experts whom the king had summoned.

My word is final: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as My word is final is more literally “The word from me is sure,” as in the RSV. Scholars disagree as to the meaning of the word “sure” in this context:

1. It means “certain,” that is, “decided.” For example:

The word from me is firm (ESV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV, NJPS)

1. It means “proclaimed, decreed.” For example:

This is a public decree (NRSV) (KJV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the great majority of English versions. Nebuchadnezzar had made a definite decision about what to do. He was not just suggesting that his experts tell him the dream, he was requiring it. Other ways to translate this include:

The command from me is firm (NASB)

I meant what I said! (GW)

I am serious about this. (NLT)

2:5b

If you do not tell me the dream and its interpretation,

- If you^(plur) do not tell me both my dream and its meaning,
- Tell^(plur) me what the dream was and explain what it means. If you^(plur) fail to do so,
- You^(plur) must tell me what I saw in my dream and then interpret what it means, or else

If you do not tell me the dream: This clause introduces a stern warning. If the experts did not obey the king, he would punish them severely. Probably he was pretending to forget the dream in order to test them. Languages have different ways to introduce a warning like this. Some ways to say it in English are:

If you do not tell me what my dream was... (NLT)

You must tell me the dream...If you do/can not

Express the meaning in a way that is natural in your language.

tell: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as tell means “inform, cause to know.”

and its interpretation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as its interpretation is the same as in 2:4d. It refers to explaining how the dream would come true or be fulfilled. Other ways to translate this include:

and what it means (NLT)

and its meaning (GW)

2:5c

you will be cut into pieces

- I will command my soldiers to cut your^(plur) bodies into pieces
- I will order my men to chop you^(plur) up

you will be cut into pieces: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates you will be cut into pieces is literally “I will have you made into parts/limbs.” This clause indicates that the king would order others to kill his advisers by cutting them up, probably with a sword. There are several ways to translate it:

- Using an active verb. You may need to supply an actor. For example:

I will command my soldiers to cut you into bits

- Using a passive verb. For example:

you will be chopped to pieces (CEV)

- Using a causative verb. For example:

I will have you torn apart (NCV)

I will cause you to be cut to pieces

cut into pieces: The punishment the dream experts were to receive was death. The king would order his soldiers/servants to punish them by chopping their bodies into pieces. The kings in the Ancient Near East were often very cruel. They punished people severely if they disobeyed. Other ways to translate this include:

hacked limb from limb (REB)

chopped up

2:5d

and your houses will be reduced to rubble.

- and to make your^(plur) homes into heaps of rocks/junk.
- and destroy/demolish your^(plur) homes.

and your houses will be reduced to rubble: This verse part is a short way of saying “I will have your houses turned into piles of rubble.” The king would order others to destroy the homes of his advisers. Their families would not be able to live in them anymore. There are several ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and your houses turned into piles of rubble (NIV)

and your houses shall be laid in ruins (NRSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

and they will destroy your homes

and the soldiers will make your houses a pile of stones

- Using a causative verb. For example:

and I will cause your home to be destroyed

rubble: The exact meaning of the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rubble is uncertain. It probably refers to useless heaps of stones, all that would remain after the destruction of the houses. Other ways to translate this include:

heaps of rubble (NLT)

a pile of ruins (GNT)

a complete ruin

Daniel 2:6

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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Paragraph 2:5–6

The king insisted that his expert advisers must both tell him what he had dreamed and interpret it for him.

2:6a

But if you tell me the dream and its interpretation,

- But if you^(plur) tell me what I dreamed and also explain what the dream means,
- But if any/one of you^(plur) tells me what I dreamed and what it means,

But: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* here introduces a contrast. In Daniel 2:5 the king threatened to punish the experts if they did not explain his dream. In 2:6 the king offered to reward them if they did explain it.

if you tell me the dream and its interpretation: The Aramaic text says more literally "if you declare/reveal the dream and its interpretation." The indirect object *me* is implied. The king demanded that his advisers both tell him what he had dreamed and explain to him what it meant. Other ways to translate this include:

if you can disclose the dream and its interpretation (NET)

if you can tell me both the dream and its meaning (GNT)

if you tell me what I dreamed and what the dream means (NLT)

if you tell: The Aramaic verb is plural here. The king was speaking to his advisers in general. But he was not expecting them to all reply together. So in some languages it may be more natural to say:

if any of you tell

if one of you tells

and its interpretation: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as and its interpretation is the same Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as “and its interpretation” in 2:5b. See the note there. Some other ways to say this are:

and what the dream means (NLT)

and its meaning (GNT)

2:6b

you will receive from me gifts and rewards and great honor.

- I will give you^(plur) many wonderful gifts and I will give you^(plur) great honor.
- then I will richly reward him/you^(sing) and honor him/you^(sing) with an important position in my kingdom.

you will receive from me gifts and rewards and great honor: The king promised that he would reward the experts for telling him his dream and its interpretation. In some languages it may be natural to focus on the king by making him the subject of the verb. For example:

I will give you many... (NLT)

I will reward you with... (GNT)

gifts and rewards: These two words are close synonyms. Together they emphasize the quality and number of the gifts. If you have only one word or phrase in your language with this meaning, you can use it here. For example:

many wonderful gifts (NLT)

you will be richly rewarded by me (REB)

rewards: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rewards is in the singular, “a reward.” It is a rare word that is used only here and in Daniel 5:17. It seems to refer to something good that would be done or given to someone.

and great honor: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as great honor may refer to a high position

or title. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea with a verb and say that the king would honor the advisers who interpreted the dream. For example:

and I will honor you

2:6c

So tell me the dream and its interpretation.”

- Now tell^(plur) me what I have dreamed and what the dream means.”
- So tell^(plur) me what the dream was and what it means/signifies!”

So tell me the dream and its interpretation: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces what the dream experts should do as a result of what the king had told them about rewards and punishments. Express this relationship in a way that is natural in your language. Possible models include:

So tell me what the dream was about and reveal to me what it means.

Now tell me the dream and explain what it means. (CEV)

Now then, tell me what the dream was and what it means. (GNT)

Daniel 2:7

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Paragraph 2:7–9

The dream experts repeated their request that the king tell them his dream, and the king repeated his demand that they explain its meaning.

2:7a

They answered a second time,

- ¶ The advisers again replied:
- ¶ The king's divination/occult experts gave him the same reply as before:

They answered a second time: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as They answered a second time introduces the experts' response to the king. It was almost but not exactly the same as their response in 2:4. It suggests there was increased tension between the experts and the king. The experts still hoped to influence the king to change what he had decided. Other ways to translate it include:

Once more they replied (NIV)

They answered the king again (GNT)

Once more they said (GW)

The king's advisors repeated their answer

In some languages it may not be necessary to translate the words a second time, since this idea is implied by the context. However, if it is possible to choose a verb that indicates tension between the experts and the king, you should use it here.

2:7b

"Let the king tell the dream to his servants,

- “Your Majesty, please tell us^(excl) your servants what you^(sing) dreamed,
- “Our^(excl) king, if you^(sing) tell us^(excl) what happened in the dream,
- “We^(excl) are your^(sing) servants. You^(sing) are our^(excl) king. If you^(sing) will only tell us^(excl) what you^(sing) dreamed,

Let the king tell the dream to his servants: The experts referred to themselves and the king in the third person, as though they were talking about other people. They spoke this way to show respect to the king. The BSB has translated this literally, but your language may have a different way to show respect. Some ways to do this in English are:

Your Majesty, tell us the dream (GW)

Please, Your Majesty. Tell us the dream (NLT)

Sire, if you would kindly tell us what the dream was...

See the Notes at 2:4b–c, especially concerning the expression “your servants.”

2:7c

and we will give the interpretation.”

- and we^(excl) will explain/reveal its meaning to you^(sing).”
- then we^(excl) will tell you^(sing) what it means.”
- we^(excl) will tell/give you^(sing) its interpretation.”

and: The word and in the BSB translates an Aramaic connector that in this context introduces a result clause. If the king told his dream, this is what the advisers would do. Here is another way to translate this:

Then we can give its interpretation (REB)

we will give the interpretation: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as give the interpretation here means to explain the meaning of something. It is the same expression as in 2:6c. Some ways to translate this expression in English are:

we will reveal to you what it means

we will tell you what it means (NLT)

we will explain it (GNT)

Daniel 2:8

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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Paragraph 2:7-9

The dream experts repeated their request that the king tell them his dream, and the king repeated his demand that they explain its meaning.

2:8a

The king replied, "I know for sure that you are stalling for time,

- ¶ Then the king declared, "I know that you^(plur) are trying to stall for time
- ¶ Then the king exclaimed, "It is obvious that you^(plur) are just trying to delay.

The king replied: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as replied here introduces the king's rejection

of his advisers' request. He refused to do as they asked. Introduce this refusal in a way that is natural in your language. Some ways to do that in English are:

The king declared

The king asserted

the king exclaimed (GNT)

I know for sure: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as I know for sure adds emphasis to the next clause. Some ways to say this in English are:

I am sure (GW)

It is clear to me (REB)

I know with certainty (RSV)

that you are stalling for time: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as stalling for time is an idiom that refers to deliberately causing a delay. The king thought his advisers wanted to postpone answering him because they did not know what to say. Many languages will have idiomatic ways of saying this. In English there are several. For example:

You are trying to gain time (NIV)

you're trying to buy some time (GW)

you are just delaying things

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the experts.

2:8b

because you see that my word is final.

- because you^(plur) know that my decision is firm:
- You^(plur) are well aware that I have made my decision:

because: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as because here introduces a reason clause. The experts realized that the king meant what he said about punishing them, and so they wanted to have more time to think what to say. In some languages you may have to add some implied information. For example:

because you do not know the meaning of the dream and

you see that: Here the Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as you see refers to understanding or perceiving something.

my word is final: This is the same expression that was used in 2:5a. See the note there, and follow the same interpretation here as you did there. Some ways to say this in English are:

I have come to this firm decision (REB)

I meant what I said (NCV)

I have made up my mind (GNT)

General Comment on 2:8b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 2:8b–c, putting the reason first. For example:

^{8c}You realize that that I have made this firm decision ^{8b}and so you are trying to gain yourselves some time.

Daniel 2:9

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
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4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:7–9

The dream experts repeated their request that the king tell them his dream, and the king repeated his demand that they explain its meaning.

2:9a

If you do not tell me the dream,

- If you^(plur) do not tell me what I dreamed,
- If you^(plur) fail to tell me what my dream was,

If you do not tell me the dream: This is a negative conditional clause, suggesting that something might not happen. Perhaps the experts would fail to tell the king what he had dreamed. Other ways to translate this include:

If you don't inform me of the dream (NET)

If you fail to tell me what my dream was

tell: This is a general verb that means “inform, cause to know,” as in 2:5b.

the dream: In some languages it may be natural to say:

my dream (NCV)

2:9b

there is only one decree for you.

- you^(plur) will all receive the same penalty/punishment.
- I will punish you^(plur) all in the same way.

there is only one decree for you: The king said that all of his advisers would receive the same punishment. If they could not tell him his dream, he would punish them all in the same way. Other ways to translate this include:

there is only one thing that is going to happen to you (NET)

there is but one sentence for you (RSV)

you will all receive the same punishment

decree: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as decree literally means “law.” This “law” refers to the decree that the king made in 2:5b about punishing his advisers. Some ways to say this in English are:

verdict (NRSV)

punishment (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to express this abstract idea using a verb. For example:

I will punish you all in the way I decreed.

General Comment on 2:9a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 2:9a–b. For example:

I have made up my mind ^{9b}to give all of you the same punishment ^{9a}if you don't tell me the dream. (GNT)

2:9c

You have conspired to speak before me false and fraudulent words,

- You^(plur) have plotted together to lie and deceive me,
- You^(plur) have agreed/decided together to lie to me. You^(plur) have spoken wickedly

You have conspired to speak before me false and fraudulent words: The king accused his expert advisers of agreeing together to deceive him. Other ways to translate this include:

You have agreed to speak lying and corrupt words before me (ESV)

You have agreed among yourselves to make up a phony explanation to give me (GW)

You have conspired: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as conspired here means to agree secretly together to do something wrong. For example:

You have agreed among yourselves (NJB)

You have planned/plotted

You've decided (CEV)

to speak before me false and fraudulent words: The king accused his advisers of continuing to lie to him. Here is another way to translate this:

to go on telling me lies (GNT)

false and fraudulent words: The Aramaic phrase that BSB translates as false and fraudulent words is more literally “a false and corrupt word.” Other ways to translate this include:

lying and corrupt words (RSV)

misleading and wicked things (NIV)

lying and misleading (NRSV)

In this context false and fraudulent have similar meanings. In some languages it is most natural to use one word or phrase to express this meaning. For example:

a bunch of lies (CEV)

a phony explanation (GW)

2:9d

hoping the situation will change.

- hoping that something will change/happen to save you.
- in the hope that I would change the decree.

hoping the situation will change: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as situation is more literally “time.” Here it refers to a possible time in the future when the king might be willing to change what he decreed. Or it might refer to a time when a new king would reign, and it would be an indication of Nebuchadnezzar’s death. But it is best not to make this explicit. Other ways to translate this include:

till the times change (RSV)

hoping that things will change (GW)

because you hope that in time the situation will change

You are hoping that eventually the decree will fail/cease.

2:9e

Therefore tell me the dream,

- So tell^(plur) me now what I dreamed.
- Therefore tell^(plur) me what happened in my dream.

Therefore tell me the dream: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces what the advisers should do as a result of what the king has just said. It implies that the king does not want any more delay. English versions have different ways of expressing this.

- Some versions use a connector that introduces the result clause. For example:

So then tell me the dream (NIV)

- Some versions do not use an explicit connector. The result relation is left implied from the context. For example:

Tell me what the dream was (GNT)

tell me the dream: This instruction implies that the experts should tell the king what he had dreamed. It does not refer only to the interpretation of the dream. See the note on 2:6c.

2:9f

and I will know that you can give me its interpretation.”

- Then I will know that you^(plur) can explain what it means.”
- That will prove to me that you^(plur) can interpret what it means.”

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces a result clause. If the dream experts could tell Nebuchadnezzar what he had dreamed, he would believe that they had supernatural help or wisdom. Then he would trust that they could give him a correct interpretation. Introduce the result clause in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

and then (GNT)

so that (NASB)

I will know that you can give me its interpretation:

There is some implied information here. Nebuchadnezzar understood that his experts could tell him his dream only if they had supernatural knowledge. Telling him his dream would prove they were genuine magicians, fortunetellers, or sorcerers. He would then be able to trust that their interpretation was reliable, not just something they had made up themselves. The following are some ways to translate this sentence in English:

I'll know that you can explain its meaning to me
(GW)

I will know that you can also tell me what it means
(GNT)

that will show me that you are able to interpret
it for me

Daniel 2:10

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. **Lists:** The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. **Synonyms:** The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. **Poetry:** You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. **Repetition:** Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom

(2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:10–11

The king's experts and advisers all assured the king that his demand was impossible. Nobody could tell the king his dream. Only a god could do that.

2:10a

The astrologers answered the king, “No one on earth can do what the king requests!”

- ¶ The king's advisers said to him, “No one in the whole world can do what Your Majesty has asked.
- ¶ But the divination/occult experts gave this reply, “Sir, there is no human being who can tell you^(sing) what you dreamed!

The astrologers: The phrase The astrologers here refers back in general to the king's experts and advisers listed in 2:2a. See the Notes at 2:4a and translate it as you did there.

answered the king: See the Notes at 2:5a. In this context the Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates answered the king introduces a response that disagrees with someone of higher status. Use an appropriate expression in your language. For example:

responded to the king

asserted

objected to the king's command

No one on earth can do what the king requests!:

This is an emphatic way for the advisers to say that they could not do what the king asked. They thought that it was impossible for anyone to do it. Other ways to translate this include:

No one on earth can tell the king what he asks.
(GW)

no human being can fulfill your Majesty's request

There is no one on earth who can reveal what the king demands! (NRSV)

No one on earth: The phrase No one on earth means “nobody at all.” No human being could know what someone else had dreamed about. Here is another way to translate this:

Nobody in the world (NJB)

can do what the king requests: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as can do what the king requests is literally “who will be able to tell the king's matter/thing.” This refers to the king's problem or question concerning what he saw in his dream. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

can tell the king his dream (NLT)

the king: Again the experts addressed the king in the third person to show respect. In some languages it may be more natural to address him with second-person pronouns like “you” and “your.” For example:

There is no one on the face of the earth who can tell Your Majesty what you want to know. (GNT)

Your Majesty, you are demanding the impossible!
(CEV)

2:10b

No king, however great and powerful, has ever asked anything like this of any magician, enchanter, or astrologer.

- No other great and mighty king like you has ever asked his advisers, magicians, or enchanters to do anything like this.
- Not even the most powerful king has ever asked his experts to tell him what he dreamed.

In the Aramaic text, 2:10b is connected to the previous verse part with a connector that some versions translate as “for.” In this context it introduces a further explanation of why the advisers/experts should not be required to tell the king his dream. The BSB leaves this connector untranslated, since it is implied by the context.

No king, however great and powerful, has ever asked anything like this of any magician, enchanter, or astrologer: The royal advisers protested to the king that his demand was unprecedented. That

is, no king had ever made such a demand before. The implication is that the king should not expect to have his demand fulfilled. Other ways to translate this include:

No other king, no matter how great and powerful, has ever asked such a thing of any magician, psychic, or astrologer (GW)

No king, not even the most famous and powerful, has ever ordered his advisors, magicians, or wise men to do such a thing (CEV)

No great and powerful king has ever asked the fortune-tellers, magicians, or wise men to do this. (NCV)

No king, however great and powerful: There are two ways to understand the Aramaic words that the BSB translates as No king, however great and powerful:

1. The words great and powerful function as adjectives describing the king. For example:

no great and powerful king (ESV) (BSB, ESV, NIV, RSV/NRSV, NET, GW, NCV, CEV, REB, NLT)

1. The words great and powerful are titles referring to other rulers: “the great one,” “the mighty one.” For example:

no other king, governor or chief (NJB)

no great king or ruler (NASB) (NASB, NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

No king: The royal advisers were saying that Nebuchadnezzar was the only king to have made such a request. In some languages it may be natural to say:

No other king (GW)

however great and powerful: The words great and powerful mean much the same thing in this context. They refer to a man with power over others. The advisers implied that Nebuchadnezzar was a great and powerful king. They were suggesting that he should behave like other great kings and not make such demands of his advisers. Other ways to translate this include:

regardless of his position and power (NET)

not even the most famous and powerful (CEV)

not even the greatest and most powerful (GNT)

any magician, enchanter, or astrologer: This list of experts is not the same as the list in 2:2a, where there is a fourth term, “sorcerer.” These names may be simply examples of the various kinds of experts whom the king summoned. You could begin the list with a general phrase. For example, “any of his experts, such as....” In some languages there may be only one or two terms to express this category. You may wish to say something like:

any of his various wise men

In some languages it may be natural to use plural forms. For example:

has ever asked the fortune-tellers, magicians, or wise men to do this (NCV)

magician: See the Notes at 2:2a.

enchanter: See the Notes at 2:2a.

astrologer: See the Notes at 2:2a.

General Comment on 2:10b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two shorter, positive sentences. For example:

Many great and mighty kings have ruled. You are the only one to have made such a demand of his magicians, enchanters, and wise men!

Daniel 2:11

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)

6. The GNT has three sections:

- (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
- (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
- (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:10–11

The king's experts and advisers all assured the king that his demand was impossible. Nobody could tell the king his dream. Only a god could do that.

2:11a

What the king requests is so difficult

- Your Majesty, you^(sing) have asked us^(excl) to do something that is too difficult/hard.
- Sir, what you^(sing) have asked is beyond our ability.
- To explain your^(sing) dream without hearing it first is impossible—

What the king requests is so difficult: The royal advisers again addressed the king in the third person to show respect. This may not be natural in your language. Another possibility is to use the second-person pronoun and a polite form of address. For example:

What you ask is too difficult, Your Majesty (GW)

Sir, what you^(sing) have asked us to do is too difficult.

so difficult: In this context the Aramaic word that the BSB translates so difficult means "impossible." Some ways to say this in English are:

too hard (CEV)

impossible thing (NLT)

can't be done (CEV)

2:11b

that no one can tell it to him except the gods,

- Only the gods can reveal to you^(sing) what you dreamed,
- Only the divine beings can reveal this dream to you^(sing).
- except for divine beings,

no one can tell it to him except the gods: The advisers explained what they meant by saying the king's command was "so difficult." It was impossible for them to obey because no one could reveal the king's dream to him. They could not know what he had dreamed unless he told them. They continued to address the king respectfully in the third person. Here are some different ways to translate this clause in English:

no one can find the king an answer to it, except the gods (NJB)

Sir, no one is able to do what you have asked. The gods alone can do it.

There is no one but the gods capable of revealing this thing to you, Your Majesty.

In some languages it may be natural to make explicit the reference of the pronoun it. For example:

no one can tell you what you dreamed (GW)

No one except the gods can tell you your dream (NLT)

no one can tell...except the gods: The phrase no one here in the BSB includes both human and divine persons, as the phrase except the gods makes clear. In some languages it may be natural or necessary to exclude the gods from phrase no one and say:

No human can.... Only the gods can....

except the gods: The phrase the gods here refers to the false deities that the Babylonians worshiped. In some languages you may have to use a different word for gods. For example:

divine beings

spirits

the ones/beings we worship

General Comment on 2:11b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

Only the gods could tell the king this. (NCV)

2:11c

whose dwelling is not with mortals."

- and they do not live among us^(incl) human beings.
- Those beings do not stay with mere people like us^(incl) so that we^(excl) could consult them."
- who are very far from us^(incl) human beings."

whose dwelling is not with mortals: This verse part indicates that the gods do not live on earth, among human beings. The experts were implying that the gods were so distant that they could not consult them about the dream. Other ways to translate this include:

whose dwelling is not with flesh (RSV)

and they do not live here on earth with us^(incl)

mortals: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mortals is more literally "flesh." It emphasizes the weakness of human beings. Humans eventually die. Some ways to express this emphasis in English are:

with humans (NIV)

among mere human beings

among mortal men

In some languages it may be natural to use a first-person pronoun. For example:

with us^(incl)

among us^(incl) mortals

General Comment on 2:11

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of some information in this verse. For example:

^{11b}Only the gods can reveal what you have dreamed ^{11c}but they do not live here with us mortals. ^{11a}Human beings are not able to do something like this.

Daniel 2:12

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

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5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.

2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
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Paragraph 2:12–13

The king prepared to carry out his threat to kill all his expert advisers.

2:12a**This response made the king so furious with anger**

- ¶ When the king heard this, he became so very angry
- ¶ What they said enraged/angered the king, and in his fury

This response made the king so furious with anger:

His advisers' refusal to obey him caused the king to become very angry. Other ways to translate this include:

Because of this the king was angry and very furious (RSV)

The king was furious when he heard this (NLT)

When the king heard their answer, he became very angry. (NCV)

This response: The Aramaic text has only the pronoun that the BSB translates as This. It refers to what the experts said in 2:11, and the BSB has supplied the word response to indicate that.

so furious with anger: The author used two different words to describe how the king felt: the Aramaic says literally "furious and angry." The two words are similar in meaning. Together they emphasize that the king was extremely angry, and so the BSB translates them together as a phrase, furious with anger. The word so further indicates the intensity of his anger. There are at least two possibilities for translation:

- Use two expressions with similar meanings:

furious and in great rage (REB)

became irritated and enraged

- Use one emphatic expression:

the king got furiously angry (NET)

flew into a rage (GNT)

You should choose the most natural way in your language to say that the king was extremely angry.

2:12b**that he gave orders to destroy all the wise men of Babylon.**

- that he gave orders that all the Babylonian advisers/sages were to be put to death.
- he ordered the deaths of all his divination experts.

that he gave orders to destroy all the wise men of Babylon:

The king's anger was so great that he commanded his servants to put to death all his expert advisers. The Aramaic is more literally "and he said to destroy all the wise men of Babylon." The subject of the verb destroy is not mentioned. There are several ways to translate this clause:

- Using an active verb with no subject. For example:

gave orders to destroy all the wise men of Babylon (NASB)

- Using an active verb with the subject explicit. For example:

The king gave orders to his men/servants to execute all the wise men who lived in the city of Babylon.

The king commanded his guards/soldiers to kill all the Babylonian wise men.

- Using a passive verb. For example:

he ordered that all the wise men of Babylon be executed (NLT)

ordered all the Babylonian sages to be put to death (NJB)

- Using a noun. For example:

ordered the execution of all the royal advisers in Babylon (GNT)

that: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as that here introduces a result clause. The king's anger was so great or intense that he gave this command. In some languages this may be implied by a different connector. For example:

and (NLT)

he gave orders: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as gave orders is literally "said." The context implies the meaning "order, command." In some lan-

guages it may be necessary to say to whom the king was speaking or giving the order. For example:

he commanded his men

to destroy: The wise men were to be killed. The method by which they were to be put to death is not mentioned. It is probable that they were to die by being cut by swords.

all the wise men of Babylon: This refers to the same group of expert advisers who were mentioned in 2:2a and in 2:10b. It is a general term that includes all of the experts in general. They were professionals who worked as advisers for the king, not ordinary men with special wisdom. Other ways to say this are:

royal advisers (GNT)

Babylonian sages (NJB)

Babylon: This name can refer to either the city or the kingdom. Most English versions are ambiguous. If you must make a choice, refer to the city of Babylon.

General Comment on 2:12b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's command as a direct quotation. For example:

The king said to his servants, "Kill all the wise men in the city/land!"

The king gave his men the command: "Put to death every one of my so-called experts!"

Daniel 2:13

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:

(a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)

(b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)

(c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. **Repetition:** Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36-45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:12-13

The king prepared to carry out his threat to kill all his expert advisers.

2:13a

So the decree went out that the wise men were to be executed,

- So the decree went out that the soldiers should execute the advisers/sages.
- So his officials announced the king's order.

So the decree went out that the wise men were to be executed: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. The words the wise men were to be executed give the content of the decree. For example:

So a decree was issued that the wise men were to be killed. (GW) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV, REB, NJB, GW, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. There are two separate ideas: the decree was issued and the wise men were about to be executed. For example:

So a decree went out, and the wise men were about to be executed. (NET) (NRSV, ESV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English translations. Nebuchadnezzar gave an order to his soldiers to kill all the Babylonian sages. There is some repetition here. See the General Comment on 2:12-13.

So: The common Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces a result clause. You should use a form that expresses this meaning in a way that is natural in your language. Your decision may depend on how you translated the connector at the beginning of 2:12a.

that the wise men were to be executed: The Aramaic text does not make explicit who were to put the wise men to death. There are several way to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

that the wise men were to be slain (RSV)

- Using an active verb. In some languages it may be necessary to supply a subject. For example:

to execute them (NRSV)

that the soldiers/executioners should kill the wise men

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language.

General Comment on 2:13a

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 2:13a. For example:

So King Nebuchadnezzar's order to kill the wise men was announced. (NCV)

2:13b

and men went to look for Daniel and his friends to execute them.

- Daniel and his companions were included/counted among these advisers/sages, so the soldiers began to search for them to kill them.
- Men were told/sent to find and kill Daniel and his three friends, as well as the other experts.

and men went to look for Daniel and his friends to execute them: The men were sent to look for Daniel and his companions so that they could be executed, as the king had ordered. Other ways to translate this include:

and they sought Daniel and his companions, to slay them (RSV)

men were sent to find and kill Daniel and his friends (NLT)

search was made for Daniel and his companions to have them put to death (NJB)

men went to look for Daniel and his friends: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as men went to look for is more literally “they sought.” It does not say who did the seeking. The BSB has supplied the information that it was men who went to look for them. The king ordered some of his men to find out where Daniel and his friends were. Some versions use a passive verb that puts the focus on these men. For example:

men were sent to look for Daniel and his friends (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to use an active verb here. For example:

and they looked for Daniel and his friends to kill them (NASB)

and the king sent some men to find Daniel and his friends

the king ordered a search

men: In some languages it may be necessary to say who these men were. If that is true in your language, you may say:

the king’s men/soldiers

Daniel and his friends: There is some implied information here: Daniel and his friends were among the wise men, the advisers to the king. That is why the king’s men were looking for them. They were going to kill them along with all the other advisers. In some languages it may be necessary to make this information explicit in order to avoid confusion. For example:

Daniel and his companions were wise men/advisers, and so the king’s men went to look for them and kill them.

his friends: This refers to Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. See 1:6, 7. Here is another way to translate this:

his companions (RSV)

General Comment on 2:12–13

2:13a repeats information that was mentioned in 2:12. In some languages it may therefore be natural to combine verses 12 and 13. For example:

This made the king so angry that he gave orders for every wise man in Babylonia to be put to death, including Daniel and his three friends. (CEV)

Daniel 2:14

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
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4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend

for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.

2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not,

you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:14–16

Daniel was able to persuade the king to delay the executions and give him time to interpret the dream.

2:14a

When Arioch, the commander of the king’s guard, had gone out to execute the wise men of Babylon,

- ¶ Arioch, who was in charge of the king’s guard, set out to execute the Babylonian sages/advisers.
- ¶ At that time the captain of the king’s guards was a man named Arioch. As Arioch was on his way to kill the divination experts in Babylon,

When Arioch, the commander of the king’s guard, had gone out to execute the wise men of Babylon:

This clause indicates the time at which Daniel intervened to prevent the executions. It indicates an important action and introduces a conversation that changes the narrative. Embedded in this clause is some background information, the name and position of the man in charge of the execution. In view of all this, in some languages it may be natural to translate this verse part using an independent clause or clauses. For example:

Arioch, the commander of the king’s guard, was going to kill the wise men of Babylon. (NCV)

Arioch was the king’s official in charge of putting the wise men to death. He was on his way to have it done, when... (CEV)

the commander of the king’s guard: Arioch was in charge of a group of men, the king’s guard. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as guard comes from a word meaning “kill.” One of the responsibilities of the men in the guard was to execute criminals and enemies. Here is another way to translate this:

who was in charge of the king’s executioners (NET)

The guard probably had other responsibilities as well, such as protecting the king. Most English translations therefore use the more general expression guard.

the king’s guard: The English word guard is a collective noun. It is singular in form but refers to a group of men.

had gone out to execute the wise men of Babylon: This clause probably indicates that Arioch had left the

king's presence and was preparing to kill the wise men. He was on his journey to find them but had probably not started killing them yet. Other ways to translate this include:

set out to execute the wise men of Babylon (REB)

was leaving to kill the wise advisers in Babylon (NET)

was on his way to kill the Babylonian sages (NJB)

the wise men of Babylon: The phrase the wise men of Babylon refers in general to the king's advisers and practitioners of divination. It includes all the experts who were mentioned in 2:2. See the Notes at 2:12b.

2:14b

Daniel replied with discretion and tact.

- Daniel spoke to him with sensible, tactful words.
- Daniel met him and spoke to him wisely,

Daniel replied with discretion and tact: The Aramaic text is more literally "Daniel returned counsel and prudence to Arioch." It indicates that Daniel spoke to Arioch in a way that would not anger him and was wise in that situation. There are two ways to interpret and translate the phrase with discretion and tact in this context:

- as two similar ideas. For example:

with wisdom and skill (NCV)

with prudence and discretion (NRSV)

- as one idea, indicating that Daniel's reply was characterized by "prudent counsel" or "tactful wisdom." For example:

He spoke to him using shrewd judgment (GW)

Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to use adjectives for both ideas. For example:

with shrewd and cautious words (NJB)

General Comment on 2:14

This verse contains background information concerning Arioch. In some languages it may be more natural

to change the order of information in this verse. For example:

^b At that time Arioch was the commander of the king's guards. ^cAs he was going to kill the wise men of Babylon, ^aDaniel spoke to him with wisdom and skill. (NCV)

Daniel 2:15

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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6. The GNT has three sections:
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are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
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Paragraph 2:14–16

Daniel was able to persuade the king to delay the executions and give him time to interpret the dream.

2:15a

“Why is the decree from the king so harsh?” he asked.

- He asked the royal officer, Arioch, “Sir, may I ask why the king’s decree is so severe?”
- asking the reason for the king’s harsh/severe order.

Why is the decree from the king so harsh?: The Aramaic question is more literally, “Why is decree from the king harsh?” The BSB has supplied the word so, as is natural in English to add emphasis and intensity. The RSV supplies emphasis by saying:

Why has the king issued such a harsh decree?
(NLT)

In some languages, this question may seem too direct or even rude. If that is so in your language, you may need to express the question in a different way that would be polite in your language. For example:

May I ask why the king has issued this severe decree?

harsh: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as harsh occurs only here and in 3:22 in the Old Testament. Scholars interpret this word in different ways:

1. The word means “harsh, severe.” For example:

cruel orders (CEV) (BSB, GW, GNT, NLT, NIV, NJB, CEV, NCV, RSV)

1. The word means “urgent.” For example:

urgent (NET) (NJPS, NRSV, NET, NASB, KJV, ESV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In some languages it may be natural to focus on the punishment that the decree ordered. For example:

Why did the king order such a terrible punishment? (NCV)

he asked: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates asked is literally, “he answered and said.” See the Notes at 2:5a; 2:10a. In some languages it may not be natural to use two verbs like this. If that is true in your language, you may use one verb. For example:

he said to Arioch, the king’s captain (RSV)

General Comment on 2:15a

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for this question. For example:

he asked Arioch why the king had issued such a harsh order (GNT)

2:15b

At this time Arioch explained the situation to Daniel.

- Then Arioch explained everything to Daniel.
- So Arioch told Daniel what had happened.

At this time: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as *At this time* introduces what Arioch said next. Arioch replied when and because Daniel asked him this question. Here are some other way to translate this:

So (GNT)

Then (NET)

Some English versions leave this conjunction implicit. It is recommended that you introduce what Arioch replied in a way that is natural in your language.

Arioch explained the situation to Daniel: Arioch explained to Daniel why the king had ordered the advisers to be executed. Other ways to say this include:

Arioch informed Daniel about the matter. (NET)

Arioch told Daniel what had happened (GNT)

Arioch explained the whole situation.

the situation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as *situation* can mean “word” or “thing.” In this context it refers to the situation in general. Other ways to translate it include:

everything (GW)

all that had happened (NLT)

Daniel 2:16

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. **Repetition:** Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:14–16

Daniel was able to persuade the king to delay the executions and give him time to interpret the dream.

2:16a

So Daniel went in and asked the king to give him some time,

- ¶ Then Daniel went in to talk to the king. He asked him for more time
- ¶ Daniel approached the king and requested that he postpone the punishment/executions to give him an opportunity

So Daniel went in and asked the king to give him some time: Daniel asked King Nebuchadnezzar to delay carrying out his decree.

So: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as *So* here indicates the next event in a temporal sequence. In some languages no connector may be needed. Other ways to translate it include:

Then (KJV)

And (RSV)

Use a form in your language that naturally indicates the next event in a sequence.

Daniel went in and asked the king: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates *went in and asked* here indicates that Daniel went to see the king to talk to him. He officially entered the king's presence. If you have a way of referring to going to see an important person, you may use it here.

asked the king to give him some time: Scholars have interpreted this clause differently:

1. The clause means that Daniel asked the king to allow him more time so that he could interpret the dream. For example:

requested more time (NLT) (BSB, NJB, NIV, KJV, NRSV, REB, GW, GNT, NLT)

1. The clause means that Daniel asked the king for an appointment time, when he would tell the king about his dream. Here is another way to translate this:

asked for an appointment (NCV) (NCV, RSV)

Some versions are ambiguous (NASB, KJV, NET). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Daniel was asking for more time to explain the dream. He was requesting that the king postpone the punishment of the wise men to some later date. Other ways to translate this include:

asked the king to give him some time (GW)

to ask the king for a stay of execution (NJB)

It is implied from the following context that the king agreed to Daniel's request. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this. For example:

obtained royal permission for more time (GNT)

2:16b

so that he could give him the interpretation.

- to tell the king what the dream meant.
- to interpret the dream for the king. The king agreed.

so that he could give him the interpretation: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as so that in this context introduces Daniel's purpose in asking for more time. Daniel asked for a longer period of time so that he could interpret the dream for the king. Other ways to translate this include:

so that he could tell the king what the dream meant (GNT)

so that he could explain the dream's meaning (GW)

he could give him the interpretation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as give is literally "show." The word that the BSB translates as interpretation refers to the meaning of the dream. The implication is that Daniel would be able to show the king the meaning of his dream by revelation, that is, by supernatural means. See the Notes at 2:6a, 2:9a.

In some languages it may be necessary to include the implied information that the king agreed to Daniel's request. For example:

The king agreed.

General Comment on 2:16a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate Daniel's request as direct speech. For example:

Daniel rushed off and said to the king, "If you will just give me some time, I'll explain your dream." (CEV)

Daniel 2:17

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a

Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:17–18

Daniel asked his friends to pray that God would show him the dream and spare their lives.

2:17a

Then Daniel returned to his house

- ¶ So Daniel went home
- ¶ Then Daniel went back to his house

2:17b

and explained the matter to his friends Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah,

- and told his friends Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah what had happened.
- and explained everything to Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, his companions.

2:17

Then Daniel returned to his house: After the king gave Daniel more time to think about his dream, Daniel returned home. Other ways to translate this clause include:

So Daniel went home

When Daniel arrived at his house

and explained the matter: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as matter here is the same one that was used in 2:15b, where the BSB translated it as “situation.” See the notes there. Translation models include:

and told his friends...what had happened (GNT)

and explained everything to his three companions

his friends Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah: The author used the Hebrew names here. See the Notes at 1:7b and 1:7c, and spell the names as you did there. Daniel’s friends were also mentioned in 2:13b, but they were not named. In your translation it should be clear that these are the same friends.

Daniel 2:18

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
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5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.

2. **Synonyms:** The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. **Poetry:** You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
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Paragraph 2:17–18

Daniel asked his friends to pray that God would show him the dream and spare their lives.

2:18a

urging them to plead for mercy from the God of heaven concerning this mystery,

- He asked them to pray that the God of heaven would be merciful and help them understand this mystery
- He told them to pray for help from the God who rules from heaven. They should ask him to tell them the dream

urging them to plead for mercy from the God of heaven:

The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as urging them to plead for mercy is more literally “for mercy to ask/seek.” The BSB has supplied the words urging them. Daniel told his friends what he wanted them to do: to pray and ask God for mercy. Other translations supply this information in different ways (underlined):

He urged them to plead for mercy from the God of heaven (NIV)

He asked them to pray for mercy from the God of heaven (NET)

He told them to ask the God of heaven to be merciful (GW)

In some languages it may be most natural to use direct speech here. See the General Comment on 2:18. Here is another way to translate this:

Then he said, “Pray that the God who rules from heaven will be merciful...” (CEV)

mercy: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mercy refers to feelings and actions of compassion, kindness, and pity. Daniel wanted his friends to ask God to be kind to them and help them by revealing to them the king’s dream. This would save their lives. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the noun mercy as a verb. For example:

He urged them to pray that the God of heaven would be merciful to them

the God of heaven: The phrase the God of heaven means “the God who is/lives in heaven.” This is a title for the one true God. This title for God is also found in Genesis 24:7 and the longer form “the God of heaven and earth” in Genesis 24:3. The Babylonian experts believed that people did not have direct contact with

gods. See 2:11b. Daniel, however, believed that the one true God did reveal things directly to men on earth.

In some languages a literal translation of the God of heaven may imply or suggest that there is another God who is not in heaven. It is important to translate in a way that avoids this implication. There is only one God, and he dwells and reigns in heaven. It may be possible to avoid the wrong meaning by saying:

God, the one who is in heaven

In some languages it may be necessary to expand the title God of heaven. For example:

the God who rules from heaven (CEV)

heaven: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as heaven here refers to the place where God lives and reigns. See “heaven, sky” in KBT.

concerning this mystery: Daniel and his companions wanted God to help them know what the king had dreamed and what the dream meant. For example:

Pray that the God who rules from heaven will be merciful and explain this mystery (CEV)

He urged them to ask the God of heaven to show them his mercy by telling them the secret (NLT)

mystery: The Bible uses this word only in the book of Daniel. The mystery refers to both the dream and its interpretation. Baldwin (p. 89) believes that the king forgot the dream, so that the mystery includes both the dream and the interpretation. The UBS Handbook interprets the mystery as referring only to the interpretation. In this context the mystery was something that only God could reveal. Be careful not to use a word that is related to local pagan religions. Here is another way to translate this:

secret (NLT)

2:18b

so that Daniel and his friends would not be killed with the rest of the wise men of Babylon.

- so that the king would not have them put to death with the other advisers/sages of Babylon.
- so that they would not die along with the king’s other experts.

so that Daniel and his friends would not be killed:

Daniel wanted his friends to pray that God would show him mercy by revealing to him the king’s dream. Then he and his friends would not be executed. This was the result that Daniel desired and hoped for.

so that: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as so that here introduces the final result that Daniel wanted. If God showed mercy and revealed the dream, then the Hebrew youths would not die.

Daniel and his friends would not be killed: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as Daniel and his friends would not be killed is more literally “they (indefinite) might not kill Daniel and his companions.” The subject is indefinite. There are several ways to translate this:

- Using an active verb and making the subject explicit. For example:

the king might not have him and his friends put to death

the king’s men/soldiers might not execute him and his friends

- Making Daniel and his friends the subject of an active verb. For example:

Daniel and his companions might not perish (RSV)

- Using a passive verb. For example:

he and his friends would not be killed (NCV)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

with the rest of the wise men of Babylon: It is not clear whether at this point Daniel was trying to save just himself and his three friends or all of the wise men. There are two possibilities:

1. Daniel was praying that the king would spare him and his friends. For example:

so that Daniel and his friends might be spared the fate of the other Babylonian sages (NJB) (BSB, KJV, NJB, NASB, RSV, ESV, NIV, REB, NJB, NET, NLT, NCV)

1. Daniel prayed that the king would spare him, his friends, and all the rest of the wise men. For example:

so that we and the others won't be put to death
(CEV) (CEV, NRSV)

It is good to leave this ambiguous if possible. However, if it is necessary to choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1).

wise men: See the Notes at 2:12, where the same word is used. Daniel was referring to the group of divination experts who advised the king. This included all the various groups of experts listed in 2:2a. Other ways to translate this include:

other advisers (GNT)

wise advisers (GW)

sages (NJB)

General Comment on 2:18

In some languages it may be natural to translate what Daniel said to his friends as direct speech. For example:

^{18a}Daniel said to them, “Pray for us to the God of heaven. Ask him to save us ^{18b}from being executed with the rest of the wise men of Babylon.”

Daniel 2:19

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
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 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
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 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
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Paragraph 2:19–23

God revealed to Daniel what the king had dreamed and what the dream meant. Daniel expressed his thanks to God.

The author has recorded Daniel's prayer of thanks in poetic form. Some translations (for example, the NJB) indicate this by the way they print the lines. You may have a special way of writing poetic speech in your language. If so, you may use it here.

In his prayer of thanks, Daniel first refers to God in the third person (using the pronouns "he/him"). Then in 2:23 he switches to the second person (that is, using the pronoun "you"). In some languages this change may be unnatural. See the General Comment on 2:20–22.

2:19a

During the night, the mystery was revealed to Daniel in a vision,

- ¶ In the night Daniel received a vision that explained the mystery.
- ¶ During the night God revealed the secret to Daniel in a vision.
- ¶ While Daniel was sleeping, God caused him to have a dream and explained to him the mystery of the king's dream.

2:19a connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction that most English versions translate as "Then." It introduces what happened next. The BSB does not explicitly translate this conjunction. Introduce what happened next in a way that is natural in your language.

During the night, the mystery was revealed to Daniel in a vision: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as During the night...in a vision is more

literally "in a vision of the night," as in the RSV. Here is another way to translate this:

in a night vision (NET)

During the night: It is not clear on exactly what night this happened. The text does not explicitly state that it was that same night, but it might have been. It is good to leave this possibility open.

the mystery was revealed to Daniel: Here the verb is passive, and there are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

The mystery was then revealed to Daniel in a night-vision (NJB)

- Using an active verb. You may need to supply the subject, God. God was the one who revealed the dream to Daniel. For example:

God explained the secret to Daniel (NCV)

the mystery: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the mystery is the same as was used in 2:18a. It refers to the same thing, the dream and its interpretation. See the Notes there.

in a vision: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as vision is different from the one for "dream" in 2:4c and the following verses. However, in this chapter, the author seems to use the two words in a similar way. The context implies that these were not ordinary dreams. They came from God and revealed a secret that only he could reveal. As a result, most English versions have "vision" here.

In some languages there may not be different expressions to refer to ordinary dreams and visions. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use an expression such as:

in a dream from God

2:19b

and he blessed the God of heaven

- So Daniel blessed God who is/lives in heaven,
- Then Daniel praised God, the one who rules from heaven.

This verse part indicates Daniel's response to God for revealing the king's dream.

and he blessed the God of heaven: To “bless” God is to express honor, praise, and thanks to him. See how you translated this idea in Genesis 9:26, Psalm 66:8, 103:1, and Romans 9:5. For example:

Then Daniel praised the God of heaven (NIV)

Then Daniel said good things about the God of heavenft Translator’s Handbook on Daniel

the God of heaven: This is the same title that was used in 2:18a. It means “the God who dwells/lives in heaven” or “the God who rules from heaven.” It refers to the one true God and does not suggest there is another God living or ruling somewhere else. See the note at 2:18a. Here is another way to translate this:

the God who rules from heaven (CEV)

Daniel 2:20

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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tant. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:19–23

God revealed to Daniel what the king had dreamed and what the dream meant. Daniel expressed his thanks to God.

The author has recorded Daniel's prayer of thanks in poetic form. Some translations (for example, the NJB) indicate this by the way they print the lines. You may have a special way of writing poetic speech in your language. If so, you may use it here.

In his prayer of thanks, Daniel first refers to God in the third person (using the pronouns "he/him"). Then in 2:23 he switches to the second person (that is, using the pronoun "you"). In some languages this change may be unnatural. See the General Comment on 2:20–22.

2:20a

and declared: "Blessed be the name of God forever and ever,

- saying, "May the name of God receive praise/glory for all time and eternity!
- This is what he said: "May everyone/people praise God throughout all ages!
- He said, "Let us^(excl) praise you^(sing) forever!

and declared: The Aramaic phrase which the BSB translates as and declared is literally, "Daniel answered and said" (as in the KJV). See the Notes at 2:5a and 2:10a. This introduces the content of Daniel's prayer of thanks, what he said when he "blessed" God (see 2:19b). Versions such as the GNT and CEV leave these words untranslated and implied by the context. Introduce Daniel's prayer in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

saying,

This was his prayer:

in these words

Blessed be the name of God forever and ever: Daniel called for God to receive praises throughout eternity. See how you translated the similar expressions in Job 1:21 and Psalm 113:2. Daniel was honoring and thanking God for revealing to him the king's dream. He did not

mention himself, but his call for God to receive praise functions as praise. He declared God to be worthy of praise.

Blessed be: See the Notes at 2:19b. The Aramaic verb is passive. If it is more natural to use an active form, you can say:

May people praise...

Everyone should praise...

Let usWhether an inclusive or an exclusive pronoun is used may depend on how God is addressed in this prayer. If you translate "the name of God" using a second-person pronoun ("you"), an exclusive pronoun will be necessary here. praise...

the name of God: Daniel used the phrase the name of God to refer to God himself. This was a common Hebrew idiom. It was also a respectful way that Jewish people referred to God's personal name Yahweh. Daniel may have used this expression in order to avoid saying God's name in a careless or offensive way. See the discussion by Goldingay (p. 46). See Deuteronomy 12:5; Psalm 97:12, 115:1, 138:2. Because it is a well-known idiom from the Bible, many English versions translate the phrase literally. In some languages, however, it may be unnatural and even confusing to translate the idiom literally. If that is true in your language, you may translate the meaning directly. For example:

Praise God forever and ever (NCV)

Let us^(incl) thank/bless God at all times

In some languages it is unnatural or confusing to address a prayer to God in the third person. See the General Comment on 2:20–22. If it is natural to use the second person here, you may be able to say:

Our God, your name will be praised forever and forever. (CEV)

Blessed/Praised for all eternity are you, O God!

forever and ever: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as forever and ever refers to limitless

time, both past and future. Other ways to translate it include:

from age to age (NRSV)

throughout time and eternity

let/may...never stop

2:20b

for wisdom and power belong to Him.

- Wisdom and power belong to him.
- God is the source of all wisdom and power.
- You^(sing) know everything and you^(sing) are the most powerful.

for wisdom and power belong to Him: This part of the verse gives the basis for Daniel's call to praise God: God was wise and powerful. The Aramaic text introduces this verse part with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for. Some versions have not explicitly translated it, but you may do so if it is natural in your language. For example:

for to him belong wisdom and power (REB)

since wisdom and power are his alone (NJB)

In some languages a person cannot own abstract qualities like wisdom and power. If this is true in your language, you may translate the meaning directly, using adjectives or verbs. For example:

because he is wise and powerful (GW)

You are all-powerful and you know everything.
(CEV)

wisdom: Daniel was referring to the understanding and insight that God has and can give a person. See the Notes at 1:4b and 1:17a.

power: In this context, the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as power refers to the ability to do great things. Daniel was thinking not only of God's power to reveal dreams, but also of his power over the events of history and over creation.

General Comment on 2:20a–b

2:20b gives the reason why people are to praise God forever (2:20a). In some languages it may be natural

to reverse the order of these two verse parts. For example:

^{20c}God is wise and powerful!

^{20b}Praise him forever and ever. (GNT)

In other languages it may be natural to follow a verb like “blessed” with a direct quotation, stating the content of the praise. For example:

^{20b}Let us bless the name of God for ever and ever,

^{20c}saying, “God is wise and powerful!....”

Daniel 2:21

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.

2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not,

you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:19–23

God revealed to Daniel what the king had dreamed and what the dream meant. Daniel expressed his thanks to God.

The author has recorded Daniel’s prayer of thanks in poetic form. Some translations (for example, the NJB) indicate this by the way they print the lines. You may have a special way of writing poetic speech in your language. If so, you may use it here.

In his prayer of thanks, Daniel first refers to God in the third person (using the pronouns “he/him”). Then in 2:23 he switches to the second person (that is, using the pronoun “you”). In some languages this change may be unnatural. See the General Comment on 2:20–22.

2:21a–b

Biblical authors often wrote poetry in pairs of related lines. Daniel 2:21a and 2:21b form one of these pairs. They are closely related in that 2:21a gives a general principle and 2:21b gives an example of how that principle works out in history. If you are writing Daniel’s prayer as poetry, you may wish to print these lines as a couplet, in two lines. For example:

He controls the times and the seasons;

He makes and unmakes kings (GNT)

He determines the course of world events;

he removes kings and sets up other kings. (NLT)

2:21a

He changes the times and seasons;

- He causes times and seasons to change.
- It is you^(sing) who causes the times and the seasons to change each year.

He changes the times and seasons: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as changes here indicates that God can alter world history. He has power over all that happens, the different eras and ages of the world, and the various empires that rise and fall. Daniel was praising God for his control over time and history. Other ways to translate this include:

He controls the times and the seasons (GNT)

He determines the course of world events (NLT)

He: Daniel referred to God in the third person in order to show respect. However, this may not be natural in your language. If you used the second person at the beginning of the prayer in 2:20, you should use it again here.

times and seasons: The two words times and seasons are very close in meaning here. They probably refer to the times and seasons of history, that is, the ages or eras when different nations and rulers have power. Here is another way to translate this:

times and periods of history (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two words times and seasons into one idea. For example:

the course of world events (NLT)

human events (CEV)

2:21b

He removes kings and establishes them.

- He takes away the power of kings and gives that power to others.
- You^(sing) cause certain kings to rule and you^(sing) cause other kings to stop ruling.

He removes kings and establishes them: This verse part tells one way that God displays his control over human history. He causes some people to become kings and some kings he causes to stop ruling. He is in control of those events. Other ways to translate this include:

deposing some kings and establishing others (NET)

he removes kings and sets up other kings. (NLT)

He removes kings: Cultures have different ways to describe how people remove their kings from that powerful position. For example:

He takes away the power of kings (NCV)

he takes away their royal thrones/crowns

establishes them: Cultures also have different ways to speak of how a person becomes a king. Use a verb in your language that means, “to cause to rule.” For example:

raises up others (NIV)

gives their power to new kings (NCV)

puts others on the throne

them: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as them is literally “kings,” as in the first clause, “He removes kings.” It refers to different men, men whom God causes to become kings. Here is another way to translate this:

other kings (NLT)

General Comment on 2:21b

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of the two clauses. For example:

you give rulers their power and take it away (CEV)

he makes and unmakes kings (GNT)

2:21c

He gives wisdom to the wise and knowledge to the discerning.

- He is the one who gives wise people their wisdom. He is the one who causes intelligent people to understand matters.
- You^(sing) make people wise and you^(sing) help them to understand difficult things.

He gives wisdom to the wise and knowledge to the discerning: The two parts of this verse part are in poetic parallelism. The second line repeats the meaning of the first line in a different way. It is good to show this by translating them as a couplet. For example:

He gives wisdom to the wise;

he imparts knowledge to those who have understanding. (NET)

He gives wisdom to the wise

and knowledge to those who have insight. (GW)

If someone/anyone is wise, it is you who gave them their wisdom.

If someone/anyone is discerning, it is you who gave them their discernment.

He gives wisdom to the wise: If a person is wise, that wisdom has come from the Lord. This is very similar to the idea in 2:20. See the Notes at 2:20b. Other ways to translate this include:

He gives the wise their wisdom

Wise people receive their wisdom from you

And you are the source of wisdom (CEV)

- Some languages may not have an abstract word that means wisdom. You may be able to say:

You are the one who makes a person wise

You make people wise

the wise: The phrase the wise here refers to people who know things others do not know, who give good advice, and who know how to make good decisions. They are not the same as the professional “wise men” of 2:12-14. Refer to these people in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

those who are wise

wise people

someone wise

and knowledge to the discerning: The phrase and knowledge to the discerning is short for “and he/God gives knowledge to the discerning.” If someone is knowledgeable or quick to learn and understand, it is God who has given them that ability. Other ways to translate this include:

you give discerning people their ability to discern

it is you who gives knowledgeable men their understanding

knowledge: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as knowledge can refer to the ability to gain knowledge, the power of knowing. See the Hebrew-English Lexicon by Brown, Driver, and Briggs, p. 1095. In some languages, there may not be an abstract word that means knowledge. It may be more natural to use a verb, such as “cause to understand.” For example:

and you make people understand things

and you help people to discern things

the discerning: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the discerning is more literally “the knowers of understanding.” Here it probably refers to people who understand things easily and know many things. In this context it means much the same as “the wise.” Your language may have a special name for people such as this. The following are some English examples:

those who have understanding (RSV)

those who have insight (GW)

the scholars (NLT)

Daniel 2:22

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
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5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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Paragraph 2:19–23

God revealed to Daniel what the king had dreamed and what the dream meant. Daniel expressed his thanks to God.

The author has recorded Daniel's prayer of thanks in poetic form. Some translations (for example, the NJB) indicate this by the way they print the lines. You may have a special way of writing poetic speech in your language. If so, you may use it here.

In his prayer of thanks, Daniel first refers to God in the third person (using the pronouns "he/him"). Then in 2:23 he switches to the second person (that is, using the pronoun "you"). In some languages this change may be unnatural. See the General Comment on 2:20–22.

2:22

In 2:22 Daniel uses figurative language. If you have the same figures of speech, you can use them here. If you do not, you may use a different figure or simply translate the meaning.

2:22a

He reveals the deep and hidden things;

- He reveals mysteries and explains things that are hard to understand.
- You^(sing) explain to people even the most secret mysteries.

He reveals the deep and hidden things: This is figurative language. It indicates that God reveals mysteries and secrets, things that people cannot know by themselves. The king's dream was an example of one such deep and hidden thing. Other ways to translate this include:

who uncovers depths and mysteries (NJB)

He makes known secrets that are deep and hidden (NCV)

reveals: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as reveals means to uncover or show something concealed or unknown. It is a different form of the verb “was revealed” that was used in 2:19a. See the note there. Other ways to translate this include:

explain (CEV)

makes known (NCV)

In some languages a verb like reveals may require an indirect object to indicate to whom the things are revealed. For example:

he reveals deep and mysterious things to people

deep and hidden things: The two adjectives deep and hidden overlap in meaning, and they are both used in figurative ways. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the ideas in a different way. For example:

deep mysteries (REB)

the most mysterious secrets

deep: In this verse Daniel used the word deep in a figurative way to refer to things that are hard to understand. The word deep may not have this figurative meaning in your language. Use an expression that is clear in your language. For example:

matters that are hard to understand

hidden: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates literally as hidden is used figuratively here. It means “secret things” or “mysteries,” referring to such things as the king’s dream that people could not know naturally. Other English versions have:

mysterious (RSV)

secret (GNT)

The word hidden may not have this figurative meaning in your language. If you have another expression that

has this meaning, you may use it here. For example, you may say:

matters that are beyond human understanding

2:22b

He knows what lies in darkness,

- He knows what is hidden in dark places.
- You^(sing) know/see everything that humans cannot know/see.

He knows what lies in darkness: Daniel continued to praise God, saying that he knows things that are impossible for human beings to know. Darkness does not hide anything from him. Another way to translate this is:

[He] sees in the darkThe Message

what lies in darkness: Daniel used the word darkness in a figurative way. The phrase what lies in darkness not only refers to what is difficult for our eyes to see but also to what is difficult for our minds to understand and interpret. It does not refer to a specific thing or a specific dark place.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate in some way that the language is figurative or even to translate the meaning directly. For example:

he knows what is hidden in darkness (NCV)

he knows what lies hidden in darkness (NLT)

he fully understands what is a mystery to humans

2:22c

and light dwells with Him.

- With him is light.
- With you^(sing) there is light.
- You^(sing) are the one who causes people to understand what they could not know by themselves.

and: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces a continuation and expansion of the previous thought.

light dwells with Him: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates literally as light dwells with Him means that where God is, there is light. This is a metaphor. Just as light reveals things and makes them clear, so God reveals secrets and mysteries and

makes their meaning clear. Other ways to translate this include:

he himself is surrounded by light (GNT)

light is all around him (NCV)

In some languages it may not be natural to use light in this figurative way. If that is true in your language, you may have to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

with him is the light of truth

General Comment on 2:20–22

In 2:20–22, Daniel referred to God in the third person. This was a way Jewish people showed respect to God. If this is unnatural in your language, you can translate the prayer using second-person pronouns. For example:

^{20a}Our God, your name will be praised forever and forever.

^{20b}You are all-powerful and you know everything.

^{21a}You control human events—

^{21b}You give rulers their power and take it away,

^{21c}and you are the source of wisdom and knowledge.

^{22a}You explain deep mysteries,

^{22b-c}because even the dark is light to you. (CEV)

Daniel 2:23

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
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6. The GNT has three sections:

(a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)

(b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)

(c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
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is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
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Paragraph 2:19–23

God revealed to Daniel what the king had dreamed and what the dream meant. Daniel expressed his thanks to God.

The author has recorded Daniel's prayer of thanks in poetic form. Some translations (for example, the NJB) indicate this by the way they print the lines. You may have a special way of writing poetic speech in your language. If so, you may use it here.

In his prayer of thanks, Daniel first refers to God in the third person (using the pronouns "he/him"). Then in 2:23 he switches to the second person (that is, using the pronoun "you"). In some languages this change may be unnatural. See the General Comment on 2:20–22.

2:23a

To You, O God of my fathers, I give thanks and praise,

- You^(sing) are the God of my forefathers, and I thank you and praise you
- My God, you^(sing) are the one whom my ancestors served/worshiped. I give you thanks and praise,

To You, O God of my fathers, I give thanks and praise: In 2:23 Daniel began to speak to God directly,

using the second-person pronoun You. This is the climax of the prayer. The Aramaic word order of this sentence is unusual. The pronoun You comes before the verb to emphasize that God was the one Daniel praised. Use a word order that is natural for conveying this emphasis. For example:

To you do I give thanks and praise, God of my ancestors.

O God of my fathers: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as God of my fathers is a title for the one true God. It indicates that Daniel's ancestors worshiped the Lord, the God of Israel, as Daniel himself did. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

the God my ancestors served

the God my ancestors also worshiped

In some languages it may not be natural to address God directly with a title such as this. If that is true in your language, it may be best to translate this information as a separate statement. For example:

You are the God who was worshiped by my ancestors. (CEV)

fathers: Here the word fathers refers to Daniel's parents, grandparents, and other ancestors, both male and female.

I give thanks and praise: The two expressions that the BSB translates as thanks and praise have similar meanings. The repetition of the idea adds emphasis. In some languages it may be natural to translate these two words with an expression that adds emphasis in a different way. For example:

I give heartfelt thanks

I greatly praise

I give thanks: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates here with the noun thanks means to express appreciation, to acknowledge with gratitude what God has done.

praise: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates with the noun praise means to "worship, adore."

2:23b

because You have given me wisdom and power.

- because you^(sing) have made me wise and you^(sing) have given me power to understand the dream.
- for you^(sing) have made me wise. You^(sing) have given me the ability to understand this mystery.

because: In the Aramaic text this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a conjunction that the BSB translates as because. Here this conjunction introduces the reason why Daniel thanked and praised God. Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

You have given me wisdom and power: The Aramaic words that the BSB translates as wisdom and power are the same ones that were used in 2:20b. In 2:20 Daniel praised God for being the one who gives wisdom and power in general. Here in 2:23b he praised God for giving him wisdom and power in this situation. See the note on 2:20b. In some languages it may be natural to translate wisdom and power using adjectives. For example:

You have made me wise and strong

wisdom: This refers to insight that God gives. See the Notes at 1:4b and 1:17a. See also the note on 2:20b.

power: In this context the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as power refers to a special ability. God gave Daniel the ability to know and understand the king's dream. He could not have understood it by himself. See the Notes at 2:20b.

2:23c–d

These verse parts are a parallel couplet. 2:23d repeats the information in 2:23c in a different way, and the phrases “what we have requested” and “the dream of the king” refer to the same idea. This repetition is used for emphasis. The same verb that the BSB translates as “have made known” is also used in both verse parts.

In some languages this repetition may imply that the two verse parts refer to different things. If that is true in your language, it may be best to combine these verse parts. For example:

For when we asked you about the king's matter/
dream, you revealed it to us.

2:23c

And now You have made known to me what we have requested,

- You^(sing) have revealed to me what we^(excl) asked.

- You^(sing) have answered our^(excl) prayers.

And now You have made known to me what we have requested: Daniel thanked God for revealing or telling him the king's dream and its meaning. See the Notes on the verb “tell” at 2:5b.

what we have requested: This refers to the prayer of Daniel and his friends in 2:18a. Daniel's friends had done as he urged them and asked God to reveal the king's dream.

we: The pronoun we is exclusive here. It refers to Daniel and his three friends.

General Comment on 2:23c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse part, translating it in the order in which events happened. For example:

We asked you to tell us something, and you told it to me.

2:23d

for You have made known to us the dream of the king.”

- You^(sing) have explained to us^(excl) the king's dream.”
- You^(sing) have solved for us^(excl) the king's problem/
mystery.”

for: The Aramaic text connects this verse part to the previous verse part with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for. In this context it introduces a restatement of the previous verse part and helps to indicate that 2:23c and 2:23d form a parallelism. It also adds emphasis to the climax of the prayer. In some languages a conjunction will not be needed. Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

You told us what the king wants to know. (GW)

that is, you revealed to us the king's dream

You have made known to us the dream of the king:

This verse part tells more specifically what it was that God had made known to Daniel and his friends.

to us: God had revealed the dream to Daniel, and he was going to tell his friends. He was the representative of the four men. So Daniel used the plural pronoun us here, referring to himself and his friends. This is an exclusive pronoun.

the dream of the king: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the dream of the king more literally uses the general term “the matter/word of the king.” It refers to the king’s dream and its meaning. Other ways to say this in English are:

what the king wants to know (GW)

the answer for the king (REB)

the king’s problem (NJB)

Daniel 2:24

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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Paragraph 2:24–25

In this paragraph there is a change of setting. Daniel went to Arioch and told him that he could interpret the king's dream. Arioch took him to the king.

2:24a**Therefore Daniel went to Arioch,**

- ¶ So Daniel went to speak to Arioch,
- ¶ And Daniel returned to speak to Arioch.

Therefore: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces a result. Because God revealed the dream to Daniel (2:19–23), Daniel went immediately to Arioch and asked him if he could speak to the king. Introduce what Daniel did as in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So (GNT)

Daniel went to Arioch: The Aramaic verb literally means “went in,” as in 2:16. Daniel entered the room where Arioch was in order to talk to him. Other ways to translate this include:

Daniel went in to see Arioch (NLT)

Daniel went to meet with Arioch

Arioch: The author first referred to Arioch in 2:14a. Spell his name here as you did there.

2:24b**whom the king had appointed to destroy the wise men of Babylon,**

- the official who had orders from the king to kill the Babylonian advisers/sages.
- This Arioch was the captain/commander to whom the king had given the responsibility of putting to death the experts of Babylon.

whom the king had appointed to destroy the wise men of Babylon: This is background information. The author is reminding his readers of what he told them in 2:14, that Arioch was the commander of the men who were going to kill the royal advisers. In some languages it may be natural to imply that Arioch was not going to kill all the wise men personally. For example:

whom the king had made responsible for putting the Babylonian sages to death (NJB)

whom the king had commanded to oversee/organize the execution of the wise men of Babylon

who had been given the responsibility of having the Babylonian wise men executed

whom the king had appointed: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as whom the king had appointed indicates that the king had given Arioch a certain task or responsibility. Some ways to say this in English are:

whom the king had ordered (NLT)

the officer put in charge

to whom the king had entrusted the task

to destroy the wise men of Babylon: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as destroy means “execute, kill.” See the Notes at 2:12b and 2:18b. Other ways to translate this include:

putting the Babylonian sages to death (NJB)

that the wise men of Babylon be executed

of the executionThe Message

wise men: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wise men refers to the king's experts and advisors. See the Notes at 2:12b, where the same word is used. Other ways to say this include:

royal advisers (GNT)

wise advisers (GW)

sages (NJB)

Babylon: See the Notes at 2:12b. You will want to translate in the same way here.

General Comment on 2:24a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 2:24a–b, translating the background information first. For example:

^{24b}Arioch was the man whom the king had appointed to execute the wise men of Babylon. ^{24a}So Daniel went to him

^{24b}The officer/commander charged/entrusted with the execution of the Babylonian wise men was Arioch, ^{24a}so Daniel went to him

2:24c

and said to him, “Do not execute the wise men of Babylon!”

- Daniel said, “Sir, do not execute^(sing) the wise men of Babylon!
- “Please spare^(sing) the wise men of Babylon,” Daniel said.
- “Halt/Stop^(sing) these executions!” Daniel exclaimed.

and said to him: This phrase introduces what Daniel said to Arioch. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence. For example:

Daniel told him (GW)

The Aramaic text introduces Daniel’s words with the phrase “he went/came and said thus to him.” Introduce what Daniel said to Arioch in a way that is natural in your language. The idea that Daniel went to Arioch was already stated in 2:24a, so the BSB leaves it implicit here. But some English translations translate it explicitly. For example:

He came and said to him (NET)

He approached him and said (REB)

Do not execute the wise men of Babylon!: The verb phrase Do not execute is in the form of a command. However, Daniel was not in a position to command Arioch. He was advising Arioch that he should not kill the wise men or that it was not necessary to do so. He was speaking politely but urgently. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Since Arioch was in charge of the guards who were to do the actual executions, in some languages it may be necessary to say:

Do not have the Babylonian wise men killed/executed.

Do not order the wise men of Babylon to be killed.

In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea with a positive verb. For example:

Let the wise men of Babylon live.

Spare the lives of the Babylonian wise men.

the wise men of Babylon were just mentioned in 2:24b. So in some languages it may be natural to leave this phrase implied or abbreviate the reference. For example:

Let the wise men live!

Call off the execution!The Message

2:24d

Bring me before the king, and I will give him the interpretation.”

- If you^(sing) take me to the king, I will interpret the dream for him.”
- “Let^(sing) me come with you^(sing) to the king, for I can let him know what his dream means.”
- “I can tell the king the meaning of his dream. So bring/lead^(sing) me to him!”

Bring me before the king: Daniel needed someone in authority to accompany him and ask permission for him to speak to the king. Use the verb that is most natural in your language. It may be natural to imply that the king had higher status or authority than Daniel. For example:

Take me to the king (NIV)

Present me to/before the king

Take me into the king’s presence (NASB)

and I will give him the interpretation: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as give him the interpretation is literally “declare the interpretation.” Daniel would tell the king what his dream meant. Some other ways to say this are:

and I will show the king the interpretation (RSV)

and I will tell him what his dream means (GNT)

and I will tell him the meaning of his dream (NLT)

General Comment on 2:24c–e

In some languages it may be more natural to translate these verse parts as indirect speech. For example:

Daniel asked Arioch not to kill the wise men but to take him to the king so that he could interpret the king's dream for him.

Daniel 2:25

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different

words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:24–25

In this paragraph there is a change of setting. Daniel went to Arioch and told him that he could interpret the king's dream. Arioch took him to the king.

2:25a

Arioch hastily brought Daniel before the king

- Arioch immediately took Daniel to the king.

- Arioch quickly/hastily led Daniel into the king's presence.

The Aramaic text connects this verse part with the previous verse part using a common connector that most English versions translate as “Then” to indicate that in this context, it introduces the next event in a temporal sequence. A few versions, such as the NET, translate this connector as “So” to indicate that Arioch brought Daniel to the king as a result of his request. The BSB and some other versions do not explicitly translate it. Introduce what Arioch did next in a way that is natural in your language.

Arioch hastily brought Daniel before the king:

Arioch was able to arrange a meeting with King Nebuchadnezzar straight away. He and Daniel went before the king. They probably went down on their knees before the king.

hastily: This word means “quickly, in a hurry.” Here are some ways that English versions translate this:

Arioch immediately took Daniel to the king (GW)

Arioch rushed Daniel into the king's presence (NJPS)

Antioch hurried Daniel to the king

brought: See the Notes at 2:24d, where the same verb is used. Arioch accompanied or led Daniel to Nebuchadnezzar.

2:25b

and said to him, “I have found a man among the exiles from Judah

- He said to the king, “I have located someone among the exiles from the land of Judah
- He told the king, “It has come to my attention that there is a man among the Judean exiles

and said to him: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in a temporal sequence. In some languages, it may help to add some implied information. For example:

When they arrived , Arioch said to the king

I have found a man: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as found here refers to locating someone that the speaker did not know existed. Arioch did not know that anyone could do what Daniel said he was able to do. In some languages a literal translation may

suggest that Daniel was lost or that Arioch had not known where he was. To avoid these wrong meanings it may be possible to translate 2:25b–c as:

I have found out that one of the men brought here from Judah can explain your dream. (CEV)

It has come to my attention that one of the exiles from Judah can tell you what your dream means.

among the exiles from Judah: The term exiles describes people who have been forced to leave their home country. The people of Babylon had conquered Judah and forced many of the Jewish people there to leave their homes and come to live in Babylon. Daniel was one of these people. Other ways to say this are:

one of the Jewish exiles (GNT)

one of the captives of Judah (GW)

one of the men brought here from Judah (CEV)

2:25c

who will tell the king the interpretation.”

- who is able to tell Your Majesty the meaning of your dream.”
- who can interpret your dream, O king.”

who will tell the king the interpretation: The Aramaic verb form that the BSB translates as will tell here expresses both the ability and the intention to do something. Daniel was able and willing to tell the king the meaning of his dream. Other ways to translate this include:

who can reveal the meaning to the king (NJB)

who can explain the dream's meaning to you, Your Majesty (GW)

the king: Arioch was speaking to the king, but he referred to him in the third person. This was a common way in that culture to show respect for someone in authority. See the Notes at 2:20b. This may not be natural in your language. If not, other possibilities are:

- Use a second-person reference such as “you.” For example:

who can explain the dream's meaning to you (GW)

- Use a special way to address a king directly. For example:

who can tell Your Majesty the meaning of your dream (GNT)

Your Majesty...one of the men brought here from Judah can explain your dream. (CEV)

Use the option that is the most natural in your language.

General Comment on 2:25c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of information in this verse part. For example:

I have found a man who can interpret your dream.
He is one of the exiles from the land of Judah.

I have found a man who can interpret your dream.
He is one of the men that the army brought here from Judah.

Daniel 2:26

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
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 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel

then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:26–28

Daniel told the king that God had revealed to him the king's dream. He introduced one of the central themes of the chapter: only God can reveal mysteries.

2:26a

The king responded to Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar,

- ¶ The king asked Daniel (that is, Belteshazzar),
- ¶ The king questioned Daniel (now known as Belteshazzar):

The king responded to Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as responded is the same one that was used in 2:5a, 2:10a, and 2:20a. See the Notes on those verses.

whose name was Belteshazzar: The phrase whose name was Belteshazzar gives background information about Daniel. When Daniel came to Babylon, the Babylonians changed his name to Belteshazzar, which was a Babylonian name. See 1:7. There are several ways to indicate this in a translation. For example:

that is, Belteshazzar

(also called Belteshazzar) (NIV)

(now known as Belteshazzar)

Present this background information in a natural way in your language.

2:26b

“Are you able to tell me what I saw in the dream, as well as its interpretation?”

- “Can you^(sing) really tell me what I dreamed and interpret what it means?”
- “Are you^(sing) able to reveal what I have dreamed and tell me what it means?”

Are you able to tell me what I saw in the dream, as well as its interpretation?: The king's question expressed doubt or uncertainty. He was not sure that Daniel could reveal what he had dreamed. English versions express the doubt in different ways. For example:

Is this true? Can you tell me what my dream was and what it means? (NLT)

Can you really tell me my dream and its interpretation?

Express the king's uncertainty in a way that is natural in your language.

tell me: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as tell means “reveal, explain.” See the Notes at 2:25c. Here is another way to translate this:

make known to me (RSV)

what I saw in the dream: Languages have different ways to speak about the content of dreams. Some ways that English versions translate this are:

what my dream was (NLT)

the dream I had (GW)

what I dreamed (GNT)

Express the idea in a way that is natural in your language.

as well as its interpretation: The phrase as well as its interpretation in this context is short for “and are you able to interpret my dream?” Other ways to say this include:

and its meaning (GW)

and what it means (NLT)

and can you tell me its interpretation?

Daniel 2:27

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one

section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1-13)
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 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1-13)
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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
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3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20-23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliter-

ation. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20-23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
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Paragraph 2:26-28

Daniel told the king that God had revealed to him the king's dream. He introduced one of the central themes of the chapter: only God can reveal mysteries.

2:27

Daniel answered the king, "No wise man, enchanter, medium, or magician can explain to the king the mystery of which he inquires."

- Daniel answered, "None of the wise advisers/sages can reveal this mystery that you^(sing) have asked about, my king. None of the enchanters, magicians, or astrologers can do this.
- "This kind of secret is not something that any diviner or other occult/divination expert can reveal to you, Your Majesty," Daniel answered.

Daniel answered the king: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as Daniel answered uses two verbs of speech. This formula gives some emphasis

to Daniel's words. Some versions translate both verbs. For example:

Daniel answered before the king and said (NASB)

Introduce Daniel's answer in a way that is natural in your language.

As the NASB quotation just above shows, the Aramaic text includes the phrase "before the king." This is the same expression that was used in 2:10a to refer to addressing someone of higher status. The BSB does not explicitly translate this phrase. If it is natural in your language, you may indicate that Daniel was addressing a king. It may be natural to do this with an introductory form of address. For example:

Daniel replied, "Your Majesty..." (GNT)

No wise man, enchanter, medium, or magician can explain to the king the mystery of which he inquires: Daniel told the king that none of the various Babylonian experts could tell him what he wanted to know. Here is another way to translate this:

Your Majesty, there is no wizard, magician, fortuneteller, or astrologer who can tell you that. (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to use plural forms for the different types of experts. For example:

There are no wise men, enchanters, magicians, or fortunetellers who can reveal the king's secret. (NLT)

It is not possible for any of the expert advisers to solve your mystery for you

No wise man, enchanter, medium, or magician: Notice that the list of experts in this verse part is not the same as the list in 2:2a or 2:10b. This implies that the author did not mean to give an exact list of all the experts. The names are probably examples of the various kinds of experts whom the king summoned. Your language may not have a specific term for each of these experts. You may have to use one term for two or three of the names listed here. Another option is to begin or end the list with a general term. For example:

Out of all your expert advisers—wise men, enchanters, magicians—there is no one who...

Among all your wizards, magicians, fortunetellers and other wise men there is none who...

wise man: This is the same expression that was used in 2:12. It seems to be a general term that could include any of the types of advisors that were mentioned. See the note on 2:12b.

enchanter: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as enchanter describes someone who performed rituals to obtain knowledge or to influence people's futures. See the Notes at 2:2a and 2:10b.

magician: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as magician refers to a person who seemed to perform different occult functions. He probably interpreted dreams and foretold the future through divination. See the Notes at 2:2a and 2:10b.

medium: This term describes a new group of experts whom Daniel did not mention in 2:2a or 2:10b. The exact meaning of this word is uncertain. It has been translated in various ways by English versions:

astrologers (RSV)

fortuneteller (GW)

exorcists (NJB)

can explain to the king: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates explain is literally "tell." The form of the verb can be interpreted differently:

1. It expresses a general truth: no human advisor would be able to reveal what the king wanted to know. For example:

can explain to the king (NCV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, ESV, KJV, NJPS, GW, NLT, GNT, REB, NCV, CEV)

1. It refers to what had happened in the past. For example:

None...has been able to tell the king (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the great majority of English versions.

to the king: Daniel spoke to the king in the third person, as Arioch did in 2:25. See the note on 2:25c. This indirect address was a way to show special respect in that culture. Indicate respect in a way that is natural in your language.

the mystery of which he inquires: This refers to the king's question in 2:26. Be sure that this is clear in your translation. Some ways to say this in English are:

the secret about which you ask (REB)

what the king has demanded (GW)

See the Notes at 2:18a.

General Comment on 2:27

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse, emphasizing "the mystery," as in the Aramaic text. For example:

The mystery that the king is asking about is such that no wise men, astrologers, magicians, or diviners can possibly disclose it to the king. (NET)

As for the mystery about which the king has enquired, neither wise men, conjurers, magicians nor diviners are able to declare it to the king. (NASB)

Daniel 2:28

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:26–28

Daniel told the king that God had revealed to him the king's dream. He introduced one of the central themes of the chapter: only God can reveal mysteries.

2:28a

But there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries,

- Only God who rules from heaven can reveal these mysteries.
- “However, the true God in heaven can do what human experts cannot do. He is the one who reveals such secrets.

But: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast with the previous verse. Although no human expert could reveal the king's secret, there is a God in heaven who reveals such secrets. Express this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries: This sentence contrasts God with the various wise men mentioned in 2:27. He could do what they could not do. Translate this in a way that makes the contrast clear. For example:

the God who rules from heaven does reveal mysteries

a God in heaven: This is the same title for God that was used in 2:18. See the Notes at 2:18a. It refers to the true God. It does not indicate there is more than one God. In some languages it may therefore be necessary to say:

the God who is in heaven

In some languages it may be necessary to expand this phrase. For example:

the God who rules from heaven (CEV)

heaven: This refers to the place where God lives, not merely to the sky. See KBT for suggestions on how to translate this key term.

mysteries: This refers to secrets such as the king's dream and its interpretation. These were things that only God could reveal. See the Notes in 2:18a and 2:27.

2:28b

and He has made known to King Nebuchadnezzar what will happen in the latter days.

- He has given this dream to you, my king, in order that you^(sing) may know what will happen in the time to come.
- He has caused you^(sing) to have this dream in order that you^(sing) can know what will happen in the future.

and He has made known to King Nebuchadnezzar:

The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as has made known is the same as the verb translated as “will tell” in 2:25c. It means to inform or make something known. In this context it indicates that God gave Nebuchadnezzar the dream in order to let him know future events. God did not tell Nebuchadnezzar directly, and at this time Nebuchadnezzar did not yet know the meaning of the dream. Here is one way to translate this phrase:

He has given this dream to you, king, in order that you may know what will happen in the future.

In some languages, to express this idea, it may be natural to use a different verb tense or to speak of something that God had already done, such as giving the dream. The Aramaic verb refers to something that God had already done. Most English versions translate it in the present perfect tense, as the BSB does. The reason for this tense may not be clear to readers, since God had not yet revealed the meaning of the dream to the king. Daniel was about to explain it to him. The GW translates this verb in the future tense. For example:

he will tell King Nebuchadnezzar (GW)

King Nebuchadnezzar: Daniel spoke to the king in the third person. This was a way of showing respect to someone of higher status. see the Notes at 2:27b. If this is not natural in your language, you may use the second person. However, it is important to translate the attitude of respect. For example, you could say:

for God has told you, O King,...G has: “O King live forever.” This may be an assimilation to 2:24.

what will happen in the latter days: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates in the latter days is more literally “at the end of the days.” MT, Theodotian, G. The phrase occurs again in Daniel 10:14. It is traditionally translated as in the latter days. BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV. This phrase refers to a time in the future when there will be important changes. Scholars interpret it differently here.

1. The phrase refers in a general way to the future. Le Semeur; GeCL97; Baldwin (p. 93). For example:

in days to come (NIV)

in the future (GNT) (GNT, NLT, KJV, CEV, NCV, NIV, GW, NET)

1. The phrase is a technical term that refers to the end of time and history. Horst Seebass, TDOT 1 (1974): 207–12. See the discussion in Collins, p. 161. Other passages that interpret the phrase in this way include Ezekiel 38:16, Daniel 10:14, Hosea 3:5, Isaiah 2:2, and Micah 4:1). For example:

in the final days (NJB) (REB, NJB, NRSV, NJPS)

Interpretation (1) is probably best in this context. You may wish to follow the BSB, which uses a phrase which could mean either interpretation (1) and (2). The dream told about what would happen in the near as well as the distant future.

2:28c

Your dream and the visions that came into your mind as you lay on your bed were these:

- This is the dream you^(sing) dreamed as you lay on your bed.
- I will now tell you^(sing) the vision that you saw while you were on your bed.

Your dream and the visions that came into your mind as you lay on your bed were these: This verse part introduces Daniel’s explanation of the content and meaning of the king’s dream. Other ways to translate this include:

These, then, are the dream and the visions that passed through your head as you were lying in bed (NJB)

The dream and the visions you had while lying on your bed are as follows. (NET)

Now I will tell you your dream and the visions you saw as you lay on your bed. (NLT)

Your dream and the visions: In this context the Aramaic expressions that the BSB translates as Your dream and the visions probably refer to the same thing. The book of Daniel does not seem to distinguish between the two terms. For the plural visions, see the Notes at 2:1. Nebuchadnezzar probably dreamed the same dream on several different nights.

In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that the words dream and “vision” have the same meaning here. For example:

This is your dream, the vision you saw (NCV)

In some languages you may have only one word for these two terms. If that is true in your language, you may translate using just the one word. For example:

I will now tell you what you saw in your dream....

that came into your mind: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as that came into your mind is more literally “of your head,” as in the RSV. It indicates that the king did not see the visions with his physical eyes. They occurred while he was on his bed asleep.

as you lay on your bed: This phrase tells where the dream occurred. The king was in his bed. It is implied he was lying there asleep. Other ways to translate this include:

while you were asleep (GW)

while lying on your bed (NCV)

In some languages you may not need to make this information explicit, because it is implied by the context and the words “dream” and “visions.”

were these: This expression introduces the description of Nebuchadnezzar’s dream. The word these refers to the details of the dream that Daniel would tell the king. Daniel did not actually begin to describe those details until 2:31. He continued the introduction to his speech in 2:29–30. So in some languages it may be more natural to say something like:

I will now explain your dreams and the visions that passed through your mind.

Daniel 2:29

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
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6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
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 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
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using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
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Paragraph 2:29–2:30

Daniel 2:29–30 repeats much of the information that was in 2:27–28. The repetition emphasizes one of the main themes of this narrative: Only God can reveal the events that will happen in the future.

2:29a

As you lay on your bed, O king, your thoughts turned to the future,

- ¶ "Your Majesty, when you^(sing) were lying on your^(sing) bed, you thought about what would happen in the future.
- ¶ "While you^(sing) were asleep, you dreamed about the future.

As you lay on your bed, O king, your thoughts turned to the future: This verse repeats information that was in 2:28c. While Nebuchadnezzar was sleeping, he dreamed about the future.

As you lay on your bed, O king: The king was sleeping in his bed at night, as mentioned in 2:1. Other ways to translate this include:

as you lay in bed (NRSV)

While Your Majesty was sleeping (GNT)

O king: Daniel continued to address the king respectfully, using his title and the third person. Cultures have different ways to show respect when people are speaking to an important person like a king or chief. As in 2:27 and 2:28b, you should use a term of respect that is natural in your language. For example:

Your Majesty (NIV)

your thoughts turned to the future: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as your thoughts turned to the future is more literally “your thoughts went up to what will be after this.” This probably means that the king began to dream about future events. Other ways to translate this include:

thoughts about what would happen in the future came to you (GW)

your thoughts turned to future things (NET)

you dreamed about coming events (NLT)

the future: This is a different phrase than the one in 2:28b but the meaning is the same.

2:29b

and the Revealer of Mysteries made known to you what will happen.

- Then God, who reveals mysteries, showed to you^(sing) what will happen.
- Then God revealed to you^(sing) the events that will happen in the future. He alone is able to reveal mysteries.

and the Revealer of Mysteries made known to you what will happen: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here connects the event in 2:29a with more information about the same event. While

the king slept, in his dream God revealed what would happen in the future.

the Revealer of Mysteries: This title refers to God. He is the one who reveals mysteries to people. In some languages, it may be necessary to make the reference clear. For example:

God, who reveals mysteries (GNT)

Revealer: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Revealer is from the same verb as in 2:22a. It means to tell or uncover something that was previously a secret, to explain something that was before mysterious.

Mysteries: See the Notes at 2:18a.

made known to you: See the Notes at 2:5b. God gave or sent the dream to the king so that he could understand what would happen in the future.

what will happen: This expression refers to what will happen in the future. Other ways to translate this clause are:

what will be (RSV)

what will happen in the future (CEV)

Daniel 2:30

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do

so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes

will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

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Paragraph 2:29–2:30

Daniel 2:29–30 repeats much of the information that was in 2:27–28. The repetition emphasizes one of the main themes of this narrative: Only God can reveal the events that will happen in the future.

2:30a

And to me this mystery has been revealed,

- The reason why I have come to know this mystery
- And he has shown me this mystery

And to me: In Aramaic this verse part connects with the previous verse part with a common conjunction that the BSB translates as *And*. Most English versions translate it as "But." A few versions do not explicitly translate it. Connect this verse part to the previous verse part in a way that is natural in your language.

In the Aramaic text, the pronoun *me* comes at the start of this sentence. It indicates a contrast. Daniel is contrasting the way that God is the "Revealer of Mysteries" (2:29b) with the way that he himself does not have "more wisdom than any man alive" (2:30b). Another way to translate this phrase is:

But as for me (ESV)

Some translations do not translate this phrase, since the contrast is implied by the context. Introduce the contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

this mystery has been revealed: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural to use an active clause in your language you may supply the implied subject (God). For example:

God has allowed me to understand this mystery

God also told this secret to me... (NCV)

mystery: See the Notes at 2:18a. The mystery was something that only God could reveal. Be careful not to use a word that is related to local pagan religions.

2:30b

not because I have more wisdom than any man alive,

- is not because I am wiser than everyone else,
- not on account of my unique wisdom

not because I have more wisdom than any man alive: This clause indicates what was not the cause of the previous verse part. It was not because Daniel was wiser than anyone else that he was able to understand the mystery. Other ways to translate this include:

not because of any wisdom that I have more than all the living (RSV)

not because I possess more wisdom than any other living person (NET)

I have more wisdom: To have...wisdom means to be wise. The Aramaic phrase is more literally “the wisdom that is in me.” In some languages, wisdom is not something that is “in” a person or that can be had/possessed by a person. It may be more natural to translate this idea using an adjective. For example:

I am wiser (NLT)

I am smarter (CEV)

I am very wise compared to everyone else

than any man alive: The phrase any man alive here refers to any other human being alive at that time. There is no implied contrast to dead human beings. Other ways to translate this include:

more than any other living being (NRSV)

than anyone else (GNT)

General Comment on 2:30a–b

In some languages it may be natural to have the negative verb in 2:30a. For example:

these mysteries weren’t explained to me because I am smarter than anyone else (CEV)

This secret wasn’t revealed to me because I’m wiser than anyone else. (GW)

In other languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 2:30a–b. For example:

^{30b}And it is not because I am wiser than anyone else ^{30a}that I know the secret of your dream (NLT)

2:30c

but in order that the interpretation might be made known to the king,

- but because God wants/intends you^(sing) to learn what your dream means
- but in order that you^(sing) may understand the meaning/interpretation

but: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as but here introduces a clause that contrasts with 2:30b. It tells the real reason why God revealed the dream to Daniel. God’s intention was to inform the king about future events.

in order that the interpretation might be made known to the king: This is a purpose clause. The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as in order that introduces the purpose for which God revealed the dream to Daniel. God’s purpose was the reason why the dream was revealed to Daniel. Other ways to translate this include:

so that (NIV)

for this sole purpose (NJB)

but because God wants you to understand (NLT)

the interpretation might be made known to the king: In the Aramaic this is literally “that they might cause the king to know.” It is an indefinite plural pronoun and refers ultimately to the work of God. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- As a passive clause. For example:

the interpretation may be made known to the king (RSV)

- As an active clause. For example:

but in order that the king might understand the dream

so that you may know what it means (NCV)

so that Your Majesty may learn the meaning of your dream (GNT)

2:30d

and that you may understand the thoughts of your mind.

- and understand what you^(sing) were thinking about.
- of what you^(sing) dreamed.

and that you may understand the thoughts of your mind: Here the phrase and that introduces God's second purpose in revealing the dream to Daniel.

may understand: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as may understand here means "may come to know," that is, "may learn." It refers to something that the king did not know and was about to learn from Daniel.

the thoughts of your mind: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the thoughts of your mind is more literally "the thoughts of your heart" (as in the KJV). In the Aramaic language and culture, people considered the heart as the center of thinking. In some languages it may not be necessary to mention the mind or heart. For example:

your innermost thoughts (GW)

what you were thinking about (NLT)

what worries you

General Comment on 2:30a–d

In 2:30 Daniel denied that his own wisdom caused him to understand the dream. He stated that the cause of his understanding was God's purpose to inform the king of the future. In some languages it may be natural to reorder 2:30a–d and put the positive statement before the negative. For example:

This mystery has been revealed to me so that Your Majesty may learn the interpretation of your dream. It was not revealed because I am wiser than everyone else!

General Comment on 2:30c–d

God's two purposes in revealing the dream are similar and some versions combine them. For example:

it was done so that you might understand what you have seen (CEV)

but because God wants you to understand what was in your heart (NLT)

Daniel 2:31

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

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Paragraph 2:31–2:35

Daniel told the king what he had seen in his dream.

2:31a

As you, O king, were watching, a great statue appeared.

- ¶ "Your Majesty, you^(sing) saw standing in front of you a large/great statue.

- ¶ "As you were dreaming, suddenly you^(sing) saw a giant statue.

As you, O king, were watching, a great statue appeared: This verse part is more literally "You, O king, were seeing and behold a great image." This verse part gives a summary of what the king first saw in his dream. The details follow. Other ways to translate this summary description include:

O king, you saw in your dream a large statue standing before you

As you watched, there appeared to your majesty a great image (REB)

In your vision, you saw (NLT)

O king: Daniel addressed the king in a respectful and formal way. See also the note on 2:29a.

a great statue appeared: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as appeared often introduces a dream (Daniel 4:7; 7:2). It introduces something that is unexpected or surprising. Another way to translate this is:

and behold, a great image (RSV)

You may have a different way of translating this idea in your language. Some English versions have "behold" (KJV, RSV). The NRSV has "lo!" Some versions translate "in front of you" (NLT, NIV) or "standing before you" (GNT, similarly the CEV). Some versions do not translate this word (GW, REB). For example:

suddenly you saw a great statue

you saw a great statue, right there in front of you

great: This adjective refers to the statue's size. It was big and tall, much taller than a man. See the General Comment on 2:31.

The following are some different ways that English versions translate this word:

large (NIV)

huge (NLT)

giant (GNT)

statue: The word that the BSB translates as statue here refers to a model or image of a man, greater than life size. Here is another way to translate this:

image (RSV)

It is probably best not to translate it using a word whose primary meaning is “idol.” There is no mention of people worshipping this statue.

2:31b

A great and dazzling statue stood before you, and its form was awesome.

- It was a huge statue, glittering and awesome to look at.
- It was enormous, bright and awe-inspiring.

A great and dazzling statue stood before you, and its form was awesome: Daniel continued to describe the statue that the king had seen in his dream. While several English versions translate 2:31 as a single sentence, most versions begin a new clause or sentence here, as the BSB does. In some languages it may be natural to do that as well. For example:

This statue was enormous, dazzling bright, and awesome in appearance.

This image, mighty and of exceeding brightness, stood before you, and its appearance was terrifying. (ESV)

Huge and dazzling, it stood before you, awesome to behold. (REB)

great: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates great indicates that the statue was big and tall. It has the same basic meaning as the word that is translated as “great” in 2:31. Some translations only translate these two synonyms with one word. See the GW, GNT, CEV, NCV. Theodotian omits the first word. The Old Greek puts both words in the second sentence; “very great statue.” See Collins, p. 151. Here is another way to translate this:

huge (NRSV)

dazzling: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as dazzling is literally “its splendor was extraordinary.” This indicates that the statue was very bright and shiny. English versions have different ways to translate this phrase:

shining brightly (NLT, CEV)

This statue was very bright (GW)

bright and shining (GNT)

statue: See the Notes at 2:31, where the same word occurs. In some languages it may be important to mention that the statue looked like the figure of a person. For example:

a huge and powerful statue of a man (NLT)

stood: In some languages, only people can stand. You should use a word that is natural in your language to describe the statue. In some cases it may not be necessary to describe the position of the statue, since statues are usually in an upright, vertical position. For example:

you saw a huge...statue in front of you. (NCV)

before you: This expression indicates that the statue was in front of the king. It was right in the direction that he was looking. Another way to translate this is:

in front of you (NCV, NLT)

its form was awesome: The Aramaic text says literally “its appearance was terrible/terrifying.” This indicates that the statue caused fear in those who saw it. It was probably the immense size of the statue and its amazing brightness that caused fear. There are different ways to translate this feeling, for which the BSB uses the term awesome. For example:

terrifying (GNT)

terrible to see (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

and its appearance was frightening (NRSV)

It was a frightening sight. (NLT)

General Comment on 2:31

In the Aramaic text, the information that the statue was standing before the king is found near the end of

the verse. This is followed by several English versions, including the BSB. For example:

^{31a}You were looking, O king, and there was a great statue. This statue was huge, its brilliance extraordinary; ^{31b}it was standing before you and its appearance was frightening. (NRSV)

^{31a}Your Majesty, you had a vision. You saw a large statue. This statue was very bright. ^{31b}It stood in front of you, and it looked terrifying. (GW)

^{31a}O king, in your dream you saw a huge, shiny, ^{31b}and frightening statue in front of you. (NCV)

Some other English versions have reordered the information in a way that is natural in English. Some examples of translations that reorder the text include:

^{31a}Your Majesty looked, ^{31b}and there before you stood ^{31a}a large statue—an enormous, dazzling statue, ^{31b}awesome in appearance. (NIV)

³¹Your Majesty, in your vision you saw ^{31b}in front of you ^{31a}a huge and powerful statue of a man, shining brilliantly, ^{31b}frightening and awesome. (NLT)

³¹Your Majesty, what you saw ^{31b}standing in front of you ^{31a}was a huge ^{31b}and terrifying ^{31a}statue, shining brightly. (CEV)

Follow the order that is most natural in your language.

Daniel 2:32

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)

(b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)

(c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a

Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:31–2:35

Daniel told the king what he had seen in his dream.

2:32a

The head of the statue was pure gold,

- The head of the statue was made of the best gold.
- The head of the statue was high/top quality gold.

Daniel described the statue from the top down to the bottom. The top parts had greater value than the lower parts.

The head of the statue was pure gold: See the Notes on “image” at 2:31a. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates was is the past tense of the verb “to be.” However, your language may have a different way to translate this idea. Some possibilities are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The head of this statue was made of fine gold.
(GW)

- Use an active verb with an indefinite subject. For example:

They had made the head of fine gold.

- Use only a form of the verb “to be,” as in the Aramaic, as the BSB does. For example:

The head of this image was of fine gold. (RSV)

there was a pure gold head

pure gold: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as pure gold is literally “good gold.” It was easy for people to bend and form this metal. As a result, people were able to make coins and jewelry from gold. It is the heaviest and most valuable of the four metals that Daniel mentioned in this section. Other ways to translate this include:

the finest gold (GNT)

fine gold (RSV)

If you do not have a word for gold you may have to borrow a term in the national language. Another possibility is to describe gold as “the most precious metal.”

2:32b

its chest and arms were silver,

- The chest and arms of the statue were made of silver.
- The chest and arms were silver.

its: Most English versions use the neuter pronoun its. Use the pronoun that is most natural in your language to refer to a statue that represents a male figure.

chest: Each language has its own way of describing the different parts of the body. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as chest refers to the part of the body between the shoulders and the stomach. Some English versions say:

breast

Use the term that is natural in your language to refer to the upper part of a man’s body.

silver: This metal is valuable but less valuable than gold. In that culture silver was a standard of trade and a symbol of wealth. People used silver to make jewelry, coins, decorations, and coverings for cups. If you do not have a word for silver, you may:

- Borrow a national language term.
- Use a general expression such as “a less precious metal.”

2:32c

its belly and thighs were bronze,

- The belly and thighs of the statue were made of bronze,
- From the waist to the knees was bronze,

belly and thighs: Each language has its own way of describing the different parts of the body. Use the expression that most naturally describes this part of the body in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

from its waist down to its knees (CEV)

If your language has only one word to describe both the belly and the thighs, you can use that word here.

belly: This word describes the middle of the body, the “abdomen.” It is the part of the body that extends from just below the chest to the hips.

middle (NRSV)

stomach (GW)

waist (GNT)

thighs: This word describes the part of the human leg between the hips and the knee. Here is another way to translate this:

upper part of the legs (NCV)

bronze: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as bronze can refer to either bronze or copper. Most English versions say “bronze.” Bronze is an alloy of copper and tin. It is stronger than copper and has a reddish-brown color. People used this metal to make tools and weapons. If your language does not have a word for bronze, other possibilities for translation are:

- Borrow a national language term.
- Use a general expression such as “an even less precious metal.”

Daniel 2:33

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)

5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)

6. The GNT has three sections:

- (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)

- (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)

- (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language

has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:31–2:35

Daniel told the king what he had seen in his dream.

2:33a

its legs were iron,

- and the legs were made of iron.
- and the legs were iron.

its legs were iron: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as legs refers to the lower leg, from the knees to the ankle. Other ways to say this include:

the lower part of the legs were made of iron (NCV)

From there to its ankles it was iron (CEV)

iron: This was the most common and useful of all metals. In trade, iron was worth less than gold, silver, or bronze. However, people did value iron for its superior strength. People used it to make tools and weapons. The metal iron was often a symbol of power. If you do not have a word for iron in your language, other possibilities for translation are:

- Borrow a national language term.
- Use a general expression such as "a very strong metal."

2:33b

and its feet were part iron and part clay.

- The feet of the statue were made partly of iron and partly of baked clay.
- The feet of the statue were/consisted of part iron and part baked clay.

its feet were part iron and part clay: The feet of the statue were a mixture of iron and clay. This was the weakest part of the statue. Other ways to translate this include:

Its feet were made partly of iron and partly of clay (GW)

its feet were a mixture of iron and clay (CEV)

iron: See the Notes at 2:33a.

clay: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as clay refers to a material that was baked to make pottery. The mixture of iron and clay would cause this part of the statue to be weak.

Daniel 2:34

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
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5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. **Lists:** The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. **Synonyms:** The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. **Poetry:** You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. **Ambiguity:** In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. **Repetition:** Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom

(2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:31–2:35

Daniel told the king what he had seen in his dream.

2:34a

As you watched, a stone was cut out,

- As you^(sing) were looking at the statue, suddenly, someone cut out a rock from a mountain ,
- As you^(sing) watched the statue, someone cut out a stone from a mountain.

As you watched, a stone was cut out: The king watched as a stone was cut out. That is, in his dream he saw this happening. Other ways to translate this include

While you were watching, a rock was cut out (NIV)

You saw a rock being cut out

In your dream a rock was cut out

There is a textual problem in this verse part. Some ancient versions, such as the Greek Septuagint, include the phrase “from a mountain,” explaining from where the rock was cut. Scholars differ about whether this phrase was part of the original text:

1. Many English versions do not include this phrase. Only later in 2:45 does the text explain that the stone came from a mountain. For example:

As you looked, a stone was cut out (ESV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, RSV/NRSV, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NET, GW)

1. Some English versions do include this phrase. For example:

While you were looking at it, a great stone broke loose from a cliff (GNT) (NLT, GNT, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). However, in some languages it may be good to include the

phrase as implied information, to explain what the stone was cut from.

a stone was cut out: This is a passive clause. The Aramaic does not indicate who or what caused the rock to separate from the cliff face. It is implied in the context that it was God or his angels, but this is not stated explicitly. There are several ways to translate this clause:

- Using an active verb with an indefinite subject supplied. For example:

one/they cut out the rock

- Using an active verb with the stone itself as the subject. For example:

a stone broke away (NJB)

- Using a passive verb. For example:

a stone was broken off (NASB)

Use the form that is most natural in your language.

stone: This may have been a large stone, such as workers would use in constructing a building. HALOT, p. 1844, describes it as “a block of stone.” The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel describes this stone as a “very large stone, more like a boulder.”

2:34b

but not by human hands.

- but it was not a human being who did this.
- This was not the deed of any mere mortal.

not by human hands: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates not by human hands is literally “not by hands.” The phrase indicates that a human being did not do this. It implies that a supernatural being cut the rock from the mountain. Some English versions translate literally. For example:

not by hands (NJPS)

However, in some languages a literal translation could imply that people used tools or some other way to cut out the stone. Check that your translation does not imply this. In some languages it may be necessary to avoid mention of hands. For example:

not by humans (GW)

You may have a way in your language to imply that God caused this to happen without saying so directly. The BSB implies this by supplying the word human. Other ways to imply this may include:

not by the hand of man

this was not the work of man

without human intervention

2:34c

It struck the statue on its feet of iron and clay, and crushed them.

- The rock hit the statue on its feet of iron and clay. It smashed the feet into pieces.
- The stone hit the feet of the statue, the feet made from iron and clay. The stone shattered the feet into pieces.

It struck the statue on its feet of iron and clay, and crushed them: The falling rock hit the statue and broke its feet. Other ways to translate this include:

It hit the statue on its feet of iron and clay and smashed them (NCV)

it struck the image on its feet of iron and clay and shattered them (REB)

statue: See the note at 2:31a. Use the same word here that you did there. In some languages it may be natural to leave the statue implicit, mentioning only the feet. For example:

The stone struck the feet (CEV)

on its feet of iron and clay: See the Notes at 2:33b. This information is repeated from 2:33. If this repetition is unnatural in your language, it may be possible to alter or shorten the expression in some way. For example:

on its iron and clay feet

on its feet made from iron and clay

Remind the readers of the composition of the feet in a way that is natural in your language.

and crushed them: The rock caused the statue's feet to break up into smaller bits. Other ways to translate this include:

and broke them in pieces (RSV)

and shattered them (REB)

and smashed them (NIV)

Use the word or phrase that most naturally describes this action.

them: The pronoun them here refers to the feet of the statue.

Daniel 2:35

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:31–2:35

Daniel told the king what he had seen in his dream.

2:35a

Then the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold were shattered

- Then the statue made of gold, silver, bronze, iron, and clay collapsed all at once.
- Then suddenly the whole statue—iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold—fell and broke into pieces.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates Then here introduces the next event in the narrative.

the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold were shattered: This is a passive clause that uses a different form of the same verb as in 2:34c. There are several ways to translate this clause;

- Use an active verb with the rock as the subject. For example:

that rock broke into pieces the whole statue—the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold

- Use an active verb with the statue or its metals as the subject. For example:

the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold crumbled (GNT)

iron and clay, bronze, silver and gold, all broke into pieces (NJB)

the statue and all its metals fell to pieces

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold were smashed (GW)

the iron, the clay, the bronze, the silver and the gold were all shattered into fragments (REB)

the iron, the clay, the bronze, the silver and the gold were crushed (CEV)

Translate this idea in the way that is most natural in your language.

the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold: See the Notes on these different metals at 2:32–33.

2:35b

and became like chaff on the threshing floor in summer.

- The pieces of the statue became like the chaff/dust lying on the threshing floor during the summer
- It broke into pieces as small as the pieces of straw left when a person threshes wheat during the harvest season.
- The pieces that were left were like fine powder, so small that

and became like chaff on the threshing floor in summer: This is a figure of speech called a simile. Daniel compared the broken pieces of the statue to chaff. The point of this comparison is that the pieces of the statue that were left were extremely small, almost as small as dust. They were as small and insignificant as chaff. Be sure that this idea is clear in your translation. In some languages it may be necessary to make the point of the comparison explicit. For example:

as tiny as the bits of straw when a person threshes wheat during the summer

as small as chaff on a threshing floor (NLT)

chaff: The word chaff refers to the part of the wheat that people did not eat, the husks. These husks had no value and were very light. Refer to this chaff in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

husks of wheat (CEV)

If your readers are not familiar with chaff, you may have to substitute a word with a similar meaning that refers to something small and of little value. For example:

dust (GNT)

on the threshing floor: Farmers put their harvested wheat on a hard, level surface called a threshing floor. Then they beat it with sticks or made their cattle walk over it. This caused the grain to separate from the husks, and it all lay on the threshing floor together. Afterwards the workers tossed the pieces into the air. The wind blew away the lighter chaff, and the good grain fell back to the floor. This floor was outdoors near their fields. Avoid using an expression that sug-

gests an indoor location. It may be natural to use a more general expression. For example:

on a threshing place (GNT)

If people in your culture are unfamiliar with this type of action, it may be natural to include a footnote about how people threshed their wheat at this time.

Use the option that is most appropriate for your language.

in summer: There were two main seasons in the land of Israel, summer and winter. People plowed and planted in winter. The summer was the hot, dry season when people harvested their crops. Languages have different ways of describing the seasons of the year. Use the term that refers to the harvest season. Possibilities for translation include:

General Comment on 2:35b

- Translate the name of the harvest season. For example:

in summer (NJB)

- Use the word meaning “harvest.” For example:

during the harvest See La Bible du Semeur.

- Omit the name of the season, if this information is implied by the context. For example:

like chaff on a threshing floor (NLT)

This clause introduces a lot of information that may be new to people in your culture. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate some of this information in a general way. Keep the focus on the fact that the remaining pieces of the statue were very small. For example:

until nothing remained but pieces as fine/small as dust

In some cultures it will be good to add a footnote explaining threshing. For example:

Farmers in Israel separated the good grain from the useless parts by beating it or treading on it and then tossing it into the air. The wind blew away the smaller, lighter, useless parts. Daniel

compared the remains of the statue to the small, useless parts of wheat, the chaff.

2:35c

The wind carried them away, and not a trace of them could be found.

- The wind blew all the pieces away and there was nothing left of the statue there.
- They were carried away by the wind and nothing was left behind.
- the wind blew them away. And nothing remained of the statue.

The Aramaic text connects this verse part with the previous verse part using a common conjunction that many versions translate as “and.” In this context it introduces the next event in a series. The BSB and many other versions leave it untranslated. Introduce what happened next in a way that is natural in your language.

The wind carried them away, and not a trace of them could be found: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as carried...away means to take or sweep something away, that is, to remove it. The wind scattered all the remaining pieces of the statue. Nothing was left to show that anything had been there. Use the expression that is natural in your language to describe what wind does to small objects. For example:

the wind carried them away, so that not a trace of them could be found (NRSV)

The wind blew them away, leaving not a trace behind. (NJB)

not a trace of them could be found: This phrase indicates the result of the wind’s action. There was nothing left of the statue after the pieces had blown away. Some ways to express this in English are:

No one could see any sign of it.

there was nothing left (NCV)

leaving nothing behind

2:35d

But the stone that had struck the statue became a great mountain and filled the whole earth.

- But the stone that struck the statue grew into a huge mountain. It became so big that it covered the entire world.
- However, the stone that hit the statue grew bigger and became as large as a tall mountain. It was so big that it spread over all the earth.

But the stone that had struck the statue became a great mountain: In the king's dream, the statue had gone, but the rock remained. It grew and became as large as a mountain.

But: The connector that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast between the statue and the rock. Nothing remained of the statue, but the stone became a huge mountain. Express this contrast in a natural way in your language.

the stone: See the Note at 2:34a.

that had struck the statue: The same phrase occurs in 2:34b. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

the rock that knocked the statue down (NLT)

became a great mountain: In the king's dream, the stone grew bigger in size until it became as big as a mountain. Other ways to translate this include:

became a huge mountain (NIV)

grew and became a huge mountain (REB)

grew to be a mountain (GNT)

and filled the whole earth: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates literally as filled the whole earth here indicates that the mountain became so big that it was everywhere on the earth. Other ways to translate this include:

that filled the entire earth (NET)

that covered the whole earth (NLT)

that became present all over the world

General Comment on 2:35

In the Aramaic text, 2:35 forms one long sentence. Most English versions break this up into two or more sentences. Use sentence lengths that are natural in your language. For example:

Then all at once, the iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold were smashed. They became like husks on a threshing floor in summer. The wind carried them away, and not a trace of them could be found. But the stone that struck the statue became a large mountain which filled the whole world. (GW)

Daniel 2:36

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean

“crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:36–2:38

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king’s dream.

2:36

This was the dream; now we will tell the king its interpretation.

- 𐤀𐤋 “That was what happened in your dream. Now we^(excl) will tell you what the dream means.
- 𐤀𐤋 “I have described what you^(sing) saw in your dream. Now we^(excl) will interpret the dream for you.

This was the dream: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as This refers to the details of the dream that Daniel had just told the king (2:31–35). This phrase concludes the description of the dream and prepares the reader for the interpretation. Other ways to say this in English are:

That was the dream. (NLT)

That is what happened in your dream.

I have just described what happened in your dream.

now: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as now here indicates that Daniel was about to talk about a new topic. He was about to interpret the meaning of the king’s dream.

we will tell the king its interpretation: Scholars interpret the plural pronoun we in two ways here:

1. It refers to Daniel and his three friends. Daniel was speaking as the representative of the four Hebrew youths. For example:

we will interpret it to the king (NIV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, REB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, ESV, NET, GW)

1. It refers only to Daniel. Daniel used the plural in order to show humility by not focusing attention on himself. However, the king would have understood he was referring just to himself. For example:

I will tell Your Majesty what it means. (GNT) (NLT, GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as it is supported by the use of “us” in 2:23d. As in that reference, this use of the first-person plural is exclusive. It refers to Daniel and his friends but not the king, who was listening to Daniel.

the king: In Babylonian culture, a person spoke to the king in the third person to show respect. See 2:4, 2:7, 2:10–11, and throughout this chapter. This way of speaking may not be natural in your language. If so, you may use the second person. For example:

and now we will interpret the dream for you

and now I'll tell you what it means (CEV)

its: The pronoun *its* here refers to the king's dream.

Daniel 2:37

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
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Paragraph 2:36–2:38

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king's dream.

2:37a

You, O king, are the king of kings,

- Your Majesty, you^(sing) are the greatest of kings.

- O king, you^(sing) are surely the most powerful king in the world.

You, O king, are the king of kings: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates literally as You, O king, are the king of kings uses repetition to emphasize Nebuchadnezzar's power and high status. It shows great respect and honors him. It would not be natural in your language to repeat the word king, you can indicate this honor in another way. For example:

Your Majesty, you are the greatest of all kings.
(GNT)

Your Majesty, you are the greatest of kings. (CEV)

Your Majesty, you are the greatest king. (GW)

You, O king: Daniel addressed Nebuchadnezzar as king. Use the term of address that is most natural and respectful in your language for addressing a king or other top ruler. See also 2:4b, 2:29a. Here is another way to translate this:

Your majesty (NIV)

the king of kings: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the king of kings indicates that Nebuchadnezzar was more powerful than any other king. Some ways to say this in English are:

you are the greatest king (GW)

you are the greatest of all the kings BFCL 88.
(similarly GNT, CEV)

you are the most powerful king

2:37b

to whom the God of heaven has given sovereignty, power, strength, and glory.

- The God who rules from heaven has given you^(sing) royal authority, power, strength, and majesty.
- The true God, who rules from heaven, has made you^(sing) a strong/powerful king/emperor. You are great and majestic!

to whom the God of heaven has given sovereignty, power, strength, and glory: Daniel asserted that it was God who had given Nebuchadnezzar his powerful position. All of Nebuchadnezzar's glory and power

came from God. The BSB follows the Aramaic text, in which the sentence continues from 2:37a. In many languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here, as several English versions have done. For example:

The God of heaven has given you dominion and power and might and glory (NIV)

The God of heaven has granted you sovereignty, power, strength, and honor. (NET)

The God of heaven has given you a kingdom. He has given you power, strength, and honor. (GW)

the God of heaven: The title the God of heaven refers to the one true God. See the Notes on this title at 2:18a. Other ways to say this in English are:

The God who rules in heaven

The true God, who rules from heaven

heaven: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as heaven here refers to the spiritual realm where God lives.

has given sovereignty: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as has given sovereignty here indicates that God had given Nebuchadnezzar his power to rule, his royal authority. God had made him emperor of Babylonia and caused him to reign over it. Other ways to translate this include:

has given you a kingdom (GW)

has made you emperor (GNT)

God has allowed you to rule/reign

power: In this context, the word power has a similar meaning to sovereignty and refers to Nebuchadnezzar's royal authority. All the people of his realm did whatever he commanded. He had the final control over what happened.

strength: The word strength is a near synonym of power. In this context, it probably refers to military strength. Use a general word that expresses this meaning.

glory: In this context the clause to whom...God...has given...glory indicates that God had given Nebuchadnezzar his royal honor or majesty. Nebuchadnezzar lived and reigned in great splendor and magnificent beauty. People all over the known world were in awe of his wealth and greatness. See the key term “glory” 1(a) in KBT. See how you translated “glory” in this sense in Matthew 4:8 and Revelation 21:24, 26.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a verb. For example:

God has highly honored you (CEV)

General Comment on 2:37b

Daniel 2:37b has four words that are closely related in meaning. In some languages you may not have four words with a similar meaning. If that is true in your language, you may need to combine two or more of the words and emphasize the idea in another way. For example:

God has highly honored you with power. (CEV)

God has given you full authority to rule in splendor.

Daniel 2:38

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do

so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
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3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes

will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:36–2:38

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king's dream.

2:38a

Wherever the sons of men or beasts of the field or birds of the air dwell, He has given them into your hand

- God has made you^(sing) the ruler over all people, all the animals and all the birds, wherever they live.
- God/He has given you^(sing) power over people, animals, and birds, everywhere on earth.

Wherever the sons of men or beasts of the field or birds of the air dwell: The Aramaic phrase Wherever... dwell has been interpreted in two ways:

1. It refers to the sons of men, the beasts of the field, and the birds of the air. For example:

human beings, wild animals, birds of the air, wherever they live (NJB) (BSB, RSV, GW, NJPS, NJB, NIV, NET, NCV)

1. It refers only to the sons of men. For example:

human beings, wherever they live, the wild animals of the field, and the birds of the air (NRSV) (NRSV, REB, NASB, GNT, NLT, KJV)

Both interpretations are possible and are strongly supported. Either is acceptable. Interpretation (1) is supported by several commentators and the BSB and is therefore followed in these notes. Other ways to translate this include:

Wherever people, wild animals, and birds live (NCV)

people, wild animals, and birds, wherever they live (GW)

the sons of men: This phrase refers to people in general, both men and women.

beasts of the field: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates literally as beasts of the field means "wild animals." Here is another way to translate this:

wild beasts (NJPS)

However, Daniel did not mean that the king only ruled over the wild animals, not domesticated animals. If readers interpret this phrase in that way, it would be better to translate this term in a more general way. For example:

animals (GNT)

birds of the air: In many languages the phrase of the air or "in the sky" is unnecessary. It may wrongly suggest that birds such as chickens (that do not generally fly) are not included. If that is true in your language, you may use a simple expression. For example:

birds (GNT)

He has given them into your hand: This reference to the hand of Nebuchadnezzar is figurative language that indicates that God had given him power over all people and animals. As king, Nebuchadnezzar had power to decide who should live and who should die. In many languages it may be natural to state the meaning directly. For example:

He has given you control over people, wild animals, and birds, wherever they live. (GW)

He has made you ruler of all the inhabited earth and ruler over all the animals and birds. (GNT)

General Comment on 2:38a

The BSB follows the phrase order of the Aramaic in 2:38a. Use the order that is most natural in your language. For example:

^{38a}human beings, wild animals, birds of the air, wherever they live, he has entrusted to your rule (NJB)

^{38a}and into whose hand he has given, wherever they dwell, the children of man, the beasts of the field, and the birds of the heavens (ESV)

^{38a}in your hands he has placed all mankind and the beasts of the field and the birds in the sky. Wherever they live, (NIV)

Note that the NIV connects the phrase “Wherever they live” with 2:38b. These Notes recommend that you connect it with 2:38a, as in all the other examples shown.

2:38b and has made you ruler over them all.

- God has appointed you^(sing) the ruler over all of them.
- He has caused you^(sing) to rule over all living creatures.

and has made you ruler over them all: This expression repeats some information from 2:38a. It repeats the information, “He has given them into your hand.” It functions as a summary statement. God was the one who had permitted the king to rule over all people, animals, and birds. Other ways to translate this include:

making you king of them all (NJB)

making you rule over them all (NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this summary statement as a separate sentence. For example:

He has made you ruler of them all. (GW)

He has given you authority over them all. (NET)

General Comment on 2:38a–b

Daniel 2:38b repeats information from 2:38a. In some languages it may be more natural to combine these two parts. For example:

^{38a-b}Wherever people, wild animals, and birds live, God made you ruler over them. (NCV)

^{38a-b}God has allowed you to rule over all people, animals, and birds, wherever they live.

2:38c You are that head of gold.

- You^(sing) are the head of gold on the statue.
- And so the golden head of the statue represents you^(sing) and your kingdom.

You are that head of gold: This clause is the climax of 2:36–38. Daniel declared that the head of gold in the dream represented King Nebuchadnezzar. He spoke of the king himself, rather than his kingdom, Babylonia. In this context the king represents his kingdom. Some possible ways to translate this in English are:

you are the head of gold on that statue (NCV)

So then, the head of gold in your dream—it is you!

That head of gold symbolizes you and your kingdom

Daniel 2:39

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

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another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:39–2:43

In this paragraph, Daniel explained that the other parts of the statue represented three kingdoms that would have power after Nebuchadnezzar. Scholars disagree as to which historical kingdoms these are. These different views should not influence the way you translate. Scholars also differ in the way they interpret the fact that the metals progressively decline in value. It is best to translate this section as literally as possible.

2:39a

But after you, there will arise another kingdom, inferior to yours.

- ¶ “After you, another kingdom will rise/come to power. However, it will not be as great as your kingdom.
- ¶ “Another kingdom will become powerful after you and your kingdom. But that kingdom will have a lower status than your kingdom.

But after you, there will arise another kingdom, inferior to yours: Daniel said that the dream foretold that Nebuchadnezzar’s kingdom would not endure forever. It would pass away, and another kingdom would take its place.

But after you: Here the pronoun you is used in a figurative way. The king represented his kingdom. After Nebuchadnezzar died, the Babylonian kingdom in fact continued to exist for another 43 years. The new kingdom did not arise immediately after his death. Another way to translate this is:

But after your kingdom comes to an end (NLT)

there will arise another kingdom: The author used the verb arise in a figurative sense. Your language may have a different verb that describes when a new kingdom begins.

another kingdom will rule (CEV)

another kingdom will come (NCV)

another kingdom will take its place

kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom here refers to the realm over which a king or emperor rules. Other ways to say this in English are:

empire (GNT)

great kingdom (NLT)

In some languages it may be helpful to add implied information:

another kingdom, the one symbolized by silver,

This second kingdom has traditionally been identified with the empire of the Medes and the Persians (or Medo-Persian Empire). However, this is nowhere stated and many scholars disagree, so it should not be made explicit.

inferior to yours: The pronoun yours here means “your kingdom,” that is, Babylonia. The word inferior means to be less in quality or value than something else. It is best to use a general expression rather than indicating in what specific way this kingdom was inferior. For example:

not as great as yours (NJB)

2:39b

Next, a third kingdom, one of bronze, will rule the whole earth.

- After that, a third kingdom will gain power over the whole world. The third kingdom is the bronze part of the statue.
- Next a third kingdom will have authority over all the earth. That is what the bronze part of the statue represents.

Next, a third kingdom, one of bronze, will rule the whole earth: The middle part of the statue was made of bronze. This bronze part represented a third kingdom. This kingdom has been traditionally identified with the Greek empire. Again, this is disputed and should not be made explicit. Other ways to translate this include:

and after that a third, an empire of bronze, which will rule the whole earth (GNT)

Then it will be followed by a kingdom of bronze that will rule the whole world. (CEV)

Next: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Next here introduces the next kingdom in the temporal sequence. Other ways English versions translate this are:

Then there will be... (GW)

After that kingdom has fallen (NLT)

a third kingdom, one of bronze: Daniel identified the third kingdom with the bronze part of the statue. In some languages it may be necessary to make the comparison more clear. For example:

a third kingdom, represented by bronze (NLT)

a third kingdom, the bronze part (NCV)

the kingdom after that will be like the bronze part of the statue

bronze: See the Notes on bronze at 2:32c. Translate it here as you did there.

will rule the whole earth: The phrase rule the whole earth emphasizes the great power of the third kingdom. The leaders of the third kingdom would have power over all the known world. Other ways to translate this include:

will rise to rule the world (NLT)

whose kings will rule over all the world

its power will extend/reach over the whole world

Daniel 2:40

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)

6. The GNT has three sections:

- (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
- (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
- (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:39–2:43

In this paragraph, Daniel explained that the other parts of the statue represented three kingdoms that would have power after Nebuchadnezzar. Scholars disagree as to which historical kingdoms these are. These different views should not influence the way you translate. Scholars also differ in the way they interpret the fact that the metals progressively decline in value. It is best to translate this section as literally as possible.

2:40a

Finally, there will be a fourth kingdom as strong as iron;

- And then a fourth kingdom will come into being/ power. It will be strong like iron,
- Next there will be a fourth kingdom. Iron is strong, and this kingdom will be strong,

Finally, there will be a fourth kingdom as strong as iron:

Traditionally interpreters have identified this fourth kingdom with the Roman Empire. However, other interpreters dispute this, and you should not make it explicit. Ways to translate this include:

Then there will be a fourth kingdom, one strong like iron. (NET)

Following that kingdom, there will be a fourth one, as strong as iron. (NLT)

The next kingdom to come to power will be as strong as iron.

Finally: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as Finally here introduces the next and final element in a series. Other ways to translate it include:

Next (CEV)

Then (NCV)

there will be a fourth kingdom: The fourth kingdom would begin after the third one. Make the temporal sequence clear. For example:

Following that kingdom, there will be a fourth one

the kingdom after that, kingdom four,

as strong as iron: This is a comparison that helps to explain the dream. The fourth kingdom is compared to iron, and the point of similarity is strength. The context implies that the kingdom would be a strong military power. See the Notes at 2:33a, and translate iron in the same way that you did there. Translate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

as iron is strong, so this kingdom will be strong

like iron, it will have great strength

it will possess the strength of iron

2:40b

for iron shatters and crushes all things,

- which breaks and shatters everything to pieces.
- and like iron will break and shatter everything.

for iron shatters and crushes all things: There are two ways to understand the clause that the BSB translates as for iron shatters and crushes all things:

1. It is connected to the previous clause and introduces an explanation of the way in which this fourth kingdom was like iron. It introduces an explanation of the comparison. For example:

because iron breaks to pieces and shatters all things (ESV)

which shatters and breaks everything (GNT) (BSB, RSV, ESV, GW, GNT, NJB, NIV, KJV)

1. It is connected to the following clause and forms the first half of another comparison. For example:

just as iron crushes and smashes everything, it shall crush and shatter all these (NRSV)

In the same way that iron crushes and smashes things to pieces, the fourth kingdom will smash and crush all the other kingdoms. (NCV) (NRSV, REB, NET, NLT, NCV, NASB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which seems the most natural reading in the context. The choice of interpretation (2) leads to repetition with the following verse part.

iron shatters and crushes all things: The two verbs shatters and crushes are similar in meaning. Daniel used two verbs to emphasize the strength of iron. Emphasize the strength of iron and its destructive power in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

iron breaks and smashes everything (NIV)

iron totally breaks everything into pieces

shatters: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as shatters means “crushes” or “grinds something into small pieces.”

crushes: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as crushes means “smashes, shatters.” It can be used to describe the impact of a hammer on a fragile object.

all things: This is a general phrase. Since iron was the strongest metal known at that time, people used it to break anything else they wanted to break. Other ways to translate this include:

anything

everything (NIV)

2:40c

and like iron that crushes all things,

- Just as iron crushes all these,
- And as iron breaks all these metals to pieces,

and like iron that crushes all things: This clause repeats information from 2:40b. Scholars differ as to whether this clause was in the original text.

1. This clause did form part of the original Aramaic text. For example:

and like iron which crushes (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NJPS, GW, GNT, NIV, NJB)

1. This clause was not in the original text. Some ancient versions (translations) do not include it. For example:

^{40a,b,d}Next, a kingdom of iron will come to power, crushing and shattering everything. (CEV) (NRSV, CEV, NLT, NCV, REB)

Option (1) probably best represents the original text. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), translating this as the first half of a comparison, which continues in 2:40d.

and like: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates and like introduce a comparison. The author compared the fourth kingdom to iron. You should make this comparison clear. For example:

And just as (GNT)

Like iron that... (NJB)

iron that crushes all things: The BSB has supplied the object things. You may supply a general object or leave it implicit, whichever is most natural in your language. For example:

iron which crushes (RSV)

crushes: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as crushes is a different verb from the two verbs used in 2:40b. All three verbs are close synonyms. If you do not have a different verb to translate this idea, you can use one of the verbs you used in 2:40b.

2:40d

it will shatter and crush all the others.

- so the fourth kingdom will smash and crush the other kingdoms.
- in the same way the fourth kingdom will destroy everything.

it will shatter and crush all the others: The two verbs shatter and crush are close synonyms. For the verb

shatter see the note at 2:40b. For the verb crush, see the note at 2:40c. The use of two verbs emphasizes the idea. Translation models include:

shatters and breaks (REB)

totally smash

it: The pronoun it refers to the fourth kingdom. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

the fourth kingdom will smash and crush (GW)

all the others: The phrase all the others in this context refers to the three previous kingdoms. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear. For example:

all the other kingdoms (GW)

all the earlier empires (GNT)

General Comment on 2:40

In the Aramaic text 2:40a–d forms one sentence. The BSB has translated it as one sentence and the NIV has translated it as two sentences, 2:40a–b and c–d. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as three or more sentences. For example:

There will also be a fourth kingdom. It will be as strong as iron. (Iron smashes and shatters everything.) As iron crushes things, this fourth kingdom will smash and crush all the other kingdoms. (GW)

Daniel 2:41

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:

- (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
- (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
- (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean "crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:39–2:43

In this paragraph, Daniel explained that the other parts of the statue represented three kingdoms that would have power after Nebuchadnezzar. Scholars disagree as to which historical kingdoms these are. These different views should not influence the way you translate. Scholars also differ in the way they interpret the fact that the metals progressively decline in value. It is best to translate this section as literally as possible.

2:41a

And just as you saw that the feet and toes were made partly of fired clay and partly of iron,

- Just as the feet and toes were partly baked clay and partly iron,
- You^(sing) saw in your dream that the feet and toes were made partly of baked clay and partly of iron.

And just as you saw that the feet and toes were made partly of fired clay and partly of iron: This verse part introduces an explanation of the meaning of the feet and toes of the statue. Other ways to translate this include:

You also saw that the feet and the toes were partly clay and partly iron. This means that....
(GNT)

The feet and toes you saw were a combination of iron and baked clay, showing that.... (NLT)

You saw that the statue's feet and toes were partly baked clay and partly iron. That means... (NCV)

the feet and toes: In some languages it may be unnatural to mention the toes separately. as they may form part of the feet. In those languages you may need to follow the NJB and leave them implicit:

The feet (NJB)

fired clay: For the word clay, see the Notes at 2:33b. The phrase that the BSB translates as fired clay is literally "clay of the potter." This phrase refers to something people made from clay, pottery, rather than the raw material. English versions translate this material in different ways:

potter's clay (RSV)

earthenware (NJB)

iron: See the Notes at 2:33a, where the same word is used.

2:41b

so this will be a divided kingdom,

- so the fourth kingdom will not be united.
- That means the kingdom will not be united.
- In a similar way, the fourth kingdom will be divided.

so this will be a divided kingdom: The clause this will be a divided kingdom indicates the significance or meaning of the clay-iron mix in the feet and toes. Connect this clause to the 2:41a in a way that is natural in your language. The BSB has supplied the conjunction so. Other possible translations include:

showing that this kingdom will be divided (NLT)

This means that it will be a divided empire (GNT)

a divided kingdom: Scholars have interpreted the phrase a divided kingdom in two ways:

1. It indicates that the kingdom will lack internal harmony or unity. For example:

this kingdom will not be unified

1. It indicates that the kingdom will separate into two or more parts. For example:

a kingdom which will be split in two (NJB)

Most English translations use the word divided, which can have either meaning. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits best with the context of the rest of the verse. The different people groups or members of this kingdom/empire will not live in peace and harmony. There will be internal conflict.

General Comment on 2:41a-b

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder 2:41a-b. For example:

The fourth kingdom will not be united. That explains why the feet and the toes were part iron and part clay. Similarly, the GeCL98.

2:41c

yet some of the strength of iron will be in it—

- However, part of the fourth kingdom will be strong as iron
- But it will contain some of the strength of iron,

yet some of the strength of iron will be in it: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as yet here introduces a contrast. Although the feet would be a mixture of iron and clay, it would still have parts in it that were strong. Other ways to translate this include:

but some of the strength of iron shall be in it (NRSV)

It will have something of the strength of iron (GNT)

strength: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as strength refers to the quality of being firm or hard. Other ways to translate it include:

firmness (RSV)

stability (NJPS)

In some languages it may be natural to use an adjective. For example:

it will be...strong (CEV)

2:41d**just as you saw the iron mixed with clay.**

- for you^(sing) saw that there was iron mixed with the baked clay.
- as you saw that

just as you saw the iron mixed with clay: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as just as here probably introduces an explanation or reason for what Daniel had just said. For example:

for you saw iron mixed with wet clay (NET)

because there was iron mixed with the clay (GNT)

clay: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates clay is here literally “potter’s clay of clay.” The exact reference of this expression is not clear. However, the emphasis is on the weakness of the material. Use an expression that suggests or implies this. For example:

earthenware (NJB)

Comment on 2:41c–d

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this clause. For example:

You saw in your dream that the iron was mixed with clay. This means that parts of the fourth kingdom will be strong as iron.

Daniel 2:42**Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream**

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)

(c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying

who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:39–2:43

In this paragraph, Daniel explained that the other parts of the statue represented three kingdoms that would have power after Nebuchadnezzar. Scholars disagree as to which historical kingdoms these are. These different views should not influence the way you translate. Scholars also differ in the way they interpret the fact that the metals progressively decline in value. It is best to translate this section as literally as possible.

2:42a

And as the toes of the feet were partly iron and partly clay,

- Just as the toes of the statue were part iron and part clay,
- the toes consisted of some iron and some clay.

And as the toes of the feet were partly iron and partly clay: This clause repeats information from 2:41a, d, and uses it to make another comparison. Other ways to translate this include:

As in your vision the feet and toes were part iron and part potter’s clay (REB)

The toes—partly iron and partly clay—mean that... (GNT)

In the vision, the toes were partly iron and partly clay. This means...

Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

the toes of the feet: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the toes is literally “the toes of the feet,” as in the NASB. In some languages it may be natural to translate in this way, but in many cases it may be more natural to follow the BSB or to say, following the NCV:

The toes of the statue (NCV)

2:42b

so this kingdom will be partly strong and partly brittle.

- in the same way part of the fourth kingdom will be strong and part of it will be weak.
- This shows/means that some of the fourth kingdom will be strong and some of it will be weak.

so this kingdom will be partly strong and partly brittle: This is the second half of the comparison. Like the toes, the fourth kingdom will be a mixture of elements, part strong and part brittle. You can say:

Part of the fourth kingdom will be strong and part of it will be brittle

strong: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as strong can be used to describe a material that is hard to break. In this context, however, it is used figuratively to describe a kingdom that is powerful and united. Try to find a word that can describe both a metal like iron and a country or empire.

brittle: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as brittle can describe material that breaks easily. Here the word is used figuratively to describe a kingdom that is weak and not united. Again, try to use a word that readers can understand in both ways. For example:

weak (GNT)

breakable (NCV)

fragile

In some languages it may be most natural to say:

not strong

General Comment on 2:41–42

There is a lot of repetition of information in 2:41–42. In some languages it may be natural to combine some of these verse parts and say:

This fourth kingdom will be divided—it will be both strong and brittle, just as you saw that the feet and toes were a mixture of iron and clay.

Daniel 2:43

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different

words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:39–2:43

In this paragraph, Daniel explained that the other parts of the statue represented three kingdoms that would have power after Nebuchadnezzar. Scholars disagree as to which historical kingdoms these are. These different views should not influence the way you translate. Scholars also differ in the way they interpret the fact that the metals progressively decline

in value. It is best to translate this section as literally as possible.

2:43a

As you saw the iron mixed with clay,

- And as you saw that baked clay was mixed with the iron,
- You saw the iron and the clay were mixed together,

As you saw the iron mixed with clay: This clause repeats information from 2:41–42. This information is again used to begin making a comparison with the future kingdom. Here is another way to translate this:

This mixture of iron and clay also shows that...
(NLT)

clay: This is the same phrase as in 2:41a. It is probably used to emphasize the weakness of this material, especially as compared to iron. Here is another way to translate this:

the clay of the earthenware (NJB)

2:43b

so the peoples will mix with one another,

- so its people will be a mixture.
- which shows/means that the kingdom will be a combination/alliance of people,

so the peoples will mix with one another: This is the second part of the comparison. The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as the peoples will mix with one another is more literally “they will be mixing with the offspring/seed of humankind.” Daniel did not specify whether the pronoun “they” referred to people, rulers, races, cultures, or exactly what. Scholars interpret this clause in two ways:

1. It refers to general social and political mixing/mingling. Different religious, social, or ethnic groups will try to unite. For example:

they will be a mixture (NCV) (BSB, NIV, NCV, NJPS, KJV, NASB, NET)

1. It refers to people who try to unite together by intermarrying. For example:

the rulers of that empire will try to unite their families by intermarriage (GNT) (NJB, GNT, REB, NLT, RSV/NRSV, ESV, GW, CEV)

Interpretation (1) is recommended. It is good however to translate in such a way that this “mixing” could include intermarriage, as in interpretation (2). Those commentators who interpret the fourth kingdom as the Greek Empire, see a reference to the marriages between the Ptolemaic and Seleucid dynasties. See Collins, pp. 170–71. These marriages are mentioned again in Daniel 11:6,17. Those who interpret the fourth kingdom as the Roman Empire, often interpret the pronoun as referring to different races of people. Collins (p. 171) cites Keil, Young.

2:43c

but will not hold together

- But they will not remain/hold together
- but it will eventually break up.

but will not hold together: The implied subject is indefinite, like the subject of the previous verb “will mix.” The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as hold together means “stick together, cling.” This is a metaphor that in this context probably refers to the alliances that the various peoples of the fourth kingdom will make with one another. These alliances will not remain strong. Other ways to translate this include:

and will not remain united (NIV)

But this will not succeed (NLT)

without adhering to one another (NET)

but such alliances will not be stable (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to use a positive verb. Try to use a verb that can be used of both alliances and physical objects like statues. For example:

but it will crumble (CEV)

but: The common Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as but here introduces an action that is opposed to the action in the previous verse part. Although these people or peoples will mix, they will not keep a strong union. This is why many English versions, including the BSB, translate it as but here. Connect 2:43b to 2:43c in a way that is natural in your language.

2:43d

any more than iron mixes with clay.

- just as iron cannot remain mixed with clay.

- For iron cannot really combine with clay.

any more than iron mixes with clay: See the Notes on iron at 2:33a and clay at 2:33b. Iron and clay are substances that cannot be successfully united or joined together. Other ways to translate this include:

just as iron and clay do not mix (NLT)

just as iron does not unite with pottery

just as you/one cannot combine iron and clay

In some languages this verse part may appear to involve a contradiction of 2:43a. If that is a problem in your language, you may be able to use a different verb here. The point is that although you can “mix” iron and clay, you cannot join or combine them into one. They will just fall apart again. For example:

just as iron and clay don’t stick together (CEV)

any more than iron will blend with clay (NJB)

General Comment on 2:43a–d

In 2:43 two comparisons are made between the statue’s feet and the fourth empire. In 2:43a and 2:43d Daniel talked about the statue, and in 2:43b and 2:43c, he talked about the empire. In some languages it may be natural to reorder these verse parts to put the references to the statue together and the references to the empire together. For example:

^{43a}You saw the iron and clay mixed together, ^{43d}but iron and clay do not hold together. ^{43b}In the same way the people of the fourth kingdom will be a mixture, ^{43c}but they will not be united as one people. (NCV)

Another possibility is to put either the statue or the empire as the first half of both the comparisons. For example:

^{43a}You saw the iron and clay mixed together. ^{43b}In this way the people of the fourth kingdom will be mixed together. ^{43d}But iron cannot stick to clay. ^{43c}And in this way the people will not be united.

Daniel 2:44

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote

using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20-23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36-45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:44-2:45

This paragraph introduces the new topic of a fifth kingdom. This kingdom will be different from all the other kingdoms. God himself will establish it, and it will last forever.

2:44a-b

the God of heaven will set up a kingdom that will never be destroyed: Daniel said that God will establish a kingdom that no other kingdom will ever conquer. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two sentences or two independent clauses. For example:

the God of heaven will set up another kingdom.
This kingdom will never be destroyed.

2:44a

In the days of those kings, the God of heaven will set up a kingdom

- ¶ "During the time when those kings rule, the true God who rules from heaven will establish a new kingdom.
- ¶ "In the time of the rulers of the fourth kingdom, God, who rules from heaven, will raise up another kingdom.

In the days of those kings: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates literally as days does not refer to 24-hour days here, but to a general period of time. Another way to translate this is:

During the time when those kings ruled

The author did not say how long a period this was. It is best not to be specific.

those kings: Daniel did not say who these kings were. In this chapter he has only mentioned Nebuchadnezzar, who was the king of the first kingdom. Scholars disagree as to who these kings were. Some think that it refers to the kings who ruled during the last kingdom, the kingdom represented by the feet and toes. While this may be true, it is recommended that you translate this in a general way, without saying to which kings Daniel was referring. Here is another way to translate this:

those rulers (GNT)

the God of heaven will set up a kingdom: God will cause another kingdom to rise or become powerful. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

the God of heaven will establish a kingdom

the God of heaven: See the Notes at 2:18a for the phrase God of heaven. Here is another way to translate this:

the God who rules from heaven (CEV)

2:44b

that will never be destroyed,

- No one will ever be able to destroy that kingdom,

- No one will ever conquer this kingdom.

that will never be destroyed: This is a passive clause. It indicates that no other king or kingdom will be able to destroy the kingdom that God has established. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

that will not be destroyed (NET)

- Using an active verb. For example:

that no army/king will ever conquer

2:44c

nor will it be left to another people.

- and no other group of people will ever rule over it.
- God will not allow another nation to rule over it.

nor will it be left to another people: This also is a passive clause. It indicates that no other people will be able to take over and rule that kingdom. God will not allow any other people to conquer it. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

or given to another group of people (NCV)

a kingdom that will not be transferred to another people (NJPS)

- Using an active verb. For example:

No other people will ever rule over it (NLT)

It will not pass into the hands/power of another people.

people: It is good to translate this word in a general way, referring to a group of people such as another country or nation.

2:44d

It will shatter all these kingdoms and bring them to an end,

- This kingdom will crush all those other kingdoms. It will completely destroy them.
- The new kingdom will smash every other kingdom. It will cause them all to end/collapse,

It will shatter all these kingdoms and bring them to an end: The new kingdom that God will establish will

destroy all human kingdoms. Try to use expressions that can apply both to a rock crushing things and to an empire destroying other countries. Other ways to translate this include:

It shall break in pieces all these kingdoms and bring them to an end (ESV)

It will crush all those kingdoms and bring them to an end (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two ideas of “shattering” and “bringing to an end” the other kingdoms. For example:

but will completely destroy all those empires (GNT)

it will crush all these kingdoms into nothingness (NLT)

It: This pronoun refers to the new kingdom that God will establish.

all these kingdoms: Daniel does not specifically say which kingdoms. It probably refers in a general way to all human kingdoms, including the four kingdoms represented by the four metals, and all other kingdoms in existence. In some languages it may be natural to say:

all the other kingdoms (NCV)

2:44e

but will itself stand forever.

- but this/God’s kingdom will last forever.
- but will itself never come to an end.

but will itself stand forever: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as stand means “rise.” Here it is used figuratively and indicates that the new kingdom will last forever. Other translation models include:

but it will itself endure forever. (NIV)

and then last forever (GNT)

But it will itself never come to an end.

General Comment on 2:44

In some languages it may be natural to translate 2:44a–d using several shorter sentences. For example:

^{44a}At the time of those kings, the God of heaven will establish a kingdom that will never be destroyed. ^{44b}No other people will be permitted to rule it. ^{44c}It will smash all the other kingdoms and put an end to them. ^{44d}But it will be established forever. (GW)

Daniel 2:45

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar’s Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar’s dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel’s God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean

“crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king’s dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:44–2:45

This paragraph introduces the new topic of a fifth kingdom. This kingdom will be different from all the other kingdoms. God himself will establish it, and it will last forever.

2:45a

And just as you saw a stone being cut out of the mountain without human hands,

- ¶ “This is the meaning of the rock that someone cut from a mountain. It was not a human being who did this. It was God.
- ¶ “This is what the dream meant when you saw someone cut out a stone from a mountain. It was not a human who cut it out. God made it happen.

And just as you saw: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as *And just as you saw* here introduces a summary statement. Daniel identified the new kingdom with the symbol of the rock in the king’s dream. Other ways to translate this include:

This is the meaning of the vision (NIV)

This is the meaning of your vision (REB)

That is the meaning of... (NLT)

Introduce this summary statement in a way that is natural in your language.

a stone being cut out of the mountain: See the Notes at 2:34a. See how you translated this idea there. For example:

- Use a passive, as most English versions do. For example:

a stone was cut from a mountain (NET)

- Use an indefinite form. For example:

someone/he cut out a stone

You may have another way in your language to imply that God caused this to happen. You should not make this explicit.

without human hands: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as *without human hands* is literally “not by hands” (NJPS). The phrase indicates that a human being did not do this. It implies that a supernatural being cut the rock from the mountain. See the Notes at 2:34a. Translate here as you did there. If you have a way of implying that God did this, without saying so explicitly, you should use that here.

2:45b

and it shattered the iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold,

- That rock smashed the statue that was made of gold, silver, bronze, iron, and baked clay.
- Then the stone struck the statue made of gold, silver, bronze, iron, and baked clay and completely destroyed it.

and it shattered the iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold: Daniel continued to summarize what the king had seen in his dream. Other ways to translate this include:

It smashed the iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold. (GW)

and then shattering the iron, the bronze, the clay, the silver, and the gold (REB)

that crushed to pieces the statue of iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold (NLT)

the iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold: See the Notes on these terms at 2:32a, 2:32b, 2:32c, 2:33a. Here the materials are listed in almost reverse order, from the bottom to the top of the statue. The significance of this is not known, but it is good to maintain this order. In some languages it may be natural to say:

the statue of iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold (NLT)

2:45c

so the great God has told the king what will happen in the future.

- The great God has showed you^(sing) the king what will happen in the future.
- The great God has revealed to Your Majesty what will happen in the future.

so the great God has told the king what will happen in the future: Daniel told Nebuchadnezzar that his dream was a message from God. God was letting Nebuchadnezzar know what was going to happen in the coming years. Other ways to translate this include:

The great God was showing the king what will happen in the future. (NLT)

In this way the great God showed you what will happen. (NCV)

The great God is telling Your Majesty what will happen in the future. (GNT)

the great God: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as God can refer to a pagan god or the God of Israel. In this context, Daniel refers to the God of Israel. The BSB has supplied the definite article the. You should supply it if that gives the correct meaning, that there is one God, and he is great. It is important to make sure that your translation does not imply that there is another God who is not great.

great: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as great here is a title of respect for God and indicates that he is great in power. It is the same adjective that is used to describe an earthly king in 2:10b. In your translation, use a word that is appropriate for speaking highly of God's power. It need not be the same word that you used to describe a human king. Here is another way to translate this:

mighty (REB)

has told the king: God had informed the king, through his dream, of future events. Use a verb that is appropriate for revealing information indirectly, such as through a dream. For example:

has let the king know

Daniel addressed the king in the third person in order to show respect. If this is not natural in your language, you can use the second person. If your language has a special way to show respect to someone who has a higher status, you should use it here. For example:

has shown your Majesty (NLT)

has revealed to you, sir

what will happen in the future: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as in the future is more literally "after this." Other ways to translate this include:

what will happen in the future (NLT)

what will happen (NCV)

future events

2:45d

The dream is true, and its interpretation is trustworthy."

- I have told you the truth about your dream, and you can trust the interpretation."
- This was your^(sing) dream, and I have interpreted it correctly/accurately."
- This is exactly what you dreamed, and I have explained to you^(sing) its true meaning."

The dream is true: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as true means "sure, certain." There are two ways to interpret the clause that the BSB translates as The dream is true:

1. God had sent the dream and it gave an accurate description of future events. For example (combining the two clauses in 2:45d):

The dream and its interpretation are true and trustworthy. (REB) (CEV, NJB, REB, probably NCV, NLT, GW, REB)

1. It indicates that Daniel had accurately revealed the content of the dream. This was truly the dream. For example:

I have told you exactly what you dreamed (GNT)
(GNT, probably NET)

Most English versions are similar to the BSB and can be understood either way, although interpretation (1) is the more natural understanding. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

and its interpretation is trustworthy: The phrase and its interpretation is trustworthy means "and the way I have interpreted the dream is accurate." Daniel claimed he had interpreted the dream correctly. The king could trust what he had said. Other ways to translate this include:

and its interpretation is reliable (NET)

and its interpretation sure (NIV)

and you can trust that this is the meaning (GW)

Daniel 2:46

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

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6. The GNT has three sections:
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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.

4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:46–2:47

The king was deeply impressed that Daniel could tell him his dream. He honored him and his friends with high positions in the government of Babylon.

2:46a

At this, King Nebuchadnezzar fell on his face, paid homage to Daniel,

- ¶ Then King Nebuchadnezzar bowed down low before Daniel with his face to the ground and honored Daniel.
- ¶ At this King Nebuchadnezzar bowed down low to the ground to show respect to Daniel.

At this, King Nebuchadnezzar fell on his face: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as fell on his face indicates that the king bowed face down to the ground in front of Daniel. This was a gesture of great respect. Make sure that your readers understand this. The king did not fall over accidentally. In some languages it may be possible to avoid this wrong meaning by saying:

King Nebuchadnezzar bowed down with his face to the ground (NET)

Then King Nebuchadnezzar bowed to the ground (GNT)

paid homage to Daniel: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as paid homage here indicates that Nebuchadnezzar honored Daniel as God's representative. The same word is sometimes used of venerating a god. It describes an attitude of submission and respect to a superior being. Here is another way to translate this:

the king honored him (NCV)

2:46b

and ordered that an offering of incense be presented to him.

- He commanded his servants to offer a sacrifice of grain and an offering of incense to Daniel.
- He ordered his workers to offer a grain offering to Daniel and to burn sweet smelling perfume for him.

and ordered that an offering of incense be presented to him: King Nebuchadnezzar gave orders to his servants to honor Daniel as the representative of God. Other ways to translate this include:

and commanded that an offering and incense be offered up to him (RSV)

and gave orders for sacrifices and offerings to be made to Daniel (GNT)

Then he gave orders for incense to be burned and a sacrifice offered in honor of Daniel (similar to CEV)

offering: An offering is a gift that is given to a deity. This could have been a grain offering or an animal offering. It is best to leave this general, as the BSB

has done. See the KBT for how to translate the term "offering." Here is another way to translate this:

sacrifice (NET)

incense: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as incense here probably refers to a substance that people burn in order to produce a sweet smell and please or honor a deity. If incense is not known in your culture, it may help to make this clear by following the NLT:

sweet incense (NLT)

be presented to him: The verb be presented is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb. In those languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that Nebuchadnezzar gave this order to his servants, probably men. For example:

he commanded his people to offer sacrifices and burn sweet incense before him (NLT)

General Comment on 2:46b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's command as direct speech. For example:

The king commanded, "An offering and incense are to be presented to Daniel."

He gave this command to his servants: "Offer a sacrifice to Daniel and burn incense in his presence."

Daniel 2:47

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)

- (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean “to reveal” or “to make known.” There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean “crush, break to pieces.” In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.
3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a

Daniel referred to “those kings” without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of “all these kingdoms.” The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.

5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:46–2:47

The king was deeply impressed that Daniel could tell him his dream. He honored him and his friends with high positions in the government of Babylon.

2:47a

The king said to Daniel,

- He/Nebuchadnezzar said to Daniel,

The king said to Daniel: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates The king said to Daniel is literally “and the king was answering Daniel and saying.” This introduction indicates that the king was about to say something very important. You can say:

he declared

The king exclaimed

2:47b

“Your God is truly the God of gods

- “Your^(sing) God is truly the greatest of all gods.
- “It is certain that the God you^(sing) worship must be greater than all other gods.

2:47b-c

Your God is truly the God of gods and Lord of kings: This verse is the climax of the chapter. If your language has a special way to mark the climax of a story, you should use that here. Try to add emphasis in a way that is natural to your language. For example:

Wow! So your God is indeed the God of gods and the Lord of kings!

Your God is truly the God of gods: Nebuchadnezzar probably believed that there were many gods. He proclaimed that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest one. See how you translated the phrase God of gods in Deuteronomy 10:17. In that context, however, the speaker/writer did not believe in many gods, so you may need to use a different expression here.

Your God: In some languages it is not possible to use a possessive pronoun with God. You may be able to say:

the God you worship

the God you serve

God of gods: In this context, the expression is a superlative. The God Daniel worshiped was greater than all other gods.

the greatest of all gods (GNT)

the God who rules over all other gods

truly: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as truly is literally “from truth that.” This expression is an exclamation. It introduces and emphasizes a positive assertion. English ways to do this include:

Truly I know... (CEV)

Certainly (NET)

2:47c and Lord of kings,

- He is the Lord who rules over all kings.
- He must be the Lord/ruler over all kings.

and Lord of kings: The phrase Lord of kings means “the one who is the ruler of all other kings.” You can say:

the Lord over kings (GNT)

the Lord over all the kings (NCV)

he is the Lord who rules over all the kings

2:47d the Revealer of Mysteries,

- He can reveal mysteries—
- He reveals to people what they cannot know/understand by themselves.

the Revealer of Mysteries: God is able to tell people things that they could not find out or know by themselves. See the Notes at 2:29b. The following are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He can reveal secrets (GW)

He alone can reveal mysteries

He tells people about things they cannot know (NCV)

Mysteries: See the Notes at 2:18a.

2:47e since you were able to reveal this mystery.”

- for you^(sing) were able to explain this mystery.”
- I know this because you^(sing) had the power/ability to interpret my dream.”

since you were able to reveal this mystery: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as since here introduces the basis for what the king had said. It introduces his reason for concluding that God was the greatest God, the Lord of kings, and the one who reveals mysteries. Indicate this connection in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 2:47a–d below. Other ways to translate this clause include:

because he gave you the power to explain this mystery (CEV)

I know this because you have been able to explain this mystery (GNT)

this mystery: The phrase this mystery here refers to the king’s dream and its meaning. See the Notes at 2:18a. Here is another way to translate this:

these secret things (NCV)

General Comment on 2:47a–e

In some languages it may be natural to indicate the connection between 2:47a–c and 2:47d in 2:47a rather than at the beginning of 2:47d. For example::

So your God must be the God of gods and the Lord of kings....You were able to reveal this mystery!

That shows/proves that your God is the God above all gods and the Lord over all kings!.... You were able to reveal this mystery!

Daniel 2:48

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king's dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
2. Nebuchadnezzar's Troubling Dream (2:1–13)
3. The Dream Revealed to Daniel (2:14–23)
4. Daniel Interprets the Dream (2:24–45)
5. Nebuchadnezzar Promotes Daniel (2:46–49)
6. The GNT has three sections:
 - (a) Nebuchadnezzar's dream (2:1–13)
 - (b) God shows Daniel what the dream means (2:14–23)
 - (c) Daniel tells the king the dream and explains it (2:24–49)

This section tells how Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream. He asked his advisers to tell him what he had dreamed and its meaning. They were unable to do so, and the king threatened them with death. But God revealed the meaning of the dream to Daniel. Daniel then told the king what he had dreamed and what it meant. The king honored Daniel and Daniel's God.

The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author of the book of Daniel liked to use lists (2:2, 10). However, the author did not intend for these lists to be complete or exact. The lists usually provide examples of the types of people or things that belong in a certain group or category. The Notes will suggest options on how to translate these lists.
2. Synonyms: The text often uses different terms for similar ideas. For example, there are several verbs that mean "to reveal" or "to make known." There are three different Aramaic verbs in 2:40 that mean

"crush, break to pieces." In some languages it may be difficult or confusing to use several different words for similar ideas. The Notes will suggest how you might translate these similar words and terms.

3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20–23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20–23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
4. Ambiguity: In the section where Daniel interpreted the last part of the king's dream, there are a number of ambiguous references. For example, in 2:44a Daniel referred to "those kings" without identifying who those kings were. In 2:44b Daniel spoke of "all these kingdoms." The ambiguity may be deliberate, since the dream itself is a mystery. It will be important not to over-interpret these passages by assuming a particular historical context. The Notes will suggest several options for how to translate these verses.
5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36–45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:48a–2:49b

In this paragraph the king rewarded Daniel for interpreting his dream.

2:48a

Then the king promoted Daniel and gave him many generous gifts.

- ¶ The king then made Daniel an important man and gave him many valuable gifts.
- ¶ Then the king honored Daniel by giving him a high rank and expensive things/gifts.
- ¶ So the king promoted Daniel to an important position in the kingdom. He showered him with presents.

Then the king promoted Daniel: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates the king promoted Daniel is more literally “then the king made Daniel great.” This is a general statement that here indicates that the king increased Daniel’s importance and honor. He made him an important and respected man. Other ways to translate this include:

and the king conferred high rank on Daniel (NJB)

Then the king placed Daniel in a high position (NIV)

Then the king gave Daniel high honors (ESV)

If you have a general expression that says that that the king honored Daniel, you can use it here.

and gave him many generous gifts: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as gave him many generous gifts is more literally “gave him many great gifts,” as in the NRSV. The gifts were many. That is, they were numerous, and “great,” or of high quality. They were expensive. Other ways to translate this are:

and gave him many valuable gifts (NLT)

and gave him presents, both many and valuable

2:48b

He made him ruler over the entire province of Babylon

- He made Daniel ruler of the whole province of Babylon.
- He appointed Daniel to be the ruler of the province of Babylon.

He made him ruler over the entire province of Babylon: King Nebuchadnezzar rewarded Daniel by putting him at the head of the government of Babylon. Other ways to translate this include:

He granted him authority over the entire province of Babylon (NET)

Nebuchadnezzar made Daniel governor of the whole province of Babylon (GW)

put him in charge of the province of Babylon (GNT)

made him ruler: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as made him ruler is a verb that means “caused to rule.” Use an expression that refers to appointing someone to govern a region. For example:

promoted him to governor (CEV)

made him head/chief

the entire province of Babylon: The word Babylon can refer to either the Babylonian empire or the capital city. The meaning here is probably that the king gave Daniel authority over the entire area surrounding the city of Babylon.

2:48c

and chief administrator over all the wise men of Babylon.

- He even made him chief of all his counselors in Babylon.
- He also put him in charge of the royal advisers/experts in Babylon.

and chief administrator over all the wise men of Babylon: The king gave Daniel a position of authority over the other wise men of Babylon. Other ways to translate this include:

and put him in charge of all Babylon’s wise men (REB)

over all the wise men of Babylon: This clause probably refers to the king’s advisers who lived in the province of Babylon, not all the advisers in the empire.

wise men: See the Notes at 2:12. Here is another way to translate this:

royal advisers (GNT)

Daniel 2:49

Section 2:1–49: Daniel explained the king’s dream

These Notes interpret Daniel 2:1–49 as a complete narrative unit. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one section and to give each section a separate heading. For example:

1. The BSB has four sections.
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The climax of this narrative occurs in 2:47. There the king declared that the God whom Daniel worshiped was the greatest of all gods.

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3. Poetry: You will need to think carefully about how you will translate the poetic section in this chapter (2:20-23). Authors of Hebrew poetry usually wrote using matching pairs of lines. The relationship between these parallel lines differs. Sometimes the second line repeats the information in the first line using different words. Sometimes the second line contrasts with the first line. Hebrew poetry also has word plays, figurative speech, and alliteration. It may not always be easy to translate these literary features into your language. The Notes will suggest ways of translating the different features of Hebrew poetry. For more information about how to translate Hebrew poetry, see the Bible Translation Handbook of the Psalms. The poetry in 2:20-23 is a song of praise or thanksgiving. If your language has a special poetic form that fits this song, you can use it here.
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5. Repetition: Daniel interpreted the meaning of the first three kingdoms in a very brief way. He used many more words to describe the fourth kingdom (2:36-45). In this section he also repeated much of what was described before. In this way, Daniel emphasized the fourth kingdom as the most important. Some of the repetition in this section emphasizes specific ideas. Sometimes the repetition has another function. You will need to evaluate if this kind of repetition is natural in your language. If not, you will need to find another way to emphasize these ideas.

Paragraph 2:48a-2:49b

In this paragraph the king rewarded Daniel for interpreting his dream.

2:49a

And at Daniel's request, the king appointed Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to manage the province of Babylon,

- And when Daniel asked him, the king put Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego in charge of the administration/government of the province of Babylon.
- Daniel then asked the king to appoint Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to administer the affairs of the province of Babylon. And the king agreed.
- Daniel requested that the king appoint Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to govern Babylon province. The king did this/so.

And: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces something else that the king did to reward Daniel. Other ways to translate it include:

Moreover (NIV)

Furthermore

Besides this

at Daniel's request: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as at Daniel's request is more literally "Daniel asked from the king." You may be able to say:

Daniel asked the king

Daniel requested

Daniel made a request of the king (NRSV)

the king appointed Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to manage the province of Babylon: Nebuchadnezzar also gave Daniel's three friends positions of authority within Babylon province. This probably indicates that they were put in charge of civil and economic affairs, working under Daniel himself. Other ways to translate this include:

the king put Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego in charge of the affairs of the province of Babylon (GNT)

the king entrusted the affairs of the province of Babylon to Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-Nego (NJB)

the king appointed Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to be in charge of all the affairs of the province of Babylon (NLT)

to manage the province of Babylon: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as to manage is more literally "over the administration," Use an expression referring to those who supervise or manage a province or region. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb. For example:

to administer the province of Babylon (REB)

to govern the province of Babylon (GW)

the province of Babylon: The province included the city of Babylon. See the note on 2:48c.

General Comment on 2:49a

In some languages it may be more natural to indicate the content of Daniel's request at the beginning of 2:49a. For example:

Daniel asked the king to make Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego administrators of the province of Babylon. The king did as/what Daniel asked.

2:49b

while Daniel remained in the king's court.

- But Daniel himself served the king at the royal court.
- But Daniel continued to work in the imperial court itself near the king.

while Daniel remained in the king's court: The Aramaic more literally says, "but Daniel in the gate of the king." The verb is implied in the Aramaic. In contrast to his three friends, Daniel stayed in the city of Babylon, where he served the king at the palace gate. You can also say:

but Daniel remained as an official at the royal court

But Daniel stayed as a palace official in the king's court

the king's court: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the king's court is more literally "the gate/door of the king." This phrase implies that Daniel remained close to the king. He was ready to advise him at all times, while his friends went out to administer the province. Check that your translation implies that Daniel held an especially honored position near the king. Here is another way to translate this:

in the king's court (NLT)

Daniel 3:1

Section 3:1-30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

This is the only chapter in the book of Daniel where the author does not refer to Daniel himself. Scholars have debated why this might be. Possibly he was traveling somewhere else in the empire on the king's business at this time.

The author wrote Daniel 3 in the Aramaic language. These Notes usually follow the Aramaic found in the Masoretic Text (MT). The early Greek translation of

Daniel 3 is somewhat different from the Aramaic. The Greek translation includes two stories that are not in the MT. The first is called “The Prayer of Azariah” (3:24–45). The second is called “The Song of the Three Young Men” (3:50–90). These two stories are connected by a short paragraph (3:46–50). Most English versions do not include these two stories. The NJB, however, does include them. As a result the verse numbers in the NJB are different from those of most other English versions.

In some other places the Greek text of Daniel 3 differs from the Aramaic of the Masoretic Text. For example, the Greek text includes a date in 3:1 that is not in the MT. Scholars have different views on why the two texts differ. It is possible that the Greek versions may have translated from a different Aramaic original. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

Outline: This chapter can be divided into four parts:

1. Setting: Nebuchadnezzar commanded all his officials of Babylon to come and worship the golden image that he had set up. (3:1–7)
2. Problem: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refused to bow down and worship the image. The king threatened to kill them, but they still refused. (3:8–18)
3. Action: The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three young men into the furnace. (3:19–23)
4. Result/Outcome: God delivered the three young men from the furnace, and Nebuchadnezzar gave honor to God. (3:24–30)

The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

Headings:

The Notes interpret Daniel 3:1–30 as a one unit with one heading. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one unit and to give each unit a separate heading. The following are some examples of how English versions divide the chapter into units and the headings they give for each unit:

1. Some versions have one heading. For example:
2. “The Image of Gold and the Fiery Furnace” (NIV)
3. “The Fiery Furnace” (REB)

4. “Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego Refuse to Worship an Idol” (GW)
2. Some have two headings:
3. “The Golden Image” (NRSV, 3:1–18)
 - “Nebuchadnezzar’s Gold Statue” (NLT, 3:1–18)
1. “The Fiery Furnace” (NRSV, 3:19–30)
 - “The Blazing Furnace” (NLT, 3:19–30)
3. The GNT has four headings:
4. “Nebuchadnezzar Commands Everyone to Worship a Gold Statue” (3:1–7)
5. “Daniel’s Three Friends Are Accused of Disobedience” (3:8–18)
6. “Daniel’s Three Friends Are Sentenced to Death” (3:19–25)
7. “The Three Men Are Released and Promoted” (3:26–30)

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author liked to use lists. He repeated these lists throughout the chapter. For example:
2. the list of the names of officials (3:2, 3, 27)
3. the list of musical instruments (3:5, 7, 10, 15)
4. the phrase: “peoples, nations, and languages” (3:4, 29)
5. Repetition: The author also liked to repeat phrases throughout the narrative. Some of these phrases are:
6. “the image that King Nebuchadnezzar set up” (3:1, 2, 3, 5, 7, 12, 14, 18)
7. “hear the sound of the horn” (3:5, 7, 10, 15)
8. “fall down and worship” (3:5, 6, 7, 10, 11, 15)
9. “burning fiery furnace” (3:6, 11, 15, 17, 20, 21, 23, 26)
10. “Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego” (3:12, 13, 14, 16, 19, 20, 22, 26, 28, 29, 30)

Each language uses repetition in its own way. These notes will discuss the significance of the repetitions in Daniel. In some languages, the repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you will have to consider how best to communicate the same meaning.

Paragraph 3:1a–3:3b

Several years may have passed since the events in chapter two. In some languages it may be necessary

to introduce the story with a general remark of when the story began. For example:

After some time...

Later...

3:1a

King Nebuchadnezzar made a golden statue

- ¶ One day King Nebuchadnezzar had a statue made from gold,
- ¶ Some time later King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his servants to build a golden column.

King Nebuchadnezzar made a golden statue: The king did not make the image himself. He commanded his workers to do it. If this is not clear, you may have to add implied information. Ways to translate this idea in English include:

King Nebuchadnezzar had a gold statue made (GNT) -

King Nebuchadnezzar ordered his servants to build a gold statue.

King Nebuchadnezzar caused a golden statue to be made/built.

King Nebuchadnezzar: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as King Nebuchadnezzar is literally “Nebuchadnezzar the king.” Use the word order that is most natural in your language.

a golden statue: The phrase a golden statue indicates that the statue was made from gold. It was probably not solid gold. The workers more likely made it of stone or wood and covered it with a layer of gold.

statue: The dimensions of the object resemble a column or pillar. It is uncertain, however, what the statue or column represented. There are at least two possibilities:

1. The image represented the king. Assyrian kings set up statues of themselves as symbols of their power. Following this interpretation, the image in Daniel 3 relates back to the image in King Nebuchadnezzar’s dream in chapter 2.
2. The image represented the king’s god. Lucas, p. 88. This view is supported by 3:12, 14, 18 (“who... have refused to serve your gods or worship the golden statue you have set up.”). Herodotus (1:183)

describes a statue of Bel in Babylon made of 800 talents of gold (22 tons). It was 12 cubits high. The king may have wanted to unify his country under one religion. He commanded everyone to bow down and worship his god.

Both (1) and (2) may be true. People may have considered the king and a particular god to be closely associated with each other. It is probably best not to be too specific.

The word that the BSB translates as statue is the same word that described the statue in Nebuchadnezzar’s dream in Daniel 2. However, the shape of the object implies that it did not have the same form. This was not a statue according to the usual English meaning of the word—the representation of a human figure. The dimensions of the object describe a tall pillar or column. It may have been a tall, four-sided pillar tapering toward the top, shaped like a pyramid. This is sometimes called an obelisk. Another possibility is that it was a stele, a standing stone containing an inscription or design in bas-relief. It may have been a column with a sculpture of a person on the top. Since we do not know for sure, use an expression that refers in a general way to this type of object.

3:1b

sixty cubits high and six cubits wide,

- a statue ninety feet high and nine feet wide.
- It was thirty meters high and three meters wide.

sixty cubits high and six cubits wide: These are the dimensions of the image, its size. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

It was ninety feet high and nine feet wide.

sixty cubits high: A cubit was an ancient unit of measurement. It was based on the length of a man’s forearm from his finger tips to his elbow, about 500 millimeters. Sixty cubits is about thirty meters. It is good to use modern units of measurement. For example:

thirty meters high

ninety feet high (GNT)

You should use a measure that people in your language normally use to measure a tall object like this.

and six cubits wide: This phrase refers to the distance from one side of the image to the other. You can translate this as:

three meters wide

nine feet wide (GNT)

Again, you should use the measure that people in your culture normally use to measure the width of an object like this.

3:1c

and he set it up on the plain of Dura in the province of Babylon.

- The king had this statue placed/erected in the plain called Dura, which was in the province of Babylon.
- They built the column in the valley called Dura. This was in the same province as the city of Babylon.

and he set it up: The phrase set it up here indicates that the king ordered his workers to place the image in an upright position. Other ways to say this are:

He caused it to be set up

and he ordered his workers to raise/stand it up

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

he had it set up (GNT)

on the plain of Dura: The word plain refers to a broad expanse of flat land. In some languages this term contrasts with hilly or mountainous regions.

Dura: The name of the plain was Dura. People probably named the plain after a nearby city or a place called Dura. Some ways to translate this are:

Dura Valley (CEV)

the plain called Dura

in the province of Babylon: The king had divided the empire into provinces. Each province had a governor, who administered the province for the king. In this context, the province included the capital city of Babylon. Other ways to translate this are:

the province that included the city of Babylon

Babylon province

Your country may have a different word for this unit of government. Some nations have “states.” Others have “regions.” Use a word in your language that most naturally corresponds to a province. In some languages it may be necessary to say something like:

near the city of Babylon (CEV)

near the area of Babylon

Daniel 3:2

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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3. Action: The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three young men into the furnace. (3:19–23)
4. Result/Outcome: God delivered the three young men from the furnace, and Nebuchadnezzar gave honor to God. (3:24–30)

The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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Each language uses repetition in its own way. These notes will discuss the significance of the repetitions in Daniel. In some languages, the repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you will have to consider how best to communicate the same meaning.

Paragraph 3:1a–3:3b

Several years may have passed since the events in chapter two. In some languages it may be necessary to introduce the story with a general remark of when the story began. For example:

After some time...

Later...

3:2a

Then King Nebuchadnezzar sent word to assemble the satraps, prefects, governors, advisers, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and all the other officials of the provinces

- Then he sent messages to the provincial rulers/governors, magistrates, and assistant governors/rulers, and to the advisers/counselors, treasurers, judges, officers, and all the other leading men in/of the provinces, commanding/telling them
- The king then summoned the provincial leaders/rulers, the governors, magistrates, and assistant governors. He also summoned all the other provincial officials. He said to them,
- Then the king sent messengers to the officials in each of the provinces. This included the governors, magistrates, and assistant governors, as well as the advisers, treasurers, judges, and law officers, and all the other rulers of the province.

Then King Nebuchadnezzar sent word to assemble the satraps, prefects, governors, advisers, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and all the other officials of the provinces: Nebuchadnezzar sent messages to all his officials, telling them to gather together.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next event in the story.

King Nebuchadnezzar: See the Notes at 3:1a. Once again the literal word order is “Nebuchadnezzar the king” (KJV). Use the word order that is most natural in your language.

sent word to assemble: The king sent a message to his officials. He told them to assemble together near the statue. Other ways to say this in English are:

sent for (NRSV)

called for (NCV)

sent messengers to assemble (GW)

he sent messages to (NLT)

gave orders for all his officials to come together (GNT)

the satraps, prefects, governors: The Aramaic text includes a connector between the words prefects and governors. Here is another way to translate this:

the satraps, the prefects, and the governors (RSV)

The presence of this connector groups the first three officials together. These three officials may have had a higher rank than the four officials that follow.

satraps: Satraps were in charge of the provinces of the Persian empire. This official was probably the most important one on the list. You may:

- translate the function of the “satrap”:

the provincial governor

- use a general term for an important official:

princes (GNT)

leaders (NCV)

- transliterate the Greek term “satrap” (NRSV). However, most people will not be familiar with this term, and you would probably want to include a footnote explaining the function of a satrap.

prefects: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as prefects refers to another high official. The exact role of a “prefect” is not known for certain. Ways to interpret this include:

magistrates (NJB)

advisers (CEV)

governors: Again, the exact function of these officials is uncertain. They were possibly men who administered subdivisions of the provinces. For example:

lieutenant governors (GNT)

assistant governors (NCV)

advisers, treasurers, judges, magistrates: The Aramaic text groups these four titles together. Connect them in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

as well as the counselors, treasurers, judges and magistrates

These four officials were probably of lower in rank than the first three officials in the list.

advisers: The exact meaning of this title is uncertain. It is probable that it refers to officials who counseled or advised the higher officials. For example:

counselors (RSV)

elders

commissioners (GNT)

treasurers: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as treasurers probably refers to officials who were responsible for keeping the king’s money safe and advising him about its use.

judges: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as judges probably refers to men who heard cases and made decisions in a court of law. Here is another way to translate this:

justices (NRSV)

magistrates: The exact role of these officials is uncertain. It is good to translate using a general term for officials with the power to enforce the law. For example:

officers (GW)

and all the other officials of the provinces: The list was not complete. This last expression refers in general to all other governmental officials in the provinces of Babylonia. For example, you can say:

and all the rulers of the provinces (KJV)

and all the rest of the officers of the province

General Comment on 3:2a

The list of names includes seven types of officials. The exact work that each of these men did is uncertain and the names come from different languages. The names of these officials are transliterations of Akkadian and Old Persian terms. Goldingay (p. 65) notes that as such they do not all belong to a single ranking system. In some languages it may help to indicate the general category before the list. For example:

Then the king gave orders for all his officials to come together—the princes, governors, lieutenant governors, commissioners, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and all the other officials of the provinces. (GNT)

Then he called for the leaders: the governors, assistant governors, captains of the soldiers, people who advised the king, keepers of the treasury, judges, rulers, and all other officers in his kingdom. (NCV)

The author did not intend the list to be a complete or exact list of all the different people who attended the ceremony. Your language may not have as many different names for officials. In that case, you may give a shortened but more general list of names. For example:

and he commanded his governors, advisors, treasurers, judges, and his other officials to come from everywhere in his kingdom (CEV)

3:2b

to attend the dedication of the statue he had set up.

- to come to dedicate the statue he had set up.
- “You^(plur) must attend a ceremony to celebrate the start of the worship of the image I have erected.”
- The king ordered them to come to a special ceremony where they would begin to worship the golden column.

to attend the dedication of the statue he had set

up: The king told his officials to come to a ceremony to begin the worship of the image. This ceremony would honor the image and celebrate the beginning of its worship. Other ways to say this in English are:

to attend the dedication of the statue which King Nebuchadnezzar had set up. (GNT)

to attend the dedication of the statue that he had erected (NET)

to dedicate the statue he had set up (GW)

the dedication of the statue: The phrase the dedication of the statue refers to a ceremony that honored the image. At this ceremony people were to start worshiping the image. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

the celebration to begin the worship of the image

he had set up: See the Notes at 3:1c. The Aramaic text repeats the phrase set up several times. This repetition emphasizes the authority of the king. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat this information. If that is true in your language, you may not have to repeat it here, since it is implied from 3:1c. For example:

to the dedication of the statue (CEV)

However, you should translate in a way that emphasizes the king's power and authority.

General Comment on 3:2a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's command as direct speech. For example:

Then the king sent a command to all the satraps, prefects, and governors, as well as all the advisors, treasurers, judges, magistrates and the rest

of the provincial officials. He said, “Come to the dedication of the image that I have set up.”

Daniel 3:3

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language

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Paragraph 3:1a–3:3b

Several years may have passed since the events in chapter two. In some languages it may be necessary to introduce the story with a general remark of when the story began. For example:

After some time...

Later...

3:3a

So the satraps, prefects, governors, advisers, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and all the rulers of the provinces assembled

- So the provincial governors, magistrates and the assistant governors came to the plain called Dura. The advisers, treasurers, judges, and officers and all the other leaders/rulers of the province also came
- So they all came for the special ceremony in the valley called Dura

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces what happened in response to the king’s order. Introduce this next action in a way that is natural in your language.

the satraps, prefects, governors, advisers, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and all the rulers of the provinces assembled: All the officials gathered together, as the king had commanded them. See the notes on 3:2a for ways to translate the titles of the various officials.

The repetition of the titles here emphasizes the importance of the ceremony. The dedication of the image was to be formal and solemn. If this use of repetition is not natural in your language, you may be able to use a shorter form here. For example:

When all these officials had arrived (NLT)

So all of them came (CEV)

If you do not repeat all the information, you should still try to emphasize the formality and importance of the ceremony.

3:3b

for the dedication of the statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up,

- to dedicate the statue that the king had set up.
- in order to celebrate the worship of the golden column.

for the dedication of the statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up: This verse part indicates the purpose of the gathering. See the Notes at 3:2b. In some languages it may again be natural to translate the noun phrase the dedication as a verb. For example:

to dedicate the statue he had set up (GW)

The repetition of so much information from 3:2b may be heavy and unnatural in some languages. It may be more natural to leave some of the information implied. For example:

for the dedication (GNT)

3:3c

and they stood before it.

- All the officials stood and faced the statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.
- They all gathered around the golden column.

and they stood before it: The BSB is using the pronoun it in place of a phrase in the Aramaic text that is literally “the statue that Nebuchadnezzar had set up.” Some English versions translate this full phrase. For example:

and stood in front of the statue which King Nebuchadnezzar had set up (NJB)

This repetition emphasizes the power and authority of the king. However, in some languages such repetition may be heavy, confusing, or unnatural. If this is true in your language, you may leave this clause implied, as the BSB and several other English versions have done. For example:

They stood in front of the statue (GW)

and stood in front of it (CEV)

General Comment on 3:3

In some languages it may be natural to translate 3:3c as the introduction to the action of 3:4. For example:

^{3a}So the satraps, the prefects, and the governors, the counselors, the treasurers, the justices, the magistrates, and all the officials of the provinces, assembled ^{3b}for the dedication of the statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up. ^{3c}When they were standing before the statue that Nebuchadnezzar had set up,... (NRSV)

If you choose to translate in this way, 3:4 will not begin a new paragraph.

Daniel 3:4

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:4–6

The king’s herald announced that everyone present must bow down before the image of gold. Those who refused to do so would be punished by death in a furnace.

3:4a

Then the herald loudly proclaimed,

- ¶ Then a spokesman for the king announced in a loud voice,
- ¶ Then the king’s spokesman made/shouted this announcement/proclamation:

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next important action in the narrative. It introduces the danger that threatened God’s people.

the herald loudly proclaimed: A herald was a man who announced messages for the king. He stood before a crowd of people and announced these messages with a loud voice. This was his responsibility. It is important that your readers understand that the herald was giving a royal message, not speaking his own ideas. In some languages it may help to make this clear by following the NCV and saying:

the man who made announcements for the king
said in a loud voice (NCV)

the herald: There were probably several heralds in the king’s service. This particular herald has not been mentioned before, so in some languages it may be natural to say:

a herald (GNT)

loudly proclaimed: The phrase loudly proclaimed describes the normal way in which a herald would deliver the king’s messages to the people. Other ways English versions translate this expression are:

called out loudly (GW)

shouted out (NLT)

announced in a loud voice (GNT)

made a loud proclamation (NET)

3:4b

“O people of every nation and language, this is what you are commanded:

- “The king commands you^(plur) who belong to every race, and to every nation, and who speak every language,
- “People of every province, nation, and language! Listen to what the king has commanded:
- “To all you^(plur) people who have come from many nations and speak many languages, the king has given this command:

O people of every nation and language: The herald addressed himself to the representatives of the whole empire. His words are more literally “Nations, peoples, and languages.” This is figurative language. It indicates that the herald addressed many different groups of people, people who were from different nations and who spoke many different languages. You should translate in a way that is natural in your language for a person who speaks to a large audience. For example, you may be able to say:

People of every province, nation and language!
(GW)

People of all nations, races, and languages! (GNT)

You, people from all tribes and nations and language-groups, give me your attention.

this is what you are commanded: This clause introduces the king's command. The Aramaic uses the form "they are commanding you" and the BSB translates it as a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active clause, you may say:

The king commands you...

listen to the king's command! (NLT)

General Comment on 3:4

In some languages it may be more natural to change the word order in the clause and follow the Aramaic order. For example:

You are commanded, O peoples, nations, and languages,... (NRSV)

Daniel 3:5

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16-18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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Each language uses repetition in its own way. These notes will discuss the significance of the repetitions in Daniel. In some languages, the repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you will have to consider how best to communicate the same meaning.

Paragraph 3:4–6

The king’s herald announced that everyone present must bow down before the image of gold. Those who refused to do so would be punished by death in a furnace.

3:5a**As soon as you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music,**

- on hearing the sound/music of the horn, the flute, the lyre, the small harp, the large harp, the drum and all the other musical instruments,
- When you hear the horns, the flutes, the lyres, the harps, and the other musical instruments all playing together,

As soon as you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music:

The herald listed six different types of musical instruments. This list emphasizes how grand and important the ceremony was.

Many languages do not have names for all of these kinds of instruments. For help in translating some of these instruments see Ivor H. Jones, “Musical Instruments in the Bible,” *The Bible Translator* (January

1986) 101–116; (January 1987): 129–143. The author gives pictures of some of these instruments. The *Translator’s Handbook on Daniel* also has pictures of instruments. If that is true in your language, you may need to borrow names from the national language or translate a shorter list of names. For example:

Trumpets, flutes, harps, and all other kinds of musical instruments... (CEV)

all kinds of wind instruments and stringed instruments

trumpets and harps, large and small

As soon as you hear the sound: The phrase *As soon as you hear the sound* refers to the moment when the instruments would start playing. Other ways to translate this clause are:

when you hear the sound (RSV)

the moment you hear the sound of (NJB)

when the music begins

horn: This is a general word for any kind of horn. In this passage the word probably refers to a metal or clay trumpet. A person would hold the trumpet to their mouth and blow into it to make a sound. Here is another way to translate this:

trumpets (GNT)

flute: This was also some type of a wind instrument. It is uncertain what it looked like. Other possible ways to translate it include:

pipe (NJB)

oboes (GNT)

zither: A zither is a stringed instrument with thirty or forty strings stretched across a flat soundboard. People played it with a small thin piece of metal. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as zither probably refers to this or a similar stringed instrument. For example:

lyre (RSV/NRSV)

harp (KJV)

lyre: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as lyre also refers to a stringed instrument, probably a kind of small triangular harp. You may be able to translate this as:

small harp

harp: Scholars differ in the way they interpret what kind of harp this was. It was probably a large angular harp. People held it horizontally and played it by beating on the strings with sticks. You can translate this as:

large harp

pipes: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as pipes probably refers to another type of musical instrument. However, scholars are not sure whether it was a type of drum, pipe, or stringed instrument. English versions make various choices. For example:

drum (NRSV)

It is recommended that you use a word referring to a musical instrument well known in your culture. Or you may leave it untranslated, as it is included in the following phrase “all kinds of music.”

and all kinds of music: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as all kinds of music here probably refers to all different types of musical instruments. This was probably a summary phrase that referred to all kinds of instruments. It referred even to those instruments that the herald had not specifically mentioned (3:2b). You could translate this:

at the same time with all other kinds of instruments (GW)

and other instruments (NLT)

and then all the other instruments will join in (GNT)

General Comment on 3:5a

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse: For example:

Trumpets, flutes.... will soon start playing. When you hear the music...

3:5b

you must fall down and worship the golden statue that King Nebuchadnezzar has set up.

- you^(plur) must bow down to the ground and worship the golden statue that King Nebuchadnezzar has set up.
- you^(plur) must bow with your face to the ground and worship the golden column.

you must fall down and worship: In this context, the verb fall down means to bow down quickly to the ground. People in the ancient Near East usually bowed down with their face to the ground when they worshiped a god. Nebuchadnezzar was commanding his officials to honor the image as a god. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this by saying:

you must bow down and worship (NCV)

bow to the ground to worship (NLT)

Use the form of command that is most natural for a king to use to his subjects.

and worship: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as worship here means to give great honor and respect, as to a god. The king wanted the officials to worship the statue. However, the text does not say that

the golden statue: See the Notes at 3:1a. Use the same phrase here that you used there.

that King Nebuchadnezzar has set up: The repetition of this phrase emphasizes the authority of the king (see 3:1c, 2b, 3b). If this repetition is unnatural in your language, you may not have to repeat this information here. However, you should still try to keep the same emphasis on the king's authority.

Daniel 3:6

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author wrote Daniel 3 in the Aramaic language. These Notes usually follow the Aramaic found in the Masoretic Text (MT). The early Greek translation of

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Paragraph 3:4–6

The king’s herald announced that everyone present must bow down before the image of gold. Those who

refused to do so would be punished by death in a furnace.

3:6

And whoever does not fall down and worship will immediately be thrown into the blazing fiery furnace.”

- If someone does not bow and worship the golden statue, the king will command his men to throw that person into the blazing fire inside the furnace.”
- If you do not obey, the soldiers will push/drop you into the furnace where the fire is burning/blazing.”

And whoever does not fall down and worship: There is no object to the verb worship here, but 3:5b identifies the statue as the object of worship. There are different ways to translate this:

- you may supply the object. For example:

and anyone who does not bow down and worship the statue

- you may use a different expression to avoid repeating the same information. For example:

Anyone who refuses to obey (NLT)

And whoever does not: There are different ways to translate this general subject. For example, you may:

- Use the third person

If anyone does not...

If someone does not

- Use the second person

If you do not bow down...

Use the form that is most natural in your language to express this meaning.

fall down and worship: See the Notes at 3:5b. Here is another way to translate this:

bow to the ground to worship (NLT)

will immediately be thrown into the blazing fiery furnace: The punishment for refusing to worship the image was death by fire. This is a passive clause. The king's men would push or drop the disobedient person through an opening down into the furnace. The person

being punished would fall into the fire and die. If it is more natural in your language to use an active clause, you may translate this:

- Using an indefinite subject

they will throw him into a furnace that burns hotly

they will cause him to fall into a fiery furnace

- supplying the subject, the king's soldiers or the king's men

The king's soldiers will push/drop that person into the furnace

The king will command his servants to throw that person into the furnace

blazing fiery: The author literally describes the furnace as a blazing fiery furnace, as in the BSB. The author probably used these two adjectives in order to emphasize the intensity of the fire. You may use one or two expressions, whichever is most natural in your language. For example:

a furnace where the fire burns intensely

a furnace of blazing fire (NRSV)

a red-hot blazing furnace^{cf} Goldingay

a flaming furnace (CEV)

furnace: Scholars differ in the way they describe the shape and function of this furnace. It was probably a large oven, like those where Babylonians would bake bricks. It probably had a door at the top (3:21–23) and another opening in the side (3:25). Archeologists have discovered large brick kilns like this outside the city of Babylon.

Daniel 3:7

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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3:7a

Therefore, as soon as all the people heard the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, and all kinds of music,

- ¶ So, as soon as everyone heard the sound of the horn, the flute, the lyre, the small harp, the large harp, and all the other musical instruments,
- ¶ And at the moment when the officials heard all the different musical instruments start to play ,

Therefore: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates *Therefore* here introduces a result clause. The officials obeyed the king's command. Here is another way to translate this:

And so (NJB)

as soon as all the people heard: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates *as soon as all the people heard* is more literally “as soon as all the peoples heard.” You can also translate this as:

when they heard

At the moment when everyone heard

the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, and all kinds of music: See the Notes at 3:5a for ways to translate these musical instruments. Translate them here the same way you did there.

There is a textual problem in this verse. A few Aramaic manuscripts include a sixth type of musical instrument. There are two options:

1. Follow the Masoretic Text and do not translate the sixth instrument. For example:

the sounds of the horns, flutes, lyres, zithers, pipes, and all the other musical instruments (NCV) (BSB, KJV, GW, REB, NCV, NIV)

1. Include the sixth instrument. For example:

the sound of horn, pipe, lyre, zither, harp, bagpipe and all the other instruments (NJB) (RSV/NRSV, NASB, ESV, NLT, NJB, NJPS, NET)

It is recommended that you follow the Masoretic Text and option (1).

In this verse the author repeated most of the instruments in the previous lists. This slows and increases

the tension in the narrative. In some languages this type of repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you may not have to translate all the instruments. For example:

And so, as soon as they heard the sound of the instruments (GNT)

As soon as the people heard the music (CEV)

Hearing the sound of the whole great orchestra playing

However, if you do not translate all the instruments in the list, you should try to communicate the tension in the narrative in another way.

and all kinds of music: See the Notes on this phrase at 3:5a.

3:7b

the people of every nation and language would fall down and worship the golden statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.

- all the people from every nation and people and language bowed down and worshiped the golden statue which King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.
- they all bowed to the ground—men from every nation and people, men who spoke every language—and they worshiped the golden column the king had set up.

the people of every nation and language: See the Notes at 3:4. Translate in a similar way here as you did there. The author repeated this phrase to emphasize the formality and seriousness of the ceremony. If it is not natural in your language to repeat this information here, you may be able to use the third person plural pronoun. For example:

they (CEV)

However, if you do this, you should try to keep the same tone of formality.

would fall down and worship the golden statue: See the Notes at 3:5b. In your translation it should be clear that the officials chose to bow down to the ground to honor the image. Your readers should not think that they accidentally fell over. You may translate this as:

bowed down and worshiped the gold statue (GW)

bowed to the ground and worshiped the gold statue (NLT)

that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up: This clause is repeated several times in this passage (see also in 3:1c, 3:2b, 3:3b, 3:5b). This repetition emphasizes the authority of the king. In some languages it may be natural to shorten the reference to Nebuchadnezzar. For example:

that the king had set up (CEV)

General Comment on 3:7a–b

In the Aramaic text, the subject of the clause in 3:7a is “all the people.” The subject in 3:7b is “the people of every nation and language.” These two phrases both refer to the officials who were gathered in front of the statue. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear by saying:

^{7a}And all the people gathered there from every nation and language heard the sound of the different musical instruments playing ^{7b}and bowed down and worshiped the golden statue that the king had set up.

^{7b}And all the people from every nation and language bowed to the ground to worship the king’s golden statue ^{7a}as soon as they heard the music—the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, and harp and other instruments all playing together

Daniel 3:8

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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3:8

At this time some astrologers came forward and maliciously accused the Jews,

- ¶ At that point some of the experts in magic came and made accusations against the Jews.
- ¶ It was then that some of the occult experts/practitioners went to the king and spoke evil of the three Jews.

The Aramaic text connects this verse to 3:7 with a phrase that is literally “all because of this.” Here it introduces what some enemies of the Jewish young

men did. Some ancient versions do not translate this connecting phrase. Introduce the action in 3:8 in a way that is natural in your language.

At this time: This is the same time phrase that the BSB translates as “Therefore” in 3:7a. Other ways to translate it here include:

It was then that (GNT)

At that point

After that happened (GW)

When that took place

some astrologers came forward: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as astrologers is more literally “Chaldeans.” Here it probably refers specifically to men who were experts in the occult and magical arts, as in 2:2a. See how you translated it there.

came forward: The astrologers came out from the crowd and asked to talk to the king or his close advisers. Here is another way to translate this:

went to the king (NLT)

and maliciously accused the Jews: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as maliciously accused is an idiom. Literally, “they ate their pieces.” that means “accused.” Some ways English versions translate this are:

denounced (NIV)

brought charges against (GW)

began speaking against (NCV)

If you may have an idiom in your language that has this meaning, you may be able to use it here.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the astrologers accused the Jews to King Nebuchadnezzar. For example:

Some Babylonians used this as a chance to accuse the Jews to King Nebuchadnezzar. (CEV)

But some of the astrologers went to the king and informed on the Jews. (NLT)

the Jews: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the Jews here refers to three specific Jews, Daniel's three friends. See how you referred to them in 1:6. Express the name of their people group in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel 3:9

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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3. Action: The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three young men into the furnace. (3:19–23)

4. Result/Outcome: God delivered the three young men from the furnace, and Nebuchadnezzar gave honor to God. (3:24–30)

The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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3:9

saying to King Nebuchadnezzar, “O king, may you live forever!”

- They said to Nebuchadnezzar, “May you, our^(excl) king, live forever.
- They said, “King Nebuchadnezzar, we^(excl) desire that you^(sing) will have a long and healthy life.

saying to King Nebuchadnezzar: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as saying is literally: “They answered and saying.” See the Notes at 2:4a. This idiom here introduces what the Chaldeans said when they denounced the Jews. Introduce what they said in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

They addressed King Nebuchadnezzar (GW)

You should communicate that the Chaldeans were about to announce something important.

O king, may you live forever!: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as O king, may you live forever is more literally “O king, live forever!” This is a figure of speech that means the Chaldeans wished the king a long and healthy life. This was a common and respectful way people greeted a king at that time. There are different ways to say this in English. For example:

May you, our king, live a long and healthy life!

Long live the king! (NLT)

Your Majesty, we hope you live forever! (CEV)

Use a form that expresses this meaning in a way that is natural in your language. Bathsheba spoke a similar phrase when she addressed King David in 1 Kings 1:31.

Daniel 3:10

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language

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3:10a

You, O king, have issued a decree

- You^(sing), King Nebuchadnezzar, gave an order
- You^(sing) have commanded

You, O king, have issued a decree: The astrologers reminded the king of the decree he had told his herald to proclaim (3:4–5).

You, O king: In the Aramaic text, the Chaldeans began their speech with the words You, O king. The BSB has translated this literally. The officials wanted to emphasize that the crime was a personal offense against the king. The three men had disobeyed the king himself. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language and shows respect for Nebuchadnezzar as the king. See the Notes at 2:4a.

have issued a decree: A decree is like a law. In that time, the king’s decrees became the law for all the people in the land. Other ways to translate this are:

you made an order (GW)

You commanded (CEV)

3:10b

that everyone who hears the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music

- that everyone who hears the horn, the flute, the lyre, the small harp, the large harp, the drum, and all the other musical instruments,
- that as soon as the orchestra/music starts playing, everyone

that everyone who hears the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music: This verse part begins a paraphrase of the content of the decree. See how you translate the decree itself in 3:5.

everyone: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as everyone is literally “every man.” In this context,

most of the officials who attended the ceremony were probably men. However, the command did not exclude women, as a literal translation might suggest. It may be good to use a general expression. For example:

all the people (NLT)

who hears the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music: See the Notes at 3:5a and 3:7a for the musical instruments. This is the third time the author lists the names of the instruments. This repetition emphasizes how formal and serious this ceremony was. In some languages this type of repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a summary clause. For example:

as soon as the music starts (GNT)

when the music played (CEV)

However, if you give a summary of the instruments, you should try to emphasize the large number and variety of instruments in another way.

3:10c

must fall down and worship the golden statue,

- should bow down and worship the golden image.
- is to bow down and worship the golden column.

must fall down and worship the golden statue: See the Notes at 3:5b. Translate here as you did there.

Daniel 3:11

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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3:11

and that whoever does not fall down and worship will be thrown into the blazing fiery furnace.

- You^(sing) also said that anyone who does not bow down and worship the golden statue will be thrown into the burning fire in the furnace.
- If anyone refused/disobeyed, you^(sing) said you would order your soldiers to throw that person into the furnace where the fire blazes/burns.
- And anyone who does not do that/so will receive punishment in the great/hot fire.

and that: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the second part of the decree. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence and supply a verb. For example:

That decree also states that (NLT)

You also decreed/commanded that

whoever does not fall down and worship will be thrown into the blazing fiery furnace: See the Notes at 3:6. This expression repeats the decree that was in 3:6. The only difference is that here the clause does not have the word “immediately.”

worship: As in 3:6, in some languages it may be necessary to add the implied object:

worship the statue

will be thrown into the blazing fiery furnace: This is a passive clause. If this is not natural in your language, you may use an active clause. You may:

- Use an indefinite pronoun. For example:

They will throw him into the blazing furnace...
Similarly, the BFCL88: “on le jettera...”

- Supply a subject: the king’s soldiers or the king’s men/servants, who were the ones doing the action. For example:

your soldiers will throw him into the blazing furnace

you will command your servants to throw that person into the blazing furnace

- Make the disobedient person the subject. For example:

that person must enter the furnace that burns with a great fire

that person must die in the blazing furnace

blazing fiery furnace: See the Notes at 3:6.

General Comment on 3:10–11

In some languages it may be natural to refer back to the king’s decree using direct speech. For example:

You, King, have given the command: “Everyone who hears the sound of the musical instruments must bow down and worship the golden image. And if anyone refuses to do so, he must be thrown into the blazing furnace.”

Daniel 3:12

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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3:12a

But there are some Jews you have appointed to manage the province of Babylon—

- But, there are some Jewish men here whom you^(sing) have appointed to govern the province of Babylon.
- There are some men from Judah here, men you^(sing) have appointed to administer the province of Babylon.

But: The BSB has supplied the word But to indicate that this verse introduces a contrast. The three Jewish men disobeyed what the king had commanded.

there are some Jews: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as some Jews is more literally “Jewish men.” The events in this chapter probably occurred several years after the events in Daniel 1. Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego would have been young men by now. See how you translated Jews in 3:8.

you have appointed to manage the province of Babylon: Nebuchadnezzar had given these Jewish men important positions in the government of the province. See the Notes at 2:49a. Other ways to translate this include:

whom you appointed over the administration of the province of Babylon (NET)

whom you have put in charge of the province of Babylon (NLT)

manage the province of Babylon: The phrase manage the province of Babylon refers to the government or administration of Babylon province. Some other ways to translate this idea using a verb are:

[you appointed] to govern the province of Babylon (GW)

[you appointed] to administer the province of Babylon (NJPS)

3:12b

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego—

- Their names are Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.
- And these men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego,

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: See the Notes at 1:7a–b The author repeated these names twelve times in the chapter. In some languages it may be natural here to translate the names using a separate sentence. For example:

Their names are Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego (NCV)

3:12c

who have ignored you, O king,

- Your Majesty, these men have defied you^(sing).
- have deliberately ignored your command, O king.

who have ignored you, O king: In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

These pay no heed to you, O King. (NRSV)

These men, O king, pay no heed to you. (RSV)

who: You can also translate this as:

These men (RSV)

They (NLT, GNT, NIV, NCV)

Those Jews (CEV)

have ignored you: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as have ignored you here means that the Jewish men were ignoring or defying the king’s command. Other ways to translate this include:

they have defied your Majesty (NET)

did not obey your order (GW)

have ignored your command (NJB)

O king: See the Notes at 2:4a. Use an expression that is natural in your language to address someone important.

3:12d

and have refused to serve your gods

- They do not honor your^(sing) gods,
- They refuse to worship the gods you^(sing) worship,

and have refused to serve your gods: In this context, the verb serve means to honor and worship. For example:

They don't honor your gods... (GW)

They refuse to worship your gods (CEV)

your gods: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as gods is plural. However, early versions and English versions differ as to whether the word gods should be understood as singular or plural:

1. It refers to the Aramaic gods in general. For example:

your gods (NJB) (BSB, NJB, CEV, NCV, GW, NLT, REB, KJV, RSV, NRSV, NIV, NJB)

1. It refers to one specific god. For example:

your god (GNT) (NJPS, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the majority of English versions. This is the reading of the written form of the Masoretic Text.

3:12e

or worship the golden statue you have set up."

- and they do not bow down to the golden statue which you have set/raised up."
- and they refuse to worship the golden column which you have caused to be erected."

or: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as or here introduces a second accusation against the three men. The second accusation is more specific than the first. English versions translate the connector in different ways:

They do not...and they do not... (NRSV, NCV, similarly the NJB)

They do not worship...or bow down (GNT, similarly GW, NLT, NJPS)

Translate in the way that is most natural in your language.

or worship the golden statue you have set up: See the Notes at 3:5b. Most versions translate the verb as worship. The author used this verb together with the synonym "to serve" in 3:12, 14, 18, 28. If your language has only one verb that means worship, you may use it here. For example:

Those Jews, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, refuse to worship your gods and the statue you have set up (CEV)

you have set up: The phrase set up is repeated in 3:1c, 2b, 3b, 5b, 7, 14, 18. This repetition emphasizes the authority of the king. You should translate this clause here.

Daniel 3:13

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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1. Setting: Nebuchadnezzar commanded all his officials of Babylon to come and worship the golden image that he had set up. (3:1-7)
2. Problem: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refused to bow down and worship the image. The king threatened to kill them, but they still refused. (3:8-18)
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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16-18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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Each language uses repetition in its own way. These notes will discuss the significance of the repetitions in Daniel. In some languages, the repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you will have to consider how best to communicate the same meaning.

Paragraph 3:13a-15c

In this paragraph the king threatened and rebuked Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. He said that they would certainly die if they did not worship his image.

3:13a

Then Nebuchadnezzar, furious with rage,

- ¶ At this, Nebuchadnezzar became furiously angry.
- ¶ Hearing this, the king was enraged.

Then: In the Aramaic text this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a word that the BSB translates as Then. Introduce this new phase of the story in a way that is natural in your language.

furious with rage: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Furious with rage is literally "in rage and fury." The words "rage" and "fury" are synonyms. Used together they emphasize the idea and describe a person who became very angry. There are two ways you can translate this expression:

- combine the words into one emphatic idea. For example:

In furious rage (RSV/NRSV)

furious (CEV)

very angry

- translate the two words separately. For example:

in his rage and fury (KJV)

in a fit of rage and anger (GW)

Use a natural expression or idiom in your language that describes a person who quickly becomes very angry.

3:13b

summoned Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.

- He commanded that his men bring Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego directly to him.
- He ordered the three Jewish men to appear before him.

summoned Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The king ordered that the three Jewish men come to him. The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as summoned is literally “he said to bring.” Other ways to translate this include:

Nebuchadnezzar commanded that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego be brought. (RSV)

commanded that they (indefinite) bring Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego to him

commanded his soldiers to bring Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego to him

Nebuchadnezzar: English translations translate the subject in different ways:

- the title with the name. For example:

King Nebuchadnezzar (CEV)

- the title by itself. For example:

The king (GNT)

Use the expression that is most natural in your language in this context.

3:13c

So these men were brought before the king,

- So they were led to the king.
- When they arrived,

So: The Aramaic word that introduces 3:13c is the same that introduces 3:13a. Here it introduces what happened next as a result of the king’s command.

these men were brought before the king: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as were brought is passive. The text does not state who brought the men to the king. There are different ways to translate this expression:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

When they were brought in (NLT)

- Use an active expression. For example:

They brought these men before the king (RSV)

So his soldiers brought these men to the king.

Use the form that is most natural in your language in this context.

before the king: See the Notes at 2:2c .

General Comment on 3:13a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine 3:13a–b. For example:

^{13a–b}and ordered the three men to be brought before him (GNT)

Daniel 3:14

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16-18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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Paragraph 3:13a-15c

In this paragraph the king threatened and rebuked Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. He said that they would certainly die if they did not worship his image.

3:14a

and Nebuchadnezzar said to them,

- Then King Nebuchadnezzar asked them,
- the king interrogated/questioned them.

and Nebuchadnezzar said to them: See the Notes at 3:13a. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the name of the king. If that is true in your

language, you may use a pronoun “he” or the title “king.” UBS Handbook.

See the Notes at 2:5a; 3:9. The phrase is literally, “Nebuchadnezzar answered and saying to them.” Nebuchadnezzar was about to ask them something important. The context is that of a confrontation. Introduce the king’s angry words in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar asked them (GW)

Then King Nebuchadnezzar questioned/interrogated them

Nebuchadnezzar demanded

3:14b

“Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, is it true that you do not serve my gods

- “Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego! Are you^(plur) really refusing to honor/worship my gods?
- “Listen, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego! Is it true what I have heard? Do you^(plur) refuse to worship the gods that I worship?

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, is it true: In the Aramaic text the word the BSB translates as *is it true* occurs before the names Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. In some languages it may be natural to put the names first in the sentence, as the BSB and some other English versions have done.

is it true: The Aramaic question that the BSB translates as *is it true* probably means “Is it a fact?” The king had heard that the three Jewish men had refused to bow down. He wanted to hear from the men themselves to be sure that it was not a false accusation. The CEV makes this clear by saying:

I hear that you refuse to worship my gods and the gold statue I have set up (CEV)

that you do not serve my gods: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as *serve* here means “worship, honor.” See the Notes at 3:12d. Here is another way to translate this:

you refuse to worship my gods (CEV)

my gods: See the Notes at 3:12d. Use the same word for gods here that you did there.

3:14c

or worship the golden statue I have set up?

- And do you^(plur) refuse to worship the golden statue, which I have set up?
- And will you^(plur) not bow before the golden column that I have caused/ordered to be erected?

or: See the Notes at 3:12e.

worship the golden statue I have set up?: See the Notes at 3:5b. The king asked a second question. This is probably a slightly different question. The king wanted to know if the Jewish men had deliberately acted against his authority.

I have set up: The phrase *set up* is repeated in 3:1c, 2b, 3b, 5b, 7, 14, 18. This repetition emphasizes the authority of the king.

Daniel 3:15

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:13a–15c

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3:15a

Now, if you are ready,

- At this time, you will have another opportunity.
- I am giving you^(plur) another chance.

Now: In the Aramaic text this verse connects to the previous verse with a connecting word that the BSB translates as Now. This Aramaic connector is an adverb that expresses time. Possible ways to translate this Aramaic word are:

Now then (GNT)

In a moment (NCV)

if you are ready: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as ready in this context means “willing to obey.” It implies that the Jewish men must actually obey. The king was giving the three men another chance to worship the statue. Here is another way to translate this:

I will give you one more chance (NLT)

3:15b

as soon as you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music,

- When you^(plur) hear the horn, the flute, the lyre, the small harp, the large harp, and the drum and all the other musical instruments,
- You^(plur) will hear once more the sound of the musical instruments.

as soon as you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and all kinds of music: See the Notes at 3:7a. The author once again repeated the list of instruments. This increases the tension in the narrative. It encourages the reader to anticipate what will happen next in the story. In some languages this type of repetition may not be natural and may even confuse some readers. If that is true in your language, you may give a summary. For example:

If you bow down and worship the statue when you hear the music (CEV)

However, if you did not translate the list in 3:10, you may be able to translate the whole list again here without the readers feeling that the repetition is unnatural.

3:15c

you must fall down and worship the statue I have made.

- I require that you bow down and worship the statue that I have made.
- And if you are willing to bow^(plur) down before the golden column, everything will be all right.

you must fall down and worship the statue I have made: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If you bow down and worship the statue I made, that will be good. (NCV)

bow down and worship the statue (GNT)

General Comment on 3:15a–c

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of the information in these verse parts. For example:

Now when you hear the sound..., if you are ready to fall down and worship the image I made, (NIV)

3:15d

But if you refuse to worship,

- But if you^(plur) do not worship the statue,
- But if you^(plur) refuse to worship the golden column,

But: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. Use a form in your language that shows that this new clause contrasts with the previous clause.

if you refuse to worship: See the Notes at 3:6. In the Aramaic text the verb does not have an object. Some English versions supply the pronoun “it” referring to the statue. For example:

if you refuse to worship it (NJB)

if you do not worship it (NIV)

3:15e

you will be thrown at once into the blazing fiery furnace.

- I will immediately have you^(plur) thrown into the furnace of burning fire.
- I will command my soldiers to throw you^(plur) into the blazing/hot fire in the furnace.

you will be thrown at once into the blazing fiery furnace: See the Notes at 3:6. This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active clause, you may say:

I shall have/cause you to enter/fall

I shall command my soldiers to throw/push you...

at once: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as at once is literally “in a brief time, hour.” You can also translate this:

immediately (NIV)

without delay

into the blazing fiery furnace: This is more literally “into a furnace of burning fire.” See the Notes at 3:6.

3:15f

Then what god will be able to deliver you from my hands?”

- And then will any god be able to save you^(plur) from my power? Certainly not!”

- No god will be able to save you^(plur) then.”

Then what god will be able to deliver you from my hands?: This is a rhetorical question. The implied answer is “no one” or “none.” This question functions as an emphatic statement. Nebuchadnezzar was claiming that no god could rescue the Jewish men from the furnace.

There are several ways you can translate this:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think there is any god who can save you?
(GNT)

Now, who is that god who can rescue you from my power? (NET)

- as a question with the answer supplied. For example:

Is there any god who can save you from me? No!

- as a statement. For example:

No god can save you from me. (CEV)

Translate this emphatic statement in the way that is most natural in your language.

god: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as god can refer to a pagan god or to the one true God. Here it refers to any of the pagan gods. King Nebuchadnezzar believed that there were many gods. The king did not think that any of them could rescue the three men from the fiery furnace.

from my hands?: In this context, the word hands is an idiom that refers to the king’s power or authority. There are three ways to translate this idiom:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

What God can save you from my power then? (GW)

- Leave this phrase implied, if the meaning is clear from the context. For example:

Do you think there is any god who can save you?
(GNT)

- Translate the idiom literally if you have the same idiom in your language. For example:

and who is the god that will deliver you out of my hands? (NRSV)

Daniel 3:16

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:16–18

In this paragraph, the three men responded to the king. The paragraph does not begin with a connector. However, the relation between the two paragraphs (3:13–15; 3:16–18) is one of contrast. If you have a natural way of showing this in your language, you can use it here. For example, in English you could begin the paragraph with the connector “But...”

3:16a–b

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The author repeated these names twelve times in the chapter. If it is not natural to repeat the names here, you can use a phrase that clearly refers to these three individuals. For example:

The three men (CEV)

replied to the king, “O Nebuchadnezzar...”: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as replied to the king, “O Nebuchadnezzar is more literally “answered and said to the king Nebuchadnezzar.” The BSB has translated the words O Nebuchadnezzar as part of the men’s speech, indicating whom they were addressing. Consider what is the most natural in your language. For example:

replied to King Nebuchadnezzar (NJB)

answered the king, saying, “Nebuchadnezzar,...” (NCV)

answered, “Your Majesty,...” (GNT)

we have no need to answer you in this matter: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as to answer you in this matter is more literally “give back a word to you.” The three men did not feel any need to explain their action to the king. They implied that they were responsible to God for their actions, not to the king. And God himself would show the answer to the king’s

question. In some languages it may be possible to imply this by placing the emphasis on the words to... you. For example:

It is not to you that we need to answer concerning this matter

Other ways to translate this include:

We have no need to present a defense to you in this matter (NRSV)

We do not need to give you a reply concerning this (NET)

Your question needs no answer from us (NJB)

3:16

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego replied to the king, “O Nebuchadnezzar, we have no need to answer you in this matter.

- ¶ Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego answered the king, “Nebuchadnezzar, we^(excl) do not need to defend what we did.
- ¶ The three men declared, “King Nebuchadnezzar, there is no need for us^(excl) to give you^(sing) an answer.

Daniel 3:17

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

This is the only chapter in the book of Daniel where the author does not refer to Daniel himself. Scholars have debated why this might be. Possibly he was traveling somewhere else in the empire on the king’s business at this time.

The author wrote Daniel 3 in the Aramaic language. These Notes usually follow the Aramaic found in the Masoretic Text (MT). The early Greek translation of Daniel 3 is somewhat different from the Aramaic. The Greek translation includes two stories that are not in the MT. The first is called “The Prayer of Azariah” (3:24–45). The second is called “The Song of the Three Young Men” (3:50–90). These two stories are connected by a short paragraph (3:46–50). Most English versions do not include these two stories. The NJB, however, does include them. As a result the verse numbers in the NJB are different from those of most other English versions.

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the Greek text includes a date in 3:1 that is not in the MT. Scholars have different views on why the two texts differ. It is possible that the Greek versions may have translated from a different Aramaic original. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

Outline: This chapter can be divided into four parts:

1. Setting: Nebuchadnezzar commanded all his officials of Babylon to come and worship the golden image that he had set up. (3:1–7)
2. Problem: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refused to bow down and worship the image. The king threatened to kill them, but they still refused. (3:8–18)
3. Action: The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three young men into the furnace. (3:19–23)
4. Result/Outcome: God delivered the three young men from the furnace, and Nebuchadnezzar gave honor to God. (3:24–30)

The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

Headings:

The Notes interpret Daniel 3:1–30 as a one unit with one heading. However, in some languages it may be helpful to divide this chapter into more than one unit and to give each unit a separate heading. The following are some examples of how English versions divide the chapter into units and the headings they give for each unit:

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4. “Nebuchadnezzar Commands Everyone to Worship a Gold Statue” (3:1–7)

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Special Translation Problems:

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In this paragraph, the three men responded to the king. The paragraph does not begin with a connector. However, the relation between the two paragraphs (3:13–15; 3:16–18) is one of contrast. If you have a natural way of showing this in your language, you can use it here. For example, in English you could begin the paragraph with the connector “But...”

3:17a

If the God whom we serve exists, then He is able to deliver us from the blazing fiery furnace

- If we^(excl) are forced into the blazing fire in the furnace, the God we^(excl) worship is able to save us^(excl) from it.
- If they throw/push us^(excl) into the fiery furnace, our^(excl) God, the God we^(excl) honor, has the power to rescue us^(excl) from it.

- It may be that your soldiers/men will throw/put us^(excl) into the furnace where the fire burns.
- But our^(excl) God, the God we^(excl) worship, can keep us^(excl) safe from its fire/flames.

(ESV:) If this be so: Scholars differ in the way they interpret the Aramaic clause that is literally “if it be so” which the ESV very literally translates as If this be so:

1. The phrase “if it be so” means “if this is to happen,” that is, “if we are to be thrown into the furnace.” For example:

If you throw us into the blazing furnace (NCV) (NIV, NCV, NLT, CEV, NJPS, probably KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV)

1. The phrase “if it be so” goes with the verb phrase “able to rescue/save.” The three men responded to the question that the king asked in 3:15c (if any god would be able to save them). For example:

If the God whom we serve is able to save us (GNT) (GNT, NRSV, NJB, GW)

1. The phrase “if it be so” means, “if this God exists.” For example:

If our God whom we are serving exists, he is able... (NET) (BSB, NET, possibly REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Other ways to translate this include:

if this is the situation

if this is the state of affairs

if this must happen

(ESV:) our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace: The three men were referring to Yahweh, the God of Israel. In some languages it may be natural to say:

our God whom we serve (RSV)

(ESV) our God whom we serve: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as our God whom we serve means “the God we (exclusive) worship/honor.” See the Notes at 3:12d. The phrase does not imply that the

speakers believed that there was more than one true God. They did acknowledge that other people, non-Jews, served other gods. These other gods were gods in name only. They were false and without power.

(ESV:) is able to deliver us: See the Notes at 3:15c. Other ways English versions say this are:

is able to save us (GNT)

is able to save us (NLT)

(ESV:) from the burning fiery furnace: The ESV translates this Aramaic phrase literally. See the Notes at 3:6.

3:17b

and from your hand, O king.

- He will rescue us^(excl) from your^(sing) power, O king.
- And he will.

(ESV:) and he will deliver us from your hand, O king: Scholars interpret the Aramaic verb that the ESV translates as he will deliver us in two ways:

1. It is a statement of what will happen. For example:

He will rescue us from your power (NLT) (BSB, ESV, NIV, GNT, KJV, NASB, RSV, NJB, REB, NET, GW, NCV, NLT)

1. It expresses a wish or prayer. For example:

let him deliver us (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

(ESV:) from your hand, O king: The ESV translates this Aramaic phrase literally. See the Notes at 2:4b and 3:12c and how you translated the reference to Nebuchadnezzar there.

(ESV:) hand: The word hand is again used as a figure of speech meaning “power.” See the Notes on the phrase “hands” at 3:15f and translate it as you did there.

Daniel 3:18

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

This is the only chapter in the book of Daniel where the author does not refer to Daniel himself. Scholars have debated why this might be. Possibly he was traveling

somewhere else in the empire on the king’s business at this time.

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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Paragraph 3:16–18

In this paragraph, the three men responded to the king. The paragraph does not begin with a connector. However, the relation between the two paragraphs (3:13–15; 3:16–18) is one of contrast. If you have a natural way of showing this in your language, you can use it here. For example, in English you could begin the paragraph with the connector “But...”

3:18a

But even if He does not,

- But even if he does not rescue/save us^(excl),
- But even if he chooses/decides not to do so,

But: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a possibility that contrasts with the previous statement.

even if He does not: This conditional sentence is a short way to say “even if our God does not deliver us from the furnace.” In some languages it may be natural to include some of this implied information. For example:

But even if God does not save us (NCV)

3:18b

let it be known to you, O king,

- King Nebuchadnezzar, you^(sing) need to know
- we^(excl) want to make it clear/plain to you^(sing), O king,

let it be known to you: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as let it be known to you is more literally “be it known to you” (as in the RSV). This is a passive clause. If an active clause is more natural in your language, you may follow the NIV or the NLT, which say:

we want to make it clear to you (NLT)

we want you to know (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to make the king the subject of the verb. For example:

you should know (GW)

you can be sure/certain

3:18c

that we will not serve your gods

- that we^(excl) will not/never worship the gods you^(sing) worship

- that we^(excl) refuse to worship your^(sing) gods

that we will not serve your gods: See the Notes at 3:5b, 3:12d. The statement is emphatic. Emphasize the men's refusal in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

we will never serve your gods (NLT)

gods: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates gods is plural, as in 3:12d. Translate it here as you did there.

3:18d

or worship the golden statue you have set up."

- and we^(excl) will not bow down to the golden statue which you^(sing) have set up."
- and we^(excl) refuse to worship the golden column which you^(sing) have had erected/established."

or: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as or here introduces another thing that the Jewish men refused to do. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as:

and

worship the golden statue you have set up: See the Notes at 3:5b, 3:12e, and translate here in the same or a similar way.

Daniel 3:19

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:19–23

The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three Jews into the furnace.

3:19a

At this, Nebuchadnezzar was filled with rage,

- ¶ Then Nebuchadnezzar was very angry with Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.
- ¶ King Nebuchadnezzar became extremely angry at them.

At this: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *At this* here introduces a new phase in the action of the story. See also 3:13a. Some English translations leave this word implied. You should introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

Nebuchadnezzar was filled with rage: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates literally here as was

filled with rage means Nebuchadnezzar became very angry. Other ways to translate this include:

This infuriated King Nebuchadnezzar. (NJB)

Nebuchadnezzar was so furious...that... (NLT)

This made King Nebuchadnezzar very angry

3:19b

and the expression on his face changed toward Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.

- His face twisted/contorted in rage/fury.
- With a furious/terrible expression on his face,

and the expression on his face changed toward Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates quite literally as the expression on his face changed is more literally “the image of his face changed.” Scholars have interpreted this in two ways:

1. The king was so angry that the expression on his face changed. For example:

his face became distorted with rage (NLT) (BSB, KJV, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NJPS, NLT, REB, CEV, NJB, GNT, GW)

1. The king changed what he thought about the three men. For example:

and he changed his mind (NCV) (NET, NCV, NIV)

Interpretation (1) is recommended. Consider how to describe someone who is so angry that it shows on their face.

General Comment on 3:19b

The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as “toward Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego” is more literally “against Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego,” as in the RSV. If it is unnatural to repeat these three names, you may leave this phrase untranslated, as it is implied by the context. Or you may use a pronoun like the NIV, or follow the CEV:

toward them (NIV)

at the three men (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two ideas in 3:19a, that Nebuchadnezzar was angry at the three men and that his expression toward them changed. For example:

^{19a}Nebuchadnezzar's face twisted as he raged against the three men.

^{19a}His face distorted with anger, Nebuchadnezzar....

3:19c

He gave orders to heat the furnace seven times hotter than usual,

- He commanded that the furnace be made seven times hotter than it usually was.
- he commanded his men to heat the furnace up to its maximum/greatest possible temperature.

He gave orders: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as gave orders is literally “answered and saying.” In this context, the expression emphasizes what the king was about to say. See the Notes at 2:5a; 3:9. Here is another way to translate this:

He commanded (NLT)

to heat the furnace: Other ways to translate this using an active verb are:

he commanded them (indefinite) to heat the furnace

he ordered his soldiers/workers to heat the furnace

furnace: See the Notes on the word furnace at 3:6.

seven times hotter than usual: This is probably an idiomatic or proverbial expression meaning “much hotter.” Technology at this time permitted a temperature of up to fifteen hundred degrees Celsius. See Walton, Matthews, and Chavalas, *The IVP Bible Background Commentary*, p. 735. There are two options:

- You can translate literally: seven times hotter. For example:

seven times its usual heat (REB)

- You can translate more generally. For example:

as hot as possible

than usual: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as usual means “customary.” For example:

than normal (GW)

Daniel 3:20

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:19–23

The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three Jews into the furnace.

3:20a

and he commanded some mighty men of valor in his army to tie up Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego

- Then he ordered some of the warriors in his army to tie/bind Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego
- And he commanded some of his best fighting men to tie the hands and feet of the three men with ropes

and he commanded: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in the sequence. The king gave some further orders. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Then he ordered (NLT)

Next, he commanded (CEV)

some mighty men of valor in his army: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as some mighty men of valor in his army means “some of his warriors.” In your translation, avoid suggesting that some of the soldiers in the army were not very strong. Other ways to translate this include:

certain mighty men of his army (RSV)

some soldiers from his army (GW)

some of the strong guards in his army (NRSV)

to tie up Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The soldiers tied the three men to prevent them from trying to escape. They probably tied their hands and feet with chains or rope. In some languages it may be necessary to add some of this implied information. For example:

to tie the hands and feet of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego

In some languages it may be natural to refer back to the young men in a different way. For example:

to tie the three men up (GNT)

3:20b and throw them into the blazing fiery furnace.

- and to throw them into the burning fire in the furnace.
- and to throw them into the furnace where the fire was burning/blazing.

and throw them into the blazing fiery furnace: See the Notes at 3:6.

General Comment on 3:19b–20b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's orders using direct speech. For example:

he commanded his men, "Make that furnace as hot as possible! And you guards, tie up Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego! Throw them into the fire!"

Daniel 3:21

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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Paragraph 3:19–23

The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three Jews into the furnace.

3:21a

So they were tied up, wearing robes, trousers, turbans, and other clothes,

- So the soldiers tied the three men, who were still wearing their trousers, shirts, hats, and other clothes

- So the soldiers tied their hands and feet. The three men were still wearing all their clothes, including their turbans.
- Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego still had on their trousers, shirts, hats, and other clothes, but the soldiers tied them up.

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces what happened in response to the king’s commands.

they were tied up, wearing robes, trousers, turbans, and other clothes: The king’s soldiers tied up the three Jewish men just as they were, wearing all their ceremonial clothes. This is unexpected, since the clothes were valuable. It probably indicates that the soldiers were working quickly. It may be natural to imply this by saying:

these men, still wearing their robes...

they were tied up: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active clause, you may say:

Then the soldiers tied the three men

So they tied them up (NLT)

wearing robes, trousers, turbans, and other clothes: In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

They were wearing their clothes, hats, and other clothing. (GW)

robes: The exact meaning of this Aramaic word is uncertain. Most English versions interpret it as a piece of clothing that covered the upper body. For example:

cloaks (NJB)

shirts (GNT)

tunics (NRSV)

trousers: The meaning of this Aramaic word is also uncertain. It may well have covered the legs and lower body, and possibly the upper body as well. For example:

robes (GNT)

turbans: Most English versions agree that the Aramaic word refers to a piece of clothing that men wore on their heads. If you have a general word for something a man wears on the head, you can use it here. For example:

hats (NRSV)

headgear (NJB)

and other clothes: This is a general expression that includes all sorts of other clothing a man would normally wear, such as shoes and belts. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 3:21a

In some languages it may be difficult to translate these exact clothing items. If that is true in your language, you may have to combine the terms. For example:

- You may combine two of the terms:

They were wearing their suits, hats and other clothing.

- You may combine three items. For example:

With all their clothes still on, including their turbans (CEV)

- You may combine all of the items. For example:

And threw them into the furnace, fully clothed (NLT)

3:21b

and they were thrown into the blazing fiery furnace.

- Then the soldiers threw them into the blazing fire in the furnace.
- Then they took them to the furnace and threw them into the fire that was burning intensely.

and they were thrown into the blazing fiery furnace: The three Jewish men were forcibly pushed or dropped into the furnace. See the Notes at 3:6. This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to have an active clause, you can follow the NLT and say:

they...threw them into the furnace (NLT)

Daniel 3:22

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:19–23

The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three Jews into the furnace.

3:22a**The king’s command was so urgent and the furnace so hot that**

- Because the king had spoken/acted so harshly and the furnace was so very hot,
- The king had acted very severely by ordering that they (indefinite) make the fire extremely hot, and so

The king’s command was so urgent and the furnace so hot that...:

This is a reason clause. It gives the reason for what happens in the following verse part, 3:22b. Other ways to translate it include:

Because the king’s command was urgent and the furnace was so overheated... (NRSV)

But since the king’s command was so urgent, and the furnace was so excessively hot... (NET)

The king’s command was so urgent: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as so urgent can have different meanings. See also 2:15a, the only other place this word occurs in the Old Testament. In this context, the word probably means “harsh, severe,” with the additional ideas of “strict” and “urgent.” Different English versions focus on different aspects of this. For example:

Now because the king had given strict orders (GNT)

Because the king’s command was urgent (NRSV)

Try to translate this with an expression referring to a harsh, ruthless order requiring immediate obedience.

and the furnace so hot: The fire in the furnace was at a higher temperature than normal. Other ways to translate this in English are:

and the furnace was so overheated (NRSV)

and the furnace was so extremely hot (GW)

3:22b

the fiery flames killed the men who carried up Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.

- the flames burned to death the soldiers who took Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego up to the opening of the furnace.
- its flames killed the guards who brought the three men up to the opening/edge.

the fiery flames killed the men: The fire was so hot that the flames burned the soldiers who were at the opening on the top of the furnace. Other ways to translate this include:

the raging flames killed the men (NRSV)

the flames burned up the guards (GNT)

who carried up Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego:

This clause identifies which soldiers died. It was the ones who carried the three Jewish men to the furnace. Other ways to translate this include:

as they threw the three men in (NLT)

who carried Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego (GW)

who took the men to the furnace (GNT)

General Comment on 3:22b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 3:22b. For example:

the men carrying Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego were burnt to death by the flames from the fire (NJB)

Daniel 3:23

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:19-23

The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three Jews into the furnace.

3:23

And these three men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, firmly bound, fell into the blazing fiery furnace.

- And the three men fell into the blazing fire in the furnace, with their hands and their feet securely/tightly tied/bound.
- So Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, ropes tight around their hands and feet, fell into the fiery furnace.

And these three men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, firmly bound, fell into the blazing fiery furnace: This verse repeats information from 3:22. This repetition emphasizes the difference between what the king saw in 3:23 and what he saw in 3:24.

And: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as And here introduces what happened next in the story. Here is another way to translate this:

Then (GNT)

these three men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The BSB translates the Aramaic text here literally as these three men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. Some English versions do not translate the three names, as this repetition from 3:22b is unnatural in English. You may:

- translate both the number and the names of the three men as the BSB and some other English versions have done. For example:

the three men, Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-Nego (NJB)

- translate only the first phrase. For example:

these three men (NIV)

- translate only the names. For example:

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego (GNT)

Option (1) is recommended. If the repetition is unnatural or confusing in your language, you may follow options (2) or (3).

firmly bound, fell into the blazing fiery furnace: The soldiers pushed or dropped the three men into the opening at the top of the furnace so that they fell down into the fire. The hands and the feet of the three men were still tied when they fell. You can say:

fell down, bound, into the furnace of blazing fire (NRSV)

securely tied, fell into the roaring flames (NLT)

fell into the furnace of blazing fire while still securely bound (NET)

the blazing fiery furnace: See the Notes at 3:6.

Daniel 3:24

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The narrative does not directly tell what happened to the men in the furnace. Instead, the focus moves to the king. The king expressed his shock and amazement at what he saw. The Septuagint (LXX), the ancient Greek version, here adds two stories that are not in the Masoretic Text. The LXX says “the king is amazed because he hears them singing.” Like the LXX, the NJB adds “the song of Azariah in the furnace” (3:24–50) and “The song of the three young men” (3:51–90). The NJB includes these additions and then continues translating the Aramaic text at verse 91. For more information on these added texts see the introduction to the Notes. The Dead Sea Scrolls, like the Masoretic Text, do not include these additions. These Notes also do not include these sections in the Notes or the Display.

3:24a

Suddenly King Nebuchadnezzar jumped up in amazement

- ¶ But King Nebuchadnezzar was so astonished that he suddenly stood up.
- ¶ But as he was sitting watching, King Nebuchadnezzar was shocked and quickly stood up.

Suddenly: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates Suddenly begins a new stage in the action. Collins, p. 179. Here there is a change in the focus and also a sudden strong contrast. As a result,

some translations, including the BSB, introduce the clause with a connector that shows contrast. For example:

But suddenly (NLT)

Use a form that is natural in your language for introducing a sudden change in the action of a story.

King Nebuchadnezzar jumped up in amazement:

This is more literally “was amazed and stood up quickly.” The king was probably sitting on his throne watching the celebrations. He saw something that surprised him and caused him to stand up quickly. Other ways to translate this include:

King Nebuchadnezzar was astonished and rose up quickly (NRSV)

Nebuchadnezzar was startled. He sprang to his feet. (GW)

as he was watching, Nebuchadnezzar jumped up in amazement.

3:24b

and asked his advisers, “Did we not throw three men, firmly bound, into the fire?”

- He said to his advisers, “We threw three men into the fire, did we not? And we tied them up!”
- He exclaimed to his counselors, “I thought that I had ordered the soldiers to tie up three men and put them into the fire!”

and asked his advisers: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as asked is literally “answered and saying.” In this context, the phrase introduces the king’s reaction to an unexpected sight. Introduce the king’s reaction to what he saw in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

exclaimed to his advisers (NLT)

advisers: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as advisers probably refers to high-ranking royal officials who advised the king. It is the same as the fifth word in the list in 3:2. Other English versions say:

officials (GNT)

counselors (RSV)

Did we not throw three men, firmly bound, into the fire?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a statement and implies a positive answer, “yes.” The king was expecting his advisers to confirm/agree that they had tied up three men and thrown them into the fire. There are several ways to translate this question:

- As a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

Was it not three men that we threw bound into the fire? (NRSV)

Is it not true that we tied/bound three men? We threw only those three men into the fire, didn’t we?

- As a statement. For example:

I thought that I had three men bound and thrown into the furnace!

I am/feel sure it was three men that I ordered my soldiers to tie up and throw into the furnace!

we: The king himself did not take part in this action. He ordered his guards/soldiers to tie up the Jewish men. If in your language it is not natural to use a first-person plural pronoun in this context, you may need to say:

I had three men bound and thrown into the fire, did I not?

How many men did I command my soldiers to tie up and throw into the fire? Was it not three?

I thought my soldiers bound and threw three men into the fire!

three men: The word three is emphatic and important in this verse part. In some languages it may be natural in this context to follow the NCV and say:

only three men (NCV)

firmly bound: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as firmly bound is emphatic. Translate this verb explicitly, as in 3:20a.

3:24c

“Certainly, O king,” they replied.

- They answered the king, “Yes, king, that is true.”
- The counselors answered, “Yes, you did, sir.”

Certainly: The counselors agreed with the king. Translate this in a way that is natural for expressing agreement. For example:

Yes, we did (GNT)

True (RSV)

Surely (NJPS)

O king: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as O king is more literally “King.” Translate in a way that is natural for advisers to speak in addressing their king. See the Notes at 2:4a. Here is another way to translate this:

Your Majesty (NIV)

they replied: The Aramaic text indicates that the advisers replied to the king. You may include this in your translation if it is natural in your language. For example:

They answered the king (NRSV)

Daniel 3:25

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author wrote Daniel 3 in the Aramaic language. These Notes usually follow the Aramaic found in the Masoretic Text (MT). The early Greek translation of Daniel 3 is somewhat different from the Aramaic. The Greek translation includes two stories that are not in the MT. The first is called “The Prayer of Azariah” (3:24–45). The second is called “The Song of the Three Young Men” (3:50–90). These two stories are connected by a short paragraph (3:46–50). Most English versions do not include these two stories. The NJB, however, does include them. As a result the verse numbers in the NJB are different from those of most other English versions.

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The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16–18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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3:25a

“Look!” he exclaimed. “I see four men, unbound and unharmed, walking around in the fire—

- Then the king said, “But look! I now see four men walking around in the middle of the fire.
- They are untied and none of them are hurt.
- Then the king exclaimed, “But look at the fire! I can see four men walking about in it! Their hands and feet are not tied! None of them have been burnt!

Look!: The Aramaic exclamation that the BSB translates as Look! calls attention to something important and surprising. Here it also contrasts with the previous clause. Try to translate both ideas. For example:

But look... (GW)

But what do I see!

he exclaimed: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as he exclaimed is literally “he was answering and saying.” See the Notes at 3:9. In this context, the expression indicates that the king was about to say something surprising and unexpected. It introduces the climax of the narrative. Introduce what the king said in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

He said

Nebuchadnezzar shouted (NLT)

I see four men: The king saw that there were four men in the fire. The text does not say so, but presumably everyone else could also see four men. The fourth man was actually there. So in your translation you should use the first person singular I without implying that the advisers could not see the same thing. For example:

I can see that there are four men

unbound and unharmed: Nebuchadnezzar could see that the four men were walking freely and that they were not in pain or distress. There were no ropes or chains around them, and the fire was not burning or hurting them.

unbound: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as unbound is passive. It can also be translated as “loosed.” Here it indicates that there were no ropes/chains binding/tying the men in the furnace. In trans-

lating this, bear in mind that one of the four men had never been bound. Other ways to say this in English are:

loose (RSV)

They are free of chains/ropes.

They are not tied up. (GNT)

unharmed: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as unharmed is more literally “there is no hurt on them.” The fire had not burned the skin/bodies of any of the men. Different ways to translate this include:

they show no sign of being hurt (GNT)

They are not burned (NCV)

The flames have not hurt/harmed them!

walking around in the fire: The furnace was big enough for all the men to walk around inside it. They were surrounded by flames. Other ways to translate this include:

walking in the middle of the fire (NRSV)

walking about in the flames

3:25b

and the fourth looks like a son of the gods!”

- And the fourth person looks like a god!”
- The fourth person appears divine/godlike!”

and the fourth looks like a son of the gods: The king described the fourth person that he saw in the furnace. This is important information. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a complete sentence. For example:

The fourth one looks like a son of the gods. (GW)

a son of the gods: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates literally as a son of the gods here refers to a supernatural being of some kind. Nebuchadnezzar, like the other Babylonians, believed in the existence of various gods. This fourth figure looked godlike, supernatural. Here is another way to translate this:

a divine being (NLT)

Many scholars believe that this fourth figure may have been Jesus Christ, the Son of God, appearing as a man before his birth on earth. However, you should not make this explicit in the text. This was not what Nebuchadnezzar thought.

Daniel 3:26

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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Paragraph 3:26–27

The king went closer to the furnace and spoke directly to Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. The three men left the furnace, unharmed.

3:26a

Then Nebuchadnezzar approached the door of the blazing fiery furnace and called out,

- ¶ Then Nebuchadnezzar went to the door of the furnace. He called inside,
- ¶ The King Nebuchadnezzar went as close as he could to the opening of the furnace. He shouted into it:

Then Nebuchadnezzar approached the door of the blazing fiery furnace: The king walked over to the furnace so that he could talk to the men inside. Other ways to translate this include:

Nebuchadnezzar went to the door of the blazing furnace (GW)

Then Nebuchadnezzar came as close as he could to the door of the blazing furnace (NLT)

Then: The connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces what the king did next. Use a form in your language that indicates that this is a new stage in the action in the story.

the door of the blazing fiery furnace: See the Notes at 3:6. Scholars disagree about the exact design of the furnace. Some commentators think the furnace was “metal and beehive-shaped with an opening on the top into which the men were thrown, and a door at the side through which the inside could be seen.” Goldingay, p. 70. In some languages it may be natural to

leave implied the idea that the furnace was blazing. For example:

the furnace door (REB)

door: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as door refers to the hole in the furnace by which people could enter. Here is another way to translate this:

opening (NIV)

and called out: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as called out is literally “answered and saying.” In this context, the expression indicates that the king was about to say something important. He was not very close to the men, so it may be natural to say:

and shouted (NIV)

3:26b

“Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, servants of the Most High God, come out!”

- “Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego, you^(plur) who serve/worship the Most High God! Come out of the furnace. Come here to me.”
- “Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego! You^(plur) obey/worship the Supreme God! Come here, out of the fire!”

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: See how you translated these names at 1:7b-c. The king addressed the three Jewish men using their Babylonian names.

servants of the Most High God: In this context, the word servants describes men who worshiped and obeyed the Most High God. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this expression as a verb. For example:

you who serve the Most High God

the Most High God: This was a title that non-Jews used to refer to the God of Israel. Sometimes Jews also used this expression to refer to God. Goldingay, p. 72. The title was used by Israelites and pagans. For example, it was used by Melchizedek (Genesis 14:18–20), Balaam (Numbers 24:16), and the king of Babylon (Isaiah 14:14). It was used by a Jew in Daniel 4:21–29; 5:15, 21; 7:18–27; Genesis 14:22; and Deuteronomy 32:8. See Genesis 14:18–20, 22. This title refers to God as having great authority. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel says that the term describes “the greatness

of this God without necessarily stressing that he is greater than all other gods.”

come out!: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as come out contains two verbs and is more literally “Come out and come.” The king used two verbs to add emphasis to his command. The NIV translates this phrase as “come out! Come here!” to show this emphasis, but in some languages it may not be natural to use two verbs. In that case, you could use one emphatic verb. For example:

come out here (GW)

come out at once! (CEV)

3:26c

So Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego came out of the fire,

- So Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego came out from the fire.
- So the three men walked out of the furnace.

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces what the men did as a result to the king’s commands. Translate this connection in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages, the connection may be implied by the context. An explicit connector may not be necessary.

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego came out of the fire: See the Notes at 3:11. The author repeated these three names twelve times in the chapter. If this is not natural in your language, you can use a pronoun or refer to them in another way. For example:

They came out (CEV)

the three men came out

Daniel 3:27

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3:27a

and when the satraps, prefects, governors, and royal advisers had gathered around,

- The provincial governors, magistrates, assistant governors, and the king’s advisers gathered around them,
- The provincial governors, magistrates, and other royal officials crowded around to look at the three men.

and when the satraps, prefects, governors, and royal advisers had gathered around:

See the Notes on satraps, prefects, and governors at 3:2a. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as advisers is the same as the word in 3:24b. Translate it here as you did there. Notice that here a word meaning “of the king,” that is, royal, describes these officials.

had gathered around: The same verb is used in 3:3a, where the BSB translates it as “assembled.” It means “came together, met as a group.” Here the men gathered together informally in order to look at the men who had come out of the furnace. For example:

gathered together (ESV)

crowded around (NLT)

3:27b

they saw that the fire had no effect on the bodies of these men.

- and they saw/realized that the fire had not damaged/burnt their bodies.
- They could not see any marks from the fire on them!

they saw that the fire had no effect on the bodies of these men:

The officials observed that the fire had not burned the men. In some languages it may be unnatural to say that the officials saw that something had not happened. Other possible ways to translate this include:

They could not see any burnt marks on them.

It was clear/obvious to them that the men were safe/whole. The fire had not harmed them at all.

No signs of harm/burns were on them. The fire had not affected them.

the fire had no effect on the bodies of these men:

The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates had no effect

is more literally “had not ruled over.” The author used this verb in a figurative way. He meant that the fire had not burned the three men. Other ways to translate this expression include:

the fire had not harmed their bodies (NIV)

the fire had not had any power over the bodies of those men (NRSV)

3:27c-e

These three clauses give examples of how the fire did not harm the three Jewish men. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. It may also be natural to use two or three sentences. For example:

Their hair was not singed, their clothes were not burned, and there was no smell of smoke on them. (GNT)

Not a hair on their heads was singed, and their clothing was not scorched. They didn’t even smell of smoke! (NLT)

3:27c

Not a hair of their heads was singed,

- Their hair was not burned.
- The fire had not burned their hair

Not a hair of their heads was singed: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural to use an active clause, you can say:

The fire had not singed/burnt the hair on their heads

The hair on their heads was untouched by the fire

a hair of their heads: In some languages it may be unnatural to mention that the hair involved was of or on the men’s heads. It may be more natural to leave this information implied and follow the GNT by saying:

Their hair (GNT)

3:27d

their robes were unaffected,

- The clothes that they were wearing were not damaged.
- or their clothes.

their robes were unaffected: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as were unaffected is literally “were not changed.” In many languages it may be natural to indicate in what way the robes were not changed. For example:

their robes were not scorched (NIV)

In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb. For example:

The fire had not burned their clothes

robes: See the Notes on robes at 3:21a. The exact meaning of this Aramaic word is uncertain. The author probably just chose this item of clothing as an example of something that was true of all the clothes the men were wearing. So it is good to translate it with a general word for clothing. For example:

their clothing (NLT)

3:27e

and there was no smell of fire on them.

- The advisers could not even smell fire/smoke on them.
- Nor was there any odor of smoke on them.

and there was no smell of fire on them: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as there was no smell of fire on them probably means that no odor of smoke came from the three men. They did not smell of smoke, as one might expect. Ways to translate this include:

and not even the smell of fire came from them (NRSV)

They did not even smell of smoke (NLT)

The officials could not even smell smoke on the three men.

Languages have different ways to describe smells. Use a natural way in your language to express the officials’ inability to smell smoke/fire on these men.

Daniel 3:28

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

This is the only chapter in the book of Daniel where the author does not refer to Daniel himself. Scholars have

debated why this might be. Possibly he was traveling somewhere else in the empire on the king's business at this time.

The author wrote Daniel 3 in the Aramaic language. These Notes usually follow the Aramaic found in the Masoretic Text (MT). The early Greek translation of Daniel 3 is somewhat different from the Aramaic. The Greek translation includes two stories that are not in the MT. The first is called "The Prayer of Azariah" (3:24-45). The second is called "The Song of the Three Young Men" (3:50-90). These two stories are connected by a short paragraph (3:46-50). Most English versions do not include these two stories. The NJB, however, does include them. As a result the verse numbers in the NJB are different from those of most other English versions.

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Outline: This chapter can be divided into four parts:

1. Setting: Nebuchadnezzar commanded all his officials of Babylon to come and worship the golden image that he had set up. (3:1-7)
2. Problem: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refused to bow down and worship the image. The king threatened to kill them, but they still refused. (3:8-18)
3. Action: The king ordered his soldiers to throw the three young men into the furnace. (3:19-23)
4. Result/Outcome: God delivered the three young men from the furnace, and Nebuchadnezzar gave honor to God. (3:24-30)

The author gave prominence to Daniel 3:16-18, when the three young men proclaimed that they trusted in God to rescue them. If you have a way in your language to mark this section as important, you should use do that here

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 2. "The Image of Gold and the Fiery Furnace" (NIV)
 3. "The Fiery Furnace" (REB)
 4. "Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego Refuse to Worship an Idol" (GW)
2. Some have two headings:
 3. "The Golden Image" (NRSV, 3:1-18)
 - "Nebuchadnezzar's Gold Statue" (NLT, 3:1-18)
 1. "The Fiery Furnace" (NRSV, 3:19-30)
 - "The Blazing Furnace" (NLT, 3:19-30)
3. The GNT has four headings:
 4. "Nebuchadnezzar Commands Everyone to Worship a Gold Statue" (3:1-7)
 5. "Daniel's Three Friends Are Accused of Disobedience" (3:8-18)
 6. "Daniel's Three Friends Are Sentenced to Death" (3:19-25)
 7. "The Three Men Are Released and Promoted" (3:26-30)

Special Translation Problems:

1. Lists: The author liked to use lists. He repeated these lists throughout the chapter. For example:
 2. the list of the names of officials (3:2, 3, 27)
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 4. the phrase: "peoples, nations, and languages" (3:4, 29)
5. Repetition: The author also liked to repeat phrases throughout the narrative. Some of these phrases are:
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 7. "hear the sound of the horn" (3:5, 7, 10, 15)
 8. "fall down and worship" (3:5, 6, 7, 10, 11, 15)
 9. "burning fiery furnace" (3:6, 11, 15, 17, 20, 21, 23, 26)
 10. "Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego" (3:12, 13, 14, 16, 19, 20, 22, 26, 28, 29, 30)

Each language uses repetition in its own way. These notes will discuss the significance of the repetitions in Daniel. In some languages, the repetition may not

be natural. If that is true in your language, you will have to consider how best to communicate the same meaning.

Paragraph 3:28–30

In this concluding paragraph the king praised God for the miracle that had happened, and he rewarded the three Jewish men.

3:28a

Nebuchadnezzar declared, “Blessed be the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego,

- ¶ Then King Nebuchadnezzar declared, “Praise^(plur) the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego!
- ¶ Then the king exclaimed, “I praise the God that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego worship!

Nebuchadnezzar declared: See the Notes at 3:9. The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Nebuchadnezzar declared is more literally “Nebuchadnezzar was answering and saying.” The expression indicates that Nebuchadnezzar was about to announce something important. You can say:

Then Nebuchadnezzar said (NIV)

Nebuchadnezzar exclaimed (NET)

Nebuchadnezzar: Refer to the king in the way that is most natural in your own language.

Blessed be the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: Nebuchadnezzar honored God by calling for him to receive praise. He did not indicate who should praise God. In some languages it may be natural to translate Praise as a verb. It may be necessary to supply a subject. For example:

I praise... (GNT)

Let/May everyone praise...

Praise the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. (NCV)

the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The king believed in many different gods. He thought he was praising one of them, the God whom Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego worshiped. Other ways to translate this include:

the God who is worshiped by Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego

the God whom Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego serve

3:28b

who has sent His angel and delivered His servants

- He sent his angel here in order to rescue these servants of his.
- He told his angel to come to these men who serve him and he saved them from the fire.

who has sent His angel: An angel is a messenger and servant of God. In 3:25b the king called this fourth person “a son of the gods.” Here in 3:28b he called him an angel. Nebuchadnezzar believed that there were many gods, and possibly he did not distinguish between angels and gods. Some commentators believe that the fourth person refers to Jesus Christ. Showers (p. 35) cites Leon Wood, *A Commentary On Daniel* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan Publishing House, 1973), 93. See “angel” in KBT.

and delivered His servants: The subject of the verb is God. The king believed that God had sent his angel, and that through this angel God had rescued the three men from the fire. Other ways to translate this in English are:

and saved his servants (GW)

in order to rescue his servants

His servants: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a clause with a verb. For example:

who serve...him (GNT)

who worship him

3:28c

who trusted in Him. They violated the king’s command

- They trusted him and rejected/refused my command.
- They refused to obey the order I had made/given. Instead, they trusted their God to save/rescue them.

who trusted in Him: English versions interpret this phrase in two ways:

1. It connects closely with the following clause. For example:

he has sent his angel to rescue his servants who, putting their trust in him, defied the order of the king (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NJPS, NJB, CEV, NCV)

1. It connects closely with the previous clause. For example:

who has sent his angel and delivered his servants who trusted in him. They disobeyed the king's command (NRSV) (KJV, NRSV, GW, NLT, REB, GNT)

The two interpretations are close in meaning. Interpretation (1) is recommended.

They violated the king's command: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as violated the king's command is literally, "and have changed the king's word." In many languages it is more natural for the king to refer to himself in the first person. For example:

and refused to obey my orders (CEV)

They disobeyed my orders (GNT)

3:28d and risked their lives

- They risked their own lives
- They were willing to die,

and risked their lives: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as risked their lives is more literally "gave their bodies." It indicates that the men were willing to die. They were willing to give their bodies to be burned in the fire. Your translation should avoid implying that the men did actually die in the fire. Other ways to translate this include:

and were willing to give up their lives (NIV)

and were willing to die (NLT)

3:28e rather than serve or worship any god except their own God.

- rather than honor or worship a different god than the God of their own people.
- but they were not willing to worship any god other than the one God they always worshiped.

rather than serve or worship any god except their own God: The same two Aramaic verbs that the BSB translates as serve and worship are used together in

3:12, 14, and 18. See the Notes at 3:12d-e. You can also say:

so that they would not have to honor and worship (GW)

rather than to obey and worship

The two verbs are synonyms. If it is natural to use only one verb, that is acceptable.

any god except their own God: This phrase implies that the king believed that there was more than one god.

their own God: The phrase their own God means "the God whom they worshiped." Another way to make this clear is:

other than the one God they always worshiped

Daniel 3:29

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

This is the only chapter in the book of Daniel where the author does not refer to Daniel himself. Scholars have debated why this might be. Possibly he was traveling somewhere else in the empire on the king's business at this time.

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Paragraph 3:28-30

In this concluding paragraph the king praised God for the miracle that had happened, and he rewarded the three Jewish men.

3:29a

Therefore I decree that

- Therefore I now command that
- So today I make the following law:

Nebuchadnezzar declared that the Jewish people would be free to worship their own God. The Jewish religion would be legal in the Babylonian empire. No one would persecute the Jews for worshiping their God.

Therefore: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces a result clause. Because of the way God rescued the three men, the king decided to make a new law. Introduce the king's announcement in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So (NCV)

And now (GNT)

I decree that: See the Notes at 3:10. The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates I decree that is literally “from me is set a decree.” Emphasis is on the phrase “from me.” It was the king himself who proclaimed the royal decree. Other ways English versions translate this are:

I order that (GW)

I command that (GNT)

3:29b

the people of any nation or language who say anything offensive against the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego

- no one may insult/disrespect the God whom Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego worship. This law applies to people from every people group and nation and every language.
- No one should ever blaspheme the God that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego worship. Everyone of every tribe, nation, and language must obey this new law.

the people of any nation or language: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the people of any nation or language is more literally “any people, nation, or tongue.” See the Notes at 3:4, where similar words are used. In this context this phrase refers to any individual from any group of people. This includes anyone from any nation, no matter what language they spoke. Other ways to say this include:

people of every province, nation and language

anyone of any nation, race, or language (GNT)

any person from any tribe or nation, speaking any language

who say anything offensive against: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as say anything offensive against refers in a general way to speaking with lack of respect. For example:

who insults/blasphemes

who say anything slanderous about (GW)

speaks disrespectfully of (NJB)

the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: See the Notes at 3:28a. The king thought that there were many gods. He was speaking specifically of one of them, the God whom the Jewish men worshiped.

3:29c

will be cut into pieces and their houses reduced to rubble.

- If anyone disobeys, I will command my soldiers to cut their bodies into pieces and to make their houses into nothing but piles of stones.
- If someone blasphemes their God, I will have my soldiers cut off their arms and legs, and I will command my soldiers to destroy their homes.

will be cut into pieces: See the Notes at 2:5c. This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive clause. For example:

shall be torn limb from limb (RSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

I will order my servants to cut/chop them up

I will command my soldiers to cut their bodies into pieces.

The kings in the Ancient Near East were often very cruel. They punished people severely if they did not obey them.

and their houses reduced to rubble: The king said that the homes of those who disrespected the Jewish God would be destroyed. See the Notes at 2:5d. Here is another way to translate this:

his house is to be made a pile of ruins (GNT)

This is a passive clause. If it is more natural to translate this as an active clause, you can say:

and my soldiers will destroy their homes

and my servants will utterly demolish their houses

3:29d

For there is no other god who can deliver in this way.”

- I make this decree because no other god can rescue people like this.”
- I announce this law because no other divine/supernatural power is able to save people like their God can.”

For: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *For* here introduces the reason why the king made this law. People were forbidden to disrespect this God because he was great. He had shown his power by saving the three Jewish men. No other god could save as he had done. Connect this clause to the previous clause in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to leave the connection implied. For example:

There is no other god who can rescue like this.
(GNT)

there is no other god who can deliver in this way:

The king worshiped many gods who were really not gods at all. He declared that none of the gods he worshiped could do what the Jewish God had done. Other ways English versions translate this include:

No other god can rescue like this (GW)

no other god has such great power to save (CEV)

In some languages it may not be possible to speak in a general way of god or gods. It may be necessary to say “idol” or “power.” *Translator’s Handbook on Daniel*. But if you use a word meaning “idol,” you should not say “no other idol,” which would imply that the Jewish God was an idol. Instead you may be able to say:

none of our^(incl) idols can save in this way

Daniel 3:30

Section 3:1–30: God delivered Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from the fiery furnace

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The author wrote Daniel 3 in the Aramaic language. These Notes usually follow the Aramaic found in the Masoretic Text (MT). The early Greek translation of Daniel 3 is somewhat different from the Aramaic. The Greek translation includes two stories that are not in the MT. The first is called “The Prayer of Azariah” (3:24–

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Paragraph 3:28–30

In this concluding paragraph the king praised God for the miracle that had happened, and he rewarded the three Jewish men.

3:30

Then the king promoted Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego in the province of Babylon.

- Then the king gave Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego more important jobs in the province of Babylon.
- Then the king promoted Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to very high positions in the province of Babylon.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Then* here introduces the conclusion of this episode in the narrative. Introduce this concluding statement in a way that is natural in your language.

the king promoted Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: The king treated the three men well. He honored them by giving them greater power and responsibilities. He caused them to rise/advance in the government of the province. Other ways to translate this include:

the king promoted Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to higher positions (GNT)

the king gave them more important jobs

in the province of Babylon: This probably refers to the area around the city of Babylon. See the note on 2:49.

Daniel 4:1

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

The verse numbers of the BSB and most English versions are different from the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. The NJPS and NJB are two exceptions. They follow the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. Baldwin (p. 107) notes that the chapter divisions in the present Aramaic text were not necessarily those of the original text. The difference in numbering can cause confusion when citing verses in different translations. For example, Daniel 4:1 in the BSB is 3:31 in the NJPS and NJB. Daniel 4:4 is 4:1 in the NJB and NJPS, and so on. When these Notes cite verses in the NJPS and the NJB, they will give both the verse numbers in those versions and the corresponding BSB verse numbers.

Versions give different headings to Daniel 4. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar's second dream (NRSV)

Nebuchadnezzar's dream about a tree (NLT)

A letter from Nebuchadnezzar about his insanity (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed a second dream

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed about a tree

Nebuchadnezzar wrote a letter about how he became insane

Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1-18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19-27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28-33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

D. In 4:34-37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

2. Repetition: When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19-27), he repeated parts of what the king had previously told him (in 4:10-16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28-33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.

3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

6. Form: The author wrote Daniel 4 in the form of a royal proclamation. This proclamation form gives authority to the account. The style of the proclamation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.

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thor plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: “God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth.” The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:1–3

This chapter is in the form of a royal proclamation or announcement. In this first paragraph the king introduced himself as the person who was making the proclamation. He mentioned whom he was addressing and greeted them.

The king’s scribes would have written a proclamation like this on a stone or wooden slab. His servants would then have placed it where people could see and read it easily.

The verse numbers in the BSB differ from the numbers in the NJB and the NJPS. These versions begin the account at 3:31, and the paragraph ends at 3:33. So in these versions chapter 4 does not begin until 4:4 in the BSB. 4:4 in the BSB is 4:1 in the NJB. See the discussion in the Introduction to these Notes.

4:1a

King Nebuchadnezzar, To the people of every nation and language who dwell in all the earth:

- ¶ I, King Nebuchadnezzar am writing/announcing this to people from every tribe, nation, and language on earth.
- ¶ It is I, King Nebuchadnezzar, who make/issue this proclamation/announcement. It is for everyone on earth—those belonging to every tribe and nation, whatever language they speak.
- ¶ King Nebuchadnezzar send this message/proclamation to the people of all tribes and nations and every language in all the earth.

King Nebuchadnezzar: King Nebuchadnezzar explained that he was the author of this proclamation. In some languages it may therefore be natural to include a first-person reference here. For example:

I, King Nebuchadnezzar, am making this announcement.

Nebuchadnezzar was the author, but he was probably not the actual writer. In order to make this clear, you may need to add implied information. For example:

It is by the command of King Nebuchadnezzar that this proclamation is made/written.

To the people of every nation and language: The Aramaic is more literally “to all the peoples, the nations, and the languages.” The king was addressing his proclamation to everyone on earth, whatever their language. In some languages you may need to add implied information. For example:

I write this to everyone, whatever their nationality, race and language

I announce/declare this to you people belonging to every tribe, nation, and language-group

people: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as people refers to people groups, such as tribes and ethnic groups. Here is another way to translate this:

racess (GNT)

nation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as nation refers to people who have a common government.

language: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as language literally means “tongues.” Here it refers to people speaking the different languages in the world.

who dwell in all the earth: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as earth can refer to the world or to the land in the sense of the Babylonian empire. Since Nebuchadnezzar ruled most of the known world, you can translate it either way. For example:

that live in all the land (NET)

in the world (GW)

throughout the world (NLT)

General Comment on 4:1a

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this introduction separately and in the third person, rather than as part of the proclamation. For example:

King Nebuchadnezzar sent this message... (NLT)

King Nebuchadnezzar sent the following letter... (CEV)

King Nebuchadnezzar wrote to the people of all nations, tribes and speech in all the earth. He said:

4:1b

May your prosperity be multiplied.

- I wish you peace and prosperity.
- Greetings! I wish you good health and increasing wealth.

May your prosperity be multiplied: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as May your prosperity be multiplied is more literally “May your peace increase!” This expression was a standard greeting in the Babylonian culture. The idea of “peace” included both physical and material well-being, that is, both health and wealth. There are at least three ways you can translate this:

General Comment on 4:1

- Translate the Aramaic greeting. For example:

May your peace abound! (NASB)

- Translate the meaning of the Aramaic greeting. For example:

May you have abundant prosperity (NRSV)

I wish you peace and prosperity (GW)

- Use a local greeting suitable for use in a royal proclamation. For example:

Greetings! (GNT)

Peace be with/upon you!

Health and wealth be yours!

abundant prosperity

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of the information in 4:1a–b. For example:

^{1a}Greetings to the people of all nations, races, and languages in the world. I, King Nebuchadnezzar,

^{1b}wish you great prosperity.

^{1b}May peace and prosperity be ^{1a}with you who dwell in all the land—all nations, races and languages! Greetings from Nebuchadnezzar the king!

Daniel 4:2

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

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Nebuchadnezzar dreamed about a tree

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Special Problems:

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A. In 4:1–18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19–27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28–33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

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4:2a

I am pleased to declare

- I am pleased/glad to write to you
- I want to tell you

I am pleased to declare: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as I am pleased to declare is more literally “It seemed good to me to declare to you.” Nebuchadnezzar introduced what he wanted to tell his readers. Other ways to say this in English are:

I am glad to tell (CEV)

I want you to know (NLT)

I am pleased to write to you (GW)

4:2b

the signs and wonders that the Most High God has performed for me.

- about the miraculous signs and amazing things that the Most High God has done for me.
- of the wonderful miracles that the Supreme God did to help me.

the signs and wonders: The two Aramaic words that the BSB translates as signs and wonders are close synonyms. These two words also occur together in 6:27. The use of two words emphasizes the idea. The two words do not refer to different or separate events. There are at least two ways to translate this expression:

- Use two words or phrases. For example:

the miraculous signs and amazing things (GW)

miracles and wonderful things

- Use one expression. For example:

wonderful miracles (AB)

miraculous signs^{ft} Translator’s Handbook on Daniel

signs: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as signs refers to things that God does to show his power—signs of his power.

wonders: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wonders also refers to strange and unusual things God does to show his power. It is a close synonym to “signs.”

the Most High God: See the Notes at 3:26b. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Most High comes from the adjective that means “highest.” The king referred to God as the God who was the “highest,” that is, greater than all other gods. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel, however, says that the title “expresses the greatness of this God without necessarily stressing that he is greater than all other gods.” Here is another way to translate this:

Supreme God (GNT)

has performed for me: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as performed means “done, made.” God had done some amazing deeds to show the king his power. Other ways to say this in English are:

did for me (GW)

has worked for me (NRSV)

General Comment on 4:2a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 4:2a–b. For example:

^bThe Most High God has done ^amiracles and wonderful things for me that I am happy to tell you about. (NCV)

Daniel 4:3

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

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4:3

This verse is written in poetic form. If you have a special way of indicating that this is poetic speech, you can use it here. For example, some versions indent these lines or use different kinds of type.

There are two pairs of parallel lines in this verse. The first part of each pair is followed by a second part that says the same thing in a different way.

4:3a

How great are His signs,

- The signs he has given/performed are very great!
- I praise him for his wonderful signs!
- He has shown me amazing signs!

How great are His signs: The king praised God for the signs that God had showed him. These signs were great. That is, they were very impressive or wonderful. Other ways to translate this include:

His wonderful acts are great (NCV)

Your language may have a different way to express this kind of praise. It may be natural to supply a verb. For example:

I praise him because he performs great signs

Praise him for his great miracles!

great: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as great in this context means “imposing, amazing, unusual.” Here is another way to translate this:

impressive (GW)

signs: See the Notes at 4:2. The GW says explicitly:

miraculous signs (GW)

4:3b

how mighty His wonders!

- The miracles he has done are powerful!
- I praise him for his wonderful works!
- He has performed mighty miracles!

how mighty His wonders!: The king praised God for the wonderful things God had done. This is very similar in meaning to 4:3a. Other ways to translate it include:

and his miracles are mighty (NCV)

He uses his power to do amazing things (GW)

I praise God for his powerful wonders/miracles!

mighty: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mighty means “strong.” Here is another way to translate this:

powerful (NLT)

wonders: See the Notes at 4:2b, where the same word is used. In some languages it may be natural to use a verb here. For example:

the wonderful/miraculous things he has done

General Comment on 4:3a–b

In Aramaic, the repetition of ideas makes a natural poetic form suitable for songs or exclamations of praise. But in some languages it may not be natural to repeat the same idea in two different ways. If that is true in your language, you may be able to combine 4:3a–b into one clause. For example:

His miracles are mighty and marvelous. (CEV)

4:3c**His kingdom is an eternal kingdom;**

- He has authority to rule forever.
- He will reign forever,

His kingdom is an eternal kingdom: The king continued to praise God. He exclaimed that God's kingdom will last forever. God will never cease to rule as king over his people. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the idea kingdom as a verb. For example:

He will rule forever (CEV)

His kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as His kingdom in this context refers to God's authority to rule. God will always have the power and authority to reign.

eternal: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as eternal in this context means "for limitless, unending time." Here is another way to translate this:

everlasting (RSV)

4:3d**His dominion endures from generation to generation.**

- He reigns over each new generation of people.
- the lord/king over us and our children and their children and all who are yet to come/live.

The Aramaic text connects this verse part to the previous verse part with the common conjunction that is often translated as "and." In this context it introduces a parallel line of poetry that says the same thing in a different way. The BSB has not translated it. Introduce this parallel line of poetry in a way that is natural in your language.

His dominion endures from generation to generation: This line repeats the meaning of the previous line, but with a different emphasis. Here the king emphasized that God will continually rule people, from one generation of people to the next, now and forever.

His dominion: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates His dominion means "God's rule." It is synonymous with "His kingdom." See the Notes at 4:3c. It may be natural to translate this with a verb phrase. For example:

he will rule

he will reign

generation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as generation refers to an age group. Parents are one generation, their children another, and their grandchildren another. God will rule over each new age group that is born. There are at least two ways to say this:

General Comment on 4:3c–d

- Translate literally. For example:

God will reign over each new generation

His sovereignty endures through all generations (REB)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

he will rule for all time (GNT)

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^{3c-d}God will rule forever over each new generation

Daniel 4:4**Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar**

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Paragraph 4:4-7

Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream and summoned the wise men of Babylon. They were unable to explain the meaning of his dream. Before you translate this paragraph, read Genesis 40 and Genesis 41:1-2, where there are descriptions of similar events that took place in ancient Egypt.

4:4a-b

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was at ease in my house and flourishing in my palace: Daniel 4:4a-b gives the background to the account that begins in 4:5. The two parts of the verse are in Aramaic poetic form, with the second line repeating the basic meaning of the first. It literally says:

I Nebuchadnezzar was at ease in my house

and I was flourishing/prospering in my palace

Some English versions translate this form closely. For example:

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was living at ease in my home and prospering in my palace. (NRSV)

The NIV has reordered the information and made it clear that “my home” and “my palace” refer to the same location.

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was at home in my palace (NIV)

Other versions that combine these parallel lines include:

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was happy and successful at my palace. (NCV)

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was living in my palace in comfort and prosperity. (NLT)

You should order the information in these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

4:4a

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was at ease in my house

- ¶ I, Nebuchadnezzar was living in my palace.
- ¶ At that time, I lived in my great/royal house/mansion

I, Nebuchadnezzar, was at ease in my house: The king told his account in the first person. See the note above on 4:4a-b and the General Comment. The king introduced his narrative by giving background information: at the time the story began he was living in his palace home in comfort. Here is another way to translate this:

I, Nebuchadnezzar was living comfortably in my house (NJB)

I, Nebuchadnezzar: The king said his name in order to emphasize his authority. In some languages it may not be natural for a person to state his name after saying I. If that is true in your language, you may need to translate this as:

I the king

Translate in a way that is natural in your language and that puts the same emphasis on the king’s authority.

at ease: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as at ease probably means “calm, relaxed.” Other ways to translate this include:

living comfortably (GW)

happy (NCV)

contented (NIV)

4:4b

and flourishing in my palace.

- I was comfortable and successful/wealthy.
- in peace and prosperity.

flourishing: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as flourishing means “thriving, flourishing.” The word is sometimes used to describe a healthy tree with many leaves. There may have been an intentional double meaning. Later in the dream, Nebuchadnezzar is represented by a tree. In this context, the word is used figuratively to describe a person who is doing well in a worldly or material sense. Here is another way to translate this:

successful (NCV)

in my palace: A palace is the home of a ruler. The word implies luxury and wealth. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

in my luxurious house

living in my royal house

Daniel 4:5

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

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Paragraph 4:4–7

Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream and summoned the wise men of Babylon. They were unable to explain the meaning of his dream. Before you translate this paragraph, read Genesis 40 and Genesis 41:1–2, where there are descriptions of similar events that took place in ancient Egypt.

4:5

This verse is also in poetic form, with two parts or lines. The second part, 4:5b, repeats the meaning of the first part, 4:5a, but also adds more information. Both parts describe the same event.

4:5a

I had a dream, and it frightened me;

- Then I dreamed something that frightened me.
- But one night I had/dreamed a terrifying dream.

I had a dream, and it frightened me: The fear that the king describes in this verse contrasts with the peace he described in the previous verse. In some languages it may be helpful to make this contrast clear. For example, you may supply a connector:

But one night I had a dream that frightened me
(NLT)

I had a dream: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as I had a dream is literally “I saw a dream.” Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to dreaming in one’s sleep. See how you translated the word dream in 2:1a and 2:3a.

and it frightened me: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as frightened me indicates that what Nebuchadnezzar saw in his dream caused him to feel very frightened. Use the expression that is natural in your language for describing the effect of a bad dream or nightmare. For example:

which terrified me (GW)

that greatly frightened me (NLT)

that scared me (NET)

4:5b

while in my bed, the images and visions in my mind alarmed me.

- As I was asleep in bed, I saw/had dreams and visions that horrified me.
- What I saw in my/those nightmares filled me with fear/dread.

4:5b is parallel to 4:5a. It says the same thing in a different way.

while in my bed: In Daniel’s time, people usually explained where they were when they had an important dream. See also 2:28c. In some languages, some of this information may be implied by the context. If that is true in your language, you may not have to translate this information directly. For example, you may be able to say:

while I was asleep (GNT)

as I was sleeping

the images and visions in my mind: The Aramaic words that the BSB translates as images and visions are synonyms in this context. They are also synonyms of the word “dream” in 4:5a.

images: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as images means “appearances, fantasies.” It refers generally to something a person might imagine or think about. You may be able to say:

pictures (NCV)

things I imagined (NET)

fantasies (REB)

visions in my mind: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as visions in my mind is literally “the visions of my head.” In some languages the expression in my mind is implied by the word visions. If that is true in your language, you may omit this phrase. For example:

visions (GNT)

alarmed me: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as alarmed is a synonym to the verb “frightened” in 4:5a. The king saw visions that frightened him. Some other translation models include:

terrified me (NIV)

tormented me (NJB)

I saw...terrifying visions (GNT)

General Comment on 4:4a–b

In some languages you may not have three different words with similar meanings like “dreams,” “images,” and “visions.” If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate using one or two terms. For example:

One night as I lay on my bed I had a dream that tormented me. What I saw was terrifying.

Daniel 4:6

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:4-7

Nebuchadnezzar had a disturbing dream and summoned the wise men of Babylon. They were unable to explain the meaning of his dream. Before you translate this paragraph, read Genesis 40 and Genesis 41:1-2, where there are descriptions of similar events that took place in ancient Egypt.

4:6a

So I issued a decree that all the wise men of Babylon be brought before me

- Therefore I ordered all the wise advisers of Babylon to appear/come before me
- Therefore I told my servants to bring all the experts/scholars of Babylon to me

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces a result clause. This clause tells what the king did as a result of seeing the dream and becoming afraid. Introduce this result in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

Therefore (RSV)

I issued a decree: The king issued an order, a royal command or decree. Here the Aramaic is literally “from me a decree was issued.” Other ways to translate this include:

I ordered (GW, GNT)

I decreed (NJB)

I commanded (NIV)

that all the wise men of Babylon be brought before me: This is the content of the king’s order or decree. The king’s servants were to bring all the wise men of Babylon into his presence. In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech. See the General Comment on 4:6a–c for a suggestion of how to do this.

all the wise men of Babylon be brought before me: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural to use an active verb you may be able to:

- use an indefinite subject. For example:

they (indefinite) should bring to me all the wise men of Babylon

- use an intransitive form. For example:

all the wise men of Babylon must come to me

- supply a subject. For example:

my servants should bring all the wise men of Babylon to me

the wise men: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the wise men refers to a class of men with certain responsibilities. They were professional advisers to the king and experts in various occult practices. See the Notes at 2:12b, 2:27. In this context, this expression may be a general term for all of the king’s religious experts and advisers. Here is another way to translate this:

the royal advisers (GNT)

Babylon: Here this term probably refers to the whole kingdom, and not only the capital city with that same name. Here is another way to translate this:

Babylonia (CEV)

4:6b to interpret the dream for me.

- in order that they might interpret/explain my dream for/to me.
- so that they could tell me what my dream meant.

to interpret the dream for me: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as to here introduces the purpose of bringing the wise men to the king. The king wanted them to explain to him the meaning of his dream. See Genesis 41:8, where there is a similar situation. This is a purpose clause. Other ways to translate it include:

to tell me the dream’s meaning (GW)

so they could tell me what my dream meant (NLT)

so that one of them might tell me what the dream meant
See the Translator’s Handbook on Daniel.

interpret the dream: See the Notes at 2:5b. The verb that the BSB translates as interpret means “inform, tell.” The king wanted the wise men to tell or explain to him the meaning of his dream. He thought it must have some connection to real life, but he did not know what it was. Here is another way to translate this:

make known...the interpretation of the dream
(NRSV)

General Comment on 4:6a–c

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king’s command as direct speech. For example:

^{6a}So I gave/issued this decree/order: ^{6b}“All the wise men of Babylon are to be brought before me ^{6c}so that they can tell me what the dream means.”

^{6a}So I commanded, ^{6b}“Bring all the Babylonian wise men into my presence. ^{6c}I want them to interpret my dream for me.”

Daniel 4:7

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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4:7a

When the magicians, enchanters, astrologers, and diviners came in,

- When they all arrived, the fortunetellers, the spell/charm makers, the astrologers, and the wizards/sorcerers,
- So all the experts/scholars arrived, including the specialists in magic, in dreams, and in divination.

When the magicians, enchanters, astrologers, and diviners came in: The various experts in the occult and magical practices arrived. They went to the king so that he could speak to them.

When: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as When here introduces the next event in a sequence or the next phase of the action. Here is another way to translate this:

Then (RSV)

the magicians: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the magicians refers to people who used the occult to obtain knowledge, learn secrets, or tell the future. Translate in the same way you did at 1:20b. See the Notes at 1:20b; 2:2a.

enchanters: The enchanters were people who knew how to cast spells or who could interpret omens. Translate the same way you did in 1:20b. See the Notes at 1:20b and 2:2a.

astrologers: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as astrologers is literally “Chaldeans,” as in the RSV. The word has several different meanings. In this context, it refers to men who were experts in the occult and magical rites. See the Notes at 2:2a and translate here the same way you did there.

diviners: See the Notes at 2:27. This expression probably refers to people who used occult means to try to know what would happen to people in the future. Here is another way to translate this:

fortunetellers (NLT)

came in: In this context, the verb came refers to the fact that the men entered the king’s court. Here is another way to translate this:

came to me (GW)

General Comment on 4:7a

The job titles are probably examples of the various kinds of experts whom the king summoned. Your language may not have a specific term for each of these experts. If that is true in your language, you may have to use one term for two or three of the names listed here. Another option is to begin the list with a general expression. For example:

all the occult experts , including the astrologers and the fortunetellers

For similar lists of experts see the Notes at 1:20b and 2:2a, 1:10c, 1:27.

4:7b

I told them the dream, and they could not interpret it for me.

- I told them about my dream, but they were not able to tell me its meaning/interpretation.
- I told them what I had dreamed, but they could not explain to me what the dream meant.

I told them the dream: Nebuchadnezzar told the experts what had happened in his dream. The author does not repeat this information. In some languages it may be necessary to identify this dream in some way. For example:

I told them my terrifying dream

I told them what I had just dreamed

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *and* here introduces a contrast, something that is against expectation. Although Nebuchadnezzar told the wise men his dream, they could not tell him its meaning. Here is another way to translate this:

but (NIV)

they could not interpret it for me: The king's experts were unable to explain the meaning of the king's dream. See the Notes at 2:5b. Other possible ways to translate this expression include:

they could not tell me its interpretation (NRSV)

they could not tell me what it meant (NLT)

they could not explain it to me (GNT)

Daniel 4:8

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D. In 4:34–37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

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from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.

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4. **Commands:** In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.
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Paragraph 4:8–9

Daniel went before the king in order to tell him the meaning of his dream.

4:8a

But at last, into my presence came Daniel

- ¶ Finally, Daniel came to me.
- ¶ Last of all, Daniel came to speak to me.

But at last: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as But at last here refers to the end of a period of time. Here is another way to translate this:

Finally (NIV)

into my presence came Daniel: Daniel entered the king’s court, where he could talk to the king. See the Notes at 4:7a. The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as into my presence is literally “before me.” It implies that Daniel had come to speak to someone who had a higher status.

4:8b–c

The BSB has placed 4:8b–c in parentheses to indicate that this is parenthetical information. It is not part of the main storyline. Nebuchadnezzar was telling his people some information about Daniel that he wanted them to know. Indicate that this parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language. The NRSV, for example, uses dashes.

4:8b

(whose name is Belteshazzar after the name of my god,

- (I had given Daniel the name Belteshazzar after the name of my god,
- (Daniel’s Babylonian name was Belteshazzar. I had named him after Bel, the god I worship,

whose name is Belteshazzar after the name of my god: Nebuchadnezzar explained that Daniel’s Babylonian name was Belteshazzar. The king had given him this name in honor of a god he himself worshiped, Bel. See the notes on 1:7b.

whose name is Belteshazzar: This is a passive clause. There are several ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

he who was named Belteshazzar (NRSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

whom I named Belteshazzar

- Using a form of the verb “to be”: For example:

His Babylonian/new name is Belteshazzar.

after the name of my god: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as after the name of my god is more literally “like the name of my god.” The main god whom Nebuchadnezzar worshiped was called Bel, which means “lord.” This was another name for the Babylonian false god Marduk. You may want to put this information in a footnote. Other ways to translate this include:

after my god (NLT)

after my god Bel (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

I called him Belteshazzar to honor my god (NCV)

my god: Nebuchadnezzar worshiped a false god whom he called Bel, that is, “lord.” It may be natural to make this relationship clear by translating the phrase my god as:

Bel , the god/idol that I worship

4:8c

and in whom is the spirit of the holy gods).

- and the spirit of the holy gods lives in him.)
- because the sacred gods/deities have given him their spirit.)

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces more parenthetical information about Daniel.

in whom is the spirit of the holy gods: This clause probably refers to Daniel’s special wisdom. The king was praising Daniel. He realized that Daniel’s ability to understand dreams and visions was supernatural.

Daniel understood things that only divine beings can know.

Since we do not know exactly what Nebuchadnezzar was thinking, it is best to translate this literally. Remember that the king thought that there were many gods.

the holy gods: The word holy is a key term in the Old Testament. In this context, it describes the gods as separate, distinct from human beings. They are set apart as sacred and belong to the supernatural realm. You may be able to translate this as:

the gods, who are far/separate from us

the gods, who live above

the gods on high

gods: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as gods is in the plural. King Nebuchadnezzar believed that there were many different gods.

4:8d

And I told him the dream:

- And I told him my dream.
- I told him what I had dreamed about.

And I told him the dream: The king told Daniel what he had seen in his dream. Other ways to translate this include:

I told my dream to him (NCV)

I told him what I had dreamed (GNT)

I recounted the dream for him as well (NET)

Daniel 4:9

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

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Paragraph 4:8–9

Daniel went before the king in order to tell him the meaning of his dream.

4:9a

“O Belteshazzar, chief of the magicians,

- ¶ I said, “Belteshazzar, you are the chief of my expert advisers.
- ¶ Then I said to him, “Belteshazzar, I have appointed you as the head of my counselors.

Belteshazzar: The king addressed Daniel by his Babylonian name.

chief of the magicians: In 2:48c, the king appointed Daniel to be in charge of all the wise men of Babylon. In this verse, the king addressed Daniel as chief of the magicians. Probably the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as magicians is being used here in a general way to refer to the royal advisers and experts. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as magicians is the same word as in 1:20b; 2:2a; and the first word in the list in 4:7a. Here it probably has a more general meaning. You may be able to translate this as:

chief of the royal advisers

leading counselor

chief: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as chief here refers to someone with authority over others. Other ways to translate it include:

head (GW)

the most important (NCV)

4:9b

I know that the spirit of the holy gods is in you

- I know that the spirit of the holy gods lives in you
- I realize that the sacred gods/deities have given you their spirit of special power/ability

In the Aramaic text this verse begins with a connector that the RSV translates as “because.” In this context it introduces the reason or grounds for the king’s request in 4:9d. Translate this relation in the most natural way in your language. See the General Comment on 4:9b–d.

I know that the spirit of the holy gods is in you:

See the Notes at 4:8c. Now the king told Daniel his thoughts about him. In some languages it may be natural to translate the king’s thoughts as direct speech. For example:

I understand this: ‘The spirit of the holy gods is in you...’

4:9c

and that no mystery baffles you.

- so no mystery is too difficult for you to understand.
- to understand/solve even the deepest/hardest mysteries.

and that no mystery baffles you: This is a second thing that the king knew or understood about Daniel. There was no mystery that he could not solve or explain. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this expression as a positive clause. For example:

you understand all mysteries (GNT)

you are able to solve the most difficult mysteries

mystery: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mystery is only used here and in Daniel 2. It refers to a secret, something that only God could reveal. Use the word that you used in 2:18a and see the note there.

baffles you: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates baffles normally means “oppress.” The king used the word in a figurative way to emphasize that Daniel had great abilities. No mystery was too hard for him to solve and explain. Other ways to translate this include:

is too difficult for you (NIV)

puzzles you

too great for you to solve (NLT)

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

4:9d

So explain to me the visions I saw in my dream, and their interpretation.

- This is my dream: tell me its meaning.
- So explain to me what this dream of mine means.

So explain to me the visions I saw in my dream, and their interpretation: Scholars disagree on the original wording and meaning of this verse part. The expression is more literally: “the visions of my dream which I saw and its interpretation tell.” However, the king did not ask Daniel to tell him the content of his dream as he had in chapter 2. He himself told Daniel what he had dreamed. As a result, some versions supply implied information or suggest changes to the Aramaic text. There are four possibilities:

1. The text originally said, “Here is my dream; tell me its interpretation.” For example:

This is my dream. Tell me what it means. (GNT)
(NIV, RSV, NJB, GNT, NCV)

1. The text originally said, “Hear/Consider my dream and interpret it. For example:

Hear the dream that I saw; tell me its interpretation. (NRSV) (NRSV, REB, NET, CEV)

1. The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here means “even” or “that is.” See Benjamin Davidson, *The Analytical Hebrew and Chaldee Lexicon*, p. 233, meaning VIII. So the text means, “Tell/Explain my dream, that is, its interpretation.” For example:

Tell me the meaning of the visions I had in my dream. (GW) (BSB, GW, NLT)

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tell me the visions of my dream that I saw and its interpretation (ESV) (NASB, KJV, ESV)

Either (1), (2), or (3) is possible. You may wish to follow your local majority-language version here. Interpretation (4) is unlikely because the king proceeded to tell the dream himself.

General Comment on 4:9b–d

In some languages it may be natural to indicate that 4:9b–c give the grounds of the king’s request in 4:9d by following the CEV:

^{9b}the holy gods have given you special powers ^{9c}to solve the most difficult mysteries. ^{9d}So listen to what I dreamed and tell me what it means:... (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the verse parts and translate the request (4:9d) before the grounds for that request (4:9b–c). For example:

^{9a}I said “Belteshazzar, chief of my expert advisers!
^{9d}Tell me the meaning of my dream! ^{9b}For the holy gods have given you a spirit ^{9c}that understands all such mysteries.

Daniel 4:10

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:10–12

Nebuchadnezzar described the tree he had seen in his dream.

4:10a**In these visions of my mind as I was lying in bed,**

- ¶ This is what I dreamed while I was asleep in my bed:
- ¶ In my dream,

In these visions of my mind as I was lying in bed:

The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as In these visions of my mind as I was lying in bed is more literally “the visions of my head on my bed.” This phrase introduces Nebuchadnezzar’s account of his dream. The BSB has supplied the words In these, as is natural in English. Other ways to translate this include:

Here are the visions of my mind while I was on my bed. (NET)

While I was lying in my bed, this is what I dreamed. (NLT)

While I was asleep, I had a vision of... (GNT)

The expression points ahead to the retelling of the dream that begins in 4:10b. Translate it in a way that is natural for introducing such an account.

as I was lying in bed: In some languages it may be natural to indicate that the king was asleep. You may wish to leave implied the information that he was in bed. For example:

while I was asleep (GW)

4:10b**I saw this come to pass: There was a tree in the midst of the land,**

- I dreamed that there was a tree, standing/growing in the middle of the earth.
- I saw a tree. It was in the very center of the world,

I saw this come to pass: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as I saw this come to pass here introduces a retelling of a dream. See the Notes at 2:31, where the same expression is used. If your language has a special way to introduce a dream, you may be able to use it here. The following are some ways English versions translate this:

I was looking and I saw (GW)

I looked, and there in front of me (NCV)

this come to pass: See the Notes at 2:31. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as come to pass often introduces something new or unexpected. It directs the reader to give attention to what the speaker is about to say. If you have an equivalent word in your language, you can use it here. Here is another way to translate this:

there before me (NIV)

There was a tree in the midst of the land: In his dream Nebuchadnezzar saw a tree. It was upright. That is, it was growing, planted in the ground. And it was in a central or prominent position. In some languages it may be natural to say:

in the middle of the land a tree was growing

in the very center of the land there was a tree

a tree: A tree was a common symbol in the Old Testament. In this context the tree is a symbol of the king, who protects and provides for his people. See Isaiah 11:1; 53:2; Ezekiel 31 (The pharaoh is compared to a tree of Lebanon); Ezekiel 17:1–10 (David’s dynasty is compared to a cedar of Lebanon). The text does not say what kind of tree the king saw. In some languages it may be necessary to be specific. If this is so in your language, you should indicate that it was a type of fruit-bearing deciduous tree.

in the midst of the land: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as in the midst of the land indicates that the tree was in a central or prominent location. It was growing in a place where everyone could see it.

the land: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as land can mean ground, country, earth, or world, depending on the context. Here the context suggests that it refers to everywhere that was under Nebuchadnezzar’s power. This included most of the world known at that time. Use the expression that is natural in your language here. For example:

the earth (GNT)

the world (CEV)

**4:10c
and its height was great.**

- It was very tall.
- and it was huge.

its height was great: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as height refers to the distance from the bottom of an object to the top. The height of the tree was very great. That is, the tree was very tall. See the Notes on 2:31 referring to the tall statue of the king. Other ways to translate this include:

Its height was enormous (NIV)

It was very tall (NCV)

a huge tree (GNT)

Daniel 4:11

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.
6. Form: The author wrote Daniel 4 in the form of a royal proclamation. This proclamation form gives authority to the account. The style of the proclamation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.
7. Key Terms: Two key terms in Daniel 4 are “earth” and “heaven.” Both words have more than one meaning. The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “earth” can mean either “ground,” “land,” or “world.” The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “heaven” can mean either “sky” or “where God lives.” In 4:26 the author used the word “Heaven” to refer to God himself. The author plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: “God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth.” The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:10–12

Nebuchadnezzar described the tree he had seen in his dream.

4:11a

The tree grew large and strong; its top reached the sky,

- It became tall and strong, and its top seemed to touch the sky/clouds.
- It grew so big and sturdy that it reached the sky/heavens

The tree grew large and strong: The tree was already tall, so in some languages it may be natural to say:

The tree grew taller and stronger. (NJB)

its top reached the sky: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as reached here indicates that the tree appeared to reach or touch the sky. This can be understood as a figurative way of saying that the tree was very tall. However, since this was a dream, it is possible that this is how it did appear to Nebuchadnezzar. Nebuchadnezzar probably believed the sky to be a flat surface, so he probably dreamed in those terms. A literal translation is therefore acceptable. Here is another way to translate this:

its top touched the sky (NIV)

Translate in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

it became...tall enough to reach the sky (GW)

its top: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as its top is the same as in 4:10c, where it is translated as “its height.”

the sky: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the sky has two possible meanings:

1. The literal sky. In ancient thinking, the sky was a flat surface stretched out some distance above the earth. The stars were thought of as holes in this surface, holes that allowed in light from beyond the sky itself. For example:

its height reached the sky (NASB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, NJB, REB, NET, GW, NCV, NLT)

1. The place where God lives, heaven. For example:

its top reached to heaven (NRSV) (KJV, RSV/NRSV, ESV, CEV)

Some of the versions listed supporting interpretation (2) may be using “heaven” in a figurative way, as is common in poetry.

Nebuchadnezzar himself probably thought that the gods lived in the sky. So the two interpretations are not too different in this context. However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That probably best represents what Nebuchadnezzar saw in his dream. However, if it is more natural in your language to say “heaven” in this context, in a dream narrative, that is also acceptable.

General Comment on 4:11a

In some languages it may be natural to make a close connection between the clauses in 4:11a. For example:

It became strong enough and tall enough to reach the sky. (GW)

It grew bigger and bigger until it reached the sky. (GNT)

4:11b

and it was visible to the ends of the earth.

- Everyone on earth could see it.
- and could be seen all over the world.

it was visible to the ends of the earth: People all over the world could see this tree. In Nebuchadnezzar’s dream this was possible because the earth or world was probably flat. So something tall standing in the center could be seen everywhere.

it was visible: The phrase it was visible means “it could be seen.” If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you may say:

everyone in the world could see it

people could see it from anywhere on earth

to the ends of the earth: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates the ends of the earth is an idiom. It refers to the farthest place on earth. The word that the BSB translates as the earth here is the same word as that translated as “the land” in 4:10b. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

- Translate the idiom. For example:

the end of the whole earth (RSV)

- Translate the meaning of the idiom. For example:

from anywhere on earth (NCV)

everywhere on earth (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that it was people living in the far parts of the earth who could see the tree. For example:

to people who lived everywhere on earth

could be seen by everyone in the world (GNT)

General Comment on 4:11a–b

It was because the tree was so tall that people could see it from all over the world. In some languages it may be natural to make this connection explicit. For example:

reaching high into the heavens for all the world to see (NLT)

The top of the tree touched the sky and so it could be seen from anywhere on earth (similar to NCV)

until it reached to heaven and could be seen from anywhere on earth (CEV)

Daniel 4:12

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

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Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1-18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

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3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

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thor plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: “God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth.” The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:10–12

Nebuchadnezzar described the tree he had seen in his dream.

4:12a

Its leaves were beautiful, its fruit was abundant,

- Its leaves were beautiful and it had/produced lots of fruit.
- It had green, healthy leaves and much fruit,

Its leaves were beautiful: The leaves of this great tree were healthy, green, and flourishing. Describe the leaves on a healthy tree in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

It had fresh green leaves (NLT)

its fruit was abundant: There was a lot of fruit on this tree. Other ways to translate this include:

it had plenty of good fruit on it (NCV)

it was loaded down with fruit (GNT)

heavy with fruit (CEV)

4:12b

and upon it was food for all.

- There was enough food to feed everyone.
- enough/plenty for everyone.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces a result. The tree bore a lot of fruit, so there was enough food for everyone. In some languages it may be natural to say:

and so

upon it was food for all: This clause emphasizes the great amount of fruit. The tree provided plenty of food, enough to feed everyone. Other ways to translate this include:

enough food for everyone (NCV)

enough for the whole world to eat (GNT)

for all: The expression that the BSB translates for all is a general term that can refer to all living beings. In this context, it seems to refer more specifically to people. Here is another way to translate this:

everyone (GW)

General Comment on 4:12a–b

In some languages it may be natural to link the last clause of 4:12a and 4:12b closely together. There was so much fruit that there was plenty for everyone. For example:

it was loaded with fruit for all to eat (NLT)

its fruit was so plentiful that it could feed everyone on earth

it bore so much fruit that everyone on earth could eat from it

4:12c

Under it the beasts of the field found shelter,

- Wild animals lived in its shade. (NLT)
- The tree provided shade/shelter for wild animals.

Under it the beasts of the field found shelter: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates found shelter here indicates that the wild animals were sheltered and protected from the sun by the branches of the tree. The tree provided them with a shady place to rest. In some languages it may be natural to make the tree the subject of this clause. For example:

for the wild animals it provided shade (NJB)

the beasts of the field: This Aramaic expression, which the BSB translates literally, refers in general to animals that do not live in barns, cages, or other man-made structures. Refer to such animals in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the wild beasts (REB)

the wild animals (NIV)

4:12d

in its branches the birds of the air nested,

- Birds lived/nested in its branches.
- Birds built their nests on its branches.

in its branches the birds of the air nested: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as in its branches the birds of the air nested means that various birds made their nests in the great tree. Other ways to translate this include:

birds built nests in its branches (GNT)

The birds of heaven nested in its branches (NJB)

and birds nested in its branches (NLT)

the birds of the air: This Aramaic expression, which the BSB translates literally as the birds of the air, refers to wild birds, birds that fly around freely, as opposed to birds kept for food, like chickens.

4:12e

and from it every creature was fed.

- Every living being found/received their food on/from the tree.
- The tree provided food for all the people and animals.

and from it every creature was fed: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

Every living being ate food from the tree.

All animals and people got/obtained food from the tree.

And the tree provided food for all the people and animals on the earth

every creature: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as every creature is more literally “all flesh.” It probably refers to all living beings in general, including people, animals, and birds. Other ways to translate this include:

all living beings (NRSV)

all living creatures (NJB)

All the world (NLT)

In some languages it may be necessary to mention the different types of creature separately. For example:

all people, all birds, and all animals

Daniel 4:13

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:13–16

In this paragraph the king continued to tell Daniel his dream.

4:13a

As I lay on my bed, I also saw in the visions of my mind

- ¶ “I lay in my bed, still dreaming,
- ¶ “Next, in my dream

As I lay on my bed, I also saw in the visions of my mind:

This expression introduces a new part of the king’s dream. Some languages may have a special way to introduce a new part of a dream or vision. If that is true in your language, you may use that way here. The BSB uses the word *also* to indicate that this is a new part of the king’s dream. The following are some other ways English versions do this:

Then as I lay there dreaming (NLT)

As I was looking at those things...I saw (NCV)

I watched the visions passing through my head as
I lay in bed: ...Next... (NJB[4:10])

As I lay on my bed: See the Notes at 2:28c and 4:5b. The phrase also occurs at 4:10a.

I also saw in the visions of my mind: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the visions of my mind is literally “the visions of my head.” See the Notes at 4:5b. The phrase also occurs at 4:10a. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language for referring to dreams that come during sleep.

4:13b

a watcher, a holy one,

- and suddenly there appeared a watcher, an angel,
- I saw an angel of God, alert and watchful.

4:13a-b

I also saw in the visions of my mind a watcher, a holy one: While the king was dreaming about the tree, a figure appeared in his dream. This figure was apparently human-like in form. It is described as a watcher and a holy one.

a watcher, a holy one: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as a watcher, a holy one, is literally “a watcher and a holy one.” The two Aramaic terms refer to the same being. They are two different descriptions of the one human-like figure that the king saw. In your translation, it is important that your readers do not think that there were two different beings. It may be necessary to combine the terms into one expression. For example:

A holy angel (CEV)

A holy watcher (NRSV)

an angel, alert and watchful (GNT)

a watcher: This expression is one of a number of expressions in Daniel referring to heavenly beings. For example, “angel” (3:28); “one of those who were standing there [before God]” (7:16); “Michael, one of the chief princes” (10:13). The term may refer to a special class of angels. Just as human kings had watchmen, so God had supernatural watchmen who provided for and controlled his heavenly kingdom. English versions have translated this expression in different ways. For example, you may:

- Translate literally. For example:

watcher (NRSV)

an observer (NCV)

- Describe what the watcher does. For example:

alert and watchful (GNT)

messenger (NIV)

- Indicate who the watcher was. For example:

A holy angel (CEV)

a holy one: In this context the Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as holy explains who the watcher was, rather than his moral character. He was a holy one, a being who came from God and belonged to God. See also the discussion in the Notes at 4:8c. The same word is used in the plural to refer to angels in Psalm 89:7. See how you translated it there. For example:

angel (GNT)

of/from God

one of God’s holy ones

4:13c

coming down from heaven.

- who came down from heaven.
- He came from God in heaven.

coming down from heaven: This expression describes “the holy one, the messenger.” This holy one came from heaven.

heaven: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as heaven can refer to the sky and to God’s home. The king believed that God lived in the sky, so in this context both are true. In the dream the king probably saw the angel coming from the sky. But the important point is that the angel came from God. So it is good to follow the majority of English translations and use a word that refers to God’s dwelling place.

Daniel 4:14

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:13–16

In this paragraph the king continued to tell Daniel his dream.

4:14–16

In these verses the messenger/watcher made a number of commands. He was speaking with authority as a holy one from God. The text implies that the things that he commanded were certain to happen. However, the text does not identify to whom he was talking. The notes will suggest ways to translate these commands.

Compare the commands in Genesis 1:9, 11, 20, 22, 24. Here God gave commands to non-human creatures and non-living objects. His commands were authoritative: the commands themselves caused the actions to take place.

4:14a

He called out in a loud voice: ‘Cut down the tree and chop off its branches;

- He shouted, ‘Cut^(plur) down the tree and cut off its branches.
- In a loud voice he declared, ‘They must cut down the tree and remove its branches.
- He spoke with strength and said, ‘The tree must be chopped down and its branches cut off.

He called out in a loud voice: The Aramaic literally has two verbs, as in the RSV (“He cried aloud and said

thus”). The two verbs of speech emphasize that this was an important announcement. The holy one spoke with authority. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this idea using only one verb, as the BSB has done. For example:

He shouted (NJB)

He proclaimed in a loud voice (GNT)

Cut down the tree: The holy one did not say who was to cut down the tree. There are at least two ways to translate this command:

- Translate it as a direct command. The holy one gave an order to cut down the tree. The command is in the plural. The addressee is not in focus. For example:

Chop^(plur) the tree down!

Let the tree be cut down! Compare Genesis 1:3, 9, 11, and throughout Genesis 1.

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. The holy one was telling what must happen because God had decided that it would happen.

They (indefinite) must chop down the tree.

The tree is to be cut down.

The tree will be cut down.

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next command.

chop off its branches: There are at least two ways to translate this expression:

- Translate it as a command. The holy one commanded some people to cut off the branches from the tree. Again, the text does not say who the watcher was speaking to. For example:

trim off its branches (NIV)

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. For example:

They (indefinite) must cut its branches off.

Its branches are to be cut off.

Its branches will be lopped off.

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

4:14b

strip off its leaves and scatter its fruit.

- Tear^(plur) off all its leaves and scatter/waste its fruit.
- They must pull off its leaves and throw its fruit to the ground.
- Its leaves must be torn off and its fruit thrown/tossed away.

strip off its leaves: The holy one continued to issue commands that further destroy the tree. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as strip off means to shake or tear off the leaves. HALOT, 1936. This word only occurs here in Daniel 4:14. Again there are at least two ways to translate this:

- Translate it as a direct command. The holy one commanded others to shake off or remove the leaves from the tree. For example:

shake off its leaves (NLT)

- Translate it as an authoritative declaration. For example:

They (indefinite) must strip off its leaves.

Its leaves are to be torn off.

Its leaves will be stripped away.

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. Again, the people being addressed are not in focus.

and scatter its fruit: The action is destructive. There are two ways to translate this idea:

- Translate it as a command. The watcher commanded others to take the fruit off the tree and to throw it in different directions. Again, the text does not say who the watcher was talking to. For example:

Scatter the fruit (REB)

pull off the fruit and throw it all over

- Translate it as an authoritative statement.

They (indefinite) must scatter the fruit

The fruit is to be scattered (passive)

Its fruit will be scattered.

scatter: The word that the BSB translates as scatter means “disperse, throw in different directions.” It is implied that the fruit will be wasted. No one will collect it for food. Here is another way to translate this:

throw away (NJB)

4:14c

Let the beasts flee from under it, and the birds from its branches.

- Make the animals flee from its shelter and make the birds flee from its branches.
- The animals must run away from their homes under the tree. The birds must fly away from their nests in its branches.
- They (indefinite) must drive the animals from under the tree. They (indefinite) must cause the birds to fly away from its branches.

Let the beasts flee from under it: The watcher continued to shout commands. This command is addressed to the wild animals that were sheltering under the tree. They were told to run away from their homes or shelters under the tree.

There are different ways to translate this command:

- Translate this as a command. The holy one ordered that the wild animals not stay under the shelter of the branches of the tree. Address these animals in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Flee from under the tree, all you wild animals!

Leave your homes/shelter, creatures of the forest!

In some languages it may be natural to address this command to people, rather than the animals themselves. For example:

Drive the animals from under it (GNT)

Chase the animals from its shade (NLT)

Make the animals under it run away (GW)

- Translate this as an authoritative statement

The wild animals must leave their homes under the tree.

The animals will have to flee from the shelter of the tree.

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

the beasts: See the Notes at 4:12c, where the Aramaic phrase used is “the beasts/animals of the field.” Although the phrase “of the field” is not used here, the meaning is the same. Translate it so that is clear.

and the birds from its branches: The context implies the same verb as the one in the previous clause: “let flee.” There are at least two ways to translate this expression.

- Translate it as a command. The watcher ordered the birds to leave the branches of the tree and fly away. For example:

escape from its branches, all you birds!

make the birds fly away from its branches (GW)

send the birds flying from its branches (CEV)

- Translate it as an authoritative statement:

The birds must fly away from the branches.

The birds will be driven away from the branches of the tree.

The birds will have to flee their nests.

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

the birds: The phrase the birds refers to the same creatures as in 4:12d. See the note there. The Aramaic here does not contain the words “of the sky,” but there is no difference in the meaning.

General Comment on 4:14a–c

The birds and animals would have to run away from their homes because the tree would be cut down. In some languages it may be helpful to make this clear by changing the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{14c}Drive the animals and birds away from the tree
^{14a}by cutting it down. Yes, cut it down and chop off the branches. ^{14b}Strip off the leaves and take away its fruit. *Translator’s Handbook on Daniel.*

Daniel 4:15

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

The verse numbers of the BSB and most English versions are different from the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. The NJPS and NJB are two exceptions. They follow the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. Baldwin (p. 107) notes that the chapter divisions in the present Aramaic text were not necessarily those of the original text. The difference in numbering can cause confusion when citing verses in different translations. For example, Daniel 4:1 in the BSB is 3:31 in the NJPS and NJB. Daniel 4:4 is 4:1 in the NJB and NJPS, and so on. When these Notes cite verses in the NJPS and the NJB, they will give both the verse numbers in those versions and the corresponding BSB verse numbers.

Versions give different headings to Daniel 4. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar’s second dream (NRSV)

Nebuchadnezzar’s dream about a tree (NLT)

A letter from Nebuchadnezzar about his insanity (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed a second dream

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed about a tree

Nebuchadnezzar wrote a letter about how he became insane

Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1-18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19-27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28-33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

D. In 4:34-37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

2. Repetition: When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19-27), he repeated parts of what the king had previously told him (in 4:10-16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28-33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.
3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.
4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural

to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.
6. Form: The author wrote Daniel 4 in the form of a royal proclamation. This proclamation form gives authority to the account. The style of the proclamation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.
7. Key Terms: Two key terms in Daniel 4 are "earth" and "heaven." Both words have more than one meaning. The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as "earth" can mean either "ground," "land," or "world." The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as "heaven" can mean either "sky" or "where God lives." In 4:26 the author used the word "Heaven" to refer to God himself. The author plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: "God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth." The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:13-16

In this paragraph the king continued to tell Daniel his dream.

4:15a

But leave the stump with its roots in the ground, and a band of iron and bronze around it,

- But leave^(plur) the stump and roots of the tree in the ground. Bind them with iron and bronze chains,

- However, do not dig^(plur) up the stump of the tree or its roots. Instead, fasten^(plur) the stump with a metal band made of iron and bronze
- But the stump and its roots must be secured with iron and bronze bands and left in the ground,

But: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. The watcher contrasted the negative commands in 4:14 with the more positive ones in 4:15a. Show this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

leave the stump with its roots in the ground, and a band of iron and bronze around it: The holy one commanded that no one dig up the stump of the tree. Those being addressed were ordered to bind the stump and leave it in the ground. There are at least two ways to translate this idea:

- Translate it as a command. The watcher gave the command not to dig up the stump of the tree. For example:

leave the stump in the ground (GNT)

Leave the stump and its roots in the ground (NCV)

Do not dig up the stump of the tree or its roots.

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. For example:

They (indefinite) are to leave the stump in the ground.

The stump must be left in the ground.

No one will dig up the stump in the ground

Translate this idea in the way that is most natural in your language.

the stump with its roots: The Aramaic text is more literally “the stump of its roots.” The two Aramaic words that the BSB translates as stump and roots are similar in meaning. See Goldingay, p. 80; HALOT, 1953. The first word refers to the main or tap root of the tree. Together they refer to what is left in the ground after a person cuts down a tree. English versions translate this in different ways:

- Using two words. For example:

the stump and its roots (NIV)

- Use one expression. For example:

stump (GNT)

deep rootft Goldingay

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

a band of iron and bronze around it: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as a band of iron and bronze around it is literally, “in/with a fetter of iron and bronze.” The word can refer to anything that held something tightly to one spot. It could refer to a shackle, a chain, or a metal band. The word can also refer to one or more fetters. See the Translator’s Handbook on Daniel. People used to put fetters on the legs of prisoners so that they would not run away. The fetters were made of metal and they fastened them around the leg of a prisoner. English versions translate this in different ways. For example:

bound with iron and bronze (NIV)

in fetters of iron and bronze (NJPS)

held by chains of iron and bronze (CEV)

This expression describes what the holy one said must happen to the stump. The image may imply that the stump could not be removed by anyone. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Translate it as a command. The watcher ordered others to fasten a band of iron and bronze around the stump. For example:

fasten it with iron and bronze chains

bind them with chains of iron and bronze

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. For example:

They (indefinite) will fasten it with iron and bronze chains.

The stump will/must be fastened with iron and bronze chains.

iron and bronze: The bands were to be strong, made of metal. See the notes on iron at 2:33a and on bronze at 2:32c.

4:15b in the tender grass of the field.

- and leave^(plur) them in the grassy field.
- and leave^(plur) it there in the meadow grass.
- among/in the wild grass.

in the tender grass of the field: This expression describes where the stump was. The holy one ordered that the stump be left in a field where grass grew. Other ways English versions translate this include:

in the grass of the countryside (NJB)

surrounded by the grass of the field (NET)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

Leave it there in the field with the grass (GNT)

tender grass: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as tender grass may refer to the new grass that grows in the spring. HALOT. If you have a term for this type of grass, you may use it here. Here is another way to translate this:

new grass (NASB)

General Comment on 4:15a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder some of the information in 4:15a-b. For example:

^{15a-b}The stump must stay there in the grassy field, securely fastened with metal chains.

^{15a}The stump must be bound with chains of iron and bronze and left there ^{15b}in the meadow.

4:15c Let him be drenched with the dew of heaven

- Make^(plur) him wet from the dew
- He will/must become damp from the dew.
- The dew will drench/soak him

Daniel 4:15c begins with a common connector that here introduces the next command that the angel gave. The BSB has not translated this connector. Intro-

duce this next command in a way that is natural in your language.

Let him be drenched with the dew of heaven: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as Let him be drenched is a command. It functions as a declaration of what must and will happen. There are at least two ways to translate this expression:

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. For example:

He will become wet from the dew of heaven

- Translate it as a third-person command. For example:

Now let the dew fall on this man (GNT)

- Translate it as a command addressed to the dew. For example:

Dew from the sky, fall on this man!

In some languages it will be unnatural to command the dew to do something. If that is true in your language, you should follow the first option.

him: The Aramaic pronoun that the BSB translates as him is ambiguous. In Aramaic the word for tree is masculine, so the pronoun could refer either to the stump or to a man. The vision slowly changes from a dream about a tree stump to a dream about a man. The angel began to speak about the man, the ruler, whom the stump represented. Some translations transition to using the pronoun “him” here and some continue to use “it,” that is, the stump. The possibilities are:

- use “him.” For example:

Let him be wet with the dew of heaven. (ESV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, ESV, RSV, NRSV, REB, NLT)

- use “it.” For example:

Let it become damp with the dew of the sky (NET) (NJB, KJV, NET, GW)

- make a sharp change with an explicit reference to a man. For example:

Let the man become wet from dew (NCV) (NCV, GNT, CEV)

If you have a third person pronoun that can refer to either the stump or to a man, you can use that here. Try to make the transition as gradual as possible. If you must choose, it is probably best to use a noun or pronoun that refers specifically to a man. For example:

Now let the dew fall on this man (GNT)

Let him be wet with the dew of heaven (RSV)

be drenched: This is a passive verb. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

Let him be bathed with the dew of heaven (NRSV)

unprotected from the dew (CEV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

let the man become wet with dew (NCV)

let the dew fall on this man (GNT)

with the dew of heaven: dew refers to the moisture that appears during the night in little drops on plants and on the ground. If you do not have a word that means dew, you may be able to say:

with the water that comes at night

of heaven: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as heaven here means “sky, air.” In some languages the idea will be implied and can be left untranslated. For example:

the dew (GNT)

4:15d

and graze with the beasts on the grass of the earth.

- and make^(plur) him live outside with the wild animals and plants.
- He will/must live outdoors with the wild animals/creatures and plants.
- as his home will be with the beasts, among the plants.

and graze with the beasts on the grass of the earth: The Aramaic text is more literally “and his portion/lot with the animals in the grass of the earth.” The

holy one gave the command that the man live with the wild animals in the grasslands. This command functions as a declaration of what must and would take place. There are again several ways to translate this command. For example:

- Translate this as a command

let him live with the animals among the plants of the earth (NIV)

let him live with the animals and the plants (GNT)

- Translate this as an authoritative statement

He must/will live with the animals and plants

Continue to use the form that is most natural in your language to express this idea.

with the beasts: See the Notes at 4:12c.

(NIV:) live with the animals: There are two ways to interpret the Aramaic word that the NIV translates as live. It literally refers to having part or share of something. The possibilities are:

1. It refers to the kind of life that God determines that a person will live. It can mean “destiny.” See *halaq* TDOT 4:448–49. The man will live with the animals, like an animal himself. For example:

let him live with the wild animals among the plants of the field (NLT) (NIV, NLT, KJV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NET)

1. It refers to sharing the food of the wild animals. For example:

eating grass (NJB) (BSB, NJB, GW, possibly NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. This interpretation can include the idea of eating the food that wild animals eat.

Daniel 4:16

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

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Special Problems:

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3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

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mation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.

7. Key Terms: Two key terms in Daniel 4 are “earth” and “heaven.” Both words have more than one meaning. The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “earth” can mean either “ground,” “land,” or “world.” The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “heaven” can mean either “sky” or “where God lives.” In 4:26 the author used the word “Heaven” to refer to God himself. The author plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: “God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth.” The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:13–16

In this paragraph the king continued to tell Daniel his dream.

4:16a

Let his mind be changed from that of a man,

- Change^(plur) his mind from a human mind
- He will no longer think like a human
- His thinking/mind must no longer be that of a human being.

Let his mind be changed from that of a man: This verse part has the form of a command. However, this is not a command to someone to do something. It functions as an authoritative declaration. The man’s mind was going to change. This must happen. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Translate it as a command. For example:

Let him have the mind of an animal (NLT)

Give him the mind of an animal (CEV)

Let him not think like a human any longer (NCV)

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. For example:

His mind will cease to be human (REB)

He is to receive the mind of an animal

Translate this idea in the way that is most natural in your language. Note that the expression does not mean that the man received an animal’s brain. It means that he lost the ability to think clearly and rationally, like a human being, and he acted as if he was an animal.

Let his mind be changed: This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb.

His thinking must be changed

Let his mind be altered (NET)

- Using an active verb. For example:

Let his mind change

He will no longer think like a man

he will not have a human mind (GNT)

his mind: This phrase makes it clear that the speaker was now referring to a human being, not a tree stump. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mind is literally “heart.” In the Aramaic language, the heart was the place in the body where people thought, made decisions, and felt emotions. It referred to the source of thoughts and desires. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

a human heart (NJB)

think like a human (NCV)

man: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as man can refer to any human being, male or female. The king was a man, not a woman, but that is not the point here. The contrast here is between man and animal. So in most languages it is good to follow the NRSV and say:

human (NRSV)

4:16b

and let him be given the mind of a beast

- to an animal mind.

- but/and he will think like an animal.
- Instead, his mind/thinking must become that of a wild beast/creature.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates and in this context introduces the second part of the angel's command. It involves a contrast between a human and an animal mind. In some languages it may therefore be natural to follow the GNT and say:

but (GNT)

let him be given the mind of a beast: This is a command. Like the earlier commands, it functions as an authoritative declaration of what must happen. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Translate it as a command. The angel commanded that the man begin to think and act like an animal. For example:

and give it the mind of an animal (GW)

- Translate it as an authoritative statement. For example:

and he will think like an animal

and he is to begin thinking like a beast

be given the mind of a beast: The verb be given is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb. For example:

let him have the mind of an animal (NCV)

he must/will receive the mind/thinking of a wild creature

he is to start thinking like an animal thinks

the mind of a beast: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the mind of a beast is literally "animal's heart." See the Notes on "mind" at 4:16a. Here is another way to translate this:

the heart of a beast (NJB)

General Comment on 4:16a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to combine Daniel 4:16a–b into one clause with one verb. For example:

Give him the mind of a wild animal instead of the mind of a human

In place of his human mind, he must receive an animal's mind.

He must/will think like an animal instead of a human

4:16c

till seven times pass him by.

- Cause him to be like this for seven periods of time.
- He will/must stay in this condition until seven time periods are complete/over.
- This will last for seven years.

till seven times pass him by: The holy one commanded that the man remain in this condition, with the mind of an animal, for seven periods of time. He did not say how long these time periods were. There are several different interpretations. For example:

1. It refers to a definite but unspecified period of time, as in 2:8. For example:

seven time periods (GW) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, NIV, NJB, KJV, REB, GW, NLT, NET)

1. It refers to a year. The Translator's Handbook on Daniel. See the ancient Greek translation LXX. HALOT has "years" and cites Daniel 4:13, 20, 22, 29, and 7:25 "three and a half years." Josephus, Jerome and medieval Jewish commentators follow this view. The duration of Nabonidus's sickness in 4QPrNab is seven years. For example:

for seven years (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In some languages it may not be possible to refer to an indefinite period of time. If that is the case in your language, you can follow interpretation (2). However, if you follow the second interpretation, you should put interpretation (1) in a footnote.

pass him by: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as pass him means "come in turns, succeed each other." In this context, the seven periods of time would

happen one after another while the man lived in the field with the animals. Other ways to translate this include:

pass over him (NRSV)

go by for him (NET)

General Comment on 4:16a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 4:16a–c, translating the time periods involved first. For example:

^{16c}For seven periods of time, ^{16b}let him have the mind of a wild animal ^{16a}instead of the mind of a human. (NLT)

^{16c}For seven years ^{16a}he will not have a human mind, ^{16b}but the mind of an animal. (GNT)

Daniel 4:17

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1–18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19–27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

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D. In 4:34–37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

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Paragraph 4:17

In this verse, the watchers spoke about themselves in the third person. This way of speaking indicated their authority. If this is unnatural in your language, you may translate using first-person pronouns. For example:

^a We , the watchers, have declared this sentence for God.

^b We , God’s holy ones, announce what he has decided.

4:17a–b

Biblical authors often wrote poetry in pairs of clauses. The two lines often communicate the same thing in two different ways. Daniel 4:17a–b forms a pair of clauses in poetic speech. You may wish to indent the lines to show that this is poetic speech.

These verse parts are more literally

The command is by the decree of the watchers,

and the verdict is by the word of the holy ones

The Aramaic text does not explicitly include the verb “is.” In some languages that may be natural and acceptable. In other languages it may be natural to supply verbs or translate the nouns “decree” and “word” as verbs. Most English versions supply one or more verbs. For example:

This sentence is by the decree of the angelic watchers

And the decision is a command of the holy ones. (NASB)

The sentence is by the decree of the watchers, the decision by the word of the holy ones. (RSV)

For this has been decreed by the messengers;

it is commanded by the holy ones. (NLT)

The observers gave this command;

the holy ones declared the sentence. (NCV)

See also the suggestions in the notes that follow.

4:17a

This decision is the decree of the watchers,

- ¶ “The watchers proclaim this verdict.
- ¶ “We the watchful angels announce what God has decided,

This decision is the decree of the watchers: This verse part refers back to the decision that the messengers had just announced to the king in his dream. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as is the decree of is a noun meaning “by the decree of.” A decree is an official order or decision. There are several ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

Such is the sentence proclaimed by the watchers (NJB)

- Using an active verb. For example:

The observers gave this command (NCV)

The guardians have announced the decision (GW)

We^(excl) who are watchers proclaim this punishment

- Using a noun. For example:

The sentence is by the decree of the watchers. (ESV)

Translate this using the form that is most natural in your language.

This decision: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as decision implies a formal verdict or judgment. The messengers were announcing the verdict against someone. The content of the verdict was given in 4:14-16 in the form of angelic commands. Other ways English versions translate this are:

This sentence (RSV)

this punishment (CEV)

In some languages it may be necessary to say who made the decision or verdict. In those languages you may indicate that it was God. He told the messengers what to say. For example:

God’s decision

the watchers: See the Notes on “watcher” at 4:13b. Note that the word is plural here. The messengers or watchers spoke about themselves in the third person, emphasizing a formal statement. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that the watchers were speaking of themselves by using a first-person pronoun. See the note above on Paragraph 4:17. For example:

we^(excl) the watchers

4:17b

the verdict declared by the holy ones,

- These angels declare this punishment
- and how God will punish him.

Daniel 4:17b begins with the common connector that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces a clause that says the same thing as 4:17a but in a different way. This was common in Hebrew and Aramaic poetry. The BSB has not translated this connector. Introduce this next command in a way that is natural in your language.

the verdict declared by the holy ones: God’s holy angels declared the verdict by giving the commands recorded in 4:14-16. It may be natural to make this clearer by saying:

The holy ones declare this verdict

The holy ones have announced this (GW)

this is the sentence pronounced by the holy angels

the holy ones: See the Notes at 4:13b. This expression is a synonym of “watchers” in 4:17a. In this context, it refers to the same angelic beings as coming from God and belonging to God. So it may again be natural to use a first-person plural pronoun. For example:

we, the holy ones

we, God’s holy ones

the verdict: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as verdict is a synonym of the word “decision” in 4:17a. It refers to the decision of a judge that someone is guilty and will receive punishment. Use the expression

that is natural for such a decision. Here is another way to translate this:

the sentence (REB)

General Comment on 4:17a–b

The two clauses in 4:17a and 4:17b have the same meaning and refer to the same thing. In some languages it may be more natural to combine them. For example:

God's watchful angels announce this verdict

This punishment is given at the command of the holy angels. (CEV)

4:17c

so that the living will know that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind

- so that every living person may know that the Most High God is lord/king over all earthly kingdoms.
- God's purpose is to show everyone that he, the Supreme One, rules over all the nations of the world.

The purpose of the angels' decree was that everyone would know that God is sovereign over all men.

so that: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as so that here introduces the purpose of the decree, that is, of the punishment. Here is another way to translate this:

the purpose of this decree is that (NLT96)

In some languages it may not be possible to speak of an object like a decree as having a purpose. It may be more natural to follow the CEV and indicate result:

It will show to all who live that... (CEV)

Since the decree was given by God through his holy angels, its purpose was the angels' purpose and ultimately God's purpose. So it may be natural to say:

the angels ordered this so that...

God ordered this decree so that...

the living will know that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind: The holy angels wanted all people to recognize that God has power over all the

nations and peoples of the world. He rules over all earthly kings and rulers. Other ways to translate this include:

let all people everywhere know that the Supreme God has power over human kingdoms (GNT)

everyone may know that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of the world (NLT)

It will show to all who live that God Most High controls all kingdoms. (CEV)

the living: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the living means "all living beings." In this context it refers primarily to human beings, who are able to know and understand who God is. There is no contrast implied with dead human beings. See how you translated this word in the singular in 2:30b. Here is another way to translate this:

all people everywhere (GNT)

will know: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as know here means realize or understand. People will know something they did not know before. For example:

may understand (NET)

may learn (NJB)

may recognize

that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind: This is what God wanted people to understand: that he is in control over all the earth and is more powerful than any human authority.

the Most High: See the Notes at 4:2b. Here, however, the expression does not occur with the word "God." In some languages it may be necessary to make the word "God" explicit. For example:

the Supreme God (GNT)

God Most High (CEV)

Most High God (NCV)

rules over: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rules is literally “powerful, mighty” or “lord over.” English versions translate this as:

rules (RSV)

has power over (GNT)

controls (CEV)

the kingdom of mankind: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the kingdom of mankind is more literally “the kingdom of man,” in the singular. It probably refers to human rule in general. That is, it refers to all the many kingdoms that exist or have existed. For example:

human sovereignty (NJB)

human kingdoms (GNT)

every kingdom on earth (NCV)

the kingdom: See the Notes at 4:3c. The rulers of nations may be called kings, emperors, or have other titles such as president or chancellor. It is good to use a word that refers to any human unit of government ruled by a single powerful man.

4:17d

and gives it to whom He wishes,

- He can give authority to rule the kingdoms to whomever he wants,
- He can choose/place anyone he wants to be their king.

and gives it to whom He wishes: The phrase gives it to whom He wishes here indicates that God is able to give authority over nations to whomever he wants. For example:

he can give them to anyone he chooses (GNT)

God gives those kingdoms to anyone he wants (NCV)

and chooses for their rulers whoever he wants

4:17e

setting over it the lowliest of men.’

- choosing/appointing even the least important man to be their king.”
- If he wishes, he can make the most insignificant person their ruler.”

setting over it the lowliest of men: This expression indicates that there are no limits for God. He can choose unlikely people, people of humble backgrounds, to rule nations. Other ways to translate this include:

even to those who are least important (GNT)

He places the lowest of people in charge of them

He can even choose the most humble man

setting over: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as setting literally means “raises” (NJB). In this context, the phrase setting over means to make someone ruler of a nation. Other ways to translate this include:

appoint over (REB)

place...in charge (GW)

the lowliest of men: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as lowliest means “humble.” HALOT, 2001 In this context, it probably refers to people of low social status. Other ways to translate this include

those who are least important (GNT)

those who are most inferior GeCL97

the most insignificant of men La Bible du Semeur

General Comment on 4:17d–e

4:17d–e indicates that God is able to choose people of low rank to rule nations. He has full power to appoint whoever he wishes, including a poor or low-status person. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the unexpected nature of such a choice by following the GNT:

he can give them to anyone he chooses—even to those who are least important (GNT)

General Comment on 4:17a–e

In the Aramaic, as in the BSB, 4:17a–e forms one long sentence. In some languages it may be natural to break this up into several shorter sentences. For example:

^{17a}The guardians have announced this decision. ^{17b}The holy ones have announced this ^{17c}so that every creature will know that the Most High has power over human kingdoms. ^{17d}He gives them to whomever he wishes. ^{17e}He can place the lowest of people in charge of them. (GW)

Daniel 4:18

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:18

Nebuchadnezzar asked Daniel to interpret his dream.

4:18a

This is the dream that I, King Nebuchadnezzar, saw.

- ¶ That was the dream that I, King Nebuchadnezzar, dreamed.
- ¶ I, Nebuchadnezzar the king, have told you my dream.

This is the dream that I, King Nebuchadnezzar, saw:

The king summarized what he had just been telling

Daniel. This functions as an introduction to his command to Daniel. Other ways to translate this include:

This dream I, King Nebuchadnezzar, saw. (RSV)

That is what I, King Nebuchadnezzar, dreamed (NCV)

I, King Nebuchadnezzar, have told you my dream.

This is the dream: In this context the Aramaic pronoun that the BSB translates as This refers back, to the contents of the dream in 4:13–17. In some languages it may be natural to say:

that was the dream (NLT)

I, King Nebuchadnezzar: The king mentioned his name to emphasize his authority and the importance of what he was about to ask. If it is unnatural in your language for a ruler to state his name like this, you may have another way to express this same emphasis.

4:18b

Now, Belteshazzar, tell me the interpretation,

- And you, Belteshazzar, must interpret it for me,
- I want you, Belteshazzar, to explain its meaning,

Now: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Now here introduces the king’s command to Daniel. The king required Daniel to explain the dream he had just described to him. Introduce this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

And (ESV)

So now

Belteshazzar: The king addressed Daniel by his Babylonian name. See the Notes at 4:8b.

tell me the interpretation: The king asked Daniel to interpret his dream. He believed that the contents of the dream indicated something about events in real life. He wanted Daniel to tell him what this was. Another way to say this is:

declare the interpretation (RSV)

tell me its meaning (GW)

4:18c

because none of the wise men of my kingdom can interpret it for me.

- because all of the wise advisers in my kingdom/land are unable to interpret the dream.
- since none of the experts/scholars of Babylon were able to explain what it meant.

because: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as because here introduces a reason clause. The king commanded Daniel to interpret his dream because none of the other wise men were able to do it. Introduce this reason in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

for (NIV)

since (NRSV)

none of the wise men of my kingdom can interpret it for me: The king had already called his various experts to him to explain the dream. They had not been able to do so (see 4:6–7). Other ways to translate this include:

not one of the sages in my kingdom has been able to interpret it for me (NJB)

None of my royal advisers could tell me. (GNT)

none of the wise men of my kingdom can do so (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a negative verb. For example:

all the wise men of my kingdom are unable to tell me the interpretation (NRSV)

the wise advisers in my kingdom can't tell it to me (GW)

all the wise men of my kingdom are not able to make known to me the interpretation (ESV)

none of the wise men: In some languages it may be natural to translate this negative idea using a singular noun. For example:

There is not one wise man who

No wise man

the wise men: In this context, the phrase the wise men is a general expression that includes all the king's advisors. See the Notes on wise men at 4:6a. Other ways to translate it here include:

the wise advisers (GW)

the royal advisers (GNT)

of my kingdom: The phrase of my kingdom refers to all the territory that Nebuchadnezzar ruled. Other ways to translate this include:

in all the lands I rule

throughout my country/empire

can interpret it for me: See the Notes at 4:6b. None of the king's wise men were able to interpret the dream for the king. Other ways to say this include:

can explain it to me (NCV)

can do so (NLT)

4:18d

But you are able, because the spirit of the holy gods is in you."

- But I know you are able to interpret the dream for me, for the spirit of the holy gods lives in you."
- But the sacred deities/gods have give you their spirit of special power/ability, so I know you can explain it."

But: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as But here indicates a contrast. The wise men were not able to interpret the dream, but the king believed that Daniel could do it.

you are able: In some languages it may be more natural to indicate what the king believed Daniel could do. For example:

you can tell me the meaning

you are able to interpret the dream

because: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as because here introduces the reason why the

king believed that Daniel could interpret the dream. Translate this connector in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

for (NRSV)

the spirit of the holy gods is in you: Nebuchadnezzar worshiped many gods. He believed that these gods had given Daniel special wisdom to understand dreams. See the Notes at 4:8c. Translate in the same or similar way here.

Daniel 4:19

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:19–23

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king’s dream.

4:19a

For a time, Daniel, who was also known as Belteshazzar, was perplexed,

- ¶ For a short while/time Daniel, that is, Belteshazzar, stood there horrified/appalled.
- ¶ For a few minutes, Daniel, whom I had named Belteshazzar, was too shocked by the dream to answer.

For a time, Daniel, who was also known as Belteshazzar, was perplexed: Daniel did not immediately obey the king’s command. He was deeply disturbed.

For a time: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as a time refers to a brief time. HALOT, 2000–2001. Here is another way to translate this:

for a while (NRSV)

For: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as For here introduces Daniel’s response and a new phase in the account. Here is another way to translate this:

Then (NIV)

Daniel, who was also known as Belteshazzar: This is background information. The author had previously mentioned Daniel’s Babylonian name in 4:8b and 4:18b. Translate this repeated background information in a way that is natural in your language.

was perplexed: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as perplexed has been interpreted in two main ways in this context:

1. It means “disturbed, appalled.” Another possibility is “was momentarily stunned” (GW). For example:

was severely distressed (NRSV) (RSV/NRSV, GNT, NASB, ESV, NET, GW)

1. It means “confused, puzzled.” For example:

was terribly confused (CEV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, CEV, REB)

Interpretation (1) is recommended. Daniel was very unhappy at what he heard. He was dismayed, shocked, or horrified. This interpretation fits the context of 4:20 better and is followed by the majority of English versions.

In some languages it may be natural to indicate what disturbed or distressed Daniel. You may wish to supply “the dream” as the subject of the clause. For example:

The dream troubled Daniel

The king’s dream shocked Daniel.

4:19b and his thoughts alarmed him.

- He thought about the dream and felt terrified.
- As he thought about it, he was very frightened.

and his thoughts alarmed him: This expression has a similar meaning to 4:19a. Daniel was deeply disturbed when he thought about the dream. Other ways to translate this include:

his thoughts terrified him (NIV)

what he was thinking frightened him (GW)

worried by what he was thinking (CEV)

his thoughts: This Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as his thoughts refers to what Daniel thought about the meaning of the dream. The NLT says explicitly:

frightened by the meaning of the dream (NLT)

alarmed: See the Notes at 4:5b. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as alarmed is an approximate synonym to the verb in 4:19a. Daniel was horrified and alarmed by the meaning of the dream.

4:19c

So the king said, “Belteshazzar, do not let the dream or its interpretation alarm you.”

- But the king said, “Belteshazzar, do not let the dream and its message alarm you.”
- But I the king told him, “Do not be shocked by my dream, Belteshazzar. Do not be afraid of what it means. Tell me.”

So: The BSB has supplied the connector So. The Aramaic does not indicate the connection between 4:19b and 4:19c. Most English versions have no explicit connection. You should introduce the king’s response to Daniel in a way that is natural in your language. For example

but (REB)

the king said: Here the king’s proclamation begins to refer to the king in the third person. Some English versions continue to use the first person, as in 4:2, 4. For example:

I told him (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to make the reference clear by saying:

I the king

said: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as said is literally “answers and tells.” Some English translations change from third person to first person. For example, the GW has: “I told him.” The CEV has: “But I said.” The two verbs of speech emphasize that the king was about to say something important. If this is unnatural in your language, you may use one verb like the BSB does. However, try to keep the same emphasis.

Belteshazzar: The king addressed Daniel by his Babylonian name. See the Notes at 4:8b, 4:18b, 4:19a.

do not let the dream or its interpretation alarm you:

The king ordered Daniel not to be frightened because of the dream or because of the meaning of the dream. Translate this negative command in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

do not let the dream or its meaning make you afraid (NCV)

don’t be alarmed by the dream and what it means (CEV)

alarm: This is the same verb as in 4:19b.

General Comment on 4:19c

The king wanted Daniel to tell him what his dream meant. He did not state this explicitly in this verse part, but it is implied. The king was trying to reassure Daniel. He was implying that he would not be angry at Daniel if the meaning was not a good one. In some languages it may be natural to make some of this implicit meaning explicit. For example:

Do not be alarmed by the dream, Belteshazzar, whatever it means. Tell it to me.

4:19d

“My lord,” replied Belteshazzar, “may the dream apply to those who hate you,

- ¶ Belteshazzar answered, “My king, I wish that the dream referred/applied to those who hate you.
- ¶ Belteshazzar replied, “Master, it would be good/preferable if the dream was about your enemies,
- ¶ Belteshazzar replied to the king, “Sir, I am sorry that the dream is for you, not for your enemies!

“My lord,” Daniel addressed the king by the title My lord. This is a title of respect. Daniel addressed the king as someone important who had authority over him. If you have a title like this in your language, you can use it here. Other ways English versions translate this include:

Your Majesty (GNT)

My master (NCV)

My king

replied Belteshazzar: Daniel responded to the king. Here he is called by his Babylonian name.

may the dream apply to those who hate you: Daniel was implying that he knew that the dream applied to the king, and that the meaning was not a good one. The dream symbolized something bad that was going to happen to the king. Daniel wished that this bad thing would happen to the king’s enemies, rather than to the king himself. However, the context implies that Daniel was certain that it would happen to the king.

Consider how it is natural in your language to talk about something that the speaker desires but knows is not true. For example:

I wish the dream were about your enemies. (NCV)

How good it would be if the dream applied to your enemies.

It would be a good thing if this dream was about your enemies! But it is not.

4:19e and its interpretation to your enemies!

- I wish that its meaning/interpretation referred/applied to your enemies.
- if its meaning/message was for your opponents, not for you.
- I regret that it means that something bad will happen to you rather than to your foes!

and its interpretation to your enemies!: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces another way of saying the same thing as the previous clause.

its interpretation to your enemies!: This is a short way of saying “if only the meaning of the dream

applied to your adversaries!” Daniel wished the meaning/message of the dream concerned or referred to Nebuchadnezzar’s enemies. Other ways English versions translate this are:

I wish its meaning were for those who are against you! (NCV)

I wish that the dream meant that your enemies would experience these things!

to your enemies: The context implies “rather than to you” or “and not to you.” Daniel wished the dream referred or applied to the king’s enemies instead of to the king. He knew it applied to the king but did not wish to state this clearly. In your translation, it is good to leave this implied. However it is important to check that your readers will understand the implication. In some languages it may be natural or necessary to make this implied information explicit. For example:

I wish the dream was about those who hate you and not about you

I wish the events foreshadowed in this dream would happen to your enemies, my lord, and not to you! (NLT)

General Comment on 4:19e–f

4:19e and 4:19f basically mean the same thing. If it is unnatural in your language to repeat information like this, you may be able to combine the two clauses. For example:

I wish the dream had been against your enemies. (CEV)

Daniel 4:20

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

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Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1–18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19–27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28–33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

D. In 4:34–37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

2. Repetition: When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19–27), he repeated parts of what the king had previously told him (in 4:10–16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28–33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.
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Paragraph 4:19–23

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king’s dream.

4:20–22a

In Daniel 4:20–21, Daniel repeated most of what the king had said about the tree. He does not repeat the phrase “from it all flesh was fed.” Then in 4:22 Daniel explained that the tree symbolized the king. The order of these clauses creates suspense. This ordering also places the emphasis on the last clause, 4:22a, “you, O king, are that tree!” In some languages, however, it may be more natural to present this information in a different order. The Notes will suggest some ways you may do this. For example, it may be natural to begin with the point of comparison:

The tree that you saw in your dream was you, O king. That tree grew and became strong.

4:20a

The tree you saw

- As you were dreaming, you saw a tree.
- In your dream, you saw a tree.

The tree you saw: See the Notes at 4:10b. The king had seen a tree in his dream, and this tree is the main topic of the dream. Introduce this topic in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

You saw a tree in your dream (NCV)

You described a tree that you saw in a dream.

Now concerning the tree you dreamed about

4:20b

that grew large and strong, whose top reached the sky

- It grew tall and strong. It grew until its top seemed to touch the clouds.
- It grew tall and strong until the top of the tree was high in the sky.

that grew large and strong, whose top reached the sky:

See the Notes at 4:11a. Translate in the same or a similar way here. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a complete sentence. For example:

It grew large and strong, and its top reached to the sky.

In your dream this tree grew to become strong and tall, so tall that it seemed to touch the sky.

4:20c

and was visible to all the earth,

- People could see the tree from anywhere on earth.
- It grew so high that everyone in the world could see the tree.

was visible to all the earth: See the Notes at 4:11b. Other ways to translate this include:

which could be seen in all the land (NET)

It could be seen everywhere on earth. (GW)

Daniel 4:21

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:19–23

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king’s dream.

4:21a

whose foliage was beautiful and whose fruit was abundant,

- Its leaves were beautiful and it had lots of fruit,
- It had lots of leaves/foilage and bore/produced much fruit,

whose foliage was beautiful and whose fruit was abundant: The tree showed it was healthy by growing healthy foliage and producing lots of fruit. See the Notes at 4:12a–b. Other ways to translate this include:

whose foliage was attractive and its fruit plentiful (NET)

It had beautiful leaves and plenty of fruit. (GW)

4:21b

providing food for all,

- enough to feed everyone.
- plenty for everyone.

providing food for all: The fruit was so “abundant” (4:21a) that there was enough for everyone to eat. See the Notes at 4:12b. Other ways to translate this include:

and from which there was food available for all (NET)

enough to feed everyone (GW)

a tree which yielded food for all (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause or sentence. For example:

and it had enough fruit on it to feed the whole world (GNT)

There was enough fruit to feed everyone.

4:21c

under which the beasts of the field lived,

- The wild animals stayed in the shade of the tree.
- The tree provided shade for the wild animals,

under which the beasts of the field lived: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as under which the beasts of the field lived is literally “under it lived the wild animals.” The verb is different from that in 4:12c, where there is a similar idea. Other ways to translate this include:

beneath which the wild beasts dwelt (REB)

The wild animals rested/sheltered underneath the tree.

the beasts of the field: This is the same Aramaic phrase as the phrase the BSB also translates “the beasts of the field” in 4:12c. See the Notes there.

4:21d

and in whose branches the birds of the air nested—

- Birds made their homes in its branches.
- and birds built their nests on its branches.

and in whose branches the birds of the air nested: The Aramaic text says literally “in its branches lived the birds of the heavens.” The verb is not the same as in 4:12d, but the meaning is the same. Other ways to translate this include:

birds made their homes in its branches (GW)

The birds nested in its branches. (CEV)

in whose branches the birds of the air had nests (NRSV)

the birds of the air: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the birds of the air is more literally “the birds of the heavens.” This refers to wild birds, birds that normally fly around freely. See how you translated this in 4:12d.

General Comment on 4:20–21

In the BSB 4:20–21 forms one long sentence. However, in the Aramaic a new sentence begins at 4:21a. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Aramaic or to translate these verses as several shorter sentences. For example:

^{20a}You saw a tree in your dream ^{20b}that grew large and strong. Its top touched the sky, ^{20c}and it could be seen from all over the earth. ^{21a}Its leaves were beautiful, ^{21b}and it had plenty of fruit for everyone to eat. ^{21c}It was a home for the wild animals, ^{21d}and its branches were nesting places for the birds. (NCV)

Daniel 4:22

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king’s dream.

4:22a–d

Daniel 4:22a–d is in poetic form. The parts c–d are in parallelism to parts a–b. 4:22c–d repeats the meaning in 4:22a–b but is more specific.

^aIt is you, O king, who have grown ^band become strong.

^cYour greatness, has grown and reaches until heaven ^dand your dominion to the ends of the earth.

Aramaic poetry uses figurative language. The Notes will explain the meaning of the figures of speech in 4:22 and will give some suggestions about how best to translate this verse.

4:22a

you, O king, are that tree!

- And, sir, as for that tree—it is you!
- That tree in the dream—it represents you, Your Majesty!

you, O king, are that tree!: This verse part is the climax toward which 4:19–21 has been building. The BSB uses an exclamation mark to give it emphasis. Emphasize this statement and mark it as a climax in a way that is natural in your language.

you, O king: See the Notes at 2:4b, 2:29a. Daniel addressed the king with respect. Languages often have special ways to address a king or other important people in authority. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

O king (NRSV)

The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as you, O king, are that tree emphasizes the pronoun you. The tree in the dream represented the king. Indicate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language. Other ways to say this in English are:

it is you (NRSV)

That tree is you (CEV)

4:22b

For you have become great and strong;

- As the tree grew great, so you have grown great. As the tree became strong, so you have become strong.
- Your fame/glory has increased. You have grown in power/might.

For you have become great and strong: This is more literally “you have become/grown great and you have grown/become strong.” Daniel compared the king to the tree. This verse part indicates the point of comparison: Just like the tree became great/tall and strong,

so did the king. However, Daniel used the verbs “grow/ become great” and “grow/become strong” in two different ways. The king did not grow big and tall in size like the tree. Instead, it was the king’s fame and reputation that became great. People all over the known world respected and honored him.

If it is natural to use the same verb for the king and the tree, you may do that here.

If it is more natural to use two different verbs to describe what happened to the king and the tree, that is also acceptable. For example:

As the tree grew great and strong, so you have become great and strong.

have become great: In some languages you may have to indicate in what way the king had become great. For example:

Your reputation has increased.

You have become very important

and strong: Just as the tree became strong, so the king had become strong. Daniel again used the same verb in two different ways. Daniel did not mean that the king increased in physical strength. He meant that the king’s authority and power to rule increased.

- If it is natural to use the same verb for the king and the tree, you may do that here.
- If it is more natural to use different verbs to describe what happened to the king and the tree, you should do that here. For example:

and as the tree grew strong, you also became strong

In some languages you may have to indicate in what way the king had become strong. For example:

Your kingdom has become powerful

You have increased/grown in power and authority.

4:22c

your greatness has grown to reach the sky,

- You have become as great as anyone ever could.

- You have become more and more important so that now everyone in the world knows how important you are.

your greatness has grown to reach the sky: In this verse part, Daniel explained what he meant in 4:22b when he said that the king had grown or “become great.” He used figurative language to explain this. This expression probably means that the king’s reputation had become greater than that of any other king. Everyone on earth knew how important he was. There were no limits to his fame. There are two ways to translate this figurative language:

- keeping the figure of speech. You may use either sky or “heaven,” whichever you used in 4:11a. See the note there. For example:

Your greatness has increased and reaches to heaven (NRSV)

your glorious reputation has reached heaven (CEV)

Your royal majesty reaches sky-high The Message

- translating the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

you are greater than any mortal man

Your fame is worldwide

your greatness: The word greatness here refers to the king’s fame, reputation, or importance.

has grown: See the Notes on “have grown” at 4:22b.

4:22d

and your dominion extends to the ends of the earth.

- Your kingdom has become so powerful that now you rule everywhere on earth.
- You have become more and more powerful until now you rule over people who live in the farthest places.

and your dominion extends to the ends of the earth: Daniel explained what he meant in 4:22b when he said that the king had become “strong.” The king now ruled everywhere, to the farthest places on earth. Other ways to translate this include:

Your power reaches the most distant part of the world. (GW)

You have authority over the farthest places of the world

You rule over people who live everywhere on earth

dominion: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as dominion is a synonym to “kingdom.” Like the word “kingdom” it can have different meanings. In this context it can be translated as:

rule (NLT)

power to rule

empire (NJB)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this using a verb. For example:

You rule

the ends of the earth: See the Notes at 4:11b. The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the ends of the earth is an idiom which means “everywhere on earth.” If you have another expression or an idiom in your language that has this meaning you can use it here.

General Comment on 4:22c–d

In some languages it may be natural to translate 4:22c–d using just one verb. For example:

Your greatness reaches to heaven, and your authority to the ends of the earth.

General Comment on 4:22b–d

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the information in 4:22b–d. If that is true in your language, you may be able to combine the four parts. For example:

Your reputation has become so great that everyone on earth knows about you. Your power has increased so much that you rule over people who live in the farthest places.

Your glorious reputation has reached heaven, and your kingdom covers the earth. (CEV)

Daniel 4:23

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

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language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

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Paragraph 4:19-23

In this paragraph Daniel began to interpret the king's dream.

4:23a

And you, O king, saw a watcher, a holy one, coming down from heaven

- ¶ "And then Your Majesty, you saw a watcher, an angel, who was coming down from heaven.
- ¶ "In the dream, my king, you also saw one of the holy angels coming down from God in heaven. He was alert and watchful.

And you, O king, saw a watcher, a holy one, coming down from heaven:

Daniel began to interpret the second part of the king's dream (see 4:13). In the Aramaic text this verse part is connected to the previous verse with a word that the BSB translates as And. This introduces the topic of this verse. Other ways to begin this verse include:

So next Your Majesty saw one of God's messengers

As for the king seeing a holy sentinel coming down from heaven (NET)

Then you saw a holy angel come down from heaven (CEV)

Introduce this second part of the dream in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

In the dream you also saw...

And you, O king, saw: See the Notes at 4:13a. In the Aramaic text Daniel addressed the king in the third person: “the king saw.” If this is not natural in your language you may use the second person. For example:

Also, your majesty, you saw (REB)

O king, you saw (NCV)

You saw (GW)

a watcher, a holy one: See the Notes on these two phrases at 4:13b.

As in 4:13b, the two expressions refer to the same being. If this is not clear, you may wish to combine them into one expression. For example:

an angel (GNT)

a holy angel (CEV)

coming down from heaven: In his dream the king saw the angel descending from the sky. This was where he understood God to have his dwelling. The angel was coming from God. See the Notes at 4:13c, and translate here as you did there.

4:23b

and saying: ‘Cut down the tree and destroy it,

- He commanded, ‘Cut down^(plur) the tree and destroy it!
- He declared, ‘The tree must be cut down and destroyed.

and saying: Daniel then quoted what the angel had said in the king’s dream. Translate in a way that is natural in your language for introducing a quotation within a quotation. You may wish to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He said (GW)

He commanded that...

See the General Comment on 4:23.

Cut down the tree: See the Notes at 4:14a. Translate in a way that clearly refers back to that command.

and destroy it: In Daniel 4:14a–b the holy one gave specific commands: “chop off its branches,” “strip off its leaves,” and “scatter its fruit.” Here Daniel summarized what the watcher had said in one short command. In some languages it may emphasize the idea if it is translated as a separate sentence. For example:

Destroy it! (GW)

destroy: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as destroy is a general word that can refer to ruining buildings, kingdoms, or people. Try to use an expression that can refer to ruining or destroying both trees and people.

4:23c

but leave the stump with its roots in the ground, and a band of iron and bronze around it, in the tender grass of the field.

- Leave^(plur) the stump in the field of grass. Fasten it with a band made of iron and bronze. Leave^(plur) its roots there in the ground.
- The stump must be bound with an iron and bronze chain and left in the grassy meadow/field. The tree roots can stay there in the earth/soil.

but leave the stump with its roots in the ground, and a band of iron and bronze around it, in the tender grass of the field: See the Notes at 4:15a–b In the Aramaic and the BSB there is no sentence break here but you may wish to translate this as a separate sentence or sentences. For example:

But leave the stump and its roots in the ground. Secure it with an iron and bronze chain in the grass of the field. (GW)

4:23d

Let him be drenched with the dew of heaven,

- Make^(plur) him become wet from the dew.
- He will/must become wet from the dew.

Let him be drenched with the dew of heaven: The BSB has changed here from using the pronoun it/its

to using the pronoun him. The dream begins to refer to the king rather than to the tree. The Aramaic text does not make the change clear; it is gradual. Several English versions make the change at this point. For example:

and let him be wet with the dew of heaven (RSV)

Some versions continue with to use the pronoun “it/its” in this verse part. For example:

Let it get wet with the dew from the sky. (GW)

Let it become damp with the dew of the sky. (NET)

let it be drenched by the dew (NJB)

Consider where it is most natural to make the change. You may wish to follow your national or major-language version here.

The verb Let...be drenched is a passive command. See the Notes at 4:15c and see how you translated it there. There are several ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and let him be bathed with the dew of heaven (NRSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

Let him become wet with dew. (NCV)

Let the dew fall on this man. (GNT)

4:23e

and graze with the beasts of the field

- Make^(plur) him live outdoors with the wild animals.
- He will/must make his home outside with/like the wild animals/beasts.

and graze with the beasts of the field: See the Notes at 4:15d. At this point the angel seems to be speaking of a human rather than a tree. This person was to live outdoors, in the “tender grass of the field,” like an animal. It may be helpful to follow the GNT and make the location explicit:

let him live there with the animals (GNT)

the beasts of the field: The same Aramaic word for animals is used as in 4:15d, but here there is also the phrase of the field. See how you translated the word there.

4:23f

till seven times pass him by.’

- He must stay this way for seven periods of time.’
- He will/must live like this for seven years.’

till seven times pass him by: See the Notes at 4:16c. Follow the same interpretation here as you did there. For example:

for seven time periods (GW)

General Comment on 4:23

This verse part contains an embedded quotation. Daniel reported what the holy one had said in the king’s dream. In some languages it may be natural to translate this embedded quotation using indirect speech. For example:

The holy one said that the tree must be cut down and destroyed. Its stump however, was to remain in the ground, bound with iron and bronze. The dew, he said, must make him wet. He was to live with the wild animals for seven time periods.

Daniel 4:24

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:24–26

In this paragraph Daniel interpreted for the king the events of his dream. He explained what the dream foretold.

4:24a

This is the interpretation, O king,

- ¶ “Your Majesty, I will now interpret the dream.
- ¶ “Now I will explain what the dream means, my king.

This is the interpretation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as This refers ahead to what Daniel was about to say (in 4:25–26). In some languages it may be natural to say:

Now I will tell you the interpretation

Now I will explain the dream

Now I will interpret the dream

interpretation: See the Notes at 2:5b; 4:7b.

O king: See the Notes at 2:4b, 2:29a, and 4:22a. Daniel addressed the king with respect.

4:24b

and this is the decree that the Most High has issued against my lord the king:

- This is what the Most High God has decreed/announced will come upon you^(sing), my lord and king.
- God Most High has declared that this will happen to you^(sing), you who are my lord and king:

and this is the decree that the Most High has issued against my lord the king: The Aramaic text says more literally “and the decree of the Most High which has reached my lord the king.” It indicates that the decree applied to Nebuchadnezzar. Other ways to translate this include:

this is what the Supreme God has declared will happen to you (GNT)

it is a decree of the Most High that affects my lord the king (REB)

The Most High God has commanded these things to happen to my lord the king (NCV)

this: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as this refers ahead to what Daniel was about to tell the king.

decree: See the Notes at 4:17a. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as decree here refers to an order or decision made by God. The word is *gezerah*. It is a different word than the one translates decree in Daniel 2:13. HALOT defines this as a decree or resolution. It occurs in Daniel 4:17, 24. In some languages it may be natural to use a verb phrase. For example:

has declared (GNT)

has commanded these things (NCV)

Most High: See the Notes on Most High God at 4:2b; 4:17c. In 4:21 the word God is missing, but it has the same meaning. This expression is a title. It describes the one true God as having universal authority. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that this is a reference to God. For example:

the Most High God (NCV)

God Most High (CEV)

the Supreme God (GNT)

has issued against my lord the king: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as issued against means “to reach, affect.” The word *metah* occurred in Daniel 4:11, 20, 22 with the sense “to reach, or attain to.” Here it has the sense “to affect” (HALOT) with the preposition *‘al* with a person. In Daniel 4:28 it means “to happen.” The decree applied to Nebuchadnezzar. It referred to him, or affected him.

my lord the king: Daniel addressed the king in the third person. This was a way to show respect to someone important in his culture. If this is not natural in your language, you may be able to use the second person. For example:

you, my lord the king

you (GNT)

Use an expression that is natural in your culture for showing respect to someone of high status.

my lord: See the Notes at 4:19d. Here is another way to translate this:

my master (NCV)

Daniel 4:25

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:24–26

In this paragraph Daniel interpreted for the king the events of his dream. He explained what the dream foretold.

4:25a

You will be driven away from mankind,

- You^(sing) will be forced to live away from others/people
- People will banish you from human society.
- Everyone will send you away from their town.

The Aramaic text connects this verse part with the previous verse part with the common connector that

the RSV translates as “that.” In this context, it introduces the meaning of the dream and its application to the king. Introduce the interpretation in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages no connector will be necessary.

You will be driven away from mankind: The Aramaic expression is more literally “they will be chasing you from among men.” The BSB translates this as a passive clause. The GW also uses a passive verb:

You will be forced away from people (GW)

If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

they (indefinite) will force you to live away from people
La Bible du Semeur has: “On te chassera du milieu des humains.”

people will banish you from human society

The subject is not in focus.

from mankind: In this context, the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mankind refers to people in general. Other ways to translate this include:

from human society (NET)

far from humans (CEV)

4:25b

and your dwelling will be with the beasts of the field.

- and to live outdoors where the wild animals live.
- You will have to live outside with wild animals/beasts instead.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in the sequence.

and your dwelling will be with the beasts of the field: See the Notes at 4:15d. The king would have to live where wild animals live, far away from people. Other ways to translate this include:

your dwelling shall be with the beasts of the field
(RSV)

you will make your home with wild animals

You will have to live where wild animals live

your dwelling will be: The same noun, “dwelling,” occurs in 2:11c. This is a general word that refers to the place where someone lives. Use a noun or a verb, whichever is more natural in your language. For example:

you home will be

you will make your home

you will live

the beasts of the field: See the Notes at 4:12c. The expression refers to animals that live freely in the wild, undomesticated.

4:25c

You will feed on grass like an ox

- You will have to eat grass like an ox/bull does.
- You will feed on grass like cattle

You will feed on grass like an ox: The Aramaic expression is literally “making (pl) you eat grass like oxen.” The subject is not in focus. Other ways to translate this include: The clause is literally active in Aramaic with an indefinite third person plural subject.

You shall be made to eat grass like oxen (NRSV)

You will have to eat grass like cattle

you will feed on grass, as oxen do (NJB)

The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel explains that it is best not to translate this as “people will make you eat grass,” because the king would not be near other people.

ox: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as ox usually refers to an adult male cow, that is, a bull or a steer. However, here it is plural and refers to cattle in general. Here is another way to translate this:

like cattle (GW)

4:25d

and be drenched with the dew of heaven,

- Your body will become wet with dew.
- The dew from the sky will fall on you.

and be drenched with the dew of heaven: See the Notes at 4:15c. The expression is literally, “wetting (pl) you...” This is a pael participle masculine plural. The king would live outside in the open and would become wet from the dew. Other ways to translate this are:

The dew from the sky will make you wet (GW)

the dew will fall on you (GNT)

You will become wet from dew

4:25e

and seven times shall pass you by,

- All this will last for seven periods of time
- You will live like this for seven time periods.

and seven times shall pass you by: The king would live like this for seven periods of time. See the Notes at 4:16c. Translate this following the same interpretation you followed there.

4:25f

until you acknowledge that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind

- until you realize/recognize that the Most High God has authority over all human kingdoms
- Then you will understand that the Supreme God is the true ruler/king of all human kingdoms,

until you acknowledge: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as acknowledge is the same verb “know” as in 4:17c. Here again it has the stronger sense of recognize or understand. For example:

until you realize (GW)

until you have learned (NRSV)

The phrase until you acknowledge means “until the time comes when you acknowledge.” When Nebuchadnezzar acknowledged that God was the Supreme King, then the seven periods of time would be over and the situation would change. Other ways to translate this include:

then you will learn (NCV)

Then you will admit (GNT)

before you understand (NET)

that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind: The king would finally realize that God was the ultimate ruler of the earth. He controlled all things.

the Most High: See the Notes at 4:2b. In this context, however, as in 4:24b, the expression does not occur with the word “God.” In some languages it may be necessary to make the word “God” explicit. For example:

the Supreme God (GNT)

God Most High (CEV)

Most High God (NCV)

rules over: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rules is literally “powerful, mighty,” or “is lord over.” HALOT (1996) cites Daniel 4:17, 25, 32, 5:21 with this sense. See also GeCL97; BFCL88. Other ways to translate this include:

rules (RSV)

has power over (GW)

controls (GNT)

over the kingdom of mankind: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the kingdom of mankind is singular. It is more literally “the kingdom of men” and refers to human rule in general. See 4:17c. Other ways to translate it include:

human sovereignty (NJB)

human kingdoms (GNT)

every kingdom on earth (NCV)

kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom is used twice in 4:3c. See the Notes and your translation of this verse part.

4:25g

and gives it to whom He wishes.

- and that he is able to give these kingdoms to whomever he wants.
- and he decides who is going to rule them.

and gives it to whom He wishes: See 4:17d. In this context the verb gives indicates that God is able to give human kingdoms to anyone he wants. God decides who should rule. See how you translated 4:17d. For example:

he can give them to anyone he chooses (GNT)

chooses their rulers (CEV)

it: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as it probably refers to the idea of human sovereignty, human kingdoms. Refer back to this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

those kingdoms (NCV)

to whom He wishes: See the Notes at 4:17d. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates He wishes in this context means “decides, chooses.” God is free to appoint anyone to rule.

General Comment on 4:25f–g

In your translation of 4:25f–g it is good to distinguish between the final authority of God and the temporary and lesser authority of human rulers. Avoid saying something like “God rules all human kingdoms and he chooses as ruler whoever he wants.” Instead, you should distinguish between the two types of authority by saying something like:

God Most High controls all earthly kingdoms and chooses their rulers (CEV)

the Most High has power over human kingdoms and...gives them to whomever he wishes (GW)

Daniel 4:26

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

The verse numbers of the BSB and most English versions are different from the verse numbers in the Ara-

maic text. The NJPS and NJB are two exceptions. They follow the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. Baldwin (p. 107) notes that the chapter divisions in the present Aramaic text were not necessarily those of the original text. The difference in numbering can cause confusion when citing verses in different translations. For example, Daniel 4:1 in the BSB is 3:31 in the NJPS and NJB. Daniel 4:4 is 4:1 in the NJB and NJPS, and so on. When these Notes cite verses in the NJPS and the NJB, they will give both the verse numbers in those versions and the corresponding BSB verse numbers.

Versions give different headings to Daniel 4. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar's second dream (NRSV)

Nebuchadnezzar's dream about a tree (NLT)

A letter from Nebuchadnezzar about his insanity (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed a second dream

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed about a tree

Nebuchadnezzar wrote a letter about how he became insane

Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1-18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19-27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28-33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

D. In 4:34-37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

2. Repetition: When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19-27), he repeated parts of what the king

had previously told him (in 4:10-16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28-33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.

3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

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Paragraph 4:24–26

In this paragraph Daniel interpreted for the king the events of his dream. He explained what the dream foretold.

4:26a

As for the command to leave the stump of the tree with its roots,

- The command that the stump and its roots remain/ stay in the ground
- But the angel ordered that no one should dig up the stump and/or roots of the tree.

As for the command to leave the stump of the tree with its roots: This verse part introduces the third part of Daniel’s interpretation. See the Notes at 4:23c. Here Daniel identified the part of the dream he was about to interpret. The BSB translates the Aramaic connector that begins this verse as *As for*. The NJB translates the Aramaic connector this way:

And the order “Leave the stump and roots of the tree”... (NJB)

This command stands in contrast to the previous commands. Part of the tree was to remain standing. Some versions therefore use a connector that indicates contrast. For example:

But he gave orders not to disturb the stump and roots (CEV)

But the stump and roots of the tree were left in the ground. (NLT)

Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language.

the command: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the command is more literally a verb, “they said.” The pronoun “they” is indefinite. However, in verse 15, the king said it was the angel who gave the order. So you can translate:

it was commanded (RSV)

The angel ordered... (GNT)

The holy one commanded...

to leave the stump of the tree with its roots: See the Notes at 4:15a. This is the content of the command.

The text does not say who the holy one told to do this. The agent of the action is not in focus. If this is not natural in your language, you may be able to say:

that they (indefinite) leave the stump in the ground

that no one should dig up the stump in the ground

that the stump should stay in the ground

General Comment on 4:26a

In some languages it may be natural to translate this command as direct speech. For example:

And the order, “Leave the stump and roots of the tree”... (NJB)

4:26b

your kingdom will be restored to you

- indicates/signifies that you^(sing) will receive your kingdom back.
- This means that you^(sing) will again rule as king of/in Babylon,

Some English versions supply the word “means” or the phrase “This means” at the beginning of this verse. The Aramaic does not contain either of these but because 4:26b explains the meaning of 4:26a you may need to follow the example of these English versions and supply this implied information. For example:

This means... (GNT)

your kingdom will be restored to you: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as will be restored is

more literally “will remain/endure for/to you.” In some languages it may be possible to translate this as:

you will continue to rule

In some languages however a literal translation might indicate that Nebuchadnezzar would rule without ever stopping. And in this context the verb “will remain/endure” refers to the fact that Nebuchadnezzar would again rule the kingdom or empire of Babylonia. He would become king of Babylon once more. Other ways to translate this include:

your kingdom will be given back to you (NCV)

you will receive your kingdom back again (NLT)

This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

it is certain you will rule again

you will become king again (GNT)

God will let you become king again.

your kingdom: See the Notes on kingdom at 4:3c. In this context, kingdom refers to the king’s authority to rule over the Babylonian empire.

4:26c

as soon as you acknowledge that Heaven rules.

- This will happen when you^(sing) realize/recognize that God in heaven rules everywhere/earth.
- after/once you^(sing) understand that God is the greatest/highest ruler.

as soon as you acknowledge that Heaven rules: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as as soon as you acknowledge introduces the condition for the fulfillment of the previous clause. It refers to a time in the future when the king would acknowledge that God is the true King. See also 4:25f where the same phrase is used. Other ways to translate this are:

once you recognize that God is lord over all

when you acknowledge that God rules all the world (GNT)

when you recognize that God is the highest lord

as soon as you acknowledge that: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as as soon as you acknowledge that is more literally “when you will know that.” Other ways to translate this in English are:

after you learn that (CEV)

after you recognize (NASB)

from the time that you learn that (NRSV)

Heaven rules: The phrase Heaven rules means that God has authority over all human kingdoms. See the Notes at 4:17c. The same verb is used here. But here Daniel used the name of the place, Heaven, instead of the name of the person who lived there. Baldwin (p. 113) notes that this is the only place in the Old Testament where this figure occurs. It is later used in the books of Maccabees and in the New Testament. In many languages it will be more natural to say explicitly:

the God who rules from heaven is in control (CEV)

God in heaven has true/final authority

In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly what or whom God rules. For example:

God rules all the world (GNT)

God rules everywhere/everyone

one in heaven rules your kingdom (NCV)

General Comment on 4:26b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 4:26b and c. For example:

^{26a}The command to leave the stump with its roots in the ground means that ^{26c}once you acknowledge that God is sovereign, ^{26b}you will receive your kingdom back.

^{26a}The command to leave the stump and its roots in the ground indicates/signifies that ^{26c}after/when you recognize/admit that God rules over all, ^{26b}you will again rule your country.

Daniel 4:27

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4:27a

Therefore, may my advice be pleasing to you, O king.

- ¶ “Therefore, please accept my advice, my king.
- ¶ “That is why, O king, I hope you will agree to do what I have said.

Therefore: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces Daniel’s conclusion. Based on his interpretation of the dream, Daniel hoped the king would accept his advice and repent from his sins. See the Notes at 2:6a and 2:9e. Introduce Daniel’s concluding advice in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

This is why (GW)

So then (GNT)

may my advice be pleasing to you: The Aramaic clause is more literally “Let my advice be acceptable to you,” as in the RSV. Daniel was expressing a polite request. He asked the king to do what he was going

to recommend. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Please accept my advice (NCV)

Please listen to me (NLT)

follow my advice (GNT)

my advice: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as my advice means, “the counsel I am going to give” or, “what I recommend that you do.” Daniel gave this advice immediately after, in 4:27b–c. In some languages it may be natural to make it clear that he was referring to future advice by saying something like:

the following advice

what I am about to say
Translator’s Handbook on Daniel.

O king: See the Notes at 2:4b, 2:29a, and 4:22a. Daniel addressed the king with respect.

4:27b–c

These verse parts form Daniel’s advice to the king. They are in poetic form. The second part (4:27c) repeats the meaning in the first part (4:27b), but in a more specific way. The poetic form of these two clauses marks these them as the climax of 4:19–27.

4:27b

Break away from your sins by doing what is right,

- Stop sinning and do what is right.
- Stop the bad things you are doing, and instead start living in a good way.

Break away from your sins by doing what is right:

Daniel’s advice was in the form of a command. Daniel told the king to stop sinning and to start doing what was right. Instead of committing sins, he should start doing what is right. Other ways to translate this include:

Turn from your sins and start living right. (CEV)

Stop sinning, do what is right (GNT)

Break away from your sins: In this context the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Break away has two possible meanings:

1. It can mean “break away from something,” that is, “stop doing something.” BDB: “to tear away, break off.” See Cornelis Van Dam. *prq* TDOTTE III: 694. Van Dam says, “In Aram. the root can also signify separating oneself from sin.” Baldwin (p. 114) cites Genesis 27:40 and Exodus 32:2 as support that the phrase means, “to break with old habits.” For example:

Stop sinning (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NJB, GW, NCV, GNT, NLT, CEV, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB)

1. It can mean “atone for.” LXX, S, Vg, NEB, Collins, p. 212. HALOT has “to remove, wipe away.” The LXX has: “to redeem.” However, see also Lucas, p. 101. Lucas explains that the verb *prq* can mean “redeem” when the object is the thing redeemed. That is not the case here. Similarly, Goldingay, p. 81. For example:

Atone for your sins (NRSV) (NJPS, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. Other ways to translate this include:

Renounce your sins (NIV)

break with your sins (NJB)

Turn from your sins (CEV)

your sins: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as sins is a general term for acts that do not please God. You may be able to translate this as an action.

sinning (NLT)

doing what is wrong (GeCL97).

by doing what is right: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as by doing what is right is more literally “by righteousness.” The term “righteousness” here refers to righteous living, behavior that pleases God. In this context this includes generosity, justice, and fulfilling one’s duties and responsibilities. Daniel told the king to replace his sins with these good deeds. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

and do what is right (NCV)

and start living right (CEV)

4:27c

and from your iniquities by showing mercy to the oppressed.

- Put an end to doing evil things. Be kind to the poor/ needy.
- Stop doing wrong things. Start doing good to those who are wretched.

and from your iniquities: The verb “renounce” or “break away from” is implied from 4:27b. In some languages it may be necessary to supply a verb here so that the meaning is clear. If that is true in your language, you may use the same verb as in 4:27b or a close synonym. For example:

Stop doing wicked things (NCV)

iniquities: This is a synonym to “sinning” in 4:27b. It refers to doing wrong things, evil deeds. Harry F. van Rooy, *wh* NIDOTTE 6:340. English versions have:

wickedness (NIV)

crimes (NJB)

wicked things (NCV)

If you do not have a synonym for sin, you may be able to use the same word twice. Daniel said the same thing in two different ways in order to emphasize it.

by showing mercy to the oppressed: The phrase by showing mercy to the oppressed indicates what the king should do. Daniel told him to replace his iniquities with mercy. Other ways to translate this include:

and be kind to the poor (NCV)

by being kind to the oppressed (NIV)

The expression showing mercy to the oppressed is a specific example of “doing what is right” in 4:27b. It means to act in a merciful way toward people in need. It implies giving them what they need, rather than just thinking of them in a kindly way. Other ways to translate this include:

be merciful to the poor (GNT)

show kindness to those in need

the oppressed: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the oppressed is a general word referring to poor people, those lacking the basic necessities of life. Other ways to translate this idea in English include:

the poor (GNT)

the needy

those in want

General Comment on 4:27b–c

Daniel 4:27c repeats the same idea as 4:27b but is more specific. It explains 4:27b by giving a specific example of righteousness or right behavior. In some languages it may be more natural to combine these two parts of the verse. For example:

^{27b-c}Stop sinning and start living right. Be kind to the poor.

4:27d

Perhaps there will be an extension of your prosperity.”

- It may be that then you will continue to be successful.”
- Perhaps then God will allow you to keep on living/ ruling with great prosperity/success.”

Perhaps there will be an extension of your prosperity: Daniel said that the king could continue to prosper if he turned from his sins. There are two interpretations of this expression:

1. It introduces a possible result. For example:

Perhaps then you will continue to prosper. (NLT)
(BSB, NIV, NET, KJV, RSV/NRSV, GW, NLT, REB, NCV, NJPS, NASB, ESV)

1. It introduces a certain result. For example:

Then you will continue to be prosperous (GNT)
(GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. The Aramaic text suggests the idea of doubt or possibility rather than certainty.

Other ways to translate this include:

your prosperity may be prolonged (NRSV)

Perhaps your prosperity will be prolonged. (NET)

there will be an extension of your prosperity: The abstract noun prosperity refers to the idea of being successful in some way: depending on the context, happy, healthy, powerful, or respected. HALOT. Lucas (p. 99) translates “well-being.” This is the same word that was used in 4:4 to describe the King’s state before the dream. In this context, it refers primarily to Nebuchadnezzar’s reign in Babylon, his power and fame. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a verb. For example:

you might continue to be successful (NCV)

you may continue to prosper as ruler

Daniel 4:28

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1-18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

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2. Repetition: When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19-27), he repeated parts of what the king had previously told him (in 4:10-16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28-33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.
3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be

natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.
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Paragraph 4:28–30

In this paragraph Nebuchadnezzar described in the third person what happened to him twelve months later. In some languages it may be more natural to include a first-person pronoun. For example:

All this happened to me, King Nebuchadnezzar....

If you decide to translate using the first person, you will need to continue doing so throughout this paragraph.

4:28**All this happened to King Nebuchadnezzar.**

- ¶ Everything that Daniel said about King Nebuchadnezzar happened to him.
- ¶ All that Daniel predicted about me, King Nebuchadnezzar, came true.

All this happened to King Nebuchadnezzar: This is a summary statement of what happened next. What Daniel predicted about the king eventually took place. Summarize this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

But all these things did happen to King Nebuchadnezzar (NLT)

Everything that Daniel said then happened to King Nebuchadnezzar

all these things started happening to me (CEV)

All this: This expression refers to the events in Daniel's interpretation of the dream (4:24–26). You can also translate this more specifically as:

All that Daniel predicted Similarly, BFCL97.

happened to King Nebuchadnezzar: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as happened to is more literally “came upon,” as in the RSV. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this idea with the king as the subject. For example:

And King Nebuchadnezzar experienced all these things.

King Nebuchadnezzar did live/go through all the events predicted in his dream.

Daniel 4:29**Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar**

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4:29

Twelve months later, as he was walking on the roof of the royal palace of Babylon,

- Twelve months later, the king was walking on the flat roof of his palace in Babylon.
- One year later, I the king was walking on the flat roof of my splendid/majestic house in Babylon.

Twelve months later: The phrase Twelve months later introduces what happened to the king the following year. You can also say:

At the end of twelve months (RSV)

One year later

as he was walking on the roof of the royal palace

of Babylon: This clause describes what the king was doing when the events predicted in the dream began to happen. The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as on the roof of the royal palace is literally “on the palace of the kingdom.” This expression could refer to the roof or to a flat path on the wide walls that protected the city. The LXX describes the king walking around on the city walls. The important point is that the king could see out over the city of Babylon. In some cultures people do not walk on the tops of their houses because their roofs are sloped or made of soft material. If that is true in your language, you may have to add some background information. For example:

on the flat roof (CEV)

on the walls of the royal palace of Babylon. (NET)

Another option is to put this information in a footnote.

royal palace: This expression describes the house where the king lived. Scholars tell us that Nebuchadnezzar build a magnificent palace. In some cultures, people may not be familiar with the idea of a formal royal residence. If that is true in your culture, you may be able to say:

the king’s big house

the king’s beautiful rich house

General Comment on 4:28–29

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 4:28 and 4:29, putting the time indication first. For example:

²⁹About twelve months later, when I was walking one day on the roof of my royal palace in Babylon,

²⁸all these things started happening to me.

Daniel 4:30

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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4:30a–b

Is this not Babylon the Great, which I myself have built by the might of my power as a royal residence and for the glory of my majesty?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as an exclamation or strong statement. The king did not expect an answer. He was boasting to himself as he admired what he had done. There are several ways to translate this verse:

- Using a rhetorical question. For example:

Is this not magnificent Babylon, which I have built as a royal capital by my mighty power and for my glorious majesty? (NRSV)

- Using an exclamation, or an exclamation with a statement. For example:

Just look at this wonderful capital city that I have built by my own power and for my own glory! (CEV)

Look how great Babylon is! I built the royal palace by my own impressive power and for my glorious honor. (GW)

Look at this great city of Babylon! By my own mighty power, I have built this beautiful city as my royal residence to display my majestic splendor. (NLT)

- As a statement or statements. For example:

I have built this great Babylon as my royal home. I built it by my power to show my glory and my majesty. (NCV)

4:30a

the king exclaimed, “Is this not Babylon the Great,

- The king boasted to himself: “There is the great city of Babylon.
- I said to myself: “Babylon is a magnificent city!

the king exclaimed: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as exclaimed is literally “answering and saying.” See the Notes at 4:19c. The two verbs of speech indicate that the king was about to say something important. It appears that the king was alone at the time and was boasting to himself as he looked at the beautiful city of Babylon. His boast was in the form of a rhetorical question. Introduce this boastful question in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

and the king boasted to himself:

The king reflected and said (NASB)

I was saying to myself (CEV) Similarly, the GeCL97.

Is this not Babylon the Great...?: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a positive statement or exclamation. For example:

There is the great city of Babylon!

Look how great Babylon is! (GW)

Just look at this great city of Babylon! (NLT)

Babylon the Great: The king admired Babylon by saying that it was Great. Use a word appropriate for praising a city for its beauty, size, and strength. For example:

magnificent Babylon (NRSV)

4:30b

which I myself have built by the might of my power as a royal residence and for the glory of my majesty?”

- I designed it as my capital city
- I have built it by my own great power to show everyone how glorious and important I am.”
- I had it built to be worthy of me, a king. I in my great strength caused it to rise/exist! It shows what a glorious/amazing king I am!”

I myself have built...as a royal residence: The emphasis is on the pronoun I. However, the king did not build the city by himself in a physical or literal sense. He may have planned it and designed some of the buildings and gardens himself, and then ordered his workers to build them. There are at least two ways you can translate this:

- Translate the verb literally:

I built it as a place for me to live as king

- Add the implied information of who actually built the city. For example:

I myself ordered my workers to build it as the place where I, the king, should live.

- Indicate that the king was the cause of the action. For example:

I have caused it to be built for my residence

I have caused my workers to build it to be the royal city

Translate in a way that is most natural in your language.

as a royal residence: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as a royal residence is literally “a house of the kingdom” (KJV). In this context it probably refers to the city of Babylon as a whole. It is good to translate this using an expression that refers to the town where the king lives. For example:

as my capital city (GNT)

as my royal home (NCV)

to be the royal city

by the might of my power...and for the glory of my majesty: Nebuchadnezzar boasted that the beautiful city of Babylon displayed his power and majesty. It was his achievement. He wanted to receive all the praise and credit for it. He wanted all who saw it to recognize that he was a powerful and important ruler. Other ways to translate this include:

to display my power and might, my glory and majesty (GNT)

to show how very powerful I am and how worthy of honor

by the might of my power: The expression that the BSB translates as by the might of my power indicates that Nebuchadnezzar thought that he was able to build the city because he was powerful. The city was evidence of his power. Its existence displayed how powerful he was. Other ways to translate this include:

using my great strength

because I am so strong and powerful

might of my power: In the Aramaic this phrase is literally “the strength of my might.” HALOT. The same two words occur in 2:37 but in the opposite order. The two words “strength” and “might” are close synonyms. Used together they emphasize the king’s pride in his power. Different ways to translate this include:

mighty power (NIV)

my power and might (GNT)

by my own mighty strength (NET)

and for the glory of my majesty: This expression tells why the king built the city of Babylon: the king wanted to show how important he was. The two words glory and majesty are close synonyms and used together they emphasize the king’s pride in his greatness. There are different ways you can translate this:

• Using two nouns. For example:

to show my glory and my majesty (NCV)

• Using a noun phrase. For example:

and for my glorious honor (GW)

to display my majestic splendor (NLT)

• Using a clause with a verb. For example:

so that people will honor me greatly when they see what I have done

so that people will think/know I am very great/important

so that people will give me the respect of which I am worthy

Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

glory: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as glory here means “dignity, honor.” Some languages may not have an abstract term like this. If that is true in your language, you may need to express this idea using a verb. For example:

People will honor/respect me.

my majesty: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as majesty is a synonym to “glory.” Nebuchadnezzar wanted to receive honor and respect for his greatness. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a verb. For example:

People will understand/see how important I am.

Daniel 4:31

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

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letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.

7. Key Terms: Two key terms in Daniel 4 are “earth” and “heaven.” Both words have more than one meaning. The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “earth” can mean either “ground,” “land,” or “world.” The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “heaven” can mean either “sky” or “where God lives.” In 4:26 the author used the word “Heaven” to refer to God himself. The author plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: “God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth.” The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:31–32

A voice from heaven told Nebuchadnezzar that he would receive punishment for his pride.

4:31a

While the words were still in the king’s mouth, a voice came from heaven:

- ¶ While the king was still saying these words, a heavenly being said:
- ¶ While I was still speaking, I heard someone in heaven say:

While the words were still in the king’s mouth: This is a figure of speech. It indicates that the king was still talking when someone interrupted him. Other ways to translate this include:

Even as the words were on his lips (NIV)

While he was still speaking these words (NLT)

While the king was still speaking

a voice came from heaven: The Aramaic text is more literally “a voice fell from the heavens” (similar to the RSV). This is a figure of speech. The king heard someone speak to him from heaven. The text implies that it was God or his angel who spoke. In some languages it may not be natural to say that a voice spoke. If this is the case in your language, you can say:

Someone spoke from heaven

A heavenly being said

I heard these words from heaven

heaven: The word heaven here refers to the place where God lives. Daniel and Nebuchadnezzar thought of this place as somewhere in or beyond the sky.

4:31b

“It is decreed to you, King Nebuchadnezzar,

- “King Nebuchadnezzar, listen to what I have to say to you^(sing).
- “I have a message for you, King Nebuchadnezzar! God decrees that
- “This message is for you, King Nebuchadnezzar!

It is decreed to you: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as It is decreed to you is more literally “they are saying to you.” In this context it implies that God and other heavenly beings had said or ordered something concerning Nebuchadnezzar. The message or decree follows. In some languages it may be natural to translate the phrase It is decreed as a noun. For example:

Listen to this decree

This message is for you! (NLT)

Here is the decision concerning you:

King Nebuchadnezzar: The heavenly being/voice addressed the king by his name. In some languages it may be natural to put this address at the beginning of the speech. For example:

O King Nebuchadnezzar, to you... (RSV)

4:31c

that the kingdom has departed from you.

- You^(sing) will no longer rule this kingdom.
- you^(sing) will no longer be king of Babylon.
- your^(sing) rule over Babylon has come to an end.

the kingdom has departed from you: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as the kingdom has departed from you is more literally “the kingdom has passed away from you.” It indicates that the king would no longer be able to rule over Babylon. You should translate in a way that shows that the speaker spoke with authority. What he said happened because he said it. Other ways to say this include:

The kingdom has departed from you. (RSV)

You are no longer ruler of this kingdom. (NLT)

This kingdom is no longer yours. (CEV)

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit who had taken the kingdom from Nebuchadnezzar. If that is true in your language, you may say:

I/We have stopped you from ruling.

God has ended your rule.

the kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the kingdom here refers to Nebuchadnezzar's right to rule, his power over the kingdom of Babylon. Other ways to translate this include:

Your royal power (GNT)

Your royal authority (NIV)

See the Notes at 4:3c.

Daniel 4:32

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

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3. **Synonyms:** The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.
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Paragraph 4:31–32

A voice from heaven told Nebuchadnezzar that he would receive punishment for his pride.

4:32a

You will be driven away from mankind

- You^(sing) will be forced to go/live far away from people
- People will banish/send you^(sing) from their towns/society.

You will be driven away from mankind: See the Notes on this expression at 4:25a. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates with the passive verb phrase You will be driven is literally “they will drive/chase.” The subject is not in focus. Other ways to translate this include:

You will be forced away from people (GW)

they (indefinite) will force you to live away from people

People will banish you from human society

4:32b

to live with the beasts of the field,

- and live outdoors where wild animals live.
- You^(sing) will have to make your home outside with the wild animals/beasts.

to live with the beasts of the field: See the Notes at 4:15d; 4:25b. Translate it here as you did there. The king would have to live where wild animals live, far away from people. For example:

You will be forced to live with the wild animals (CEV)

You will have to live with the wild beasts/creatures

4:32c

and you will feed on grass like an ox.

- You^(sing) will be made/forced to eat grass like an ox.
- You^(sing) will have to eat grass like cattle do.

and you will feed on grass like an ox: The Aramaic text is more literally “they will feed you grass like oxen.” The subject is indefinite and not in focus. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel explains that it is best not to translate this as “People will make you eat grass” because the king would not be near other people. Pael participle masculine plural. See Daniel 4:29; 5:21. See the Notes at 4:25c. Other ways to translate this include:

You will have to eat grass like cattle do.

you shall be made to eat grass like an ox (RSV)

you will eat grass like the ox (NIV)

an ox: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as an ox is plural, referring to cattle in general. The BSB has compared Nebuchadnezzar to just a single male head of cattle. You may use a singular or plural form, whichever is more natural in your language in this context.

4:32d

And seven times will pass you by,

- All this will last for seven periods of time
- You^(sing) will live like this for seven time periods.
- You^(sing) will be like this for seven years,

seven times will pass you by: The king would live like a wild animal for seven periods of time. The seven periods of time would occur one after another while Nebuchadnezzar lived in the field with the animals. See the Notes at 4:16c; 4:25e. Translate it here as you did there.

4:32e

until you acknowledge that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind

- until you^(sing) realize/recognize that the Most High God has authority greater than all human authority.
- This/It will end when you^(sing) admit that the Supreme God rules over all human kingdoms.
- until at last you^(sing) confess that God is the Most High King/Lord over all kingdoms in the world.

until you acknowledge that the Most High rules over the kingdom of mankind: See the Notes at 4:17c; 4:25f for a very similar clause. Here the text has “until you have learned” in the place of “till you know.” The king would continue to live this way until he acknowledged that the Most High God ruled over men. Other ways to translate this include:

until you realize that the Most High has power over human kingdoms (GW)

Then you will acknowledge that the Supreme God has power over human kingdoms (GNT)

Most High: See the Notes at 4:2c; 4:17c; 4:25f. In this context, however, the expression does not occur with the word “God.” In some languages it may be necessary to make the word “God” explicit. For example:

God Most High (CEV)

Most High God (NCV)

rules over: See the Notes at 4:25f. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rules is literally “powerful, mighty,” or “is lord over.” HALOT (1996) cites Daniel 4:17, 25, 32, 5:21 with this sense. See GeCL97 and BFCL88. Modern versions translate this as:

has power over (GW)

controls (CEV)

is sovereign over (NIV)

the kingdom of mankind: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the kingdom of mankind is singular. It is more literally “the kingdom of men,” as in the RSV, and it probably refers to human rule in general. See the note on 4:25f and translate it here as you did there. For example:

human sovereignty (NJB)

human kingdoms (GNT)

every kingdom on earth (NCV)

4:32f

and gives it to whom He wishes.”

- And he is able to give human/earthly authority to anyone he wants.”
- He chooses whoever he wants to rule.”
- He decides who is going to be their earthly/human king.”

and gives it to whom He wishes: God can cause anyone to rule a kingdom. He is the one who decides

who will rule. See how you translated this in 4:25g and translate it the same way here. For example:

he can give them to anyone he chooses (GNT)

he is the one who chooses their rulers (CEV)

Daniel 4:33

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:33

Nebuchadnezzar received the punishment that God had decreed for him.

4:33a

At that moment the sentence against Nebuchadnezzar was fulfilled.

- ¶ These things happened to Nebuchadnezzar at that very time.
- ¶ Immediately, God caused this message about Nebuchadnezzar to be fulfilled.
- ¶ At once these words came true.

At that moment: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as moment means “a moment, a short space of time.” In this context, it has the more specific

sense of “at the same moment, at once.” HALOT, 2001. See also Daniel 3:6–15; 4:33, 5:5. As soon as the king stopped speaking, the events began to occur. Other ways to translate this include:

At once

That very same hour (NLT)

the sentence against Nebuchadnezzar was fulfilled:

The Aramaic text more literally says, “the word was fulfilled upon Nebuchadnezzar.” The BSB translates this expression using a passive verb (was fulfilled). If it is more natural in your language to use active verbs, you may be able to say:

At once, God caused these events to happen to the king just as he had announced:

Immediately, the words came true (NCV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this verse in the first person. For example:

Immediately, these things began to happen to me.

the sentence: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the sentence is literally “the word.” It refers to what God had proclaimed in 4:32–33. God had said he would punish the king. Other ways to say this in English are:

what had been said (NIV)

the prophecy (NLT)

this judgment (REB)

In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea using a verb. For example:

God judged the king just as he had announced

was fulfilled: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as fulfilled here means that God caused what he said in 4:32–33 to happen. Here is another way to translate this:

came true (GNT)

4:33b

He was driven away from mankind.

- He was forced to live away from other people
- People banished him from human society.
- People sent me away from their towns.

He was driven away from mankind: Nebuchadnezzar was forced to live away from other people. See the Notes at 4:25a. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar was forced to go away from people (NCV)

- Using an active verb. The subject is not in focus. For example:

they (indefinite) forced him to live away from other people

people/others banished him from human society

In some languages it may be more natural to use the first person to refer to Nebuchadnezzar. See the Notes at 4:28–31.

They (indefinite) forced me to live far away from people

They (indefinite) banished me from human society

4:33c

He ate grass like an ox,

- and made to eat grass like cattle.
- He ate grass like an ox.
- I had to eat grass like cattle do.

He ate grass like an ox: See also the Notes at 4:25c, 4:32c. The king acted like an ox. He ate grass in the fields as oxen do.

ate: The verb ate here refers to something the king did on a regular or consistent basis.

like an ox: See also the Notes at 4:25c. In this context, the word ox is probably a collective term for cattle in general. In some languages it may be natural to use a plural term. For example:

like cattle (GW)

like oxen/cattle do

4:33d

and his body was drenched with the dew of heaven,

- Each day he became wet from dew from the sky,
- The morning dews soaked/chilled him.
- Every day my body became damp from the dew.

his body was drenched with the dew of heaven: See the Notes at 4:15c; 4:25d. The king lived outside, without any shelter. The GeCL has: “and slept unprotected in the open.” So he got wet with dew every morning. Other ways to translate this include:

He became wet from dew (NCV)

Dew from the sky made his body wet (GW)

the dew of heaven: See the Notes at 4:15c.

4:33e

until his hair grew like the feathers of an eagle

- while his hair grew as long as eagles’ feathers.
- His hair grew very long,
- My hair grew as long as eagle feathers,

until: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as until here introduces something that happened over the same time period as the previous clauses. While the king lived out in the open, his hair grew long. Other ways to translate this include:

As time went by (CEV)

He lived this way until (NLT)

and during that time

his hair grew like the feathers of an eagle: This Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as his hair grew like the feathers of an eagle is literally “his hair like eagles grew big/great.”

grew like: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as grew is a general word that means “grow big.” In this context it refers to hair that grows long and wild, shaggy and unkempt. Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to hair that is not cut for a long time. For example:

grew as long as (RSV)

his hair became shaggy like (REB)

like the feathers of an eagle: The Aramaic text does not mention feathers. However, the word is implied from the context and the BSB has supplied it. An eagle is a large flesh-eating bird. It has a large wing span and long feathers. In some cultures, people may not be familiar with eagles. In that case, you may need to:

- use the term for a similar large bird. For example:

like a vulture's feathers

- use a general term. For example:

like the feathers of a huge bird

- translate the meaning of the comparison. For example:

very long/wild

4:33f

and his nails like the claws of a bird.

- His nails grew long like the claws of a bird.
- and his nails started to look like birds' claws.
- and my fingernails and toenails grew as long as the claws of a large bird.

and his nails like the claws of a bird: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as and his nails like the claws of a bird is literally "and his nails like birds." The verb is implied from 4:33e. The king's nails grew long, sharp, and curved like birds' claws. In some cultures, people may only know about small birds and may not be familiar with birds that have long claws. In that case, you may have to translate the meaning without using this comparison. Examples of different ways to translate this expression include:

his nails grew as long as birds' claws (GW)

his nails grew long, like the claws of a large bird

his nails became extremely long

Daniel 4:34

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your

language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

6. Form: The author wrote Daniel 4 in the form of a royal proclamation. This proclamation form gives authority to the account. The style of the proclamation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.

7. Key Terms: Two key terms in Daniel 4 are "earth" and "heaven." Both words have more than one meaning. The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as "earth" can mean either "ground," "land," or "world." The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as "heaven" can mean either "sky" or "where God lives." In 4:26 the author used the word "Heaven" to refer to God himself. The author plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: "God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth." The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:34-35

In this paragraph, the king once again described what happened in his own words. He told how he changed his attitude. He acknowledged that God was the ruler over all people.

4:34a

But at the end of those days I, Nebuchadnezzar, looked up to heaven,

- ¶ When the set time period had ended, I, Nebuchadnezzar, looked up to God in heaven.
- ¶ At the end of the seven periods of time, I, Nebuchadnezzar the king, looked up to God for help,
- ¶ Finally, when the seven years had passed, I humbled myself before God.

But at the end of those days: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as at the end of those days refers to the end of the period of time when the king lived like an animal. See the Notes at 4:16b-c, 4:25f. English versions have translated this as:

When the time was over (NJB)

At the end of the seven time periods (GW)

When the seven years had passed (GNT)GeCL97;
BFCL88.

I, Nebuchadnezzar: See the Notes at 4:4a. The king mentioned his name to emphasize who he was and the importance of what he was about to say. In some languages it may be unnatural for someone to state his name like this. In those languages there may be another way to express this same emphasis. For example:

I, the king,

I...looked up to heaven: This is a figure of speech. It means to pray and seek God's help. In this context, the expression implies that the king changed his attitude and recognized that God was the greatest ruler and king. He humbled himself and acknowledged God's authority. It is important that people understand this implied meaning. Other ways to translate this include:

then I looked up to heaven (NLT)

I prayed to God in heaven (CEV)

I looked/turned to God for help

heaven: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as heaven can refer to the sky, the heavens, or to the place where God lives. The GNT says: "I looked up at the sky." However, the word has the extended sense of "the place where God lives." In this context the two meanings are both relevant. Nebuchadnezzar prayed looking up, toward the sky, because that was where he believed God lived.

4:34b

and my sanity was restored to me.

- As a result, I became able to think clearly/normally again.
- and God restored my mind.
- God healed me so that I could think like a human again.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces a result clause. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

then

As a result

my sanity was restored to me: See the Notes at 4:16a-b. The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as my sanity was restored is more literally "my reason returned to me," as in the RSV. It indicates that Nebuchadnezzar began to think like a human being again, and it implies that it was God who allowed this to happen. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

My reason was restored to me (NJPS)

I was restored to my right mind (REB)

- Using an active verb. For example,

My sanity returned (NLT)

my mind came back to me (GW)

I was able to think clearly again

my sanity: See the Notes at 4:16a-b. HALOT, 1920 has "understanding." The word occurs at Daniel 2:21; 4:34-37; 5:12. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as my sanity can also be translated as "my understanding" or "my reason" (RSV). Here it refers to the ability to think clearly and rationally, like a human being. Once again the king was able to think like a person and not like an animal. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an action.

and I could think normally again (NCV)

God caused me to think normally again

4:34c-35

The author wrote Daniel 4:34e-35 in poetic style. In 4:34e-35 there are four pairs of clauses. The second part of each pair repeats the meaning of the first line in different way.

4:34c

Then I praised the Most High,

- Therefore I praised God Most High.
- So I blessed/glorified the Supreme God/One.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the result of 4:33a-c. The king praised God because God had allowed him to think

like a human again. You can also translate introduce this as:

so

therefore

I praised the Most High: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as praised is literally “blessed.” See the Notes at 2:19b. When humans bless God, they express praise, appreciation, thanks, and honor to him. You can say:

I thanked the Most High (GW)

I blessed the Most High (REB)

I gave/offered praises to the One/God who is over all

the Most High: See the Notes on “the Most High God” at 3:26b and 4:2b and the Most High at 4:17c, 4:24b, and 4:25f. This expression is a title. It describes God as having universal authority.

4:34d

and I honored and glorified Him who lives forever:

- I thanked and praised God who lives forever.
- I greatly/highly praised the eternal One/God.

and I honored and glorified Him who lives forever:

In this verse part, the king used two other words that mean “praise.” See the notes on 2:23a, where two similar Hebrew words are used (in reverse order). The king used a total of three different verbs in order to emphasize how much he wanted to praise God. In some languages it may be natural to show this emphasis in a different way. For example:

I highly exalted the one who lives forever

Him who lives forever: The phrase Him who lives forever is a title for God. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

God , who lives for ever

General Comment on Daniel 4:34c–d

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the same information in two clauses. The reader may think that the king was praising two different beings. If this

is true in your language, you may be able to reorder the two parts and combine information. For example:

^{34c,d}I praised, honored and glorified the Most High God, the one who lives forever

^{34c-d}Then I said, “God the Most High is the ever-living one! He is the one to whom I give praise, glory, and honor!”

4:34e–f

Daniel 4:34e–f is also in poetic form. 4:34f says the same thing as 4:34e but in a different way. Note also that Daniel 4:34e–f is almost the same as Daniel 4:3b–c. The only difference is that the word “dominion” and “kingdom” are in opposite lines.

4:34e

“For His dominion is an everlasting dominion,

- For he has authority to rule forever!
- He will rule forever,

For: This verse part begins with an Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as For. In this context this connector introduces the reason why the king praised God. That is, it introduces the reason why God is worthy of praise. Some English versions leave this connector untranslated and the relationship between 4:34d–c implied. Introduce 4:34e in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

because (GW)

His dominion is an everlasting dominion: The dominion or kingdom of God will last forever. There will never be a time when he will no longer rule his people. In some languages, you may not have an abstract expression like dominion. It may be more natural to translate this using an active verb. For example:

God reigns forever!

God will always rule his people!

everlasting: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as everlasting means “for all future time.” It refers to all ages yet to come. God’s kingdom is everlasting. It has no end. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

will last forever

will never end

dominion: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as dominion is a synonym of “kingdom.” See the Notes at 4:3c. In 4:3b–c the author reverses the two synonyms. In this context it means: “God will have authority” or “God will rule/reign.”

4:34f

and His kingdom endures from generation to generation.

- He will reign over every generation of people!
- king/sovereign over each new/future generation of people!

His kingdom endures from generation to generation: This line repeats the meaning of 4:34e using different words. This repetition emphasizes the idea that God will rule for all time. Although people die and whole generations pass away, God will continue to rule. For example:

He will rule from one generation to the next.

God will reign throughout all the lifetimes of human beings.

kingdom: See the Notes at 4:3c. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom here refers to the act of ruling. God will rule for generation after generation.

from generation to generation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as generation refers to an age group—grandparents, parents, children, grandchildren and so on. Each of these groups is a generation. The king declared that God would rule over each new age group that is born. In some languages it may be natural to say:

from one human lifespan to the next

one lifetime after another

every baby that is born, and all their descendants

General Comment on 4:34d–e

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the same information in the two clauses. If this is true in your language, you may be able to combine the two clauses into one. For example:

^{34d–e}and he will rule each generation of people forever

Daniel 4:35

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

The verse numbers of the BSB and most English versions are different from the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. The NJPS and NJB are two exceptions. They follow the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. Baldwin (p. 107) notes that the chapter divisions in the present Aramaic text were not necessarily those of the original text. The difference in numbering can cause confusion when citing verses in different translations. For example, Daniel 4:1 in the BSB is 3:31 in the NJPS and NJB. Daniel 4:4 is 4:1 in the NJB and NJPS, and so on. When these Notes cite verses in the NJPS and the NJB, they will give both the verse numbers in those versions and the corresponding BSB verse numbers.

Versions give different headings to Daniel 4. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar’s second dream (NRSV)

Nebuchadnezzar’s dream about a tree (NLT)

A letter from Nebuchadnezzar about his insanity (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed a second dream

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed about a tree

Nebuchadnezzar wrote a letter about how he became insane

Special Problems:

1. **Change of Speaker:** In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1–18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19–27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28–33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

D. In 4:34–37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

2. **Repetition:** When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19–27), he repeated parts of what the king had previously told him (in 4:10–16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28–33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.

3. **Synonyms:** The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

4. **Commands:** In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. **Poetic Parallelism:** The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type

of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.

6. **Form:** The author wrote Daniel 4 in the form of a royal proclamation. This proclamation form gives authority to the account. The style of the proclamation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.

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Paragraph 4:34–35

In this paragraph, the king once again described what happened in his own words. He told how he changed his attitude. He acknowledged that God was the ruler over all people.

4:35a–b

Daniel 4:35a–b is in Aramaic poetic style. The first part states that God is more important and more powerful than all the people on earth. 4:35b further emphasizes this idea: God has control over all the angels in heaven and over all the people who live on earth.

4:35a

All the peoples of the earth are counted as nothing,

- Compared to the Most High God, all the people who live on earth are completely powerless/insignificant.
- How powerless/weak are all the inhabitants of the earth!

All the peoples of the earth are counted as nothing: Nebuchadnezzar was emphasizing God's power. This verse part includes an implied comparison: all the peoples of the earth, their power and glory, are like nothing. Some ancient texts say "like/as nothing" rather than "like/as not." In many languages there may be no difference in translation between the two options, compared to God and his power and glory. In some languages it may be natural to make this comparison explicit. For example:

All the people of the earth are nothing compared to him. (NLT)

There are two ways of understanding this clause:

1. The king was making a statement about his own attitude. He realized and stated that all the people of earth have no power in comparison to God's power. For example:

Everyone who lives on earth is nothing compared to him (GW) (GW, REB, NLT, NCV)

1. The king was making a statement about God's attitude. God considered all the people in this world as insignificant compared to his mighty power. See also the TH of Daniel. For example:

He looks on the people of the earth as nothing (GNT)

To him the nations are far less than nothing. (CEV) (GNT, CEV)

Several other translations are ambiguous (BSB, NET, RSV/NRSV, NJB). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The king recognized that all human power was nothing to God's power. Avoid implying that God does not care about people at all, or that he views them as worthless.

the peoples of the earth: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the peoples is more literally "those who live." The king was referring to every human being. Here is another way to translate this:

the inhabitants of the earth (RSV)

If a literal translation suggests that some people live not on earth but elsewhere, you may need to leave the phrase of the earth implicit. For example:

human beings

are counted as nothing: The verb are counted is passive. Following interpretation (1) in the previous note, it can be translated in at least two ways:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

are seen to be nothing

- Using an active verb. For example:

count for nothing

- Using an adjective. For example:

are not truly important (NCV)

are insignificant

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

4:35b

and He does as He pleases with the army of heaven and the peoples of the earth.

- He does whatever he decides with angels in heaven and with people here on earth.
- God has authority over both the angels in heaven and the people who live here on earth.

and He does as He pleases with the army of heaven and the peoples of the earth: This verse part indicates that God has power over all beings, those in heaven and those on earth.

He does whatever he wishes with the army of heaven and with those who live on earth. (GW)

He has authority over the angels in heaven and the people who live on earth.

The angelic host/armies and the whole human race are under his control.

angels in heaven and people on earth are under his control (GNT)

He does as He pleases: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as does means "perform an action, cause something to happen." Here it has the sense "act toward, treat." God freely chooses how to act with

regard to beings in heaven and people on earth. Other ways to translate this include:

He does whatever he wishes (GW)

he does according to his will (ESV)

God does what he wants (NCV)

as He pleases: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as as He pleases is another form of the verb the BSB translates as “He wishes” in 4:17d, 4:25g, 4:32f. HALOT, 1962. In this context, the word implies deliberate action or choice. God acts exactly as he chooses to act. He does whatever he decides to do.

the army of heaven: The Aramaic expression that the BSB literally translates as the army of heaven HALOT, 1875. See also Daniel 3:20. probably refers, in this context, to the supernatural beings who live with God in heaven. Here is another way to translate this:

angels in heaven (GNT)

and the peoples of the earth: See the Notes at 4:35a. The same phrase is used here. Other ways English versions translate this expression are:

the inhabitants of the earth (RSV)

everyone on this earth (CEV)

those who live on earth (NLT)

4:35c

There is no one who can restrain His hand

- No one can stop him from doing something.
- No one is powerful enough to prevent God from acting as he chooses.
- There is no one who can oppose the Most High God,

There is no one who can restrain His hand: This is the first clause of the fourth pair of clauses in the king’s speech. The phrase His hand is a metaphorical way of referring to God’s power. This entire clause is a figure of speech indicating that no one can stop God from doing as he chooses. There are two ways to translate it:

- Translate the figure of speech. For example:

No one can stop his powerful hand (NCV)

- Translate the meaning in a non-figurative way:

There is no one who can oppose him (GW)

No one can stop him or challenge him (NLT)

When God does something, no one can change it (NLT)

Translate the meaning in the way that is most natural in your language. In some languages the use of the figure His hand may not be natural. And in some languages it will cause your readers to assume that God has a physical body with physical hands. If this is the case in your language, you should translate the meaning of the figure.

can restrain His hand: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as can restrain literally means “strike.” HALOT, 1914. When someone strikes someone on the arm, it hinders or stops them from doing something. Here is another way to translate this:

slaps his hand (NET)

4:35d

or say to Him, ‘What have You done?’

- No one can ask him, “Why did you do that?”
- Nor does anyone have the right to ask him why he did something.
- and no one can question/criticize his actions/motives.

or: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as or here introduces a second thing that people cannot do. They cannot rebuke God for what he chooses to do. Translate this connector in a natural way in your language. In some languages it may be natural to say:

and says to him... (NET)

say to Him, ‘What have You done?’: No human being or supernatural being has the right to rebuke God for his actions. No one has the right to demand an explanation. They can, but God does not have to answer. There is no one with the right to judge God, no one to whom he is obliged to explain his actions. Other ways to translate this include:

say to him, “What do you mean by doing these things?” (NLT)

or say to him, “Explain why you have done this.”

say to Him: What follows is a question. So in some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

ask him (GW)

question him

‘What have You done?’: This is a question demanding that God explain why he acted as he did. It is not respectful or humble. Try to translate it in a way that is judgmental and arrogant. For example:

Why did you do that?

Explain your actions!

General Comment on 4:35d

This verse part contains a quotation within a quotation. In some languages it may be natural to use indirect speech for the embedded question. For example:

and no one can demand that God explain his actions

or question what he does (NCV)

or even ask why (CEV)

Daniel 4:36

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

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Paragraph 4:36–37

After the king repented, he was able to think and act like a human again.

4:36a–b

The Aramaic text on 4:36 can be interpreted in two main ways:

1. It indicates that when the king’s sanity returned, he received back his position as king. For example:

When my sanity returned, my honor, my majesty, and the glory of my kingdom were given back to me. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NLT)

1. It indicates that when the king honored God, two things happened: his sanity returned, and he became king again. For example:

At that time my sanity returned to me. I was restored to the honor of my kingdom, and my splendor returned to me. (ESV) (NET, NRSV/RSV, NJB, ESV, REB, GW, CEV, NCV)

The two interpretations are not very different. The difference is more one of emphasis. If you must choose between them, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). 4:34b has already told how the king’s sanity returned. This happened when he first looked up to God in heaven (4:34a). This verse refers back to that event and indicates that because of it Nebuchadnezzar was able to receive his royal throne back again.

4:36a

At the same time my sanity was restored,

- ¶ When/As God restored/healed my mind,
- ¶ So I began to think normally/clearly again. At the same time

At the same time my sanity was restored: The expression that the BSB translates as At the same time my sanity was restored refers back to 4:34b. This was the time when the king looked up to heaven (4:34a) and acknowledged that God had authority over the kingdoms of men (4:34–35). Other ways to translate this idea include:

When my sanity returned to me (NLT)

I began to think clearly again, and right/soon after that...

At the same time: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as At the same time is literally “at the/that time.” The BSB has supplied the word same. In this context the phrase refers to the same general time period. The events were closely linked and followed soon after one another.

my sanity was restored: This refers to the time when the king began to think like a human being again. See the Notes at 4:34b. Translate it here as you did there. For example:

my mind came back to me (GW)

my reason returned to me (ESV)

I could think normally again (NCV)

4:36b

my honor and splendor returned to me

- people again began to honor me as king. I amazed/impressed them all,
- he also caused people to give me honor/praise once again. People were in awe of the great things I did.

my honor and splendor returned to me: This is a passive clause. It indicates that Nebuchadnezzar received back the honor and splendor that he had previously had. God caused people to honor him once more. It may be more natural in some languages to use an active verb. For example:

I received once again great honor and power

God caused people to honor and admire me again.

God gave back my great honor and power. (NCV)

my honor: See the Notes at 4:30b. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as honor here refers to how important and great the king was in the view of other people. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this idea as an action:

People honored me as king.

People respected me highly/greatly.

splendor: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as splendor means “radiance, brightness, brilliance.” Here it is used figuratively to refer to the king’s great fame. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- keeping the same or a similar figure. For example:

my greatness dazzled the world

- translating the meaning of the figure. For example:

People again were/stood in awe of me.

Again I impressed/amazed everyone.

4:36c

for the glory of my kingdom.

- and, as a result, they honored/respected the kingdom of Babylon.
- In this way the kingdom of Babylon once again became great.

for the glory of my kingdom: This indicates result. Because of Nebuchadnezzar’s renewed honor, the kingdom of Babylon once again became great. You can say:

so that people once again highly respected the kingdom I ruled.

and as a result people again began to call the kingdom of Babylon great.

glory: See the Notes at 4:30b. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as glory means “dignity, honor.” HALOT. The word yaqar also occurs in Daniel 2:6, 37; 4:36, 5:18, 20; 7:14. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this idea as a verb. For example:

people highly respected the kingdom of Babylon

everyone called the kingdom of Babylon great

my kingdom: See the Notes at 4:3c. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates kingdom can have different meanings. In this context, it refers to the empire of Babylon that King Nebuchadnezzar ruled.

General Comment on 4:36b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 4:36b and 4:36c, translating the result before the causes. For example:

^{36c}Once again people began to call the kingdom of Babylon great, ^{36b}because God caused people to honor me again and to admire the great things I did.

4:36d

My advisers and nobles sought me out,

- My advisers/counselors and officials came to meet me,
- My ministers and leading men came to me to ask my help/advice.

My advisers and nobles sought me out: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as sought means “to call upon, to request something.” HALOT has: “to call upon, to beseech.” Goldingay (p. 81) says that the sense is close to “acclaim.” He translates: “sought audience.” These important men in the government came to talk to Nebuchadnezzar once again. They wanted to ask for his help and advice. Other ways to translate this include:

My advisers and nobles came to ask my advice

My advisers and nobles wanted to meet with me again. (GW)

My officials and my noblemen welcomed me (GNT)

My advisers: See the Notes at Daniel 3:24b, 3:27a. Here the word advisers has the general sense of high-ranking royal officials. These were men who had previously served Nebuchadnezzar. Here is another way to translate this:

officials (GNT)

nobles: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as nobles refers to influential people or dignitaries in the Babylonian court. HALOT, 1978. Here is another way to translate this:

officers (NLT)

4:36e

and I was restored to my throne,

- and I again received the right to rule over my kingdom.
- God restored to me the authority to reign as king over Babylon

and I was restored to my throne: The Aramaic text of this verse part is more literally “and concerning/over my kingdom, it was established.” English versions agree that this indicates that Nebuchadnezzar again began to reign over Babylonia. The word “kingdom” and the pronoun “it” refer to royal authority, the power and right to rule as king. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb, as the BSB has done. For example:

and I was re-established in my kingdom (REB)

I was given back my kingdom (GW)

- Using an active verb. God is the one who restored Nebuchadnezzar to his throne. That is, God caused him to rule as king again. For example:

God caused me to rule again in Babylon.

God gave me the authority to rule again over the kingdom of Babylon

I became king again (NCV)

4:36f

and surpassing greatness was added to me.

- I became even more powerful than I had been earlier.
- and gave me power and honor that exceeded/surpassed what I had ever had before.

and surpassing greatness was added to me: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as surpassing greatness was added to me is literally “extraordinary greatness was added to me.” The word meaning great-

ness includes both the idea of power and the idea of honor/fame. The clause indicates that Nebuchadnezzar became even more powerful and famous than he had been previously. Other ways to translate this include:

and I had greater power than ever before (CEV)

and was even greater and more powerful than before (NCV)

with even greater honor than before (NLT)

Daniel 4:37

Section 4:1–37: God judged King Nebuchadnezzar

The author of Daniel 4 wrote in the Aramaic language. These Notes are based on the BSB, which is based on the Aramaic text called the MT (Masoretic Text). However, the early Greek translation known as the Septuagint is different from the Aramaic text in many places in Daniel 4. Scholars are uncertain why the two are so different. It may be that the Greek translators worked from an Aramaic text that was different from that of the MT. The Notes will discuss the differences between the two texts for certain important passages.

The verse numbers of the BSB and most English versions are different from the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. The NJPS and NJB are two exceptions. They follow the verse numbers in the Aramaic text. Baldwin (p. 107) notes that the chapter divisions in the present Aramaic text were not necessarily those of the original text. The difference in numbering can cause confusion when citing verses in different translations. For example, Daniel 4:1 in the BSB is 3:31 in the NJPS and NJB. Daniel 4:4 is 4:1 in the NJB and NJPS, and so on. When these Notes cite verses in the NJPS and the NJB, they will give both the verse numbers in those versions and the corresponding BSB verse numbers.

Versions give different headings to Daniel 4. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar's second dream (NRSV)

Nebuchadnezzar's dream about a tree (NLT)

A letter from Nebuchadnezzar about his insanity (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural that the heading be a full sentence. For example:

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed a second dream

Nebuchadnezzar dreamed about a tree

Nebuchadnezzar wrote a letter about how he became insane

Special Problems:

1. Change of Speaker: In Daniel 4, the person who tells the story varies between the king and the narrator. For example:

A. In 4:1–18 the king told what happened to him in the first person.

B. In 4:19–27 the narrator told the story of how Daniel interpreted the king's dream.

C. In 4:28–33 the narrator told what happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

D. In 4:34–37 the king again spoke directly in the first person.

The Notes will inform you when there is a change of speaker and suggest how to translate these passages.

2. Repetition: When Daniel interpreted the king's dream (4:19–27), he repeated parts of what the king had previously told him (in 4:10–16). Later, when the narrator told what happened to the king (4:28–33), he repeated what Daniel had said would happen (in 4:25). This kind of repetition creates suspense in the story. Repetition also helps to emphasize the main theme of the account. For example, at the end of the account, the king repeated information from the beginning (4:3, 34). This information is the theme of the chapter: God is sovereign over human rulers.

3. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms, different words with the same or similar meaning. In some cases, he used synonyms to emphasize an idea. For example, in 4:37 the king used three synonyms in the same sentence to emphasize the idea of praise. In some languages this may not be natural. The Notes will suggest other ways you can translate synonyms.

4. Commands: In the dream, the angel made a number of commands. The text does not usually say to whom the angel was giving these commands. Sometimes the angel commanded non-living objects to do something. In all these cases, the angel was speaking a message from God. And when God commands that something happen, it will certainly happen. In some languages it may not be natural

to use commands in this way. If that is true in your language, you may be able to translate these commands as authoritative declarations. The Notes will give examples of how you may do this.

5. Poetic Parallelism: The author of Daniel 4 liked to use poetic form to communicate ideas. In Aramaic poetry, authors often used pairs of clauses to say the same thing in two different ways. This type of poetry has many different functions. Sometimes the author used poetry to emphasize themes. Other times he used poetry to mark the climax of a section. This kind of poetry may not be natural in your language. The Notes will describe the function of the poetic speech in Daniel. They will also suggest some options on how you might translate this type of poetry in your own language.
6. Form: The author wrote Daniel 4 in the form of a royal proclamation. This proclamation form gives authority to the account. The style of the proclamation is similar to that of a letter, and the beginning of the chapter is similar to other Aramaic letters. The king first identifies himself. Second, he indicates to whom he is writing, that is, those he intends to read his letter. Third, he greets his readers. In your language, people may have a different way of identifying the author or addressee of a letter. The Notes will suggest some options on how to translate this letter style.
7. Key Terms: Two key terms in Daniel 4 are “earth” and “heaven.” Both words have more than one meaning. The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “earth” can mean either “ground,” “land,” or “world.” The Aramaic word that the BSB generally translates as “heaven” can mean either “sky” or “where God lives.” In 4:26 the author used the word “Heaven” to refer to God himself. The author plays on these two words and their meanings to highlight the main theme of the chapter: “God in heaven rules over the affairs of men on earth.” The Notes will explain the meaning of these two key terms in each context.

Paragraph 4:36–37

After the king repented, he was able to think and act like a human again.

4:37a

Now I, Nebuchadnezzar, praise and exalt and glorify the King of heaven,

- ¶ So now, I, Nebuchadnezzar, praise and honor and glorify the King who rules in heaven.
- ¶ That is why, I, the king, greatly/highly praise and honor God who reigns in heaven,

Now: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Now is an adverb that indicates time. See also 2:23c, 3:15a. In this context, it also introduces a result clause. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. Other ways English versions translate this idea are:

So now (NJPS)

That’s why I say (CEV)

I, Nebuchadnezzar: See the Notes at 4:4a. The king spoke in the first person in Daniel 4:1–18. The king mentioned his name to emphasize the importance of what he was about to say. If it is unnatural in your language for someone to state his name in this way, you may have another way to express this same emphasis. For example:

I, the king,

I, your^(plur) king

praise and exalt and glorify the King of heaven: The king used three words to emphasize how greatly he honored God. In some languages it may be unnatural to use three synonyms like this. If this is the case in your language, you may be able to use one or two verbs with the same meaning. It is important to keep the same emphasis. For example:

with my whole heart I praise God, who rules in heaven.

I give highest praises to the King who rules in heaven

praise: See the Notes at 2:23a; 4:34c, and see how you translated this word there.

exalt: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as exalt means “lift up, praise.”

glorify: See the Notes at 4:34d. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as glorify is a synonym to “praise” and “exalt.”

the King of heaven: King Nebuchadnezzar called God the King of heaven. You can also say:

the king who rules in heaven (CEV)

God, who rules in heaven

heaven: In this context, the word heaven refers to the place where God lives, the supernatural realm.

4:37b

for all His works are true

- because everything that God does is right
- for God does everything according to what is true

for: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as for introduces three reasons why the king praised God. Introduce these reasons in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

because (NIV)

all His works are true: God always acts in a way that is good and right. He never makes mistakes or fails to act justly. Other ways to translate this include:

Everything that God has done is right

God does everything according to what is right.

all His works: The Aramaic expression that the BSB literally translates as all His works refers to the things that God does or has done, his activity. You can say:

all that God does

everything he does (NIV)

all his deeds/actions

true: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as true means, in this context, “in accordance with what is right or true.” Other ways to translate this include:

right (NIV)

just (NJPS)

goodGeCL97

4:37c

and all His ways are just.

- and all his actions are just
- and just/fair.

Daniel 4:37c is in parallelism to 4:37b. The two parts express different aspects of the same meaning.

and all His ways are just: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as His ways is literally “his paths.” It is used figuratively to speak of God’s activity in the world. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a verb. For example:

and the way God does things is just

just: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as just is a close synonym to “truth” in 4:37b. The Aramaic word here is diyn. HALOT, 1852 has: “justice.” The KJV has: “judgment.” However, the latter does not fit the context. Here it has the sense of “fair.” English versions translate it as:

just (GNT)

right (NJB)

fair (CEV)

General Comment on 4:37b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to combine these two parts into one:

^{b-c}Everything that God does is right and just.

^{b-c}All God’s deeds are completely just/fair.

4:37d

And He is able to humble those who walk in pride.

- And he is able to humble those who live with a proud heart/mind.
- He humiliates those who act in an arrogant way.

And: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates And here introduces the third reason why the king praised God. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

those who walk in pride: The verb walk here refers to a customary or habitual manner of living. God is able to humble anyone and everyone who thinks and acts in an arrogant, prideful way. Other ways to translate this include:

those who behave arrogantly (NJPS)

anyone who is full of pride

in pride: In this context, the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as pride has a negative sense. The word describes a person who thinks he is more important than he is. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using an adverb or adjective. For example:

arrogantly (GW)

with arrogant behavior/attitude

thinking themselves great/big

He is able to humble: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as He is able to humble is literally “he is able to make low.” Here is another way to translate this:

he can humiliate (GW)

God is not just able to humble proud people, but he actually does so. If a literal translation would mean that God is only able to do so, it may be necessary to say:

he brings down those who live in a high/arrogant way

God will humiliate proud people

General Comment on 4:37d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the phrases in 4:37d. For example:

And those who walk in pride he is able to humble.
(NIV)

Daniel 5:1

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

English versions give different headings to Daniel 5. These include:

The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

The Writing on the Wall (NIV)

King Belshazzar’s Banquet (CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

Some versions give headings to the subsections of Daniel 5. For example, the NLT has two headings:

The Writing on the Wall (5:1)

Daniel explains the writing (5:13)

The NRSV has three headings:

Belshazzar’s Feast (5:1)

The Writing on the Wall (5:5)

The Writing on the Wall Interpreted (5:13)

You should decide the number of headings that is best in your translation. The purpose of headings is to help readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:1–4

Daniel 5:1–4 introduces a new episode in the narrative. It identifies the time, place, and the major characters in this new episode.

5:1a

Later, King Belshazzar held a great feast for a thousand of his nobles,

- ¶ King Belshazzar invited a thousand of his nobles/officials to a banquet.
- ¶ One day, when Belshazzar was the king of Babylon, he made/organized a big feast for a thousand important men in his land.

Later: The text introduces the main character, Belshazzar, in the first clause. In some languages it may be natural to indicate first when these events happened. The word Later is not in the Aramaic text but the BSB has supplied it to indicate to the reader that the events that follow took place after the previously recorded events. The events in chapter 5 took place about thirty years after the events of chapter 4. Nebuchadnezzar had died in 562 B.C. This episode takes place in 539 B.C. So you may wish to supply a time phrase such as:

A number of years later (NLT)

One time

Later when Belshazzar was king

King Belshazzar held a great feast for a thousand of his nobles: The king of Babylon ordered his servants to prepare a banquet for his guests. Here are some other ways to translate this:

King Belshazzar organized/prepared a big feast for a thousand of his high officials.

King Belshazzar invited a thousand noblemen to a great banquet (GNT)

King Belshazzar: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as King Belshazzar is literally “Belshazzar the king.” This is the first time the text has referred to this person. Your language may have a special way to introduce new people into a story.

King: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as King here refers to the son of the king, who was ruling in the king's place. Belshazzar was probably acting as the king in the capital, while his father was living in another area of the empire. Use the normal word that you have used for king elsewhere in the book of Daniel.

great: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as great here means “big, large, generous.” There was a lot of food and drink for the guests to enjoy.

feast: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as feast literally means “bread.” Here it has the extended meaning of a meal. Use a word appropriate for a fine meal that a king might provide to important people on a special occasion. English versions also say:

festival (NRSV)

banquet (NIV)

a thousand of his nobles: The king may have had more than a thousand nobles. He invited one thousand of them to eat a meal at his palace. The number a thousand may be a round number for an impressive crowd rather than an exact head count.

nobles: The Aramaic title that the BSB translates as nobles refers to important men who participated in the king's court. See the Notes at 4:33. Other ways to say this in English are:

lords (NRSV)

noblemen (GNT)

highest officials (CEV)

5:1b

and he drank wine with them.

- The king drank wine there in the presence of his guests.
- He celebrated and began to drink wine with the other men.

and he drank wine with them: wine was an alcoholic drink that people made from a fruit called grapes.

People usually drank wine on special occasions, especially when there was a celebration or feast. If your culture is not familiar with wine, see the options of how to translate this expression in the Notes at 1:5a.

with them: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as with them is more literally “in front of” or “in the presence of.” However, this does not mean that the king was the only person drinking wine. He probably sat at a high table facing the nobles as he drank wine along with them all.

them: The Aramaic literally says “the thousand,” referring to the noblemen mentioned in 5:1a. Refer back to these nobles in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel 5:2

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus’ army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:1–4

Daniel 5:1–4 introduces a new episode in the narrative. It identifies the time, place, and the major characters in this new episode.

5:2a

Under the influence of the wine,

- As he was drinking/enjoying his/the wine,
- After the king had been drinking for a while,

Under the influence of the wine: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Under the influence of the wine is more literally “in the taste of the wine.” This is a time indicator that introduces the beginning of the action in the story. Belshazzar was enjoying the wine, probably at the end of the meal. Possibly he was drunk and was not thinking clearly. The NRSV says, “Under the influence of the wine....” and the CEV says, “He got drunk.” This is possible but is not stated by the author. However, this is not stated clearly and it is best to

leave this as just a possibility. For example, in English one can say:

While Belshazzar was enjoying the/his wine

In some languages a translation like that of the BSB may suggest that Belshazzar was drinking alone. If that is the case in your language, it may be necessary to say, like the GNT:

While they were drinking (GNT)

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

As he drank the wine

5:2b

Belshazzar gave orders to bring in the gold and silver vessels

- he ordered his servants to bring to him the gold and silver vessels
- he called for the gold and silver cups/bowls

Belshazzar gave orders to bring in the gold and silver vessels: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as gave orders is literally “said in a decree.” Belshazzar made an order or decree that his servants bring him certain goblets made of silver and gold. Other ways to translate this include:

Belshazzar commanded that they bring in the vessels of gold and silver (NRSV)

Belshazzar issued an order to bring in the gold and silver vessels (REB)

and ordered his servants to bring in the gold and silver cups (CEV)

the gold and silver vessels: Workmen or artisans had made these vessels from gold and silver metals. Some of the vessels were made of gold and others were made of silver. It is implied that they were therefore beautiful and valuable. If people do not use or value gold and silver in your culture, you may:

- borrow terms from the national language. It is important that your readers understand that these metals were valuable and beautiful. For example:

vessels of valuable metals/materials called gold and silver

- describe these metals. For example:

vessels made from the most beautiful and precious metals

the treasures

gold: See the Notes at 2:32a. This was the most precious and valuable metal that people had at that time. It was easy for people to bend and shape gold. As a result, people used gold to make coins, jewelry and different vessels.

silver: Silver is a pale colored metal that is lighter and less valuable than gold, but still precious. In the Ancient Near East, silver was a standard of trade and a symbol of wealth. People used silver to make jewelry, coins, and decorations.

vessels: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as vessels is a general word. It can refer to a variety of different containers. In this context, it refers to containers that hold liquids. The Hebrew priest had used these containers to offer sacrifices to God. See the Notes at 1:2b. English versions translate this term in different ways.

cups (NLT)

cups and bowls (GNT)

goblets (NIV)

5:2c

that Nebuchadnezzar his father had taken from the temple in Jerusalem,

- that his father/grandfather Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the temple in Jerusalem.
- that his predecessor King Nebuchadnezzar had removed/looted from God’s house in Jerusalem.

that Nebuchadnezzar his father had taken from the temple in Jerusalem: This clause refers to something that had happened over forty years before. There had been many sacred treasures in the temple. The Hebrew people had used them in their religious ceremonies. Nebuchadnezzar had ordered his men to remove some of these sacred treasures from the temple and to bring them to Babylon. See 1:2b–d. Some of these items, “the gold and silver vessels,” Belshaz-

zar now ordered to be brought to him in the hall of feasting.

Nebuchadnezzar his father: The relationship between Nebuchadnezzar and Belshazzar is not certain. It appears that Belshazzar was the son of King Nabonidus, who had married Nebuchadnezzar's daughter. So in this context the word father can mean both "predecessor" and "ancestor" (here, grandfather).

There are several ways to translate the word father here:

- If your readers will understand that the term father can have this extended meaning, you can use it here.
- You may translate it as "predecessor." For example:

his predecessor Nebuchadnezzar (NLT)

- You may translate it with a word referring to an ancestor. For example:

his grandfather Nebuchadnezzar (GW)

had taken from the temple in Jerusalem: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as had taken refers back to an action that took place forty years before the main narrative. It indicates that King Nebuchadnezzar had commanded his soldiers or servants to carry these treasures out of the temple and back to Babylon. Other ways to translate this include

had carried off from the Temple in Jerusalem (GNT)

had ordered his men to take/steal from the Jerusalem

had looted/confiscated from the house of God in Jerusalem

the temple in Jerusalem: This phrase refers to the building where Jewish people worshiped God and offered sacrifices. God was present there in a special way. See the key term "temple" in KBT.

5:2d

so that the king could drink from them, along with his nobles, his wives, and his concubines.

- He ordered this so that he, together with his nobles/officials, wives, and concubines, could use them to drink from.
- King Belshazzar wanted to be able to drink from these sacred cups/bowls—he himself and his leading/important men, his wives, and his secondary/lesser wives.

so that the king could drink from them, along with his nobles, his wives, and his concubines: The king wanted to display and use the religious treasures from God's temple. He wanted his guests to admire them and admire him for possessing them.

so that: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as so that here introduces a purpose clause. Introduce Nebuchadnezzar's purpose in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

in order that

He wanted to... (GW)

the king: The phrase the king here refers to Belshazzar himself. In some languages it may be natural to use a pronoun here. But make sure that it is clear that the pronoun refers to Belshazzar, not to Nebuchadnezzar. The GNT uses the pronoun "he."

could drink from them: It was an act of disrespect and sacrilege to drink from the holy cups and bowls in this way. The priests of God had dedicated these vessels to God, for service in God's temple. Now Belshazzar wanted to use them for a drinking party. This showed that he had no respect for God.

In some cultures readers might not understand that it was disrespectful to drink from the cups. It may be necessary to indicate or imply this by the way you translate drink from them. For example:

might enjoy drinking from them

might make use of them in their drinking

might put them to use themselves

along with his nobles: See the Notes on this title at 5:1a.

his wives, and his concubines: These two groups of women, wives and concubines, together made up the king's harem. They were all the king's sexual partners and could not marry anyone else.

his wives: The king's wives had the higher status. They generally brought a dowry into the marriage, their children had full inheritance rights, and if the king died they kept a position of privilege.

and his concubines: A “concubine” was a secondary wife. The relationship was permanent and recognized, but concubines had lower status than the official wives. They had fewer legal rights, and the children they bore to the king also had fewer rights. A “concubine” was often a female slave whom the king purchased or took captive in a war.

However, scholars disagree as to the meaning of the Aramaic word used here:

- It means concubines. That is, it means wives of secondary status. For example:

his concubines (GNT) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, GW, GNT, NLT)

- It means female entertainers or slaves who were not in an official or recognized relationship with the king. For example:

the women who sang for him (NJB) (NJB, NCV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. In some languages it may be natural to describe the role of concubine with a phrase such as:

junior/lesser wives

wives of second rank

Daniel 5:3

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

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Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle.

and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:1–4

Daniel 5:1–4 introduces a new episode in the narrative. It identifies the time, place, and the major characters in this new episode.

5:3a

Thus they brought in the gold vessels that had been taken from the temple, the house of God in Jerusalem,

- So they brought the golden vessels which King Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the temple, the house of God in Jerusalem,
- So the servants fetched the gold and silver cups that the Babylonians had removed/looted from God's house, the temple in Jerusalem.
- At once the sacred bowls from God's temple were brought/carried in to the banquet hall.

Thus: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Thus* here introduces what Belshazzar's servants did in obedience to his order. It marks the next phase of the action. Other ways English versions translate this are:

Then (RSV)

At once (GNT)

they brought in: The pronoun *they* refers to the people whom the king had ordered to bring in the vessels (5:2b). They were probably servants. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

the servants brought (GW)

the gold vessels: See the Notes at 5:2b. There is a textual problem in this verse. The expression “and silver” is not in the MT but is in Theodotion and the Vulgate. The Old Greek does not mention either silver or gold (Lucas, p. 120). The two possibilities are:

1. The original text did not mention the silver vessels, only the gold. The Aramaic text that we now have (the MT) does not mention the silver cups. For example:

the golden vessels (ESV) (BSB, KJV, GNT, NIV, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, NJPS, NASB)

1. The original text mentioned both the gold and the silver goblets that the king had ordered to be brought. For example:

the gold and silver vessels (NET) (NET, RSV/NRSV, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The original text probably did not mention the silver goblets. The context, however, implies them. In some languages a literal translation may imply that the servants disobeyed the king by bringing only some of the goblets. In those languages you may wish to refer back to the goblets in a different way. For example:

the/those precious goblets

that had been taken from the temple, the house of God in Jerusalem: In 586 BC, Nebuchadnezzar's soldiers had conquered Jerusalem and taken these sacred treasures from the temple. See the Notes at 5:2c. The verb *had been taken* is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

that had been confiscated from the temple (NET)

- Using an active verb. For example:

belonging to the house of God, the temple in Jerusalem (REB)

that they had brought from God's temple in Jerusalem

the house of God in Jerusalem: See the Notes on “house of God” at 1:2b. This expression is a synonym of the word “temple.” The author repeated the idea in order to emphasize the sacred nature of the goblets and the disrespect Belshazzar was showing. In some languages it may be unnatural to repeat this information in this way. If this is the case in your language, you may combine the two expressions, as the BSB has done. For example:

God's temple (GW)

the building where they worshiped God

the temple where God was present

Whatever option you choose, you should communicate that Belshazzar's order was irreverent and showed disrespect for sacred things.

General Comment on 5:3b

The repetition of the information about the gold goblets from 5:2 emphasizes the importance of the sacred goblets. However, in some languages it may not be natural to repeat the information. Another way to translate this is:

When the gold cups were brought in... (CEV)

Try to emphasize the importance of the sacred vessels in a way that is natural in your language.

5:3b

and the king drank from them, along with his nobles, his wives, and his concubines.

- and the king, his nobles/officials, his wives, and his concubines drank from them.
- Everyone at the banquet drank from them—the king, his leading/important men, his wives and his secondary/lesser wives.

and the king drank from them, along with his nobles, his wives, and his concubines: The author here repeated the information about the guests in order to emphasize how many people acted in a disrespectful way toward God. For information on how to translate these references to the various guests, see the Notes at 5:2d.

General Comment on 5:3

If it is unnatural to repeat so much information, you may be able to translate in a briefer way. For example:

When the gold cups were brought in, everyone at the banquet drank from them (CEV)

At once the gold cups and bowls were brought in, and they all drank wine out of them (CEV)

Daniel 5:4

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Paragraph 5:1–4

Daniel 5:1–4 introduces a new episode in the narrative. It identifies the time, place, and the major characters in this new episode.

5:4a

As they drank the wine,

- As they drank the wine,
- While drinking and drinking,

As they drank the wine: This clause repeats information from 5:3b. This repetition makes a strong connection between the drinking and the worship of the false gods. Here are some other ways to translate this:

While they drank from them (NLT)

During the drinking party

Drinking and drinking,

5:4b

they praised their gods of gold and silver, bronze and iron, wood and stone.

- they praised their gods, idols made from gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood, and stone.
- they praised the idols they worshiped. They had made these idols out of gold and silver, bronze, iron, wood, and stone.

they praised: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as praised means “spoke well of.” The drinkers thought that their gods had given them victory over Israel and its God, and so they praised and honored them. The author used the same word in 2:23a when Daniel praised God, and in 4:34c when Nebuchadnezzar praised the God of heaven. See how you translated it there.

their gods of gold and silver, bronze and iron, wood and stone: The Babylonians made idols from these different materials. Some idols were made from one

material and some from another. The various materials were not combined in one idol.

In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb, either passive or active, and say:

the gods made from gold and silver, bronze, iron, wood and stone

the idols their craftsmen had formed from gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood or stone

gods: The Babylonians worshiped many different false gods. These gods were represented by figures made from different materials. So the NLT translates this as:

idols (NLT)

gold: See the Notes at 5:2b.

and silver: See the Notes at 5:2b.

bronze: See the Notes at 2:32c. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as bronze can refer to either bronze or copper. Most versions have bronze. bronze is an alloy of copper and tin. It is stronger than copper and has a reddish brown color. If your language does not have a word for bronze, you may:

- use a national language word for bronze or copper
- use a phrase like “a reddish-brown metal.”

iron: See the Notes at 2:33a. People valued iron for its superior strength. If you do not have a word for iron in your language you may:

- use a national language word for iron.
- use a phrase like “a very strong metal.”

wood: The Babylonians carved some of their idols out of wood.

and stone: The Babylonians sculpted some of their idols from different types of rock.

General Comment on 5:4

There are various ways to list and organize the materials mentioned in 5:4. For example:

gold and silver, bronze and iron, wood and stone
(NJB)

List these materials in the way that is most natural in your language.

Daniel 5:5

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

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Paragraph 5:5–6

The king suddenly saw a hand, writing a message on the wall.

5:5a

At that moment the fingers of a human hand appeared

- ¶ Suddenly they saw the fingers of a man's hand
- ¶ All of a sudden a man's hand could be seen. Its fingers

At that moment: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as that moment means "a short space of time, at once." Here it introduces an event that shocked and surprised the people at the banquet. The hand appeared out of nowhere, not gradually but instantaneously. See also 3:6,15; 4:16, 30. Other ways to translate this include:

At that very moment (NLT)

Just then (NJPS)

the fingers of a human hand appeared: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as appeared is literally "came forth." Where the hand came from is not stated. It was apparently visible to everyone present. They could see what appeared to be a person's hand. Other ways to translate this include:

the fingers of a human hand came into view/sight

a human hand was seen (CEV)

they saw the fingers of a human hand (NLT)

a hand became visible

the fingers of a human hand: The fact that these were fingers of a hand may be implied by the context. It may then be natural to say:

a man's fingers

However, in some languages it may be necessary to mention the hand in order to distinguish between fingers and toes.

In other languages it may be more natural to leave the idea of fingers implicit. For example:

a human hand (GNT)

Translate in a way that is most natural in your language.

human hand: In this context the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as human can refer to either a man or a person in general. Use the expression that is most natural in your language:

a man's hand (RSV)

a person's hand (NCV)

5:5b

and wrote on the plaster of the wall,

- writing on the white plaster wall
- wrote some letters on the plaster wall

and wrote: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as and wrote can also be translated as:

began writing (NRSV)

began to write (NJB)

In some languages it may be necessary to also translate an object of the verb. For example:

It wrote something...

it wrote letters

on the plaster of the wall: plaster is a white substance that people made from mixing lime with water. People used it to cover walls and floors. Archeologists have discovered that the throne room in the palace of Babylon was covered with fine, white plaster. ISBE 3: 883. There are different ways to translate this expression:

If you do not have plaster in your culture, you may be able to say:

on the whitewashed surface of the inner wall

on white colored wall

Use an expression that is most natural in your language.

5:5c

near the lampstand in the royal palace.

- by the lamp that stood in the king's palace.
- of the palace, where the lamp was shining.

near the lampstand: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as near describes the position of something relative to something else. English versions have translated it in different ways. For example, it can refer to something that is:

1. in front of something else. For example:

opposite the lampstand (RSV)

1. near something else. For example:

next to the lampstand (NRSV)

1. behind something else. For example:

directly behind the lampstand (NJB)

The exact translation of this preposition depends upon where the king was sitting in relation to the lampstand. This is uncertain. A good option is to translate the implied meaning of this expression. For example:

where the light from the lamps was shining most brightly (GNT) The GeCL97 has : « it was exactly in the place where the light of the lamp fell. »

where people could see it very clearly Translator's Handbook on Daniel.

in the lamplight

the lampstand: There are at least two ways to interpret the definite article the in this phrase:

1. The definite article may refer to a particular lampstand. That is, it may refer to the one that was near the throne.
2. The definite article may imply that there was only one lampstand in the huge hall.

Interpretation (1) is probably best.

in the royal palace: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as palace refers to the residence of an important person. the royal palace, literally, “the palace of the king,” was the building or group of buildings where the king and his family lived. It included a throne room where the king met special visitors. There was a large courtyard in front of the throne and a special hall for banquets.

Palaces were very big and had beautiful, expensive furnishings and decorations. If people in your region are not familiar with palaces, you may be able to use a word or phrase that describes the residence of an important person. See the Notes at 1:4c.

5:5d

As the king watched the hand that was writing,

- The king watched it writing.
- The king observed carefully while the hand wrote the letters.

As: The Aramaic text connects 5:5d to 5:5a–c with the common conjunction that the BSB translates as As and the RSV translates as “and.” Here it introduces what happened at the same time as the hand wrote on the wall. You should connect this verse part to the previous verse part in a way that is natural in your language.

the king watched the hand that was writing: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as watched indicates continuous action. The king could see the hand all the time it was writing on the wall. The focus here is on the king, but he was probably not alone in what he could see. Avoid implying that he was the only one who could see the hand. Other ways to translate this include:

The king watched as the hand wrote (GW)

The king could see it writing (CEV)

The king himself saw the hand as it wrote (NLT)

the hand: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates the hand is literally “the palm of the hand.” However, anyone watching could not see the palm of the hand while the hand was writing. So most English translations interpret this as referring to the hand as opposed to the lower arm. The point seems to be that the hand was not attached to an arm. Lucas (p. 120) explains that the expression *pas yedāh* “denotes the hand itself, as distinct from simple *yedāh*, which denotes the lower arm and the hand.” He adds “that the word *pas* usually refers to the palm, but ‘palm of the hand’ would not make good sense here. The implication here seems to be that it was only the hand that was seen, with no arm visible.” See also Goldingay, p. 101, note 5b.

that was writing: The Aramaic verb form that the BSB translates as was writing refers to continuous action. Use a verb form in your language that describes continuous action in the past. For example:

as it was writing

General Comment on 5:5a–d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 5:5a–d. For example:

^{a-d}Suddenly, a man’s fingers and hand appeared near the lamp. The king watched it as it wrote on the plaster wall of his palace.

^{a-d}Just at that time, the king saw a hand. The hand was writing on the white plaster wall of the palace, near to where the lamp was shining.

Daniel 5:6

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

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Paragraph 5:5–6

The king suddenly saw a hand, writing a message on the wall.

5:6a

his face grew pale and his thoughts so alarmed him that

- Then his face changed color and he became very afraid.
- He became so frightened that his face turned white.

The Aramaic text connects 5:6a to 5:5d with a conjunction that the RSV translates as “then.” It introduces a new stage of the action in an emphatic way. The BSB does not explicitly translate it. You should introduce what happened in response to the appearance of the hand in a way that is natural in your language.

his face grew pale: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as his face grew pale is more literally “his brightness changed.” See the Notes at 2:31; 4:36b. Here it refers to the king's face. You should use an expression that describes the way a person's face changes when they receive a sudden shock and become afraid. For example:

Then the king's face changed color.

His face turned white (NCV)

Languages may describe this change in different ways. It may be necessary to indicate why the king's face changed color. See the General Comment on 5:6a–b for ways to do this by reversing or combining the information.

and his thoughts so alarmed him that: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as his thoughts so alarmed him is more literally “his thoughts alarmed him.” Other ways to translate this include:

King Belshazzar was very frightened (NCV)

his thoughts terrified him (NRSV)

General Comment on 5:6a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 5:6a–b. For example:

^{6b}He was so frightened that ^{6a}his face turned pale (CEV)

In other languages it may be natural to combine 6a-b. For example:

^{6a-b}his face turned pale with fright (NLT)

5:6b

his hips gave way

- He lost his strength/control
- He became weak in the legs,

his hips gave way: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as his hips gave way is literally “the knots of his loins/hips were loosened.” The word meaning “loins” or hips is often a metaphor for strength. So this probably indicates that the king lost strength and could no longer stand up. The expression implies that the king was very afraid. There are different ways to translate this. For example:

his legs gave way beneath him (NLT)

his legs became weak (CEV)

the strength went from his legs (REB)

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

5:6c

and his knees knocked together.

- and his knees began to knock together.
- and his knees began to shake/tremble.

and his knees knocked together: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as his knees knocked together indicates that the king’s legs were shaking from fear. His legs trembled and so his knees kept bumping or “knocking” together. This action symbolized that the king was very afraid. Translate this so that this is clear. Other ways to say this include:

His knees knocked together in fear (NLT)

his knees began to shake (GNT)

His knees trembled

In some languages, this action may not be natural and may not clearly imply that the king was afraid. If that is true in your language, you may translate more generally. For example:

He began to tremble/shake all overLa Bible du Semeur.

General Comment on 5:6

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of the clauses. For example:

^bKing Belshazzar was very frightened. ^aHis face turned pale, ^dhis knees knocked together, ^cand he could not stand up because his legs were too weak. (NCV)

Daniel 5:7

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

English versions give different headings to Daniel 5. These include:

The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

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King Belshazzar’s Banquet (CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

Some versions give headings to the subsections of Daniel 5. For example, the NLT has two headings:

The Writing on the Wall (5:1)

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The NRSV has three headings:

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You should decide the number of headings that is best in your translation. The purpose of headings is to help readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:7–9

The king summoned his advisers to interpret the writing on the wall. A number of English versions begin a new paragraph at this verse.

5:7a

The king called out for the enchanters, astrologers, and diviners to be brought in,

- ¶ Then the king shouted for his spell/charm makers, astrologers, and divination experts to come to him.
- ¶ Then the king called loudly to his servants to bring/summon the scholars of Babylon—the experts in spells/charms, the wizards, and others who studied magic.

The king called out for the enchanters, astrologers, and diviners to be brought in: The king was terrified by what he saw, and so he called for his advisers and religious experts. He probably ordered his servants to tell these advisers to come to him in the palace. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that the king did not speak to the advisers in person. For example:

The king shouted for the enchanters, astrologers, and fortune-tellers to be brought before him. (NLT)

He shouted for someone to bring in the magicians, wizards, and astrologers (GNT)

He called out to his servants, ordering them to bring the enchanters, astrologers, and diviners to him.

The king called out: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as called out is literally “called with power to bring in.” Other ways to translate this include:

The king called loudly to bring in (ESV)

He shouted for (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's command using direct speech. For example:

The king shouted to his servants, “Bring/Call my enchanters, astrologers and diviners!”

the enchanters, astrologers, and diviners: This list probably includes examples of the various kinds of experts whom the king summoned. See the General Comment at the end of 5:7a.

See the Notes at 2:2a and how you translated the list there and at 2:10b.

enchanters: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as enchanters refers to people who performed rituals in order to influence the future. For example, they might try to cast a spell on someone by using a charm. These same experts would also try to interpret omens. See the Notes on the second word in the list at 2:2a. See also 2:10c, 27b; 4:4; 5:11, 2:15. You should translate using the same word here.

astrologers: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as astrologers is literally “Chaldeans,” as the footnote in the BSB indicates. See the Notes on the fourth word in the list at 2:2a. This word can have different meanings depending on the context. Here it refers to people who were experts in the occult and magical rites. They were also skilled at solving mysteries. You should try to use the same word that you used in 2:2a.

diviners: The meaning of the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as diviners is uncertain. It may refer

to people who used occult means to determine what would happen to someone in the future. See the Notes at 2:27 and 4:7a. Translate it in the same way here you did there. For example, the GW says “fortune tellers.”

General Comment on the List in 5:7a

The expert advisers in this list are probably examples of the various kinds of experts whom the king summoned. Your language may not have a specific term for each of these experts. If that is true, you may have to use one term for two or three of the terms listed here. Another option is to begin the list with a general term. For example:

any of his experts , such as...

all the king’s advisers , including...

the wise men of Babylon ,...

See also the General Comment on 5:7a–b at the end of 5:7b.

5:7b

and he said to these wise men of Babylon,

- Then he told these expert advisers of Babylon,
- When they came, the king declared,

and: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces what happened after the experts and advisers arrived. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit, as some English versions have done:

When they came in (GNT)

The he said to these wise men... (NIV)

he said: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as said is literally “answered and said.” It indicates that the king was about to announce something important to the whole group of wise men. Another way to say this is:

he declared

the king proclaimed

to these wise men of Babylon: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as these wise men of Babylon is more literally “the wise men of Babylon.” In this context it refers back to all the experts whom the king

had summoned in 5:7a. Refer back to this group of men in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 5:7a–b.

The word that the BSB translates as wise men here refers to royal advisers, experts who worked for the king. The Aramaic word is *ḥakim*. It occurs at 2:12, 14, 18, 24, 27, 48; 4:3, 15; 5:7, 15. In some languages a literal translation wise men may imply the wrong meaning, that these were ordinary men who were wise. To avoid this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to translate this as:

royal advisers

wise advisers (GW)

Babylon: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Babylon can refer to either the city of Babylon or the kingdom of Babylonia. If you must distinguish between the two, it is recommended that you refer to the city of Babylon.

General Comment on 5:7a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder some of this information. You may wish to indicate in 5:7a that the various experts were members of the group called “the wise men of Babylon.” Then in 5:7b you may be able to refer to them using a pronoun. For example:

^{7a}The king summoned the wise men of Babylon—the enchanters, astrologers, and diviners. ^{7b}When they came in, he said to them....

5:7c

“Whoever reads this inscription and tells me its interpretation

- “If any of you can read this writing and tell me what it means,
- “I will reward anyone who is able to read these words and interpret/explain their meaning.

Whoever reads this inscription: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as Whoever reads this inscription implies that most people present, including the king himself, could not read the writing. The king was trying to find out if anyone was able and willing to read it. Other ways to translate this include:

Whoever can read this writing (NRSV)

The man who can read this writing (CEV)

If anyone is able to read this to me

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *and* here probably introduces a second thing the king wanted the experts to do

tells me its interpretation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as *tells* means “declares, makes known.” Other ways English versions translate this include:

shows me its interpretation (RSV)

explain it (NCV)

5:7d

will be clothed in purple

- I/they will give him purple clothes/robes to wear.
- He will receive luxurious/royal clothes

will be clothed in purple: This phrase describes the first reward that the king promised to give to the person who read the message. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as *will be clothed* is passive in form. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

he will be able to wear purple clothes

I/They will give him purple clothes/robes to wear

purple: In the Ancient Near East purple clothes were very expensive. These clothes were expensive because the purple color was obtained from the mollusks that lived in the eastern Mediterranean sea. It took approximately 8000 mollusks to produce one gram of purple dye. Usually only kings and queens wore clothes that were purple. Check that your reader understand that wearing purple clothes was a sign of high status. In some languages it may be natural to supply this implied information. For example:

purple robes of royal honor (NLT)

robes of royal purple (GNT)

purple clothes fit for a king (NCV)

5:7e

and have a gold chain placed around his neck,

- I will place a gold chain around his neck/shoulders.

- and a great necklace made from gold.

and have a gold chain placed around his neck: This phrase tells the second reward the king promised to give to the person who interpreted the message. The Aramaic text does not include a verb and more literally says “and a necklace of gold on his neck.” The BSB has supplied the passive verb “have...placed.” If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

He will receive a golden necklace/chain for his neck

I will give him a gold chain to wear around his neck.

gold chain: A chain made from gold was very expensive. The king would give a gold chain if he wanted to honor someone in a special way. In some languages, a literal translation of chain might suggest imprisonment or punishment. In those languages it may be necessary to:

- use a word for an ornamental chain. For example:

necklace (NASB)

collar (NET)

- include the implied information that the gold chain was for beauty and honor. For example:

They/I will honor him by placing a gold chain around his neck

wear a gold chain of honor around his neck (GNT)

See also the General Comment on 5:7c–f for another way to indicate the significance of the chain.

placed around his neck: Consider how it is natural to describe the placement of an ornamental chain that a man of high status might wear. In some languages it may be natural to say:

placed on his shoulders

he will wear across his shoulders

5:7f

and he will be made the third highest ruler in the kingdom.”

- And I will make him the third highest/ranking ruler in the kingdom.
- He will be appointed as the third most powerful ruler in the kingdom.

and he will be made the third highest ruler in the kingdom: This clause describes the third reward that the king promised to whoever interpreted the message: the king would make him third in rank in the kingdom. This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

I will appoint him as the third highest ruler in the kingdom

third highest ruler: There are at least two ways to interpret this expression. It can mean:

1. He would be the third highest ruler. The highest ruler was the king, the second highest was either his son or the queen mother, and this man would be the third in rank. For example:

the third in power in the kingdom (GNT) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, GW, NLT, REB)

1. He would be one of three rulers. For example:

one of the three men who govern the kingdom (NJB) (NJPS, NJB)

The RSV, KJV, ESV, NASB are ambiguous (“the third ruler”). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English translations.

General Comment on 5:7c–f

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of these clauses. If the reward of high rank is mentioned before the purple clothes and gold chain, their significance may be more clear. For example:

^{7c}The man who can read this writing and tell me what it means ^{7f}will become the third most powerful man in my kingdom. ^{7d}He will wear robes of royal purple ^{7e}and a gold chain around his neck. (CEV)

^{7c}If any of you can read and interpret this writing for me, ^{7f}I will appoint him as the third most powerful ruler in my kingdom. ^{7d}I will give him royal robes to wear ^{7e}and I will place a gold chain around his neck.

Daniel 5:8**Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar**

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

English versions give different headings to Daniel 5. These include:

The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

The Writing on the Wall (NIV)

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In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

Some versions give headings to the subsections of Daniel 5. For example, the NLT has two headings:

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Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:7–9

The king summoned his advisers to interpret the writing on the wall. A number of English versions begin a new paragraph at this verse.

5:8a

So all the king's wise men came in,

- All the king's wise/expert advisers entered the banquet hall/room,
- Although all the king's scholars/experts came forward,

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *So* here introduces a new stage in the action in an emphatic way.

all the king's wise men came in: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as *came in* is literally “were going in. It probably refers to the entrance of the various wise men into the very room where the lamp was shining and the words were visible. Perhaps the king had got up from the banquet hall and gone outside the room to wait for and speak to the wise men in the previous verse. Now they entered the dining hall to see what the writing was. There is implied information here: after entering, the wise men looked at the writing on the wall. In some languages it may be

natural to imply this by indicating that the wise men approached the writing. For example:

The royal advisers came forward (GNT)

5:8b

but they could not read the inscription or interpret it for him.

- but they were unable to read the writing or explain what the words meant.
- none of them could read the words on the wall and none of them could interpret/explain their meaning.

but: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *but* here introduces a contrast. Although all the wise advisers came and looked at the writing, none of them could read the message. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

they could not read the inscription: The text does not say why the king and his guests could not read the writing. Possibly the letters on the wall were only consonants, with no vowel marks. Or possibly they were in a script that those present did not know, rather than the usual Aramaic script.

or interpret it for him: The Aramaic text says literally “and make known to the king the interpretation.” The Aramaic verb meaning “make known” is different from the verb in 5:7c, but it has the same meaning, “inform, cause to know.” Other ways to translate this include:

or tell him what it meant (NLT)

or explain its meaning

or interpret its message

Daniel 5:9

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:7–9

The king summoned his advisers to interpret the writing on the wall. A number of English versions begin a new paragraph at this verse.

5:9a

Then King Belshazzar became even more terrified,

- So the king became more afraid than before,
- As a result the king's fear increased
- This made the king even more alarmed

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Then* here introduces a new stage in the action. Here is another way to translate this:

So (NIV)

King Belshazzar became even more terrified: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as *terrified* is an intensive form of the verb translated as “so alarmed him” in 5:6b. This is the same verb as in 5:6 but in a different form. Here the verb is a participle. In 5:6 it was an imperfect. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Became greatly terrified (NRSV)

The king grew even more alarmed (NLT)

the king was more afraid than ever before (CEV)

You should use a way that is natural in your language to describe a stronger reaction than in 5:6b.

5:9b

his face grew even more pale,

- and his face changed color even more.
- and his face became even whiter.

his face grew even more pale: This is the same expression as in 5:6a, except here the Aramaic text says that “his brightness/face changed over him.” The added phrase “over him” adds emphasis. English versions have expressed this emphasis in different ways. For example:

grew even paler (GNT)

And his face became even whiter (NCV)

Each language has its own way to describe a person's face when they become very afraid. Choose an expression that is natural in your language and indicates an increase in fear.

5:9c and his nobles were bewildered.

- His nobles/officials were confused.
- His important/leading men did not know what to do.

his nobles were bewildered: English versions interpret the Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as were bewildered in several ways:

1. It means "were confused." The nobles did not know what to say or do. This was a big problem. For example:

his lords were perplexed (RSV) (BSB, NIV, NCV, RSV/NRSV, GW, GNT, REB, NASB, ESV, CEV, NET)

1. It means "disturbed." The nobles were shocked and distressed. For example:

His noblemen were equally disturbed (NJB) (NJB, NLT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. Other ways to translate this include:

they were completely puzzled (CEV)

and his noblemen had no idea what to do

his nobles were perplexed

nobles: The nobles were the men whom the king had invited to the banquet in 5:1. See the Notes at 5:1a.

Daniel 5:10

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

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Paragraph 5:10–12

The queen now entered the banquet hall and addressed the king.

5:10a–b

Hearing the outcry of the king and his nobles, the queen entered the banquet hall: These verse parts indicate that the queen came into the banquet room when and because she heard the men speaking. In this context, the two ideas are close in meaning. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate the connection in an explicit way. The idea may be implied from the context. Here are some ways to indicate this connection:

The queen mother heard the noise made by the king and his noblemen and entered the banquet hall (GNT)

Then the king's mother, who had heard the voices of the king and his royal guests, came into the banquet room. (NCV)

When the queen heard the king and his officials talking, she came in (CEV)

The queen heard the raised voices of the king and his noblemen. So she came into the banquet hall...

General Comment on 2:10a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the two verbs in these verse parts. For example:

The queen herself entered the banquet hall when/ because she heard the raised voices of the king and his nobles.

5:10a

Hearing the outcry of the king and his nobles, the queen

- ¶ The queen heard the king and his nobles talking about this,

- ¶ Then because even she could hear their loud conversation/discussion,

Hearing the outcry of the king and his nobles, the queen: In the Aramaic text, the word queen is emphasized by its position in the sentence. In Aramaic the word that the BSB translates as the queen is the first word in the sentence. The NIV follows the Aramaic order to show this emphasis:

The queen, hearing the voices of the king and his noble (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to add this emphasis in a different way. For example:

The queen herself heard the king and his nobles speaking

Hearing the outcry of the king and his nobles: The BSB has supplied the word Hearing. The Aramaic is more literally “because of the voices of the king and nobles,” as in the NASB. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as outcry is a general one meaning “words, things, matters.” In this context it implies that the men were talking loudly. The queen could probably hear enough of their words to understand what was happening. And she could hear that they were alarmed and worried. It is good to translate in a way that implies this. For example:

hearing their raised voices

the outcry of the king and his nobles: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as outcry has a broad meaning of “words, matters, things.” In this context it refers to the loud discussion that the king and his lords were having. The queen could hear them talking and even shouting. She could hear the panic in their voices, and enough of the subject to understand what was happening. English translations express different parts of this meaning. For example:

the discussion of the king and his lords (NRSV)

the noise made by the king and his noblemen (GNT)

the king and his officials talking (CEV)

It is good to use an expression that indicates or implies both that the queen could hear the subject matter, and that the voices were loud. For example:

Hearing the loud discussion of the king and his nobles

When she heard the king and his nobles talking like this

Hearing their loud voices

the queen: The text does not identify who this person was. Scholars suggest that she was either Belshazzar's mother. According to Herodotus, the mother of Belshazzar was Nitocris the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar. or Nabonidus' mother, that is, Belshazzar's grandmother. See Josephus. The mother of Nabonidus was named Adda-guppi. She was born in 650 and lived to the age of 104. The title could refer to Belshazzar's wife, but 1:2 says that Belshazzar's wives were already present at the banquet. If you have a general title for a queen, it is good to use that here. But if you must be more specific, it is recommended that you use a title that refers to the mother of the queen. For example:

the queen mother (NCV)

It is good to include a footnote saying that the text literally has "queen." If you choose to translate with a general word for "queen," you should include a note that says that this title here probably referred to the mother of the king. The mother of the king at this time was probably Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar and wife of Nabonidus.

5:10b entered the banquet hall.

- so she came into the banquet hall.
- the queen mother entered the room where the king and his nobles/officials were eating/feasting.

entered the banquet hall: The queen entered the large room where the king and his guests were eating and drinking. Other ways to translate this include:

the queen entered the banqueting hall (REB)

came into the banquet room (NCV)

5:10c "O king, may you live forever!" she said.

- She said, "King Belshazzar, may you live for ever!"
- She addressed the king with respect, "Your Majesty, I wish you good health!"

"O king, may you live forever!" she said: The Aramaic text says "the queen said." The Aramaic language often repeats a person's name or title when it first introduces them in a story. In some languages it may be more natural to follow the BSB and use a pronoun.

O king, may you live forever!: This was a common way people greeted the king. It is a figure of speech. It indicates that the speaker respected the king and wished him a long and healthy life. See 2:4b. Use a greeting that is natural in your language and expresses this same meaning. For example:

Long live the king!

In the Aramaic this is a second-person command addressed to the king. Some English versions follow this. For example:

O king, live forever! (NASB)

Your Majesty, may you live forever (GW)

Use a form that is natural in your language for showing respect and honor to someone in authority.

said: In some languages it may be necessary to identify to whom the queen was speaking. She was speaking to Belshazzar the king, who was probably her son. For example:

She said to Belshazzar (NLT)

5:10d "Do not let your thoughts terrify you, or your face grow pale.

- Do not be afraid. There is no need to look so white/frightened!
- You do not have to look so pale and frightened! Cheer up!

Do not let your thoughts terrify you: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as Do not let your thoughts terrify you is literally "Do not let your thoughts alarm you." See the Notes at 5:6a, where the same verb phrase occurs. The queen was telling the king not to panic or be afraid. She was implying that everything would be all right. In translating this, remember that the queen was probably the mother of

the king. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Don't be...afraid about this (NLT)

Please do not be so disturbed (GNT)

There is no need to panic.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive expression. For example:

Relax.

Calm down.

or your face grow pale: See the Notes at 5:6a. Here the text is more literally "Do not let your brightness be changed." The queen told the king that he need or should not look so frightened. She implied that it was not necessary because there was nothing to be afraid of. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and don't turn pale (GW)

Please do not...look so pale

There is no need to turn so white!

In some languages it may seem very strange to command someone not to change color. If that is true in your language, you may have to translate in a more general way. For example:

Please do not look so frightened.

There is no need to be so afraid/upset.

Cheer up!

General Comment on 5:10d

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two commands into one clause. Put the two ideas in the order that is most natural in your language and makes the meaning clear. For example:

Please do not panic and turn pale.

You do not have to turn white with fear!

You should/need not let yourself look so alarmed/upset.

Daniel 5:11

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

English versions give different headings to Daniel 5. These include:

The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

The Writing on the Wall (NIV)

King Belshazzar's Banquet (CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

Some versions give headings to the subsections of Daniel 5. For example, the NLT has two headings:

The Writing on the Wall (5:1)

Daniel explains the writing (5:13)

The NRSV has three headings:

Belshazzar's Feast (5:1)

The Writing on the Wall (5:5)

The Writing on the Wall Interpreted (5:13)

You should decide the number of headings that is best in your translation. The purpose of headings is to help readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:10–12

The queen now entered the banquet hall and addressed the king.

5:11a

There is a man in your kingdom who has the spirit of the holy gods in him.

- A man here in your kingdom has a spirit like that of the holy gods.
- There is a man who lives here in Babylon who has special powers. The sacred gods/deities have given him their spirit.

In this verse the queen explained the reason why the king should not be afraid. She knew someone who could solve the problem. In the Aramaic text, as in the BSB, this connection is left implicit. But in some languages it may be natural to introduce this clause with a word or phrase meaning “for” or “because.” For example:

For in your kingdom there lives a man who...

There is a man in your kingdom: In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the words in this clause. For example:

There is in your kingdom a man (RSV)

In your kingdom there is a man (NJB)

For living in your kingdom is a man

in your kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom in this context refers to the territory that the king ruled. This man lived in the land of Babylonia.

who has the spirit of the holy gods in him: The word gods is plural. The Babylonians believed in many gods. See the Notes at 4:8c. The queen believed that Daniel had received special wisdom from the gods. There are different ways to translate this. For example:

the spirit of the holy gods lives in him

to whom the holy gods have given their spirit

the holy/sacred gods have given him their power/
wisdom

spirit: See the Notes at 4:8c. This expression here probably refers to wisdom or power/ability. Here is another way to translate this:

special powers (CEV)

the holy gods: See the Notes at 4:8c. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as holy here describes the gods as completely different and separate from people. They belong to the supernatural realm. Here are some ways to translate this:

the gods, who are completely separate/different
from human beings (TH)

the gods, who live above/afar

the gods on high

gods: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates gods is plural. It refers to more than one god. The queen, like the other Babylonians, believed in many gods.

5:11b

In the days of your father

- In the time/days when your father/grandfather Nebuchadnezzar ruled,

- When your predecessor King Nebuchadnezzar was king,

In the days of your father: This is a general expression that refers back to the time when Nebuchadnezzar was king. This was several decades before. You can translate this as:

When your father was king (GNT)

In the time of King Nebuchadnezzar

When Nebuchadnezzar was reigning/ruling

your father: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as father can refer to a father, grandfather, male ancestor or even to a predecessor. In this context it is clear that the queen was referring to Nebuchadnezzar. However, Nebuchadnezzar was not Belshazzar's father. He may have been his grandfather. That is, he may have been the father of the queen mother herself. See the notes on 5:10a. Here are some ways you may translate this:

- You may refer to Nebuchadnezzar by name. For example:

During Nebuchadnezzar's reign (NLT)

When Nebuchadnezzar, was king

- You may use an expression for a predecessor, that is, someone who was king at some time before Belshazzar. For example:

your predecessor, King Nebuchadnezzar

- You may refer to your father if this word can have a more general meaning of "ancestor" or "predecessor." For example:

your father (GNT)

In many languages, it is natural to refer to the name of the person, the first time they are mentioned in a story. But either of the other options is also possible.

5:11c

he was found to have insight, intelligence, and wisdom like that of the gods.

- he/we^(excl) realized that this man had insight and understanding. His wisdom was like the wisdom of the gods.
- this man showed that he could solve difficult problems and understand mysteries. He was as wise as the gods themselves.

he was found to have insight, intelligence, and wisdom like that of the gods: This is a passive clause. It indicates that King Nebuchadnezzar (and others in power at that time, perhaps including the queen herself) realized that Daniel was a very wise man. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. The subject may be either Daniel himself, as in the BSB, or his gifts/abilities. For example:

light and understanding and wisdom, like the wisdom of the gods, were found in him (RSV)

he was known for a perception, intelligence and wisdom comparable to that of the gods (NJB)

- Using an active verb. Various subjects are possible. For example:

the king found/saw that he had insight, intelligence, and wisdom like that of the gods

we^(excl) realized/discovered that he was sensible, intelligent and as wise as the gods themselves

this man showed good sense, knowledge, and wisdom like the wisdom of the gods (GNT)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. Here are some other possibilities:

This Daniel...was found to have knowledge, judgment, and an extraordinary spirit. (GW)

This man showed himself to have insight and understanding. He was wise like the gods.

this man was known to be as smart, intelligent, and wise as the gods themselves (CEV)

insight: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as insight is related to the word meaning "light." Here it used figuratively to refer to the ability to understand

the true meaning/significance of things. HALOT (1927) gives the definition “illumination of the mind.” Other ways English versions translate this are:

good sense (GNT)

understanding (NCV)

perception (NJB)

In some languages it may be more natural to include some implied information. For example:

insight into problems

intelligence: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as intelligence is similar in meaning to the previous word. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel explains that this word describes the “intelligence that enables a person to avoid errors or miscalculations.” English versions translate this expression in different ways:

good judgment (GW)

knowledge (GNT)

understanding (NLT)

In some languages it may be more natural to supply an implied object. For example:

and understood mysteries

wisdom like that of the gods: The Aramaic text compares the wisdom of Daniel to wisdom like that of the gods. Daniel’s wisdom was godlike, divine in quality or source. In some languages it may be natural to compare Daniel himself directly to the gods. For example:

as though he himself were a god (NLT)

wise as the gods themselves (CEV)

wisdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wisdom is a close synonym of the previous two words. It refers to the practical ability to think, speak, and act in a good and sensible way. See the Notes at 2:20b. The same word is used in 2:20c, 23, 30; 5:11, 14; Ezra 7:25.

The corresponding Hebrew word is found in Daniel 1:4b, 7. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a clause. For example:

and he was able to make wise decisions

the gods: The Babylonians, including the speaker, the queen, believed in and worshiped many gods. See the Notes at 5:4.

General Comment on 5:11c

In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract terms “insight,” “intelligence,” and “wisdom” as adjectives or verb phrases. For example:

When your father Nebuchadnezzar was king, this man was known to be as smart, intelligent and wise as the gods themselves (CEV)

When King Nebuchadnezzar was ruling Babylon, this man showed that he could solve difficult problems. He could understand mysteries that others could not understand. He was able to make wise decisions.

In some languages there may be two words or phrases that have the same meaning as the three Aramaic words. If that is true in your language, use those two words or phrases here.

5:11d

Your father, King Nebuchadnezzar, appointed him chief of the magicians, enchanters, astrologers, and diviners. Your own father, the king,

- King Nebuchadnezzar, your father/grandfather the king, made him the chief/head of those who studied magic, those who made spells/charms, the astrologers, and the divination experts.
- King Nebuchadnezzar, your predecessor—yes, King Nebuchadnezzar himself—put him in charge of all his scholars who studied magic, including the fortunetellers, the experts in spells/charms, the wizards, and the sorcerers.

In the Aramaic text this verse part connects to the previous verse part with a common conjunction that the BSB does not translate and the RSV translates as “and.” In this context it introduces what Nebuchadnezzar did when he realized how wise Daniel was. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

So that (REB)

Your father, King Nebuchadnezzar: See the Note at 5:11b. Translate here in a way that is similar to what you did there. The reader should understand that the same man is referred to here and in 5:11b. You may choose not to translate the phrase Your father explicitly if you have already translated this in 5:11b. Refer back to Nebuchadnezzar in a way that is natural in your language.

appointed him chief of: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as appointed him chief here indicates that Nebuchadnezzar gave Daniel the position of head or leading adviser. He put Daniel in charge of the other expert advisers. See the Notes at 2:48c. Here are some other ways to translate this:

made him head of (GW)

made master of (KJV)

put this man in charge of (NCV)

the magicians, enchanters, astrologers, and diviners: See the Notes and Display at 2:2a for a similar list. This list of experts probably consists of examples of various kinds of experts in the occult. In some languages you may have only one or two terms that refer to people who do these things. If that is true in your language, you may be able to begin the list with a general term like “chief of all the experts, such as....”

magicians: See the Notes at 2:2a. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as magicians is a term for people who use occult means to determine the future or to learn secrets. Most English versions translate it as magicians. However, in this context the word “magician” does not have the modern meaning of someone who performs illusions or who does tricks. Translate this term in the same way you did at 2:2a.

enchanters: See the Notes at 2:2a; 5:7a. See also 2:10c, 27b; 4:4; 5:11, 15. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as enchanters describes people who performed rituals in order to influence a person’s future. For example, sometimes they would try to cast a spell on someone by using a charm or magic. They also interpreted omens. You should use the same word you used in 5:7a.

astrologers: The Aramaic word that the BSB transliterates as astrologers is literally “Chaldeans.” It can have various meanings, depending on the context in which it is used. See for example the Notes at 1:4d. Here it refers to people who were experts in the occult and magical rites. They were also people who were

skilled at solving mysteries. Use the same word that you used in 2:2a.

and diviners: See the Notes at 2:27; 4:7a; 5:7a. The term *gʒr* occurs in 2:27; 4:7a; 5:7, 11. HALOT (1844) says that it can have the more general meaning “seer” or alternatively “soothsayer,” “fortune teller.” The meaning of the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as diviners is uncertain. It may refer to people who used occult means to determine what would happen to someone in the future. Translate it in the same way you did at 5:7a. For example: diviners (NJPS, NRSV, REB)–or–fortune tellers (GW, NLT)

General Comment on 5:11d

There is a textual problem at the end of this verse. The Aramaic text repeats the phrase “your father the king.” English versions differ as to whether they include this phrase:

- Some English versions do include the phrase (BSB, KJV, NLT, NIV84, NASB, ESV)
- Most English versions do not include this phrase (RSV/NRSV, GW, REB, GNT, NCV, CEV, NJPS, NJB, NET, NIV11)

The phrase is probably original. See HOTTP. The repetition of the information adds emphasis to the fact that it was King Nebuchadnezzar who appointed Daniel to a high position. The BSB translates this repeated Aramaic phrase as “Your own father, the king.” Here are some other ways to translate this verse part with the repetition included:

and King Nebuchadnezzar your father—your father the king—made him chief of the magicians, enchanters, Chaldeans, and astronomers (ESV)

And King Nebuchadnezzar your father, your father the king, appointed him chief of the magicians, conjurers, Chaldeans and diviners (NASB)

and your father the king put him in charge of the magicians, enchanters, Chaldeans, and diviners. Yes, this was by the order of your father the king.

If this type of repetition is not natural in your language, you may omit it. However, try to express the same emphasis in another way. For example:

and he was appointed chief of all.... by Nebuchadnezzar himself—yes, by your father the king!

and your great ancestor/predecessor made him head over all.... It was King Nebuchadnezzar himself who did this.

Daniel 5:12

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:10–12

The queen now entered the banquet hall and addressed the king.

5:12a–d

did this because Daniel ... was found to have an extraordinary spirit: There are two main ways to understand the function of the Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as because:

1. It introduces the reason for the command to send for Daniel (5:12d). For example:

Since this man Daniel...is filled with such a marvellous spirit...send for him (NJB)

He has unusual ability and is wise and skillful...so send for this man Daniel (GNT) (NJPS, NJB, GNT, REB, implied in NCV, CEV, NLT, GW, NET)

1. It introduces the reason why the king had appointed Daniel as the head of his experts (5:11c). For example:

Your father...made him chief of the magicians...because an excellent spirit... (NRSV) (BSB, RSV/ NRSV, NIV, NASB, ESV, probably KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as do most modern English versions. The queen urged the king to summon Daniel because of Daniel's many excellent qualities and abilities. The NJB is therefore used in the following notes on 5:12 and as the source line in the Display.

5:12a

did this because Daniel, the one he named Belteshazzar,

- This man, Daniel, was given by the king the name Belteshazzar.
- The name of this man was Daniel, but the king gave him the new/Babylonian name "Belteshazzar."

(NJB) Since this man Daniel, whom the king had renamed Belteshazzar: The Aramaic phrase that the NJB translates as Since here introduces the reason for a command that the queen was about to give. She began to explain why she wanted the king to send for Daniel. See the General Comment on 5:12 for another way to show this logical connection.

(NJB) Daniel, whom the king had renamed Belteshazzar: See the Notes at 1:7b. Many years before King Nebuchadnezzar had given Daniel the Babylonian name Belteshazzar. English versions have translated this clause in different ways. For example:

The king gave him the name Belteshazzar

whom the king named Belteshazzar (NIV)

This clause repeats information that was given in previous chapters. In some languages it may be more natural to present this information in a different way. For example, you may:

- Translate this clause as a parenthesis within 5:12b.

This Daniel (whom the king renamed Belteshazzar)... (GW)

- Translate this clause at the beginning of the verse (5:12a).

The King changed the man's named from Daniel to Belteshazzar. (CEV)

- Translate this clause after the name Daniel in 5:12c.

so send for this man Daniel, whom the king named Belteshazzar (GNT)

Present this information in a way that is natural in your language.

5:12b-c

(NJB) is filled with such a marvellous spirit and such knowledge and intelligence in interpreting dreams, solving enigmas, and unravelling difficult problems: The MT describes Daniel's excellence by referring to six qualities or abilities:

an extraordinary spirit and understanding and insight, an interpreter of dreams, and declaring of riddles, and loosening of knots was found in him

Here are some other ways to translate this list of qualities:

He has unusual ability and is wise and skillful in interpreting dreams, solving riddles, and explaining mysteries (GNT)

an excellent spirit, knowledge, and understanding to interpret dreams, explain riddles, and solve problems were found in this Daniel (NRSV)

was found to have knowledge, judgment, and an extraordinary spirit. He has the ability to interpret dreams, solve riddles, and untangle problems. (GW)

was found to have a keen mind and knowledge and understanding, and also the ability to interpret dreams, explain riddles and solve difficult problems (NIV)

5:12b

was found to have an extraordinary spirit, as well as knowledge, understanding,

- Daniel showed/proved himself extraordinarily intelligent and wise, and he had the ability
- He was very smart and he knew many things. He was skilled/good

(NJB) is filled with: The Aramaic phrase that the NJB translates as is filled with is more literally "was found in him." This is a passive verb. See 5:11c, where the same verb is used. Here are some other ways to translate it in this context:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

was found to have an extraordinary spirit, as well as knowledge, understanding (BSB)

- Using an active verb. It may be necessary to use the present tense (“is” or “has”) rather than the past tense (“was found to have”). For example:

This man Daniel is extremely intelligent. He also has/possesses unusual ability and wisdom.

(NJB) such a marvellous spirit: In this context, the Aramaic phrase that the NJB translates as a marvellous spirit refers to great or unusual human intelligence. The English word *such* has been supplied by the NJB to create a natural style. It does not represent a specific word in the Aramaic. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a keen mind (NIV)

a sharp mind (NLT)

very smart (NCV)

(NJB) marvellous: The Aramaic word that the NJB translates as marvellous means “excellent, extraordinary.”

(NJB) such knowledge: The Aramaic word that the NJB translates as knowledge also occurs in 2:21e and 4:34–36. It refers to the ability to discern things. Most English versions translate this as knowledge. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a verb phrase. For example:

and he knows many things

and he is able to discern things

(NJB) intelligence: The Aramaic word that the NJB translates as intelligence also occurs in 5:11b. Here are some other ways to translate it:

understanding (BSB)

insight (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a verb phrase. For example:

He understands how...

he is skilled...

5:12c

and the ability to interpret dreams, explain riddles, and solve difficult problems.

- to interpret dreams, explain riddles, and solve problems.
- at interpreting dreams, explaining riddles, and solving all kinds of problems.

(NJB) in interpreting dreams: Daniel was able to explain the meaning or symbolism of peoples’ dreams. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the ability to interpret dreams (NIV)

He can interpret dreams (NLT)

he can explain dreams (CEV)

(NJB) solving enigmas: Daniel also had the ability to explain the meaning of things that were hard to understand. The Aramaic word that the NJB translates as solving is a synonym to “interpret” and means “making known.” HALOT, 1871. For example:

solve riddles (GW)

explain riddles (NIV)

(NJB) enigmas: The Aramaic expression that the NJB translates as enigmas literally means “things that have been closed up tightly.” In this context, it has the sense of a “puzzle” or “riddle.” HALOT, 1809. Here are some other ways to translate this:

secrets (NCV)

riddles (NIV)

(NJB) and unravelling difficult problems: The Aramaic expression that the NJB translates as unravelling difficult problems literally means “loosening of knots.” In this context, it is a figure of speech that means “solving difficulties.” HALOT, 2003. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as “solve” is a pael participle *mišra’*. It literally means to “untie, loosen.” Here it means to “solve.” The Aramaic word that the BSB translates “difficult problems” is *qeṣar*. It means, “joint” or “knot.” Here it has the figurative meaning, “difficulties.” See HALOT, 1069. The author may have used this phrase in a humorous or ironic way. In 5:6 the king was so alarmed that the “knots” of his hips

were loosened. In 5:12 the king said that he had heard that Daniel could “loosen knots.” In some languages you may be able to translate this irony by translating the two phrases literally. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

untangle problems (GW)

solving difficult problems (NIV)

explaining mysteries (GNT)

The author may have intentionally used this phrase in a humorous way, as a joke or pun. In 5:6 the king was so alarmed that the “knots” of his hips were “loosened.” Here the queen says that she has heard that Daniel can “loosen knots.” In some languages, you may be able to translate literally and maintain the pun. If that is unnatural, translate the meaning in a more direct way.

5:12d

Summon Daniel, therefore, and he will give you the interpretation.”

- So tell Daniel to come to you and he will tell you what the writing means.”
- So you should send your servants to bring Daniel here and he will explain/interpret the meaning of the words/letters on the wall.”

The Aramaic text connects this verse part to the previous verse part with an adverb that the RSV translates as “Now.” This connector here introduces the conclusion of the queen’s speech, her advice to Belshazzar. Here are some other ways to introduce the queen’s concluding advice:

Therefore

so (GNT)

(NJB) send for him: The queen encouraged the king to call for or send for Daniel. The king was not going to call or summon Daniel himself. So in some languages it may be natural to indicate this by saying:

Send your servants to get Daniel...

Tell them (indefinite) to bring Daniel here

If it is more natural and polite in your language to use a passive verb, you may say:

Let Daniel be summoned

(NJB) he will be able to tell you what this means:

The Aramaic text is literally “and he will declare the interpretation.” In some languages it may be natural to indicate what Daniel was to interpret, that is, what the word this represents. For example::

and he will tell you what the writing means (NIV)

He will tell you what the writing on the wall means (NCV)

General Comment on 5:12d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 5:12d and translate the queen’s advice at the end of her speech. For example:

^{12d}He will be able to tell you what the writing means. You should send for him.

Daniel 5:13

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:13–16

The king summoned Daniel and asked him to interpret the writing on the wall. Some versions have a new heading at this verse. The NLT has: "Daniel Explains the Writing." The NRSV has: "The Writing on the Wall Interpreted." The GNT has: "Daniel Explains the Writing."

5:13a

So Daniel was brought before the king,

- ¶ So someone/they brought/led Daniel to the king.

- ¶ So the king sent his servants to bring Daniel to him. When he arrived,

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So and the RSV as "Then" here introduces a new stage in the action. The king did summon Daniel, and he arrived. Introduce this next event in the story in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to supply the implied information that the king did as the queen suggested. For example:

So that is what the king did.

So the king summoned Daniel

Daniel was brought before the king: Daniel entered the king's presence. In the Aramaic text, as in the BSB this is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb and supply a subject. For example:

they brought Daniel to the king (NCV)

the king's servants brought Daniel to the king

a messenger ordered Daniel to come to the king, and he came

before the king: This expression describes a situation where a person of lower status comes to a person of higher status or authority. Some English versions have:

into the king's presence (NJB)

into the royal presence (REB)

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

5:13b

who asked him, "Are you Daniel,

- Then the king said to Daniel, "So are you that/the Daniel
- the king declared, "So you are Daniel, are you?

who asked him: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as asked is literally "answering and saying." This expression implies that the king was about to say something new or important. Try to show this in a way that is natural in your language. For example, you may be able to communicate the same idea with one verb:

The king declared to Daniel

The king addressed Daniel (NJPS)

If you translate the quotation that follows as a question, it may be natural to say:

the king asked him

Are you Daniel...?: Scholars have punctuated this clause in two ways:

1. as a question. The king was asking Daniel for confirmation of his identity. For example:

Is your name Daniel....? (NCV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, GW, NLT, GNT, NCV, KJV, NASB, NET)

1. as a statement. For example:

So you are Daniel (NRSV) (RSV/NRSV, CEV, ESV)

The function of this speech is to confirm and emphasize Daniel's identity. The king already expected to see Daniel and had received information about him. Consider how it is natural in your language for a person of authority, such as a judge, to receive confirmation of the identity of an inferior. Translate this using the form that is most natural in your language, either as a statement or as a question, real or rhetorical. The king was expressing surprise, curiosity, and perhaps even disdain.

5:13c

one of the exiles my father the king brought from Judah?

- who is one of the Jewish exiles whom my father King Nebuchadnezzar brought as captives from the land of Judah?
- I have heard that you are one of those men whom my royal predecessor caused/forced to come here from their own country, Judah.

one of the exiles my father the king brought from Judah: The Aramaic text is more literally "one of the sons of the exile of Judah whom my father the king brought from Judah." The BSB and several other modern translations have chosen not to repeat the place name Judah. The king probably repeated this name to emphasize Daniel's low status. The king wanted to make Daniel seem foreign, unimportant. Try to reflect this emphasis in your translation. For example:

one of those Jewish exiles/deportees whom my father the king brought into the country

one of the exiles: An "exile" is a person whom others have forced to leave his country. The Babylonian army under Nebuchadnezzar had taken many young Jewish men away from their homeland. See 1:1–5. Daniel was among these young men. The Babylonian soldiers had brought him to Babylon to serve the Babylonian empire and king. See the Notes at 2:25b. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one of the Jewish exiles (GNT)

one of those men whom our^(excl) army captured

one of the captives (GW)

my father the king brought from Judah: King Nebuchadnezzar's army had conquered Judah and forced many Jewish youths to leave their homes and come to Babylonia. See the Notes at 1:3b. The king himself had not personally brought the exiles to Babylon. He had ordered his soldiers to bring them. In some languages it may be necessary to supply this implied information. For example:

the king ordered his soldiers to bring

whom his soldiers brought back from Judah

whom the king deported from Judah

The king deliberately focused on Daniel's inferior status as an exile from Judah. This was in contrast to the status of King Nebuchadnezzar, whom he called his father.

my father the king: The actual relationship between Nebuchadnezzar and Belshazzar is uncertain. It is possible that Belshazzar's mother was Nebuchadnezzar's daughter. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as father may also mean "grandfather, ancestor, founder, predecessor." See the Notes at 5:11b–c. Translate this here as you did there. For example:

my predecessor, King Nebuchadnezzar (NLT)

If the word for father in your language can also mean "ancestor" or "predecessor" you can translate literally

here. It may help to add a footnote that explains the possible meanings of “father” in Aramaic.

from Judah: See the Notes on Judah in 1:1a. This name here refers to the kingdom of Judah. Judah was the homeland of Daniel and the other exiles.

Daniel 5:14

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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5:14a

I have heard that the spirit of the gods is in you,

- I have heard that you^(sing) have a spirit like that of the gods
- The queen has told me that the gods have given you^(sing) their spirit of special powers/wisdom.

I have heard that the spirit of the gods is in you:

King Belshazzar repeated what the queen had told him in 5:11a. See the notes there and translate in a similar way here. In some languages it may be natural to indicate how the king had heard about Daniel, that is, who had told him. It was the queen, who was probably his mother, who had told him. For example:

The queen has told me that the spirit of the gods is in you

the spirit of the gods: There is a textual problem here. Scholars differ as to whether the original text said the gods or “the holy gods.” The two views are:

1. The original text did not include the Aramaic word meaning “holy.” The MT does not include this word. For example:

the spirit of the gods (NJB) (BSB, NASB, ESV, KJV, GW, NLT, REB, CEV, NCV, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

1. The original text did include the word “holy” here, as well as in 5:11a. For example:

the spirit of the holy gods (RSV) (RSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the MT and the majority of English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

you have the spirit of the gods (GW)

the spirit of the gods lives in you

the gods have given you their spirit

5:14b

and that you have insight, intelligence, and extraordinary wisdom.

- and that you^(sing) can solve difficult problems and understand mysteries and that you are very wise.
- She said/says that you^(sing) are able to solve difficult problems and you can understand difficult things. She also said/says that you are able to make very wise decisions.

and that you have insight, intelligence, and extraordinary wisdom: The Aramaic more literally says “and that insight, intelligence and outstanding wisdom were found in you.” This is a passive clause very similar to 5:11c. See the Notes there, and translate in a similar way here. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here, using a similar introductory phrase to that in 5:14a. For example:

I have also heard that you have insight, intelligence and outstanding wisdom.

insight: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as insight is related to the word meaning “light.” In this context, it refers to the ability to understand the true

meaning/significance of things. See the Notes at 5:11c. Other ways English versions translate this are:

enlightenment (NRSV)

clear insight (REB)

perception (NJB)

In some languages it may be more natural to include implied information. For example:

insight into problems

intelligence: See the Notes at 5:11c. The word is similar in meaning to “light.” The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as intelligence refers to the ability to understand and explain difficult things. Other ways English versions translate this expression are:

good judgment (GW)

knowledge (GNT, NCV)

understanding (NRSV)

In some languages it may be more natural to add an implied object. For example:

understand mysteries

extraordinary wisdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as extraordinary is used in 5:12b-c. It means “outstanding, marvelous.” The king uses this word where the queen said “like that of the gods” (5:11c). English versions translate this phrase in different ways:

marvelous wisdom (NJB)

exceptional wisdom (REB)

excellent wisdom (NRSV)

General Comment on 5:14b

In some languages it may be natural to translate abstract terms like “insight,” “intelligence,” and “wisdom” using adjectives or verbal clauses. For example:

and that you are perceptive, intelligent and extremely wise

The queen also told me that you can solve difficult problems and understand mysteries that other men cannot understand. She also said that you are able to make very wise decisions.

As noted in the General Comment on 5:11, if you do not have three words similar to these, you may translate using two words or expressions. For example:

and that you are intelligent and very wise (CEV)

Daniel 5:15

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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5:15a

Now the wise men and enchanters were brought before me

- The wise/expert advisers and spell/charm makers have already come
- My servants brought my wise advisers and spell/charm experts

Now the wise men and enchanters were brought before me:

In the Aramaic text this verse connects to the previous verse with a conjunction that the BSB translates as Now. In this context it introduces an event that had just then taken place. In some languages it may be natural to say:

The sages and soothsayers have already been brought to me (NJB)

The wise men, the exorcists, have just been brought before me (REB)

the wise men and enchanter: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the wise men and enchanter is literally “The wise men, the enchanter.” This suggests that in this context both wise men and enchanter are general words. Both refer to the various experts whom the king had mentioned in 5:7a.

the wise men: In some languages a literal translation of the phrase the wise men may imply a wrong meaning in this context. These were men who worked as advisers for the king. They were not ordinary men with special wisdom. See the note at 5:7b. Other ways to say this are:

advisers (GNT)

The wise advisers (GW)

and enchanter: The same word occurs at 2:2a; 5:7a; 5:11d. See also 2:10c, 27b; 4:4; 5:11, 15. Here, however, it does not refer to a specific group of experts as it did in 5:11c. In this context you should use a general word that refers to any experts who try to use the occult to get information or cast spells.

were brought before me: This is a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

my servants brought them to me

they (indefinite) brought them to me

My advisers and enchanter have just come

before me: See the Notes at 5:13a. This expression describes a situation where a person of lower status comes to a person of higher status or higher authority. You can say:

into my presence

into my royal court

5:15b
to read this inscription and interpret it for me,

- and tried to read the writing and tell me its meaning.
- to read the message and interpret it,

to read this inscription: See the Notes at 5:7c. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as to read here implies the meaning “to read aloud.” The king wanted his advisers to read the writing aloud. He did not know whether they would be able to do so. It may therefore be natural to say:

to try to read this writing to me

The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as inscription refers to the words that the hand had written on the wall. In some languages it may be necessary to include this information. For example:

to read the words on the wall (NLT)

and interpret it for me: See the Notes at 5:7c. This is the second thing the king wanted his experts and advisers to do. He wanted them to tell him the meaning of the words on the wall. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and tell me its meaning (GW)

and explain it to me

5:15c
but they could not give its interpretation.

- But they could not tell me what it meant.
- but they were not able to do it.

but: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrast. The king summoned his expert advisers to read and interpret the writing on the wall. However they were unable to do so.

they could not give its interpretation: The Aramaic text more literally says “they were not able to tell the interpretation of the matter.” In many languages it may be natural to translate the abstract term interpretation using a verb. Here are some other ways to do this:

But they could not tell me what it meant (NJPS)

they could not explain it (NIV)

But they have been unable to reveal its meaning.

but they cannot (NLT)

Daniel 5:16

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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5:16a

But I have heard about you, that you are able to give interpretations and solve difficult problems.

- However, I have heard that you^(sing) can interpret things/messages and solve problems.
- But someone has told me that you^(sing) can explain mysteries and that you can solve problems.

But: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast with 5:15c. The king's experts were not able to interpret the writing on the wall, but the king had heard that Daniel had the ability to do this. Here is another way to translate this:

Now (NIV)

Translate the contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

I have heard about you: See the Notes at 5:12a. In some languages it may be more natural to say who told the king this information. For example:

The queen has told me:

Someone has told me:

you are able to give interpretations: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as to give interpretations is literally “to interpret interpretations.” Other ways English versions say this are:

You can interpret such things (GW)

You are able to explain what things mean (NCV)

Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

and solve difficult problems: The Aramaic phrase is literally “loosen knots.” This is the second thing that the king had heard that Daniel was able to do. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit and translate this as a separate clause:

I have also heard that you can solve difficult problems

A similar phrase occurs at 5:12b-c. See how you translated it there. For example:

untangle problems (GW)

unravel problems (REB)

explain mysteries (GNT)

The author may have intentionally used this phrase in a humorous way, as a joke or pun. In 5:6 the king was so alarmed that the “knots” of his hips were “loosened.” Here the king says that he has heard that Daniel can “loosen knots.” In some languages, you may be able to translate literally and maintain the pun. If that is unnatural, translate the meaning in a more direct way.

5:16b

Therefore, if you can read this inscription and give me its interpretation,

- Now if you^(sing) can read the writing and interpret what it means,
- So if you^(sing) can now read the words and explain to me what it means,

Therefore: The BSB translates the Aramaic conjunction that connects this verse part to the previous verse part as Therefore because, in this context, it introduces what the king planned to do in light of what he had heard. Other ways to translate it include:

Now then (CEV)

So then

if you can read this inscription and give me its interpretation: This is a conditional clause with two parts. The king wanted Daniel to read aloud to him the writing on the wall and to explain its meaning. See the Notes at 5:12c, 5:15a.

if you can read this inscription: See the Notes at 5:7c; 5:15b.

and give me its interpretation: See the Notes at 5:7c; 5:15b. You can also say:

and tell me its meaning (GW)

and explain it to me (NCV)

5:16c

you will be clothed in purple

- you^(sing) will be given purple robes to wear
- I will give you^(sing) royal purple clothes to wear.
- you^(sing) will receive magnificent purple robes.

you will be clothed in purple: See the Notes at 5:7d. This is a passive clause. It indicates that the king would reward Daniel by giving him expensive beautiful clothes. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

They will clothe you in purple robes.

I will give you purple clothes to wear.

My servants will give you purple clothes to wear.

In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that purple clothes were beautiful and expensive clothes such as a king would wear. For example:

You will wear royal purple robes (CEV)

I will give you purple clothes fit for a king (NCV)

They will clothe you in magnificent robes.

5:16d

and have a gold chain placed around your neck,

- and have a gold chain placed around your neck,
- I will give you^(sing) a gold chain to wear around your neck.
- You^(sing) will also receive the honor of wearing a gold necklace.

and have a gold chain placed around your neck: See the Notes at 5:7e. This is the second part of the reward. It is also a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

You will...have a gold chain around your neck.
(CEV)

I will place a gold chain around your neck.

They/Someone will put a gold chain around your neck.

5:16e

and you will be made the third highest ruler in the kingdom.”

- And I will make you^(sing) the third highest ruler in the/my kingdom.”
- I will appoint you^(sing) as the third most powerful ruler in Babylon.”

and you will be made the third highest ruler in the kingdom: This is the third part of the reward. See the Notes at 5:7f, and translate it here as you did there. This is also a passive clause. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

I will appoint you as the third highest ruler in the kingdom

General Comment on 5:16c–e

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^eI will appoint you as the third most powerful man in my kingdom. ^fI will give you royal purple robes to wear ^dand a gold chain around your neck.

you will become the third most powerful man in my kingdom. You will wear royal purple robes and have a gold chain around your neck. (CEV)

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Paragraph 5:17

This verse introduces a new speaker, Daniel. Daniel declared that he could read and interpret the writing on the wall.

5:17a

In response, Daniel said to the king, “You may keep your gifts for yourself

- ¶ Then Daniel told the king, “Please just keep^(sing) the/your gifts
- ¶ Then Daniel declared, “I do not want to accept these gifts.

In response: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as In response here introduces a new stage in the narrative. Introduce this next event, Daniel's response to the king, in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

Then (NIV)

Daniel said to the king: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as said is literally “answering and saying.” In this context, this expression implies that Daniel was about to announce something new and important. In your translation, try to indicate that Daniel was about to say something important. For example:

Daniel declared

Daniel gave his answer to the king

to the king: In Aramaic this expression is more literally “before the king” and implies that Daniel was speaking to someone who had a higher status than he did. Here is another way to translate this:

in the presence of the king (NRSV)

You may keep your gifts for yourself: Daniel spoke directly to the king. He told the king to keep his gifts. He did not want them. In some languages, people might consider it impolite to talk to a king in this way. It is good to translate this in a way that is direct but not rude. For example:

It is good/fine for you to keep your gifts

I do not look for gifts from you (REB)

Please keep those gifts for yourself.

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that Daniel did not want the king's gifts. You may need to supply something like this:

Do not give those gifts to me. Keep them.

5:17b

and give your rewards to someone else.

- or give^(sing) them to someone else.
- You^(sing) can give your rewards to someone else.

and give your rewards to someone else: There are two ways to interpret the function of this clause:

1. It suggests an alternative to the previous clause. If the king did not want to keep the fine clothes and gold chain, he could give them to someone else. In this interpretation, the words “gifts” (5:17a) and rewards are synonyms. For example:

or give them to someone else (GNT) (GNT, NRSV, NCV, CEV, NLT, REB, probably GW)

1. It refers to a second action that the king should take. In this interpretation, there is a distinction between the “gifts” and the rewards. The king should keep the gifts but give the rewards to someone else. For example:

and give your rewards to others (NJB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NET, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). See the Note below on your rewards. The NRSV is therefore used as the source line in the Display.

Daniel continued to speak plainly and directly. He made it clear that he did not want the king to pay or reward him for interpreting the writing. Some other ways to translate this include:

You can give your rewards to someone else. I do not want them.

Let someone else have/receive them.

Another man can have them.

your rewards: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rewards is a rare word. The form is odd, *neḥazbbeyāṭak* which may come from *nebizbat beyṭak* “the gift of your house.” Theodotion, the Vulgate, and the Syriac interpret it this way. See Goldingay, p. 102. The Aramaic word is *nebizbah*. See HALOT, 1924–25. It is only here and in 2:6. In both places, it is used together with the word “gifts.” This suggests that they are close in meaning. Together the two words emphasize the number and quality of gifts. Several English versions use a pronoun here to make it clear that the word rewards is referring back to the word “gifts” in the previous verse part. For example:

them (NLT)

5:17c

Nevertheless, I will read the inscription for the king and interpret it for him.

- However, I will read the writing for you^(sing) the king, and I will tell you its meaning.
- But I will read aloud the words on the wall, my king, and interpret them for you^(sing).

Nevertheless: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Nevertheless in this context introduces a contrast. Daniel said he would interpret the writing even though he would not accept the king’s gifts. Translate in a way that most naturally shows the contrast. For example:

but (NLT)

I will read the inscription for the king: See the Notes at 5:7c. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will read the writing for the king

I will read the script for you

for the king: Daniel spoke to the king in the third person. This was a polite way of speaking to someone who had a high status and greater authority. This way of speaking created distance between the speaker and listener. If this kind of speech is not natural in your language, you can translate using the second person. For example:

I will read this writing for you (GW)

I will read this to you, my king.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the second thing that Daniel said he would do. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here and translate this connector as:

I will also

interpret it for him: See the Notes at 5:7c. Daniel was able and willing to explain the writing to the king. He continued to speak respectfully to the king, indicating his respect by using the third person. See the Notes above. If this kind of speech is not natural in your language, you may be able to translate using a polite second person pronoun. For example:

tell you^(plur) what it means

General Comment on 5:17

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses. For example:

^aDaniel declared to the king, “I will read the writing and tell you what it means. ^aBut you may keep your gifts. ^bGive your rewards to someone else.”

Daniel 5:18

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to

punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

English versions give different headings to Daniel 5. These include:

The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

The Writing on the Wall (NIV)

King Belshazzar's Banquet (CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

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The NRSV has three headings:

Belshazzar's Feast (5:1)

The Writing on the Wall (5:5)

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You should decide the number of headings that is best in your translation. The purpose of headings is to help readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the

last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:18–19

Daniel summarized the lessons that King Nebuchadnezzar had learned from God in Daniel 4.

5:18a

As for you, O king, the Most High God gave your father Nebuchadnezzar sovereignty

- ¶ “Your Majesty, the Most High God gave Nebuchadnezzar your father/grandfather the authority to rule as king.
- ¶ “My king, the one Supreme God caused your father Nebuchadnezzar to become a great king.

As for you, O king: Daniel addressed the king with an Aramaic expression that is literally “you the king.” Languages often have special ways for people to address a king or an important person. Here are some possible models:

Sir

Your majesty (NIV)

My lord, king (REB)

my king

Use a form that is natural in your language in this context.

the Most High God gave your father Nebuchadnezzar sovereignty: The Aramaic clause indicates that God had caused Nebuchadnezzar to become king of Babylonia. He gave him the right and power to rule. In some languages it may not be natural to say that a person can give an abstract idea like sovereignty to someone. Other ways to say this may include:

the Most High God gave a kingdom...to your father, Nebuchadnezzar (REB)

The Supreme God made your father Nebuchadnezzar a great king (GNT)

the Most High God caused your father Nebuchadnezzar to become king of Babylon

the Most High God: See the Notes at 3:26b. This expression is a title. It describes God as the one who has authority over everyone. Avoid translating in a way that suggests there are lesser gods and that this God is higher than the others. Here is another way to translate this:

The Supreme God (GNT)

your father: See the Notes at 5:11b. Translate here as you did there. See also 5:11d and 5:13c.

sovereignty: See the Notes at 2:37b. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as sovereignty has a wide range of meanings. Here it is an abstract noun and refers to kingship, the right and power to rule as king.

5:18b and greatness, glory and honor.

- He gave him power, glory, and majesty.
- God caused him to become great, glorious, and honored.
- God made him so powerful that people honored him and were in awe of him.

and greatness, glory and honor: The three abstract nouns that the BSB translates as greatness, glory, and honor are close in meaning. Together they emphasize the idea that Nebuchadnezzar was important and powerful. Others honored him and looked up to him in awe. They are all positive words used to praise someone.

greatness: See the Notes at 4:22c, 4:36f. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as greatness includes the ideas of power and of importance. Try to include both ideas in your translation. In some languages it may be necessary to emphasize one or the other. For example:

might (GW)

power (REB)

great/much authority

glory: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as glory here means “dignity, honor.” See the Notes and

Display at 2:37b; 4:30b. Here are some other ways to translate this:

majesty (NJB)

honor (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this idea with a verb. For example:

God has honored him

God has caused him to have a great reputation among people

honor: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as honor is a synonym to “glory.” The word *hedar* also occurs at 4:30b, and 4:36c. Both words occur together at 4:30b. Here are some other ways to translate this:

magnificence

splendor (NIV)

royal dignity

In some languages it may be natural to express this idea with a clause. For example:

He/God caused people to respect/honor Nebuchadnezzar very highly.

General Comment on 5:18a–b

In some languages it may be natural to introduce the idea of “greatness” in 5:18a. For example:

^{18a-b}The Supreme God made your father Nebuchadnezzar a great king and gave him dignity and majesty. (GNT)

Daniel 5:19

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to

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last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:18–19

Daniel summarized the lessons that King Nebuchadnezzar had learned from God in Daniel 4.

5:19a

Because of the greatness that He bestowed on him, the people of every nation and language trembled in fear before him.

- He made King Nebuchadnezzar so great that people in every province and nation and language group were afraid of him. They all trembled when they thought of him.
- He caused Nebuchadnezzar to become a powerful king. People from every tribe and nation and who spoke every language were terrified of him.

Because of the greatness that He bestowed on him: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as **Because of the greatness that He bestowed on him** indicates the cause of the following verse part. Due to, or as a result of, Nebuchadnezzar's greatness, everyone feared him. Translate this logical relation in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 5:19a–b. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Because God made him important (NCV)

Due to the greatness that he bestowed on him (NET)

God did such great things for him that (CEV)

the greatness that He bestowed on him: See the Notes at 5:18b. The text repeats information from 5:18b for emphasis. Languages translate repeated information in different ways. Translate this expression in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

he made him so great that (NJB)

He was so great (GNT)

he caused him to become powerful

greatness: See the Notes at 5:18b. This abstract noun is the same Aramaic word that is also translated as “greatness” there. It is a general term that means power, importance, or high status. Here are some ways to translate it in this context:

power (GW)

high position (NIV)

such a great king

the people of every nation and language trembled in fear before him: This clause expresses the result of 5:19a. One way to show this is to introduce this clause with a connector:

Therefore all the nations....

So all the nations....

so great that people of all races and nations and languages trembled before him in fear (NLT)

Translate this logical relation in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 5:19a–b.

the people of every nation and language: The Aramaic text says “all the peoples, nations, and languages.” See the Notes at 3:4b. This is figurative language. The expression refers to people who came from every people group, who came from every nation, and who spoke every language. Other ways to say this in English are:

People from every province and nation, and people who speak every language

People from every tribe and nation and people who speak every language.

trembled in fear: The two Aramaic words that the BSB translates trembled in fear are literally “trembled and feared.” They are close synonyms and the repetition

functions to emphasize the idea of fear. Other ways to say this are:

Trembled with fear (REB)

shook with dread (NJB)

were afraid of him and trembled (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the two verbs into one intensive verb phrase. For example:

were very frightened (NCV)

in fear: The people were afraid of the king because he had the power to punish them. See the Notes at 2:31.

before him: See the Notes at 5:13a. This expression describes a situation where a person of lower status comes to a person of higher status or higher authority. In this verse part the idea is already implied by the context. Many English versions do not translate it explicitly. Translate the idea of people being afraid of a powerful ruler in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 5:19a–b

In some languages it may be natural to indicate the cause-result relationship between 5:19a–b using an expression meaning “so great that.” For example:

He made him so great that people of all races and nations and languages trembled before him in fear. (NLT)

He was so great that people of all nations, races, and languages were afraid of him and trembled. (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these two clauses. For example:

^bPeople from every province, nation, and language trembled and were terrified by him, ^abecause God gave him power. (GW)

5:19b

He killed whom he wished

- If he wanted to kill someone, he had him/them killed.

- He put to death whomever he wished.

He killed whom he wished: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wished usually means “wish for, like.” In this context, the meaning is closer to “want” or “to choose.” Some other ways to translate this include:

Those he chose

Those the king wanted to put to death (NIV)

Those he wanted to kill (NRSV)

This refers in a general way to anyone and everyone. In some languages it may be natural to use the singular form. For example:

If he wanted to kill someone (GNT)

He killed: In this context the idea is not that the king killed them personally, but that he ordered his soldiers to execute them. So in some languages it may be necessary to say:

he ordered his servants/men to kill those people

he had his soldiers execute that person

See the Notes at 4:17c; 4:25f; 4:32e.

General Comment on 5:19b

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of the information in this verse part. For example:

Those the king wanted to put to death, he put to death; (NIV)

5:19c

and kept alive whom he wished;

- Anyone he wanted to let live, he let live.
- He spared from death whomever he wanted.
- He allowed someone to live if he wanted him to live.

and kept alive whom he wished: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as kept alive means “allow to live.” If Nebuchadnezzar wanted to forgive someone for even a serious crime, he forgave him. That person would not receive punishment. The soldiers would not kill/execute him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and whom he wanted to keep alive, those people he kept alive

whomever he wished he spared alive (NASB)

whom he would, he kept alive (ESV)

As in 5:19b, it may be natural to use a singular object. For example:

if he wanted to keep someone alive, he did (GNT)

If he wanted someone to live, he let that person live (NCV)

General Comment on 5:19c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the information in 5:19c. For example:

those he wanted to spare, he spared (NIV)

whomever he wished he spared alive (NASB)

if he wanted to keep someone alive, he did (GNT)

General Comment on 5:19b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine these verse parts into one clause. Order the ideas in the way that is natural in your language. For example, in English it is natural to put the idea of living first:

He chose whom he wanted to live and whom he wanted to die

He could decide who lived and who died

5:19d

he exalted whom he wished

- If he wanted to promote someone, he promoted him/them.
- He raised/honored whomever he wished.
- he promoted whomever he wanted to promote. (GW)

he exalted whom he wished: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as exalted is literally “make higher.” In this context it is used figuratively to mean “honor.” For example, you can say:

and whomever he wished he elevated (NASB)

whom he would, he raised up (ESV)

As in 5:19b–c, it may be natural to use a singular object. For example:

If he wanted to honor someone, he honored him

General Comment on 5:19d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the verbs in this verse part. See how you translated 5:19b, c. You may wish to follow the same model here. For example:

and whomever he wished he elevated (NASB)

whom he would, he raised up (ESV)

5:19e

and humbled whom he wished.

- If he wanted to demote someone, he demoted him/ them.
- He disgraced/dishonored whomever he wished.
- He humbled anyone he wanted to humble.

and humbled whom he wished: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as humbled is literally “made low.” In this context it means “humiliated.” See the Notes at 4:37d (NJB 4:34). Here are some other ways to translate this:

Those he wanted to be less important, he made less important (NCV)

whomever he wished he humbled (NASB)

In some languages it may be natural to use a singular object. For example:

if he wanted to disgrace someone, he disgraced him

General Comment on 5:19e

As in 5:19b–d, it may be natural to reverse the order of the verbs. For example:

and those he wanted to humble, he humbled. (NIV)

and whomever he wished he humbled. (NASB)

General Comment on 5:19d–e

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two verse parts. See how you translated 5:19b–c. For example:

He honored or disgraced anyone he wanted to. (GNT)

He chose/decided whom to honor and whom to disgrace.

Daniel 5:20

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Paragraph 5:20–21

Daniel told Belshazzar how God had humbled Nebuchadnezzar because of his pride.

5:20a

But when his heart became arrogant and his spirit was hardened with pride,

- ¶ “However, when his heart/head swelled with pride and he became conceited and obstinate,
- ¶ “But because he became very proud and stubborn,
- ¶ But Nebuchadnezzar became haughty, self-confident, and inflexible.

But: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. In contrast to the time when the king ruled with great power (5:18–19), there came a time when God no longer allowed him to rule. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

when his heart became arrogant and his spirit was hardened with pride: Scholars have understood the Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as when in two ways:

1. The connector introduces a temporal (time) clause. For example:

when (RSV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, RSV/NRSV, NIV, NJPS, GW, NLT, REB, CEV)

1. The connector introduces a reason. For example:

because his heart grew swollen with pride, and his spirit stiff with arrogance (NJB) (NJB, GNT)

Both aspects of the connection are true. God humbled Nebuchadnezzar when and because he became proud. If you have a way to express both ideas, that is good. If you must choose between the two options, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

his heart became arrogant: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as his heart became arrogant is more literally “his heart rose up.” This is an idiomatic way of saying that Nebuchadnezzar became proud or arrogant. Here are some other ways to translate this:

his heart was filled with pride

he became proud (CEV)

his heart: In the Aramaic language, the heart was the part of the body where people thought, made decisions, and felt emotions. There are different ways to translate this:

- Use an expression or idiom in your language to refer to the part of the person that thinks and feels. For example:

his mind

- Refer to the person himself. For example:

But when he became proud (CEV)

- Translate this idea as a verb. For example:

But when he began to think arrogantly/proudly

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

and his spirit was hardened: The Aramaic text is more literally “and his spirit grew strong.” In this context,

the word meaning spirit is a synonym for “heart.” Not only did the king become proud, but he also became strong or hardened. He became stubborn, obstinate, and inflexible. He determined to do whatever he wanted to do. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and he refused to change his thoughts/thinking

and he became stubborn

with pride: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as with pride is more literally “to act presumptuously.” This verb occurs only here in the Old Testament. It probably describes the king as behaving/acting in an overconfident, arrogant way. His actions and behavior were in accordance with his prideful thinking. Here are some other ways to translate this:

he became...presumptuous (REB)

that he became overconfident (GW)

he behaved/acted in a proud/arrogant way

5:20b

he was deposed from his royal throne,

- Nebuchadnezzar’s rule/reign was brought to an end.
- God removed the king from his position.
- So he lost his right to rule,

No Aramaic connector joins this clause to the previous one, and the BSB does not supply one. This clause indicates the result of 5:20a–b: Nebuchadnezzar was deposed because of his pride. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

so (NCV)

he was deposed from his royal throne: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as he was deposed means that Nebuchadnezzar was forced to give up his position as king. He was removed from his throne. That is, he could not longer sit on it to rule the country. This is a passive verb. Here are some ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

he was removed from his royal throne (GNT)

he was taken off his royal throne (NCV)

the throne of Babylon was taken from him

- Using an active verb. God caused some unnamed people to force Nebuchadnezzar to stop ruling as king. For example:

God removed him from his royal position/throne.

God stopped him from ruling as king.

God caused them to remove him as king.

his royal throne: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as his royal throne is literally “the throne of his kingdom.” This is a figure of speech. The royal throne was a symbol of royal power. It represented the king’s position as the ruler of the kingdom. Nebuchadnezzar was no longer allowed to rule as king over Babylon. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Translate the figure of speech. For example:

deposed from his sovereign throne (NJB)

removed from the throne of Babylon

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

God did not let him continue to rule as king

his rule/reign over Babylon was brought to an end

Translate in a way that is natural in your language and makes the meaning clear.

5:20c

and his glory was taken from him.

- His glory was taken away from him.
- God took his glory away from him,
- and people no longer honored him as king

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces something else that happened to Nebuchadnezzar. This second event is closely connected to the previous event (5:20c).

his glory was taken from him: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as was taken is literally “they took away.” The subject is indefinite. It is implied that God caused people to do this. There are at least two ways to translate the phrase that the BSB translates as his glory was taken from him:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

he was...stripped of his glory (NIV)

he was deprived of his glory

- Using an active verb. For example:

they (indefinite) took his glory away from him

People no longer honored him as king.

People no longer thought of him as important.

his glory: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as his glory does not include the pronoun his. However, this idea is implied by the context. The phrase refers to Nebuchadnezzar's great fame. People all over the known world had respected, honored, feared, and admired him. Now they did so no longer. In some languages it may be natural to use a verb to translate this idea. For example:

they did not honor him any longer

The same Aramaic word that means glory occurs at 2:6b, where it is translated as "honor," 4:30b, and 5:18b. See the Notes and Display for other suggestions of how to translate it.

Daniel 5:21

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Paragraph 5:20–21

Daniel told Belshazzar how God had humbled Nebuchadnezzar because of his pride.

5:21a**He was driven away from mankind,**

- He was driven from human society.
- and they (indefinite) forced him to live away from people.
- They banished him from their towns/society.

He was driven away from mankind: The Aramaic expression is literally “and from the sons of men was driven.” It is a passive clause. Ways to translate it here include:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

He was driven from human society (NET)

He was chased away from people (GW)

he was forced to stay away from people (CEV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

they (indefinite) forced him to live away from people

people banished him from human society

from mankind: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as from mankind is literally “from the sons of mankind.” Compare 4:25a and 4:33b, where the Aramaic text is literally “from mankind.” The meaning is the same. The phrase refers to people in general. Here is another way to translate this:

from human society (GNT)

5:21b**and his mind was like that of a beast.**

- He began to think and act like a wild animal.
- God caused him to think and act like an animal.

and his mind was like that of a beast: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as his mind was like that of a beast is more literally “was made the same as the mind of an animal.” It indicates that God caused Nebuchadnezzar to begin thinking and acting irrationally, like an animal does. See the Notes at 4:16a–b and how you translated it there. In Aramaic

this is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

his mind was changed into an animal’s mind (GW)

his mind was made like that of an animal (NRSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

his mind became like that of an animal (GNT)

and he began to think like an animal thinks

The Most High God caused him to think like an animal.

The expression does not mean that Nebuchadnezzar physically received an animal’s brain. It simply means that he began to think irrationally and act as if he were an animal. Translate this expression in a way that is natural in your language.

his mind was like that of a beast: Here the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as like indicates a comparison. Other ways to translate this to show comparison are:

a mind like an animal’s mind

stopped thinking like a human and began thinking like an animal

mind: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mind is literally “heart.” In the Aramaic language, the heart was the place in the body where people thought, made decisions, and felt emotions. See the Notes at 4:16a, 5:20a, and 5:21b. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. For example

- use the name of the body part that has this function in your language and culture:

heart/stomach/liver

- use a verb:

He thought like...

beast: See 4:12c. The same Hebrew expression is used here. While in 4:12b this expression referred to wild animals, here it can refer to any animal. It is good to use a term that emphasizes the inferiority of animals over people as the BSB has done here.

5:21c

He lived with the wild donkeys

- He made his home where wild donkeys live.
- He had to live outdoors with wild animals,

He lived with the wild donkeys: The Aramaic text literally says, “his dwelling place was with the wild donkeys.” See the Notes at 4:15d, 4:25b. The king lived where wild donkeys live, far away from people. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel suggests that the point of comparison is that just as the donkeys were wild and untamed, so the king acted wildly, in a uncivilized manner. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He lived where the wild donkeys lived

He had to live outdoors with wild donkeys.

The home/shelter of the wild donkeys became his home/shelter.

wild donkeys: In 4:25b Daniel said that Nebuchadnezzar would have to live with wild animals. Here Daniel identified one kind of those wild animals—the wild donkey, or wild ass. A donkey is an animal that resembles a horse but has longer ears and a shorter mane. People used these animals to carry heavy loads, because they were very strong.

5:21d

and ate grass like an ox,

- He ate grass like cattle do.
- and he had to feed/graze on grass like an ox.

and ate grass like an ox: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as ate grass is literally “they fed him with grass.” The subject is indefinite. See the Notes at 4:32c, 4:33c. In your translation, use a word for grass that refers to the type of food that cattle eat—wild grasses and grains—rather than lawn grass. Here is another way to translate this:

he had...to feed on grass like oxen (REB)

like an ox: The ancient farm animal known as the ox (plural “oxen”) had horns and was related to modern day cows. In this context, the word ox refers to cattle in

general. See the Notes at 4:25c, 4:33c. Here is another way to translate this:

like cattle (GW)

In your translation, use either the singular or the plural form, whichever is most natural in this context.

5:21e

and his body was drenched with the dew of heaven

- His body became wet from the dew.
- Dew from the sky made him wet.

and his body was drenched with the dew of heaven:

The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as was drenched means “to become wet.” The dew caused the king to become wet because he lived outside. He did not have any shelter. See the Notes at 4:15c, 4:25d, 4:33d. Here the verb describes a regular action in the past. Each morning Nebuchadnezzar became wet from the dew.

Some English translations begin a new sentence here. For example

He became wet from dew (NCV)

Dew from the sky made his body wet (GW)

the dew of heaven: See the Notes at 4:15c. dew refers to the moisture from the air that condenses at night and appears in the morning as little drops on plants and on the ground. The expression occurs in Daniel 4:12, 20, 22, 30; 5:21. If you do not have a word that means dew, you may be able to say:

the water that appears in the morning

5:21f

until he acknowledged that the Most High God rules over the kingdom of mankind,

- He lived like this until he realized/recognized that the Most High God has authority over all the kingdoms on earth.
- This lasted/continued until he admitted/confessed that the Most High God is ruler/king over every earthly/human kingdom.

until he acknowledged that the Most High God rules over the kingdom of mankind:

See the Notes at 4:25f. This verse part indicates when the situation described in 5:21a–e came to an end. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

This lasted until he acknowledged that the Most High God is lord over all kingdoms on earth

These things happened to him until he learned his lesson: The Most High God rules over every kingdom on earth (NCV)

He was forced to do this until he learned that the Most High God rules all kingdoms on earth (CEV)

acknowledged: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as acknowledged is the same verb as in 4:17c (“will know”) and 4:25f. In this context it means “accepted” or “came to know.” It refers to affirming something the king had previously denied. Here are some other ways to translate this:

he admitted (GNT)

he learned (NLT)

the Most High God: The title the Most High God identifies the one true God as greater than all other beings that people worship. In your translation of this title, avoid implying that there exist other gods with less power. See the Notes at 3:26b and 4:2b. Translate it here as you did there. For example:

the Supreme God (GNT)

God Most High (CEV)

rules: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rules is more literally “is powerful, mighty” or “is lord over.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

is sovereign (NIV)

has power over (GW)

controls (CEV)

the kingdom of mankind: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as the kingdom of mankind is singular but because this phrase refers to all the kingdoms on earth some English translations translate this phrase in a way that indicates it includes all earthly kingdoms. See how you translated this in 4:25f. For example:

human sovereignty (NJB)

human kingdoms (GW)

every kingdom on earth (NCV)

5:21g

setting over it whom He wishes.

- He appoints whoever he wants to be their rulers.
- He chooses/decides who will rule them.

setting over it whom He wishes: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as setting literally means “raises” (NJB). In this context, it means “appoints” or “causes to rule.” God decides who should rule, and he makes that person the ruler. See the Notes at 4:17d–e. Other ways to translate this phrase include:

appoints over it whom he will (REB)

appoints anyone he desires to rule over them (NLT)

over it: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as over it refers back to all kingdoms on earth, all human rule, and every kingdom on earth. Use the pronoun that makes this clear. Or you may wish to follow the NCV and say explicitly:

over those kingdoms (NCV)

whom He wishes: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as whom He wishes means “decides, chooses.” See the Notes at 4:17e, 4:25g Other ways to translate this include:

whom he will (RSV)

anyone he chooses (NLT)

General Comment on 5:21g

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the verb phrases in this verse part. For example:

And anyone he chooses he sets over them

and he decides whom to make ruler

and chooses their kings (CEV)

Daniel 5:22

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Paragraph 5:22–24

Daniel continued speaking to King Belshazzar in 5:22, but he changed the topic. He began to rebuke the king.

5:22a

But you his son, O Belshazzar, have not humbled your heart,

- ¶ “But you^(sing), Belshazzar, his son, have not lived/acted with humility
- ¶ “King Belshazzar, you^(sing) are his successor and you acted in the same way and did not live in submission to God ,

But: There are two ways to interpret and translate the Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as But:

1. It introduces a contrast between what happened to Nebuchadnezzar (in 5:20–21) and what Belshazzar chose to do. For example:

Yet (NASB) (BSB, NASB, NJPS, NIV, NJB, GW, REB, GNT, NET)

1. It introduces the next event. For example:

and (ESV) (RSV/NRSV, NLT, CEV, NCV, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In spite of the fact that Belshazzar knew what had happened to Nebuchadnezzar, he had not honored God.

you his son, O Belshazzar: Daniel addressed the king by his name and called him the son of Nebuchadnezzar. Belshazzar was in fact not a biological son, but a

successor and possibly grandson, of Nebuchadnezzar. See the Notes on “your father” at 5:11b. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

you, Belshazzar, his descendant

you, Belshazzar, who are king after him

you, Belshazzar, are in his royal line

have not humbled your heart: The Aramaic verb phrase that the BSB translates as humbled your heart is literally “made low your heart.” It contains the same verb that is used in 5:19e and 4:37d. In this context it refers to recognizing/acknowledging God and submitting to him. Here are some other ways to translate this: BFrCL88 “You did not adopt a more humble attitude.” GeCL97 “You did not guard yourself against arrogance.”

did not remain humble (GW)

continued to act in a proud way

General Comment on 5:22a

This verse part refers to Belshazzar in three ways: by name, by the pronoun “you,” and as Nebuchadnezzar’s “son.” This serves to emphasize Belshazzar’s identity. His identity increased his responsibility and his guilt. Emphasize the king’s identity in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

But you, Belshazzar, who are his son, you have not humbled your heart (NJB)

But you, Belshazzar, you who are king in Nebuchadnezzar’s line/place, you have not humbled yourself.

5:22b

even though you knew all this.

- even though you^(sing) knew about all these events.
- even though you^(sing) knew what had happened to Nebuchadnezzar.

even though you knew all this: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as though here introduces a concessive clause, a fact that makes the following statement surprising or unexpected. In spite of the fact that Belshazzar knew what had happened to Nebuchadnezzar,

he was arrogant and did not honor God. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

though you knew all this (NIV)

although you knew all this (REB)

in spite of knowing all this (NJB)

you knew all this: This clause tells why the king should not have acted this way. He knew the lesson that God had taught Nebuchadnezzar. The pronoun this refers in general to what Nebuchadnezzar had done and what had happened to him (5:18–21). In some languages it will be necessary to add this implied information.

you knew all that happened to Nebuchadnezzar

you knew that God had taught Nebuchadnezzar not to act arrogantly.

General Comment on 5:22a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses. For example:

^bEven though you knew all this, ^ayou, Nebuchadnezzar’s successor, still did not humble yourself.

^bBut although you knew all this, ^ayou, his son Belshazzar, did not humble your heart. (REB)

King Belshazzar, ^byou knew all this, ^abut you still refused to honor the Lord (CEV)

Daniel 5:23

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5:23a

Instead, you have exalted yourself against the Lord of heaven.

- Instead, you^(sing) defied the Lord of heaven.
- Instead of humbling yourself, you^(sing) rebelled against the one/God who rules in heaven.

Instead, you have exalted yourself against the Lord of heaven: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Instead* here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between what Nebuchadnezzar should have done (humbled himself, 5:22a) and what he actually did. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but you have exalted yourself against the Lord of heaven (NASB)

You have exalted yourself against the Lord of heaven! (NRSV)

but you have lifted up yourself against the Lord of heaven (RSV)

you have exalted yourself: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as *exalted yourself* is literally “lifted/raised yourself.” This is an idiom that in this context means to challenge God’s authority. Here are some examples of ways to translate this:

You have defied (NJB)

You rebelled against

You turned against him (CEV)

the Lord of heaven: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates *Lord* is a title that people called an important person who had authority over them. For example, sometimes people addressed the king (4:16, 21) or God (2:47) with this title. In this context, it refers to God. Other ways modern versions translate this are:

the Lord who rules in heaven

the highest LordGeCL97.

the God of heavenBFrCL88.

5:23b

The vessels from His house were brought to you,

- You^(sing) gave orders to bring the vessels from God's temple to you to use.
- You^(sing) commanded your servants to bring you the sacred cups that the Jewish priests had used in God's temple.

The vessels from His house were brought to you:

The Aramaic text is more literally "and they have brought the vessels of his house before you." There are several ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the vessels of his house have been brought in before you (RSV)

- Use an active verb. In this context the subject is indefinite. In some languages it may be necessary to make the subject explicit. For example:

Your servants brought the vessels from God's temple to you.

- Indicate that the king himself was the cause of the action. Examples of ways to do this include:

you caused the goblets from the temple to be brought to you

you ordered your servants to bring you the vessels from God's temple.

The vessels from His house: The phrase The vessels from His house refers to the cups and bowls that the priests had used to offer sacrifices in the temple in Jerusalem. See the Notes at 5:2b-c. Here are some other ways to refer to these items:

cups (NLT)

cups and bowls (GNT)

utensils (GW)

His house: This phrase refers to the building where the Jews worshiped and offered sacrifices to God in Jerusalem. God was present there in a special way. See the Notes on "temple" at 5:2c, 5:3a. For help on how to translate this term, see "temple" in KBT.

to you: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as to you in this context means "in front of you." In some languages this information is implied by the context. Here is another way to translate this:

here (CEV)

5:23c

and as you drank wine from them with your nobles, wives, and concubines,

- Then you^(sing) and your^(sing) nobles/officials, your^(sing) wives and your^(sing) concubines drank wine from them,
- Then you^(sing) and your^(sing) leading/important men/guests, your^(sing) wives and your^(sing) secondary wives used them for drinking!

and as you drank wine from them with your nobles, wives, and concubines:

In the Aramaic text the word wine is left implied. In many languages it is good to follow the BSB and supply the object wine. The king and his guests drank an alcoholic drink made from grapes using the sacred vessels as their cups. See 5:1b. Other ways to translate this clause include:

Then you and your royal guests, your wives, and your slave women drank wine from them. (NCV)

You and your nobles and your wives and concubines have been drinking wine from them (NLT)

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next thing that happened. Here is another way to translate this:

Then (NCV)

Some English versions do not include an explicit connector since this idea is implied by the context.

drank: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates drank is a participle. Here it refers to an action that had been taking place for several hours. It may or may not have stopped by this time. Use the verb form that is natural in your language. For example:

have been drinking (NRSV)

have drunk (NJB)

your nobles: These men were important officials and friends of the king. See the Notes on nobles at 5:1a and 5:2d. Translate it here as you did there. For example:

your lords (RSV)

your noblemen (GNT)

officials (CEV)

wives: See the Notes at 5:2d. Translate here as you did there.

and concubines: See the Notes at 5:2d. Translate here as you did there.

5:23d

you praised your gods of silver and gold, bronze and iron, wood and stone,

- and you^(sing) praised the gods that people had made from gold and silver, bronze, iron, wood, and stone,
- While drinking, you^(sing) praised your^(plur) idols, idols formed from gold and silver, bronze, iron, wood and stone.

The Aramaic text connects this verse part to 5:23c with the common connector that the RSV translates as “and.” Here it introduces what the king and his guests did while they were drinking. The BSB does not explicitly translate this connector. Introduce this verse part in a way that is natural in your language. The two events (drinking the wine, 5:23c, and praising the false gods, 5:23d) happened at the same time. One way to translate this is:

while praising gods... (NLT)

you praised your gods of silver and gold, bronze and iron, wood and stone: See the notes at 5:4b. The phrase gods of silver and gold, bronze and iron, wood and stone indicates that Belshazzar praised some idols that were made of silver, some other idols made of gold, others made of bronze, and so on. The people made their gods (idols) from, or out of, these materials. In order to make this clear, you may need to say:

You praised the gods that men made/formed from silver, from gold, from bronze, from iron, from wood, and from stone.

You praised gods made from silver, gods made from gold, and other gods made from bronze, iron, wood and/or stone.

you praised: Nebuchadnezzar and his guests had done this together. See 5:4a–b and the notes there. However, the Aramaic verb you praised is singular here. Daniel focused upon what the king had done. Try to keep this focus in your translation. If a literal translation would indicate that only the king had done this, it may be necessary to say:

together with your guests, you^(sing) praised

your gods: See the Notes at 2:11b; 5:4b. The Babylonians worshiped many different gods, all of them false. In some languages, the word “god” only refers to the one true God. If that is true in your language, you may have to use a different word for gods here. For example:

evil spirits

the beings they worshiped

idols

The NCV adds the implied information:

gods...that are not really gods (NCV)

Translate this idea in the way that is most natural in your language.

gold: See the Notes at 5:2b.

silver: See the Notes at 5:2b

bronze: See the Notes at 2:32c; 5:4b.

iron: See the Notes at 2:33a; 5:4b.

wood: See the Notes at 5:4b.

stone: See the Notes at 5:4b.

5:23e

which cannot see or hear or understand.

- even though these gods do not see, hear, or know anything.
- These idols see nothing, hear nothing, and understand nothing!

which cannot see or hear or understand: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as which refers back to the word “gods” in the previous verse part. In some

languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

these gods can't see, hear, or know anything (GW)

gods that cannot see or hear and that do not know anything (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that this was contrary to expectation. It was strange and useless to worship such gods. For example:

even though they cannot see or hear or think (CEV)

cannot see or hear or understand: The Aramaic verbs that the BSB translates as cannot see, hear, and understand are more literally “are not seeing, hearing and knowing.” In this context the verb form expresses continuous or habitual action. The verbs are participles. Indicate this meaning in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

gods that neither see nor hear nor know anything (NLT)

which can neither see, hear nor understand (NJB)

understand: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as understand and the RSV as “know” here refers to any kind of thinking. In some languages it may be necessary to add an object. For example:

understand anything (NCV)

know anything (GNT)

5:23f

But you have failed to glorify the God

- But you^(sing) did not honor God,
- Yet you^(sing) refused to give honor to the true God.

But you have failed to glorify the God: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast between what Belshazzar did in 5:23d–e, praise false gods, and what he should have done but did not do, honor the true God.

you have failed to glorify the God: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as glorify in this context

means to praise and worship. The same Aramaic word occurs in 4:34 and 37. Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

you have given no glory to the God (NJB)

you have not given glory to God (REB)

you have not declared how great God is

the God: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the God has a definite article, the. Daniel focused on the unique identity of God. English versions, however, differ as to whether they use the article or not. For example:

God (REB)

It is important that your translation does not imply that Daniel thought that there was more than one God. Translate in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages you may be able to say:

the true God

General Comment on 5:23f

In some languages it may be possible to indicate the contrast by emphasizing the word “God.” For example, in English the word “God” can be emphasized by placing it at the beginning of the clause:

But God you have not honored

5:23g

who holds in His hand your very breath and all your ways.

- he who gives you^(sing) life and controls its course/ events.
- And it is he who has the power over whether you live or die. He determines/decides what will happen to you.

who holds in His hand your very breath: The Aramaic words meaning hand and breath are both used figuratively. The word hand is used to mean “power.” The word breath is used to mean “life.” Consider if either of these metaphors are natural in your language. In many languages it may be natural to translate the meaning directly. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

who gives you breath (CEV)

has power over your life (GW)

who determines whether you live or die (GNT)

and all your ways: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as and all your ways here indicates that God had power over all Belshazzar's ways or paths. The word meaning ways is used figuratively. In this context it refers to what will happen to a person in the future. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

everything that will happen to you

your destiny (NLT)

the course/events of your life

General Comment on 5:23f–g

In some languages it may be natural to emphasize the contrast between the idols and the true God by reversing the order of 5:23f–g. For example:

^{23g}But the God who has power over your life and all your ways—^{23f}him you have failed/refused to honor.

Daniel 5:24

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

The Writing on the Wall (NIV)

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In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

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The Writing on the Wall (5:1)

Daniel explains the writing (5:13)

The NRSV has three headings:

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The Writing on the Wall Interpreted (5:13)

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Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:22–24

Daniel continued speaking to King Belshazzar in 5:22, but he changed the topic. He began to rebuke the king.

5:24

Therefore He sent the hand that wrote the inscription.

- That is the reason God made the hand appear and write these words on the wall.
- And so God caused the hand to write this message on the wall.

Therefore: There are two ways to interpret the Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Therefore*:

1. It introduces the conclusion or result of the previous action. For example:

That is why (NJB)

So (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, REB, GNT, CEV, NCV, NRSV, GW, NLT, NJPS, NET)

1. It introduces a new stage of the narrative and adds emphasis. This is its usual meaning. For example

Then (RSV) (KJV, RSV, NASB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of modern English versions.

He sent the hand: The Aramaic says more literally “from his presence the hand was sent.” This is a passive clause. It tells where the hand came from. God caused the hand to appear. However, in some languages it may not be natural to use the verb “to send” with the word hand. If that is true in your language, you may say:

He...made the hand appear (NJPS)

God caused the hand to be seen

the hand: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the hand is literally “the palm of the hand.” See the Notes at 5:5a. Use the word in your language that most naturally describes the part of the body that people use to write with.

that wrote the inscription: The Aramaic text is more literally “and this inscription was written” (RSV). The BSB translates this passive clause as an active clause. Use whichever form is more natural in your language. The phrase the inscription refers to the letters or

“words” (GNT) on the wall. It does not indicate what kind of tool or marker the hand used, if any.

Daniel 5:25**Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar**

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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The Writing on the Wall (5:5)

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Paragraph 5:25

Daniel read the message on the wall for King Belshazzar.

5:25a

Now this is the inscription that was written:

- ¶ “These are the words that the hand wrote:
- ¶ “This is what the hand wrote:

Now: This verse begins with the Aramaic common conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here because, in this context, it introduces the next thing that Daniel said, the climax of his speech. You should introduce what Daniel said next in a way that is natural in your language.

this is the inscription that was written: See the Notes at 5:24. This clause repeats information from 5:24b. It is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

This is the writing that was inscribed. (RSV)

This is what was written

- Using an active verb. For example:

This is what the hand wrote:

These are the words that the hand wrote:

The words are these:

this: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as this here refers to what follows, the words in 5:25b.

5:25b

MENE, MENE, TEKEL, PARSIN.

- Mene, mene, tekem, and parsin.

MENE, MENE, TEKEL, PARSIN: These words are from the Aramaic language. The three words could each have had various readings, depending on the vowels the reader supplied. The MT supplies vowels of nouns in the q^{at}el form. When Daniel interprets the writing he vocalizes the words as passive participles. See the discussion by Lucas, pp. 132–33. Aramaic was widely spoken in the Babylonian empire. However, the king and the other experts had difficulty reading and understanding these words. This may have been because only the consonants were written, and so each word could have various meanings. There are several ways to translate these words:

- Transliterate them. This is what most English versions do. For example:

Mene mene tekem and parsin (RSV)

- Translate them. For example:

Numbered, Numbered, Weighed, and Divided (GW)

Number, number, weight, divisions (GNT)

- Transliterate and supply the meaning. For example:

mene, which means, “numbered,” tekem, which means “weighed,” and parsin, which means “divided” (CEV)

The first option is usually best, since each of these words can have more than one meaning. See below.

MENE: This word could have more than one meaning, depending on what vowels were supplied. In the MT the first vowel is short and the second long. It is pronounced “menay.” The exact meaning is uncertain, but it probably comes from a root verb meaning “number, count.”

TEKEL: This word could also have more than one meaning. The word in the MT is pronounced “tekale,” with the first vowel short and the second long. It probably comes from a verb root meaning “weigh.”

PARSIN: This word could also have more than one meaning. The word in the MT is pronounced “up-arseen.” The “u” means “and,” and the BSB has left it implied. The word PARSIN probably comes from a verb root meaning “divide.”

Daniel 5:26

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus’ army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:26–28

In these three verses Daniel interpreted the words on the wall. He explained what they meant.

5:26a

And this is the interpretation of the message:

- ¶ “I will now tell you what these words mean:
- ¶ “This is what the message means:

And this is the interpretation of the message:

This verse part introduces Daniel’s explanation of the words on the wall. Here are some other ways to translate this:

This is its meaning: (GW)

And I will tell you what they mean

I will now interpret/explain it for you

And this: The word this refers forward to what Daniel was about to say in 5:26b–28.

the message: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the message is a general one referring to things or matters in general. Here it refers to the message that God wrote on the wall.

5:26b

MENE means that God has numbered the days of your reign

- ‘Mene’ means ‘counted.’ God has been counting the days you have been ruling/reigning,
- ‘Mene,’ or ‘measured,’ means/indicates that God has measured the length of your rule.

MENE means that God has numbered the days of your reign: The Aramaic consonants of the word MENE could be read as either a noun or a verb. Daniel interpreted it as a verb, supplying God as the subject. In your translation, you should use the same form of the word MENE as you did in 5:25b:

- You may transliterate the word Mene. For example:

MENE: God has measured your sovereignty (NJB)

- You may translate the meaning. For example:

Numbered—God has numbered the days of your kingdom (GW)

- You may both transliterate and supply the meaning. For example:

MENE means ‘numbered’: God has numbered the days of your reign (NLT)

the days of your reign: The Aramaic expression is literally “your kingdom/kingship.” The BSB has supplied the word days, referring to a length or period of time. God had determined the length of time that Belshazzar would rule over the kingdom of Babylonia.

5:26c

and brought it to an end.

- and he will now end them.
- He has now decided that your rule is over/finished.

and brought it to an end: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as brought it to an end describes a decision God had made regarding an event in the future. Belshazzar’s kingdom had not yet come to an end, but it was about to end. This was certainly going to happen, because God had decided and determined it. The Aramaic verb is in the past tense, but in some languages it may be natural to use a future tense, as it refers to a future event. For example:

and will bring it to an end (GW)

until your kingdom will end (NCV)

Daniel 5:27

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

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Paragraph 5:26–28

In these three verses Daniel interpreted the words on the wall. He explained what they meant.

5:27a

TEKEL means that you have been weighed on the scales

- 'Tekel' means 'weighed.' God has weighed you on his scales,
- 'Tekel' or 'weighed,' means/indicates that God has tested/evaluated you. He is like a merchant who weighs precious metal on his balances,
- 'Tekel' means to check/find the weight of something. And God has judged/tested you, like a merchant who checks/tests the weight of metal on a scale,

TEKEL means that you have been weighed on the scales: Daniel interpreted the Aramaic word TEKEL as a verb that means "be weighed." Translate this word in the same way as in 5:25b. For example:

- You may transliterate the Aramaic word TEKEL. For example:

teqel: you have been weighed in the balance (NJB)

- You may translate the meaning of the word TEKEL. For example:

Weighed—you have been weighed on a scale (GW)

weight, you have been weighed on the scales (GNT)

- You may both transliterate and supply the meaning. For example:

TEKEL means 'weighed': you have been weighed on the balances (NLT)

you have been weighed on the scales: This is a figure of speech, a metaphor. In Daniel's time, people weighed coins, metals, or objects for sale, such as wheat. They did not weigh people. However, God said that he had weighed Belshazzar. This means that God had evaluated or judged Belshazzar. He did not judge him to see if he was too fat or too thin, but to test his heart and spirit. There are different ways to translate this:

- You can translate the figure of speech. For example:

your weight has been determined/revealed

He/God has weighed you on his balance scales (CEV)

- You can translate this expression as a comparison.

God has evaluated you, like a merchant evaluates/ weighs precious metal on his scale.

- You can translate the meaning directly.

you have been tested/evaluated

Translate this expression in a way that is natural in your language.

you have been weighed: This is a passive verb. If it is more natural in your language to use an active verb, you can say:

God has weighed you

God has tested you

on the scales: In the Middle East people used scales or balances to determine the weight of coins or precious metals. The balance usually had the form of a

crossbeam the merchant hung from a hook or a cord. He then hung a pan from each end of the beam. He placed standard weights in one pan and the objects he wanted to weigh in the other pan.

5:27b
and found deficient.

- and he has found/seen that you do not weigh enough.
- and he has determined that you are not a good ruler.
- and you have failed the test.

and found deficient: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as deficient means “lacking, deficient.” This is a passive clause. Its full form is “and you have been found deficient.” God is the one who found Belshazzar deficient. He knew that Belshazzar was deficient or lacking in what it took to be a good ruler. If it is more natural in your language to use an active clause, you may be able to say:

and God has found you wanting

This continues the figure of speech in 5:27b. God found Belshazzar to be deficient in weight. That is, he was not heavy enough. This is a figure of speech. It refers to Belshazzar’s moral character, not to his physical weight. Belshazzar was insufficient or inadequate for the task of ruling. You can translate this figure of speech in several ways:

- You can translate the figure of speech:

and found to be too light (GNT)

have judged that you lack weight^{BFrCL88}.

- You can indicate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

and found you lacking in character/virtue

and found not good enough (NCV)

and you have failed the test (similarly the NLT)

found deficient: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as found is here used in a figurative way. In this context it means “determined, shown, judged to be.” For example:

God has determined that you are inadequate

God has judged you to be insufficient

Daniel 5:28

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

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Paragraph 5:26–28

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5:28a

PERES means that your kingdom has been divided

- 'Peres' means 'division.' There are divisions in your kingdom.
- 'Parsin,' or 'divided,' means/indicates that God will divide your kingdom.

PERES: The Aramaic word that the BSB transliterates as PERES is the singular of the Aramaic word "Parsin" in 5:25b. Daniel may also have intended to make a play on the word pares which means Persia. The kingdom of Persia attacked and conquered Babylon that very night. Daniel interpreted it as the verb that sounded like it, the verb that means "divided." The verb is a perfect passive form. It can also refer to half a shekel or half a mina.

Translate this word in the same way as in 5:25b. For example:

- You may transliterate the Aramaic word PERES or "parsin." For example:

parsin: your kingdom has been divided (NJB) In the online version of the NJB, "parsin" and "divided" are not in italics. However, they may be in italics in printed versions. The words "divisions" and "Parsin/parsin" are in italics in the GNT, NLT,

and CEV, cited just below. So in those cases the codes are appropriate.

- You may translate the meaning of the word PERES. For example:

Divided—your kingdom will be divided (GW)

divisions, your kingdom is divided up (GNT)

- You may both transliterate and supply the meaning. For example:

Parsin means 'divided' (NLT)

parsin, which means "divided" (CEV)

your kingdom has been divided: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as divided means "break in two, divide, separate." This was to happen that very night. God had decided this and it was certain to happen. Daniel referred to this future event as if it had already happened. This is the haphal perfect of šelem. HALOT (1996) suggests "to make an end of, finish, or to abandon." This was a special way that prophets talked when they proclaimed a message from God. Use the verb tense that is natural in your language. For example:

your kingdom will be divided (GW)

Your kingdom is being divided (NCV)

I declare/proclaim what God has decided: the division of your kingdom!

The word divided does not mean that the Medes and the Persians would share the country with the Babylonians. It means that God would end the power of the Babylonian empire. Translate the meaning in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

your kingdom is broken

This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. God is the implied subject. For example:

God will divide your kingdom

God has decided to break your kingdom

your kingdom: See also the Notes at 5:26b. In this context the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom refers to the territory of Babylonia.

**5:28b
and given over to the Medes and Persians.”**

- God will give your kingdom to the Medes and Persians.
- The Medes and the Persians will conquer it.”

and given over to the Medes and Persians: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as given over to the Medes and Persians indicates that God would allow the Medes and Persians to conquer the kingdom of Babylon. This was an event still to happen, in the very near future. So in some languages it may be natural to translate this using a future tense verb. For example:

will be...given to the Medes and Persians (GW)

This is a passive clause. In some languages an active clause may be more natural. If that is true in your language, you may supply the subject “God” and say:

God will give it to the Medes and Persians.

God will allow the Medes and Persians to conquer it.

Medes: The Medes were an Indo-European tribe that lived in the area that is now part of the modern country of Iran.

Persians: The Persians were a tribe that lived in the land that is now called Iran. They had previously been allies of the Babylonians. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Persians sounds like the word “PERES.” Some versions show this play on words by using italics for both words. Another option is to explain the play on words in a footnote.

Daniel 5:29

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

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Daniel explains the writing (5:13)

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Belshazzar’s Feast (5:1)

The Writing on the Wall (5:5)

The Writing on the Wall Interpreted (5:13)

You should decide the number of headings that is best in your translation. The purpose of headings is to help readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

Nabonidus was the king of Babylon from 556 to 539 B.C. Historical records indicate that he married Nitocris, the daughter of Nebuchadnezzar, and that Belshazzar was their oldest son. See the ancient Greek historian Herodotus and the Nabonidus Chronicles. While Nabonidus was absent from Babylon during the

last ten years of his reign, Belshazzar acted as king in his place.

Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:29

The king rewarded Daniel for interpreting the writing on the wall.

5:29a

Then Belshazzar gave the command, and they clothed Daniel in purple,

- Then Belshazzar commanded that Daniel be given purple clothes to wear
- ¶ Immediately King Belshazzar ordered his servants to honor Daniel. They dressed Daniel in a valuable/beautiful purple robe.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces what happened next, immediately afterwards. Here is another way to translate this:

Immediately (GNT)

Belshazzar gave the command: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as Belshazzar gave the command is literally "Belshazzar said." In some languages it may be more natural to include the implied object. For example:

Belshazzar ordered his servants (GNT)

Belshazzar commanded his men.

they clothed Daniel in purple: The Aramaic clause is literally, "They clothed Daniel with purple." See the Notes at 5:7d, 5:16c. There are different ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

Daniel was dressed in purple (NJB)

- Using an active verb. For example

they (indefinite) gave Daniel purple clothes to wear

his servants dressed Daniel in a robe of royal purple

purple: In the Ancient Near East, purple clothes were extremely expensive. See the Notes at 5:7d, 5:16c. Usually only kings and queens wore clothes that were purple. Some translations supply this implied information. For example:

robes of royal purple (GNT)

purple clothes fit for a king (NCV)

expensive clothes

5:29b

placed a gold chain around his neck,

- and a gold chain to go around his neck.
- His servants also honored Daniel by giving him a gold chain to wear on his neck/shoulders.

placed a gold chain around his neck: See the Notes at 5:7e, 5:16d. The NIV translates this expression as a passive clause, and the BSB translates this as an active clause. If it is more natural to translate this as an active clause, some other ways to do this are:

and they (indefinite) put a gold chain on his neck

and his servants put a gold chain around his neck

and hung a gold chain of honor around his neck.

a gold chain: The phrase a gold chain indicates that this chain was made of solid gold. Such a chain was very expensive. It was an ornament, a symbol of honor. The purpose of the chain was not to keep Daniel imprisoned but to honor him. In some languages, it may be important to include this implied information. For example:

a gold chain of honor (GNT)

a beautiful necklace made of gold

5:29c**and proclaimed him the third highest ruler in the kingdom.**

- He made a proclamation that Daniel was to be the third highest ruler in the kingdom.
- The officials then proclaimed Daniel as the third most powerful person in the kingdom.

and proclaimed him the third highest ruler in the kingdom: The Aramaic clause is literally, “They proclaimed about him that he will be ruling third in the kingdom.” The pronoun “They” is indefinite. The king’s officials proclaimed or announced this message publicly. When they proclaimed or announced this, Daniel actually became the third highest ruler. The proclamation caused this to happen. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clear by saying:

by proclamation he was made the third highest ruler in the kingdom

it was announced that he was now the third highest ruler in the kingdom

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language. You may:

- use a passive verb. For example:

a proclamation was made about him, that he should be the third ruler in the kingdom (ESV)

proclamation was made that he should rank third in the kingdom (REB)

- use an active verb. For example:

He made Daniel the third-highest ruler in the kingdom. (GW)

The royal officials proclaimed him the third ruler in the kingdom

Then his officials announced that Daniel was now the third-highest ruler of the land.

the third highest ruler in the kingdom: See the Notes at 5:7f, 5:16e. Translate it here the same way you did there.

kingdom: See also the Notes at 5:26b. In this context the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom refers to the territory or empire of Babylonia.

General Comment on 5:29

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

“Belshazzar gave a command for Daniel to be made the third most powerful man in his kingdom^a and to be given a purple robe^b and a gold chain. (CEV)

“Then Belshazzar proclaimed Daniel the third most powerful ruler in his kingdom. ^aHe gave him royal purple robes to wear ^band he placed a gold chain around his neck.

Daniel 5:30**Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar**

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

English versions give different headings to Daniel 5. These include:

The Handwriting on the Wall (GW)

The Writing on the Wall (NIV)

King Belshazzar’s Banquet (CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to write the heading in the form of a clause. For example, you could say:

King Belshazzar saw a hand write on the wall.

King Belshazzar had/gave a banquet/feast.

Some versions give headings to the subsections of Daniel 5. For example, the NLT has two headings:

The Writing on the Wall (5:1)

Daniel explains the writing (5:13)

The NRSV has three headings:

Belshazzar's Feast (5:1)

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You should decide the number of headings that is best in your translation. The purpose of headings is to help readers to follow the events of the story. Headings also help the reader understand the relationships between the different parts of the story. You should try not to have more headings than necessary.

Historical Background:

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Daniel 5 describes the last night of the Babylonian empire. From other historic sources we know that Cyrus, the king of Persia, attacked the Babylonian army during the 7th month of the year 539 B.C. On the 15th day of that month, they attacked the town of Sippar and King Nabonidus fled. The next day Cyrus' army entered the city of Babylon without any battle and killed its ruler, Belshazzar. Daniel 5 describes what Belshazzar was doing on the last day of the Babylonian empire.

Paragraph 5:30–31

A new topic begins at 5:30. The text summarizes what happened later that evening. The Medes and Persians attacked Babylon and killed King Belshazzar.

5:30

That very night Belshazzar king of the Chaldeans was slain,

- ¶ That same night, Belshazzar, the king of the Babylonians, was killed.
- ¶ That night enemy soldiers killed Belshazzar, king of the Babylonians.
- ¶ That was the night that the Medes and Persians attacked Babylon and killed King Belshazzar.

That very night: The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates That very night refers to the night following the celebration feast/banquet (5:1–4).

Belshazzar king of the Chaldeans was slain: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as was slain means “was killed.” The same verb occurs in 5:19b This is a passive clause. If an active clause is more natural in your language, you can say:

they (indefinite) killed Belshazzar, the Chaldean king.

enemies attacked Babylon and killed Belshazzar, king of the Babylonians.

the Medes and the Persians attacked Babylon and killed King Belshazzar

king of the Chaldeans: In this context, the Aramaic word that the BSB literally translates as Chaldeans, refers to people from Chaldea, that is, Babylon. HALOT, 1903. There are several ways to translate this:

- Use the more general name that refers to these people. For example:

Babylonian king (NLT)

king of Babylonia (GNT)

king of the Babylonian people (NCV)

- Use a name that is based on the name Chaldeans. For example:

king of the Chald-people

king of the Chaldeans (REB)

the Chaldean king (RSV)

- Include a reference to both of the names above. For example,

king of the Chaldeans, that is, the Babylonians.

Since Babylon has been mentioned previously, a reference to “Babylonians” here may be the best choice. However, if the church in your area prefers the name

“Chaldean,” you may want to include it in a footnote. The footnote should explain that these two names refer to the same people.

Daniel 5:31

Section 5:1–31: God judged King Belshazzar

The author continued to write in the Aramaic language. He wrote about how King Belshazzar gave a big banquet and made use of the sacred treasures from the Jerusalem temple. Belshazzar saw a hand writing a mysterious message on the wall. Only Daniel was able to explain the message, that God was about to punish Belshazzar. That same night an army of Medes and Persians conquered the city and killed Belshazzar.

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Paragraph 5:30–31

A new topic begins at 5:30. The text summarizes what happened later that evening. The Medes and Persians attacked Babylon and killed King Belshazzar.

5:31a and Darius the Mede received the kingdom

- Darius the Mede became the new ruler of the kingdom/country.
- A man named Darius the Mede then began to rule over the Babylonians.

5:31b at the age of sixty-two.

- He was sixty-two years old.
- He was sixty-two years old at that time.

5:31

Some English versions number this verse as 6:1 (NJB, NJPS). Daniel 5:30 is 6:1 in the Aramaic text. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB. It may be best to follow the verse numbers in the national translation of the Bible. You will want to discuss this issue with your consultant.

and Darius the Mede received the kingdom: Some different ways to translate this are:

And Darius the Mede became ruler of the Babylonian kingdom

And Darius the Mede became the king of the Babylonian kingdom.

Ancient records do not record the name or title Darius the Mede. Commentators differ as to who this person was. The Old Greek manuscripts say “Artaxerxes” or “Xerxes.”

1. Some scholars think that this was the throne name of Cyrus when he conquered Babylon in 539 B.C. Cyrus was the king who later freed the Jews from Babylon. 2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–8; 3:7; 4:5; 5:13–6:14; Isaiah 45:1.
2. Some scholars think that this was the name of the general who actually captured Babylon for Cyrus. This man’s name was Ugbaru. He apparently died a few weeks after taking Babylon.
3. Some scholars think that this is the name of a man called Gubaru, whom Cyrus appointed as governor of the territories of Babylon. The classical name for this man was Gobryas. Lucas (p. 135) cites Rowley as saying that there is no evidence that he was called Darius, that he was a Mede or that he bore the title king.

You should translate his name literally.

received the kingdom: In this context, the Aramaic phrase that the BSB literally translates as received the kingdom, indicates that Darius became king of Babylonia. Here are some other ways to translate this:

became the new king (NCV)

seized the royal power (GNT)

was given royal power

at the age of sixty-two: Darius the Mede was 62 years old when he became ruler of Babylon. Other ways English versions translate this are:

who was then sixty-two years old (GNT)

when he was sixty-two years old (NCV)

General Comment on 5:31

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

when he was 62 years old, Darius the Mede began to reign.

Daniel 6:1

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

Special Problems:

1. **Lists:** The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1–2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.

2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. Verbs of Speech: The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:1-2

This paragraph explains the background to the main narrative. It tells how Darius structured the government of his kingdom.

6:1

Now it pleased Darius to appoint 120 satraps to rule throughout the kingdom,

- ¶ Darius thought it good to appoint a hundred and twenty governors to rule throughout his kingdom.
- ¶ Darius decided to choose men to help him govern his empire. He chose 120 officials to be in charge of the provinces.

Now: In the Aramaic text there is no connector at the beginning of this verse but in some languages it may be necessary to supply a connection to the previous chapter as the BSB has done by supplying the word Now. Other ways to connect this portion to the previous chapter are:

After Darius became king ...

One day ...

it pleased Darius to appoint 120 satraps to rule throughout the kingdom: The new ruler of Babylonia, Darius the Mede, decided to rule his large kingdom through 120 satraps. These men would have authority in each local district or area. Here are some other ways to translate this:

It pleased Darius to set over the kingdom 120 satraps. (NRSV)

Darius decided it would be good to appoint 120 satraps to rule throughout the kingdom. (GW)

Darius decided to appoint a hundred and twenty governors to hold office throughout his empire. (GNT)

it pleased Darius to appoint: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as pleased means “seemed good to.” In this context, the phrase implies that Darius decided to act in this way, and then he actually did so. For example:

Darius decided it would be good to appoint (GW)

Darius decided...and he appointed (NLT)

Darius: See the Notes at 5:31. You can also translate this name as:

Darius the Mede (NLT)

King Darius

to appoint 120 satraps: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as appoint here indicates that Darius chose one hundred and twenty men and gave them the position and authority of rulers called satraps. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

to set over the kingdom a hundred and twenty satraps (RSV)

to choose one hundred twenty governors (NCV)

satraps: See the Notes at 3:2a. A “satrap” was an official who ruled over a region of the Persian empire. Esther 1:1 mentions 127 provinces at the time of Xerxes (485-465 B.C.). From other ancient sources, there appeared to be between 20 to 29 satraps in the Persian empire at the time of Darius I (522-485 B.C.) The author may use the word “satrap” here in the wider sense of a provincial official. The term was used in 3:2 referring to the time of the Babylonian empire. Use a term that is natural in your language for the title of such an official. For example:

governors (GNT)

high officer (NLT)

to rule throughout the kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as to rule is a general verb. The Aramaic phrase is more literally “who will be throughout the kingdom.” The satraps would live and rule spread out over the kingdom, each ruling one of the 120 provinces. Here are some other ways to translate this:

stationed throughout the whole kingdom (NRSV)

to hold office throughout his empire (GNT)

who would be in charge of the entire kingdom (NET)

throughout the kingdom: The phrase throughout the kingdom here refers to the entire country that Darius ruled. See how you translated the kingdom in 5:31. For example:

throughout his empire (GNT)

over his whole realm

General Comment on 6:1

This verse implies that the 120 men ruled over 120 different parts of the kingdom. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Darius the Mede decided to divide the country into 120 provinces, and he appointed a high officer to rule over each province. (NLT)

Darius divided his kingdom into a hundred and twenty states and placed a governor in charge of each one. (CEV)

One day King Darius decided to appoint men to help govern his kingdom. He divided the kingdom into one hundred and twenty provinces and appointed an official to be in charge of each one.

Daniel 6:2

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone

but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

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2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. Verbs of Speech: The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The

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4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:1-2

This paragraph explains the background to the main narrative. It tells how Darius structured the government of his kingdom.

6:2a

and over them three administrators, including Daniel,

- He also appointed three overseers to supervise the governors. One of these three men was Daniel.
- He chose three men as supervisors over the one hundred and twenty officials. One of these supervisors was Daniel.

and over them three administrators: The king also appointed three officials to supervise the 120 satraps. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

The king also chose...three administrators to supervise the princes (NLT)

He chose three men as supervisors over those governors.

Darius put three other officials in charge of the governors. (CEV)

over them: The pronoun them refers to the 120 satraps.

administrators: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as administrators means “high officials.” English versions translate this term in different ways:

chief ministers (REB)

presidents (RSV)

supervisors (GNT)

commissioners (NASB)

Translate this term in a way that is natural for referring to high-level government officials.

including Daniel: Daniel was one of the three administrators placed over the provincial governors.

General Comment on 6:2a

In some languages it may be more natural to refer to Daniel earlier in the sentence, as he is the chief character of the book. For example:

The king also chose Daniel and two others as administrators to supervise the high officers. (NLT)

6:2b

to whom these satraps were accountable so that the king would not suffer loss.

- The governors had to report to the administrators so that no one would cause the king loss/trouble of any kind.
- The three supervisors oversaw/checked the work of the officials. They had to make sure that no one cheated the king.

to whom these satraps were accountable: The Aramaic pronoun that the BSB translates as to whom here refers to the three administrators or high officials. The 120 satraps had to report to the three administrators.

In some languages it may be natural to indicate that the administrators were over the satraps. For example:

administrators to supervise the high officers (NLT)

Darius put three other officials in charge of the governors (CEV)

were accountable: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as were accountable means “were reporting to, were responsible to.” The satraps had to give a report of what they did and were responsible for the results. Here are some other ways to translate this:

to report to (GW)

gave account (NRSV)

were to be responsible to (NJB)

so that the king would not suffer loss: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as so that here introduces the purpose of the previous clause. The king’s purpose in appointing the three administrators was to

protect his interests. He wanted to make sure that the satraps were honest and gave him all the taxes they collected. Here are some other ways to translate this purpose clause:

so that the king's interests might not suffer (REB)

so that the king wouldn't be cheated (GW)

The supervisors were to ensure that the governors did not try to cheat the king. (NCV)

the king would not suffer loss: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as suffer loss refers to suffering any kind of injury, difficulty, or failure.”HALOT, 1929 has: “to come to grief.” The ancient versions have “to be bothered.” These officials were responsible to ensure that the king would not lose any territory because of rebellion. They also made sure that everyone paid their taxes and that no one cheated the king. See also the last clause in Ezra 4:13. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that no one might cause the king trouble/loss

so that no one might cause difficulty for the king

so that no one would cheat the king

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to use a positive expression. For example:

to...protect the king's interests (NLT)

to look after the king's interests (GNT)

the king: Make sure that it is clear that the phrase the king refers to the same person as Darius, the subject of the verb in 6:1. In some languages it may be more natural to use a pronoun here. For example:

King Darius appointed them so that no one could cheat/defraud him.

General Comment on 6:2

In some languages it may be more natural to refer to Daniel at the end of the verse part, mentioning his position in a separate sentence. For example:

In order to make sure that his government was run properly, Darius put three other officials in charge of the governors. One of these officials was Daniel. (CEV)

He named three head/chief officials to supervise the satraps. In this way no one could cause damage to the king's interests. Daniel was one of these head/chief officials.

Daniel 6:3

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:3-5

The other government officials became jealous of Daniel and began to plot against him.

6:3a

Soon, by his extraordinary spirit, Daniel distinguished himself among the administrators and satraps.

- ¶ Daniel showed/proved himself superior to the other overseers and the governors because he was exceptionally/unusually capable/competent.
- ¶ Daniel did much better work than the other two supervisors and all the provincial officials because he had extraordinary intelligence and ability.

Soon...Daniel distinguished himself among the administrators and satraps: Daniel was a better ruler than the others. He was superior to them in his ability to govern the country. Other ways to translate this include:

Daniel...was so evidently superior to the other presidents and satraps (NJB)

Daniel soon showed that he could do better work than the other supervisors or the governors (GNT)

And he did his work so much better than the other governors and officials (CEV)

Soon: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Soon here introduces a new stage in the narrative and adds emphasis. Other ways to translate it include:

Then (RSV/NRSV)

Now (NIV)

by his extraordinary spirit: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as by here introduces a reason clause. There are at least two interpretations:

1. It connects to the previous clause and introduces the reason why Daniel was able to do better work than the other men. For example:

because an excellent spirit was in him (RSV) (BSB, NIV, RSV/NRSV, KJV, ESV, NJB, REB, NET, GW, NASB)

1. It connects to the following clause and introduces the reason why the king appointed Daniel. For example:

Because of Daniel's great ability, the king made plans to place him over the entire empire. (NLT) (NLT, CEV, NCV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

his extraordinary spirit: This phrase refers to Daniel's intelligence and ability to learn and understand. See 1:17a. See the notes at 5:12b-c, where the same phrase occurs. Here are some other ways to translate this:

excellent spirit (NRSV)

exceptional qualities (NIV)

exceptional ability (REB)

Daniel: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Daniel is literally "this Daniel." The pronoun "this" identifies Daniel as the same Daniel the author referred to in 6:1. Translate in a way that is natural in your language. If you decide to translate the pronoun, make sure that it does not give a negative or derogatory meaning.

distinguished himself among the administrators and satraps: Daniel was an excellent administrator. He was clearly superior to the other officials. Others—probably including the king—could see what good work he did. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Among all the administrators and satraps, it was Daniel who proved to be the best

In that group of administrators and satraps, Daniel showed/displayed excellence

Daniel stood out among the administrators and satraps

In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea as a comparison. Daniel showed himself better than the other officials. He did better work than they did. For example:

proved himself more capable than all the other high administrators and high officers (NLT)

showed that he could do better work than the other supervisors or the governors (GNT)

did his work so much better than the other governors and officials (CEV)

among the administrators and satraps: Daniel was one of the three administrators. So in some languages it may be natural to say:

among the other administrators and satraps

all the other presidents and satraps (RSV)

administrators: See the Notes at 6:2a. Daniel was one of a group of three administrators. So it may be natural to say:

than the two other supervisors

than both of the other high officials

and satraps: See the Notes at 6:1. Use the same word here that you did there. For example:

and the governors

and all the officials

General Comment on 6:3a

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the two clauses. For example:

Daniel excelled all the other high officials and satraps because he could learn and understand things well.

6:3b

So the king planned to set him over the whole kingdom.

- So the king started to make plans to appoint him to administer the whole kingdom.
- As a result, the king decided he would put him in charge of the entire empire.

So the king planned to set him over the whole kingdom: This is a result clause. Because Daniel was so outstanding an administrator (6:3a), the king planned to promote him.

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So can also be translated as “and,” as in the RSV. In this context, it introduces a result. Here are some other ways to translate this:

that (NIV)

That is why...

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your own language.

the king planned to set him over the whole kingdom: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as planned to set means “intended to appoint.” The king wanted to make Daniel the highest official in the land. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the king made plans to place him over the entire empire (NLT)

the king considered putting him in charge of the whole empire (GNT)

the king decided to let him govern the whole kingdom (CEV)

The phrase implies that the king had not yet formally appointed him to that office, but was intending to do so. *Translator's Handbook on Daniel*.

over the whole kingdom: This phrase refers to the Persian empire. See 1:20b. Here is another way to translate this:

the entire empire (NLT)

Daniel 6:4

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The

difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

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Paragraph 6:3–5

The other government officials became jealous of Daniel and began to plot against him.

6:4a

Thus the administrators and satraps sought a charge against Daniel

- After that, the overseers and governors tried to find a reason to accuse Daniel
- Then the other officials looked for a way to find fault with Daniel

Thus: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Thus* here introduces what happened when the administrators and satraps heard what the king was planning. Other ways to translate this include:

So (NRSV)

because of this (NCV)

when they heard this

the administrators and satraps sought a charge against Daniel: The other officials did not want Daniel to be in charge of the whole government. They tried

to avoid this by looking for a way to make him look bad in the king's eyes. They wanted to discredit Daniel, so they looked for evidence that he was corrupt or incompetent. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The other men tried to find something wrong with the way Daniel did his work for the king. (CEV)

the other administrators and high officers began searching for some fault in the way Daniel was handling government affairs (NLT)

There is some implied information here. It is implied that the other officials were not happy about the king's plan. They were angry and became jealous of Daniel. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate some of this implied information. For example:

the administrators and satraps became angry/jealous and tried to find a reason to charge Daniel with wrongdoing.

the administrators and satraps: The text is referring to the officials mentioned in 6:1, 6:2a. But Daniel himself is not included. So in some languages it may be natural to include a word meaning "other." For example:

the other supervisors and governors (NCV)

the two other supervisors and all the governors

sought: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as sought is literally "were seeking to find." The officials searched for a reason to accuse Daniel of something bad. Other ways to say this in English are:

began searching for (NLT)

looked for (NJPS)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

a charge against Daniel: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as a charge is a general word meaning "matter, affair, occasion."^{4a} "matter, affair, occasion," BDB, 1106; "reason for making a complaint, pretext" HALOT, 1947. The men wanted to find something, anything, that they could use as a reason for making a complaint. In this context the word refers to

an inadequate reason, that is, a pretext. Other ways English versions translate this are:

something to accuse Daniel of (GW)

reasons to accuse Daniel (NCV)

something wrong (GNT)

6:4b concerning the kingdom,

- in the way that he administrated the kingdom.
- in his management of the government,

concerning the kingdom: The officials wanted to show the king that Daniel was failing in the way he conducted his government duties. Here are some other ways to translate this:

with regard to the kingdom (RSV)

in his duties for the kingdom (GW)

with the way Daniel administered the empire (GNT)

General Comment on 6:4a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder and combine the information in 6:4a–b. For example:

^{4a-b}When the other administrators and governors heard about this, they began to examine the way Daniel did his work in order to accuse him of something wrong.

6:4c but they could find no charge or corruption,

- but they could not discover anything to criticize him for.
- but they could not find any fault to accuse him of.

but: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrast. In spite of their efforts, the officials could not discover anything about Daniel that they could complain about to the king.

they could find no charge or corruption: See the Notes at 6:4a. Some English versions, such as the RSV and BSB, follow the Aramaic and repeat this idea. For example:

but they could find no ground for complaint (RSV)

But in many languages such a repetition may be unnatural. It may be more natural to translate this phrase in another way. For example:

they couldn't find anything to criticize (NLT)

they could not find anything wrong (GW)

but they couldn't (GNT)

The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as they could find no charge or corruption here indicates that it was clear to the officials that Daniel was not corrupt. He never took bribes or placed his own interests above his duties. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But they were unable to find any such damaging evidence (NET)

They could find nothing to his discredit. (NJB)

but they failed to find any malpractice on his part (REB)

It is important to avoid implying that the officials could not find corruption but that it was secretly present. The author was not saying that Daniel was able to hide his corrupt dealings. If a literal translation would give this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to say:

they found he had never acted corruptly

they found him to be incorruptible/honest

corruption: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as corruption is also used in 2:9c, where the BSB translates it as “fraudulent.” It literally refers to something that is spoiled or bad. In this context it refers to accepting bribes and using public office for personal gain.

6:4d

because he was trustworthy, and no negligence or corruption was found in him.

- They saw/realized that he was not corrupt. He was reliable and honest and did/fulfilled all his duties/responsibilities.

- He did not use his office for personal gain and was dependable. He did not neglect to do anything he was supposed to do, and he did not act dishonestly.

because he was trustworthy, and no negligence or corruption was found in him: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the official could not find any fault with Daniel. It was because there were no faults in his behavior, public or private.

he was trustworthy: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as trustworthy is also used in 2:45f. In Daniel 2:45f it is used as an adjective to describe Daniel's interpretation. The RSV translates it “sure.” The GNT has “true.” The NJB has “exact.” In this context, it describes Daniel as honest and dependable. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

he was faithful (RSV)

Daniel was reliable (GNT)

and no negligence or corruption was found in him: This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and no error or fault was found in him (RSV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

and did not do anything wrong or dishonest (GNT)

No one could accuse him of laziness or dishonesty.

He was not guilty of any negligence or corruption. Similarly, the NET.

no negligence or corruption: The Aramaic text says “any negligence and corruption.” Use the order and grammatical form that is most natural in your language. For example:

neither corrupt nor negligent (NIV)

corruption: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as corruption refers to self-serving behavior, acting for personal gain rather than the common good. See the Notes at 6:4c-d. Other ways to translate this are:

corrupt (NIV)

dishonest (GNT)

negligence: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as negligence refers to a habit of working in a careless and lazy way. A negligent person is one who does not fulfill their duties and responsibilities. Other ways to translate this include:

lazy (NCV)

irresponsible

General Comment on 6:4d

In some languages it is more natural to translate all of 6:4d in a positive way. For example:

He was faithful, always responsible, and completely trustworthy. (NLT)

because he was honest and faithful and did everything he was supposed to do (CEV)

Daniel 6:5

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

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B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

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Paragraph 6:3–5

The other government officials became jealous of Daniel and began to plot against him.

6:5a

Finally these men said, “We will never find any charge against this Daniel,

- Then the officials said to each other: “We will never discover any reason to accuse Daniel,
- The men discussed this together and said, “We will never be able to accuse Daniel of doing something wrong.

- The men concluded that they would never be able to bring charges against Daniel for the way he did his work.

Finally: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Finally here introduces the next event in the narrative. See the Notes at 6:3a, where the same word occurs. Here is another way to translate this:

Then (RSV)

these men said: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as these men said here introduces what the officials said to each other. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

They said to each other (GNT)

they said to one another (CEV)

We will never find any charge against this Daniel: The officials realized that they would not be able to find any fault with Daniel's work. See the Notes at 6:4c-d. Here are some other ways to translate this:

We will never be able to bring any charge against Daniel (CEV)

We will never find any reason to accuse Daniel (NCV)

We shall never find a way of discrediting Daniel (NJB)

We: If your language distinguishes between the inclusive "we" and the exclusive "we," use the inclusive form. The men were talking to one another.

any charge: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as charge here refers to a reason for making a complaint. Translate this as you did in 6:4a, b. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

pretext (NET)

fault (NJPS)

ground of complaint (RSV)

this Daniel: See the Notes at 6:3a. Here, however, the use of the pronoun this may have a negative or derogatory implication.

6:5b
unless we find something against him concerning the law of his God."

- unless we find a reason that has to do with the law of his God."
- The only way we can accuse him is to find something connected/related to the law of the God he worships."
- Only in connection with the law of his God might they bring such a charge.

unless we find something against him concerning the law of his God: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as unless here introduces an exception to the previous clause. HALOT, 1908. It also occurs in 2:11; 3:28; 6:8-13. The officials agreed that they might be able to accuse Daniel of something related to the laws of his God. Your languages may have a different way to translate exceptions like this. For example:

only if it is something to do with the laws of his God

except a complaint in connection with the laws of his God

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

It will only be possible to find such a ground for complaint in connection with the law of his God

something against him concerning the law of his God: Other ways to say this include:

in connection with the law of his God (NRSV)

it is connected with his religion (REB)

it is about the law of his God (NCV)

it is in relation to the law of his God

the law of his God: The phrase the law of his God refers in general to the collection of laws that Daniel's God had given to his people. The officials knew that Daniel always obeyed this law. The word is singular,

although the plural “laws” is also acceptable in this context. For example:

the rules of his religion (NLT)

law: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as law usually refers to a royal command (2:13–15) or to laws made by the government (2:16; 6:8,12, 15).^{da†} HALOT, 1856. Here, however, it refers to religious law.^{HALOT}, 1856.

General Comment on 6:5a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this verse in a positive way. For example:

The only way we can accuse him is in connection with his religious duties/obligations.

The only point that we can catch him is in his loyalty to the law of his God.^{GeCL97}.

Our only chance of finding grounds for accusing Daniel will be in connection with the rules of his religion. (NLT)

Daniel 6:6

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken

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Paragraph 6:6–9

This paragraph indicates what the officials did as a result of what they had concluded in the previous paragraph. They went and spoke to the king in order to trap Daniel in connection with the laws of his God.

6:6a

So the administrators and satraps went together to the king

- ¶ So the overseers and governors went together to the king

- ¶ The two other supervisors and the governors all went to talk to the king.

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces what the officials did after and in accordance with what they decided in 6:5. They had decided that they could only find fault with Daniel in connection with God's laws. Now they tried to find or invent such a fault. Introduce this action in a way that is natural in your language.

the administrators and satraps went together to the king: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as together is rare and its meaning is uncertain. *reḡaš*. See HALOT, 1979. Ancient as well as modern versions differ in the way they translate it. The ancient versions translate this word differently in the three places it occurs. Here Theodotion and Syriac have "approached." The Vulgate has "went secretly." Collins (p. 267) favors the view that the word means "to come in a throng, or tumult." See also the note by Goldingay, p. 121. There are several possibilities:

1. It means "came/went as a crowd." For example:

they all went to the king (CEV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NCV, NJB, GW, CEV, NJPS)

1. It means "went as they had planned." For example:

came by agreement (NASB) (NASB, ESV, NET, RSV/ NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is not in fact very different from interpretation (2). But since the exact meaning is not certain, some versions use a more general verb. For example:

went to see (GNT)

went (NLT)

6:6b

and said, "O King Darius, may you live forever!"

- and said, "King Darius, we^(excl) wish/hope that you will live forever!
- They addressed the king: "Long live King Darius!"

and said: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as and said is more literally "and thus said." It gives emphasis to what the men were about to say. Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

and this is what they said

and spoke these words

said: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as said here introduces what the officials communicated to the king. The men did not speak together all at the same time. One of the men probably spoke to the king as the representative of the whole group. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

O King Darius, may you live forever!: See the Notes at 2:4b, 3:9, and 5:10c. This figure of speech was a common way people greeted a king. It means that the officials wished the king a long and healthy life. Other ways English versions translate this are:

O King Darius, live for ever! (RSV)

We hope you live forever (CEV)

Long live King Darius (NLT)

Use a natural way someone in your language might greet and show respect to an important person.

King Darius: See the Notes at 2:4b, 3:9, and 5:10c. The officials addressed the king with respect. They called him by his title and his name, using the third person. Languages have different ways to address an important person. For example:

Your Majesty

our^(excl) king

Use a form that is natural in your language to show respect to an important person.

Daniel 6:7

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where

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wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:6–9

This paragraph indicates what the officials did as a result of what they had concluded in the previous paragraph. They went and spoke to the king in order to trap Daniel in connection with the laws of his God.

6:7a

All the royal administrators, prefects, satraps, advisers, and governors have agreed

- All the overseers of the kingdom, the administrators, the governors, the advisers, and the top officials have agreed together
- All of us who serve the king, the supervisors, the high officials, the king's counselors, and the other officials have had a meeting and want

All the royal administrators, prefects, satraps, advisers, and governors have agreed:

The officials were talking about themselves. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

We ^(excl) the royal administrators, prefects, satraps, advisers and governors

We are all agreed, presidents of the realm, magistrates, satraps, councillors and governors (NJB)

Scholars are uncertain of the exact function of each of these officials. They are also unsure if the names are listed according to rank. The main point is that the text refers to all the important members of the administration, the government officials. In some languages you may not have so many different names for officials. In that case you may have to translate a shorter list and use more general terms for officials. For example:

All of your officials, leaders, advisors and governors (CEV)

All of us who administer your empire—the supervisors, the governors, the lieutenant governors, and the other officials (GNT)

royal administrators: This term refers to the high officials who supervised the satraps. Not including Daniel, there were only two of them. See the Notes at 6:2a. Translate the term here as you did there. For example:

chief officials of the kingdom
Nouvelle Version
Second, the BFrCL88 is similar.

administrators (NLT)

supervisors (GNT)

prefects: The prefects were also government officials but their specific role is uncertain. See the Notes at 3:2a. Translate the term here in the same way you did there. For example:

advisors (CEV)

magistrates (NJB)

satraps: See the Notes at 6:1 and 6:2a. Translate the term here as you did there. For example:

governors (NCV)

advisers: See the Notes at 3:24b, 3:27a. The same word is used in 3:24b, 27a, 4:36. Translate here as you did there. For example:

counselors (RSV)

governors: See the Notes at 3:2a. Translate here as you did there and at 3:27.

have agreed: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates have agreed means “have taken counsel together.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

are in agreement

have taken counsel and all are agreed (REB)

are unanimous

6:7b

that the king should establish an ordinance and enforce a decree

- that you, the king, should make a new law that everyone must obey;
- you to make a new law and enforce it strictly.

that the king should establish an ordinance: The officials asked the king to make a new law. They spoke in a polite way in order to influence the king to do what they wanted. Only the king had the authority

to make a law official. Here are some other ways to translate this:

that Your Majesty should issue an order (GNT)

the king should make a statute (GW)

you should make a law (CEV)

ordinance: The word that the BSB translates as ordinance here refers to a law that was to be in effect for a specific period of time. Use a term that can refer to a temporary order such as this one. For example:

decree (REB)

edict (NIV)

law (CEV)

and enforce a decree: This phrase explains more about the law. The officials wanted to be able to punish those who disobeyed it. Here are some other ways to translate this:

that will be strictly enforced (NLT)

and enforce it strictly (GNT)

for everyone to obey (NCV)

decree: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as decree refers to a law that prohibits something. HALOT, 1821. The word occurs in 6:8,10,13,15. You can translate this as:

interdict (RSV)

ban

prohibition

However, make sure that you do not imply that the men were talking about two laws. The term decree refers to the same law as the word “ordinance” in the previous clause. In some languages it may be better to use a pronoun that refers back to the law in the previous clause. For example:

and enforce it strictly (GNT)

6:7c

that for thirty days anyone who petitions any god or man

- For the next thirty days, anyone who prays to a god or man/human
- For the next month, no one may pray to any god or person

In Daniel 6:7c the officials told the king what the law should say. In some languages it may be good to start a new sentence here. For example:

The decree should state... (GW)

Give orders... (GNT)

that for thirty days anyone who petitions any god

or man: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as petitions is literally “requests a request.” In this context, it means “prays a prayer.” There are two ways to indicate the content of the decree:

- You can state this positively:

that whoever prays to anyone (NRSV)

- You can state it negatively:

no one should pray to...

The Persians used to pray both to gods and to people who represented gods, like the king. In some languages it may not be natural use the verb “pray” in this way. If that is true in your language, you may have to use a different verb for “pray” as the BSB has done. Some other ways to do this are:

no one may request anything

whoever asks for anything (GW)

for thirty days: This phrase indicates that this new law would be in force for thirty days. After that time, it would no longer apply.

any god: See the Notes at 2:11b; 5:4, 2:23a. The Persians worshiped many different kinds of gods. In some languages, the word god only refers to the one true God. If that is true in your language, you may have to use a different term here. For example:

to any divine/supernatural being

to any spirit

to anyone/anything we worship

man: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as man here refers to people in general.

human (NRSV)

person (GW)

6:7d

except you, O king,

- other than to you, our king,
- but only to you, the king.

except you, O king: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as except introduces the one exception to the law. People could make their prayers and requests to the king. The officials intended to compliment the king by treating him like a god. Goldingay (p. 128) notes that the Persian king was not thought of as divine in the same way as the Egyptian Pharaoh was thought of by his people. However, in the court, people showed him respect in a ceremonial way as one would show respect to a god. The king was considered as a manifestation or representative of deity as well as a mediator with deity. Other ways you can translate this phrase are:

except to your Majesty (NLT)

other than you, O king (NET)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

They may/must pray to you alone, our king.

Only to you may they pray, O king.

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment on 6:7c–e.

O king: Use a form that is natural in your language to show respect to an important person. For example:

Sir/Sire

Honorable one

our^(excl) king

6:7e

will be thrown into the den of lions.

- is to be tossed/pushed into the den of lions.
- If he disobeys, he must be punished. Let your men throw him into the pit where the lions live so they can eat him!

will be thrown into the den of lions: The punishment for praying to any god or person other than the king was to be death. The king's men would force the offender to enter the den where lions were kept. It is implied that the lions would certainly kill and eat him.

The verb will be thrown is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

they (indefinite) will throw him/them into the den of lions

your soldiers will cause them to fall into the pit where lions live

be thrown: In this context, the verb be thrown indicates that the men would lift the offenders up and drop them into the den. In some languages, you may have to use a different verb. Translate this idea in a way that is most natural in your language. For example:

be dropped

be forced to enter

be caused to fall

the den of lions: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as den here refers to a large room below the ground. There was probably an opening at the top where food could be dropped to the lions. The king kept lions here as a way to execute criminals. In some languages it may not be natural to translate the definite article the since the author has not referred to this den before. You can translate this:

a pit (GNT)

a large hole

lions: The lion is a large and powerful animal of the cat family. It has a brownish yellow skin and a tufted tail, and the male has a shaggy mane. Lions hunt and kill other animals for food. The king punished people by throwing them into the pit where he kept lions. The lions would kill and eat the people. In some languages, people may not be familiar with lions. If that is true in your language, see KBT for different ways to translate unknown terms.

General Comment on 6:7a-e

This is a long and complex sentence. In some languages it may be natural to break it into two or more shorter sentences. For example:

^{7a}All the officials, governors, satraps, advisers and mayors agree that ^{7b}the king should make a statute and enforce a decree. ^{7c}The decree should state that for the next 30 days whoever asks for anything from any god or person ^{7d}except you, Your Majesty, ^{7e}will be thrown into a lions' den. (GW)

^{7a}All of your officials, leaders, advisors, and governors agree that ^{7b}you should make a law ^{7c}forbidding anyone to pray to any god or human except you for the next thirty days. ^{7e}Everyone who disobeys this law must be thrown into a pit of lions. (CEV)

General Comment on 6:7

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses. For example:

^{c-e}The law should state that they will throw into the lion pit anyone who prays to any god or person except you, the king, during the next thirty days,

^{b-e}Give orders, King Darius, that for the next thirty days this law will be in force: your soldiers will throw to the lions anyone who prays to any god or human except you.

General Comment on 6:7c-e

The content of the decree is given as indirect speech. In some languages it may be more natural to give the content directly. For example:

The decree should say this: 'Anyone who prays to any god or human being except for King Darius

shall be thrown into the lions' day. This is in force for thirty days.'

should issue the following decree: For thirty days no one is to pray to any god or human being apart from King Darius. Anyone who disobeys will be thrown to the lions.

Daniel 6:8

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the

numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

Special Problems:

1. **Lists:** The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1–2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.
2. **Repetition:** The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. **Verbs of Speech:** The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. **Synonyms:** The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7–9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:6–9

This paragraph indicates what the officials did as a result of what they had concluded in the previous paragraph. They went and spoke to the king in order to trap Daniel in connection with the laws of his God.

6:8a

Therefore, O king, establish the decree and sign the document

- You, our king, should issue the law and sign it
- So, your Majesty, quickly make this new law and sign it.

Therefore: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *Therefore* here adds emphasis or urgency to the officials' request. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

O king: See the Notes at 6:7d.

establish the decree: See the Notes at 6:7b.

and sign the document: In this context there are two ways to interpret the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as *sign*:

1. It means "sign." Goldingay (p. 120) suggests that it may mean "put your seal to." The officials asked the king to sign or inscribe his name to the law. For example:

and sign it (GNT) (BSB, NASB, GW, GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT, KJV, RSV/NRSV, NJB, ESV)

1. It means “write.” rešem “to write.” HALOT, 1984. The officials asked the king to write the law down. For example:

and have it put in writing (REB) (NIV, REB, NJPS, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

the document: The phrase the document refers to the written form of the decree. The terms the document and “the decree” in the previous clause thus refer to the same law. Translate in such a way that the reader understands this.

6:8b

so that it cannot be changed—

- so that no one can change it.
- Then no one can make any changes to the law,

so that it cannot be changed: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates so that here introduces a purpose clause. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so that it may not be changed (NASB)

so that it cannot be altered (NIV)

so that it becomes unalterable (REB)

it cannot be changed: No one was to be allowed to alter this law. No one could change it. The BSB translates this as a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

so that no one can change it

6:8c

in accordance with the law of the Medes and Persians, which cannot be repealed.”

- The new law will then be like the rest of the laws of the Medes and Persians, which no one can annul/cancel.
- just as no one can revoke/repeal any of our^(incl) laws, the laws governing the Mede people and the Persian people.

in accordance with the law of the Medes and Persians: The Aramaic preposition that the BSB translates as in accordance with means “according to, in agreement with.” The law would be one of the laws of the Medes and Persians, and would function like their other laws. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The law would then correspond with the law of the Medes and Persians

The law would then conform to the law of the Medes and Persians

just as no written law of the Medes and Persians can be changed (CEV)

the law of the Medes and Persians: When the king made a law, it became part of the groups of laws that governed the Medes and the Persians. In some languages, you may have to include some implied information. For example:

the laws that govern the kingdom that the Medes and Persians rule/inhabit

the Medes and Persians: See how you translated the names of these people groups in 5:28, where the same phrase occurs.

which cannot be repealed: There are two ways to interpret the Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as be repealed:

1. It means “be removed, revoked.” For example:

cancelled (NCV) (BSB, GW, NIV, NCV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NJB, REB, NLT)

1. It means “be changed.” According to this interpretation, it is a synonym to “changed” in 6:8b. For example:

changed (GNT) (GNT, CEV, KJV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). No one was allowed to revoke, cancel, or annul the laws of the Medes and the Persians. No one, not even the king, had the authority to put an end to the authority of these laws. See also Esther 1:19a and Esther 8:8c Use the expression that is natural for bringing a law to an end. For example:

revoked (NRSV)

put an end to

This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

which no one can repeal/annul

cannot be repealed: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates cannot is an emphatic negative. Emphasize the impossibility of repealing the law in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

in no way be repealed

In some languages it may be natural to use a strong positive expression. For example:

must remain in force

are firmly established

General Comment on 6:8

In some languages it may be more natural to combine some of the information in this verse. For example:

^{8a}So let your Majesty issue and sign this law.

^{8b,d}Then it will be unchangeable and irrevocable,

^{8c}like the other laws of the Medes and Persians.

Daniel 6:9

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

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Special Problems:

1. Lists: The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1–2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.
2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. Verbs of Speech: The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7–9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:6–9

This paragraph indicates what the officials did as a result of what they had concluded in the previous

paragraph. They went and spoke to the king in order to trap Daniel in connection with the laws of his God.

6:9

Therefore King Darius signed the written decree.

- As a result of their request, the king signed the written ban.
- So King Darius signed the law that prohibited people from praying to their god/God.

Therefore: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces a result clause. The Translator's Handbook on Daniel argues that the connector has a more general sense, such as in NJB and NEB ("accordingly"). Introduce this result in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

And so (GNT)

therefore (RSV/NRSV)

accordingly (NJB)

King Darius signed the written decree: As in 6:8a, there are two ways to interpret the Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as signed the written decree:

- it means "signed." For example:

King Darius signed the order (GNT) (BSB, NASB, GNT, RSV/NRSV, ESV, KJV, GW, NLT, REB, NCV)

- it means "wrote down." For example:

King Darius issued the written interdict. (NET) (NIV, NET, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as in 6:8a.

signed the written decree: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as signed the written decree is more literally "signed the writing and/even the decree." Both terms ("writing" and "decree") refer to the same law. Translate in a way that does not imply that there were two documents. See the notes on 6:7b and 6:8a. Here is another way to translate this:

King Darius signed the document, that is, the injunction (NASB)

Other ways to translate this include:

Darius signed the written decree (GW)

King Darius signed the law (NLT)

Daniel 6:10

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

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1. Lists: The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1-2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.
2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. Verbs of Speech: The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:10-12c

After Daniel heard that the king had signed the law, he went home and prayed to God, as he had always done. The other officials saw this and informed the king.

6:10a-b

There are two ways to understand the connection between 6:10a and 6:10b:

1. They refer to consecutive events. Daniel heard about the decree and went home, where he continued acting as he had before. For example:

When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went to his house (ESV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NIV, RSV, ESV, REB, NJB, NET, GW, GNT)

1. They refer to contrasting events. Daniel heard about the decree but he went home and continued acting as he had before. For example:

But when Daniel learned that the law had been signed, he went home and knelt down as usual... (NLT) (NRSV, CEV, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

6:10a

Now when Daniel learned that the document had been signed,

- ¶ But when Daniel heard that the king had signed the new law,

- ¶ Daniel heard the news/report about the law

Now when: In this context the common Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Now when introduces what happened next in the narrative. See the note above on 6:10a-b. Introduce what Daniel did in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel learned that the document had been signed:

The Aramaic text does not say how Daniel learned that the king had signed the law. Someone probably told Daniel the news. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. It is usually best not to explain how Daniel learned this information. Other ways to translate this include:

Daniel knew that the document had been signed (ESV)

Daniel realized that a written decree had been issued (NET)

Daniel heard about the law (CEV)

the document had been signed: See the Notes at 6:8a and 6:9, where the same Aramaic phrase is used. However in some languages it may be natural to vary the wording and use a more general expression as some English versions do. The king signed the decree in order to show that he authorized and approved it, and by so doing he issued and published it. The decree was not published in the modern sense of being printed. It was written by hand and read aloud to the population. Some other ways to translate this are:

the decree had been published (NIV)

a written decree had been issued (NET)

The BSB translates this as a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it as an active clause. For example:

the king had issued/signed the document

document: See the Notes at 6:8a.

6:10b

he went into his house,

- he went back to his house. In an upper room
- and went home. There on the flat roof there was a room

he went into his house: Daniel entered his own house. It is implied that at the time he heard the news he was somewhere else, but we do not know where.

General Comment on 6:10a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in 6:10a, b. For example:

^{10b}Daniel went home ^{10a}when he heard that the king had issued the new law.

6:10c

where the windows of his upper room opened toward Jerusalem,

- there were windows that opened towards Jerusalem.
- with windows that faced in the direction of the city of Jerusalem.

his upper room: Daniel's house had a flat roof. On one corner of his roof there was a room. It had windows and a door. There were stairs that allowed a person to walk up to the room on the roof. In some cultures, people may not be familiar with this type of house and do not build rooms above other rooms, or on roofs. Refer to such a room in a way that is clear and natural in your language. For example:

the roof-chamber (REB)

his upper chamber (ESV)

room on top of a house (TH)

opened toward Jerusalem: This phrase describes Daniel's house. It is background information. It indicates that customarily the windows were open in the direction of the holy city of Daniel's God. Jewish people normally prayed facing Jerusalem. And, it is implied, since the windows were open, Daniel's enemies would be able to see him praying.

In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence. For example:

An upper room in his house had windows that opened in the direction of Jerusalem (GW)

In an upstairs room of his house there were windows that faced toward Jerusalem (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit who opened the windows. For example:

he opened the windows that faced Jerusalem

However, it is best if you can describe the windows as already open and not mention who opened them. See also the note below on opened toward Jerusalem.

toward Jerusalem: The windows were on the side of the building that faced west. This was in the direction facing the city of Jerusalem, which was west of Babylon.

General Comment on 6:10a–c

The BSB follows the Aramaic text and leaves as implicit the information that Daniel entered this upper room:

^{10a}And when Daniel knew that the writing was signed ^{10b}he went into his house. ^{10c}And windows in his upper room were facing toward Jerusalem.

Some English versions, including the BSB, follow the Aramaic order and leave the same information implicit:

^{10a–c}When Daniel learned that the order had been signed, he went home. In an upstairs room of his house there were windows that faced toward Jerusalem. (GNT)

^{10a–c}When Daniel learned that the document had been signed, he went to his house. An upper room in his house had windows that opened in the direction of Jerusalem. (GW)

You may leave the information that Daniel entered the upper room implicit if that is clear and natural in your language. However, if you do this, make sure that it is clear in the next verse part that Daniel was praying in front of the open windows. The NIV, rather than leave it as implicit, supplies the information in 6:10b and indicates that Daniel went to his upstairs room:

^{10a}Now when Daniel learned that the decree had been published, ^{10b}he went home to his upstairs room ^{10c}where the windows opened toward Jerusalem. (NIV)

6:10d-e

and three times a day he got down on his knees, prayed, and gave thanks to his God: This describes a regular, habitual action. This happened each day for some time.

prayed, and gave thanks to his God: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as prayed, and gave thanks to his God, is more literally “and was praying and was praising.” The author used two verbs to describe what Daniel did. Daniel prayed to God and praised/thanked him. In this context, these are not two different actions but two verbs referring to the same action.

6:10d

and three times a day he got down on his knees, prayed,

- There three times each day he knelt down to pray,
- In front of those windows Daniel knelt and prayed every morning, noon, and evening.

and three times a day he got down on his knees:

This clause leaves implicit the idea that Daniel got down on his knees in front of the windows, or where he could look toward Jerusalem. Make sure that this is clear in your translation. For example:

Three times a day he knelt there

Three times a day he knelt down before those windows

Three times a day he knelt down and looked toward Jerusalem

and three times a day: Each day, Daniel knelt to pray at three different times, probably morning, noon, and night. Translate this idea in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

Three times each/every day

he got down on his knees: The Aramaic clause is literally “kneeling on his knees.” When Daniel prayed, he knelt down on his knees. This was the way he showed that he honored and respected God. In some cultures people may pray in a different position, such as prostrate on the floor. However, if Daniel had been lying on the floor, his enemies would not have been able to see him. So if kneeling is an unnatural position for prayer in your culture, you may wish to say something like:

he got ready to pray according to the Jewish custom

he positioned himself to pray

he knelt down as all the Jews did

6:10e

and gave thanks to his God,

- praising his God
- He thanked God for all his blessings/kindness,

to his God: The phrase that the BSB translates as to his God is literally “in front of his God” or “in the presence of his God.” The phrase implies meekness before someone who was in authority.

In some languages it may not be natural to use a possessive pronoun with God (his God). If that is true in your language you may be able to say:

to God (GNT)

to the God whom he worshiped

6:10f

just as he had done before.

- as was his regular custom.
- in the same way as he had done before the king passed the law.

just as he had done before: This is a comparison. Daniel acted in the same way as he had before. He had been in the custom of praying three times a day before his open window. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

just as he had always done (GNT)

as was his custom (REB)

He had always praised God this way. (GW)

The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as he had done describes a habitual action in the past. Use the verb tense that is appropriate in your language. For example:

just as he always used to do

in the same way that he always did

General Comment on 6:10

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses, giving the background information first. For example:

^{10c}Daniel had an upstairs room in his house which had windows that faced Jerusalem. ^{10d}Three times a day he would kneel down in front of those windows and pray and praise God. ^{10a}When Daniel knew that the king had signed the new law, ^{10b}he went to his house and prayed there, ^{10e}just as he had always done before.

Daniel 6:11

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

Special Problems:

1. Lists: The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1–2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.
2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. Verbs of Speech: The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7–9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:10–12c

After Daniel heard that the king had signed the law, he went home and prayed to God, as he had always done. The other officials saw this and informed the king.

6:11a

Then these men went as a group

- ¶ Then the officials went there together ,
- ¶ Then Daniel's enemies met/gathered at Daniel's house,

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next event in the narrative. After a change in the subject to Daniel, the subject is again the same as in 6:6a.

these men: This phrase refers to the satraps and administrators (6:4a, 6:6a) who were jealous of Daniel. If this is not clear, you may need to be more specific. For example:

the officials (NLT)

Daniel's enemies (GNT)

these men who had spoken to the king (CEV)

went as a group: See the Notes at 6:6a, where the same word appears. Translate it here the same way as you did there. For example:

came as a group (GW)

went together (GNT)

6:11b

and found Daniel petitioning and imploring his God.

- and they could see Daniel praying and asking God for help.
- and there was Daniel, at the window, praying to God.

and found Daniel petitioning and imploring his God:

The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as found here means “saw, observed.” It does not indicate that the men had not known where Daniel was and had to search for him. The TH says that “the idea is that they caught him in the act of praying.” For example, La Bible du Semeur has: “Then these men came abruptly into his house and surprised him as he was in the process of praying and imploring his God.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

and saw him praying to his God for help (CEV)

observed him praying to God (GNT)

petitioning and imploring his God: In this context the two verbs petitioning and imploring are close synonyms. If you have two verbs that are similar in meaning you can use them here. In some languages it may be natural to use one verb. For example:

praying to God (GNT)

praying to his God for help (CEV)

Daniel 6:12

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued

to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

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Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

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Paragraph 6:10-12c

After Daniel heard that the king had signed the law, he went home and prayed to God, as he had always done. The other officials saw this and informed the king.

6:12a

So they approached the king and asked about his royal decree:

- After that, they returned to the king to speak with him about his new law. They said/asked,
- Then the officials went back to the king and reminded him about his ban against praying to anyone else. They said,

So: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces the next event in the narrative. The officials acted in a certain way because of what they had seen. Introduce this action in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

then (NRSV)

they approached the king: The Aramaic verb that the BSB literally translates as approached implies, in this context, that the subject was approaching someone of higher status and importance. HALOT, 1972. If you have a special verb that has this meaning, you can use it here.

and asked: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as asked here introduces the act of speech in a general way. In this context, it may be natural to use a more specific verb. For example:

talked to the king (NCV)

and reminded him (NLT)

about his royal decree: The phrase his royal decree indicates the topic of the officials' conversation with the king.

his royal decree: There are two ways to understand the function of the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as royal:

1. It means "of the king" and refers to the decree that the king had made. For example:

the king's decree (KJV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, GW, NET note)

1. It is a form of address for the king and introduces the officials' speech. For example:

O king! (NRSV) (RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB)

The Aramaic text does not contain quotation marks, so it is difficult to be certain. You may wish to follow your national language version. Either option may involve some unnatural repetition. In some languages it may be natural to avoid this repetition by using a personal pronoun here. For example:

and spoke to the king about his decree (GW)

decree: See the Notes at 6:7b. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as decree refers to a law that prohibits people from doing something. The Aramaic word is ʿesar. HALOT, 1821 has "prohibition." It implies that if a person disobeyed the king, he would be punished.

General Comment on 6:12a

In some languages it may be natural to supply the reason the men went to the king. For example:

all of them went together to the king to accuse Daniel. They said... (GNT)

6:12b-e

Did you not sign a decree that for thirty days any man who petitions any god or man except you, O king, will be thrown into the den of lions?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a polite way to remind the king of the law that he had signed. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

have you not issued an edict that any person who, within the next thirty days, presents a petition to any god or human being other than your majesty is to be thrown into the lion-pit? (REB)

- As a statement. For example:

Your Majesty, you signed an order that for the next thirty days anyone who requested anything from any god or from any human being except you, would be thrown into a pit filled with lions. (GNT)

Use the form that is most natural in your language in this context.

6:12b

“Did you not sign a decree that

- “Your Majesty, is it not true that you have signed a law that
- “Your Majesty, recently you signed a ban. You said that

Did you not sign a decree...?: The clause Did you not sign a decree...? functions as a strong positive statement. See the note above on 6:12b–f. The officials reminded the king that he had in fact issued a decree. See the notes on 6:10a.

6:12c

for thirty days any man who petitions any god or man

- no one may pray to any god or human for thirty days?
- for the next thirty (30) days, if anyone prays to any god or person

that: The word that here introduces the content of the decree. See also the General Comment on 6:12c–e.

for thirty days any man who petitions any god or

man: The decree was to be valid for thirty days. See the Notes at 6:7c. Here the information is in reverse order.

Paragraph 6:11–13

The officials went to the king and accused Daniel of breaking the new law.

6:12d

except you, O king,

- Only to you may they pray, our king.
- other than you,

except you, O king: See the notes on 6:7d. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Only to you may they pray, Your Majesty.

6:12e

will be thrown into the den of lions?”

- Anyone who disobeys this law must be tossed/pushed into the den of lions.”
- your men will throw him into the pit where the lions live. They can/will eat him!.”

will be thrown into the den of lions: This is a passive clause. See the notes on 6:7e. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it as an active clause. For example:

your men will throw/push them into the lion-pit

they must die in the lions’ den

General Comment on 6:12c–e

The word “that” here introduces indirect speech, the content of the decree. In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech. See the General Comment on 6:7. For example:

did you not sign this law: ‘No one may pray to any god or man other than His Majesty and anyone who disobeys is to die in the lions’ den?’

General Comment on 6:12b–e

In some languages it will be more natural to translate this rhetorical question using two or more shorter sentences. For example:

Didn’t you sign a law that says no one may pray to any god or human except you, O king? Doesn’t it say that anyone who disobeys during the next thirty days will be thrown into the lion’s den? (NCV)

6:12f

The king replied, “According to the law of the Medes and Persians the order stands,

- ¶ The king answered, “That is true. It is a law of the Medes and Persians.
- ¶ The king replied, “Yes, that is the law.” It conforms with the law of the Medes and Persians.
- ¶ The king agreed, “Yes, the law is absolute. It is a law of the Medes and Persians.

The king replied: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as replied is literally “answering and saying.” The author used two verbs to indicate that the king was about to say something important. In some languages it may be more natural to use just one verb of speech. For example:

the king answered (NIV)

the king agreed (CEV)

According to the law of the Medes and Persians:

See the Notes at 6:8c. The king’s decree was now one of the laws of the Medes and the Persians. As such, it was consistent with and conformed to the rest of their laws. HALOT (1896): “according to, corresponding

to.” In some languages, it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

It is a law of the Medes and Persians

It conforms with the law of the Medes and Persians.GeCL97.

the order stands: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the order stands is literally “the word is true.”The HALOT (1893) has: “well established.” See the Notes at 3:24c. The king replied in a positive way. He agreed with his officials. In some languages it will be more clear to say:

That’s true. (GW)

Yes, that is the law. (NCV)

The context implies that the law was strict. In some languages it may be good to indicate this here. For example:

Yes, the law is absolute.

Yes, that is a strict order. (GNT)

the order: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as order is a general one that can mean “a spoken or written word, a matter, thing.”HALOT (1915). In this context it refers to the written law that the king had signed.

6:12g and it cannot be repealed.”

- No one can repeal it.”
- Therefore no one can cancel it.”

and it cannot be repealed: The officials reminded the king that the laws of the Persian Empire were permanent and binding. No one could choose to put an end to them, not even the king. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

No one can repeal it.

So no one can revoke it.

Therefore no one can cancel it.

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. See also the Notes at 6:8c, where the same verb is used.

General Comment on 6:12f–g

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 6:12f–g as two or more separate sentences. For example:

The king answered, “Yes, the decree is firm. It is the same as every law that the Medes and Persians issue. No one can annul it.”

Daniel 6:13

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

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Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

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4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:11-13

The officials went to the king and accused Daniel of breaking the new law.

6:13a

Then they told the king,

- ¶ The men replied,
- ¶ Then the officials told the king,

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next event in the narrative. Some English versions do not translate the connector (GW, CEV). This is acceptable, as long as the meaning is implied in the text. Introduce the next event in the way that is most natural in your language.

they told the king: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as they told the king is literally “they answered and saying before the king.” See the notes on 5:17a and 6:10d. Here are some other ways to translate this:

they responded to the king (NRSV)

They replied (GW)

6:13b

“Daniel, one of the exiles from Judah, shows no regard for you, O king,

- “Daniel, one of the exiles/captives from Judah, is not respecting/obeying you, Your Majesty.
- “Sir, the man Daniel whom your soldiers captured and brought here from Judah is ignoring you.

In the Aramaic text there is a connector introducing 6:13b. This connector is often translated as “that.” In this context there are two ways to interpret it:

1. It introduces direct speech. Therefore in English it does not need to be explicitly translated. (BSB, GW, NRSV, ESV, REB, NET, GNT, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NASB)
2. It is a demonstrative. It refers to Daniel and may imply a negative opinion of him. For example:

that Daniel (RSV) (KJV, RSV, CEV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

Daniel, one of the exiles from Judah, shows no regard for you, O king: The men brought their accusation. They said that Daniel was not listening to or obeying the king. He was not following the king’s order. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Daniel, one of the captives from Judah, is not paying attention to you, O king (NCV)

Your Majesty, Daniel, one of the captives from Judah, refuses to obey your order (GW)

Daniel, one of the exiles from Judah, does not respect Your Majesty (GNT)

one of the exiles from Judah: See the Notes at 2:25b. Here is another way to translate this:

one of the captives from Judah (GW)

exiles: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as exiles is literally “sons of the captivity.” *beney ḡaluṯā* “sons of deportation, exile.” HALOT, 1845. See also 2:25, 5:13. In some languages it may be natural to translate the idea “captivity” as an action and add implied information. For example:

one of the men whom the army captured and brought here from the country of Judah

shows no regard for you, O king: The officials complained that Daniel was ignoring the king and his authority. See the Notes at 3:12c. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with a positive verb. For example:

is ignoring you (NLT)

O king: See the Notes at 6:6b. The officials addressed the king with respect.

6:13c
or for the decree that you have signed.

- He does not obey/follow the order/law that you have signed.
- He refuses to obey the new ban/prohibition that you just approved.

or for the decree that you have signed: Daniel was failing to obey the king by failing to obey his decree. So the Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as *or* here introduces an explanation of the previous clause. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this by beginning a new sentence. For example:

He is not obeying the decree that you issued.

If you have used a positive verb in 6:13b, like the NLT, it may be necessary to use a connector meaning “and” here. For example:

is ignoring you and your law (NLT)

the decree that you have signed: For the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the decree see the Notes at 6:7b. It refers to a law that prohibits or bans something. In some languages it may be necessary or natural to use a more general word. For example:

your law (NLT)

the edict (REB)

the order you issued (GNT)

As in 6:8a, there are two ways to interpret the Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as *you have signed*. Follow the same interpretation here as you did there.

In this context, signing the decree showed that the king gave it his authority. He approved of it and would enforce it. If signing a law does not have this implication in your culture, you may wish to use a more general expression. For example

the ban that you issued

the prohibition you have approved

6:13d
He still makes his petition three times a day.”

- He prays three times each day.”
- Instead, he continues to pray to his God three times every day.”

The Aramaic text connects 6:13d and 6:13c with the common connector that the RSV translates as “but.” In this context it introduces a contrast. Daniel did not obey the law. Instead, he continued praying to his God. The BSB does not use a connector but indicates this contrast by supplying the word “still.” You should connect this verse part to the previous verse part in a way that is natural in your language.

He still makes his petition three times a day: See the Notes at 6:10d. The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as *makes his petition* is literally, “requests a request.” Use an expression that is natural for referring to daily private prayers. In some languages it may be natural to indicate to whom Daniel prayed. For example:

Daniel still prays to his God three times every day.
(NCV)

Daniel 6:14

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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Paragraph 6:14

The king wanted to save Daniel from the lions' den. However, his accusers continued to demand that the king follow the law.

6:14a

As soon as the king heard this, he was deeply distressed

- On hearing this, the king became very distressed
- When the king heard what the officials said, he was distraught.
- The king was extremely upset/disturbed when he heard the charge that the officials made.

As soon as the king heard this, he was deeply distressed: The Aramaic text is more literally "Then the king when he heard the word was greatly distressed." The king was made unhappy by what the officials told him about Daniel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The king became greatly distressed when he heard this.

On hearing this, the king was distraught.

This news disturbed the king profoundly/deeply.

Translate in a way that is most natural in your language. Give emphasis to the way the king reacted.

he was deeply distressed: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as he was deeply distressed is literally "it was very evil to him." This is a broad statement that can include a number of different ideas and emotions. Here are some other ways to translate it:

he was upset (GNT)

the king was very disturbed

was very displeased (GW)

General Comment on 6:14a

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this verse part. For example:

The king was very displeased when he heard this (GW)

The king became very upset when he heard this (NCV)

6:14b

and set his mind on delivering Daniel,

- He thought hard about how he could rescue Daniel,
- He tried to think of a way to save Daniel from the lions,
- He began to think how he could spare Daniel's life.

set his mind on delivering Daniel: The Aramaic phrase set his mind is an idiom, a figure of speech. It indicates that the king gave his full attention to this matter. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He tried every way he could think of to save Daniel. (GW)

He tried to find a way to protect Daniel

He concentrated on looking for a way to save Daniel

Translate this idea in a way that is most natural in your language.

on delivering Daniel: The same verb that the BSB translates as delivering occurs in 3:15c, 17a, 28b. In this context, it means that the king tried to find a way to avoid punishing Daniel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

to save Daniel (NRSV)

to spare Daniel's life

to protect/keep Daniel from being punished

Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

6:14c

and he labored until sundown to rescue him.

- and he did all he could to spare Daniel, until finally night came.
- and the rest of the day he did everything he could to rescue him.
- All day long he kept trying to find a way.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in the narrative sequence.

he labored: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as labored means “worked/tried hard.” HALOT, 1991. Other ways to say this in English are:

He kept trying (GNT)

he struggled to find a way

he gave his full concentration

until sundown: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as until sundown is literally “going in of the sun.” See me’al “sunset.” HALOT, 1921. The noun derives from ʾl. This is a figure of speech. It refers to the time in the evening when the sun goes below the horizon. The clause means “until it became dark.” Other ways to say this in English are:

the rest of the day (NLT)

the whole day

until evening/night

until sunset

to rescue him: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as rescue is a synonym to the verb “delivering” above, in 6:14b. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- If you have a synonym to “deliver” you may use it here. For example:

to save him (NIV)

to keep him from punishment

- In some languages this idea is implied from the previous clause and you do not need to repeat it again. If that is true in your language, you may not need to translate this phrase. For example:

did his best to find some way to rescue Daniel. He kept trying until sunset. (GNT)

he tried to think of a way to save Daniel, and continued his efforts until sunset (REB)

Translate in the way that is most natural in your language.

General Comment on 6:14

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses and combine information that is repeated. For example:

^{14a}The king was really upset to hear about this, ^{14b-}
^cand for the rest of the day he tried to think how he could save Daniel.

^{14a}The king was very displeased when he heard what the officials said. ^{14b-}^cAll that day he did everything he could to rescue Daniel.

Daniel 6:15

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

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Special Problems:

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2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. Verbs of Speech: The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7–9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:15

A new scene begins in 6:15. At the end of the day the officers returned and spoke to the king.

6:15a

Then the men approached the king together and said to him,

- ¶ Then the officials returned together. They said to King Darius,
- ¶ At sunset, Daniel's enemies hurried back as a group to the king. They told him,
- ¶ That evening, all who had accused Daniel came back to the king. They

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces a new event in the narrative. Some versions use a connector that shows contrast. For example, the NJB has: "but." Similarly the FrCL88. This new event took place after the king had been trying all day to spare Daniel from punishment.

The context makes it clear that the day was over and the sun had set. So it may be natural to say:

In the evening (NLT)

At sunset (CEV)

the men: This phrase refers to the officials who conspired against Daniel (6:4, 6, 11, 13). In order to make this clear, it may be natural to say:

Daniel's accusers (GW)

Daniel's conspirators (NRSV)

Daniel's enemies (GNT)

approached the king together: See the Notes at 6:6a, 6:11a. The officials came as a group to the king. In some languages it may not be necessary to repeat this idea. For example:

came back to the king (GNT)

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in the narrative sequence.

said to him: The Aramaic text literally says, "said to the king." However in English it is more natural to use a pronoun here. Indicate that the officials spoke to the king in a way that is natural in your language.

6:15b

"Remember, O king, that

- "Your Majesty, you surely know that
- "Sir, you must remember that
- reminded him that

Remember, O king: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as Remember is literally "know," in the form of a command. However the officials were not being disrespectful. The officials were reminding the king of something. They knew that the king already knew about the law. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a statement. For example:

Your Majesty knows (GNT)

Our ^(excl) king, you know well

We^(excl) wish to remind you, Your Majesty

Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

O king: See the Notes at 6:7d.

6:15c

by the law of the Medes and Persians no decree or ordinance established by the king can be changed."

- according to the law of the Medes and Persians no one can change a ban or law that the king has issued."
- the law of the Medes and Persians prohibits anyone from changing any law that you have signed."
- the law of the Medes and Persians did not permit anyone to change any royal decree or edict.

by the law of the Medes and Persians: See the Notes on the phrase the law of the Medes and Persians at 6:8c. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The law of the Medes and Persians says (NCV)

The law of the Medes and the Persians requires that

the law of the Medes and Persians is that

no decree or ordinance established by the king can be changed: See the Notes at 6:7b. The two Aramaic words that the BSB translates as decree and ordinance are close synonyms in this context. In some languages it may be more natural to use one word. For example:

no order which the king issues (GNT)

can be changed: See the Notes at 6:8b. This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

no one can change

General Comment on 6:15c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the information in 6:15c. For example:

the law of the Medes and Persians forbids anyone from changing any statute or ban that the king has signed

Daniel 6:16

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

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Paragraph 6:16

In this verse, the king did what the law prescribed. He commanded his men to throw Daniel into the pit of lions.

6:16a

So the king gave the order,

- ¶ So then the king commanded his men to go and arrest Daniel.
- ¶ So the king reluctantly commanded his men to execute Daniel.

So the king gave the order: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *So* introduces the next event in the narrative. He gave a command that was in accordance with the law. Introduce his command in a way that is natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

then (NRSV)

the king gave the order: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as *gave the order* is literally “said.” The king unwillingly gave the command to carry out the law and throw Daniel to the lions. Here is another way to translate this:

the king commanded (RSV)

In some languages it may be natural to supply information about what the king commanded. For example:

the king ordered his men to carry out the law

the king commanded that his servants bring Daniel

Translate the meaning in a way that is natural in your language.

6:16b

and they brought Daniel and threw him into the den of lions.

- They brought Daniel and tossed/pushed him into the den of lions.
- They brought Daniel out to throw him into the pit where the lions lived.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and is a general one that can be translated in various ways. In this context scholars have interpreted it in different ways:

1. It introduces the next event in the narrative. The king gave the order and his men carried it out. In some languages you may be able to use a different connector. For example:

so

Then (ESV) (BSB, NIV, RSV/NRSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET, GW, NCV)

1. It introduces what the king commanded. Following this view, the text does not explicitly say that the king's men obeyed his order. For example:

gave orders for Daniel to be taken and thrown into the pit (GNT) (NJB, REB, GNT, NLT, CEV)

The meaning is the same. Either interpretation is acceptable. It is important that your readers understand both that the king gave the order and that the order was carried out. Translate in a way that makes this clear. For example:

So King Darius gave the order, and Daniel was brought in and thrown into the lions' den. (NCV)

So at last Darius ordered Daniel to be brought out and thrown into a pit of lions. (NLT)

So at the king's command Daniel was brought and thrown into the lions' pit.

they brought Daniel and threw him into the den of lions: The third person subject is indefinite. Translate this in a way that is most natural in your language. For example:

- Using passive verbs. For example:

and Daniel was brought and thrown into the den of lions (NRSV)

- supplying a subject. For example:

and the soldiers led Daniel out and threw him into the lion pit

they brought Daniel: The text does not say where the men brought Daniel. Probably the meaning is that he was brought from his home and to the king and the place where the lions were kept. In some languages it may be necessary to supply some of this information. For example:

Daniel was brought out (CEV)

Daniel was brought to him (GW)

and threw him: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in the narrative. Having brought him, the king's men threw Daniel into the den of lions.

threw him into the den of lions: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as threw here indicates that the men pushed Daniel from above so that he fell into the den. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. The same verb occurs in 3:6, 11, 15, 20.

den of lions: See the Notes at 6:7e. This was a large pit where the king kept wild lions.

the lion-pit (NRSV)

the pit where they kept the lions

the hole where the lions wereTranslator's Handbook on Daniel.

6:16c

The king said to Daniel,

- The king said to Daniel/him,
- As they were doing this, the king exclaimed,

The king said to Daniel: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates said is literally "answering and saying." This phrase indicates that the king was about to say something important. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the king told Daniel (GW)

The king probably spoke to Daniel before the men threw Daniel into the lions' pit. If this is not clear, you may add this implied information. For example:

the king had told Daniel

6:16d

“May your God, whom you serve continually, deliver you!”

- “May your God save you! You have served him so faithfully.”
- “You have always been faithful to the God you worship. Now I pray/hope that he will rescue you!”

May your God, whom you serve continually, deliver you!: There are at least two ways to interpret the Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as May your God...deliver you!:

1. It expresses the king's wish or prayer that God would save Daniel. Lucas (p. 144) interprets this as a wish. For example:

May your God, whom you always worship, save you! (GW) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, RSV, NIV, GW, NLT, REB, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. The king tried to encourage Daniel by stating that his God was the one who could and would save him. Rosenthal (A Grammar of Biblical Aramaic, Sixth Rev. ed. 175) notes that the suffix form of the verb is imperfect rather than a jussive. Some commentators therefore interpret this as a statement of confidence in the God of Daniel. However, it could also be a word of comfort. See the NET: “The king consoled Daniel.” For example:

Your God, whom you continually serve, will rescue you. (NET) (NET, KJV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The king hoped and prayed that God would save Daniel. Other ways to translate this include:

May your God, whom you faithfully serve, deliver you!

I hope that your God, whom you worship, will deliver you.

I pray that the God you worship will rescue you.

your God, whom you serve continually: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as serve here means “worship.” See the Notes at 3:12d.

In some languages it may not be natural to translate the possessive pronoun in the phrase your God. If that is true in your language, you may say, following the NCV:

the God you serve all the time (NCV)

continually: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as continually is only used here and in 6:20. HALOT, 2004. In this context, it implies that Daniel was faithful in worshiping God. He did not ever worship other gods. He worshiped God alone. That is, he worshiped God exclusively. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

faithfully (NRSV)

so loyally (GNT)

deliver you: The king prayed and hoped that God would protect Daniel and save him from being killed by the lions. The same Aramaic verb is used in 6:14b. However, you may need to translate it differently here. Daniel was already being punished, but the king hoped he would not die. This verb also occurs with this meaning in 3:15f, 6:28. Other ways to translate this include:

rescue you (NIV)

save you (NCV)

Daniel 6:17

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The

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wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

6:17a

A stone was brought and placed over the mouth of the den,

- ¶ They brought a big rock and put it over the opening of the den.
- ¶ The king's men pushed a big rock on top of the entrance to the lions' pit.

In the Aramaic text this verse part connects to the previous verse part with the common conjunction that the RSV here translates as “and.” In this context it introduces the next event in the narrative. The BSB does not translate it explicitly. You should introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then

A stone was brought and placed over the mouth of the den:

A stone was placed over the opening to the lion pit so that Daniel could not try to escape. This verse part contains two passive verbs, was brought and was placed. In some languages it may be more natural to use one or more active verbs. If that is true in your language, you may translate:

They (indefinite) brought a big stone and put it on the opening of the hole

The king's men pushed a large rock over the opening of the hole.

A stone was brought and placed: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as stone refers to a very large rock. It probably took several men to position this rock over the hole. Use a word that is natural in your language for moving a very large rock like this. For example:

a large rock was pushed

over the mouth of the den: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mouth here means “entrance, opening.”

den: See the Notes at 6:7e.

6:17b

and the king sealed it with his own signet ring and with the rings of his nobles,

- Then the king sealed the rock and stamped the seal with his royal ring and with the rings that belonged to his nobles/officials
- The king then put a seal on the rock and marked the seal with his royal sign and also with the signs of his important/leading men.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *and* here introduces the next event in the narrative. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

the king sealed it with his own signet ring and with the rings of his nobles: At that time, government officials used to mark official documents with their personal seals to show that the document was authentic. Here the king and his officials put their seals on the rock to warn people not to move the stone and not to try to rescue Daniel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The king put his seal on the stone, using his ring and the rings of his nobles

The king sealed the stone with his own royal seal and the seals of his nobles

In some languages, people may not use rings or seals like this. If that is true in your language you have to use a more general expression. For example:

The king and his nobles sealed the stone and stamped their marks on the seal.

sealed it with his own signet ring: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as *signet ring* here refers to a mark that the king put on the closed door of the den. The king had a ring or cylinder with a small design or initials that he used to mark documents as official. Someone probably stretched a piece of cord or cloth across the rock and fastened it to the rock with wet clay. The king then used his signet ring to mark the clay. Or it could have been a special cylinder. If anyone tried to move the rock, they would break the cord and ruin the mark. This way the king and his officials would know if someone tried to open the hole during the night. English versions translate this in different ways:

placed his own royal seal...on the stone (GNT)

stamped the seal (CEV)

used his signet ring...to put special seals on the rock

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. You may want to put an explanation in a footnote.

and the rings of his nobles: The Aramaic text has the singular form here: “the ring of his nobles.” Each noble probably had one seal or ring each. Therefore, either the singular or plural may be appropriate. Use the form that is most natural in your language.

In some languages it may be natural to avoid the repetition of the word “ring/rings” by using a pronoun here. For example:

The king sealed it with his signet ring and with those of his nobles. (NET)

nobles: These nobles were men with important positions in the king’s court. See the Notes at 4:36d; 5:1a. Other ways to translate this are:

noblemen (GNT)

royal officers (NCV)

6:17c

so that nothing concerning Daniel could be changed.

- in order that no one might change Daniel’s condition/status.
- so that no one would try to move the stone.
- He did this so they would know if someone tried to rescue Daniel.

so that: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as *so that* introduces a purpose clause. The purpose of sealing the opening was to show that the situation must not change. The king and his nobles were indicating that the opening must remain closed and sealed. No one should open the door, and Daniel was to remain in the lions’ den. The Translator’s Handbook on Daniel notes that the seal could have had a dual purpose. Not only would it have discouraged people from rescuing Daniel, it would also have prevented Daniel’s enemies from coming in secret to make sure he was dead.

nothing concerning Daniel could be changed: The Aramaic clause is literally, “that it not be changed the thing for Daniel.” Goldingay (p. 121) translates *ṣeḇu* as “purpose” instead of “thing, matter.” See also the

KJV. This is a passive clause. Here is another way to translate this:

so that Daniel's situation could not be changed
(GW)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

so that no one could change Daniel's situation

In some languages it may be necessary to include implied information. For example:

so that no one could interfere with Daniel's punishment

so that no one could rescue Daniel (GNT)

to show that no one should let Daniel out (CEV)

Daniel 6:18

Section 6:1-28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

6:18a

Then the king went to his palace

- Then the king returned to his royal house.
- After that, the king went back to his great home.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates Then here introduces the next event in the narrative. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

the king went to his palace: Refer to King Darius in the way that is most natural in your language. Some versions use a pronoun. For example:

He returned to his palace (NLT)

palace: See also the Notes at 4:4b, 4:29; 5:5c. This was the special house where the king lived. It was probably very luxurious. If you have a word for this type of house, you can use it here. Other ways to say this in English are:

the king's big house

the king's beautiful rich house

his official residence.

6:18b

and spent the night fasting.

- All night long he did not eat any food.
- He refused to eat any food the rest of the night.

spent the night fasting: This king usually ate when he came home in the evening. However, that night the king was worried about Daniel and he refused to eat anything. Here is another way to translate this:

without food (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

He did not eat that night (NCV)

All night long he did not eat anything (CEV)

That night he refused to eat anything.

6:18c

No entertainment was brought before him,

- He also refused to have anyone entertain him,
- He did not allow anyone to bring him any amusements,

No entertainment was brought before him: This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. The Aramaic form of the verb indicates that the king himself refused entertainment. Here are some ways to translate this using an active verb:

the king refused his usual entertainment (NLT)

he would not let anyone come in to entertain him (CEV)

entertainment: The meaning of the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as entertainment is uncertain. English versions translate it in different ways. For example:

1. it refers to any kind of entertainment. For example:

diversions (RSV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, ESV, NET, GNT, NLT, NCV)

1. it refers to food or drink. For example:

foodTheodotion, Vulgate, and Syriac. (NRSV) (NRSV)

1. it refers to other people, entertainers or female companions. For example:

concubines (NJB) (REB, NJB, GW, CEV)

1. it refers to music. For example:

instruments of music (KJV) (KJV)

It is likely that the king's entertainment normally included women who made music and danced for him. However it is not certain that this is what the author was referring to here. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is more general than the other options. See the footnote in the NET. Try to use an expression that refers to entertainment in general, including that provided by drinking companions, women, and musicians. For example:

He spent the night alone.

6:18d

and sleep fled from him.

- and he was not able to sleep.
- and he did not get any sleep.

and sleep fled from him: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces another thing the king did not do that night. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

that night the king did not eat, receive entertainment, or sleep

sleep fled from him: The Aramaic clause that the BSB literally translates as sleep fled from him is a figure of speech. The author described sleep as if it were a

person who ran away. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. You may have a different idiom that expresses the same idea.

General Comment on 6:18

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 6:18a–d. For example:

^{18a}Then the king returned to the palace ^{18d}and spent a sleepless night, ^{18b}without food ^{18c}or any form of entertainment. (GNT)

Daniel 6:19

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

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Paragraph 6:19–20

6:19–20 tells what happened the next morning. The king went to the lions' den to find out if Daniel was still alive.

6:19

At the first light of dawn, the king got up and hurried to the den of lions.

- ¶ The next morning, as soon as it was light enough, the king quickly got up and went to the den of lions.
- ¶ At dawn, the king rushed to the pit where the lions lived.

The Aramaic text introduces this next event with the common connector that the RSV translates as “then.” Introduce this next event and new time indication in a way that is natural in your language.

At the first light of dawn: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as At the first light of dawn is more literally “at dawn...at brightness.” It refers to the time in the morning when it first becomes light. Here are some other ways to translate this:

at dawn, as soon as it was light (GW)

at break of day (NRSV)

Very early the next morning (NLT)

the king got up and hurried to the den of lions: This sentence uses two verbs (got up, hurried) to emphasize the quick action. The king was anxious to know what had happened to Daniel.

the king got up and quickly went to the hole where he kept the lions.

In some languages it may be more natural to use one verb, leaving the idea got up implied. For example:

the king hurried out to the lions' den (NLT)

the king rushed to the lion pit

got up: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as got up here refers to the act of rising from bed in the morning.

and hurried: The king moved quickly, walking to the lions den as soon as he could. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and quickly went (GW)

and hurried out (NLT)

Daniel 6:20

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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Paragraph 6:19–20

6:19–20 tells what happened the next morning. The king went to the lions' den to find out if Daniel was still alive.

6:20a

When he reached the den, he cried out in a voice of anguish,

- When he approached the hole where Daniel was, he called out anxiously,
- As he approached the hole, he yelled in anguish to Daniel,

When he reached the den, he cried out in a voice of anguish:

The Aramaic is more literally “as he came near to the den to Daniel in a pained voice he called out replying the king and saying to Daniel.” It is hard to know if the Aramaic word meaning “to Daniel” belongs with the verb “came near” or the verb “called out.” Compare the KJV and the RSV here. And in many languages it may not be natural to repeat Daniel’s name. The BSB has left the name “Daniel” untranslated. You should indicate that the king went to the lions’ den to speak to Daniel in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

When he got there, he called out anxiously (GNT)

When he reached the den: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as When he reached the den is more literally “and as he approached the den.” This clause repeats the mention of the den from the previous verse. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat this information again. If that is true in your language, you may say:

When he got there (GNT)

As he approached (NET)

he cried out in a voice of anguish: The Aramaic verbs of speech that the BSB translates as cried out are literally, “called out.... and the king answering and saying.” In some languages it may be more natural to use one verb of speech, as the BSB has done. For example:

he cried out anxiously to Daniel

he called out in anguish (NLT)

cried out: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as cried out means “yelled, shrieked.” Here is another way to translate this:

shouted (CEV)

in a voice of anguish: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as a voice of anguish is literally “a sound of pain/sadness.” The king sounded worried and distressed. In some languages it may be natural to describe the king himself, or the king’s action, rather than his voice. For example:

anxiously (NRSV)

in anguish (NLT)

6:20b

“O Daniel, servant of the living God, has your God, whom you serve continually, been able to deliver you from the lions?”

- “Daniel, you servant of the living God! Has the God you always worship been able to save you from the lions?”
- “Daniel! You who faithfully serve the God who lives! Has that God rescued you from the lions?”

O Daniel, servant of the living God: The king addressed Daniel as the servant of the true God. In this context, the word servant refers to someone who served God by worshiping and obeying him. In some languages it may be natural to translate this noun using a verb. For example:

Daniel, you serve/worship the living God

the living God: The phrase the living God describes God as truly existing and alive. By implication he is powerful to act and able to act to help his servants. This phrase is also used in Matthew 26:63, John 6:69, Deuteronomy 5:26, Joshua 3:10, and 1 Samuel 17:26. See how you translated it there. In some languages, it may be redundant to describe God as living. If that is true in your language, you may have another way to express this idea. For example:

the true God

the God who lives forever

has your God, whom you serve continually, been able to deliver you from the lions?: This is a real question. The king was desperate. He asked Daniel if he was still alive. See how you translated 6:16d. Other ways you can translate this are:

Has your God that you always worship been able to save you from the lions? (NCV)

Was your God, whom you serve so faithfully, able to rescue you from the lions? (NLT)

your God, whom you serve: In some languages it may not be natural to use the possessive pronoun your with God. If that is true in your language, you may be able to leave this implicit, as it is implied by the following phrase whom you serve. For example, you may simply say:

the God you serve/worship

continually: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as continually is only used here and in 6:16d. HALOT, 2004. In this context, it implies that Daniel was faithful in worshipping God. Here are some other ways to translate this:

faithfully (NRSV)

so loyally (GNT)

General Comment on 6:20

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's question as two or more sentences. For example:

Daniel, you were faithful and served your God.
Was he able to rescue you from the lions? (CEV)

Daniel 6:21

Section 6:1-28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

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Paragraph 6:21–22

Daniel answered the king, assuring him that God had kept him safe.

6:21**Then Daniel replied, “O king, may you live forever!”**

- Then Daniel answered the king, “Your Majesty, may you live/reign forever.
- Then Daniel replied, “Long live the king!”

Then: The connector that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the narrative, Daniel’s reply to the king’s question. Introduce Daniel’s answer to the king in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel replied: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Daniel replied is more literally “Daniel spoke with the king.” Introduce what Daniel said to the king in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Daniel answered (NIV)

Daniel responded to him

O king, may you live forever!: This was a common way to greet the king. See the Notes at 6:6b. Other ways English versions translate this are:

Your Majesty, may you live forever! (GW)

Your Majesty, I hope you live forever! (CEV)

Long live the king! (NLT)

Use a greeting that is respectful and natural in your language.

Daniel 6:22**Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den**

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The

lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:21–22

Daniel answered the king, assuring him that God had kept him safe.

6:22a

My God sent His angel and shut the mouths of the lions.

- The God whom I worship sent an angel to/who shut the lions' mouths.
- God sent an angel to protect me, and he closed the lions' jaws

My God sent His angel and shut the mouths of the lions: Scholars have interpreted this verse in two different ways:

1. It indicates that God sent his angel and the angel shut the lions' mouths. For example:

My God sent his angel to shut the lions' mouths (NLT) (NLT, REB, NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV, NJB)

1. It indicates that God himself both sent the angel and shut the lions' mouths. For example:

My God sent his angel and shut the lions' mouths (NRSV) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET, GW)

God acted to protect Daniel through the angel he sent. The angel did God's will and fulfilled his intention. So either way of translating this is acceptable. You may wish to follow the major language version in your area.

My God: In some languages it may not be natural or correct to use the possessive pronoun My with the word God. If that is true in your language, you may simply say:

God (GNT)

The God I worship

His angel: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates His angel refers to a supernatural being who served God. The same word occurs in 3:28b. See "angel" in KBT.

shut the mouths of the lions: This is a figure of speech. The phrase means, "prevented the lions from eating Daniel." Many versions keep the same figure of speech. For example:

to close the lions' mouths (NCV)

who sealed the lions' jaws (NJB)

and closed the lions' jawsGeCL97.

Translate in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

he sent an angel to keep the lions from eating me (CEV)

6:22b

They have not hurt me,

- The lions did not hurt me
- so that they did not harm me.

They have not hurt me: The Aramaic text begins this verse part with a connector that introduces a result clause. Because God sent his angel to shut the lions' mouths, Daniel was not hurt. The BSB leaves this idea implied, but in some languages it may be natural to say explicitly:

so that they have not harmed me (NET)

and so they have not injured me

6:22c

for I was found innocent in His sight,

- because God judged me innocent.
- God did this because he knew I was not guilty.

for: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as for here introduces the reason why God rescued Daniel. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He did this because (GNT)

I was found innocent in His sight: The Aramaic phrase is literally, "before him innocence was found to me." This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

he considered me innocent (GW)

he judged me innocent (REB)

he knew that I was not guilty

innocent: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as innocent here indicates that God saw that Daniel had not done wrong or evil. Other ways to translate this include:

blameless (RSV)

not guilty

in His sight: The word that the BSB translates as in His sight means, “in front of” or “in the presence of.” HALOT, 1967. See 6:10e, where the same word is included in the phrase that the BSB translates as “to his God.” The phrase implies that Daniel was living in view of someone (God) who was more important than he. Daniel knew that God was always watching him.

Some English versions omit this phrase because the meaning is implied by the context. Translate in a way that is natural in your language.

6:22d

and I have done no wrong against you, O king.”

- Also, I have never wronged you, my king.”
- Moreover, I have never committed any crime against you, sir.”

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here joins 6:22c with 6:22d. English versions interpret it differently.

1. The connector introduces an additional comment. For example:

and moreover (REB)

and also (NRSV) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, NIV, REB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET, NJB)

1. The connector gives a second reason why God shut the lions’ mouths. For example:

and because (GNT) (GNT)

Interpretation (1) is recommended. In some languages, this idea is implied by the context. For example, some English versions do not explicitly translate the connector (CEV, NCV, GW). Here is another way to translate this:

And (NLT)

I have done no wrong against you: See the Notes at 6:22d. The phrase against you implies that the king had higher status and was more important than Daniel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Nor have I done any harm to you (NET)

I have not wronged you (NLT)

I have never done anything to hurt you (CEV)

wrong: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wrong refers to any sort of hurt or damage, whether physical, financial, emotional, or material. Here are some other ways to translate this:

injury (REB)

harm (NET)

O king: See how you translated this at 6:6b.

Daniel 6:23

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel’s enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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Paragraph 6:23–24

The king ordered his men to take Daniel out of the lions' pit. The officials who were his enemies died in his place.

6:23a

The king was overjoyed

- ¶ The king was very happy to hear this.
- ¶ The king was very glad that Daniel was safe,

The Aramaic text connects 6:23a to the previous verse part with the common connector that the RSV translates as “then.” This connector here introduces the next event in the narrative. The BSB does not use a

connector here. You should introduce what happened next in a way that is natural in your language.

The king was overjoyed: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as The king was overjoyed is literally, “the king it was very much good to him.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

King Darius was very happy (NCV)

The king was very glad (NJPS)

Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

6:23b

and gave orders to lift Daniel out of the den,

- He commanded that Daniel be lifted/raised from the den,
- and he commanded his men/soldiers to pull Daniel up from the lion pit.

and: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces the next event in the narrative.

gave orders to lift Daniel out of the den: The Aramaic text is more literally “he said to take up Daniel from the den.” In some languages it may be necessary to indicate to whom the king spoke or gave these orders. For example:

and told his servants to lift Daniel out of the lions' den (NCV)

he commanded his men to pull Daniel up from the pit

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a passive clause. The Aramaic text has an infinitive clause: “and Daniel he said to lift up from the pit.” For example,

and commanded that Daniel be taken up out of the den (NRSV)

and gave orders for Daniel to be pulled up out of the pit (GNT)

and ordered that Daniel be lifted from the den (NLT)

lift: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as lift in this context probably means that they were to pull Daniel up from the den by a rope.

General Comment on 6:23b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the king's order as direct speech. For example:

he ordered, "Get Daniel up out of that pit."

"Pull Daniel out of the lions' den," the king directed.

6:23c

and when Daniel was lifted out of the den,

- and so they pulled Daniel up/out.
- The king's men/soldiers did so

and when Daniel was lifted out of the den: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as and here introduces what happened as a result of the king's command. The BSB has supplied the word when. Introduce what happened in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So Daniel was taken up out of the den (NRSV)

So they pulled him up (GNT)

Daniel was lifted out of the den: This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active clause. For example:

they pulled him up (GNT)

the king's men lifted Daniel out of the pit

In some languages it may be natural to leave this implied. It is clear from the context that the king's men obeyed the command. The CEV leaves the whole clause implied. Here is another way to translate this:

When this was done (REB)

6:23d

no wounds whatsoever were found on him,

- Everyone could see that Daniel was not hurt at all,
- and discovered that Daniel was totally uninjured/unharmd.

no wounds whatsoever were found on him: This verse part tells what happened when Daniel was once more in the presence of the king and his men. Everyone could see that Daniel was unharmed. In your translation, be sure that it is clear that no wounds whatsoever were found because there was no wound. Daniel was unharmed. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an active clause. For example:

People saw that he was completely unharmed (GW)

they saw that the lions had not hurt him at all

He had no injuries at all

wounds: The Aramaic noun that the BSB translates as wounds is related to the word translated as "wrong" in 6:22d. Here, however, it refers to physical harm or damage. The lions had not bitten or mauled Daniel.

6:23e

because he had trusted in his God.

- for he had put his trust/confidence in his God.
- God had kept him safe, because he had trusted God.

because he had trusted in his God: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as because here introduces a reason clause. *diy*. "because." HALOT, 1853. It introduces the reason why Daniel was not hurt by the lions.

he had trusted in his God: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as trusted is a key biblical term. The verb is *ṣmn* in the hafal "to trust in." HALOT, 1816. Daniel was steadfast and firm in his confidence in God. See "faith, trust" in KBT. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

he trusted his God (GW)

he had confidence in his God La Bible du Semeur; BFrCL88;

he had faith in his God La Nouvelle Version Second

his God: See the Notes at 6:22a.

General Comment on 6:23d–e

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these verse parts, placing the reason/cause

before the result. Here are some other ways to translate this:

^{23e}Daniel trusted in his God and ^{23d}so he received no injury from the lions.

^{23e}Daniel's faith in his God had kept him ^{23d}from being harmed. (CEV)

^{23e}Because Daniel had faith in God, ^{23d}the lions were unable to hurt him.

Daniel 6:24

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

Special Problems:

1. **Lists:** The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1–2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.
2. **Repetition:** The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. **Verbs of Speech:** The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. **Synonyms:** The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7–9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:23–24

The king ordered his men to take Daniel out of the lions' pit. The officials who were his enemies died in his place.

6:24a

At the command of the king,

- The king gave an order to his men ,
- Then the king commanded his soldiers

At the command of the king: The Aramaic verb phrase that the BSB translates as At the command of the king is literally “and the king said.” In this context, it refers to an order or command. Here is another way to translate this:

The king gave a command (NRSV)

6:24b–c

the men who had falsely accused Daniel were brought and thrown into the den of lions: The men did as the king had commanded. They arrested the officials and thrust them into the lions' den. See how you translated this idea in 6:16b.

6:24b**the men who had falsely accused Daniel were brought**

- and they brought the officials who had wrongly/unfairly accused/charged Daniel
- to arrest the officials who had made the complaint about Daniel. They brought them,

the men who had falsely accused Daniel: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as who had falsely accused Daniel is literally “who ate the pieces of Daniel.” See the Notes at 3:8. This is a figure of speech. It means “who had accused/denounced Daniel.” This phrase refers to the officials and administrators who told the king that Daniel was breaking the law by praying to God. See 6:13. Note that their accusation was not literally “false.” Daniel had in fact been praying to his God. The accusation, however, was made out of envy and concerned an unjust law. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

the men who had maliciously accused Daniel
(NET)

those who had denounced Daniel

the men who had brought charges against Daniel
(CEV)

were brought: See the Notes at 3:13c; 5:13c. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as a passive verb, were brought, is literally active, “they brought,” The subject “they” is indefinite. The king’s men, the king’s soldiers, went to the homes of these officials, and forced them to go to the lions’ den. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

were brought in (NIV)

were arrested

- Using an active verb. For example:

the king’s men brought them

the guards/soldiers arrested them

The king then sent for the men who had accused Daniel (NJB)

Translate the verb in a way that is natural in your language.

6:24c**and thrown into the den of lions—they and their children and wives.**

- and threw them into the den of lions. They threw their wives and children into the den too!
- their wives and their children, and threw them all into the pit where the lions lived.

and thrown into the den of lions: See the Notes at 3:6; 6:7e. The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as a passive, thrown, is literally active, “they threw.” The king’s men lifted the officials up and dropped or pushed them into the den in a violent way. You may translate this

- Using a passive verb. For example:

were...cast into the den of lions (ESV)

were...flung into the lion-pit (REB)

- Using an active verb. For example:

they (indefinite) pushed them into the lions’ den

the king’s men shoved them into the pit where the lions lived

Translate this idea in a way that is most natural in your language.

they and their children and wives: This phrase emphasizes the severity of the punishment. Not only did the king punish the officials, he also punished their wives and children. He threw them all into the den where the lions lived.

General Comment on 6:24b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the information, mentioning the families with the first verb (“brought”). For example:

The soldiers brought them, their wives and their children, and threw them all into the lions’ den.

General Comment on 6:24a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to make the command explicit. For example:

Then the king gave orders to arrest all those who had accused Daniel, and he had them thrown, together with their wives and children, into the pit filled with lions. (GNT)

Then the king commanded that the men who had accused Daniel be brought to the lions' den. They, their wives, and their children were thrown into the den. (NCV)

6:24d

And before they had reached the bottom of the den,

- Before they got to the bottom/ground,
- Before they landed at the bottom of the pit,

And: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as And here introduces the next event in the narrative. Translate this connector in a way that is natural in your language.

before they had reached the bottom of the den: The Aramaic clause is literally, "they did not come to the bottom of the den until..." The connector is 'ad di- This is an emphatic way of saying that the lions immediately attacked the officials. Emphasize this idea in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Before they even reached the bottom of the pit (NJB)

They had hardly reached the bottom of the den when... (NJPS)

had reached: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as had reached here means "got as far as, touched." Other ways to translate this include:

hit (NLT)

landed

the bottom of the den: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as bottom can refer to the ground or simply the lowest part of the hole. Some scholars describe the den as an inclined slope that led to a pit. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

6:24e

the lions overpowered them and crushed all their bones.

- the lions attacked and killed them, crunching them up, bones and all.
- the lions leaped on them and chewed them up.

the lions overpowered them: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as overpowered here indicates that the lions successfully attacked the officials and their families. Other ways to say this in English are:

the lions leaped on them (NLT)

the lions pounced on them (GNT)

the lions had seized them (NJB)

and crushed all their bones: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as crushed all their bones is an emphatic way of stating that the lions tore these people to pieces. See how you translated the same verb in 2:34c, 2:40b, 2:44d, where the same verb is used of the stone shattering the image. The text implies that the lions were very hungry. They not only ate the people but chewed up their bones as well. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and tore them apart (NLT)

ripped them to pieces (CEV)

crunched them up, bones and all New English Bible.

Translate this in a way that is most natural in your own language.

General Comment on 6:24d-e

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses. For example:

^{24e}The lions leaped on them and tore them apart
^{24d}before they even hit the floor of the den. (NLT)

Daniel 6:25

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he

ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

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Special Problems:

1. Lists: The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1-2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.
2. Repetition: The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
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4. Synonyms: The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7-9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue,

delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:25-27

Daniel 6:25 begins a new scene. This paragraph tells of King Darius' reaction to Daniel's rescue. He wrote a letter to the people in his kingdom, honoring Daniel's God.

6:25a

Then King Darius wrote to the people of every nation and language throughout the land:

- ¶ Then King Darius wrote a letter to all peoples, nations, and everyone who spoke every language in the world.
- ¶ Darius the king then sent a message to the people of all tribes, nations, and languages on the earth.

Then: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next event in the narrative. These events occurred some time later. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Afterwards

Later

King Darius wrote to the people of every nation and language throughout the land: The Aramaic text is more literally: "King Darius wrote to all the peoples, the nations, and the languages which were living in all the earth." It refers to all the inhabitants of the Persian Empire. Here are some other ways to translate this:

King Darius wrote to all the peoples, the nations, and the languages which were living in all the earth." It refers to all the inhabitants of the Persian Empire. Here are some other ways to translate this:

King Darius wrote to the people of every race and nation and language throughout the world.

King Darius wrote a letter to all people and all nations, to those who spoke every language in the world. (NCV)

wrote: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wrote is a general word. In some languages it may be necessary to be more specific or to add implied information. For example:

sent this message (NLT)

wrote a letter (NCV)

addressed the following message

to the people of every nation and language: See the notes on 3:4b, 4:1a, and 5:19a. You will probably want to translate in a similar way here. Notice that the BSB has followed the Aramaic order of phrases, but a few English versions change the order. You may use the order that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to use singular forms. For example:

to every race and nation and language (NLT)

people: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as people means “nation, people.” am “nation, people.” HALOT, 1950. The same word is used in a list in 3:4, 7, 29; 4:1; 5:19. Other ways English versions translate this are:

people groups

race (NLT)

tribes

nation: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates nation also occurs in the lists at 3:4, 7, 31; 5:19. ummah “nation.” HALOT, 1815. A nation usually refers to a group of people who are ruled by one government and who speak a common language.

language: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as language is literally “tongues.” liššan “tongue, language, language group, people.” HALOT, 1909. In this context it means “language groups,” that is, people who speak the same language. See also the lists in 3:4, 7, 31; 5:19.

throughout the land: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as throughout the land is more literally “that live in all the earth.” The same phrase occurs in 2:38; 3:31. There are different ways English versions translate this:

that inhabit the earth (NJPS)

throughout the world (NLT)

all over the world (GW)

on earth (GNT)

The Aramaic word that the BSB translates land can mean either earth or land. The author was referring to every place in the world that people knew about at that time. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language.

6:25b

“May your prosperity abound.”

- “Peace and prosperity to all of you!”
- “Greetings! I wish all of you abundant prosperity!”

May your prosperity abound: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as May your prosperity abound is literally “May your peace increase.” The Aramaic word meaning “peace” included the ideas of “welfare, health.” This was a common greeting at that time. See the Notes at 4:1b. Here are some other ways to translate it:

May you have abundant prosperity! (NRSV)

I hope you are all doing well!

Greetings to all of you (CEV)

In some languages you may need to use two words to translate the idea of peace. For example:

I wish you peace and prosperity (GW)

I wish you great peace and wealth (NCV)

Modern English greetings do not give the exact same emphasis as the Aramaic one. This was not a casual greeting but a formal one. It is good to use a formal, official expression. For example:

I extend my greetings to you all.

I trust that you all are flourishing/prospering.

Daniel 6:26

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions’ den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued

to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

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Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

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Paragraph 6:25–27

Daniel 6:25 begins a new scene. This paragraph tells of King Darius' reaction to Daniel's rescue. He wrote a letter to the people in his kingdom, honoring Daniel's God.

6:26a

I hereby decree

- I King Darius make the following law:
- I declare/command the following:

I hereby decree: See the Notes at 3:29a. The Aramaic expression that the BSB translates as I hereby decree is literally “from before me is set a command.” Emphasis is on the phrase “from before me.” It was the king himself who gave the command. Other ways English versions translate this are:

I command (GNT)

I decree (GW)

I hereby order the following:

decree: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as decree in this context means “command.” *ʾe'em* “command.” HALOT, 1885. It also occurs in Daniel 3:10a, 3:29a, and 4:6a.

6:26b

that in every part of my kingdom, men are to tremble in fear before the God of Daniel:

- Everyone in my kingdom is to fear Daniel's God and revere him,
- Everyone whom I rule must tremble with fear and awe before the God whom Daniel worships.
- Everyone in my kingdom must fear and respect the God whom Daniel serves.

in every part of my kingdom: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as in every part of my kingdom is more literally “in all the dominion of my kingdom.” In this context it refers to all the land where the king ruled. Other ways to translate this are:

throughout my kingdom/realm

throughout my empire (GNT)

everywhere I rule

The decree was sent to all the people in every area of his kingdom. In some languages it may be necessary to make this idea explicit. For example:

among all the people over whom I rule

for all the people in my kingdom

men are to tremble in fear before the God of Daniel:

The Aramaic clause is literally, “there shall be trembling and fearing before the God of Daniel.” The two verbs meaning “tremble” and “fear” occur together both here and in 5:19a, where the BSB translates them as “trembled” and “fear.” See the notes there.

The king was commanding that everyone should recognize the power of the God whom Daniel worshipped. They should honor him highly. English versions translate this in different ways:

- with two verbs. For example:

fear and respect (GNT)

- with one verb or phrase. For example:

tremble with terror (GW)

tremble in fear

Different languages have different ways to describe the way that people react when they are afraid. Choose an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

shake with fear

men: The word men refers to people in general, both men and women.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

people

men and women

the God of Daniel: The phrase God of Daniel here means “the God whom Daniel worshipped.”

6:26c–27

These verses are written in Hebrew poetic style. You should translate these verses in the same way you have translated Hebrew poetry elsewhere in the Old Testament. See the Notes at 2:20–23; 4:3; 4:34–35. Some English versions put each verse part on a new line to show the parallelism. You may wish to show that this is poetry in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

He is a living God, (GNT)

and he will rule forever.

His kingdom will never be destroyed,

and his power will never come to an end.

He saves and rescues;

he performs wonders and miracles

in heaven and on earth.

He saved Daniel from being killed by the lions.

In some languages it is unnatural to repeat information like this, so translators combine the information in the parallel lines. You will need to decide how best to translate the parallel lines in your language.

6:26c

For He is the living God, and He endures forever;

- because he is the God who truly lives and lives forever.
- You must fear him because he is the true God who/ and will live forever
- For he is the God who always lives, forever and ever.

For: The Aramaic connector that the BSB translates as For here introduces the reason for the king’s command. Introduce this reason in a way that is natural in your language.

He is the living God: See the Notes at 6:20b. A similar phrase is used in 4:34: “the one who lives forever.” Elsewhere in the O.T. is in Deuteronomy 5:26; Joshua 3:10; 1 Samuel 17:26. The king said that God was living, that is, powerful and active. In some languages it may be redundant to describe God as living. If that is true in your language, you may have another way to express this idea. For example:

the God who exists/acts

the true God Lucas (p. 158) notes that the epithet stresses the uniqueness of God, in contrast to idols.

and He endures forever: This line repeats the information from 6:26c in different words. Some versions begin a new line with this verse part to show the parallel lines.

The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as He endures forever means that God lives forever. See the Notes at 4:26b. Here are some other ways to translate this:

who continues forever (GW)

He will endure forever (NLT)

He lives forever (NCV)

forever: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as forever refers to the indefinite future, all ages to come. In this context, it indicates that God will always live.

6:26d

His kingdom will never be destroyed, and His dominion will never end.

- No one will ever destroy his kingdom. He will rule forever.
- No one will ever take away his power. His authority to rule will never end.
- No one will ever be able to overthrow his kingdom.

His kingdom will never be destroyed: The clause His kingdom will never be destroyed indicates that nothing and no one will ever put an end to God's rule, his kingly reign over his creation. This is a passive clause. If this is not natural in your language, you may translate it as an active clause. For example:

no one shall ever destroy his kingdom

no one will ever be able to overthrow his rule

His reign will never cease BFrCL88.

kingdom: See the Notes at 2:37b. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom here refers to God's reign or power to rule. For example:

His kingly power (REB)

His reign

His dominion will never end: This line repeats the meaning of the previous line, but in a different way. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat information like this. If that is true in your language you may combine the two lines in 6:26d. See the example in the Display.

The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as will never end is literally "to the end." There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- As a negative statement. For example:

His dominion has no end.

and his rule will never end (NLT)

his power will never come to an end (GNT)

- As a positive statement. For example:

His authority is to the end (NET)

His power lasts to the end of time. (GW)

his sovereignty will last forever BFrCL88.

If you choose to use an expression such as "to the end," as in the GW, make sure that your readers will not think that God's power will eventually end, when time itself comes to an end.

dominion: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as dominion is a synonym to the word "kingdom." šaḷān "dominion." HALOT, 1995. See also the Notes at 4:3d; 4:22d, 4:34e. In this context, it means:

his power (GW)

sovereignty (REB)

authority (NET)

Daniel 6:27

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

Other possible headings for this section include:

Daniel in the Pit of Lions (GNT)

Daniel and the Lions (NCV)

God protected Daniel from lions

Historical Background: The Persian empire under Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539/538 BC, when Daniel was over seventy years old. Daniel was taken captive and brought to Babylon in approximately 605 B.C. If he was 12 years old when he came, he would have been 78 when this story began. The Persian empire became larger than the Babylonian empire had ever been. It extended west to include both Egypt and Libya. It extended east as far as the Indus River in what is now Pakistan. It was the largest empire in the history of the world up to that time.

Some commentators think that Darius the Mede was another name or title for the Persian King Cyrus or for the governor under him, Gubaru.

Text:

The verse numbers in the NJPS and the NJB are different from the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:1 in the NJPS and the NJB is 5:31 in the BSB. The difference is because the NJPS and NJB follow the numbers in the Hebrew Bible. These Notes follow the verse numbers in the BSB.

Special Problems:

1. **Lists:** The author liked to include lists. In Daniel 6, he listed the different officials who conspired against Daniel (6:1–2; 7). Some languages may not have so many terms for officials. The Notes will suggest some ways to translate these lists.

2. **Repetition:** The author liked to repeat words and phrases in order to create suspense and emphasis. The Notes will give some suggestions on how to translate words or phrases that are repeated.
3. **Verbs of Speech:** The author sometimes used more than one verb of speech to introduce a quotation. In some languages, this may not be natural. The Notes will offer some options on how to translate these verbs.
4. **Synonyms:** The author liked to use synonyms or near synonyms to refer to the same idea. For example: 6:7–9 (ordinance, law, decree); 6:14 (rescue, delivering); 6:26 (kingdom, dominion); 6:27b (signs, wonders). The Notes will suggest different ways to translate these terms.

Paragraph 6:25–27

Daniel 6:25 begins a new scene. This paragraph tells of King Darius' reaction to Daniel's rescue. He wrote a letter to the people in his kingdom, honoring Daniel's God.

6:27a

He delivers and rescues;

- He rescues people and he sets them free.
- He delivers people from their enemies. He saves them from harm.
- He delivers people from all manner of evil.

He delivers and rescues: See also the Notes at 6:14b. This verb also occurs in 3:15g, 28b. It is a synonym to save someone (3:14b). This verb describes an action that God does regularly or habitually. It is a shaphal participle. Some ways English versions say this are:

delivers (RSV)

saves (NJB)

he rescues people (CEV)

a savior (REB)

and rescues: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as rescues is a synonym to the verb "saves." The verb form describes something that God does regularly or habitually. Some ways that English versions say this are:

and saves people (NCV)

he sets them free (CEV)

a deliverer (REB)

General Comment on 6:27a

Some languages may not have synonyms like “rescues” and “saves.” In other languages, it may not be natural to repeat the same idea twice. If either of these are true in your language, it may be necessary to use only one verb, perhaps intensifying it in some way.

6:27b

He performs signs and wonders in the heavens and on the earth,

- He performs miraculous signs and amazing things everywhere, on earth and in the sky.
- He does mighty miracles everywhere in the universe.

He performs signs and wonders in the heavens and on the earth: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as performs means “does, acts.” *ʿlḇd* “to make”; HALOT, 1942. The form of the Aramaic verb describes something that God does habitually or continually. *Peal Participle*. Some ways English versions translate this are:

he performs wonders and miracles (GNT)

he does miraculous signs and amazing things (GW)

he accomplishes wonderful signs and miracles BFrCL88

a worker of signs and wonders (REB)

signs: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as signs refers to things that God does to show his power. *ʿlṭ* “signs”: HALOT, 1828. The same word occurs in 4:2. Other ways that English versions translate this are:

miraculous signs (GW)

miracles (GNT)

wonders: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as wonders means “miracles.” *tammah* “miracle”: HALOT, 2007. It is a close synonym to the Aramaic word mean-

ing “signs” above. Both words also occur together in 4:2. Another way to translate this idea is:

amazing things (GW)

miracles (GNT)

In some languages you may not have two different words that mean “signs” and wonders. If that is true in your language, you may have to use one word or phrase that expresses this idea. For example:

by working great miracles (CEV)

he does mighty miracles (NCV)

he shows signs of his great power

in the heavens and on the earth: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as in the heavens and on the earth is an idiom that refers to everywhere, the whole of creation. God’s power is seen in the skies above and on the earth beneath.

the heavens: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as heavens can mean either the place where God lives or the sky. Here the author uses the word to refer to the sky as the opposite of the earth. Together the two words refer to all that God created.

6:27c

for He has rescued Daniel from the power of the lions.”

- He kept Daniel safe from the lions.”
- He even saved Daniel from the claws/jaws of the lions.”
- Daniel’s God has kept the lions from harming him.”

for He has rescued Daniel: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as rescued is the same verb as in 6:27a. Here it describes a past action. God saved Daniel from the lions. You can also say:

who has delivered Daniel (REB)

Daniel’s God has rescued him (CEV)

from the power of the lions: The phrase that the BSB translates as the power of the lions is literally “the hand/paw of the lions.” The GeCL97 has: “from the jaws of the lions.” Here is another way to translate this:

from being killed by the lions (GNT)

Daniel 6:28

Section 6:1–28: God delivered Daniel from the lions' den

The new Persian king, Darius the Mede, chose Daniel to be one of the three officials who administered the kingdom. Daniel did his work so well that the other officials became jealous of him. One day they asked the king to pass a law that forbade praying to anyone but him for a period of thirty days. The king signed the law. Daniel, however, refused to obey it and continued to pray to the one true God, the God of Israel. When the king heard that Daniel had disobeyed the law, he ordered his soldiers to throw Daniel into the pit where he kept hungry lions. But God protected Daniel. The lions did not hurt him. When the king saw this, he punished Daniel's enemies and honored Daniel and the God of Israel.

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Paragraph 6:28

This verse concludes chapter 6. It tells what happened later to Daniel.

6:28

So Daniel prospered during the reign of Darius and the reign of Cyrus the Persian.

- ¶ Daniel was successful in his work during the whole time Darius and Cyrus the Persian were kings over the Persian empire.
- ¶ And so Daniel did well during the whole time Darius was the king. He continued to be prosperous/successful when Cyrus the Persian became king.

So: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as So here introduces the conclusion to the narrative. Introduce this conclusion in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel prospered: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as prospered here indicates that Daniel was successful politically and materially. Things went well for him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

All went well for Daniel (CEV)

Daniel was successful (NCV)

Daniel's life went well

Daniel: The Aramaic text has a demonstrative pronoun before the name Daniel: "This Daniel." In this context it puts the focus away from the king and back on Daniel. You may translate this pronoun if it is natural in your language. For example:

This Daniel (NJB)

This man, Daniel, (GW)

during the reign of Darius: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as reign can have different meanings. See HALOT, 1917. In this context it refers to the period of time when Darius ruled the Persian empire. See 6:26d, where the BSB translates it as “kingdom,” and the note on Darius at 6:1. Other ways to translate this are:

while Darius was king (CEV)

when Darius ruled

and the reign of Cyrus the Persian: See the Notes at 1:21. Cyrus was the king of Persia from 539–530 B.C. Other ways to translate this are:

and when Cyrus the Persian ruled

when Cyrus the Persian was king (NCV)

In this second division, the second half of the book, Daniel recorded dreams that God gave him. These dreams contained many symbolic figures and strange animals. The events symbolized world events, the rise and fall of kings and kingdoms, and the dream emphasized God’s control over world history.

Daniel 7:1

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:1

Daniel introduced his vision. He indicated that he was the author and gave the year in which he wrote.

7:1a

In the first year of the reign of Belshazzar over Babylon,

- ¶ During the first year that Belshazzar was the king of Babylon,
- ¶ When Belshazzar was ruling the kingdom of Babylon, in the first year of his rule/reign,

In the first year of the reign of Belshazzar over Babylon: This narrative begins with a time indica-

tor. These events took place in the first year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. So they took place before the events of chapter 5, which describe the end of Belshazzar’s reign. They do not follow chronologically from the narrative of chapter 6.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

In Belshazzar’s first year as king of Babylon (NCV)

during the first year of King Belshazzar’s reign in Babylonia (NLT)

Earlier/Previously when Belshazzar was still ruling, and had ruled Babylon for less than a year

7:1b

Daniel had a dream, and visions passed through his mind

- one night Daniel had a strange dream. He saw visions
- Daniel had a vision

Daniel had a dream, and visions passed through his mind: The two clauses Daniel had a dream and visions passed through his mind refer to the same event. The repetition serves to emphasize what happened: Daniel had a noteworthy dream. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Daniel had a dream. He saw visions (NCV)

While Daniel was dreaming, he had a vision

Daniel had a dream: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as Daniel had a dream is literally “Daniel saw a dream.” Use the verb that is natural in your language. For example:

Daniel dreamed a dream

visions passed through his mind: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as visions passed through his mind is literally “the visions of his head.” The BSB has supplied the verb phrase passed through. The Aramaic word for visions is closely related to the word “saw” (BSB: “had”) in the previous clause. These visions are what Daniel saw in his dream. You may use the plural form (visions) or singular (“a vision”), whichever is most natural in this context.

7:1c

as he lay on his bed.

- as he was lying in bed asleep,
- while he was sleeping one night.

as he lay on his bed: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as as he lay on his bed is literally “on his bed.” This indicates that Daniel was lying down and sleeping at the time he had this dream. Where he was sleeping is not important or in focus. In some cultures people do not sleep on beds. Express the idea that Daniel was lying down to sleep in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

while I was asleep one night (CEV)

7:1d

He wrote down the dream, and this is the summary of his account.

- and he wrote a summary/account of what he had dreamed.
- He then wrote down what he had dreamed.

He wrote down the dream, and this is the summary of his account: The Aramaic text is more literally “he wrote the dream the head of things he said.” There are two ways to interpret this:

1. The two clauses refer to the same action, the recording of the dream that follows. For example:

Then he wrote down the dream (NRSV) (NIV, NET, NRSV, GW, GNT, possibly KJV, ESV, NLT)

1. The two clauses refer to two different actions. For example:

then he wrote the dream down and related the following summary of it (NASB) (BSB, NASB, NJB, GNT, REB, possibly RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This kind of repetition is a common feature of the writing in the book of Daniel. Here Daniel was introducing the written record of his dream. Other ways to translate this include:

Then he wrote down the dream in summary fashion (NET)

He wrote down the main parts of the dream. (GW)

the summary of his account: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the summary of his account is more literally “the head/chief of matters/things.”

There are two ways to interpret the word “head/chief” in this context:

1. It means “summary, record, report of the most important details.” For example:

in summary fashion (NET)

this is the record (GNT) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, GW, GNT)

1. It means “beginning.” For example:

this is how the narrative began (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

Daniel 7:2

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:2–3

Daniel introduced four beasts that he saw in his dream. They came up one by one out of the ocean.

7:2a–b

In my vision in the night I looked, and suddenly the four winds of heaven: Speaking in the first person, Daniel said/wrote that he had had a dream and in his dream he saw wind blowing from all different directions. In the BSB, as in the Aramaic, there are two clauses connected with the word and. However, it may be natural to connect these ideas in a different way. For example:

I had a dream in which I saw the four winds of heaven.

I was watching in my visions during the night as the four winds of heaven... (NET)

In my visions at night, I, Daniel, saw the four winds of heaven (GW)

7:2a

Daniel declared: “In my vision in the night I looked,

- ¶ This is Daniel’s summary/account: In my vision in the night, I was watching

- ¶ He wrote this: In my vision I could see

Daniel declared: The words Daniel declared form the immediate introduction to the dream account. After this the narrative switches to the first person, with Daniel referring to himself as “I.” If the previous verse part, 7:1d, is a sufficient introduction to the narrative, it may not be necessary to translate these words explicitly. In other languages it may be natural to indicate that Daniel was writing. For example:

This is what Daniel wrote:

7:2b

and suddenly the four winds of heaven

- and I saw winds blowing from all four directions.
- winds begin to blow from north, south, east, and west.

and suddenly the four winds of heaven: The phrase and suddenly introduces what appeared in front of Daniel. That is, it introduces what he saw in his dream. The Aramaic is more literally “and lo/behold! The four winds of the heavens.” In some languages it may not be natural to say that Daniel saw the four winds, since what he actually saw was what the four winds did. They created a storm, which blew across the water. See the General Comment on 7:2a–b. Here is another way to translate this:

and...the wind was blowing from all four directions (NCV)

the four winds of heaven: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates literally as the four winds of heaven refers to winds that blow from the north, south, east, and west. The word heaven in this context refers to the sky. Since winds always blow in the sky, in some languages it may be natural to leave this untranslated. Here are some ways to translate this:

wind/winds from all directions

wind was blowing from the north, south, east and west.

strong winds blowing from every direction (NLT)

7:2c

were churning up the great sea.

- They stirred/tossed the vast/huge sea.
- They blew on the ocean and made/caused big waves.

were churning up the great sea: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as churning up means “stirring up.” The winds were causing large waves to form on the sea. Here are some other ways to translate this:

lashing the surface of the ocean (GNT)

which made the sea very rough (NCV)

the great sea: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the great sea refers to a large expanse of water. In this context it probably refers to the Mediterranean Sea. You could indicate this in a footnote.

General Comment on 7:2a–b

In some languages it may be natural to indicate that what Daniel actually saw in his dream was the effect of the four winds on the great sea. It may be helpful to reorder some of the information to make this clear. For example:

^{2a-b}In my vision that night, I, Daniel, saw a great storm churning the surface of a great sea, with strong winds blowing from every direction. (NLT)

Daniel 7:3

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:2–3

Daniel introduced four beasts that he saw in his dream. They came up one by one out of the ocean.

7:3

Then four great beasts came up out of the sea, each one different from the others:

- Then four large beasts came up out of the sea. Each one was different from the others.
- Then four huge creatures emerged from the ocean. Each of the creatures had a different form.

Then four great beasts came up out of the sea, each one different from the others: Daniel continued to describe what he saw in his dream. He saw four huge creatures rising up out of the stormy sea. All the creatures were different. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

four great beasts emerged from the sea, each different from the others (NJB)

and four great beasts rising from out of the sea, each one different from the others (REB)

I saw four huge animals come up from the sea, and each animal was different from the others. (NCV)

four great beasts: These beasts were not normal animals but had the characteristics of various animals. They were more like mythological creatures. That is, they were more like animals that do not exist in reality but only in the imagination. Use the term that is natural for such creatures. For example:

Four large animals (GW)

four huge creatures

each one different from the others: The four beasts were all different to look at, that is, distinct in type. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause. For example:

they were different from one another (NET)

Each beast was different. (CEV)

They were all different.

Daniel 7:4

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:4

Daniel described the first beast that came from the sea.

7:4a

The first beast was like a lion,

- ¶ The first beast looked like a lion
- ¶ The first creature that came out of the ocean resembled a lion,

The first beast was like a lion: The phrase The first beast was like a lion indicates that this first beast to emerge from the ocean looked something like a lion. It was not a lion, but its body resembled that of a lion. Many scholars think that this is a reference to the kingdom of Babylon. See also Revelation 4:7, where

a similar phrase occurs, describing a heavenly being. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The first was like a lion (NIV)

The first one looked like a lion (GNT)

The first animal/creature appeared to be a lion

a lion: The lion is a large and dangerous animal in the cat family. See how you translated this in Genesis 4:9, 1 Samuel 17:34, Hebrews 11:33, or 1 Peter 5:8.

7:4b

and it had the wings of an eagle.

- with eagle's wings.
- but it had eagle's wings.

and it had the wings of an eagle: The lion-like beast had wings that looked like eagle's wings. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and had eagles' wings (RSV)

with eagle's wings (NJB)

and: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces an exception to the statement in the previous clause. The first beast had the general appearance of a lion but with wings like those of an eagle. Since this is against expectation, in some languages it may be natural to translate the conjunction with a word indicating contrast. For example:

but (GNT)

an eagle: The eagle is a very large bird that attacks and eats small mammals. See how you translated eagle in Exodus 19:4, Psalm 103:5, and Revelation 4:7 and 8:13.

7:4c

I watched until its wings were torn off

- I continued to look at the beast and suddenly its wings were pulled/plucked off.
- I saw someone remove the creature's wings

I watched until its wings were torn off: While Daniel was watching, someone removed the wings of the beast. The phrase were torn off is passive and so who did this is not stated. There are two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

as I looked, its wings were torn off (NJB)

- Using an active verb with a general subject. For example:

someone/they tore off its wings

7:4d

and it was lifted up from the ground

- It was raised from the ground
- and make it stand upright.

and it was lifted up from the ground: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as it was lifted up from the ground here probably indicates that someone forced or caused the creature to rise up on its hind legs. The phrase it was lifted up is also passive and so the subject is not indicated. There are again two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

it was lifted to an upright position (CEV)

it was raised from the ground

- Using an active verb with a general subject. For example

they lifted/raised it from the ground

someone caused it to rise

7:4e

and made to stand on two feet like a man,

- so that it stood up straight like a human, on two feet,
- Then it stood on its two back feet, just like a person/man stands

and made to stand on two feet like a man: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as and made to stand here introduces what happened when the beast was lifted from the earth. It was forced to stand upright, on its two back legs. Here are some other ways to translate this:

so that it stood on two feet like a human being (NIV)

and made to stand up straight (GNT)

and set standing on its feet like a human (NJB)

and given the mind of a man: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as mind is literally “heart.” In Hebrew thinking the heart was the center of thinking and reasoning as well as feeling. So this verse part indicates that the beast began to think like a human being. It is a passive clause, and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and was given a human mind (GW)

and it was made able to think like a human

- Using an active verb. For example:

it received the mind of a human

it received the ability to think like a human being

Many scholars think that this refers to Nebuchadnezzar and his acceptance of God’s rule in his life. In your translation, try to allow for this possibility but do not make it explicit.

7:4f

and given the mind of a man.

- and it received a human mind.
- and it was allowed to start thinking like a person/man.

Daniel 7:5

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:5

Daniel described the second beast to come out of the sea.

7:5a

Suddenly another beast appeared, which looked like a bear.

- ¶ I kept watching, and suddenly another beast appeared. This second beast looked/was like a bear.
- ¶ Then, suddenly I saw a second strange creature come out of the ocean/sea.. It resembled a bear.

In Aramaic, 7:5a begins with a common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” The BSB omits this word. Here, it introduces what Daniel saw next. That is, it introduces what happened next in Daniel’s dream. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as:

Then (GNT)

Suddenly another beast appeared, which looked like a bear: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as Suddenly is literally “and lo/behold!” as in 7:2a-b. Daniel called attention to what he saw next, a beast that resembled a bear. Many scholars think that this second beast refers either to the kingdom of the Medes or to Medo-Persia. However, this should not be made explicit in your translation. You may wish to write a footnote indicating that this is a common understanding. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Another beast appeared, a second one, that looked like a bear (NRSV)

The second beast looked like a bear (GNT)

another beast appeared, which looked like a bear: The second beast that arose from the sea looked like a bear. In your translation, make sure that it is clear that this was not the second beast to look like a bear. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear by translating this as two clauses:

a second beast arose and this second beast looked like a bear

I saw a second animal. It looked like a bear. (GW)

Then I saw a second beast, and it looked like a bear. (NLT)

a bear: In this dream the bear appears as an image of a dangerous and aggressive empire. Use a word for a species of bear that is known to attack and eat other animals. See how you referred to this type of animal in 1 Samuel 17:34-37 and 2 Kings 2:24.

7:5b

It was raised up on one of its sides,

- It had raised itself up on one side,
- It was crouching/rearing,

It was raised up on one of its sides: The Aramaic text says, “it was raised to one side.” The BSB has translated this literally, but the position of the bear is not clear. It appears that the bear was crouched on the ground, perhaps rearing up in front. The verb it was raised up is passive, and the subject is not stated. However, the emphasis is on the bear’s position, not on how it got there. Here are some possible translations

its front was raised

rearing up

It was crouching on the ground, starting to rise

7:5c

and it had three ribs in its mouth between its teeth.

- and three animal ribs were in its mouth between its teeth.
- and with its teeth it was holding/chewing three ribs from its prey/victim.

and it had three ribs in its mouth between its teeth:

There are two ways to understand this clause:

1. The bear was holding parts of an animal in its mouth. This implies that it was in the process of eating that animal. For example:

There were three ribs in its mouth between its teeth (NET) (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, RSV, ESV, NET, GW, REB, NJB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Besides having teeth, the bear had three tusks growing there. For example:

had three tusks in its mouth among its teeth (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the great majority of English versions. Here are some other ways to translate this:

It held three ribs in its teeth (CEV)

It was holding three ribs between its teeth (GNT)

Its teeth were holding/clasping three animal ribs

three ribs: The three ribs probably symbolized three countries that the kingdom represented by the bear had conquered. You should not make this explicit, but translate in a way that allows for this understanding.

7:5d

So it was told, ‘Get up and gorge yourself on flesh!’

- Someone said to the beast, “Get up! Eat as much meat as you can!”
- Then I heard this command made/given to it, “Go! Attack/Kill and eat many other animals!”

So it was told: This is literally “and thus they said unto it,” as in the KJV/NASB. In order to avoid the wrong meaning that the ribs were talking, the BSB has translated this as a passive verb phrase. In some languages it may be possible to use a general pronoun such as one:

someone said to it

Get up and gorge yourself on flesh!: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as Get up and gorge yourself on flesh! is literally “Arise! Eat much flesh!” The bear was commanded to get up and kill and eat many other animals. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Get up and eat as much meat as you want. (GW)

Go on, eat as much meat as you can! (GNT)

gorge yourself on flesh!: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as gorge yourself on flesh is more literally “Eat much flesh.” It is implied that the bear was to attack and kill many other animals, and then he could eat them. The CEV has made the implied information explicit:

Attack! Eat all the flesh you want. (CEV)

General Comment on 7:5d

In some languages it may be natural to use indirect speech for this command. For example:

it was told to get up and eat its fill of flesh

it was ordered to go and eat a lot of meat

it received the command to kill and eat all the flesh it wanted

Daniel 7:6

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:6

Daniel described the third beast he saw rising from the sea,

7:6a–b

another beast appeared. It was like a leopard: The Aramaic text is more literally “and lo/ behold! Another like a leopard.” The BSB has supplied the information that what Daniel saw was another beast or animal. It is important that your translation does not indicate that Daniel had previously seen another leopard-like beast. This was the third beast, but it was the only one that looked like a leopard. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and there before me was another animal. This animal looked like a leopard (NCV)

I saw another animal. It looked like a leopard. (GW)

Then the third of these strange beasts appeared, and it looked like a leopard. (NLT)

7:6a

Next, as I watched, another beast appeared.

- ¶ Then as I was watching another beast appeared.
- ¶ I kept watching and suddenly I saw a third strange creature.

Next, as I watched: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as Next, as I watched here introduces the next scene in Daniel’s vision.

After these things, as I was watching (NET)

After this as I gazed (REB)

7:6b

It was like a leopard,

- It was/looked like a leopard.
- This creature resembled a leopard,

It was like a leopard: The third beast resembled a large and dangerous member of the cat family. Some scholars think that this is a reference to the Greek

empire, and other scholars think that it is a reference to the Persian empire. It is not certain if the Aramaic word refers to a leopard or to a panther, but most English translations say leopard. If your language has a word for a panther or other similar animal, but not for a leopard, it is acceptable to use that.

7:6c

and on its back it had four wings like those of a bird.

- Four wings like birds' wings grew/came from its back.
- but there were four wings on its back. The wings looked like the wings of a bird.

and: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here continues the description of the fourth beast. It introduces a contrast to the previous phrase. So in some languages it may be natural to introduce this verse part with a conjunction introducing contrast. For example:

but (GNT)

on its back it had four wings like those of a bird:

The leopard had four wings on its back and the wings appeared similar to bird's wings. In your translation, avoid implying that birds have four wings. You may be able to say:

It had four wings growing/sprouting from its back, wings that looked like the wings of a bird.

on its back there were four wings. The wings appeared similar to birds' wings.

7:6d

The beast also had four heads,

- It had four heads,
- There were four heads on the creature,

The beast also had four heads: Daniel continued his description of the third beast. It had four heads. Refer back to the third beast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

This creature had four heads (REB)

it had four heads (NJB)

General Comment on 7:6b–d

Daniel said the third beast resembled a leopard and then gave two ways in which it was different from

a normal leopard. So in some languages it may be natural to say:

The third beast was like a leopard—except that it had four wings and four heads. (CEV)

7:6e

and it was given authority to rule.

- and it was permitted to rule/govern.
- and it received power to rule over people/nations.

and it was given authority to rule: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as it was given authority to rule is more literally “it was given dominion.” In this context this indicates that the animal was given political power, authority over nations. It implies that the beast was not only given such authority but actually did rule. This is a passive clause and there are two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and was given power to rule (NCV)

and it was allowed/permitted to rule

- Using an active verb. For example:

it received authority to rule

God permitted/allowed it to rule

Daniel 7:7

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:7

Daniel described the fourth beast he saw rising from the sea.

7:7a

After this, as I watched in my vision in the night, suddenly a fourth beast appeared,

- ¶ Then in my vision that night I saw a fourth beast appear.
- ¶ The next thing I saw in that night vision was another strange creature, a fourth one.

After this, as I watched in my vision in the night: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates as After this,

as I watched in my vision in the night is more literally “after this I was watching in the visions of the night.” This continues the dream description and introduces the fourth, final, and most terrifying beast. Here are some other ways to translate this:

After these things, as I was watching in the night visions (NET)

Then, in my vision that night (NLT)

suddenly a fourth beast appeared: This is more literally “and lo/behold! A fourth beast.” Some English translations leave the phrase “and lo/behold” untranslated. Introduce the fourth beast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

a fourth beast (NRSV)

a fourth beast appeared (NET)

I saw in front of me a fourth animal (NCV)

7:7b
and it was terrifying—dreadful and extremely strong—

- It was horrifying, terrible, and extremely strong.
- This creature terrified me. It was very powerful and destructive.

and it was terrifying—dreadful and extremely strong: The three adjectives that the BSB translates as terrifying and dreadful and extremely strong all describe the fourth beast. Together they emphasize that the beast was both strong and evil. Some scholars understand the fourth beast to be a symbol of the Roman empire, and some understand it as a symbol of the Greek empire. Here are some other ways to translate this description:

terrifying, dreadful, and very strong (NLT)

It was powerful, horrible, terrifying. (GNT)

that was cruel, terrible, and very strong (NCV)

terrifying...dreadful: The adjectives terrifying and dreadful are synonyms. In some languages it may be more natural to combine them into one emphatic phrase and say something like:

absolutely terrifying

7:7c
with large iron teeth.

- Its great teeth were made of iron,
- With its huge iron teeth

with large iron teeth: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as teeth is dual rather than plural. This may suggest two rows of teeth, top and bottom. Most English translations do not try to indicate the duality. But if it is natural in your language, you may wish to do that. For example:

It had two large rows of iron teeth. (NET)

7:7d
It devoured and crushed; then it trampled underfoot whatever was left.

- and it ate and crunched its prey, trampling/treading on what was left.
- it crushed and ate other animals. Then with its feet it stamped/pressed down on anything of them that remained.

It devoured and crushed: The Aramaic text is more literally “it was devouring and it was shattering.” The phrase emphasizes that this beast was brutal and destructive. Other ways to translate this include:

It crushed and devoured its victims (NIV)

and was devouring, breaking in pieces (NRSV)

It crushed and ate what it killed. (NCV)

then it trampled underfoot whatever was left: The beast walked over whatever was left of its meal. It did not value or preserve anything. Other ways to translate this include:

and anything that was left it trampled with its feet (NET)

and then it walked on whatever was left (NCV)

7:7e
It was different from all the beasts before it, and it had ten horns.

- The fourth beast was not like the previous three beasts, and it had ten horns.

- The fourth creature was completely different from the creatures that I had seen earlier/before, having ten horns on its head.

It was different from all the beasts before it: The text indicates that the fourth beast stood out or was unique in some way. If you must give some indication or explanation of the difference, it may be possible to say:

It did not look like any of the former beasts

from all the beasts before it: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as from all the beasts before it is more literally “from every beast before it.” This refers to the three other beasts Daniel had seen rising from the great sea. Since in some languages it may not be appropriate to use the word all to refer to three items, you may wish to say:

from the other beasts that I had seen

from the three previous beasts

and it had ten horns: This was the way, or one of the ways, in which the fourth beast was different from the others. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the ten horns were growing on the head of the beast. For example:

and it had horns on its head—ten of them (CEV)

there were ten horns growing on its head

horns: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as horns refers to hard pointed spikes that grow on the heads of animals like the rhinoceros. Animals use these horns to fight other animals.

General Comment on 7:7e

In some languages it may be natural to indicate explicitly that it was the ten horns on its head that made the fourth beast different from the others. For example:

Unlike the other beasts, it had ten horns. (GNT)

Daniel 7:8

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings

explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:8

A small but proud horn appeared and destroyed three of the earlier horns.

7:8a

While I was contemplating the horns,

- ¶ As I was paying attention to the horns,
- ¶ As I was focusing on those ten horns,

While I was contemplating the horns: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as I was contemplating is literally “I was considering, contemplating.” In this context there are two ways to interpret it:

1. It means to think about something. For example:

I was considering the horns (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, REB, NET, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. It means to watch something. For example:

While I was staring at the horns (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NLT)

It is good, if possible, to use an expression that includes both these ideas. Daniel was giving his attention to this part of the vision, watching and wondering about it. For example:

As I was paying attention to the horns

If you must choose between the options, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), leaving the idea of watching implied.

7:8b

suddenly another horn, a little one, came up among them,

- a little horn appeared among the ten horns.
- suddenly I saw a little/small horn grow among the others.
- I saw a new horn sprout among the other horns. It was smaller than

suddenly another horn, a little one, came up among them: The common Aramaic word that the BSB translates as suddenly is literally “and lo/behold!” Here, it is used to add emphasis to something that happened suddenly or unexpectedly. An eleventh horn appeared, this one smaller than the others. Here are some other ways to translate this:

a smaller horn appeared (CEV)

I saw a little horn (GNT)

suddenly there appeared another horn. This one was small/smaller.

came up among them: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as came up among them here indicates that the little horn rose or emerged in the middle of the other horns. Here is another way to translate this:

grew up among them (NCV)

7:8c

and three of the first horns were uprooted before it.

- Three of the other horns were torn out to make room for this little horn.
- The little/small horn displaced three of the other horns.
- the first horns, but it tore out/up three of them.

and three of the first horns were uprooted before it: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as were uprooted here indicates that three of the first horns were forced to fall out. The small horn forced them out. This phrase is passive. There are several ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

three of the original horns were pulled out by the roots to make way for it (NJB)

Three of the first horns were torn out by the roots to make room for it. (NLT)

- Using an active verb. For example:

It tore out three of the horns that were already there. (GNT)

The little horn pulled out three of the other horns. (NCV)

were uprooted: In some languages it may not be natural to speak of horns as having roots. The idea is that these three horns were completely removed. It may be more natural to say:

were pulled out

were displaced

before it: The English preposition before is not a time word in this context but indicates that the three horns were uprooted in order to allow space for the small horn. Here is another way to translate this:

to make room for it (NLT)

General Comment on 7:8d

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the information in this verse part. For example:

to make room for it, three of the earlier horns were plucked up by the roots (NRSV)

7:8d

This horn had eyes like those of a man

- This horn had eyes that looked like human eyes
- This horn had eyes! They were like a man's eyes,
- Then I saw that this small/final horn had human eyes!

This horn had eyes like those of a man: The Aramaic text is more literally "And lo/behold! Eyes like the eyes of humankind were on this horn." Here are some other ways to translate this:

and in this horn I saw eyes like human eyes, and a mouth full of boasting (NJB)

This horn had eyes resembling human eyes (NET)

This little horn had eyes like human eyes (NLT)

eyes like those of a man: Here the Aramaic word that the BSB translates as man refers to human beings in general. These eyes has the appearance of human eyes. In some languages it may be natural to leave it implied that the eyes only looked like human eyes. For example:

the eyes of a human (CEV)

human eyes (GNT)

7:8e

and a mouth that spoke words of arrogance.

- and a mouth that spoke/boasted with pride.

- and it had a mouth that was making great/arrogant boasts/claims.
- It also had a human mouth, and it was saying things to impress/awe people.

and a mouth that spoke words of arrogance: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as a mouth that spoke words of arrogance is more literally “a mouth that was speaking great things.” Daniel could see that the horn had a mouth, and that the mouth was speaking in a proud way. It is not clear whether or not he could hear what the mouth was saying. Possibly he just knew or understood this in some way. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and a mouth that was boasting arrogantly (NLT)

It also had a mouth, and the mouth was bragging.
(NCV)

and a mouth that spoke with great pride (CEV)

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that the horn itself was speaking, rather than the mouth. For example:

and the horn had a mouth and was speaking with great pride

General Comment on 7:8

7:8 gives a lot of information about the little horn of the fourth animal. In the Aramaic it all forms one long sentence. In some languages it may be natural to break it into several shorter sentences. Here are some examples of how to do this:

^{8a}While I was thinking about the horns, ^{8b}another horn, a little horn, came up among them. ^{8c}It uprooted three of the other horns. ^{8d}This horn had eyes like human eyes ^{8e}and a mouth that spoke impressive things. (CEV)

^{8a}While I was staring at the horns, ^{8b}I saw a little horn coming up among the others. ^{8c}It tore out three of the horns that were already there. ^{8d}This horn had human eyes ^{8e}and a mouth that was boasting proudly. (GNT)

Daniel 7:9

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:9–10

Daniel's vision continued. He saw God on his throne beginning to judge all people.

These verses resemble Hebrew poetry, with parallelism within each verse. There is an introductory formula (“as I looked”) and then three sets of doublets, parallel lines. Several English versions print these verses as poetry, and you may wish to translate them as such. For example:

⁹As I looked:

Thrones of judgment were set in place,

The Ancient of Days seated himself.

His clothes were white like snow,

The hair of his head, pure as wool.

Fiery his throne,

Blazing its wheels!

¹⁰A river of fire poured out,

Streaming from his presence.

A thousand thousands were serving him

there,

Tens of thousands of his servants

were standing before him.

The court sat in judgment,

And the books were opened.

7:9a**As I continued to watch,**

- ¶ While I was watching,
- ¶ I continued to see/watch this vision.

As I continued to watch: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as As I continued to watch is more literally “I was watching/looking until” This phrase here indicates that Daniel was continuing to describe his vision. Indicate this continuation in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

While I was looking (GNT)

While I was watching (NJB)

I watched as (NLT)

7:9b**thrones were set in place,**

- thrones were placed there.
- They prepared/arranged great seats for judges/judging,

thrones were set in place: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as were set in place means “were placed.” It is a passive verb and the text does not indicate who moved the thrones. It could have been angels, or it could have been that the thrones just appeared as though God had placed them there. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

thrones were put in place (NLT)

- Using an active verb. For example:

they set/put thrones in place

thrones: In this context the Aramaic word for thrones refers to special seats where kings and judges sat to judge the people.

7:9c**and the Ancient of Days took His seat.**

- The One who is ancient/old in years sat down on his throne.
- and the Ancient/Eternal One/God seated himself to begin judging.

and the Ancient of Days took His seat: God himself sat down on one of the thrones. He sat down to judge.

It is good to use an expression that is used for a judge sitting down in preparation for issuing his decisions.

the Ancient of Days: This is a title for God. It indicates great respect and refers to God as the one who had lived from ancient times. He had been the one God since before history began. For example:

one that was ancient of days (RSV)

One who had been living forever (GNT)

the Ancient One (NRSV)

the Eternal God (CEV)

took His seat: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as took His seat is literally “sat.” It indicates that God himself sat on one of the thrones. For example:

sat on his throne (NCV)

sat down on one of the thrones (GNT)

7:9d**His clothing was white as snow,**

- His clothes were white like snow,
- He was wearing robes as white as pure/fresh snow,

His clothing was white as snow: This is a comparison. The clothing of the divine Judge was white like snow is white. Indicate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

He was wearing clothes that were white like snow

He was wearing clothes that were snowy-white

clothing: Use a general word. If it is necessary to be specific, it is good to refer to the sort of clothes a judge wears. For example:

robes

white as snow: The point of this comparison is that the clothes were pure or bright white, like snow shining in the sunshine. See how you translated this idea in Matthew 28:3 and Revelation 1:14. You may need to supply some information and say:

bright/pure white, like clean/fresh snow

In some cultures snow is unknown. In those cultures it may be necessary to say simply:

bright white

7:9e

and the hair of His head was like pure wool.

- and the hair on his head was as white as wool.
- and his hair was as white as pure/clean wool.

the hair of His head was like pure wool: The Aramaic text is more literally “was pure like wool.” The color of the hair is compared to that of wool. Wool is not normally or naturally a bright white, so it may be natural to say:

the hair of his head was like clean/pure wool

the hair of his head as pure as wool (NJB)

the hair of His head: In some languages it may be natural to simply say:

his hair

7:9f

His throne was flaming with fire,

- The throne on which he sat was blazing with fire,
- His great seat was burning brightly,

His throne was flaming with fire: The Aramaic text says, “his throne was flames of fire.” The throne appeared to consist of burning flames. Here are some other ways to translate this:

His throne was fiery flames (RSV)

His throne was ablaze with fire (NET)

Fiery was his throne!

7:9g

and its wheels were all ablaze.

- and the wheels on it were flaming/burning.
- and it was set on blazing wheels.

and its wheels were all ablaze: The throne had wheels, and these also were burning like fire. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and its wheels were burning fire (GW)

and the wheels of his throne were blazing with fire (NCV)

Burning/Blazing were its wheels!

General Comment on 7:9f–g

Daniel 7:9g indicates that this throne had wheels. This has not been mentioned before and may require some explanation or introduction. This may involve combining the two clauses. For example:

^{7f-g}His throne was a blazing fire with fiery wheels (CEV)

^{7f-g}His throne, mounted on fiery wheels, was blazing with fire. (GNT)

^{7f-g}He sat on a fiery throne with wheels of blazing fire. (NLT)

Daniel 7:10

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:9–10

Daniel’s vision continued. He saw God on his throne beginning to judge all people.

These verses resemble Hebrew poetry, with parallelism within each verse. There is an introductory formula (“as I looked”) and then three sets of doublets, parallel lines. Several English versions print these verses as poetry, and you may wish to translate them as such. For example:

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The hair of his head, pure as wool.

Fiery his throne,

Blazing its wheels!

¹⁰A river of fire poured out,

Streaming from his presence.

A thousand thousands were serving him

there,

Tens of thousands of his servants

were standing before him.

The court sat in judgment,

And the books were opened.

7:10a

A river of fire was flowing, coming out from His presence.

- A fire/fiery river/stream poured from in front of the throne.
- From his presence fire streamed/gushed out like a river.

A river of fire was flowing: The Aramaic clause that the BSB translates literally as A river of fire was flowing is a metaphor. It compares the fire that was issuing from the throne of God to a river of water that moves forward rapidly. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keeping the metaphor. For example:

and a stream of fire was pouring out (GNT)

- Using a simile. For example:

fire flowed out like a river

- Translating the meaning of the comparison. For example:

fire gushed out

A river of fire: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as A river of fire means “a river consisting of fire.” This is in contrast to a normal river consisting of water. In your translation, it is good to use a word that refers to a large quantity of moving water or fire.

was flowing: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as was flowing refers to the movement of a liquid such as water. Try to use a word that can be used of the movement of both water and fire. For example:

was streaming forth (NET)

was pouring out (NLT)

coming out from His presence: The clause coming out from His presence indicates that the fire river issued from the Ancient of Days, from God himself on his throne. In the Aramaic this is a separate clause, “and it came out from before him.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

and came forth from before him (RSV)

and proceeding from his presence (NET)

General Comment on 7:10a

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two clauses into one. For example:

and a stream of fire was pouring out from it (GNT)

However, if you do this, it may be difficult to maintain the poetic structure of the verse. See the introductory comment on 7:9–10.

7:10b

Thousands upon thousands attended Him,

- Many thousands of people/angels were serving him there.
- Great crowds/numbers of his servants were there,

Thousands upon thousands attended Him: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as attended means “served, ministered to.” There were many thousands of beings there, God’s servants. These could have been people or angels. Apparently they looked like people, because nothing is said about their appearance. So it is acceptable to say

Thousands and thousands of people attended him.

There were many thousands of people there to serve him (GNT)

7:10c

and myriads upon myriads stood before Him.

- Hundreds of thousands of people/angels were standing in his presence ready to obey him.
- yes, multitudes/millions were waiting to serve him.

myriads upon myriads stood before Him: This is parallel to 7:10b, and states the same thing in other words, using a stronger expression. God's servants were so many that Daniel could not count them and used an expression meaning "a vast number." Use a phrase that refers to a huge innumerable crowd. For example:

millions stood before him

countless numbers of his servants were present

General Comment on 7:10b–c

The repetition of the information emphasizes the expression. In some languages it may be natural to combine the two verse parts 7:10b–c and say:

and millions of people stood before him (GNT)

Countless thousands were standing there to serve him. (CEV)

However, if you do this, it may be hard to keep the poetic and parallel structure of 7:10. See also the General Comment on 7:10a.

7:10d

The court was convened,

- The members of the court sat down on the thrones to judge,
- Then the judges came and took their seats/places

The court was convened: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as The court here refers to the judges who made up the court. They sat down as a sign that they were ready to begin judging. In some languages it will be good to make this explicit. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The court sat in judgment. (NRSV)

The court began its session (GNT)

The judges took their seats.

In some languages the act of sitting may not imply that the judges were about to judge. It may imply that they were resting. If this is the case in your language, you may wish to say:

The time of judgment began (CEV)

Court was ready to begin (NCV)

7:10e

and the books were opened.

- and they opened the record books.
- and opened the books of human actions/deeds.

and the books were opened: The heavenly books were opened in order that the judges could read them. This is a passive verb. There are several ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

the books were opened (RSV)

- Using an active verb. The text does not say who opened the books, and the actor is not in focus. So you may be able to say:

they opened the books

the books lay open (NJB)

If you must make the actor explicit, it may be best to say:

the judges opened the books

Making the subject "the judges" explicit will help to explain the nature and purpose of the books. The judges opened the books (or angels opened the books for the judges) in order that the judges could read them and make just decisions.

the books: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the books here refers to heavenly books in which people's deeds are written. The judges opened and read these books in order to give judgment on each person's life. See how you translated this idea in Revelation 20:12. In some languages it may be possible to imply the purpose of the books by saying:

the record books

the books of human deeds/actions

Daniel 7:11

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:11–12

In Daniel's vision, the fourth beast was killed and the other beasts lost their power.

7:11a

Then I kept watching because of the arrogant words the horn was speaking.

- ¶ I continued to watch because the horn continued to speak proud/arrogant words.
- ¶ The horn was still boasting, so I kept watching.

Then I kept watching because of the arrogant words the horn was speaking: The Aramaic text more literally says "then I was watching from the sound of the great words that the horn was speaking." This probably indicates that Daniel kept on watching because he could hear the little horn boasting. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I continued to watch because I could hear the little horn's boastful speech. (NLT)

I kept on looking because the little horn was bragging. (NCV)

the little horn was still boasting, so I continued to watch

7:11b

As I continued to watch, the beast was slain,

- While I was watching, the fourth beast was put to death,
- I watched as they killed the fourth creature

As I continued to watch, the beast was slain: The Aramaic sentence indicates that Daniel watched while the beast was slain. There is no implication that he then stopped watching. Here is another way to translate this:

And as I looked, the beast was slain. (RSV)

As I continued to watch: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as I continued to watch is the same as that in 7:11a, "I kept watching." In English it is more natural to have a variety of verb forms rather than exact repetition. Use a form that is natural in your language. For example:

And as I looked, (RSV)

I kept looking (NIV)

I went on watching (REB)

the beast was slain: This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

the beast was put to death (NRSV)

- Using an active verb. The text does not say who killed the beast, whether it was God or his agents and servants. So you should try to leave this general. For example:

they killed the beast

the beast: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the beast refers to the fourth beast in the series, the one with the ten horns. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit by saying

the fourth beast (GNT)

the fourth animal (NCV)

7:11c

and its body was destroyed and thrown into the blazing fire.

- and its body was thrown in the burning/raging fire and destroyed.
- and threw/put its body/carcass in a hot fire to destroy/burn it.

and its body was destroyed and thrown into the blazing fire: There are two passive verbs in this clause. The subject is unnamed but the same as in 7:11b, God or his agents. There are at least two ways to translate this verse part:

- Using passive verbs. For example:

Its body was destroyed, and it was thrown into the burning fire. (NCV)

Its body was destroyed and put into a raging fire. (GW)

- Using active verbs. For example:

they destroyed its body by throwing it into a blazing fire

its body: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as its body here refers to the dead body of the beast. Use a word that is appropriate for referring to an animals' dead body. For example:

its carcass (REB)

thrown into: The Aramaic verb phrase that the BSB translates as thrown into is more literally “given to.”

General Comment on 7:11a

The dead body of the fourth beast was destroyed in the fire. So in some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the two verb phrases. For example:

its body was thrown into the flames and destroyed (GNT)

Another possibility is to combine the two verbs:

its body was destroyed by fire (NLT)

its carcass was burnt

Daniel 7:12

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:11–12

In Daniel's vision, the fourth beast was killed and the other beasts lost their power.

7:12a–b

As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion was removed, but they were granted an extension of life for a season and a time: These verse parts tell what happened to the other three beasts. There are

two ways to understand when the authority of the other beasts was taken away:

1. It happened at the same time or after the fourth beast was killed. For example:

As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion was taken away, but their lives were prolonged for a season and a time. (NRSV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NJB, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV)

1. It had happened before the fourth beast was killed. The information is therefore parenthetical. For example:

(The power and rule of the other animals had been taken from them, but they were permitted to live for a certain period of time.) (NCV) (NIV, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you leave this vague and open, if possible. In a dream like this, time sequences may not have been very clear. If you must choose, it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation, leaving the timeline as general as possible. For example:

The other beasts had their power taken away, but they were allowed to live for a certain time.

7:12a

As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion was removed,

- The other beasts had their power removed,
- The remaining beasts lost their power to rule,

As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion was removed: This is literally, “And the rest of the beasts, they removed their dominion.” The text does not indicate who removed their dominion, and the BSB has translated this as a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

As for the other beasts, their dominion was taken away (NRSV)

The other three beasts had their authority taken from them (NLT)

- Using an active verb. For example:

The other beasts lost their power

God caused their authority to come to an end.

their dominion: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as their dominion here refers to the beasts' power to rule. The beasts not only lost their right or authority to rule, they lost their power and actually ceased to rule. Make this clear in your translation. For example:

the power and rule of the other animals (NCV)

7:12b

but they were granted an extension of life for a season and a time.

- but they were permitted to live for a certain/limited time.
- but they received permission to remain alive for a while.

but: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as but here indicates a contrast with the previous clause. See the General Comment on 7:12a–b.

they were granted an extension of life: The Aramaic text is more literally “a prolonging in life was given to them.” This indicates that the other beasts were allowed to continue to live. This is a passive clause and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

their lives were prolonged (ESV)

they were permitted to go on living (GNT)

- Using an active verb. For example:

they received permission/ability to live

God allowed them to live

for a season and a time: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB literally translates as for a season and a time indicates that God continued to allow the beasts to live. The two nouns meaning time and season are synonyms and together they refer to an undefined but limited period of time. This season and a time had a fixed and definite end. Here are some other ways to translate this:

for a certain time

for a limited time (GNT)

a while longer (NLT)

General Comment on 7:12a–b

In some languages it may be natural to indicate the contrasting relationship of the two verse parts 7:12a–b in 7:12a. For example:

The other beasts, though deprived of their authority, were allowed to remain alive until an appointed time and season. (REB)

Daniel 7:13

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:13–14

Daniel continued to describe his vision. He saw the figure of a man approaching the throne of God.

7:13a

In my vision in the night I continued to watch,

- ¶ While I was watching this vision during the night,
- ¶ As the/my night visions continued,

In my vision in the night I continued to watch: This clause introduces the next episode in Daniel's dream. Other ways to translate it include:

I saw in the night visions (ESV)

I was watching in the night visions (NET)

As my vision continued that night (NLT)

As I continued to watch the vision that night (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause as a phrase with no verb. See the General Comment on 7:13a–b. For example:

In my visions during the night (GW)

7:13b

and I saw One like the Son of Man

- there appeared someone like a son of man.
- suddenly I saw a figure like that of a human being

and I saw One like the Son of Man: Daniel saw what appeared to be a human figure, the figure of a man. He did not say that this was a man, but just that he was like, or similar to, a man. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I saw what looked like a human being (GNT)

and there came into my sight a figure in human form

there appeared someone resembling a son of the human race

the Son of Man: The phrase the Son of Man refers to a male person who is of the race of men, that is, a human being. See Ezekiel 33:2. The phrase the Son of Man is used as a Messianic title and applied to Jesus in the Gospels. See the notes on Matthew 8:20, Mark 2:10, 28, Luke 6:5, 22, and John 1:51 and John 3:13–14. If you have already translated the Gospels, try to use the same phrase here as you did there.

General Comment on 7:13a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the clauses 7:13a–b, using only one main verb. For example

During this vision in the night, I saw what looked like a human being (GNT)

In my vision at night I saw in front of me someone who looked like a human being (NCV)

7:13c

coming with the clouds of heaven.

- He was coming in the sky with clouds around him.
- coming surrounded by clouds.

coming with the clouds of heaven: Daniel saw the figure resembling a son of man coming in his direction, surrounded by clouds. In some languages it may be natural to translate this using an independent clause. For example:

He was approaching me, surrounded by clouds. (GNT)

And with the clouds of the sky, one like a son of man was approaching. (NET)

coming: In some languages it may be necessary to say where the figure was coming. The figure was coming toward Daniel and the One who was sitting on the throne. In some languages it may be natural to say:

approaching

with the clouds of heaven: In some languages it may be unnecessary and unnatural to refer to clouds as clouds of heaven. It may be more natural to follow the GNT and simply say:

surrounded by clouds (GNT)

General Comment on 7:13b–c

The BSB has reordered the Aramaic text, which is more literally “and lo/behold, with the clouds of the heavens like a son of man he was coming.” Many English versions similarly put the phrase “with the clouds of heaven” at the end of the sentence. However, some other versions follow the Aramaic word order. For example:

and behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man (RSV)

Use the order which is more natural in your language.

7:13d

He approached the Ancient of Days

- He came near the One who is ancient/old in years
- He approached the One who lives from ancient times,
- He went up to the Ancient/Eternal One

7:13e

and was led into His presence.

- and was brought/presented to him.
- and they led/welcomed him into his presence
- and the angels presented him before his throne.

7:13d–e

He approached the Ancient of Days and was led into His presence:

The Aramaic verb phrase that the BSB translates as was led into His presence is more literally “and they brought him before him.” The subject is not indicated. There are several ways of translating this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and he went to the one who had been living forever and was presented to him (GNT)

- Using an active verb with an indefinite subject. For example:

and they brought him near

the Ancient of Days: See how you translated this in 7:9c. Translate it the same way here.

Daniel 7:14

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:13–14

Daniel continued to describe his vision. He saw the figure of a man approaching the throne of God.

7:14a

And He was given dominion, glory, and kingship,

- He received power, honor, and the right to rule the kingdom/people.
- God gave him authority over the nations and caused everyone to honor him and obey him.

And He was given dominion, glory, and kingship:

This is a passive clause. It indicates that the one like a son of man received dominion, glory, and kingship from the Ancient of Days. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

To him was given ruling authority, honor, and sovereignty (NET)

He was crowned king and given power and honor (CEV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

He received authority, glory, and sovereign power.

The Ancient of Days gave him authority, glory, and sovereign power.

dominion, glory, and kingship: In this context these three ideas have similar meanings. The repetition serves to emphasize the idea, that this one like a son of man received all power to rule the earth. If you are unable to use three separate nouns or noun phrases, you may be able to say:

all authority/power and great glory

dominion: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as dominion means “power to rule.” See how you translated this word in 4:34e and 7:6e. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a clause with a verb and an object. For example:

he ruled all nations

glory: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as glory here means “honor.” See how you translated this word in 2:6b. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a clause with a verb. For example:

everyone honored him

kingship: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingship is literally “a kingdom.” See how you translated this in 2:29a. The Ancient of Days caused the one like a son of man to reign as king over a kingdom. In this context, the kingdom does not refer to one specific country out of many, but to the entire world, as the next verse part makes clear. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a clause. For example:

he ruled as king

he reigned

7:14b

that the people of every nation and language should serve Him.

- The people of every nation and language worshiped him.
- All over the world people served him, whatever their race and language.

that the people of every nation and language should serve Him:

The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as serve can also be translated as “pay reverence to” or “worship.” It normally refers to the worship that is only given to God. See 3:12d and 3:14b, where the same verb is used.

There are two ways of understanding the relationship of this verse part to the previous verse part:

1. It indicates something that happened along with and as a result of 7:14a. For example:

and all peoples, nations and languages became his servants (NJB) (NIV, NJB, NET, NCV, GW)

1. It is a purpose clause and indicates the purpose of 7:14a. For example:

so that the people of all nations, races, and languages would serve him (GNT) (BSB, KJV, NASB, GNT, RSV/NRSV, ESV, CEV, REB, GNT, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The one like a son of man was given power and so everyone worshiped him. However, in some languages the difference between the two interpretations may be very slight and simply a matter of emphasis. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

All peoples, nations, and language groups were serving him. (NET)

People of every tribe, nation and language served him. (NCV)

7:14c

His dominion is an everlasting dominion that will not pass away,

- His rule will endure forever. It will never come to an end,
- He will rule forever, yes, for all time/ages to come.

His dominion is an everlasting dominion that will not pass away: The Aramaic word that the BSB here twice translates as dominion is the same as the word translated as “dominion” in 7:14a. The authority of this son of man will never end. This is stated in two different ways, one positive and one negative (is an everlasting dominion and will not pass away). This repetition gives emphasis to the idea. In some languages it may be natural to use two separate clauses. For example:

His rule is eternal—it will never end (NLT)

Emphasize the meaning in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Unending his rule, unfailing his kingdom

He will surely rule for ever and ever

His dominion is an everlasting dominion: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as His dominion is an everlasting dominion is the same as in 4:34e. See how you translated it there. In some languages it may be natural to translate the abstract noun dominion as a verb. For example:

He will rule forever (CEV)

that will not pass away: The Aramaic phrase indicates that the dominion of the son of man will not come to an end. It will endure forever. Here is another way to translate this:

his kingdom is eternal (CEV)

7:14d

and His kingdom is one that will never be destroyed.

- no, never will it be destroyed.
- No enemy will ever overcome/conquer his/that kingdom.

and His kingdom is one that will never be destroyed: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces another way of saying almost the same thing as the previous verse part. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence and leave the conjunction implied. For example:

His kingdom will never be destroyed. (NLT)

His kingdom is one that will never be destroyed: The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as will never be destroyed here indicates that the rule of the son of man will never come to an end. No other king or ruler will be able to overcome him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

his kingdom would never end (GNT)

No other power will ever conquer his kingdom!

No one will overcome him!

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

his kingdom will endure forever

he will reign over all people for all time

His kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as kingdom here refers to kingship, the right and power to rule as king. See how you translated this in 4:34f and the notes on 4:34e–f. Here is another way to translate this:

his kingly power (REB)

General Comment on 7:14c–d

The two verse parts say the same thing in three different ways to emphasize the thought. If such repetition is unnatural in your language, you may wish to combine the verse parts into one or two emphatic statements. For example:

He will rule for all time. He will never ever cease to reign!

His rule/dominion will be eternal, unending, victorious!

He will be king forever, for all time to come.

Daniel 7:15

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:15–18

While still in a dreamlike state, Daniel asked about the meaning of what he had seen. God's servant briefly explained to Daniel the meaning of his dream. He gave a summary of what the vision symbolized.

7:15a

I, Daniel, was grieved in my spirit,

- ¶ As for me, Daniel, my heart/mind was troubled
- ¶ In my dream I, that is, Daniel, felt very upset.

I, Daniel, was grieved in my spirit: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as was grieved in my spirit is more literally “my spirit was distressed in its sheath.” A sheath is a covering or holder for a sword. This idiom here indicates that Daniel felt disturbed or unhappy in his inner being. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

My heart/liver was sad

I, Daniel, was deeply troubled (GW)

I, Daniel, was worried (NCV)

7:15b

and the visions in my mind alarmed me.

- and the visions I was seeing frightened me.
- I was alarmed by these visions.

and the visions in my mind alarmed me: This verse part intensifies the previous verse part. It emphasizes that Daniel was very upset by what he had seen in his dreams. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and the visions of my head terrified me (NRSV)

and my visions frightened me (GW)

the visions in my mind: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the visions in my mind is literally “the visions of my head,” as in the NRSV. Notice that Daniel was still seeing the vision while he was feeling this alarm. The context of the following verse indicates that he had not woken up. Refer to Daniel's dream in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

my visions (NLT)

General Comment on 7:15a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the two clauses 7:15a–b. For example:

^{15b}The visions I saw alarmed me, ^{15a}and I was deeply disturbed. (GNT)

In other languages it may be natural to combine the two clauses into one. For example:

I, Daniel, was worried and frightened by what I had seen in the vision.

Daniel 7:16

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:15–18

While still in a dreamlike state, Daniel asked about the meaning of what he had seen. God's servant briefly explained to Daniel the meaning of his dream. He gave a summary of what the vision symbolized.

7:16a

I approached one of those who were standing there,

- I went to one of the people/angels standing before God
- So I went up to one of God's servants who were standing before his throne.

I approached one of those who were standing there: The phrase one of those who were standing there refers back to the servants of God mentioned in 7:10c–d. While he was still in his dream or vision, Daniel went up to one of the people (or angels) who were standing by the throne of God ready to serve him. Other ways to translate this include:

I went to someone who was standing there (GW)

So I approached one of those standing beside the throne (NLT)

those who were standing there: It is not clear if these beings were people or angels. Use the same interpretation that you used in 7:10c–d. In some languages it may be possible to avoid being specific by saying:

God's servants standing there

7:16b

and I asked him the true meaning of all this.

- and asked him what the entire vision meant.
- I asked him, "What does this whole vision symbolize/signify?"

and I asked him the true meaning of all this: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the true meaning of all this is literally "the truth concerning all this." Daniel wanted to know the truth about what his vision meant. He understood that the beasts and horns were symbols of something else, something real and true. He wanted to know what they signified. He was not implying that some of his vision was true and some was not true. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and asked him what it all meant (NLT)

and asked him to explain it all (GNT)

and enquired what all this really signified (REB)

General Comment on 7:16b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 7:16b as direct speech. For example:

I asked him, "What does this vision really mean?"

"What is the meaning of this whole vision?" I asked him.

7:16c

So he told me the interpretation of these things:

- So he explained what it meant, saying,
- So he told me the meaning of the images/visions I had seen. He said,

So he told me the interpretation of these things:

The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as he told me the interpretation of these things is literally "And he told me and he made known to me the interpretation of these things" (see the NIV). The two phrases refer to the same action, the servant's response to Daniel's question, so the BSB has combined them into one sentence. Together they introduce that response. Here are some other ways to translate this:

So he told me the meaning. He said... (GNT)

He explained it to me like this: (NLT)

Daniel 7:17

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:15–18

While still in a dreamlike state, Daniel asked about the meaning of what he had seen. God's servant briefly explained to Daniel the meaning of his dream. He gave a summary of what the vision symbolized.

7:17

'These four great beasts are four kings who will arise from the earth.

- "The four large beasts represent four kings who will rise to power in the world.

- “The four huge animals are symbols/symbolic of four earthly rulers.

These four great beasts are four kings who will arise from the earth: The servant of God explained that the four beasts represented four kings. The BSB says are four kings but the Aramaic text does not include a verb. It is implied by the context. In your translation, you should supply the verb that is natural in your language for explaining the meaning of symbols. For example:

These four huge beasts represent four kingdoms that will arise from the earth. (NLT)

four kings: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates literally as kings here refers to the kings who represent their respective empires. For this reason several English translations say “kingdoms” or “empires.” For example:

four empires (GNT)

four...kingdoms (CEV)

arise from the earth: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as arise from the earth indicates that these kings or kingdoms will have their origin in the human realm. They will be earthly rulers, ruling earthly kingdoms. Avoid implying that these kings will rise from their graves to rule. Here are some possible ways to translate this:

rise to power on the earth (GW)

arise on earth (GNT)

earthly kingdoms (CEV)

Daniel 7:18

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:15–18

While still in a dreamlike state, Daniel asked about the meaning of what he had seen. God’s servant briefly explained to Daniel the meaning of his dream. He gave a summary of what the vision symbolized.

7:18a

But the saints of the Most High will receive the kingdom

- But then/afterwards the people who belong to God Most High will receive from him authority/power over the kingdom,
- But finally God Most High will give his holy people the authority to rule his kingdom.

But the saints of the Most High will receive the kingdom: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as receive the kingdom refers to receiving power to rule. It is implied that the holy people (saints) will receive this power from God. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But the holy people who belong to the Most High God will receive the power to rule

But the Most High God will give to his people the kingly authority

But the holy people of the Most High will be given the kingdom (NLT)

But: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast to the previous verse part. Although the four beasts would rule in turn, finally God’s people will rule. Here is another way to translate this:

But in the end (CEV)

the saints of the Most High: The phrase the saints of the Most High is more literally “the holy ones of the Most High.” It means “the holy people who belong to God.”

the saints: The Aramaic text says “the holy ones.” These people are called saints because they are devoted to God and belong to him.

will receive the kingdom: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the kingdom here refers to the right and power to rule. Here is another way to translate this:

will receive the kingly power (REB)

7:18b

and possess it forever—yes, forever and ever.’

- and they will possess/keep it for all time, forever and ever.”
- They will rule there for all time, yes, for all ages to come.”

and possess it forever—yes, forever and ever: God’s holy ones will always possess the kingdom. That is, they will always have authority to rule. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and will take possession of the kingdom forever and ever (NET)

and kingship will be theirs for ever, for ever and ever (NJB)

and keep it for ever and ever (GW)

and they will rule forever and ever (CEV)

Daniel 7:19

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:19–22

Daniel received some more information about the fourth beast in the vision

7:19a

Then I wanted to know the true meaning of the fourth beast,

- ¶ Next I wanted to know what the fourth beast meant,
- ¶ Then I asked what the fourth creature represented/symbolized.

Then: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces Daniel’s next question. He had asked about the meaning of the beasts in general, but now he also wanted to know about the fourth beast in particular.

I wanted to know the true meaning of the fourth beast: The Aramaic is more literally “I desired to make certain concerning the fourth beast.” Daniel wanted to receive information about the fourth beast that he had seen. Since he had already received general information (7:17), another way to translate this is:

I wanted to know more about the fourth beast (GNT)

Here are some further ways to translate this:

I desired to know the truth concerning the fourth beast (RSV)

I wanted to know what the fourth animal represented/symbolized.

I wanted to learn the meaning of the fourth beast

7:19b

which was different from all the others—extremely terrifying—

- the beast that was not like the others, but was extremely horrifying.
- It was completely different from the other three creatures, being more terrible/terrifying,

which was different from all the others: The fourth beast was different from the other three beasts. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

It was different from all the other beasts

It was different from the other three creatures

was different from all the others: The fourth beast was different in its appearance. The following context implies that it appeared more impressive and terrifying than the other beasts. Here are some other ways to translate this:

which was not like any of the others (GNT)

it appeared different from the other beasts

extremely terrifying: This phrase probably indicates the way in which this beast was different from the other beasts.

7:19c

devouring and crushing with iron teeth and bronze claws,

- It had iron teeth and bronze jaws, and it crushed and ate its prey with them,

- for its teeth were made from iron and its jaws from bronze, and with them it tore other animals into pieces. Then it ate them,

devouring and crushing with iron teeth and bronze claws: This verse part indicates what made the fourth beast so terrifying: it had iron teeth and bronze claws. See the notes on iron teeth at 7:7d.

In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb here. For example:

and had iron teeth and bronze claws (NCV)

bronze claws: The bronze claws on the fourth beast are mentioned here for the first time. bronze is a strong metal with a reddish-brown color. See how you translated bronze at 2:32c.

7:19d
then trampling underfoot whatever was left.

- trampling/stamping on anything it had not eaten.
- and trod/crushed the leftovers/remains under its feet.

then trampling underfoot whatever was left: The Aramaic text is more literally “and the rest with its feet it was trampling.”

General Comment on 7:19a–d

In some languages it may be natural to translate this long sentence as two or more shorter sentences. For example:

^{19a}Then I wanted to know the truth about the fourth animal, ^{19b}which was so different from all the others. It was very terrifying ^{19c}and had iron teeth and bronze claws. It devoured and crushed its victims, ^{19d}and trampled whatever was left. (GW)

General Comment on 7:19c–d

In some languages it may be natural to translate 7:19c–d as a separate sentence. For example:

It was the animal that crushed and ate what it killed and then walked on whatever was left. (NCV)

Daniel 7:20

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings

explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:19–22

Daniel received some more information about the fourth beast in the vision

7:20a

I also wanted to know about the ten horns on its head

- And I wanted to learn/know the truth/meaning of the ten horns on its head
- I also asked about the ten horns that were on the fourth creature’s head.

I also wanted to know about the ten horns on its head: The BSB has supplied the words I also wanted to know. In the Aramaic text the same sentence continues: “and concerning the ten horns which on its head.”

You may follow this structure if it is more natural in your language. For example:

and about the ten horns that were on its head (ESV)

But in many languages it will be more natural to begin a new sentence here, as the BSB has done. For example:

I also wanted to know the meaning of the ten horns on its head (NET)

And I wanted to know about the ten horns on its head (GNT)

Daniel not only wanted to know about the horns, but, it is implied, he also asked about them. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

I also asked about the ten horns on the fourth beast’s head (NLT)

7:20b

and the other horn that came up,

- and the truth/meaning of the horn that came/grew up afterwards/later
- I particularly asked about the little horn, the one that appeared last.

7:20c

before which three of them fell—

- and made three of the other horns fall.

- It was this horn that removed/displaced three of the other/first horns.

7:20b–c

and the other horn that came up, before which three of them fell: Daniel also wanted to know, and therefore asked, about the final horn. This horn was not one of the ten but came up afterwards (see 7:8b–c). Here are some other ways to translate this;

and the horn that had come up afterward and had made three of the horns fall (GNT)

and about the little horn that grew there. It had pulled out three of the other ten horns (NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here:

I especially wanted to know more about the one that took the place of three of the others. (CEV)

I particularly/specifically asked about the horn that made three of the other horns fall/collapse.

7:20d

the horn whose appearance was more imposing than the others,

- This horn appeared more important than the other horns,
- It was more impressive than the previous horns.

the horn whose appearance was more imposing than the others: This is a comparison. Daniel compared the little horn to the other ten horns and indicated that its appearance was more imposing. The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as imposing is a general word often translated as “great.” In this context it refers to appearing important or powerful, rather than large. The little horn appeared to be more important or powerful than the other horns did. Indicate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

and looked greater than the others (NCV)

seeming to be very important, while the other horns seemed only a little important

whose appearance was more formidable than the others (NET)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

It was more terrifying than any of the others (GNT)

This horn had seemed greater than the others (NLT)

7:20e

with eyes and with a mouth that spoke words of arrogance.

- and it had eyes and a mouth that spoke proudly/arrogantly.
- On it were eyes and a mouth with which it made great boasts.

with eyes and with a mouth that spoke words of arrogance: Daniel referred back to the description of the little horn in 7:8e. See how you translated this description there. In some languages it may be good to translate this as a new sentence or independent clause. For example:

It had eyes and a mouth that kept bragging. (NCV)

and it had human eyes and a mouth that was boasting arrogantly (NLT)

General Comment on 7:20a–d

In some languages it may be natural to translate this long sentence as several shorter sentences. For example:

^{20a}I also wanted to know about the ten horns on its head ^{20b}and about the little horn that grew there. ^{20c}It had pulled out three of the other ten horns and looked greater than the others. ^{20d}It had eyes and a mouth that kept bragging. (NCV)

Daniel 7:21**Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts**

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:19–22

Daniel received some more information about the fourth beast in the vision

7:21a

As I watched,

- While I was watching,
- Then in my dream/vision I had seen

As I watched: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as As I watched indicates that Daniel continued to see images in a dream or vision. It introduces the next scene in Daniel's dream. Other ways to translate this include:

as I looked (NRSV)

as my dream continued, I saw...

then in my dream...

7:21b

this horn was waging war against the saints and prevailing against them,

- this horn fought God's holy people and began to defeat them.
- this final horn attacking and overcoming God's own people.

this horn was waging war against the saints and prevailing against them: In Daniel's dream, the final horn, the little horn that looked the most imposing, was fighting and overcoming God's people. Here is another way to translate this:

the little horn began making war against God's holy people and was defeating them (NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to combine the ideas of waging war against and prevailing against an enemy into a clause with one verb. For example:

the little horn was conquering the holy people

against the saints: Some English translations, such as the NRSV, say "with the holy people." The English preposition "with" here means against. The little horn attacked God's holy people.

the saints: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the saints is literally "the holy ones." In this context it refers to the people who belonged to God and were consecrated to him or set apart for him. See 7:18a and how you translated this there. Here is another way to translate this:

God's holy people (NLT)

Daniel 7:22

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:19–22

Daniel received some more information about the fourth beast in the vision

7:22a–b

until the Ancient of Days arrived and pronounced judgment in favor of the saints of the Most High:

The little horn continued to attack and conquer until the Ancient of Days came. Then both the conquest and the war ceased. Once God had come and given judgment, the little horn could no longer attack and conquer God's holy people.

In some languages it will be good to begin a new sentence here or in this verse part. For example:

Then the one who had been living forever came and pronounced judgment in favor of the people of the Supreme God (GNT)

until God, who has been alive forever, came. He judged in favor of the holy people who belong to the Most High God (NCV)

Then came the Ancient of Days, the Most High! He decided in favor of his own holy people

7:22a

until the Ancient of Days arrived

- The battle continued until the One who is ancient in years came
- But then the Ancient/Eternal God the Most High, came to his own people

the Ancient of Days arrived: See how you translated this way of referring to God in 7:9c and 7:13d. If you must say where the Ancient of Days came from, you should indicate that he came from his throne in heaven. If you must indicate where he came to, you should indicate that he came to earth, or to his people.

7:22b

and pronounced judgment in favor of the saints of the Most High,

- and he gave judgment in favor of the holy people, the people belonging to him, God Most High.
- and judged in their favor,

and pronounced judgment in favor of the saints of the Most High: God pronounced judgment in favor of his people. This means that he declared them to be innocent, or in the right. It is implied that he then saved them from the aggression of the final horn.

pronounced judgment: God acted as judge and issued his decision. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

judged

gave/declared his decision

the saints of the Most High: See how you translated this in 7:18a.

General Comment on 7:22a–b

Since the subject of the verbs in this verse part is the Ancient of Days, God himself, in some languages it may be necessary to say “his own people.” It is important to avoid the wrong meaning that the Ancient of Days is someone different from the Most High. It may be helpful to avoid this wrong meaning by following the NLT:

until the Ancient One—the Most High—came and judged in favor of his holy people (NLT)

7:22c

and the time came for them to possess the kingdom.

- Then the right time came and they received the power to rule.
- and so in God’s time they began to rule/reign over the land.

and the time came for them to possess the kingdom: It is implied that at this point the little horn was defeated. It had lost all its power to defeat God’s people and all its greatness and power to rule. Instead, God’s holy people possess the kingdom. This was the result of God’s coming and judgment. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this by saying:

and so the time came when God’s people possessed the kingdom

the time came: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the time came can also be translated as “the appointed time arrived.”

for them to possess the kingdom: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as for here introduces what happened when the time came. In some languages it may be possible to say:

for God’s people to possess the kingdom

them to possess the kingdom: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as them to possess the kingdom means “they received the authority to rule.” God gave his people the right and power to rule. The text does not state exactly what kingdom they ruled, whether it was the whole earth or one particular land, so it is best to leave this as general as possible. For example:

then the time came for them to receive the power to rule (NCV)

Then the time arrived for the holy people to take over the kingdom. (NLT)

The time had arrived for God’s people to receive royal power. (GNT)

Daniel 7:23

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:23–25

The servant of God explained to Daniel the symbolism of the fourth kingdom and its horns.

7:23a

This is what he said:

- This is what he said/replied to me:
- God’s servant then told me what this meant:

This is what he said: The servant of God who was explaining the meaning of the dream continued to talk to Daniel. The clause This is what he said introduces the continuation of the explanation of the meaning. Here are some other ways to introduce this:

This is the explanation I was given (GNT)

He gave me this explanation (NIV)

7:23b

The fourth beast is a fourth kingdom that will appear on the earth,

- “The fourth beast is/represents a fourth earthly kingdom
- “The fourth creature is a symbol of a fourth kingdom that will come to power in the world.

The fourth beast is a fourth kingdom that will appear on the earth: The speaker explained that the fourth beast represented a fourth kingdom. It functioned as a symbol for a kingdom. Here are some other ways to translate this:

As for the fourth beast, there shall be a fourth kingdom on earth (RSV)

The fourth beast means that there will be a fourth kingdom on earth (NET)

that will appear on the earth: The clause that will appear on the earth is literally “will be on the earth.” This indicates that this fourth kingdom would become powerful in the world of its time. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

that will arise on earth

that will gain power in the world

that will come on the earth (NCV)

7:23c

different from all the other kingdoms,

- that will be different from the other three kingdoms.
- It will not be like the previous three kingdoms.

different from all the other kingdoms: The Aramaic text indicates that this fourth kingdom will be different from the three kingdoms that the previous three beasts represented. The BSB has supplied the word other, and this may be helpful in many languages. Here are some other ways to translate this:

that will differ from all the other kingdoms (NET)

it will not be like the other three kingdoms

7:23d

and it will devour the whole earth,

- It will eat/swallow up the entire earth,

- instead, conquering the whole world,

7:23e

trample it down, and crush it.

- breaking and crushing everything.
- it will completely destroy it all.

7:23d–e

and it will devour the whole earth, trample it down, and crush it: This verse part probably indicates some of the ways in which the fourth kingdom was different from the others. It will dominate and destroy the whole earth. Here are some other ways to translate this:

It will devour all the earth and trample and crush it (NET)

and it shall devour the whole earth, and trample it down, and break it to pieces (RSV)

will devour...trample...and crush: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as will devour means “will eat, consume.” This is a figure of speech indicating that the beast will gain power over and destroy the earth. It has a similar meaning to the follow verbs, trample and crush. But the figures of speech are unclear or clashing. See also 7:7d and 7:19c–d. In these earlier verse parts the text indicates that the beast crushed the earth before devouring it and trampling on what was left. Here are some other ways to translate this:

will devour...trampling and crushing as it goes

It will devour...trampling and crushing everything in its path (NLT)

It will crush, devour, and trample on...

Daniel 7:24**Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts**

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:23–25

The servant of God explained to Daniel the symbolism of the fourth kingdom and its horns.

7:24a

And the ten horns are ten kings who will rise from this kingdom.

- The ten horns are/represent ten kings who will come to power in this kingdom.
- The ten horns are symbols of ten kings who will rule this fourth kingdom.

And the ten horns are ten kings who will rise from this kingdom: The servant of God explained that the ten horns represented ten rulers of this fourth kingdom. It is not stated explicitly, but is probably implied, that they will reign one after another. Here are some other ways to translate this:

As for the ten horns, out of this kingdom, ten kings shall arise (RSV)

The ten horns mean that ten kings will arise from that kingdom. (NET)

The ten horns are ten kings who will rule that empire. (GNT)

7:24b

After them another king,

- Afterwards another king will take power
- After they have reigned/ruled, a new king will begin to rule.

7:24c

different from the earlier ones,

- who will be different from the previous/former kings,
- He will not be like the others.

7:24d

will rise and subdue three kings.

- and he will bring/put down three of them
- He will remove/overthrow three of the first kings.

7:24b–d

After them another king, different from the earlier ones, will rise: There is implied information here: the final horn represents another king, an eleventh. This king will be different in some way from the others, in the same way that the final horn was different from the other horns (7:19b). Here are some other ways to translate this:

Another king will rise to power after them. He will be different from the kings who came to power before him (GW)

Another king will arise after them, but he will be different from the earlier ones. (NET)

Then another king will appear; he will be very different from the earlier ones (GNT)

and subdue three kings: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as subdue means “bring low, humble.” In this context it indicates that he will defeat these kings. He will bring them down from their high position, causing them to lose their power. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and will bring down three kings (NJB)

and will overthrow three kings (GNT)

and it will conquer three other kings (CEV)

Daniel 7:25

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:23–25

The servant of God explained to Daniel the symbolism of the fourth kingdom and its horns.

7:25a

He will speak out against the Most High

- He will speak evil of the Most High God
- He will insult/blaspheme God Most High

He will speak out against the Most High: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as speak out against is more literally “he will speak words against the Most High.” It indicates that the ruler will say bad things, lies, about God. Here are some other ways to translate this:

This king will speak evil of God Most High (CEV)

This king will blaspheme the Most High God.

See also Revelation 13:6.

the Most High: This is a title of the one true God. It indicates that he is supreme over anything and anyone else. In your translation, avoid implying that there also exist lesser gods. See how you translated it in 3:26b, 4:2b, and 5:18a. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that it is a title of God. For example:

the Most High God (GW)

the Supreme God (GNT)

7:25b

and oppress the saints of the Most High,

- and will persecute his holy people.
- and will harass/attack those people who belong to him

and oppress the saints of the Most High: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as oppress means to “wear out.” Here it can mean to wear down, harass, or persecute. See also Revelation 13:7. Other ways to translate this include:

He will harass the holy ones of the Most High continually (NET)

and he will be cruel to God’s chosen ones (CEV)

and he will hurt and kill God’s holy people (NCV)

7:25c

intending to change the appointed times and laws;

- He will want/plan to change the religious festivals and the laws.
- He will attempt to alter their religious calendar and their laws.

intending to change the appointed times and laws:

The Aramaic text says “he will think to change appointed times and law.” This probably indicates that the king will want to change the established feasts/festivals and the religious laws. He will make an attempt to do this. The text does not indicate if he will succeed, and it is best not to make this explicit. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and plan to change the appointed times and laws (GW)

He will try to change their sacred festivals and laws (NLT)

the appointed times and laws: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the appointed times refers to the Jewish feasts and festivals. These took place according to the Jewish calendar and were established in accordance with Jewish law. In some languages it

may be more natural to reverse the order of the two phrases and say:

their religious laws and festivals (GNT)

God’s Law and the sacred seasons (CEV)

7:25d

and the saints will be given into his hand for a time, and times, and half a time.

- The holy people will be under his power for a time, two times, and half of a time.
- For three and a half periods of time, he will have power over the people who belong to God.

and the saints will be given into his hand for a time, and times, and half a time: This verse part indicates both that God would allow the evil king to get power over the holy people, and that the king would use this power for a certain set time. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this using two verbs. For example:

and God’s people will be delivered into his power and he will rule/domineer over them for a time, times, and half a time

and the saints will be given into his hand: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as the saints will be given into his hand is literally “they will be given into his hand.” This is an idiom that here indicates that this evil king will be given power over God’s holy people. God will allow him to oppress and persecute them. See how you translated this idiom in 1:2a and in other books such as Mark 9:31, Deuteronomy 3:2 and Joshua 8:1. Here are some ways to translate it in this context:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and they shall be given into his power (NRSV)

The holy people will be handed over to him (GW)

- Using an active verb. For example:

The holy people that belong to God will be in that king’s power (NCV)

God’s people will be/suffer under the control of that king

He will have/exercise power over the holy people

for a time, and times, and half a time: The phrase for a time, and times, and half a time indicates that the king would hold power over God's people for a certain and limited period of time. Some scholars believe that it means three and a half years (see the GNT and CEV footnote). See also 4:16c and Revelation 12:14c. Translate it here as you did there.

Daniel 7:26

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:26–27

This final evil ruler will lose his power. God's people will begin to rule in God's kingdom.

7:26a

But the court will convene,

- ¶ “But the members of the court will sit on their thrones and begin to judge,
- ¶ “Then the judges will take their seats/places in court to give their judgment/verdict.

But the court will convene: The members of the court, the judges, will take their places in order to begin judging. See how you translated this idea in 7:10d. For example:

But the court shall sit in judgment (ESV)

Then the heavenly court will sit in judgment (GNT)

But then the judges will take their places/seats in court

In some cultures judges in courts may not sit down, and translating this idea may distract from the main point, the act of judging. In those languages you may wish to translate the function of the action and say:

But the court will decide what should happen. (NCV)

But then the court will pass judgment (NLT)

7:26b

and his dominion will be taken away and completely destroyed forever.

- They will take away the power of that king. They will destroy it and bring it to an end!
- They will put a complete end to his rule/authority for all time.

and his dominion will be taken away: The Aramaic text is more literally “and they will remove his power/dominion to destroy.” The subject is the members of the court, the judges. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

and his ruling authority will be removed (NET)

and all his power will be taken away (NLT)

- Using an active verb. For example:

the heavenly court will...take away his power (GNT)

and completely destroyed forever: The Aramaic text is more literally: “to annihilate and destroy it until the end.” The two verbs “annihilate” and “destroy” are synonyms in this context and together they emphasize the idea. The BSB has combined them into one emphatic phrase, and this may be a good model to follow in some languages. Here is another way to translate this:

destroyed and abolished forever (NET)

Daniel 7:27

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:26–27

This final evil ruler will lose his power. God's people will begin to rule in God's kingdom.

7:27a

Then the sovereignty, dominion, and greatness of the kingdoms under all of heaven will be given to the people, the saints of the Most High.

- Then the holy people of God Most High will receive authority/power to rule. They will be great and will rule over all the kingdoms on earth.
- Then God Most High will give to his own holy people the right/authority to rule every nation on earth. They will have great power and everyone will honor them.

Then: The Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here means “at that time.” It does not refer to some indefinite later time.

the sovereignty, dominion, and greatness of the kingdoms under all of heaven will be given to the people, the saints of the Most High: God’s people will receive all the power and kingly majesty that the evil horn had possessed. The phrase will be given is passive. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

The kingly power, sovereignty, and greatness of all the kingdoms under heaven will be given to the holy people of the Most High. (REB)

the kingdom, authority, and greatness of the kingdoms under all of heaven will be delivered to the people of the holy ones of the Most High (NET)

- Using an active verb. For example:

the holy people of the Most High will receive the right to rule all the kingdoms of the world

the holy people who belong to the Most High God will have the power to rule. They will rule over all the kingdoms under heaven with power and greatness (NCV)

the sovereignty, dominion, and greatness: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as the sovereignty is literally “the kingdom.” The three nouns sovereignty, dominion, and greatness together indicate that God’s people will have the right, authority, and ability to rule. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea without abstract nouns. For example:

they will be the rulers...the strongest...the greatest

they will rule powerfully and gloriously

all will submit to them, obey them, and honor them

the kingdoms under all of heaven: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB literally translates as the kingdoms under all of heaven refers to all nations on earth, whether they are ruled by a king, emperor, or president.

the people, the saints of the Most High: The Aramaic phrase that the BSB translates as the people, the saints of the Most High is more literally “the people of the holy ones of the Most High.” This expression refers to God’s people, those who belong to him. See how you translated the similar phrase (“the holy ones of the Most High”) in 7:18a, 7:22a-b.

7:27b

His kingdom will be an everlasting kingdom,

- The kingdom of the Most High will last/endure forever,
- The Most High God will rule/reign for all time,

His kingdom will be an everlasting kingdom: There is a problem of interpretation here. The Hebrew singular pronoun that the BSB translates as His can refer either to the Most High God or to the people as a collective entity. The two possibilities are:

1. it refers to God the Most High. For example:

His kingdom is an eternal kingdom (NET) (BSB, NIV, NASB, NET, NLT, CEV)

1. it refers to the people of God. For example:

and their power to rule will last forever (NCV) (RSV/NRSV, NCV, ESV, REB, GW, GNT)

The KJV and NJB are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The most natural referent of the pronoun translated as His is to the Most High at the end of 7:27a. Other ways to translate this include:

His kingdom will last forever (NLT)

His kingdom will be eternal (CEV)

He will reign as king for all time

7:27c

and all rulers will serve and obey Him.’

- and all human authorities will serve him and obey him.”
- and all earthly rulers/authorities will worship him and submit to him.”

and all rulers will serve and obey Him: Again there is a difference in interpretation. The Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as Him is singular but it can be understood in one of two ways:

1. as referring to God. For example:

all rulers will serve and obey him (NLT) (BSB, KJV, NIV, NASB, NET, NLT, CEV)

1. as referring to God’s people, collectively. For example:

People from all the other kingdoms will respect and serve them (NCV) (RSV/NRSV, NCV, ESV, REB, GNT, GW)

The NJB is again ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Aramaic verb that the BSB translates as serve is normally used of rendering service to a deity, rather than to rulers (see 3:12d, 3:18c, 6:16d, 3:20b).

all rulers: The Aramaic word that the BSB translates as rulers can also be translated as “realms, empires.” In the singular it normally means “dominion, sovereignty.” Here it probably refers to those who have power within every realm or nation.

Daniel 7:28

Section 7:1–28 Daniel dreamed about four beasts

Daniel had a vision of four beasts on earth and of God on his throne in heaven. One of the heavenly beings explained to Daniel that the four beasts represented four earthly kingdoms.

Paragraph 7:28

This verse forms the conclusion of this section.

7:28a

Thus ends the matter.

- ¶ Here the account of the dream ends/concludes.
- ¶ I, Daniel, have finished describing the vision.

Thus ends the matter: This clause indicates that the vision report that began in 7:1 had concluded. Here are some other ways to translate this:

That was the end of the vision. (NLT)

This is the end of the account. (GNT)

7:28b

As for me, Daniel, my thoughts troubled me greatly,

- Thinking about the dream, I, Daniel, was very alarmed.
- I became very disturbed as I thought about it.

As for me, Daniel, my thoughts troubled me greatly:

This phrase indicates that Daniel was worried and concerned because of his thoughts about the vision he had just seen. There are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- As an active clause, as in the Aramaic text. For example:

As for me, Daniel, my thoughts greatly alarmed me. (RSV)

As for me, Daniel, my thoughts troubled me greatly (NET)

- As a passive clause. For example:

I, Daniel, was terrified by my thoughts (GW)

Use the form that is most natural in your language.

7:28c

and my face turned pale.

- I turned pale,
- My face became white,

and my face turned pale: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as my face turned pale is more literally “my brightness changed on me.” See how you translated this in 5:6a. Here are some other ways to translate it:

and I turned pale (GW)

and my face was pale with fear (NLT)

General Comment on 7:28b–c

In some languages it may be natural to make the connection between 7:28b and 7:28c clear by speaking of a cause and an effect. For example:

^{28b}I was so frightened ^{28c}that I turned pale (GNT)

7:28d**But I kept the matter to myself.”**

- but I kept the dream secret/hidden.
- but I did not tell anyone what I had seen in the vision.

But: The common Aramaic conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces what Daniel did after seeing the vision. The English versions translate it in one of two ways:

1. It introduces a contrast. Even though Daniel was very upset at the vision, he told no one what he had seen. For example:

but (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NIV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB, NET, NJB, NCV, KJV)

1. It introduces a continuation. For example:

and (GNT) (GNT, CEV)

You should introduce Daniel's reaction in a way that is natural in your language. In many languages it will be natural to indicate a contrast to what one would expect.

I kept the matter to myself: The Aramaic text that the BSB translates as I kept the matter to myself is literally “I kept the matter in my heart.” In this context it indicates that Daniel kept his dream/vision and its meaning to himself. He did not tell anyone else about it. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I kept these things to myself (NLT)

I kept everything to myself (GNT)

I told no one what I had seen/learned.

This is the end of the Aramaic section of the book of Daniel.

Daniel 8:1**Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat**

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two

horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part

of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:1–2

This paragraph gives the setting of this new vision.

8:1a

In the third year of the reign of King Belshazzar,

- ¶ When King Belshazzar was in the third year of his reign,
- ¶ During the third year that Belshazzar was king of Babylonia,
- ¶ After King Belshazzar had ruled in Babylon for more than two years,

In the third year of the reign of King Belshazzar: See the Notes at 1:1a; 2:1a. This phrase indicates when the events of this chapter happened. Belshazzar was in his third year as king of Babylon. Goldingay (Daniel, 208) suggests the date 548/547 B.C. Baldwin (Daniel, 155) has 550/549. The NET and NIV notes suggest 551 B.C. So the events in this chapter, like the events of chapter 7, happened before the events in chapter 5. Here are some other ways to translate this opening phrase:

In Belshazzar's third year as king (GW)

In the third year that Belshazzar was king (GNT)

Belshazzar ruled as king of Babylonia for over two years. Then

reign: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as reign here refers to the period of time when Belshazzar was the king of Babylonia. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this idea with a verb. For example:

when Belshazzar ruled in/over Babylon

8:1b

a vision appeared to me, Daniel,

- I, Daniel, saw a vision.
- another vision came/appeared to me, to Daniel,
- this writer, that is, Daniel, saw a second vision.

a vision appeared to me, Daniel: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as:

I, Daniel, saw a vision (GW)

a vision appeared to me, Daniel (RSV)

vision: In English, a vision is like a dream. It is something that a person sees, but not with his normal sight. It differs from a dream in that a person does not have to be asleep to see a vision. In Daniel the Hebrew words that the BSB translates as “dream” and vision are often used interchangeably. See Daniel 4:5a, b. Translate using the word that most naturally communicates this meaning in your language.

me, Daniel: This phrase emphasizes that it was Daniel himself who was telling the story. In some languages, it may not be natural to use both the name and the pronoun.

In order to make it clear that Daniel was the writing these words, the CEV begins the chapter with the phrase: “Daniel wrote:”.

8:1c

subsequent to the one that had appeared to me earlier.

- This vision followed/succeeded the vision I had seen previously.
- two years after the first vision.
- It was a successor/sequel to the one I had seen two years earlier.

subsequent to the one that had appeared to me earlier:

This clause means that the vision recorded in Daniel 8 came to him after the vision that Daniel saw in Daniel 7. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence. For example:

This vision came after the one I saw earlier (GW)

I saw this vision after the one I had seen before.

This clause repeats information from 8:1b. The repetition implies that this second vision was different but related to the previous one.

the one that had appeared to me earlier: Daniel was referring to the vision he had described in chapter 7. In some languages it may be necessary to be more precise. For example:

the one I saw two years earlier

the vision I saw/had during Belshazzar's first year as king

General Comment on 8:1a–c

In some languages the repetition may not be natural. In that case, it may be possible to combine and simplify the information in these three verse parts. For example:

In the third year that Belshazzar was king, I saw a second vision. (GNT)

I saw a second vision in the third year that Belshazzar was king.

Daniel 8:2

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:1–2

This paragraph gives the setting of this new vision.

8:2a

And in the vision I saw myself in the citadel of Susa, in the province of Elam.

- As I was watching/having the vision, I saw that I was in the walled city of Susa, which is in the province of Elam.
- In this vision I suddenly found myself in the fortified city of Susa, in Elam province.
- In the vision I was within the walls of Susa city in Elam province,

And in the vision I saw myself in the citadel of Susa:

The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as in the vision I saw myself in the citadel of Susa is more literally “and I saw in the vision and it happened as I was looking I was in Susa the citadel.” This complex introduction to the vision narrative emphasizes its

importance. Many English translations simplify this introduction. For example:

In this vision I saw myself in Susa, the citadel (NET)

In the vision I was at the fortress of Susa (NLT)

You should introduce what Daniel saw in his vision in a way that is natural in your language. Try to use a style that indicates the importance of what is to come, the dream narrative.

I saw myself: Daniel indicated that he himself was present in the vision. There are different ways to translate this idea. For example:

I suddenly found myself (GNT)

I was (NLT)

I knew/believed myself to be

in the citadel of Susa: This is more literally “I was in Susa the citadel.” This probably indicates that Susa itself was a citadel, a fortified city. See the footnote in the NET. Here is another way to translate this:

the walled city of Susa (GNT)

Susa: The Hebrew spelling of this word is “Shushan,” as in the KJV. Susa is the Greek form of the name. Either spelling is acceptable. You may wish to spell this the same way as it is spelled in the national language.

in the province of Elam: Susa was the capital of the province called Elam. This was in the southwest part of what is now Iran. See Genesis 10:22, where Elam is listed as one of the sons of Shem. There are different ways to translate this. For example:

in Elam province

in the district of Elam

which is located in the province of Elam (NET)

province: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as province refers to a large unit of government. Other ways to translate it include:

district

area (NCV)

8:2b

I saw in the vision that I was beside the Ulai Canal.

- I saw that I was by the Ulai canal.
- I was conscious/aware that I was next to the Ulai river.
- standing on the bank of the waterway called the Ulai.

In the Hebrew text this verse part begins with the common Hebrew conjunction that is often translated as “and.” In this context it introduces a more exact explanation of where Daniel was.

I saw in the vision that I was beside the Ulai Canal:

The Hebrew words that the BSB literally translates as I saw in the vision repeat information from 8:2a. This repetition may not be natural in some languages, and some ancient and modern versions omit it. However it is present in the MT. The repetition emphasizes that Daniel was not physically present by the canal, but only in his dream. Repeat as much information as necessary to make that clear. For example:

and I saw in the vision, and I was at the river Ulai (RSV)

I was standing by the Ulai River (GNT)

I was beside the Ulai Canal: Daniel sensed himself to be by the Ulai Canal. He was not actually there, physically. In his dream he was aware that he was looking at events as though he were there. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I saw myself at the Ulai Canal (NET)

I was standing by the Ulai Canal. (NCV)

the Ulai Canal: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Canal here refers to an artificial or manmade stream. The NJB has “gate,” but this is based on some ancient translations (LXX, Syriac, and Vulgate) rather than the Hebrew. This canal flowed near the north of the city of Susa. Use the word that is appropriate in your language. The fact that this was an artificial waterway is not in focus, so in some languages it may be most natural to follow the RSV and say:

river (RSV)

Daniel 8:3

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

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Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

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The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things.

For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:3–4

In his vision, Daniel first saw a powerful ram with two horns.

8:3a

Then I lifted up my eyes and saw a ram

- Then I saw/noticed in front of me one ram
- A male sheep appeared before me,

Then I lifted up my eyes and saw a ram: The Hebrew text is more literally “And I lifted up my eyes and I saw, lo/behold, one ram.” The verbs lifted up and saw calls attention to the ram and introduces the beginning of the vision. It does not indicate that Daniel was looking down before the appearance of the ram. Emphasize what Daniel saw in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

I noticed a ram

there appeared before me a ram

a ram came into view/sight

a ram: The Hebrew text is more literally “one ram.” Here is another way to translate this:

a single ram (GW)

A ram is a male sheep with horns. If you do not have a specific word for such an animal, you may say

a male sheep (NCV)

8:3b

with two horns standing beside the canal.

- and it had two horns. It was standing by the canal.
- one with two horns. It stood on the bank of the river.

with two horns standing beside the canal: The BSB has reversed the order of the two Hebrew phrases. The Hebrew says, “standing before/beside the canal, and it had two horns.” The fact that this ram had two horns was not unusual in any way. Use the order which is most natural in your language. Other ways to translate this include:

standing on the bank of the river. It had two horns (RSV)

standing there with two horns on its head (CEV)

8:3c

The horns were long,

- Its horns were long.
- The horns were both tall/high,

The horns were long: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as long can also be translated as “high,” as in the RSV. Try to use a word that suggests importance or power. Other ways to translate this include:

Its two horns were both long (NET)

both of them were long (CEV)

He held his horns high

General Comment on 8:3b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 8:3b–c. For example:

^{3b–c}with two long horns standing beside the river (NLT)

8:3d

but one was longer than the other, and the longer one grew up later.

- The longer horn grew/came up after the other.
- but the second horn was taller/higher than the first.

but one was longer than the other, and the longer one grew up later: The second horn became longer, or

higher, than the first horn. This implies that it became more powerful. This was contrary to expectation, and the GW translates this as:

one longer than the other, though the longer one had grown up later (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two clauses into one. For example:

but the second one was longer than the first (CEV)

the latter horn exceeded the former horn

In other languages it may be natural to translate this as two independent clauses or sentences. For example:

but one was longer than the other. The longer one was coming up after the shorter one. (NET)

The horns were both long/high, but the second horn exceeded the first in length/height.

Daniel 8:4

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:3–4

In his vision, Daniel first saw a powerful ram with two horns.

8:4a

I saw the ram charging toward the west and the north and the south.

- I saw the ram charging westward, northward, and southward.

- I watched/observed the ram as it ran to attack the lands in the west, the north, and the south.
- The ram was butting everything out of its way in the west, the north, and the south.

I saw the ram charging toward the west and the north and the south: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as charging here indicates that the ram pushed or thrust with its horns as it attacked other animals. The object of the verb charging is left implicit, but is implied by the following verse part, “No animal could stand against him” (8:4b). Use a verb that describes the way an animal such as a goat pushes with its horns. For example:

The ram butted everything out of his way to the west, to the north, and to the south. (NLT)

I saw the ram: The idea that Daniel was watching the ram is implied from the context and the introductory sentence in 8:3a. In your translation, it is possible to leave this implied (as the NLT has done) or to say:

As I was watching, the ram...

I saw that the ram was... (NET)

8:4b

No animal could stand against him,

- No other animal could resist/oppose/stop it/him
- None of the other animals could defend themselves,
- All the other beasts were helpless to protect themselves.

No animal could stand against him: The Hebrew text uses the plural form: “all/any animals not stood before it.” Use either the singular or plural, whichever is more natural in your language. The point is that no other animal could resist this ram. The ram was more powerful than all the other animals, and it overcame and defeated them. Other ways to translate this include:

All beasts were powerless to withstand it (NRSV)

No animal could stop him (GNT)

No other animals were strong enough to oppose him (CEV)

8:4c

and there was no deliverance from his power.

- or save another animal from its/his power.
- There was no one to deliver/protect them from its power.
- Nor could they protect/defend one another from the ram.

and there was no deliverance from his power: The Hebrew is more literally “and there was not anyone delivering from its hand.” As often, the word “hand” is a metaphor meaning power. This indicates that no animal was able to help the other animals withstand the ram. Other ways to translate this include:

or help his victims (NLT)

and none could save another animal from his power (NCV)

8:4d

He did as he pleased and became great.

- So the ram did whatever he wanted to do and became very powerful.
- So it did anything it pleased and grew strong/mighty.

He did as he pleased: The ram acted in whatever way it chose, attacking wherever he wanted. Here is another way to translate this:

He did whatever he wanted (NCV)

and became great: The Hebrew word for became great is a general one (literally, “it magnified itself” or “made itself great”). Scholars have interpreted this in two ways:

1. it refers to increasing in power. For example:

and became strong (NRSV) (NRSV, NJB, NIV, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. it refers to pride and arrogance. For example:

and grew arrogant (GNT) (GNT, NET)

The BSB could support either interpretation (1) or (2). In the Hebrew, the idea is probably that of becoming more and more powerful, as in interpretation (1). Avoid using a verb that suggests growth in virtue or nobility. The verb is used in a negative sense. The ram pushed and bullied other animals to get more power for itself.

Daniel 8:5

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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Paragraph 8:5–7

In Daniel's vision a male goat appeared and attacked the ram.

8:5a

As I was contemplating all this,

- ¶ While I was thinking about this,
- ¶ While I was paying attention to what was happening,

As I was contemplating all this: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as *As I was contemplating all this* indicates that Daniel was paying attention to what was happening in his dream. The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *contemplating* can include the ideas of both observing and considering something. Use the verb that is most natural for referring to paying attention to something that is happening in a dream. There is no explicit object, and the BSB has supplied the words *all this*. Here are some other ways to translate this:

While I was contemplating all this (NET)

While I was watching this (NCV)

8:5b

suddenly a goat with a prominent horn between his eyes came out of the west,

- I saw a he-goat coming from the west. It had a big/conspicuous horn between its eyes.
- suddenly there appeared in the west a male goat with a long horn between its eyes.

suddenly a goat with a prominent horn between his eyes came out of the west: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *suddenly* calls attention to something surprising or important. Call attention to the appearance of the goat in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

there appeared a goat, coming from the west, a great horn protruding between its eyes

look! a goat came prancing from the west, a long horn on its forehead

a goat: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as *a goat* refers to a male goat. The English words for male goat (*buck*, *billy*) are not in common use, so the NLT says:

a male goat (NLT)

a prominent horn between his eyes: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *prominent* describes something that can easily be seen, that is, is conspicuous or noticeable. Here is another way to translate this:

a conspicuous horn between his eyes (ESV)

came out of the west: The goat came out of the west from the point of view of someone in Persia. The goat is said in 8:21 to represent Greece, which is west of Persia.

8:5c

crossing the surface of the entire earth without touching the ground.

- It traveled across the entire earth so quickly that it did not even touch the ground.
- It rushed/bounded all the way to the east. It ran/moved so fast that its feet did not seem/appear to touch the ground.

crossing the surface of the entire earth without touching the ground: The goat quickly moved across the earth from the west to the east, where Daniel was situated. It approached at such a great speed that it appeared that its feet did not even touch the ground. The GNT makes this explicit:

moving so fast that his feet didn't touch the ground (GNT)

General Comment on 8:25a–c

The BSB and some other English versions have re-ordered the Hebrew clauses. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Hebrew order of clauses and information, as the NRSV has done:

As I was considering, behold, a he-goat came from the west across the face of the whole earth, without touching the ground; and the goat had a conspicuous horn between his eyes. (NRSV)

Daniel 8:6

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

Some versions have two headings within this section. For example:

NET Daniel Has a Vision of a Goat and a Ram (8:1)

An Angel Interprets Daniel's Vision (8:15)

NRSV Vision of a Ram and a Goat (8:1)

Gabriel Interprets the Vision (8:15)

GNT Daniel's Vision of a Ram and a Goat

The Angel Gabriel Explains the Vision (8:15)

BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:5–7

In Daniel's vision a male goat appeared and attacked the ram.

8:6a

He came toward the two-horned ram I had seen standing beside the canal

- It came toward the ram which had two horns, which I had seen by the bank of the canal.
- The goat approached the two-horned ram that I had seen previously,

He came toward the two-horned ram I had seen standing beside the canal: The goat came from the west toward the canal, where the ram was standing. Other ways to translate this include:

It approached the two-horned ram which I had seen standing by the canal (REB)

headed toward the two-horned ram that I had seen standing beside the river (NLT)

8:6b**and rushed at him with furious power.**

- It was very angry and rushed toward the ram.
- preparing to attack him with great fury.

and rushed at him with furious power: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as rushed at is literally “ran.” Use the verb that is appropriate for an aggressive horned animal running toward another animal as it gets ready to attack. For example;

and he ran at him in his powerful wrath (ESV)

and rushed against it with raging strength

with furious power: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as with furious power is more literally “in the rage of its strength.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

in the full force of its fury (NJB)

with savage force (NRSV)

General Comment on 8:6a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in these verse parts into one clause with one main verb. For example:

and with tremendous anger the goat started toward the ram that I had seen beside the river (CEV)

In his anger the goat charged the sheep with the two horns that I had seen standing by the canal (NCV)

Daniel 8:7**Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat**

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high

as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate

these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:5–7

In Daniel's vision a male goat appeared and attacked the ram.

8:7a

I saw him approach the ram in a rage against him,

- I saw the goat advance closer to the ram. The goat was angry.
- Then I saw him angrily charge at the ram.

I saw him approach the ram in a rage against him:

Daniel saw the goat attack the ram. Consider how it is most natural to refer to the goat in this context. For example:

I watched him attack the ram. He was so angry that... (GNT)

I watched the angry goat attack the sheep (NCV)

8:7b

and he struck the ram and shattered his two horns.

- It struck the ram with this horn and broke its two horns.
- He hit/butted the ram on the head and smashed/shattered his two horns into pieces.

and he struck the ram and shattered his two horns:

The goat hit the ram with its one horn, breaking both the horns of the ram. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and struck him, breaking off his two horns (NLT)

he smashed into him and broke the two horns (GNT)

8:7c

The ram was powerless to stand against him,

- The ram was not strong enough to oppose/resist it.
- The ram was helpless to stop him.

The ram was powerless to stand against him:

The Hebrew more literally says, "and there was no strength in the ram to stand before it." This indicates that the ram was not able to protect itself from the goat. Without its horns, it could not defend itself and was defeated. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and the ram had no strength to withstand him (NASB)

Now the ram was helpless (NLT)

so that the ram was not strong enough to hold its ground (REB)

8:7d

and the goat threw him to the ground and trampled him,

- Then the goat pushed/shoved the ram to the ground and trampled on it.
- Then the goat forced the ram to the ground and trod/walked all over him.

and the goat threw him to the ground and trampled him:

The goat completely defeated the ram. It forced it to the ground and repeatedly stepped or trod on it so that it could not stand up again. This is an image of one nation defeating another. Here are some other ways to translate this:

it threw the ram down to the ground and trampled upon it (NRSV)

The goat hurled the ram to the ground and trampled it (NET)

8:7e

and no one could deliver the ram from his power.

- No one could protect the ram from the powerful goat.
- No one could save/defend the ram.

and no one could deliver the ram from his power:

The Hebrew text is more literally "and no one was delivering the ram from its hand." As in 8:4c the "hand" is a figure of speech meaning "power, control." Here are some other ways to translate this:

no one was there to rescue the ram (NJB)

and there was no one who could save him (GNT)

General Comments on 8:6–7

In these verses it is good to use vocabulary that can be used either of animals or of world powers. For example, in English the verb phrase "throw down" can be more easily understood as referring to a world power than can the phrase "knock down." Using an

expression like this may help your readers understand that the dream had reference to political authorities rather than actual animals.

It is important to make it clear when the ram is referred to, and when the goat. Avoid using the pronouns “it” or “he” if the referent is not clear.

Daniel 8:8

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

8:8a

Thus the goat became very great,

- ¶ As a result, the goat became very powerful.
- ¶ So the goat made itself more and more powerful/strong.

Thus the goat became very great: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as became very great is more literally “magnified itself to the extreme.” See how you translated the same verb in 8:4d. Here too this statement has negative implications: the goat was acting wrongly, proudly. He did not become great in a good way. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The he-goat then grew more powerful than ever (NJB)

The male goat became very important (GW)

8:8b

but at the height of his power, his large horn was broken off,

- but when he was at his most powerful, his large horn broke/snapped.

- However, when it was extremely strong, its big horn suddenly broke/fell off.

but at the height of his power, his large horn was broken off: Scholars agree that the large horn is a reference to the Greek king Alexander the Great. He died suddenly in 323 B.C. after conquering large territories as far away as Egypt and India.

at the height of his power: The Hebrew more literally says “just as it became mighty.”

his large horn was broken off: This is a passive clause. The actor is not named. As you translate this, bear in mind that Alexander the Great died from a sudden illness rather than being killed in battle. No human being killed him. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

the large horn was broken (NASB)

- using an active verb. For example:

its great horn broke (REB)

the great horn snapped (NJB)

the large horn fell off

8:8c

and four prominent horns came up in its place,

- Then, in its place, four prominent horns came up.
- Four tall/long horns grew up where it had been.

8:8d

pointing toward the four winds of heaven.

- Each horn grew in a different direction—north, south, east, and west.
- One pointed to the north, one to the south, one to the east, and one to the west.

8:8c-d

and four prominent horns came up in its place, pointing toward the four winds of heaven:

Alexander's empire was broken into four parts, each with a different ruler. The phrase toward the four winds of heaven here probably indicates that the horns pointed in the direction of the four winds: north, south, east, and west. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and in its place sprouted four majestic horns, pointing to the four winds of heaven (NJB)

and in place of this there came up four prominent horns pointing towards the four quarters of heaven (REB)

and there arose four conspicuous horns in its place, extending toward the four winds of the sky (NET)

General Comment on 8:8a–d

In some languages it may be natural to break this long sentence into two or more shorter sentences. For example:

The goat became very powerful. But at the height of his power, his large horn was broken off. In the large horn's place grew four prominent horns pointing in the four directions of the earth. (NLT)

The male goat became very important. But when the goat became powerful, its large horn broke off. In its place grew four horns. They corresponded to the four winds of heaven. (GW)

Daniel 8:9

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:9–12

A small horn grew to become powerful and very evil.

8:9a

From one of these horns a little horn emerged

- ¶ From one of these horns there appeared/arose another horn. It was small,

- ¶ Then a little horn came/grew out from one of those four horns.

From one of these horns a little horn emerged:

There is a problem here. There are two ways to understand the MT, which reads “and from one of them one horn came out from a small thing it became great”:

1. Many English versions understand this to mean that the new horn started out small. For example:

Out of one of the horns came a small horn (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV/NRSV, GNT, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some English versions understand the text to mean that one of the four original horns was small. For example:

From one of these, the small one, sprang a horn (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the great majority of English versions.

8:9b

and grew extensively toward the south and the east and toward the Beautiful Land.

- but it grew long/big toward the south, toward the east and toward the land that is lovely/fair.
- It became very great/powerful in the south and in the east, and even in the beautiful land of Judah.

and grew extensively toward the south and the east and toward the Beautiful Land:

This small horn grew large and powerful. It gained power over lands to the south and east, and even the Beautiful Land, that is, the land of Israel or Judah.

But it grew to be very big, toward the south and the east and toward the beautiful land. (NET)

whose power came to reach/extend to the south and the east and even to the Beautiful Land

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two clauses. For example:

it grew great/big and gained power over the lands in the south and the east and even over the beautiful land.

and it became very big. It grew toward the south, the east, and toward the beautiful land of Judah. (NCV)

whose power grew very great. It extended toward the south and the east and toward the glorious land of Israel. (NLT)

grew extensively: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as grew extensively is more literally “became great.” Here it indicates that the horn appeared to grow both large and powerful.

the Beautiful Land: The phrase that the BSB translates as the Beautiful Land is literally “and to the beauty.” Scholars agree that this is a reference to the land of Judah or Israel. Other ways to translate it include:

the Land of Splendour (NJB)

the Glorious Land

the Magnificent Land of Israel

Daniel 8:10

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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Paragraph 8:9–12

A small horn grew to become powerful and very evil.

8:10b

and it cast down some of the host and some of the stars to the earth,

- It tossed/pulled to the ground some of heaven’s army, yes, some of the stars,
- It attacked some of the stars, some of God’s army, causing them to fall to the earth.

8:10a-b

Scholars disagree as to the symbolism of the host of the heavens and the starry host, and their relationship to one another.

1. Some commentators and English versions identify the two clauses as both referring to the stars. For example:

It grew strong enough to attack the army of heaven, the stars themselves, and it threw some of them to the ground (GNT) (GNT, RSV, GW, CEV, NCV, REB, probably NIV)

1. Some commentators and English versions separate the two and draw a distinction between them in the translation. For example:

It grew as high as the host of heaven. It threw down to the earth some of the host and some of the stars (NRSV) (BSB, KJV, NJB, NASB, NRSV, ESV, NET, NLT)

These notes take the view that the two phrases are closely associated with one another, though not strictly identical. Some scholars say that the Jewish people viewed the stars as visible representations or manifestations of angels or other heavenly beings. See Lucas page 215 Other scholars believe that both stars and the heavenly army could represent or be symbols of God's people. See Steinmann page 402, Miller page 226, Young p. 171.

8:10a

It grew as high as the host of heaven,

- This horn grew longer/higher until it was as high as the stars/powers in the sky.
- It grew so great/high/tall that it reached/touched the stars themselves, God's army.

It grew as high as the host of heaven: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as It grew is the same as in 8:9b. The horn made itself great, claiming and taking more and more power for itself. In the vision, this growth of power was symbolized by a growth in length. The horn appeared to grow longer and longer, reaching to the sky.

the host of heaven: that the BSB translates as the host of heaven means "the heavenly armies." This phrase refers to powerful heavenly beings under God's control. See the footnote in the NET. In the dream they are located up in the sky and are associated in some way with the stars. Here is another way to translate this:

It grew right up to the armies of heaven. (NJB)

The horn was aggressive in its growth; that is, it grew by attacking and defeating other powers. In some languages it may be natural to make this implication explicit. For example, the GNT says:

It grew strong enough to attack the army of heaven

8:10c

and trampled them.

- and trod them down.
- Then it crushed/kicked them into submission.

8:10b-c

and it cast down some of the host and some of the stars to the earth, and trampled them: In the vision, the horn pulled some of the stars down to the ground and walked over them, symbolically forcing them to submit to it.

some of the host and some of the stars: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as some of the host and some of the stars is more literally "some of the host and/even some of the stars." The Hebrew conjunction can be translated as and or as "even," and so there are at two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. the host and the stars are two ways of referring to the same concept. For example:

the stars in the sky, which were heaven's army (CEV) (NIV, RSV, GNT, REB, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. the host and the stars refer to two separate concepts. For example:

some of the host and some of the stars (NRSV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NRSV, ESV, NET, NLT)

These notes take the view that the stars and the heavenly host are closely associated. In your translation it is good to mention them separately but indicate their close association. For example:

some of heaven's army, some of the stars

and trampled them: A horn, of course, normally has no feet and cannot literally trample on something. But this horn forced the stars to submit to it, and humiliated them so that they were considered of no value or worth. In some languages it may be impossible to say that a horn trampled the stars. It may be necessary to say something more general like:

crushed them

Daniel 8:11

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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Paragraph 8:9–12

A small horn grew to become powerful and very evil.

8:11a

It magnified itself, even to the Prince of the host;

- The little horn made itself as high/great as the prince of the host/army.
- And/Then the little horn grew great/important, even up to the leader of God's/Yahweh's army,
- It even claimed/tried to be equal to the prince of heaven's armies.

It magnified itself, even to the Prince of the host:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as It magnified itself means "it made itself great." The little horn wanted to be equal to the commander of God's army. It wanted others to consider it to be worthy of the same honor and obedience as the commander. Here are some other ways to translate this:

It magnified itself, even up to the Prince of the host (RSV)

That little horn set itself up as equal to...the Commander of heaven's armies (NCV)

the Prince of the host: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the Prince of the host is more literally "the prince/commander of the army/host." Here the reference may be to God himself, the preincarnate Christ, or to his representative. See Goldingay, page 210, Steinmann, page 202–203, and Miller, pages 226–227. See how you translated this in Joshua 5:14. As

the exact reference is debated, it is best to translate literally. Use a phrase that could be applied to God himself.

the host: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the host is the same word that is translated as “the host” in 8:10a, b.

8:11b

it removed His daily sacrifice

- It caused the daily sacrifices to come to an end.
- The little horn stopped/abolished the daily sacrifices that people offered to God
- It forbade/prevented people from offering the regular sacrifices to Yahweh

it removed His daily sacrifice: The little horn removed His daily sacrifice in the sense that it prevented people from sacrificing to God in the temple. This probably refers to the time when Antiochus Epiphanes ended the regular worship at the temple in Jerusalem. He ordered people to stop offering sacrifices to God there. Here are some other ways to translate this:

stopped the daily sacrifices offered to him (GNT)

canceling the daily sacrifices offered to him (NLT)

it took the daily burnt offering from him (GW)

His daily sacrifice: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as His daily sacrifice is literally “the perpetual.” This word refers to the offerings that the priests offered daily to God in the temple at Jerusalem.

8:11c

and overthrew the place of His sanctuary.

- and God’s sanctuary was ruined.
- and caused people to abandon the holy place where they worshiped God.
- and caused people to desert the temple.

and overthrew the place of His sanctuary: The pronoun His here means “the LORD’s.” The sanctuary of the LORD is his holy place, his temple. This is a reference to the time when Antiochus Epiphanes, symbolized by the little horn, set up an idol in God’s temple (167 B.C.). The temple was thus profaned or defiled. It is good to use a word that can refer to the violation of a holy place rather than just to its physical destruction. For example:

and his sanctuary was ruined/devastated

This is a passive clause. In some languages it may be natural to use an active verb, with the little horn as the subject. For example:

and [it] ruined the Temple (GNT)

Daniel 8:12

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

Some versions have two headings within this section. For example:

NET Daniel Has a Vision of a Goat and a Ram (8:1)

An Angel Interprets Daniel’s Vision (8:15)

NRSV Vision of a Ram and a Goat (8:1)

Gabriel Interprets the Vision (8:15)

GNT Daniel’s Vision of a Ram and a Goat

The Angel Gabriel Explains the Vision (8:15)

BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both

use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:9–12

A small horn grew to become powerful and very evil.

8:12a–b

The Hebrew text of 8:12a–b is difficult to understand. Some scholars have suggested that the present Hebrew text, the MT, is incorrect, but there is no agreement as to the exact correct reading. English translations therefore translate it in various ways. It is recommended that you follow the understanding of the BSB and similar versions such as the NET and RSV/NRSV:

And the host was given over to it together with the continual burnt offering through transgression (RSV)

Because of wickedness, the host was given over to it together with the regular burnt offering (NRSV)

The army was given over, along with the daily sacrifice, in the course of his sinful rebellion. (NET)

8:12a

And in the rebellion, the host and the daily sacrifice were given over to the horn,

- In/By wickedness the little horn obtained power over the host/army and over the daily burnt offerings.
- The little horn gained power over God's army and over the daily sacrifice through an evil deed.
- The little horn took wrongful/unlawful control over God's people and over the daily burnt offerings.

And in the rebellion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And in the rebellion is literally “in transgression.” There are at least two ways to understand this phrase in this context:

1. it indicates that the little horn sinned. For example:

in the course of his sinful rebellion (NET)

(NET)

1. it indicates that God's people sinned. For example:

People sinned there (GNT)

(GNT, NIV)

It is good to leave this ambiguous in possible. However if it is not possible it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as this is the meaning that the passage is emphasizing. Other ways to translate this include:

in an act of rebellion (ESV note)

in a sinful deed

In some languages it may be natural or necessary to translate the idea of rebellion or “transgression” using a verb. For example:

it rebelled/sinned against Yahweh

the host and the daily sacrifice were given over to the horn: The Hebrew of this clause is difficult to understand. The Hebrew text includes a preposition before the word translated as the host, and its meaning in this context is not clear. These notes will recommend that the translator follow the understanding of the BSB, NIV, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NASB, and NET. These versions understand the preposition to mean “in addition to” or “together with.” The little horn received power over God's people (or host/army) as well as over the daily sacrifice. For example:

and the host was given over to it together with the regular burnt offering (NRSV)

the host will be given over to the horn along with the regular sacrifice (NASB)

The army was given over, along with the daily sacrifice (NET)

the host: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the host is the same word that was used in 8:11a. Here it probably refers to the host or multitude of the LORD's people. The little horn gained power over God's people; that is, it conquered them.

the daily sacrifice: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the daily sacrifice is "the perpetual," as in 8:11b. Translate it here as you did there

were given over to the horn: This is an idiom meaning "were put in its power." This is a passive verb. The context implies that it was God who allowed the little horn to gain power or control over both the host and the daily sacrifice. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an active clause with the subject made explicit. For example:

God allowed the horn to get/have control/power over his people

8:12b and it flung truth to the ground

- Throwing truth to the ground,
- It ignored what was right and true,
- The horn rejected/refused God's true way/word.

it flung truth to the ground: The abstract noun truth here refers to what is true, God's words or message. The little horn did not honor what was true. By flinging it to the ground, he showed that he scorned and wished to dismiss and ignore it.

There are at least two ways to translate the verb flung:

- using a passive verb. For example:

and truth was overthrown (NLT)

- using an active verb. For example:

it cast truth to the ground (NRSV)

and flung truth to the ground (NJB)

Use the form that is most natural in your language. The reader should understand that the little horn chose to dishonor the truth about God.

8:12c and prospered in whatever it did.

- it succeeded in all that it did.
- and so it accomplished/achieved whatever it wanted.
- and it was very successful.

prospered in whatever it did: The Hebrew text is more literally "it will act and it will succeed." This indicates that the little horn continued to act in an aggressive way and was successful in its various deeds. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The horn was successful in everything it did (GNT)

and kept prospering in what it did (NRSV)

The horn was active and successful (NJB)

General Comment on 8:12b–c

The BSB follows the Hebrew order. Some English versions reverse this order by placing the information in 8:12c before that in 8:12b. For example:

^{12c}It prospered in everything it did, ^{12b}and truth was thrown to the ground. (NIV)

Daniel 8:13

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little

horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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The Angel Gabriel Explains the Vision (8:15)

BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:13–14

God's angel indicated that the evil deeds of the little horn will be limited to a certain time period.

8:13a

Then I heard a holy one speaking,

- ¶ Then I heard a holy being speaking.
- ¶ Then I hear a holy/heavenly angel talking.
- ¶ Then I heard an angel talking,

Then I heard a holy one speaking: In his vision, Daniel heard one of the heavenly beings talking. He does not record to whom this holy one was speaking, or what he said.

a holy one: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as a holy one indicates that the reference is to one specific holy one, out of many. He was not unique. He was one of the many heavenly beings that serve God, perhaps an angel.

8:13b

and another holy one said to him,

- Then another holy being said to one who was speaking,
- Then another angel asked the holy/heavenly speaker,
- and a second angel asked him a question:

and another holy one said to him: A second heavenly being was present and addressed the first one.

to him: The English pronoun him refers to the first holy one, the one who was speaking in 8:13a. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as to him means something like “to whoever it was.” Here is another way to translate this:

to the speaker (NJB)

General Comment on 8:13a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to combine these two verse parts. For example:

^{13a-b}¶ I heard two holy ones talking to one another.
One said/asked...

8:13c

“How long until the fulfillment of the vision

- “How long will all these things from the vision remain/last—
- “How long must those events from the vision continue/endure?
- “For how many days will/must all that continue?

How long until the fulfillment of the vision...?: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as How long until the fulfillment of the vision are more literally “until when the vision?” The BSB has supplied the

words until the fulfillment. The angel was asking about the end or completion of the events described in the vision, not the vision itself. He was asking how long the evil power symbolized by the little horn would be successful. In order to avoid the wrong meaning, that the question was about the length of the actual vision, it may be necessary to supply some information. For example:

How long will these things that were seen in the vision continue? (GNT)

How long will the events of this vision last? (NLT)

The phrase that the BSB translates as How long often introduces a rhetorical question that protests some injustice. Here, however, it introduces a real question, but it still includes something of a complaint or lament. In English one could indicate this by asking:

How long must it be until the vision is fulfilled?

For how long must these events continue?

How long must it be before the events of this vision come to an end?

8:13d-f
of the daily sacrifice, the rebellion that causes desolation, and the surrender of the sanctuary and of the host to be trampled?: These verse parts identify and describe the contents of the vision that the angel was asking about. The BSB has supplied the word of, which is not in the Hebrew text.

You will want to refer to the contents of the vision in a way that allows the reader to identify them with the description in 8:11-12. The BSB uses noun phrases within one long question. In some languages it may be natural to use several separate clauses. See the General Comment on 8:13.

8:13d
of the daily sacrifice,

- the suppression/absence of the daily sacrifices,
- For how long will the little horn stop/prevent the daily sacrifices?
- When will people offer the daily sacrifices again?

the daily sacrifice: This is the same Hebrew word as in 8:11b and 8:12b. Translate it in the same or a similar way here. For example:

perpetual sacrifice (NJB)

the regular burnt offering (NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to make it clear that the vision concerned the suspension or absence of the daily sacrifices. For example:

how long will they stop the daily sacrifices?

8:13e
the rebellion that causes desolation,

- the wicked sin that brings destruction,
- How long will the evil thing continue to desecrate the temple?
- When will the little horn stop acting wickedly and bringing ruin?

the rebellion that causes desolation: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the rebellion is the same as that in 8:12a. The phrase here probably indicates that the sinful rebellion of the little horn caused disaster or destruction. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the transgression that makes desolate (NRSV)

the destructive rebellion (GW)

how long will it/they rebel and cause destruction

8:13f
and the surrender of the sanctuary and of the host to be trampled?"

- the surrender of the holy place and the suppression/oppression of God's people?"
- How long will the little horn have power over the holy place and crush God's army?"
- When will he stop conquering the temple and oppressing those who serve God/Yahweh?"

the surrender of the sanctuary: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the surrender is more literally "the giving over." It indicates that God gave the sanctuary over to the enemies of the Jews. He allowed them to conquer and occupy the temple in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this include:

the surrender of the holy place (GW)

how long...will enemies control the holy place

and of the host to be trampled: God's people were trampled; that is, they were crushed and oppressed. Daniel wanted to know how long this would continue. Other ways to translate this include:

and the oppression of the people of God

how long...will they trample/oppress the LORD's people

the host: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the host is literally "a host," as in 8:12a. This likely again refers to the multitude of God's people, his host or army.

General Comment on 8:13

In some languages it may be both more clear and more effective to use several questions in place of the one long question. For example:

How long will the events of this vision last? How long will the rebellion that causes desecration stop the daily sacrifices? How long will the Temple and heaven's army be trampled on? (NLT)

Daniel 8:14

Section 8:1-27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

Some versions have two headings within this section. For example:

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An Angel Interprets Daniel's Vision (8:15)

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Gabriel Interprets the Vision (8:15)

GNT Daniel's Vision of a Ram and a Goat

The Angel Gabriel Explains the Vision (8:15)

BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24-26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:13-14

God's angel indicated that the evil deeds of the little horn will be limited to a certain time period.

8:14a

He said to me, "It will take 2,300 evenings and mornings;

- I heard him answer, "It will continue for 2,300 evenings and mornings.

- The angel replied, “It will last for two thousand three hundred evenings and mornings. During that time there will be no daily sacrifices.
- This was the reply: “For a total of two thousand and three hundred evenings and mornings.

He said to me: There is a textual problem here. The Hebrew text reads to me, but other ancient versions have “to him,” that is, to the other angel. The two possibilities are:

1. the original text read to me: (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET, GW, NCV, NIV)
2. the original text read “to him.” For example:

And he said to him (RSV) (RSV/NRSV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow the MT and option (1), as the BSB has done. The REB leaves it ambiguous by saying “the answer came.” The GNT says, “I heard the other angel answer,” and the CEV says, “The other answered.” It is also possible to say;

I heard the angel reply

It will take 2,300 evenings and mornings: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as 2,300 evenings and mornings is more literally “evening, morning, two thousand and three hundred.” There are two ways to understand this:

1. it refers to a period of 1,150 days, or about three and a half years. A total of 2,300 sacrifices would be omitted or cancelled. See 7:25.
2. it refers to a period of 2,300 days, a little over six years and three months. 2,300 morning sacrifices would be omitted or cancelled, and 2,300 evening sacrifices as well.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This probably refers to the events described in the book of 1 Maccabees 4:52–52, which took place in 167–164 B.C. Antiochus banned sacrifices and desecrated the altar of the LORD in 167 B.C. Judas Maccabeus consecrated the altar and again offered sacrifices upon it in 164 BC.

Here are some other possible ways to translate this:

It will take a total of 2,300 evenings and mornings

this will happen for a total of 2,300 hundred times—both evening and morning sacrifices will be canceled

Evenings, mornings, a sum of 2,300 will pass before...

This will continue for a total of 2300 evenings and mornings

8:14b

then the sanctuary will be properly restored.”

- Then the temple will be made acceptable to God again.”
- then they (indefinite) will restore the temple.”
- After that, the priests will restore and reconsecrate the temple.”

then the sanctuary will be properly restored: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as properly restored means “put right.” This is a passive clause. It indicates that God’s people will restore God’s sanctuary, the temple, and make it fit for worship again. Here are some other ways to translate this:

then the Temple will be made right again (NLT)

Then the Temple will be restored. (GNT)

Then the holy place will be repaired. (NCV)

In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb. If this is the case in your language, it is probably best to use a general subject. For example:

then they will restore the temple

Daniel 8:15

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

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The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:15–16

Someone commanded the angel Gabriel to explain Daniel's vision to him.

8:15a

While I, Daniel, was watching the vision

- ¶ As I, Daniel, was watching the vision
- ¶ While I was seeing the vision

8:15b

and trying to understand it,

- I tried to understand what it meant.
- and was trying to understand its meaning

8:15a–b

While I, Daniel, was watching the vision and trying to understand it: This verse part introduces the explanation of the vision of the ram and the goat that is described in 8:1–14. It gives the time when the next phase of the vision, the explanation, takes place. Introduce this explanation using the verb tenses that are natural in your language. For example:

When I, Daniel, had seen the vision, I tried to understand it. (NRSV)

As I, Daniel, was trying to understand the meaning of the vision (NLT)

8:15c

there stood before me one having the appearance of a man.

- Suddenly, someone appeared in front of me who looked like a man.
- when suddenly, I saw someone who looked like a man standing right there in front of me.

there stood before me one having the appearance of a man: Daniel saw a figure like that of a man, that is, an adult male human being. This verse part includes the particle that indicates surprise or suddenness, so the GNT says:

when suddenly someone was standing in front of me (GNT)

Daniel 8:16

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

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GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became

so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24-26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:15-16

Someone commanded the angel Gabriel to explain Daniel's vision to him.

8:16a

And I heard the voice of a man calling from between the banks of the Ulai:

- Then I heard a human voice that came from near the Ulai canal. It called,
- Then I heard a voice of someone near the banks of the Ulai canal. He said,
- Then I heard someone call out from near the banks of the Ulai:

And I heard the voice of a man calling from between the banks of the Ulai: In his vision Daniel heard the sound of a human voice. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that this person himself, rather than his voice, was calling. For example:

and I heard a man calling from the Ulai

a man: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a man is "adam," that is, a member of the human race, a person. It is not the same as the word in 8:15c.

from between the banks of the Ulai: The Ulai was a canal. See how you referred to it in 8:2. The Hebrew here is more literally "between the Ulai." The exact meaning of this is unclear. Possibly it indicates that Daniel heard someone's voice coming from near the canal. This was not the same being as was referred to in 8:15b.

8:16b

"Gabriel, explain the vision to this man."

- "Gabriel, explain to him what he has seen."
- "Gabriel, tell this man what this vision means."
- "Gabriel, interpret the meaning of the vision for this man."

Gabriel: Gabriel is the name of one of God's most important angels, an archangel. Use the form of address that is appropriate for someone in authority to use

in giving a command to a high angel. See how you spelled the name Gabriel in Luke 1:19, 26.

explain the vision to this man: The Hebrew is more literally “cause this one to understand the vision.” The phrase this man refers to Daniel himself. Make sure that this is clear. It does not refer to the “one who looked like a man” in 8:15b. Other ways to translate this include;

tell him the meaning of the vision! (NJB)

help this man understand the vision. (NRSV)

explain the vision to this man (GW)

explain to him the meaning of what he saw (GNT)

In some languages it may be helpful to make the referents clear by using indirect speech. For example:

Someone called to Gabriel and told him to explain to me the meaning of the vision.

Daniel 8:17

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

Some versions have two headings within this section. For example:

NET Daniel Has a Vision of a Goat and a Ram (8:1)

An Angel Interprets Daniel’s Vision (8:15)

NRSV Vision of a Ram and a Goat (8:1)

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GNT Daniel’s Vision of a Ram and a Goat

The Angel Gabriel Explains the Vision (8:15)

BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:17–19

This paragraph introduces Gabriel’s explanation of Daniel’s vision.

8:17a

As he came near to where I stood,

- Then Gabriel came to the place where I was standing.
- So he/Gabriel approached me,
- When he/Gabriel came near,

As he came near to where I stood: The pronoun he here refers to Gabriel. In some languages it will be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Gabriel came to where I was standing. (NCV)

Gabriel came and stood beside me. (GNT)

8:17b

I was terrified and fell facedown.

- I became very afraid and bowed down with my face to the ground.
- and as he came, I felt terrified and lowered myself to the ground in awe.
- I lay down on the ground in fear.

I was terrified and fell facedown: In his vision, Daniel was so frightened that he dropped to the ground. Other ways to translate this include:

I was so terrified that I fell to the ground (GNT)

I was very afraid and bowed facedown on the ground. (NCV)

Struck by fear/awe, I knelt down on the ground

fell facedown: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as fell facedown is literally “and I fell on my face.” However, Daniel did not fall accidentally and hit his face. He quickly lowered himself and put his face on the ground because he was awed and afraid. Express this idea in a way that is natural in your language. See how you translated this in Daniel 2:46. 5/

General Comment on 8:17a–b

There is a logical connection between the verbs in these verse parts: Gabriel came near, and that caused Daniel to be afraid. Because of his fear, he fell prostrate on the ground. Show these connections in a way that is natural in your languages. For example:

Gabriel came over, and I fell to the ground in fear. (CEV)

So he approached the place where I was standing. As he came, I felt terrified and fell flat on the ground. (NET)

8:17c

“Son of man,” he said to me, “understand that the vision concerns the time of the end.”

- Gabriel said to me, “Son of the human race, I want you to know that the events you saw in the vision are about the time of the end.”
- Then he said, “I want you to understand, human, that what you saw in the vision is what will happen at the end of time.”

“Son of man,” he said to me, “understand that the vision concerns the time of the end”: The BSB has placed the phrase he said to me in the middle of the quotation. Place these words where it is natural in your language. For example:

He said to me, “Son of man, understand that the vision is about the end times” (GW)

Son of man: The Hebrew says “son of adam.” This way of addressing Daniel emphasizes his humanity. Here are some other ways to translate it:

Human being (NCV)

child of mankind

understand that the vision concerns the time of the end: Gabriel wanted Daniel to know that what he had seen would be fulfilled not immediately but in the end time. However, he did not indicate to what end this refers. It is best to leave this open. Other ways to translate this include:

understand that this vision is about the time of the end (NCV)

you must understand that the events you have seen in your vision relate to the time of the end (NLT)

Understand...that the vision points to the time of the end (REB)

Daniel 8:18

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In

this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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GNT Daniel's Vision of a Ram and a Goat

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BFrCL88 Second vision: the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

GeCL97 A second vision: The battle between the Ram and the Goat (8:1)

The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:17-19

This paragraph introduces Gabriel's explanation of Daniel's vision.

8:18a

While he was speaking with me, I fell into a deep sleep, with my face to the ground.

- ¶ As he spoke to me, I lay there unconscious/motionless with my face to the ground.
- ¶ As Gabriel was speaking, I became/fell unconscious. I was lying there with my face on the earth,

While he was speaking with me: Gabriel was speaking with Daniel. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

As Gabriel spoke to me

I fell into a deep sleep: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as I fell into a deep sleep here probably indicates that Daniel entered a state of unconsciousness. A related noun is used of Adam in Genesis 2:2. This does not refer to a normal sleep. Other ways to translate this include:

I fell into a trance (NET)

I fell...unconscious (GNT)

8:18b

Then he touched me, helped me to my feet,

- Gabriel touched me and helped me to stand up.
- but he took hold of me and lifted me to my feet.

Then he touched me, helped me to my feet: Gabriel touched Daniel in the sense that he grasped or took firm hold of him. In this way he was able to cause him to stand up. Other ways to translate this include:

But he lifted me to my feet (CEV)

But he took hold of me, raised me to my feet (GNT)

Gabriel roused me with a touch and helped me to my feet. (NLT)

Daniel 8:19

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

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The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:17–19

This paragraph introduces Gabriel's explanation of Daniel's vision.

8:19a

and said, "Behold, I will make known to you what will happen in the latter time of wrath,

- Then he said, "Listen, I am about to tell you what will happen later, during the time of God's anger,
- Then Gabriel said, "I will now show/reveal to you what will happen in the period when God shows his anger—

Behold, I will make known to you what will happen in the latter time of wrath: Gabriel told Daniel that he was going to explain to him things that would take place in the future. This future time is called the time of wrath. This phrase refers to the time when God will be angry and punish his enemies. Other ways to translate this include:

Listen, and I will tell you what will take place later in the period of wrath (NRSV)

I will tell you what will happen in the last days, the time of God's anger (GW)

Behold, I will make known to you: The Hebrew text introduces this verb phrase with an exclamation that is often translates as Behold. Here it calls attention to what Gabriel is about to say. Here is another way to translate this:

Listen, and I will tell you (NRSV)

8:19b

because it concerns the appointed time of the end.

- for there is a set time for the end.
- for there is a time appointed/chosen by God to end it/this.

because it concerns the appointed time of the end:

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as because here introduces further explanation of the last clause in 8:19a—"what will happen in the latter time of wrath." It does not introduce the cause of the main verb in 8:19a, "I am going to tell you." Other ways to translate this include:

for it refers to the appointed time of the end (NRSV)

The vision refers to the time of the end (GNT)

for there is an end at the appointed time (REB)

it concerns the appointed time of the end: The Hebrew word it refers to "what will happen in the latter time of wrath" (8:19a). Some English versions do not say it, but say "the vision." These words are not included explicitly in the MT but is supplied by many English versions and the Septuagint (LXX). You may include it if it is natural in your language. If it is not necessary, you may wish to follow one of these models:

it refers to the appointed time of the end (NRSV)

the end time has been determined (GW)

the appointed time of the end: The Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as appointed time refers in a general way to a set time, such as for a meeting or feast. Here the emphasis is on the fact that God has set a time for the ending of the events in the vision. The suffering and oppression will not last forever. God has appointed a time limit. See how you translated the time of the end in 8:17c. Here are some other ways to translate this:

at a set moment an end will come

it will end in God's time

General Comment on 8:19a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in these verse parts. For example:

Listen, and I will tell you what will happen at the end of time, when God has chosen to show his anger. (CEV)

Daniel 8:20

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar's reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

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The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:20–22

Gabriel explained the meaning of the ram that Daniel had seen in his vision.

8:20

The two-horned ram that you saw represents the kings of Media and Persia.

- ¶ “The ram you saw had two horns. It represents the kings of Media and Persia.
- ¶ “You saw a male sheep with horns. It is symbolic of the kings of the empire of Media and Persia.

The two-horned ram that you saw represents the kings of Media and Persia: The BSB has supplied the verb represents. There is no verb in the Hebrew text. Supply the verb that is most natural in your language. For example;

The ram with the two horns symbolizes the kings of Media and Persia

Some English translations make it clear that the comparison is between the two horns and the two kings. For example:

As for the ram that you saw with the two horns, these are the kings of Media and Persia. (NRSV)

The two horns of the ram are the kings of Media and Persia (CEV)

The two-horned ram represents the kings of Media and Persia. (NLT)

Daniel 8:21

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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Paragraph 8:20–22

Gabriel explained the meaning of the ram that Daniel had seen in his vision.

8:21a

The shaggy goat represents the king of Greece,

- The buck, the he-goat, represents the king of Greece,
- The male goat signifies the king of Greece,

The shaggy goat represents the king of Greece:

Again there is no verb in the Hebrew text, and here the BSB has supplied the verb represents. Supply the verb that is natural in your language. Here are other ways to translate this verse part:

the male goat is the king of Greece (NRSV)

the he-goat is the king of Greece (REB)

The shaggy goat represents the king of Greece (NLT)

the king of Greece: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Greece is “Javan.” It refers to the land that is now called Greece.

8:21b

and the large horn between his eyes is the first king.

- and the big horn between his eyes represents the first king.
- and the large horn between his eyes signifies the first king of Greece.

and the large horn between his eyes is the first

king: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as large can also mean “great.” Some English versions translate it in this way to make the comparison with the king clearer. For example:

and the great horn between its eyes is the first king (NRSV)

and the powerful horn between its eyes is the first of its kings (CEV)

Daniel 8:22

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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Paragraph 8:20–22

Gabriel explained the meaning of the ram that Daniel had seen in his vision.

8:22a

The four horns that replaced the broken one

- As for the broken horn and the four horns that arose/appeared in its place,
- One horn broke off and four horns replaced it.
- The four horns that grew/came up when the first horn broke

The four horns that replaced the broken one: This verse part refers back to what Daniel saw in 8:8. The large or great horn on the goat was broken off, and four other horns grew up in its place. In your transla-

tion, try to use the same words and phrases as in 8:8. Here are some other ways to translate this:

As for the horn that was broken, in place of which four other arose (RSV)

The four horns that came up when the first horn was broken (GNT)

The first horn broke off, and four horns replaced it.

the broken one: The Hebrew word that the BSB literally translates as the broken one refers to the horn that was broken off suddenly (8:8). In some languages it will be natural to make it explicit that this refers to a broken horn. For example:

the first horn was broken (GNT)

After this horn is broken (CEV)

8:22b

represent four kingdoms that will rise from that nation,

- four kingdoms shall arise/appear from that/one nation.
- This indicates that four kingdoms will come out of one nation.
- represent four kingdoms that will come from that/his nation.

represent four kingdoms that will rise from that nation:

The BSB has again supplied the verb represent, which is not in the Hebrew text. The four horns in the vision represented or symbolized four kingdoms. The vision indicated that four kingdoms would come from the nation represented or symbolized by the one horn. Or, in other words, the one kingdom would divide into four. Other ways to translate this include:

four other kingdoms will appear (CEV)

four kingdoms shall arise from his nation (RSV)

into which that nation will be divided (GNT)

that nation: The Hebrew text says “a nation,” but the Septuagint (LXX) and other ancient translations say “his nation.” The reference is to the nation that the broken horn symbolized. In your translation, you

should make it clear that the phrase that nation refers to the nation represented by the broken horn.

General Comment on 8:22a–b

The Hebrew text mentions the broken horn before the horns that arose in his/its place. There are various ways to arrange or organize the information in these verse parts. Here are some examples of translations that follow the Hebrew order:

As for the horn that was broken, in place of which four others arose, four kingdoms shall arise from his nation (NRSV)

As for the horn which was broken off and replaced by four other horns: four kingdoms will rise out of that nation (REB)

Use the order that is most natural in your language.

8:22c

but will not have the same power.

- However they will not have as much power as the first nation.
- But they will not be as strong/great as it was.

but will not have the same power: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as but will not have the same power is more literally “but not with his power” (see the RSV). These four nations will all be weaker than the first nation, the Greek empire. None of them will be as strong as that first nation. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and which will not be as strong as the first kingdom (GNT)

but none as great as the first (NLT)

but they will lack its power (REB)

Daniel 8:23

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat

attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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Interpretation of the second vision (8:15)

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The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

As noted above, the chapter is divided into two parts, one that describes the vision and one that gives the interpretation of the vision. Both parts lead to a climax. In the first part the horn grew until it became so great that it succeeded in everything it did (8:12). A similar sequence of events occurs in the second part of the vision. Gabriel described the growth of the horn and its climactic success (8:24–26). At the end of the

chapter, Gabriel announced that God would destroy the horn (8:25).

The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:23–25

Gabriel described the rule of an evil and powerful king who would even challenge God himself.

8:23a

In the latter part of their reign,

- ¶ “Near the end of their reign/rule,
- ¶ “During the end of the time when these four kingdoms are powerful
- ¶ “At the end of end of the time when these kings ruled

In the latter part of their reign: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as In the latter part of their reign refers to the final years of the four kingdoms that succeeded Alexander the Great’s empire. Here are some other ways to translate this:

In the last days of those kingdoms (REB)

At the end of their rule (NLT)

When the end of those kingdoms is near (GNT)

8:23b

when the rebellion has reached its full measure,

- when wicked people sin as much as possible,
- and when those who do evil act as wickedly as they can,
- that evil people will become so wicked that they must be punished.

when the rebellion has reached its full measure:

There is a textual problem here. Ancient translations, including the Septuagint, refer to sins or transgressions rather than to rebellion. The two possibilities are:

1. the reference is to people, transgressors. For example:

When those rulers have become as evil as possible (CEV) (NIV, NASB, RSV, ESV, CEV, NCV, GNT)

1. the reference is to rebellious acts or transgressions. See the NET footnote. For example:

when their transgressions have reached their full measure (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NJB, NET, REB, NLT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), the reading of the Masoretic Text. However, in some languages the two readings may result in similar translations, since the meaning is similar: evil people have sinned so seriously that God must intervene and punish. Here is another way to translate this:

When...they have become so wicked that they must be punished (GNT)

has reached its full measure: The Hebrew text says “are completed.” In this context this verb seems to indicate that the sinners or rebels have sinned as much as they can.

8:23c

an insolent king, skilled in intrigue, will come to the throne.

- a new king will begin to rule, a king bold, defiant and deceitful.
- another king gains power to rule. He will be bold, cruel and skilled in intrigue.
- At that time there will be a stubborn, vicious, and deceitful king.

an insolent king, skilled in intrigue, will come to the throne:

This verse part describes the arrival of a new king, whom scholars identify as Antiochus Epiphanes. He came to power in one of the four nations that emerged after Alexander the Great’s death. He is described in two ways, as a fierce-looking king and a master of intrigue. Here is another way to translate this:

a fierce king, a master of intrigue, will rise to power (NLT)

insolent: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as insolent is more literally “strong of face” or “stern-faced.” It is implied that the fierce or stern look on his face showed his character. That is, it showed that he was a hard-hearted or cruel man. Other ways to translate this include:

a fierce king (NLT)

a bold and cruel king (NCV)

dangerous (CEV)

skilled in intrigue: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as skilled in intrigue is more literally “understanding riddles.” In this context it implies that he will be clever in an evil way. Consider how it is natural to refer to such evil intelligence in your language. For example:

an evil genius UBS Handbook, page 224.

will come to the throne: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as will come to the throne here means “will rise to power” or “will become powerful.” This evil man will become a powerful king.

Daniel 8:24

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

The angel Gabriel came to Daniel and explained the meaning of what he had seen. The ram and the goat represented kings and their kingdoms. The little horn represented a particularly wicked king. That king would even defy God, but in the end that wicked king would be destroyed.

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The meaning of the vision of the ram and the goat (8:15)

There are a number of similarities between chapter eight and chapter seven. For example, both chapters use symbolic language to describe kingdoms, and both use the symbol of a horn to refer to particular rulers of those kingdoms. In spite of these similarities, it is important to understand that the symbols in the two chapters do not necessarily refer to the same things. For example, while there are similarities between the two little horns, there are also important differences. The Notes will explain some of these differences. The Notes will also suggest ways to translate these symbols.

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:23–25

Gabriel described the rule of an evil and powerful king who would even challenge God himself.

8:24a

His power will be great,

- The king will be very powerful
- He will have a lot of power,

8:24b

but it will not be his own.

- but not because he himself is strong/great.
- power that he himself did not gain.

8:24a-b

His power will be great, but it will not be his own:

There is a textual problem here:

1. The Hebrew MT reads “He will become great but not with his power.” For example:

This king will be very powerful, but his power will not come from himself. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NJB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The Greek translations say only “His power shall be great.” For example:

His power shall be great (RSV) (RSV/NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), that of the Masoretic Text, along with the majority of English versions.

8:24c

He will cause terrible destruction

- He will cause terrible/horrific destruction,
- He will destroy so much that people will be shocked.

He will cause terrible destruction: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as He will cause...destruction is literally “he will destroy.” The object of the verb, what he will destroy, is not stated, and it is good to leave this open and general. For example:

He will cause terrible destruction (GNT)

He will cause a shocking amount of destruction (NLT)

terrible: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as terrible means “wonderful, amazing, terrifying.” It is often used in a positive way of admiration, but here it is used to refer to a negative quality, and describes a shocking or horrifying action.

8:24d

and succeed in whatever he does.

- and he will be successful in everything he does.
- Whatever he does/attempts will succeed,

and succeed in whatever he does: The Hebrew is literally “and he will succeed and he will act.” Other ways to translate this include:

and be successful in everything he does (GNT)

in whatever he does, he will be successful

and he will accomplish/fulfill his plans

8:24e

He will destroy the mighty men along with the holy people.

- He will destroy powerful leaders and even God’s own people.
- and he will bring down powerful rulers and cause damage/harm to God’s people.

He will destroy the mighty men along with the holy people: There are two ways to understand the Hebrew words that the BSB translates as the mighty men along with the holy people:

1. It refers to two different groups. For example:

He will work havoc on the mighty nations and the holy people (REB) (BSB, GNT, REB, RSV/NRSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NJB, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, NIV84)

1. It refers to the same group of people in two different ways. For example, (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the great majority of English versions and the normal meaning of the Hebrew conjunction. The NASB is therefore used in the Display.

the mighty men: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as those who are mighty is literally “mighty ones” and probably refers to powerful human rulers and leaders. Other ways to translate this include:

those who are powerful (GW)

powerful leaders (CEV)

powerful men (GNT)

the holy people: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the holy people is literally a people of holy ones. In this context it probably refers to those who belong to God, God’s own people. The NJB makes this explicit:

the holy ones, God’s people (NJB)

Daniel 8:25

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

At this point in the narrative, the author of the book of Daniel again began to write in the Hebrew language. He described another vision, this one occurring during the third year of Belshazzar’s reign over Babylon. In this vision Daniel was by the bank of a canal near the city of Susa. He saw a very powerful ram with two horns that charged in all directions. Next he saw a

goat with one large horn between its eyes. The goat attacked and defeated the ram and grew very powerful. Its large horn broke and four prominent horns grew in its place. From one of those four horns grew a small horn. That little horn grew as high as the stars, as high as the army of heaven, and as high as the commander of the army. When it was at its highest, it stopped the daily sacrifices and desecrated the temple.

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Paragraph 8:23-25

Gabriel described the rule of an evil and powerful king who would even challenge God himself.

8:25a

Through his craft and by his hand, he will cause deceit to prosper,

- By his cunning, he will succeed in deceiving/tricking many people.
- His clever lies will make him successful.

Through his craft and by his hand, he will cause deceit to prosper: This Hebrew clause is more literally “And through his cleverness he will cause deceit to succeed in/by his hand.” In this context the word meaning “cleverness” (craft) implies negative ideas such as cunning or craftiness. The clause indicates that this ruler will be very smart or clever in using deceit to benefit himself. Other ways to translate this include:

Because he is cunning, he will succeed in his deceitful ways (GNT)

By his cunning he shall make deceit prosper under his hand (NRSV)

He will be a master of deception (NLT)

This king will succeed/prosper by using lies/deceit

He will be so clever that he will trick many people.

8:25b

and in his own mind he will make himself great.

- He will consider himself more and more important.
- He will become more and more arrogant.

in his own mind he will make himself great: The Hebrew clause is literally “in his heart he will act arrogantly.” This king will think of himself as great and important and successful. Other ways to translate this include

and in his own mind he shall be great (NRSV)

He will be proud of himself (GNT)

and will become arrogant (NLT)

He will think that he is very important (NCV)

8:25c

In a time of peace he will destroy many,

- He will destroy many people who are living safely/securely.
- While people feel safe, he will attack and kill many of them.

In a time of peace he will destroy many: The Hebrew text is more literally “and in security he will destroy many.” This probably indicates that this king will suddenly attack and destroy people who are feeling safe and secure. Here are other ways to translate this:

Without warning he shall destroy many (NRSV)

and will destroy many people when they do not expect it

8:25d

and he will even stand against the Prince of princes.

- He will even oppose the ruler who is above all rulers.
- He will defy/challenge the greatest Lord/King.

he will even stand against the Prince of princes: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as he will even stand is literally “will arise,” that is, will stand against or oppose. Other ways to translate this include:

He will even defy the greatest King of all (GNT)

He will even oppose the Prince of princes (NASB)

and shall even rise up against the Prince of princes (NRSV)

8:25e

Yet he will be broken off, but not by human hands.

- It will not be a human being who will break/destroy him.
- His fall/defeat will happen through a power that is not of men.

Yet he will be broken off, but not by human hands:

The Hebrew text is more literally “and not by hand he will be broken.” The word “hand” is a figure of speech for human power. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But he shall be broken, and not by human hands (NRSV)

But he will be broken without human agency (NASB)

Daniel 8:26

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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The vision includes a number of images that may seem obscure and confusing. It is usually best to translate these images in a literal way. Even Daniel did not understand the full meaning of what he saw.

Paragraph 8:26

Gabriel ended his explanation by assuring Daniel that what he had told him was true. He ordered him, however, to keep it secret, as it would not come true in his lifetime.

8:26a

The vision of the evenings and the mornings that has been spoken is true.

- ¶ “The vision of the evening and the morning sacrifices which I have explained is accurate/true.
- ¶ “I have explained to you the vision of the evenings and mornings. It will come true.

The vision of the evenings and the mornings that has been spoken is true: This clause indicates that the explanation Gabriel had given of the vision was accurate and that the vision would be fulfilled. Here is another way to translate this:

This vision about the evening and morning sacrifices which has been explained to you will come true. (GNT)

The vision of the evenings and the mornings: The phrase The vision of the evenings and the mornings means “the vision concerning the evening and morning sacrifices.” It refers back to “the evenings and mornings” mentioned in 8:14a. These are the days in which no sacrifices would be offered to God on his altar in Jerusalem (8:11b). Neither in the evening or in the morning would people be able to bring their sacrifices to the temple. You may need to make some information explicit in your translation. For example

The vision concerning the evening and morning sacrifices

The vision about the 2,300 evenings and mornings (GW)

that has been spoken: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as has been spoken is literally “has been told.” GW says:

that was explained to you (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to use an active verb. For example:

that I have explained to you

that you have heard me explain

is true: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as is true is more literally, “it is truth.” Here is another way to translate this:

is correct (NET)

8:26b

Now you must seal up the vision,

- But keep the vision secret,
- But you should not tell anyone about it,

Now you must seal up the vision: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as seal up means to close, shut, or stop up something. In this context it refers to keeping the vision secret. Gabriel was commanding Daniel to telling no one about the vision. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But keep the vision secret (NASB)

But you must keep the vision secret (NJB)

8:26c for it concerns the distant future.”

- because it refers to a time that is still far away.”
- because these things will not happen for many years.”

for it concerns the distant future: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as for here introduces the reason why Daniel should not tell others about the vision. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the distant future is literally “for many days.” The historical period was close to four hundred years. Use an expression that can refer to several hundred years. In some languages a literal translation may suggest just a few weeks or months and translators may need to follow the BSB. Here are some other ways to translate this:

for it points to days far ahead (REB)

for it refers to a time many days from now (NET)

because it is about things that will happen in the distant future (GW)

because it will be a long time before it does come true (GNT)

General Comment on 8:26b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 8:26b–c, indicating the reason for the command before the command itself. For example:

^{26c}But none of these things will happen for a long time, ^{26b}so keep this vision a secret. (NLT)

^{26c}but these things won’t happen for a long time, ^{26b}so don’t tell it to others. (CEV)

^{26c}The vision is about things that will happen in the distant future, ^{26b}so you^(sing) must/should keep it secret.

Daniel 8:27

Section 8:1–27 Daniel had a dream about a ram and a goat

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Paragraph 8:27

This section concludes with Daniel's response to Gabriel's explanation of the meaning of the vision.

8:27a

I, Daniel, was exhausted and lay ill for days.

- ¶ Then I, Daniel, became exhausted and lay in bed sick for days.
- ¶ When the vision ended, I was exhausted and sick for several days.

I, Daniel, was exhausted: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *was exhausted* can mean “finished, exhausted.” The exact meaning here is uncertain.

lay ill for days: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *lay ill* can mean “weak,” “sick,” or “faint.” You may wish to follow the national language version here and translate a similar idea. Some English versions supply the word “several,” but the Hebrew just says days. Here is another way to translate this:

lay sick for some days (RSV/NRSV)

8:27b

Then I got up and went about the king's business.

- Then I got up and began to do my regular work for the king again.
- When I felt better, I got out of bed and went back to work for the king.

Then I got up and went about the king's business: The implied information here is that Daniel was recovered, at least physically. He was able to rise from his bed and go back to work.

Then I got up: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *I got up* is often used to emphasize the beginning of an action. It does not always indicate that the subject had been lying or sitting down. In this context it refers to recovery from illness, and so, it does imply that Daniel had been lying in bed. Here is another way to translate this:

I got up again (NASB)

and went about the king's business: The Hebrew is more literally “and I did the work of the king.” Daniel went back to his duties, to the work that the king had told him to do. Here are some other ways to translate this:

worked for the king (GW)

went back to the work that the king had assigned to me (GNT)

General Comment on 8:27a–b

The CEV makes the logical connection between the verse parts explicit by translating this as one long sentence:

^{27a}After this, I was so worn out ^{27b}and weak that it was several days ^{27c}before I could get out of bed and go about my duties for the king. (CEV)

8:27c

I was confounded by the vision; it was beyond understanding.

- However, I was horrified by the vision and I could not understand it.
- I was greatly dismayed by the things that I had seen in the vision. I could not understand what it meant.

I was confounded by the vision: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *I was confounded* means “I was astonished.” The context shows that Daniel was astonished in a negative way. He was not impressed but horrified. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

I was greatly troubled by the vision (NLT)

I was very upset about the vision (NCV)

The vision horrified me (GW)

it was beyond understanding: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as it was beyond understanding probably indicates that Daniel himself could not understand the meaning of the vision. See Collins page 342. Here is another way to translate this:

and could not understand it (NLT)

Daniel 9:1

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:1–3

In this paragraph Daniel turned to God in prayer. Verses 1 and 2 give some historical and other background information that explains why Daniel wanted to pray to God at that time.

9:1a

In the first year of Darius son of Xerxes, a Mede by descent,

- The following things happened in the year that Darius the Mede, the son of Xerxes,
- In the year that Darius, the son of Xerxes, a man of the Medes,

In the first year of Darius: The phrase the first year of Darius refers to the first year of Darius' reign. This is the same Darius who is mentioned in 6:1. Other ways to translate this include:

In the first year of the reign of Darius (NLT)

in year one of Darius' reign

It was the year when Darius began to rule

son of Xerxes: In the Hebrew text the name of Darius' father is written as "Ahasuerus." This Babylonian ruler is more commonly known by the Greek form of his name, Xerxes, and so it is probably better to use this form in your translation.

a Mede by descent: This is parenthetical information about Darius. It gives his ethnic background. He was, literally, "of the race of the Medes."

Other ways to translate this include:

by birth a Mede (RSV)

He was a descendant of the Medes. (NCV)

9:1b

who was made ruler over the kingdom of the Chaldeans—

- was made/appointed king of Babylonia.
- began to rule the Babylonian empire,

who was made ruler over the kingdom of the Chaldeans:

This clause refers to Darius, not Xerxes. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear by beginning a new sentence here. For example:

Darius was made/appointed king over the Babylonian empire

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as was made ruler is passive. It does not indicate who made Darius the king. There are several ways to translate this:

- using a passive verb. For example:

who was made king over the kingdom of the Chaldeans (NASB)

- using an active verb. In some languages it may be necessary to supply a subject. For example:

they made him ruler of the Babylonian kingdom

- using a verb that does not take an object (intransitive verb). For example:

who became king of the Babylonians (NLT)

the kingdom of the Chaldeans: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the kingdom of the

Chaldeans is literally “the kingdom of the Chaldeans.” This is a reference to the Babylonian empire. See also 1:4d and 5:30.

Daniel 9:2

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:1–3

In this paragraph Daniel turned to God in prayer. Verses 1 and 2 give some historical and other background information that explains why Daniel wanted to pray to God at that time.

9:2a

in the first year of his reign, I, Daniel, understood from the sacred books,

- In the first year of his rule, I, Daniel, realized from the Scriptures
- I Daniel was reading the holy scrolls/books. I noticed/read that

in the first year of his reign: This is a repetition of the information in 9:1a. The GNT does not repeat it. Place this information where it is most natural in your language.

I, Daniel, understood from the sacred books: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as understood here means “perceived, observed.” Daniel learned something from the Scriptures. Other ways to translate this include:

I, Daniel, learned from the Scriptures (GW)

I, Daniel, came to understand from the sacred books (NET)

I found out from studying the writings of the prophets (CEV)

the sacred books: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the sacred books is literally “the scrolls” or “the books.” From the context it is clear that these were the holy books or writings of the Jews, the books that we now refer to as the Old Testament Scriptures. The book of Jeremiah was one of these. Refer to these books in a way that is natural in your language. However, your translation should not indicate that these were printed and bound books such as we have today. They were scrolls made of papyrus (made from reeds) or parchment (made from animal skin).

9:2b

according to the word of the LORD to Jeremiah the prophet,

- in the message that Yahweh had given/told to the prophet Jeremiah,
- Yahweh had told the prophet Jeremiah

according to the word of the LORD to Jeremiah the prophet: This verse part indicates what specific part of the Scriptures Daniel had been reading. He had been reading the book of Jeremiah. See Jeremiah 25:11–12 and 2 Chronicles 36:21.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

Yahweh had told Jeremiah the prophet that...

the Lord had said to Jeremiah (CEV)

the LORD: The Hebrew name of God that the BSB translates as the LORD is the holy Name that the Jewish people did not pronounce or read aloud. It is written in the Hebrew Scriptures as four consonantal letters (YHWH), the Tetragrammaton, and the vowels originally attached to these letters are not certain. The Name was always read aloud as the Hebrew word meaning “the Lord.” These Notes represent the Name with the English form Yahweh, as does the NJB.

Jeremiah the prophet: An Old Testament prophet was a man sent from God to give a message to the people of Israel. Sometimes this message involved telling about future things and sometimes it did not. See the article KBT Prophet 1(a) and (b). Other ways to translate this include:

Jeremiah the man from God

the man of God named Jeremiah

General Comment on 9:2a-b

“The Scriptures” and “the word of the LORD” are two ways of referring to the same book or books, that is, the Holy Scriptures, or the Word of God. In some languages it may therefore be natural to follow the NLT and reorder the information in these verses, combining the two references to the Word of God into one:

I, Daniel, learned from reading the word of the LORD, as revealed to Jeremiah the prophet (NLT)

9:2c

that the desolation of Jerusalem would last seventy years.

- that Jerusalem would be in ruins for 70 years.
- that Jerusalem would lie ruined for seventy (70) years.

that the desolation of Jerusalem would last seventy years: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as the desolation of Jerusalem would last seventy years is more literally “to complete the ruin/destruction of Jerusalem—seventy years.” This indicates that the city of Jerusalem would be ruined and would continue to remain in ruins for seventy years. Other ways to translate this include:

that Jerusalem would be empty ruins for seventy years (NCV)

that Jerusalem must lie desolate for seventy years (NLT)

General Comment on 9:2b-c

In some languages it may be natural to translate God’s word to Jeremiah as direct speech. For example:

the Lord had said to Jeremiah, “Jerusalem will lie in ruins for seventy years.” (CEV)

Daniel 9:3

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:1–3

In this paragraph Daniel turned to God in prayer. Verses 1 and 2 give some historical and other background information that explains why Daniel wanted to pray to God at that time.

9:3a

So I turned my attention to the Lord God to seek Him by prayer and petition,

- So I turned/gave my face/attention to the Lord God. I prayed and begged him earnestly/seriously.
- So I began to pray to the Lord God with full sincerity. I begged/asked him for help.

So I turned my attention to the Lord God: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as I turned my attention to the Lord God is literally “I set my face to the Lord God.” This indicates that Daniel gave the Lord God his full attention. If he was doing other things, he left them and concentrated on praying to God. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

So I began to pray earnestly to the Lord God

So I turned my attention to the Lord God (NET)

the Lord God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master.” It is not the holy name of God that the BSB translates as LORD (9:2c).

to seek Him by prayer and petition: The phrase to seek Him by prayer and petition indicates that Daniel prayed to God, and in his prayer he asked God for help. The prayer and petition are not separate actions. Other ways to translate this include:

to seek Him by prayer and supplications (NASB)

to implore him by prayer and requests (NET)

and prayed and asked him for help (NCV)

to seek Him: The Hebrew verb that the BSB literally translates as to seek Him indicates that Daniel was looking or asking for God's mercy and an answer to his prayer.

prayer and petition: The two nouns that the BSB translates as prayer and petition both refer to the action of asking God for help. In some languages it may be natural to follow the GW and translate them as verbs:

I prayed, pleaded... (GW)

9:3b

with fasting, sackcloth, and ashes.

- I fasted, and I wore sackcloth and sprinkled myself with ashes.
- I dressed in mourning clothes and refused to eat anything. I put cold ashes on my head to show my sorrow/repentance.

with fasting, sackcloth, and ashes: This verse part indicates what Daniel did while he prayed to God. He fasted and he wore sackcloth and sprinkled ashes on himself. These actions all indicated sorrow and repentance. In some languages it may be natural to translate one or more of the nouns with verbs. For example:

and fasted in sackcloth and ashes (GW)

I fasted. I wore sackcloth and put ashes on my head.

with fasting: The phrase with fasting indicates that Daniel chose not to eat in order to show his grief and sincere repentance. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the meaning or purpose of this action. For example:

I refused to eat to show my sorrow

sackcloth: The phrase sackcloth indicates that Daniel wore clothing made from rough cloth as a sign of his sincere mourning and repentance. See Esther 4:1, Isaiah 58:5, and Matthew 11:21. Here is another way to translate this:

I also wore rough burlap (NLT)

and ashes: The phrase and ashes is short for “and in ashes.” This indicates that Daniel sat in ashes or put ashes on himself, probably on his head, to show his sorrow and sincerity. See how you translated this in Jeremiah 6:26 and Luke 10:13 and the examples above. The NLT says;

and sprinkled myself with ashes

General Comment on 9:3b-c

It is probable that Daniel put on sackcloth and ashes and began to fast before he began to pray. In some languages it may therefore be natural to reorder the action recorded in these verse parts. For example:

^{3c}I dressed myself in sackcloth and sat in ashes. I stopped eating ^{3b}and began to pray and ask God for help.

General Comment on 9:3b

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the purpose of the three actions. For example:

Then, to show my sorrow, I went without eating and dressed in sackcloth and sat in ashes. (CEV)

Daniel 9:4

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:4–6

Daniel confessed to God the sin of his people, the people of Israel.

9:4a

And I prayed to the LORD my God and confessed,

- ¶ As I prayed to Yahweh my God, I confessed to him the sins of my people. I said,
- ¶ I admitted to Yahweh my God that we^(excl) had sinned. I prayed/said,

And I prayed to the LORD my God and confessed: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as prayed and confessed refer to the same action, that of speaking to God in sorrow for sin. The confession was the content of the prayer. The sins that Daniel confessed were the common sins of the people of Israel. Other ways to translate this include:

I prayed to Yahweh my God. I admitted to him the sins of my people.

I prayed to the Lord my God, confessing in this way: (NET)

9:4b

“O, Lord, the great and awesome God,

- “Lord, you are the great and awesome God.
- “Our^(excl) Master, you are the great God, the God who is/deserves to be feared.

O, Lord, the great and awesome God: Daniel praised God by describing him as great and awesome. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as awesome describes God as so great and holy that he is worthy of fear and respect. Other ways to translate this include:

O Lord, you are a great and awesome God! (NLT)

Our Lord, you are a great and fearsome God (CEV)

However, it is important to avoid implying that there are many gods and that the Lord is one of the great and awesome ones. In some languages it may be necessary to avoid this wrong meaning by translating this phrase as one or two separate clauses. For example:

Lord God, you are great, and we honor you. (GNT)

9:4c

who keeps His covenant of loving devotion to those who love Him and keep His commandments,

- You^(sing) are faithful to your covenant and to those who love you and obey your commandments.
- You are loyal to the solemn agreement you made with us. You are loyal to your loving and obedient people.

who keeps His covenant of loving devotion: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as keeps His covenant of loving devotion is more literally “keeps the covenant and the love.” The covenant and the “love” form one idea. They are not two separate things that God kept. Rather, God showed his love for his people by remaining faithful to the covenant that he had made with them. God’s covenant promise was to be loving and faithful to his people, and he had kept that promise.

Other ways to translate this include:

You are faithful to your covenant and show constant love (GNT)

you keep the covenant and show faithful love (NJB)

You are faithful to your covenant. You always act in love...

covenant: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as covenant in this context refers to God’s solemn agreement with his people Israel. See KBT “covenant” and see how you translated this in Deuteronomy 7:9, 1 Kings 8:23, Luke 1:72–73, Acts 3:25, and Hebrews 8:8–10.

loving devotion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as loving devotion has a broad range of meanings, all positive. In this case it refers to God’s loyalty and faithfulness to his people.

to those who love Him and keep His commandments: This phrase describes the people to whom God shows his faithful love. In your translation, be sure to make it clear that this refers to one group of people with two characteristics, and not to two different groups. Other ways to translate this include:

with those who love him, those who keep/obey his commandments

with those who love and obey you (CEV)

to those who love you and do what you command (GNT)

Daniel 9:5

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:4–6

Daniel confessed to God the sin of his people, the people of Israel.

9:5a

we have sinned and done wrong.

- We^(excl) have sinned. We have done wrong things.
- But we have done wrong things. Yes, we have done evil.

we have sinned and done wrong: Daniel included himself among the people of God who had sinned. He emphasized the greatness of their sin by using two different verbs. In some languages it may be natural to emphasize this in a different way. For example:

But we have sinned terribly (CEV)

9:5b

We have acted wickedly and rebelled.

- We^(excl) have acted wickedly and have rebelled against you.
- Our actions have been wicked/evil and we have refused to obey you.

We have acted wickedly and rebelled: Daniel again used two different verbs to speak about one way or pattern of behaving. He said that the people of Israel had acted wickedly and had rebelled against God, that is, they had rebelled by acting wickedly. Other ways to translate this include:

but we have sinned by refusing to obey you

We have been wicked and have turned against you (NCV)

9:5c

We have turned away from Your commandments and ordinances.

- We^(excl) have ignored your commands and your laws.
- We have not followed your commands.

We have turned away from Your commandments and ordinances: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates literally as We have turned away means to decide to ignore something. Consider if this physical act has a similar meaning in your culture. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- translate the action literally. For example:

we have turned our backs on your commands and laws

- translate the meaning of the action. For example:

we have rejected your commandments and your decrees (REB)

and scorned your commands and regulations (NLT)

we have stopped following your commands and laws

commandments and ordinances: The two nouns that the BSB translates as commandments and ordinances both refer to the orders or instructions that God gave to his people. In some languages it may be natural to combine them into one expression. For example:

the things that you commanded us to do

Daniel 9:6

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:4–6

Daniel confessed to God the sin of his people, the people of Israel.

9:6a

We have not listened to Your servants the prophets,

- We^(excl) have not paid attention to your servants the prophets.
- We have ignored the message you gave to your servants the prophets.

We have not listened to Your servants the prophets:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as have not listened in this context indicates that the people of Israel refused to listen to God's message. They might have heard the message, but they did not pay it any attention or follow it. Other ways to translate this include:

We have refused to listen to your servants the prophets (NLT)

We have ignored the message your servants the prophets spoke (CEV)

9:6c

and to all the people of the land.

- They spoke to all the people in/of the land of Israel.
- and to all the ordinary people in Israel.

9:6b–c

to our kings, leaders, and fathers, and to all the people of the land: These are the groups that the prophets addressed. The pronoun our refers to the people of Israel.

9:6b

who spoke in Your name to our kings, leaders, and fathers,

- They spoke in your name/authority to our kings, our leaders, and our fathers.

- You told them to speak to our ancestors and so they told/gave your word/message to our kings and other rulers

who spoke in Your name: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in Your name means “with your authority.” God told the prophets what to say, and they told the people that the message was from God. Other ways to translate this include:

who spoke on your authority (NLT)

who spoke for you (NCV)

who gave your message

General Comment on 9:6a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:6a and 9:6b and translate them in chronological order. For example:

^{6b}Your servants the prophets spoke in your name to our kings and other rulers. They spoke to our ancestors, and, yes, to all the people of Israel.

^{6a}But we^(excl) did not pay/give them any attention.

Daniel 9:7

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:7–10

Daniel recognized that the shame and disgrace felt by the people of Israel was due to their disobedience to God.

9:7a**To You, O Lord, belongs righteousness,**

- ¶ “Lord, you are righteous/good,
- ¶ “Our Master, you always act correctly/justly.

To You, O Lord, belongs righteousness: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as To You, O Lord, belongs righteousness is literally “to you Lord righteousness.” This indicates that God is characterized by righteousness. He always acts righteously. That is, he always acts justly. Other ways to translate this include:

To you, O Lord, belongs righteousness (ESV)

Saving justice, Lord, is yours (NJB)

You are our righteous Lord

9:7b**but this day we are covered with shame—**

- but today we^(excl) feel disgrace/shame.
- But today we are disgraced.

but this day we are covered with shame: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as we are covered with shame is literally “to us shame of face.” This is an idiom that refers to being shamed or disgraced in front of others. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. Other ways that English versions translate this include:

we have only the look of shame we wear today (NJB)

But still we suffer public disgrace (CEV)

but we are humiliated this day (NET)

9:7c**the men of Judah, the people of Jerusalem, and all Israel near and far,**

- We,^(excl) the people of Judah and Jerusalem and all Israel, near and far,
- Whether we are at home or abroad, we the people of Jerusalem and the rest of Judah and Israel, are ashamed.

the men of Judah, the people of Jerusalem, and all Israel near and far: This verse part explains or defines the word “we” in the previous verse part. In

some languages it may be natural to make this clear by beginning a new sentence. For example:

This includes all of us, both far and near—the people of Judah, Jerusalem, and Israel (CEV)

This is true of all of us, including the people of Judah and Jerusalem and all Israel, scattered near and far (NLT)

We ^(excl) all feel shame, the people of Judah and Jerusalem and all Israel, whether we are at home or abroad

At the time when Daniel was praying, many of the people of Israel had been deported to Assyria or Babylon. They were not all living in Israel. So in your translation, you should not indicate that the people of Israel, Judah, or Jerusalem were actually living there. Some were, but many were not.

near and far: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as near and far indicates that some of the people of Judah, Jerusalem, and Israel were living at home in their own land and that some were living far away. Other ways to translate this phrase include:

in countries near and far (GW)

both far and near (CEV)

at home and abroad

9:7d**in all the countries to which You have driven us**

- in all the foreign/different countries where you^(sing) have scattered us^(excl), we feel shame.
- You have made us live abroad in many different lands

in all the countries to which You have driven us:

This phrase describes the people mentioned in 9:7c who were “far” from Israel. They were living in various other countries because God had caused them to be scattered there. Other ways to translate this include:

whom you scattered among many nations (NCV)

those you sent away to foreign lands

9:7e**because of our unfaithfulness to You.**

- You scattered us because we acted toward you with treachery.
- because we were unfaithful/disloyal to you.

because of our unfaithfulness to You: This clause explains the reason why God had scattered the people of Israel in other lands. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as our unfaithfulness to You is more literally “the unfaithfulness/treachery with which they acted unfaithfully/treacherously against you.” This repetition of the root word for “unfaithful” emphasizes the horror of what the people had done. They had acted like a woman who is unfaithful to her husband or a man who betrays his king. They had not kept the covenant that God had made with them, and they had worshiped other gods. By doing this they had broken their relationship with him. Other ways to translate this include:

because they have behaved unfaithfully toward you (NET)

because they were not loyal to you (NCV)

because they broke faith with you

Daniel 9:8**Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks**

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:7–10

Daniel recognized that the shame and disgrace felt by the people of Israel was due to their disobedience to God.

9:8a**O LORD, we are covered with shame—our kings, our leaders, and our fathers—**

- Yahweh, we^(excl) and our kings, our rulers and our ancestors are all ashamed/disgraced
- We have all been put to shame/disgrace, we and our rulers and our ancestors.

O LORD, we are covered with shame—our kings, our leaders, and our fathers: This verse part adds to or expands the idea of 9:7b, that the people of Israel were ashamed and humiliated. The same idiom “shame of face” is used. This repetition emphasizes the idea. Other way to indicate this emphasis include:

Lord, we are all ashamed. Our kings and leaders and our fathers are ashamed (NCV)

Yes, Yahweh, our faces and covered with shame. Even our kings, our rulers, and our ancestors are disgraced/humiliated.

9:8b**because we have sinned against You.**

- because we^(excl) have sinned against you.
- This has happened because we have sinned against you.

because we have sinned against You: This clause gives the reason why the people of Israel were all covered with shame. They had sinned against Yahweh.

Daniel 9:9**Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks**

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the

seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:7–10

Daniel recognized that the shame and disgrace felt by the people of Israel was due to their disobedience to God.

9:9a

To the Lord our God belong compassion and forgiveness,

- You, our Lord God, are full of mercy and you forgive people.
- Our Master and God, you are compassionate. We ask you to forgive us

To the Lord our God belong compassion and forgiveness: Since Daniel was continuing to pray, in many languages it may be natural or necessary for him to address God using a second-person pronoun. For example:

Lord God, you are merciful and forgiving (CEV)

But, Lord our God, you show us mercy and forgive us (NCV)

the Lord our God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the Lord means “the Master.” In many languages it may be natural to attach the possessive pronoun to this word:

Our^(excl) Master and God

belong compassion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as compassion means “compassions.” God’s nature is one of compassion and pity toward his people. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a verb indicating regular or constant behavior:

you^(sing) give mercy

you have pity

you show compassion

forgiveness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as forgiveness means “forgivenesses.” God’s nature is also one that leads him to regularly forgive his people.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a verb. For example:

you forgive us/people

9:9b

even though we have rebelled against Him

- We^(excl) need/ask forgiveness because we have rebelled against you.
- because we have not obeyed you.

even though we have rebelled against Him: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as even though is more often translated as “for” or “because.” In this context it introduces the reason why the people needed God’s mercy and forgiveness (9:9a). So in many languages it may be natural to translate this as:

For we^(excl) have rebelled against you

Daniel 9:10

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:7–10

Daniel recognized that the shame and disgrace felt by the people of Israel was due to their disobedience to God.

9:10a

and have not obeyed the voice of the LORD our God

- Yahweh our God, we^(excl) have not obeyed your voice/ words.
- We have not done as you told us.

and have not obeyed the voice of the LORD our God:

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as and have not obeyed is literally “we have not listened to the voice of.” This indicates that the people of Israel did not listen to what Yahweh told them, his words. They did not pay attention to what he said and did not obey his instructions. Other ways to translate this include

We did not listen to you, O LORD our God.

we ignored your words/voice, Yahweh our God

9:10b**to walk in His laws, which He set before us through His servants the prophets.**

- We^(excl) have not kept the laws that you set before us through your servants the prophets.
- We have not followed/obeyed your laws that your servants the prophets gave us.

to walk in His laws, which He set before us: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as to walk in His laws, which He set before us is more literally “by walking in his laws which he set before us.” Yahweh told the people of Israel to walk in the laws he gave them through the prophets. If the people of Israel had listened to Yahweh (9:10a), they would have “walked” in his laws, that is, obeyed them. But they did not. Other ways to translate this include:

by following his laws, which he set before us (NRSV)

by living according to his laws that he set before us (NET)

nor followed the laws he has given us (NJB)

through His servants the prophets: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as through His servants the prophets is literally “by the hand of his servants the prophets.” This is an idiom indicating agency, similar to the English phrase “they handed them to us.” See also 2 Kings 17:3. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

which his servants the prophets told us

General Comment on 9:10b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

We have not followed the instruction he gave us through his servants the prophets.

Daniel 9:11**Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks**

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:11–14

In this paragraph Daniel affirmed that God was justified in punishing the people of Israel for their disobedience.

9:11a**All Israel has transgressed Your law**

- ¶ “All the people of Israel have broken your law
- ¶ “The people of Israel have disobeyed your instructions.

All Israel has transgressed Your law: This is a general statement. Daniel confessed that the people of Israel in general had broken the laws that God had given them. He himself was one of the people of Israel, and in some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

We, the people of Israel, have all broken/disobeyed your law

transgressed: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as transgressed means to cross a boundary. In this context it refers to disobeying the Torah, the book of instructions and laws that God gave Moses for Israel. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

All Israel has broken your law (NET)

Everyone in Israel has disobeyed your law!

9:11b

and turned away, refusing to obey Your voice;

- and turned away from it/you. We^(excl) have refused to obey you.
- They/We have ignored them. They/We have refused to do as you instructed them/us.

and turned away: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates literally as turned away means to turn from something in order to ignore it. See the Notes on 9:5c and how you translated it there. In some languages it may be natural to supply an object and indicate explicitly from what the people had turned away. The object is the same as in 9:11a, the law or instruction of God. The implied subject of the verb is the whole people of Israel, which included Daniel himself. For example:

We ^(excl) have turned away from your^(sing) law/
instruction

refusing to obey Your voice: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as refusing to obey Your voice is more literally “not listening to your voice.” This is another way of describing the same action as “turned away.” Other ways to translate this include:

not listening to you

unwilling to listen to your voice (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

They have not paid any attention to what you say/
command.

We have refused to listen to you.

9:11c

so the oath and the curse written in the Law of Moses the servant of God has been poured out on us,

- So evil things have come/fallen upon us, the curses and oaths that are written in the Law of Moses the servant of God,
- So you^(sing) have brought upon us the solemn curses in Moses' Law/Instruction book.

so: The common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as so here introduces a result clause. Here is another way to translate this:

Therefore (NIV)

the oath and the curse written in the Law of Moses the servant of God has been poured out on us: This is a passive clause. The implied actor is God himself. He had caused the people of Israel to suffer from the curses that Moses warned the people about in Deuteronomy 28. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- using a passive verb. For example:

the solemn curses and judgments written in the Law of Moses, the servant of God, have been poured down on us (NLT)

- using an active verb. For example:

you have poured out on us the judgment solemnly threatened in the law of Moses the servant of God (NET)

you brought on us the curses that are written in the Law of Moses, your servant (GNT)

the oath and the curse: This phrase is literally “the curse and the oath.” The BSB has reversed the order of these two words. Together, they form one idea that refers to the judgments that God warned about in Deuteronomy 28.

written in the Law of Moses the servant of God: The verb written is passive in form. Moses was the author of the law in the sense that he gave the people the law from God. He may or may not have written it personally, and this is not in focus here. Other ways to translate this include:

that the law of Moses the servant of God describes

about which the law of Moses the servant of God warns

in the book of the law of God's servant Moses

the Law of Moses: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Law is “torah,” that is, instruction. In this

context it refers to the written Law or Torah of the Hebrew Old Testament, and specifically the book of Deuteronomy. This law was of Moses in the sense that Moses gave it to the people from God. Other ways to translate this include:

the law that Moses gave us

the Teachings of Moses (NCV)

9:11d

because we have sinned against You.

- for we^(excl) have sinned against you.
- You have done this to us because we sinned against you.

because we have sinned against You: This is a reason clause. It indicates the reason why God had poured out on the people of Israel the curses written in the law.

General Comment on 9:11c-d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of verse part 9:11d and put the reason before the result. For example:

We sinned against you, and so you brought on us the curses that are written in the Law of Moses, your servant. (GNT)

Daniel 9:12

Section 9:1-27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:11-14

In this paragraph Daniel affirmed that God was justified in punishing the people of Israel for their disobedience.

9:12a

You have carried out the words spoken against us and against our rulers

- You^(sing) have done to us^(excl) and our rulers what you said that you would do.
- You have punished us and our leaders as you threatened to do.

You have carried out the words spoken against us and against our rulers: The Hebrew word that the BSB literally translates as carried out indicates that God did as he had sworn he would do and punished the people of Israel. Other ways to translate this include:

You did what you said you would do to us and our rulers (GNT)

You have kept your word and done to us and our rulers exactly as you warned (NLT)

You have carried out the threats that you made against us and against those who led us

our rulers: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as our rulers is literally “our judges who judged us.” This way of referring to the leaders of Israel puts the focus on their authority to make decisions about right and wrong. The emphasis probably implies that they were particularly guilty.

9:12b

by bringing upon us a great disaster.

- You^(sing) have brought/sent this great evil upon us^(excl).
- You have given us a great/severe punishment.

by bringing upon us a great disaster: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as disaster is the common word for something that is “bad” or “evil.” God had caused disaster to come upon the people of Israel. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

You brought this great evil upon us.

You punished us severely.

If you use a word such as “evil”, be sure that it does not imply that God did anything morally wrong.

9:12c

For under all of heaven, nothing has ever been done like what has been done to Jerusalem.

- No city in the whole world has ever been punished as Jerusalem has been punished.
- You^(sing) have done to Jerusalem what you have done to no other city on earth.

For under all of heaven: The phrase under all of heaven is an idiom meaning “in the whole earth/world.” See the note on 7:27a for a similar expression.

nothing has ever been done like what has been done to Jerusalem: This verse part contains the two passive verbs been done. In both cases God is the implied actor. He punished Jerusalem more severely or harshly than he had ever punished any other city. In some languages it may be natural to translate both passive verbs as active verbs with God as the subject. For example:

God has never punished any city in the way he has punished Jerusalem

God has punished Jerusalem more severely than he has ever punished any other city

General Comment on 9:12b-c

In some languages it may be natural to combine 9:12b-c into one clause. For example:

Never has there been such a disaster as happened in Jerusalem. (NLT)

Daniel 9:13

Section 9:1-27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent

the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:11-14

In this paragraph Daniel affirmed that God was justified in punishing the people of Israel for their disobedience.

9:13a

Just as it is written in the Law of Moses, all this disaster has come upon us,

- Every disaster that is described in the Law of Moses has happened to us.
- We^(excl) have received all the evils that the Law of Moses threatens.

Just as it is written in the Law of Moses: The phrase the Law of Moses again refers to the Torah, the Old Testament Scriptures that we now know as the first five books of the Old Testament.

all this disaster has come upon us: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as disaster means an event that is “bad” or “evil.” The people of Israel had experienced punishment in accordance with what was written in the Law of Moses. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that this disaster or evil was punishment. For example:

we have received punishment

we have been punished

If you use a word such as “evil”, be sure that it does not imply that God did anything morally wrong.

General Comment on 9:13a

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 9:13a. For example:

giving us all the punishment described in the Law of Moses (GNT)

Every curse written against us in the Law of Moses has come true (NLT)

9:13b

yet we have not sought the favor of the LORD our God

- In spite of this, we^(excl) have not tried to please you, Yahweh our God.
- Yet we have refused to act/live in the way that pleases you.

yet we have not sought the favor of the LORD our God: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as sought the favor means “appease, pacify.” The idea is to try to make someone a friend or to stop them from being angry. Other ways to translate this include:

Still we have not tried to pacify the Lord our God (NET)

But even now, O Lord our God, we have not tried to please you (GNT)

9:13c

by turning from our iniquities and giving attention to Your truth.

- We^(excl) have not turned from our sins or paid attention to your truth.
- We have not given up our sinful ways or given ourselves to your truth.

by turning from our iniquities: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as by turning from our iniquities means “by ceasing to sin.” This is the first thing that the people of Israel had failed to do. They had not stopped doing those things that they knew made God angry.

and giving attention to Your truth: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as and giving attention to Your truth describes a second thing that the people of Israel had not done. They had not tried to please God by turning from their sins. Nor had they tried to please God by giving/paying attention to God’s truth.

Here is another way to translate this:

or by following your truth (GNT)

Your truth: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Your truth can also be translated as “your faithfulness.” God is dependable and reliable and always does what he says. The people of Israel had not chosen to remember that. Other ways to translate this include:

you are true to your word (REB)

Daniel 9:14

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the

vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:11–14

In this paragraph Daniel affirmed that God was justified in punishing the people of Israel for their disobedience.

9:14a

Therefore the LORD has kept the calamity in store and brought it upon us.

- Yahweh, you watched/waited and brought disaster on us.
- You waited/watched for the right time and then you brought this disaster on us.

Therefore the LORD has kept the calamity in store and brought it upon us: Daniel was still praying to God. So in many languages it will be natural or necessary to address God using the second person. For example:

You, Yahweh, did not hesitate to bring the disaster on us

The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as has kept the calamity in store and brought it upon us is more literally “and he kept watch over the disaster and he brought it on us.” The idea is probably that God waited and watched for the right time to punish Israel. Other ways to translate this include:

Yahweh has watched for the right moment to bring disaster on us (NJB)

You, O Lord our God, were prepared to punish us, and you did (GNT)

Therefore the Lord has brought upon us the disaster he prepared (NLT)

9:14b

For the LORD our God is righteous in all He does;

- For everything you do is right/just, Yahweh our God,
- because you always do what is right (GNT)

For the LORD our God is righteous in all He does:

This verse part explains why Yahweh was prepared to punish Israel. It was because he was righteous, that is, just. Other ways to translate this include:

since Yahweh our God is just in all his dealings with us (NJB)

For the Lord our God is just in all he has done (NET)

Indeed, the Lord our God is right in all that he has done (NRSV)

If you have been using the second-person pronoun to refer to God, you should continue to do so here. For example:

because you always do what is right (GNT)

9:14c

yet we have not obeyed His voice.

- and we^(excl) did not obey your voice/words.
- and we have not done as you commanded.

yet we have not obeyed His voice: In this context there are two ways to interpret the common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as yet:

- It introduces the reason that Yahweh punished Israel and was right to do so. For example:

for we did not obey him (NLT) (KJV, NLT, RSV/NRSV, CEV, ESV, NJB, NET, GNT)

- It introduces a contrast. Although Yahweh is righteous, the people did not obey him. For example:

But we still did not obey him (NCV)

(BSB, NCV, NIV, NASB, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. The GNT therefore is used as the Source Line in the Display.

Daniel 9:15

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:15–16

In this paragraph Daniel began his appeal to God for mercy.

9:15a

Now, O Lord our God, who brought Your people out of the land of Egypt with a mighty hand,

- ¶ “Lord our God, you brought your people out of Egypt by your great strength.
- ¶ “O Lord our God, you led us^(excl) your people from the land of Egypt by your great power.

Now, O Lord our God, who brought Your people out of the land of Egypt with a mighty hand: Daniel began his appeal by mentioning a time in the past when God had saved his people.

In some languages it may be most clear and natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Now, Lord our God, by your power you saved your people from Egypt.

Now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now here begins Daniel's appeal. It introduces a transition of thought rather than functioning as a time word. The GNT has not translated it explicitly. You should introduce this new paragraph and appeal in a way that is natural in your language.

O Lord our God: Daniel addressed God directly as Master and God of the people of Israel. In your translation, Daniel should address God in this way using the form that is most clear and natural. For example:

our Master and God

our God who rules over us

with a mighty hand: This is an idiom referring to God's use of power. See Exodus 3:3, 9, and 14. Other ways to translate this include:

with great power (NET)

by your great power

in power

9:15b

and who made for Yourself a name renowned to this day,

- By this you made your name great and even today they/we praise you for this.
- You are still known/famous for having done this.

and who made for Yourself a name renowned to this day: This refers to the result of the event mentioned in 9:15a. By bringing his people out of Egypt, God won fame and glory for his name, that is, for himself. Many peoples and nations heard what he had done and how he had saved the people of Israel. Other ways to translate this include:

and made yourself famous even today (GW)

people praise you for that even today

renowned to this day: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as to this day refers to the time of Daniel. God had brought Israel out of Egypt a thousand years before, and yet people still praised him for it. Other ways to translate this include:

that lives on to this day (REB)

that is remembered to this day (NET)

and your power is still remembered (GNT)

9:15c

we have sinned; we have acted wickedly.

- We^(excl) have sinned. We have acted wickedly.
- We have done much/great wrong.

we have sinned; we have acted wickedly: These two clauses repeat the same thought for the sake of emphasis. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the emphasis in a different way. For example:

we have certainly done wrong

we have sinned terribly (CEV)

Daniel 9:16

Section 9:1-27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:15-16

In this paragraph Daniel began his appeal to God for mercy.

9:16a

O Lord, in keeping with all Your righteous acts,

- Lord, in the past you have done many righteous deeds/things.
- Lord, all that you have done for us is good and right.

O Lord, in keeping with all Your righteous acts: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as in keeping with all Your righteous acts is more literally "according to all your righteousnesses." In this context the phrase Your righteous acts refers to the ways in which God had been good to Israel in the past. Other ways to translate this include:

In view of all your faithful mercies (NLT)

In the past, you treated us with such kindness (CEV)

You have defended us in the past (GNT)

9:16b

I pray that Your anger and wrath may turn away from Your city Jerusalem, Your holy mountain;

- Now stop being angry with your city Jerusalem, your holy hill.
- Now please calm your fury/wrath. Do not be angry with Jerusalem any more.

I pray that Your anger and wrath may turn away from Your city Jerusalem: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as I pray that Your anger and wrath may turn away from Your city Jerusalem is more literally “let/may your anger and your wrath turn back.” This is an idiom that means “please stop being angry.” Translate this idiom in a way that is natural and respectful in a prayer. For example:

we beg that your wrath and anger may depart from Jerusalem (REB)

please stop being angry and furious with Jerusalem

In this context the phrases Your anger and wrath have the same meaning. So in some languages it may be natural to combine them. For example:

so do not be angry with Jerusalem any longer (GNT)

please turn your furious anger away from... Jerusalem (NLT)

Your city Jerusalem, Your holy mountain: The old part of Jerusalem was built on a hill, Mount Zion. In some languages it may be natural to translate these phrases describing Jerusalem as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

It is your city, your sacred hill (GNT)

it is your chosen city built on your holy mountain (CEV)

9:16c

for because of our sins and the iniquities of our fathers, Jerusalem and Your people are a reproach to all around us.

- All the nations around us now mock/despise Jerusalem and your people because of our sins and the sins of our ancestors.
- We have sinned and our ancestors have sinned. That is why our enemies now look on Jerusalem and your people with scorn/disdain.

for because of our sins and the iniquities of our fathers, Jerusalem and Your people are a reproach to all around us: This verse part indicates that Jerusalem and the people of Israel had become a reproach to all around us. The people living around Israel now looked at Jerusalem with scorn; that is, they despised it. The cause of this state of affairs was, ultimately, the sins of the people of Israel.

This is a complicated idea, and there are several ways to translate this verse part:

- Make Jerusalem and the people of God the subject of the main verb. This is the structure of the sentence in the Hebrew text. For example:

because of our sins and the iniquities of our ancestors, Jerusalem and your people have become a disgrace among all our neighbors (NRSV)

Jerusalem and your people are insulted by everyone around us because of our sins and the wicked things our ancestors did (GW)

- Make the people living around Israel the subject of the main verb. For example:

All the people in the neighboring countries look down on Jerusalem and on your people because of our sins and the evil our ancestors did. (GNT)

All the neighboring nations mock Jerusalem and your people because of our sins and the sins of our ancestors. (NLT)

- Make the people of Israel and their ancestors the subject of the main verb. This structure may be best for languages in which it is natural to present ideas in the order in which they happened. For example:

We and our ancestors sinned, and so as a result, the people living around us now look on us and our city Jerusalem with scorn.

- Make the sins themselves the subject of the main verb. These sins caused others to scorn Jerusalem

and the people of Israel. This is the way the NIV has translated this verse part.

You should choose the structure that is most natural in your language for giving this information.

our sins and the iniquities of our fathers: The Hebrew nouns that the BSB translates as sins and iniquities have a similar meaning. In this context they are synonyms. So you may wish to translate this as:

we and our ancestors have sinned

are a reproach: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as reproach is literally “a reproach, disgrace.” In some languages it may be natural to translate with a verb. For example;

we are disgraced

people all around insult and make fun of
Jerusalem and your people (NCV)

to all around us: The phrase to all around us refers to the people living in the countries surrounding Israel. It was assumed that these people were usually hostile.

Daniel 9:17

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:17–19

Daniel begged God to help Jerusalem. He recognized that the people of Israel did not deserve God’s help, but he asked for forgiveness on the ground of God’s own nature and mercy.

9:17a

So now, our God, hear the prayers and petitions of Your servant.

- ¶ “Now please listen to me, your servant. Please listen to my requests.
- ¶ “O God, our God, I am your servant. Please listen to me when I pray to you.

So now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So now is a transition phrase that here introduces a logical conclusion to Daniel’s prayer. In this context it is not a time word. Here is another way to translate this:

Now (NIV)

our God, hear the prayers and petitions of Your servant: Daniel asked God to hear his prayer. He used the phrase Your servant to refer to himself in a humble way. In some languages it may be natural or necessary to use a first-person pronoun;

O God, hear my prayer and pleading (GNT)

our God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as our God is a vocative form, a form of address. See the General Comment at the end on 9:17b.

prayers and petitions: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as prayers and petitions here both refer to Daniel’s prayer to God. In this context they are near synonyms.

9:17b

For Your sake, O Lord, cause Your face to shine upon Your desolate sanctuary.

- Lord, for your own sake look with kindness at the ruins of your holy place.
- For the sake of your own name/glory, be kind to your ruined temple.

For Your sake, O Lord, cause Your face to shine upon Your desolate sanctuary: The Hebrew idiom that the BSB literally translates as cause Your face to shine upon is an idiom that means to look kindly on someone and therefore to treat them kindly. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

look favorably on your holy place, which is lying in ruins (GW)

show favor to your devastated sanctuary for your own sake (NET)

do good things for your holy place that is in ruins (NCV)

O Lord: This is a form of address. In some languages it may not be natural to have a form of address that is different from the form of address in the previous sentence (9:17a has “God”). See the General Comment on 9:17a, b.

upon Your desolate sanctuary: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as desolate means “deserted, ruined.” The sanctuary had been heavily damaged by the Babylonian army and now lay empty. It was not fit for its purpose, and no one was using it to worship God.

General Comment on 9:17a, b

In this verse Daniel addresses Yahweh as “God” in 17a and as “Lord” in 17b. In some languages this may be unnatural or may give the wrong meaning that he was talking to more than one deity. In those languages it may be best to combine the forms of address or just use one. Place this form of address where it is natural in your language. For example:

So now, our God, accept the prayer and requests of your servant, and show favor to our devastated sanctuary for your own sake. (NET)

O God, hear my prayer and pleading. Restore your Temple, which has been destroyed; restore it so that everyone will know that you are God. (GNT)

Daniel 9:18

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the

seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:17–19

Daniel begged God to help Jerusalem. He recognized that the people of Israel did not deserve God’s help, but he asked for forgiveness on the ground of God’s own nature and mercy.

9:18a

Incline Your ear, O my God, and hear;

- Listen to us, O God our God!
- Our God, please pay attention to what we are saying/asking!

Incline Your ear, O my God, and hear: The two requests Incline Your ear and hear have the same meaning. The repetition is for emphasis. In some languages it may be natural to combine them into one, perhaps supplying an object, as the GNT has done:

Listen to us, O God (GNT)

9:18b

open Your eyes and see the desolation of the city that bears Your name.

- Look at us! See how the city that is called by your name has been ruined.
- Look at the ruins of our city, the city that belongs to you!

open Your eyes and see the desolation of the city that bears Your name:

The Hebrew more literally says “Open your eyes and look at our desolation and the city that bears your name” (NRSV). The two phrases “our desolation” and the city that bears Your name together refer to the desolation of the city of Jerusalem. The BSB has therefore combined the two phrases into one, the desolation of the city that bears Your name. Other ways to translate this include:

Look down and see the ruins of the city that bears your Name.

Look and see how the city that bears your Name lies desolate/ruined!

open Your eyes and see: The two expressions open Your eyes and see together are a request to God to pay attention to the suffering of Jerusalem. Daniel knew that God could already see the city, but he wanted him

to pay attention to it. In some languages it may be natural to use only one verb. For example:

please look at

please consider

the desolation of the city: This phrase refers to the ruins of the city of Jerusalem. In some languages it may be natural to translate it using a verb form. For example:

the city that has been ruined

the city that our enemies have devastated

that bears Your name: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as that bears Your name is literally “over which your name is called.” This implies that God is the owner of Jerusalem. See also the note on 2 Samuel 12:28d-e.

9:18c

For we are not presenting our petitions before You because of our righteous acts,

- It is not because we^(exc1) are righteous that we make this request.
- It is not because of any merit of our own that we ask this.

For we are not presenting our petitions before You because of our righteous acts: Daniel did not expect God to listen to his prayer because the people of Israel were righteous. As he had just confessed, they were not. So their good deeds or good lives were not the reason why he hoped that God would listen to his requests. Other ways to translate this include:

For it is not because of our own righteous deeds that we are praying to you (NET)

We do not present our supplication before you on the ground of our righteousness (NRSV)

9:18d

but because of Your great compassion.

- It is because of your great mercy.
- We ask it because you are merciful.

but because of Your great compassion: This is a short way of saying “but we make these requests of you because of your great compassion.” Daniel

implied that he hoped that God would answer his requests because God was compassionate. Other ways to translate this include:

but because your compassion is abundant (NET)

but on the ground of your great mercies (NRSV)

General Comment on 9:18c-d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:18d and c, putting the positive before the negative. For example:

It is because you are very merciful that we ask this, not because we are righteous

We ask this because you are compassionate. We do not ask it because we are righteous.

9:18c-d

(reordered) It is because you are very merciful that we ask these things. It is not because we think that we are good.

Daniel 9:19

Section 9:1-27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:17-19

Daniel begged God to help Jerusalem. He recognized that the people of Israel did not deserve God’s help, but he asked for forgiveness on the ground of God’s own nature and mercy.

9:19a**O Lord, listen! O Lord, forgive! O Lord, hear and act!**

- Lord, listen to me! Lord, forgive us! Lord, pay attention and do something for us!
- Master, please listen to my prayer and forgive our sins. Then please help us!

O Lord, listen! O Lord, forgive! O Lord, hear and act!:

In this series of commands, Daniel asked God to help the people of Israel. In some languages it may be natural to use the form of address (Lord) once rather than three times. For example:

Lord, please listen. Please forgive us. Please hear my request and help us.

O Lord, listen!: In some languages it may be natural to supply an object:

Lord, listen to us

Lord, please listen to this/our prayer

O Lord, forgive!: In some languages it may be natural to supply an object and indicate who or what the Lord should forgive. For example:

Lord, forgive us^(excl)!

Lord, please forgive our sins

O Lord, hear and act!: Again, in some languages it may be helpful to say specifically what Daniel wanted the Lord to hear and how he wanted the Lord to act. For example:

Lord, hear our prayer and help us

9:19b**For Your sake, O my God, do not delay,**

- For your own sake, my God, do not wait any longer,
- For your own glory, my God, act now!

For Your sake, O my God: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as For Your sake means “for the sake of your own glory.”

do not delay: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates literally as do not delay means “do not wait” or “act immediately.” In some languages it may be natural to say what Daniel was asking God to do immediately, that is, without delay:

do not wait to act/help!

help us^(excl) at once!

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the phrases in 9:19d. For example:

Don’t delay, for your own sake, O my God! (NET)

9:19c**because Your city and Your people bear Your name.”**

- “because your city and your people belong to you.”
- “For Jerusalem is yours and the people of Israel are yours.”

because Your city and Your people bear Your name:

This is a reason clause. The city of Jerusalem and the people of Israel belonged to God, and so, Daniel argued that God should help them right away. See the note on “that bears your name” in 9:18b, and how you translated the phrase there. Other ways to translate this include:

For your city and your people are called by your name (NET)

for the city of Jerusalem is yours, and its people belong to you

This city and these people are yours. (GNT)

General Comment on 9:19b-c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:19b and c, and to state first the ground of Daniel’s request. For example:

Your city and your people bear your Name. So for your own sake, my God, do not wait to help them!

Daniel 9:20**Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks**

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

9:20a

While I was speaking, praying,

- ¶ In this way I prayed to Yahweh.
- ¶ So I prayed to Yahweh.

While I was speaking, praying: The verbs speaking and praying refer to one and the same action. So in some languages it may be natural to use just one verb. For example;

While I continued praying,

9:20b

confessing my sin and that of my people Israel,

- I confessed my sin and the sin of the people, the people of Israel.
- I admitted that I had sinned and that my people, the Israelites, had sinned.

confessing my sin and that of my people Israel: This verse part begins to describe what Daniel was praying about. That is, it begins to describe the content of his prayer. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here and use a verb in the past tense:

I confessed my sin and the sin of my people Israel

9:20c

and presenting my petition before the LORD my God concerning His holy mountain—

- I asked Yahweh my God to be kind to his holy hill.
- I asked/prayed that Yahweh my God would help Jerusalem his holy hill.

and presenting my petition before the LORD my God concerning His holy mountain: This verse part continues to describe the content of Daniel's prayer. It may again be natural to translate this as a separate sentence or clause with a finite verb:

I made my request to the LORD my God for his holy hill

I humbly placed my request about my God's holy mountain in front of the Lord my God. (GW)

concerning His holy mountain: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as His holy mountain is a reference to Mount Zion, which formed part of the city of Jerusalem. See how you translated this in 9:16b.

Daniel 9:21

Section 9:1-27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

9:21a

while I was still praying,

- While I was praying,
- During my prayers,

while I was still praying: In many languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

While I was praying (GNT)

9:21b

Gabriel, the man I had seen in the earlier vision, came to me in swift flight

- Gabriel, whom I had seen in my previous vision, appeared. He flew swiftly toward me
- Gabriel flew quickly toward me. He was the one/being like a man whom I had seen earlier in another vision.

Gabriel, the man I had seen in the earlier vision, came to me: The Hebrew text describes the angel Gabriel as a man because he appeared to Daniel as a man. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear. For example:

Gabriel came to me appearing like a man, as he had in the earlier vision

in swift flight: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as in swift flight:

- it means “flying in flight,” that is, the angel came swiftly through the air to Daniel. For example:

suddenly came flying in (CEV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB, NJB, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. it means “wearied in weariness,” that is, very tired. Either Daniel or the angel was very tired. For example:

in my state of extreme weariness (NET) (NET, GW, NASB) It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of scholars and English versions. Following this interpretation does not mean that Gabriel necessarily had wings, as Daniel described him as looking like a man.

9:21c

about the time of the evening sacrifice.

- about the time when the evening sacrifice is offered.
- It was the time of the evening when the priests offer the/a sacrifice to God.

about the time of the evening sacrifice: Every day the priests in the temple offered two sacrifices. The second sacrifice of the day was offered in the late afternoon, just before sunset. Use the expression that is natural for describing this time of the day. For example:

about the time of the sacrifice that they offer as the sun is getting low in the sky

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

It was the time for the evening sacrifice to be offered. (GNT)

Daniel 9:22

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

9:22a

He instructed me and spoke with me, saying:

- He gave me the following explanation.
- This is what Gabriel said to me.

He instructed me and spoke with me: The two verbs instructed and spoke refer to one action. In some languages it may therefore be natural to follow the GW and combine them into one:

He informed me (GW)

9:22b

“O Daniel, I have come now to give you insight and understanding.

- “Daniel, I have come to give you wisdom and to help you understand. (NCV)
- “Daniel, I have come to you now to explain the prophecy to you.

O Daniel, I have come now to give you insight and understanding: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as give you insight and understanding means “to cause you to understand.” It is implied that what Daniel was to understand was the vision and prophecy of Jeremiah. Other ways to translate this include:

Daniel, I have come here to help you understand the prophecy. (GNT)

Daniel, I am here to help you understand the vision. (CEV)

Daniel 9:23

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God's people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

9:23a

At the beginning of your petitions, an answer went out,

- As soon as you^(sing) started to pray, a message went out from God.
- At the beginning of your prayer, God sent/gave a reply.

At the beginning of your petitions: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB literally translates as At the beginning of your petitions refers to the time when Daniel began to pray and ask God for help (9:3a–b). Other ways to translate this include:

At the beginning of your pleas for mercy (ESV)

As soon as you began to make your request (GW)

At the time you started praying to God for help

an answer went out: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as an answer here means “message.” In this case the message was a reply to Daniel's prayer, so the GW says:

a reply was sent (GW)

In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that the answer, message, or reply came from God. For example:

God sent you ^(sing) a message/reply

9:23b

and I have come to tell you,

- I have come to tell/give it to you,
- I have come to you to tell you what he said.

and I have come to tell you: The angel Gabriel indicated that he had come to bring Daniel the word or message from God. The original Hebrew text probably did not include the pronoun you. But in many languages it may be natural to supply it, as the BSB and many other English versions do.

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

I have come to give you the reply (GW)

9:23c

for you are highly precious.

- for you are of great value in God's sight. (NET)
- because you are precious to God/him.

for you are highly precious: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as highly precious means “a precious thing/treasure,” that is, “valuable.” This clause gives the reason why God immediately sent Gabriel to bring his message to Daniel. Other ways to translate this include:

because you are highly respected (GW)

for you are valued very much

In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that the one who respected Daniel was God himself. For example:

God thinks highly of you (CEV)

for you are of great value in God's sight (NET)

for you are God's precious treasure

9:23d

So consider the message and understand the vision:

- So think about the message and understand the vision. (NCV)
- Listen carefully so that you can understand the meaning of your vision. (NLT)

So consider the message and understand the vision: There are two ways to understand the Hebrew clauses that the BSB translates as consider the message and understand the vision:

1. They refer to two things. The phrase the message refers to the message from Gabriel and the vision refers to the revelation given by Jeremiah in Jeremiah 25. This is probably the interpretation followed by the following English versions:

So study the message, and understand the vision (GW)

Now pay attention while I explain the vision (GNT)

Listen carefully so that you can understand the meaning of your vision (NLT) (NCV, GW, NIV, NRSV, NLT)

1. They refer to one thing. Gabriel meant “think carefully about the revelatory vision.” See the NET note: “This sentence is perhaps a compound hendiadys.” For example, the NJB says.

Grasp the meaning of the word, understand the vision (NJB)

(perhaps REB, NJB, REB)

It is difficult to be sure which interpretation some of the English versions are following. However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Gabriel encouraged Daniel to listen to his message carefully so he would be able to understand the vision, that is, Jeremiah’s vision. The GNT and NLT (above) have left the object of the first verb implied (the word, message) and this may be natural in some other languages also.

Daniel 9:24

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the

vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:24–27

The interpretation of this paragraph is extremely controversial. Scholars do not agree as to how or when the words of Gabriel were or will be fulfilled. It is therefore important to translate the text as it stands, without attempting to explain any past or future fulfillment. It is probable that the prophecies were (or will be) fulfilled in more than one way and at more than one time. Antiochus Epiphanes defiled the temple in 167 BC, and Jesus saw the destruction of Jerusalem by the Roman army in AD 70 as another fulfillment (see Matthew 24:15 and Mark 13:14). Daniel’s words may also have reference to the end times. It is therefore recommended that the translator use vocabulary that permits multiple fulfillments. The translator should not include notes that allow for only one way of understanding Gabriel’s words.

9:24a

Seventy weeks are decreed for your people and your holy city

- ¶ “Seventy weeks have been decided for your people and your holy city
- ¶ “Seven times seventy years is the length of time God has set for freeing your people and your holy city. (GNT)
- ¶ “God has decided/declared that 70 weeks of years will/must pass for your people and your holy city.

Seventy weeks are decreed: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as decreed means “determined, decided.” This is a passive clause. The implied actor is God. God had decided that something should happen for seventy “sevens.” There are two ways to translate this:

- using a passive verb. For example:

Seventy weeks are decreed (NRSV)

Seventy weeks have been determined (NET)

a period of seventy sets of seven had been decreed (NLT)

- using an active verb, with the subject supplied. For example:

Seven times seventy years is the length of time God has set (GNT)

God has decided that seventy weeks of years must pass

Seventy weeks: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as weeks is literally “sevens.” This word is normally used of a literal week, a period of seven days. Most scholars believe that here, as in Jeremiah 25:11–12, the reference is to a period of years. Jeremiah spoke of 70 years, and Daniel of 70 weeks of years, that is, 70 x 7 or 490 years. Some English translations make this explicit. For example,

Seven times seventy years (GNT)

It will probably be necessary to write a footnote here, explaining that the Hebrew is literally “sevens” and that “sevens” is a way to refer to the seven-day week.

Some scholars believe this to be a symbolic period of time. Others believe that this is a way of referring to a period of 490 years. However, scholars do not agree as to which 490 years this is a reference.

for your people and your holy city: The phrase your people refers to the people of Israel and your holy city to the city of Jerusalem.

9:24b–d

These three verse parts speak of transgression, sin, and wickedness. These three words are close in meaning. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as “transgression” means “rebellion, revolt.” The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as “sin” refers to an act that is morally wrong and the guilt that results from it. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as “wickedness” can also refer to both sin and guilt.

9:24b

to stop their transgression,

- to end their rebellion
- During this time he will put an end to rebellion
- This is to stop them from turning against God/him,

to stop their transgression: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as transgression refers to rebelling against authority. The Hebrew word is literally “the transgression” and may refer specifically to Israel’s rebellion against God. Here are some other ways to translate this:

for putting an end to transgression (NJB)

to put an end to rebellion (NET)

to finish their rebellion (NLT)

9:24c

to put an end to sin,

- to bring sin to an end,
- and sin.
- and to bring an end to sin.

to put an end to sin: There is a textual problem with the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as to put an end to. The written form of the consonantal text reads “to seal up,” but the traditional form to be read aloud is “to finish.” The two possibilities are:

The original Hebrew verb meant “to complete, finish.” For example:

to make an end of sin (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NET, NLT, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB)

- The original Hebrew verb meant “to seal up.” For example:

for placing the seal on sin (NJB)

(NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the traditional spoken form of the Hebrew text.

9:24d

to make atonement for iniquity,

- to atone for iniquity, (NET)
- He will atone for their guilt,
- He will make compensation/amends for sin/evil

to make atonement for iniquity: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as make atonement basically means “to ransom, give a gift to secure favor.” It is used frequently in Leviticus for the action of the priest in offering a sacrifice to obtain forgiveness for sin. This sacrifice was understood as compensation offered to

God for the sin of the one who offered it. Some other ways to translate this include:

to atone for their guilt (NLT)

to reconcile wicked people to himself

to compensate for wickedness

In some languages it may be necessary to supply a subject and say who would make atonement for iniquity. God himself would atone for the wicked things that people had done. He would compensate for their sin by himself giving as an offering to cover their sin and so reconcile God with man.

9:24e

to bring in everlasting righteousness,

- to bring in justice that will last forever,
- bring in eternal justice,
- and then he will judge rightly/justly forever.

to bring in everlasting righteousness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as righteousness is the common word that refers to what is right and good, justice. It is implied that God is the one who will bring in eternal justice, and that he will do so on earth and for his people. Other ways to translate this include:

to bring in goodness that continues forever (NCV)

for introducing everlasting righteousness (NJB)

and justice will rule forever (CEV)

In some languages it may be necessary to supply a subject and indicate that God is the one who will bring in everlasting righteousness:

God will bring in eternal goodness/justice

9:24f

to seal up vision and prophecy,

- to confirm visions and prophecies,
- ratify/verify vision and prophecy,
- He will fulfill all vision and prophecy

to seal up vision and prophecy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as to seal up is a metaphor. In Daniel's time, people sealed their letters or other documents with a wax seal that had an identifying mark. This seal confirmed the identity of the sender

and showed that the letter or document was genuine. In this context this is figurative language meaning "to confirm, to show something to be true/genuine." There are several ways to translate this:

- keeping the metaphor. For example:

to seal both vision and prophet (NRSV)

- translating the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

to bring about the vision and prophecy (NCV)

God will confirm both the vision and the prophet/prophecy

vision and prophecy: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as vision and prophecy is literally "vision and prophet." This phrase probably refers to the prophet Jeremiah and his prophecy of the seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11-12).

9:24g

and to anoint the Most Holy Place.

- and anoint a holy of holies.
- and anoint that which is most holy.
- and he will cause the very holy place/one to be anointed.

and to anoint the Most Holy Place: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the Most Holy Place is literally "holy of holies." The BSB has supplied the word Place. Many recent scholars consider that this refers to the temple in Jerusalem. The anointing would then refer to the ceremony by which the temple sanctuary was restored and rededicated after it was defiled. See the note on 8:14. But it was more common for priests and kings to be anointed and so appointed to God's service. It is therefore good to consider that this may refer to the anointing of a man set apart for God, the Messiah, who would be the priest of the new covenant and the new temple. This is the traditional Christian understanding. See the discussion by Andrew Steinmann, Concordia Commentary, Daniel, pages 465-468. Try to translate in such a way that this phrase can refer to either a holy place or a holy man, the anointed Messiah. It is hard to do this in English, but in some languages it may be possible. For example:

to anoint a most holy one

so that the holy of holies will be anointed

anoint: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as anoint refers to pouring a little oil on someone or something in order to appoint them to a specific service for God. See how you translated this in 1 Samuel 2:10, 9:16, 1 Kings 1:34, and Psalm 23:5.

the Most Holy Place: As mentioned above, the English word Place has been supplied by the BSB. If possible, avoid using a word that can only refer to a physical place. You may wish to insert a footnote saying something like: “The Hebrew phrase can refer to a person who is holy to God (the Messiah), or to a building (the temple). This prophecy may include both ideas.”

Most Holy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Holy means to be separated and set aside for God, dedicated to God.

General Comment on 9:24b-g

These six clauses refer to six things that will happen within the period of the seventy weeks of years. In the BSB, as in the Hebrew, the verbs describing each event are in the infinitive form (“to stop,” “to put an end,” “to make atonement,” “to bring in,” “to seal up,” “to anoint”). In some languages it will be more natural to use finite verbs. These can be in one of two forms:

- using active verbs. For example:

Then God will bring rebellion and wickedness to an end. He will atone for sin, and introduce/establish eternal justice. The visions and words of the prophet will come true, and they will anoint the most holy place/one.

- using passive verbs. For example:

the rebellion will be stopped, sin brought to an end, iniquity expiated, everlasting right ushered in, vision and prophecy ratified, and the Most Holy Place anointed. (REB)

Daniel 9:25

Section 9:1-27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:24-27

The interpretation of this paragraph is extremely controversial. Scholars do not agree as to how or when the words of Gabriel were or will be fulfilled. It is therefore important to translate the text as it stands, without attempting to explain any past or future fulfillment. It is probable that the prophecies were (or will be) fulfilled in more than one way and at more than one time. Antiochus Epiphanes defiled the temple in 167 BC, and Jesus saw the destruction of Jerusalem by the Roman army in AD 70 as another fulfillment (see Matthew 24:15 and Mark 13:14). Daniel’s words may also have reference to the end times. It is therefore recommended that the translator use vocabulary that permits multiple fulfillments. The translator should not include notes that allow for only one way of understanding Gabriel’s words.

9:25a

Know and understand this:

- ¶ “Learn and understand these things.
- ¶ “So you must understand that

Know and understand this: In the Hebrew text this verse part is connected to the previous verse part by the common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” In this context it may be natural to follow the NET and say:

So know and understand (NET)

Know and understand: These are commands. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

I want you to know and understand

9:25b-e

There is a textual and interpretation problem in these verse parts. It is related to the punctuation of the Hebrew text. Scholars do not agree as to whether the phrases “seven weeks” and “sixty-two weeks” belong

together or whether they have reference to separate events. The two main views are:

1. the phrases “seven sevens” and “sixty-two sevens” belong together and refer to two probably consecutive periods of time. For example:

from the time the command is given to restore and rebuild Jerusalem until the anointed prince comes, seven sets of seven time periods and sixty-two sets of seven time periods will pass. Jerusalem will be restored and rebuilt with a city square and a moat during the troubles of those times. (GW) (BSB, NIV, GW, CEV, NET, KJV, NASB, NJB, NLT, NCV)

1. the phrase “seven sevens” refers to the events of 9:25a–d and the phrase “sixty-two sevens” refers to the events of 9:25e. For example, the NRSV translates 9:25b–e as:

from the time that the word went out to restore and rebuild Jerusalem until the time on an anointed prince, there shall be seven weeks; and for sixty-two weeks it shall be built again with street and moat, but in a troubled time (NRSV) (RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB, GNT) It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. This is one possible way to calculate the total of 69 “weeks” referred to here: The seven “weeks” (7x7, 49 years) could cover a period of approximately 457–407 BC. This would include the time of Ezra, Nehemiah, Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi. During these years the city of Jerusalem and the temple were rebuilt. The end of the sixty-two “weeks” (7x62, 434 years) would be around A.D. 27. This was near the time when Jesus Christ began his ministry.

9:25b

From the issuance of the decree to restore and rebuild Jerusalem,

- There will be a command given to rebuild the city of Jerusalem. From that time
- from the issuing of the command to rebuild Jerusalem

From the issuance of the decree to restore and rebuild Jerusalem: This verse part gives the beginning point of a time period. Scholars do not agree as to what year or to what event this refers. It is therefore good to translate this in a fairly literal and general way. For example:

From the issuing of the command to restore and rebuild Jerusalem (NET)

From the time the command is given to rebuild Jerusalem (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this decree or message as direct speech. For example:

From the time there went out this message: “Return and rebuild Jerusalem” (NJB)

the issuance of the decree: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates literally as the issuance of the decree refers to the giving or announcing of an order or law. The text does not say who gave this order, and scholars do not agree as to whom this refers. You should avoid making this explicit and translate this in a general way. You may use either a passive or an active verb. For example:

the command is given (GW)

a command will come (NCV)

to restore and rebuild Jerusalem: There are two main ways to understand the Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as restore and rebuild:

1. They refer to two actions. The first verb, which is literally “to bring back,” refers to the return of the community to Jerusalem and the remaking of the community. The second verb refers to the physical rebuilding of the walls and structures of Jerusalem. For example:

to restore and build Jerusalem (ESV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, NJB, REB, NET, GW)

1. They refer to one action. For example:

to rebuild Jerusalem (NCV) (NCV, GNT, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and if possible use two verbs to indicate the two actions.

9:25c

until the Messiah, the Prince,

- until the one anointed/appointed to rule comes
- until the leader whom God has chosen arrives,

until the Messiah, the Prince: This verse part gives the ending point of a time period. The phrase that the BSB translates as until the Messiah, the Prince is more literally “until an anointed one, a ruler.” It does not have a verb. Some English versions supply the verb “comes” (NIV), and this may be natural in some languages. In other languages it may be more natural to supply a noun. For example:

until a ruler—the Anointed One—comes (NLT)

until the coming/time of the Anointed One, the ruler

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the Messiah, the Prince does not have a definite article (the). There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to the Messiah, that is, Christ. Many English versions use initial capitals to refer to the Christ. For example:

until the coming of the Chosen Leader (CEV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NJB, NIV, NLT, CEV)

- It refers to another anointed ruler or priest such as Cyrus, Zerubbabel, or Joshua the high priest. For example:

until the time of an anointed prince (NRSV) (RSV, NRSV, ESV, REB, NET, GNT, GW, NCV)

In English versions translators have often used initial capital letters to distinguish titles and names of God and Christ, as the BSB does. It is therefore possible to see which translations are following this interpretation. However, the Hebrew text itself does not have this distinction and does not require this interpretation. Try to translate in such a way that readers can understand Christ to be a possible fulfillment of this prophecy, but that other understandings are also possible. For example:

until an anointed one, a prince, arrives (NET)

until God’s chosen leader comes (GNT)

until one who has been appointed/chosen comes

the Messiah: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates literally as Messiah means “anointed person.” In

ancient Israel it was the custom for a priest to pour a little oil on the head of a priest or king in order to appoint him to a position of leadership. This symbolic act showed that he was chosen and appointed by God. If the word Messiah would not have this meaning in your culture, it would be good to translate the meaning of the action and say:

the appointed/chosen one

God’s chosen one

9:25d

there will be seven weeks and sixty-two weeks.

- there will be a period of seven weeks and sixty-two weeks.
- seven weeks of years and 62 weeks of years will pass.

there will be seven weeks and sixty-two weeks:

This Hebrew phrase is more literally “there will be seven sevens and sixty-two sevens” (as in the NIV). As in 9:24a, the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as weeks is a symbolic reference to weeks of years, that is, to seven-year periods. Here are some other ways to translate this:

it will be seven weeks and another sixty-two weeks (CEV)

there will be a period of seven weeks and sixty-two weeks (NET)

Seven sets/periods of seven years will pass and then sixty-two sets/periods of seven years will pass.

9:25e

It will be rebuilt with streets and a trench, but in times of distress.

- Jerusalem will be rebuilt with streets and a trench/moat. But the times will be difficult/troubled.
- In difficult days they will again build Jerusalem. They will make/construct its streets and a moat around for protection.

It will be rebuilt with streets and a trench: Gabriel indicated that Jerusalem would be built up again. People could live in it and be protected. This is a passive clause, and there are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

Jerusalem will be rebuilt with streets and strong defenses (NLT)

- using an active verb. It is best to have a general subject. For example:

They will rebuild it, and they will make streets and a protective trench/moat

It will be rebuilt: The Hebrew is literally “it will return and it will be built.” This is an idiomatic way of saying that the city would be built again, that is, rebuilt. Here are some other ways to translate this:

It will again be built (NET)

They will build Jerusalem again

streets: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as streets normally refers to an open place in a city that could be used for a market place or other meeting place. It can also be translated as:

plaza (NET)

city square

a trench: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as trench refers to a deep ditch that can be filled with water. This would be done for protection, as such a ditch would be hard for enemy soldiers to cross. Here are some ways to translate this:

moat (NET)

strong defenses (GNT)

a trench will be dug around the city for protection (CEV)

but in times of distress: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as times of distress means “a time when people will experience many difficulties.” Here is another way to translate this:

but these will be difficult times (CEV)

Daniel 9:26

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:24–27

The interpretation of this paragraph is extremely controversial. Scholars do not agree as to how or when the words of Gabriel were or will be fulfilled. It is therefore important to translate the text as it stands, without attempting to explain any past or future fulfillment. It is probable that the prophecies were (or will be) fulfilled in more than one way and at more than one time. Antiochus Epiphanes defiled the temple in 167 BC, and Jesus saw the destruction of Jerusalem by the Roman army in AD 70 as another fulfillment (see Matthew 24:15 and Mark 13:14). Daniel’s words may also have reference to the end times. It is therefore recommended that the translator use vocabulary that permits multiple fulfillments. The translator should not include notes that allow for only one way of understanding Gabriel’s words.

9:26a

Then after the sixty-two weeks the Messiah will be cut off and will have nothing.

- After the sixty-two weeks, the one who was anointed/appointed to rule will be killed. He will have nothing left.
- After the 62 weeks of years, they will kill the chosen leader, leaving him with nothing.

Then after the sixty-two weeks: This refers to some time following the end of the second time period mentioned in 9:25d. Exactly how long after the end is not stated, but it is probably implied that it was not long after. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Now after the sixty-two weeks (NET)

After this period of sixty-two sets of seven (NLT)

And after the sixty-two weeks (NJB)

the Messiah will be cut off and will have nothing:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the Messiah is the same word as in 9:25g and seems to refer to the same figure. You should follow the same interpretation here as you did there. For example:

the anointed one will be cut off and have nothing (NET)

The Anointed One will be killed, appearing to have accomplished nothing (NLT)

God's chosen leader will be killed unjustly (GNT)

will be cut off: The Hebrew word that the BSB literally translates as will be cut off refers to someone dying by violence.

and will have nothing: The Hebrew phrase is literally "and nothing to him." It is difficult to be sure of the exact meaning. It is probable that this means that the life of the Anointed One will appear to end in failure. It may imply an absence of support or assistance. See the NET footnote. You may wish to follow the major translation in your area here. Other ways to translate this include:

left with nothing

with no gain/benefit/profit for him

9:26b

Then the people of the prince who is to come will destroy the city and the sanctuary.

- The people of the leader who is to come will destroy the city and the holy place. (NCV)
- A foreign ruler will come to Jerusalem. His army will destroy the city of Jerusalem and its temple.

Then the people of the prince who is to come will destroy the city and the sanctuary: Most scholars consider that this prince is a different figure than the anointed ruler mentioned in 9:25c. This prince is probably the ruler of a foreign people. In your translation, check that readers will not think that the prince

who is to come is referring to the Anointed One, the Messiah. You may wish to use a different word than prince. Other ways to translate this include:

As for the city and the sanctuary, the people of the coming prince will destroy them (NET)

and a ruler will arise whose armies will destroy the city and the Temple (NLT)

city and sanctuary ruined by a prince who is to come (NJB)

The city and the Temple will be destroyed by the invading army of a powerful ruler (GNT)

the people: The Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as the people is often used of an army. In this context it is the likely meaning. Here is another way to translate this:

the troops (NRSV)

9:26c

The end will come like a flood,

- Its end will be by/in a flood of difficulties/disasters.
- Disasters/Destruction will completely cover/overwhelm it.

The end will come like a flood: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as The end can mean either "his end" or "its end." That is, this can refer either to the end of the ruler or the end of the city and sanctuary. The two options are:

1. This refers to the end of the city and sanctuary. For example:

the end of the city will come like a flood (NCV) (KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB, NCV, CEV)

1. This refers to the end of the ruler. For example:

The end of that prince will be catastrophe (NJB) (NJB, NET, GW)

The BSB is ambiguous, but it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which fits the context better since the ruler is spoken of as alive in verse 27.

like a flood: This is a simile. The end will be like a flood in the sense that it will be overwhelming or

catastrophic. In some languages it may be natural to make the point of comparison clear. Here is another way to translate this:

speedily like a flood (NET)

9:26d

and until the end there will be war; desolations have been decreed.

- Men will keep fighting until the end. Destruction is determined.
- Until the end of that time armies will continue to make war. God has decreed/planned that there will be much destruction.

and until the end there will be war: Gabriel indicated that the armies of the nations will continue to fight until the end. The phrase the end seems to refer to the end of the seventy weeks, the end of that age. Other ways to translate this include:

and to the end there shall be war (ESV)

Men/Nations will keep fighting until the end.

desolations have been decreed: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as decreed means “decided, determined.” This is a passive verb and there are two ways to translate this clause:

General Comment on 9:26d

- using a passive verb. For example:

the destruction that has been determined

- using an active verb. It may be necessary to supply a subject, God. God is the one who decreed that this would happen. For example:

destruction which God has prepared (GNT)

God has ordered that place to be completely destroyed (NCV)

The two clauses “until the end there will be war” and “desolations have been decreed” are two ways of describing the same events. In both cases God is the one who decided what would happen. The phrase “until the end” also refers to both events. In some languages it may therefore be natural to combine the information in these verse parts. For example:

God has determined that there will be war and desolation until the very end

war and its miseries are decreed from that time to the very end (NLT)

war and destruction will continue until the end, just as God has decided (CEV)

Daniel 9:27

Section 9:1–27: Daniel asked God to help Jerusalem and received a message from Gabriel concerning seventy weeks

The vision recorded in this chapter occurred during the first year of the reign of Darius (538 B.C.). Thirteen years had therefore passed since Daniel received the vision described in chapter 8. Daniel was now more than eighty years old.

Daniel had read in the book of Jeremiah that God’s people would remain in exile and serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11). During that time the city of Jerusalem would remain in ruins. However, God had promised to bring his people back to the land of Judah after the seventy years were over (Jeremiah 29:10). Now Daniel realized that the seventy-year period was almost at an end. He prayed for his people and for Jerusalem. In response, God sent the angel Gabriel to reveal what would happen in the future.

Paragraph 9:24–27

The interpretation of this paragraph is extremely controversial. Scholars do not agree as to how or when the words of Gabriel were or will be fulfilled. It is therefore important to translate the text as it stands, without attempting to explain any past or future fulfillment. It is probable that the prophecies were (or will be) fulfilled in more than one way and at more than one time. Antiochus Epiphanes defiled the temple in 167 BC, and Jesus saw the destruction of Jerusalem by the Roman army in AD 70 as another fulfillment (see Matthew 24:15 and Mark 13:14). Daniel’s words may also have reference to the end times. It is therefore recommended that the translator use vocabulary that permits multiple fulfillments. The translator should not include notes that allow for only one way of understanding Gabriel’s words.

9:27a

And he will confirm a covenant with many for one week,

- The leader will make a strong/binding treaty with many people for one week of years.

- That ruler will make a firm agreement with many people for seven years.

And he will confirm a covenant with many for one week: The subject of the clause he will confirm a covenant is not made explicit. It may be God or the Messiah, or it may be the foreign ruler mentioned in 9:26b. It is good to leave this ambiguous, as the BSB has done.

he will confirm a covenant with many: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as he will confirm a covenant with many indicates that the ruler, or possibly the Messiah, will make a treaty with many people, possibly many groups of people. Here is another way to translate this:

he will strike a firm alliance with many people
(NJB)

for one week: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as one week is literally “one seven.” Again, this phrase refers to a week or period of seven years. The text does not indicate when this one week will occur. Presumably this period of time occurs after the end of the sixty-nine weeks and forms the seventieth and last week. The translator should not try to identify this time period with a particular time in history.

9:27b

but in the middle of the week he will put an end to sacrifice and offering.

- In the middle of that week/time, he will cause sacrifice and offering to stop/end.
- He will stop the offerings and sacrifices after three and one-half years. (NCV)

but in the middle of the week: The phrase the week here refers to the same time period mentioned in 9:27a. Other ways to translate this include:

halfway through this week (CEV)

after half this time (NLT)

when half this time is past (GNT)

he will put an end to sacrifice and offering: Many scholars consider that the pronoun he here refers to the foreign ruler. It is recorded that Antiochus Epiphanes had a pig sacrificed on the altar in the temple in Jerusalem in 167 B.C. In this way he desecrated the temple, making it unholy and unfit for the worship of Yahweh. All sacrifices and offerings to Yahweh then

stopped. However, other scholars indicate that it could also be said that God or the Messiah chose to put an end to sacrifice and offering. See Steinmann p. 474. It is recommended that you leave the subject open or ambiguous, as in 9:27a.

The Hebrew, like the BSB, uses the singular forms sacrifice and offering. Since this refers to sacrifices and offerings in general, in some languages it will be natural to use a plural form. For example:

he will end all sacrifices and offerings (CEV)

he will put an end to sacrifices and offerings (GNT)

sacrifice: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sacrifice normally refers to an animal sacrifice burnt on an altar to honor and please Yahweh.

offering: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as offering normally refers to grain, oil, or wine that worshipers offered to Yahweh.

9:27c

And on the wing of the temple will come the abomination that causes desolation,

- On the wing of the temple he will set up an abominable/disgusting thing that desolates/destroys.
- He will raise up a horrific/repulsive and destructive object.

And on the wing of the temple: The Hebrew is literally “and on the wing.” The meaning of this is uncertain. It may refer to the top corner of the temple mentioned in Matthew 4:5 (“the pinnacle of the temple”). Or it may refer to the protrusions at the corners of the altar that are sometimes called horns (see 1 Kings 1:50, Psalm 118:27 and Revelation 9:13). You may wish to follow the translation most commonly used in your area. The NRSV says that the meaning of the Hebrew is uncertain and suggests the phrase “and in their place” (that is, in place of the usual sacrifices and offerings).

will come the abomination that causes desolation:

In the year 167 BC, the Greek ruler Antiochus IV Epiphanes set up a statue of the Greek god Zeus in the temple in Jerusalem. You can read about these events in the Book of 1 Maccabees, chapter 1. This can be found in between the Old and New Testaments in a Roman Catholic Bible such as the NJB. Again, in the year AD 70, the Roman general Titus, son of the emperor Vespasian, set up an idolatrous sign of Roman power in the second temple. Jesus referred to this event as a fulfillment of Daniel’s prophecy. See

Matthew 24:15 and Mark 13:14. You can read about the historical events in the writings of Josephus. Both these events can be understood as fulfilling this prophecy. Some scholars consider that there may still be a further fulfillment to come. It is best to translate literally and not to indicate when the fulfillment may have taken place. Other ways to translate this include:

The Awful Horror will be placed on the highest point of the Temple (GNT)

Then the “Horrible Thing” that causes destruction will be put there. (CEV)

the abomination that causes desolation: This is a slightly different Hebrew phrase from the phrase in 8:13e that the BSB translates as “the rebellion that causes desolation.” Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the appalling abomination (NJB)

a revolting/disgusting object that destroys/devastates

the “Horrible Thing” that causes destruction (CEV)

In Matthew 24:15 and Mark 13:14, Jesus used this phrase to refer to the Roman army and the desecration of the temple that was to take place in AD 70. Therefore, there seem to be multiple fulfillments of this prophecy. In your translation, you should translate the Hebrew text without indicating how the prophecy was fulfilled.

9:27d

until the decreed destruction is poured out upon him.”

- Finally the fate that God decided will take/overcome the one who destroys.
- At last God will pour out on the destroyer the final punishment that he/God planned.

until the decreed destruction is poured out upon him: The Hebrew text is more literally “until the end that was/is decreed is poured out on the desolator.” This is a passive clause with two passive verbs (decreed destruction and is poured out). There are two ways to translate these verbs:

- using passive verbs. For example:

until the fate that is decreed for this defiler is finally poured out on him (NLT)

until the decreed end is poured out on the one who destroys (NET)

- using one or more active verbs. God is the implied subject. For example:

until the one who put it there meets the end which God has prepared for him (GNT)

until the time God has decided to destroy this one who destroys (CEV)

the decreed: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as decreed means “decided, determined.” It is implied that God is the actor. He decided or planned destruction of the one who was causing desolation. For example:

God has decided

God planned

destruction is poured out upon him: In many languages it will be impossible or meaningless to say that someone’s end is poured out on him. In those languages it may be necessary to translate the meaning, that this person has a violent or sudden death. In many languages that will be expressed in idiomatic language. For example:

he meets his doom

his fate comes upon him

him: The pronoun him here refers to the one who places the abomination in the temple. The Hebrew text says “the desolator,” that is, the destroyer. Here is another way to translate this:

the one who destroys (NET)

Daniel 10:1

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:1

This paragraph gives a short introduction to the long vision sequence that concludes the book of Daniel. It refers to Daniel in the third person.

10:1a**In the third year of Cyrus king of Persia,**

- ¶ The third year after the Persian king Cyrus began to rule,
- ¶ Cyrus of Persia ruled Babylon for about three years.

In the third year of Cyrus king of Persia: Cyrus became king of Persia in 558 B.C. He conquered and entered Babylon about twenty years later, in 539 or 538 B.C. The phrase the third year of Cyrus probably refers to the third year after the conquest of Babylon, about 536 BC. See Steinmann, page 482, and the note in the NET Bible. See the note on 1:21, “the first year of King Cyrus.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

In the third year of the reign of King Cyrus of Persia (NET)

When King Cyrus of Persia had ruled Babylon for about three years

10:1b**a message was revealed to Daniel, who was called Belteshazzar.**

- Daniel, that is, Belteshazzar, received a message from God.
- It was at that time that God sent another message to Daniel, whom the Babylonians had named Belteshazzar.

a message was revealed to Daniel: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as a message was revealed to Daniel is literally “a word/matter was revealed to Daniel.” This is a passive clause and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

a message was revealed to Daniel (GNT)

- using an active verb. For example:

God sent Daniel a message

Daniel received a message from God

Use the form that is most natural in your language.

a message: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as message is a common and general word that means “word, matter, thing.” Use a word that is appropriate for the vision that follows and continues from this point to the end of chapter 12.

who was called Belteshazzar: This is parenthetical information. The Babylonian king had given Daniel the Babylonian name Belteshazzar a long time before. See 1:7b, and spell the name here in the same way as you did there.

10:1c**The message was true, and it concerned a great conflict.**

- The message was true. It was about a great war.
- The message was dependable/reliable/trustworthy. It told of a great conflict.

The message was true, and it concerned a great conflict: The Hebrew literally says, “The word truth and great war.” The BSB has supplied the verbs was and concerned. Here are some other ways to translate this:

a true revelation of a great conflict (NJB)

The message was true. It was about a great war.
(GW)

The message was true: The Hebrew literally says “The word was truth.” The word that the BSB translates as message is the same as the word translated as “message” in 10:1b and refers to the same thing. So it may be natural to say:

This message was true (NET)

This revelation was true.

Here is another way to translate this:

the word was true (NRSV)

it concerned a great conflict: The Hebrew here is difficult to understand. The BSB has supplied the phrase it concerned. The Hebrew word that the BSB has translated as conflict can also mean “labor,” “service,” or “suffering.” There are two possibilities of how to interpret this phrase:

- It refers to the content of the message, which involved much warfare. For example:

it concerned a great conflict (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, NJB, GNT, GW, NET)

- It refers to the message itself as being difficult for Daniel to understand. For example:

but extremely hard to understand (GNT) (RSV, ESV, NASB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as this fits well in the context of the vision that follows. This interpretation is supported by Lucas, page 274, Goldingay, page 275, and Miller, page 277.

10:1d

And the understanding of the message was given to him in a vision.

- Daniel understood the message when/because it was explained to him in a vision.
- In a vision God told/showed Daniel the meaning of the message.

And the understanding of the message was given to him in a vision: The Hebrew is more literally “and he understood the word, and understanding came to him by the vision.” This indicates that Daniel understood the message because of a vision that he received. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He understood the word, having received understanding in the vision. (NRSV)

Daniel understood the message because he was given insight during the vision. (GW)

The BSB has combined the two Hebrew clauses into one clause. The GNT gives a model of another way to do this:

It was explained to him in a vision. (GNT)

a vision: In this context the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a vision refers to a revelation from God that is both seen and heard. Daniel received this revelation while he was awake and standing up (see 10:4b). It was not a dream.

Daniel 10:2

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:2–3

This paragraph, unlike the first, is in the first person. Daniel records what he was doing in the time before he received the vision

10:2

In those days I, Daniel, was mourning for three full weeks.

- ¶ During that time, I, Daniel, had been mourning for three complete weeks.
- ¶ Before that time, I had been living in/with sorrow for my people for three whole weeks.

In those days I, Daniel, was mourning for three full weeks:

This verse part gives background information. At the time he received the vision, Daniel had been mourning for three weeks. Here are some other ways to translate this:

In those days I, Daniel, was mourning for three whole weeks. (NET)

When this vision came to me, I, Daniel, had been in mourning for three whole weeks. (NLT)

I, Daniel, was mourning for three full weeks: In this context the verb was mourning refers to participating in religious ritual practices expressing grief over the nation's separation from God. It does not imply that one of Daniel's friends or relatives had died. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I, Daniel, spent three weeks in mourning rituals/practices

for three full weeks: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as for three full weeks is literally “for three weeks of days.” This probably implies that Daniel mourned every day for three weeks. Here is another way to translate this:

for three whole weeks (NET)

Daniel 10:3

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:2–3

This paragraph, unlike the first, is in the first person. Daniel records what he was doing in the time before he received the vision

10:3a

I ate no rich food,

- I had eaten no special/rich/fancy food.
- During that time, I ate only simple food.

I ate no rich food: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as rich food is more literally “bread of desirableness.” It refers in general to the rich and tasty foods that someone might eat during a celebration or feast. Daniel did not eat food like that. He ate only plain, simple food. Here is another way to translate this:

All that time I had eaten no rich food. (NLT)

10:3b

no meat or wine entered my mouth,

- I had not eaten any meat and I had not drunk any wine.
- I did not eat any meat or drink any wine.

no meat or wine entered my mouth: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as entered my mouth is literally “came into my mouth.” This is an idiom referring to eating. This clause explains and expands on the previous clause. Specifically, Daniel did not eat any meat or wine. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

no meat or wine had entered my mouth (NRSV)

no meat or wine passed my lips (REB)

No meat or wine crossed my lips (NLT)

I did not eat any...meat, or drink any wine (NCV)

10:3c

and I did not anoint myself with oil until the three weeks were completed.

- For three weeks I had not anointed myself with oil.

- Until the three weeks were over, I did not pour/rub any perfumed ointment on my body/skin.

and I did not anoint myself with oil: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as I did not anoint myself with oil is more literally “anointing I did not anoint myself.” The repetition of the verb anoint emphasizes the statement. It was the custom to anoint oneself, that is, apply oil to the skin, for comfort and an attractive appearance. Daniel did not do this. This was another way in which he showed that he was mourning. Here are some other ways to translate this:

nor did I anoint myself with oil until the end of those three weeks (NET)

or use any perfumed oil for three weeks (NCV)

and I put no olive oil on my face or hair (CEV)

oil: The Hebrew text does not indicate what Daniel did not apply to his skin. The BSB has supplied the general word oil. Olive oil was the normal oil used for the skin and hair, and you may wish to supply this here, as the CEV has done.

General Comment on 10:3

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the phrases in this verse part. For example:

and for those three weeks I did not put any oil on my skin

Daniel 10:4

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:4–6

Daniel wrote that he saw a vision of an awe-inspiring man dressed in linen.

10:4a

On the twenty-fourth day of the first month,

- ¶ On the twenty-fourth day of the first month of the year,
- ¶ On day 24 of the month that begins the year/spring,
- ¶ It was on the twenty-fourth day of the first month of the year that I saw the vision.

On the twenty-fourth day of the first month: This phrase gives a date in accordance with the Hebrew

calendar. The first month of the year was a spring month, approximately March or April. Here is another way to translate this:

On the twenty-fourth day of the first month of the year (GNT)

10:4b

as I was standing on the bank of the great river, the Tigris,

- I was standing beside the great Tigris River.
- I went and stood by the great river, the river called the Tigris.
- At that time I was standing beside the mighty River Tigris.

as I was standing on the bank of the great river, the Tigris: The Hebrew text describes Daniel as standing beside the Tigris River. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

I was beside the great river, the Tigris (NET)

I was by the great Tigris River (GW)

I was standing on the bank of the mighty Tigris River (GNT)

Daniel 10:5

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:4–6

Daniel wrote that he saw a vision of an awe-inspiring man dressed in linen.

10:5a

I lifted up my eyes, and behold, there was a certain man dressed in linen,

- I looked up and suddenly I saw a man wearing linen clothes,
- I looked around me. There appeared/stood a man dressed in linen clothing
- I looked and this is what I saw: a man wearing white linen clothes

I lifted up my eyes, and behold, there was a certain man dressed in linen: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as I lifted up my eyes is literally “I raised my eyes.” This is an idiom indicating that Daniel

looked up and around. When he did so, he noticed a man wearing linen clothing. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I looked up and saw a man clothed in linen (NET)

I looked up and saw someone dressed in linen (CEV)

and behold, there was: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as and behold, there was is literally “and I saw and behold.” This phrase indicates that Daniel suddenly saw something unusual or interesting. It calls attention to the following information. You should focus attention on what Daniel saw in a way that is natural in your language. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and looked, and behold (RSV)

I looked up and to my surprise saw (MSG)

suddenly there stood/came before me

suddenly I could see

a certain man dressed in linen: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a certain man is the usual word for a man, a male human. The description that follows suggests that he was not an ordinary man, but a divine being or angel. Some scholars suggest that it was the archangel Gabriel. However, he appeared to be a man, and this is how the word should be translated.

He was wearing clothes made of linen. That is, he was wearing clothes made from the fibers of the flax plant. This was probably the most common type of fabric at this time. (The other common fabric was wool, made from sheep or goat hair. It was warmer and thicker than linen, and less smooth.) Linen clothes were light, fresh, and clean in appearance. Here are some other ways to translate this:

a man dressed in linen clothes (NCV)

a man standing there. He was wearing clothes of linen fabric.

10:5b

with a belt of fine gold from Uphaz around his waist.

- with a belt made of pure/solid gold around his waist.
- wearing a belt of fine gold around his waist.
- tied/held around his body with a high-quality gold strap.

with a belt of fine gold from Uphaz around his waist: The Hebrew text is uncertain here. It more literally says “and his loins were girded with gold of Uphaz.” The location of Uphaz is unknown, and some scholars have suggested that there is an error in the text here. The possibilities are:

1. the text said “pure/fine gold.” For example:

and a belt of fine gold (GNT) (GNT, NIV, NJB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. the original text said “gold of/from Ophir.” For example:

with a belt of Ophir gold round his waist (REB) (REB)

1. the original text said “gold from Uphaz.” For example:

whose loins were girded with gold of Uphaz (RSV) (BSB, NIV11, ESV, CSB/HCSB, RSV/NRSV, KJV, NET, GW)

Since the original reading of the text it is uncertain, Perhaps the original text did read “Uphaz,” but presumably Daniel recognized that the gold was from Uphaz because of its fine quality. The BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, and NIV include both the ideas of “pure/fine” and “Uphaz.” It is recommended that you follow option (1) for translation reasons. The NJB provides a good model:

with a belt of pure gold around his waist (NJB)

Daniel 10:6

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:4–6

Daniel wrote that he saw a vision of an awe-inspiring man dressed in linen.

10:6a–e

This verse is a series of five similes. The appearance of the man by the river is compared to four very

bright things, and his voice is compared to the sound of a large crowd. The point of comparison is that the man’s appearance was very impressive or awe-inspiring and his voice was very loud. In your translation, use vocabulary and imagery that indicate the man was impressive rather than strange or ridiculous. In some languages it may be natural to include the points of similarity. For example:

His body glowed like topaz, his face shone like lightning, his eyes flamed like torches, his arms and feet glittered like burnished bronze, and when he spoke his voice sounded like the voice of a multitude. (REB)

His body looked like a precious gem. His face flashed like lightning, and his eyes flamed like torches. His arms and feet shone like polished bronze, and his voice roared like a vast multitude of people. (NLT)

His body was like shiny yellow quartz. His face was bright like lightning, and his eyes were like fire. His arms and legs were shiny like polished bronze, and his voice sounded like the roar of a crowd. (NCV)

10:6a

His body was like beryl,

- His body looked/appeared like a beautiful topaz gemstone,
- His body shone like quartz.
- His body glowed like a gem/jewel.

His body was like beryl: This is a simile. It indicates that the man’s body was bright and radiant like a beautiful gem. The exact gem that is referred to is not certain. The gem beryl is the same as chrysolite, which is how the translators of the LXX (Septuagint) understood it (see also the NIV). Other possibilities are yellow quartz (NCV) and yellow jasper (NET).

See how you translated the name of this gemstone in Exodus 28:20a (first gem) and Ezekiel 1:16. Chrysolite is mentioned in Revelation 21:20 (seventh foundation).

If these gemstones are not known in your culture, you may wish to translate using a more general phrase, as the CEV has done:

His body was like a precious stone. (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to make the point of similarity explicit. Here are some ways to do this:

His body glowed like topaz (REB)

His body shone like a precious gem.

10:6b

his face like the brilliance of lightning,

- and his face shone like lightning.
- His face blazed/flushed brightly like lightning.
- His face was as bright as a lightning flash.

his face like the brilliance of lightning: In some languages it may be natural to translate this simile as a separate clause or sentence, with its own verb. For example:

His face was like lightning.

In some languages it may be natural to make the point of similarity explicit. Here are some ways to do this:

his face shone like lightning (REB)

his face had an appearance like lightning (NET)

10:6c

his eyes like flaming torches,

- His eyes were/looked like torches of blazing fire,
- His eyes sparkled like flaming torches.
- His eyes were as brilliant as fiery torches.

his eyes like flaming torches: Daniel compared the eyes of this man to flaming torches. The point of similarity is that his eyes were brilliant or very bright. They blazed or sparkled like torches. Try to find a word expressing this comparison that is natural in your language for referring to eyes. In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb and translate this simile as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

his eyes were like fiery torches (NJB)

his eyes were like blazing torches (NET)

his eyes blazed like flaming torches

flaming torches: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as flaming torches is “torches of fire.” It refers to torches that were lit and burning. The light

came from cloth attached to a long pole, dipped in oil, and set on fire. In Old Testament times these torches were used to give light when people were walking in the dark. See how you translated the phrase “torch of fire” in Genesis 15:17.

10:6d

his arms and legs like the gleam of polished bronze,

- and his arms and legs gleamed like polished bronze.
- His arms and legs were as bright/shiny as copper when they polish it.
- His arms and feet had the shine of a highly polished metal.

his arms and legs like the gleam of polished bronze:

In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb and translate this simile as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

his arms and feet glittered like burnished bronze (REB)

his arms and his face had the gleam of burnished bronze (NJB)

legs: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as legs more normally refers to feet. In this context either is acceptable. Here is another way to translate this:

feet (NET)

polished bronze: The substance called bronze is an alloy (mixture) of copper and tin. The word polished means “burnished,” that is, rubbed to make it bright and shiny. See Revelation 1:15.

10:6e

and his voice like the sound of a multitude.

- His voice sounded like the shouting of many people speaking at once.
- His voice was as powerful as the voice/noise of a great crowd of people.
- His words were as loud as the shouts of a crowd.

and his voice like the sound of a multitude: This simile compares the sound of the one man’s voice to the sound of a crowd. The point of similarity is the power and volume (loudness) with which he spoke. In many languages it will be natural to translate this as a separate clause or sentence with its own verb. For example:

and when he spoke his voice sounded like the voice of a great multitude (REB)

the sound of his voice was like the roar of a multitude (NJB)

his voice thundered forth like the sound of a large crowd (NET)

General Comment on 10:6

The overall impression given by the description should be one of impressive and powerful goodness. Avoid using vocabulary associated with evil power or words that sound humorous. For example, in English to say that something is “shiny” or “glittery” or “sparkly” tends to trivialize it. It suggests humor rather than majesty. The man dressed in linen was not an evil figure or a funny one, but he was a great messenger from the one true God.

Daniel 10:7

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:7–8

Daniel described his reaction to the vision. He also described what the people with him did at this time.

10:7a

Only I, Daniel, saw the vision;

- ¶ I, Daniel, was the only person who saw the vision.
- ¶ I was the only one to see/have this vision.
- ¶ I, Daniel, was the only one who saw this person who looked like a man.

Only I, Daniel, saw the vision: This clause emphasizes that only Daniel saw the vision. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I, Daniel, alone saw the vision (NRSV)

Only I, Daniel, saw the vision (NET)

In some languages a vision may be something that one “receives” or “has” rather than “sees.” Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

I, Daniel, was the only one to receive/have this vision

I, Daniel, was the only one to whom God gave this vision.

the vision: The phrase the vision refers to the vision described in 10:5–6 and continued in 10:9 until the end of chapter 12. It translates the same Hebrew word that is used in 10:1d. The context makes it clear that this vision was not a dream that Daniel had in his sleep. He was standing on the bank of the river with some other people at the time. Use a word that can refer to a revelation of God that someone can see while they are awake. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as:

this vision (NLT)

10:7c

but a great terror fell upon them,

- Nevertheless, they became so frightened
- Yet they were suddenly terrified
- Even so they were very afraid

10:7b–c

Verse parts 10:7b and 10:7c are in contrast. What happened in 10:7c is unexpected after 10:7b. The BSB and many English versions indicate the contrast with a conjunction at the beginning of 10:7c (“but”). In some languages it may be natural to indicate it by supplying a concessive conjunction at the beginning of 10:7b. For example:

^{7b} Although the people who were with me did not see the vision, ^{7c} they became so frightened that they scattered and hid. (CEV)

10:7b

the men with me did not see it,

- Those who were with me did not see it.
- The men who were there with me did not see what I saw.
- My companions did not see anything.

the men with me did not see it: This clause indicates that other people were with Daniel at the time. However, they did not see the vision; that is, they did not see the man dressed in linen. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the men who were with me did not see the vision (NASB)

the men with me saw nothing (NLT)

10:7d

and they ran and hid themselves.

- that they ran and hid.
- and ran away to hide themselves.
- and quickly hid themselves.

10:7c-d

but a great terror fell upon them, and they ran and hid themselves: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrast with what could be expected. Even though they did not see anything, the other people with Daniel were very frightened. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but they were suddenly terrified and ran away to hide (NLT)

Nevertheless, a great dread fell on them, and they ran away to hide themselves (NASB)

a great terror fell upon them: The Hebrew is more literally “great trembling fell on them.” Use an expression that is natural in your language to indicate a sudden terror caused by the presence of something awe-inspiring or supernatural. For example:

a great dread fell on them (NASB)

they were suddenly terrified (NLT)

Daniel 10:8**Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age**

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:7–8

Daniel described his reaction to the vision. He also described what the people with him did at this time.

10:8a

So I was left alone, gazing at this great vision.

- So I was left by myself and I gazed at this great vision.
- They left me alone, and I was the only one to see this amazing/wonderful sight.
- So I was the only person left to watch this wonderful vision.

So I was left alone, gazing at this great vision: The common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces what happened when and because Daniel’s companions ran away. Only he was left. He gazed at the vision alone. Here are some other ways to translate this:

So I was left there all alone to see this amazing vision (NLT)

I alone was left to see this great vision (NET)

10:8b

No strength remained in me;

- I had no more strength.
- I became weak.
- What I saw caused me to lose all my strength.

No strength remained in me: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as No strength remained in me is more literally “and strength did not remain in me.” It means that Daniel became very weak. Here are some other ways to translate this:

no strength was left in me (NASB)

My strength left me (NLT)

I felt very weak

I became weak (CEV)

10:8c

my face grew deathly pale,

- My face changed color so that it was like the color of a dead person
- My face turned deathly pale
- I became white like a person who is about to die.

my face grew deathly pale: The Hebrew clause is more literally “my splendor was turned into corruption/destruction.” This probably means that Daniel’s normal healthy appearance changed, and he became as pale as a dead person. See the notes on 7:28c and 5:6a. Here are some other ways to translate this:

my natural color turned to a deathly pallor (NASB)

my face turned deathly pale (NIV)

I became as white as a dead person

10:8d

and I was powerless.

- and I felt extremely weak.
- and I became helpless.
- I was completely exhausted.

and I was powerless: The Hebrew more literally says “and I kept/retained no strength.” This has a very similar meaning to 10:8b. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

I had no strength

and I felt very weak (NLT)

Daniel 10:9

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:9–11

The man in the vision spoke to Daniel. He helped and encouraged him to stand up and listen to the message from God.

10:9a

I heard the sound of his words,

- ¶ I then I heard the man say something.
- ¶ I heard the messenger in the vision begin to speak.
- ¶ The messenger began to speak.

I heard the sound of his words: The Hebrew is more literally “And I heard the sound of his words,” as in the BSB. This means that Daniel heard the man in linen say something. Daniel does not record what the man said or if he understood him. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then I heard the man speak (NLT)

10:9b

and as I listened,

- As I listened
- I heard the sound of his words
- I could hear the sound of his voice,

and as I listened: The Hebrew repeats the phrase from the previous verse part, saying “and when I heard the sound of his words” (RSV). In some languages it may be natural to avoid such repetition. For example:

and when I heard the sound of his voice (NLT)

General Comment on 10:9a–b

Since there is repetition in 9a–b, in some languages it may be natural to combine them. For example:

^{9a–b}When I heard his voice (GNT)

10:9c

I fell into a deep sleep, with my face to the ground.

- I became unconscious and lay with my face on the ground.
- and was dazed. I lay on the ground face down.
- but I was so stunned/overcome that I lay with my face on the ground.

I fell into a deep sleep, with my face to the ground:

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as I fell into a deep sleep is more literally “I was dazed/stunned.” This verse part indicates that Daniel lay on the ground senseless or unconscious. He was dazed or stunned by the voice of the man in the vision. See also 8:18b.

The Hebrew text does not make it clear whether Daniel fell to the ground at this point, or whether he was already on the ground after losing his strength in the previous verse, 10:8. Try to leave this open. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I fell into a trance, face to the ground. (NRSV)

I lay there unconscious, face downward.

I fell into a trance-like sleep with my face to the ground. (NET)

I fainted and lay there with my face to the ground (NLT)

Daniel 10:10

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:9–11

The man in the vision spoke to Daniel. He helped and encouraged him to stand up and listen to the message from God.

10:10a

Suddenly, a hand touched me

- Suddenly a hand touched me
- But a/his hand grasped me.
- Then I felt his hand on me.

Suddenly: The Hebrew text introduces this verse part with a word that calls attention to what follows. Older English translations often translate this as “behold.”

The BSB translates this word as Suddenly. You should focus attention on what happens next in a way that is natural in your language.

a hand touched me: The Hebrew text does not say whose hand touched Daniel, but the context implies that it was the hand of the man in the linen clothes. If it is necessary to do so in your language, you may make this explicit:

the man put/placed/laid his hand on me

touched: The context of the following verse part suggests that the hand touched Daniel with some force or strength. This was probably not a light touch. Here is another way to translate this:

took hold of (GNT)

10:10b and set me trembling on my hands and knees.

- and lifted me onto my knees and the palms of my hands.
- It/He raised me up onto my hands and knees.
- He set me up on my hands and knees.

set me trembling on my hands and knees: Scholars have understood the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as set me trembling in three ways:

1. It means that the hand raised/roused Daniel, causing him to rise from the ground. For example:

set me on my hands and knees (NET) (NET, KJV, NRSV, CEV)

- It means that the hand caused Daniel to tremble. For example:

setting my knees and my hands trembling (NJB) (NJB, GW)

- It means that the hand caused Daniel to tremble as it raised him. For example:

raised me to my hands and knees; I was still trembling (GNT) (BSB, RSV, NASB, ESV, NIV, REB, GNT, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The NRSV is used as the source line in the Display.

my hands and knees: The Hebrew literally says “my knees and the palms of my hands.” Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. Most English versions translate hands before knees, as is natural in English.

Daniel 10:11

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:9–11

The man in the vision spoke to Daniel. He helped and encouraged him to stand up and listen to the message from God.

10:11a

He said to me, “Daniel, you are a man who is highly precious.”

- Then he said, “Daniel, you are greatly valued.
- Then he said to me, “Daniel, you are very precious to God.
- Then the man dressed in linen said to me, “Daniel, God loves/values you very much.

He said to me: The pronoun He refers to the man dressed in linen whom Daniel had seen in 10:5a. Refer back to him in a way that is clear and natural in your language. Here is another way to translate this:

And the man said to me (NLT)

Daniel, you are a man who is highly precious: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as you are a man who is highly precious is more literally “man of value/preciousness.” It indicates that Daniel was very valuable or precious. It is implied that he was precious to God. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Daniel, you are of great value. (NET)

Daniel, you are very precious to God (NLT)

Daniel, God values/esteems/loves you very much.

10:11b

Consider carefully the words that I am about to say to you.

- Listen carefully to these words that I am about to say to you.
- Think carefully about what I am going to tell you.

- Try to understand my message.

Consider carefully the words that I am about to say

to you: The Hebrew command that the BSB translates as Consider carefully in this context means to think about something in order to understand it. It involves attentive listening, along with discerning, perceiving, and considering the meaning of what one hears. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Understand the words that I am about to speak to you (NET)

Try to understand what I am about to say to you.

so listen carefully to what I have to say to you (NLT)

I want you to think carefully about what I am going to tell you

10:11c

Stand up,

- Stand up on your feet,
- Stand up and be ready,
- Stand up now.

Stand up: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Stand up is more literally “stand on your standing place.” This means something like “stand up so that you are ready to listen.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

So stand up (NET)

Stand up ready/alert

General Comment on 10:11b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 10:11b and c. It is natural to assume that Daniel would first stand up and then listen to the message. For example:

^{11c}Stand up ^{11b}and listen carefully to what I am going to say. (GNT)

^{11c}So stand up ^{11b}and pay close attention. (CEV)

10:11d

for I have now been sent to you.”

- for I have been sent to you.”

- because God has sent me to you.”
- God has sent me here to speak to you.”

for: This introduces the reason why Daniel should stand up and listen carefully to the angel’s message.

I have now been sent to you: This is a passive clause. It indicates that God had sent the man/figure to Daniel. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example

for I have been sent to you (NLT)

- using an active verb with the subject supplied. For example:

God has sent me to you

he has sent me (CEV)

Translate this using the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

10:11e

And when he had said this to me, I stood up trembling.

- As soon as he said this to me, I stood up on my feet and trembled.
- When he said this, I stood up shaking.
- So I stood up. I was shaking/trembling with fear.

And when he had said this to me, I stood up trembling:

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as when he had said this to me is more literally “when he spoke this word with me.” In some languages it may be natural to abbreviate this clause. For example:

When he said this, I stood up, but I was still shaking (NCV)

Daniel 10:12

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:12–14

The man in the vision encouraged Daniel not to be afraid. He told him that God had heard his prayers. He himself had come to help Daniel understand what would happen to his people in the future.

10:12a

“Do not be afraid, Daniel,” he said,

- ¶ Then he said to me, “Do not fear, Daniel.
- ¶ The man said, “Daniel, you do not need to be afraid.

“Do not be afraid, Daniel” he said: The BSB places the words he said in the middle of what the man said to Daniel. This is good English style. However, in some languages, it may be necessary to place these words at the beginning of 10:12a, as they are in the Hebrew text. For example:

Then he continues, “Do not be afraid,
Daniel...” (NIV)

Place the words he said wherever they are most natural in your language.

Do not be afraid, Daniel: In some languages it may be natural to place the address before the command:

Daniel, do not be afraid.

Daniel, you do not need to be afraid.

he said: This phrase is literally “And/Then he said to me.” This phrase introduces what the man in linen said to Daniel.

10:12b

“for from the first day that you purposed to understand

- From the very first day when you sought to understand things/events
- On the very first day that you began to desire insight into God’s plan

for: This verse part and the following verse part give the reason why Daniel need not be afraid. The Hebrew introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for. Some translations leave the connection implied

from the first day that you purposed to understand:

The phrase the first day probably refers to the beginning of the fast mentioned in 10:2. This was three weeks before. At that time Daniel had “set his mind to gain understanding.” Here is another way to translate this:

from the very first day that you applied your mind to understand (NET)

you purposed to understand: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as purposed to understand is

literally “gave your heart.” It means to concentrate on something. Use the expression that is natural in your language. It is best to leave implied what Daniel wanted to understand, or to supply a general expression. For example:

dedicated yourself to understanding things

10:12c

and to humble yourself before your God,

- and humbly asked God for help,
- and humbled yourself and fasted,

and to humble yourself before your God: This is a second thing that Daniel had set his mind to do. It refers to fasting and praying to God, as described in 10:2-3. In some languages it may be natural to say:

and make yourself low/small before God

General Comment on 10:12b-c

Daniel humbled himself and prayed to God for understanding. This refers to different aspects of the same action. So in some languages it may be natural to combine 10:12c and 10:12b. For example:

since the first day you humbly asked for understanding (CEV)

10:12d

your words were heard,

- your request was heard by God.
- God heard your prayers.

your words were heard: This is a passive clause and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

your prayers have been heard (REB)

- using an active verb. The implied subject is God. For example:

God has heard everything that you said (GW)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your languages in this context.

General Comment on 10:12b-d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder these verse parts. For example:

^dGod has heard everything that you said ^cever since the first day you decided to humble yourself in front of your God ^bso that you could learn to understand things. (GW)

^dGod has heard your prayers ^cever since the first day you decided to humble yourself ^bin order to gain understanding. (GNT)

10:12e

and I have come in response to them.

- I have come in response to your prayers.
- I came to you to bring you a reply.

and I have come in response to them: In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

I have come in response to your words. (NET)

I have come in response to your prayer. (GW)

Daniel 10:13

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:12–14

The man in the vision encouraged Daniel not to be afraid. He told him that God had heard his prayers. He himself had come to help Daniel understand what would happen to his people in the future.

10:13a

However, the prince of the kingdom of Persia opposed me for twenty-one days.

- The spirit/demon ruler of the kingdom of Persia opposed me for twenty-one days.
- The powerful/evil one who is over the kingdom of Persia fought/struggled with me for three weeks.

However, the prince of the kingdom of Persia opposed me for twenty-one days: The phrase the prince of the kingdom of Persia appears to refer to an evil supernatural being with power or influence over Persia. Some scholars suggest that this was a fallen angel, that is, a demon. See Steinmann, page 492. It is best not to indicate exactly who or what this being was. Avoid using an expression that implies that this was Cyrus (10:1a). Here are some other ways to translate this:

The commander of the Persian kingdom opposed me for 21 days. (GW)

But for twenty-one days the spirit prince of the kingdom of Persia blocked my way. (NLT)

10:13b

Then Michael, one of the chief princes, came to help me,

- Then Michael, who is one of the most powerful princes/rulers, came to help me.
- But then the archangel Michael came to assist me. He is one of the chief commanders of the angels in heaven.

Then Michael, one of the chief princes, came to help me:

This is the first mention of the archangel Michael in the Hebrew Bible. See how you spelled this name in Jude 9 and Revelation 12:7. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But Michael, one of the leading princes, came to help me (NET)

Then Michael, one of the archangels, came to help me (NLT)

Then Michael, one of the most important angels, came to help me (NCV)

one of the chief princes: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as princes is the plural form of the word “prince” in 10:13a. However, here it refers to supernatural beings who support the cause of God and righteousness. So it may be necessary to translate it differently. God’s chief angels are traditionally called “archangels,” and this is how some versions translate this word here:

one of the archangels (NLT)

10:13c

for I had been left there with the kings of Persia.

- For I had been left with the ruling powers of Persia.
- I had been/remained struggling with the spirit rulers of Persia.

for I had been left there: There is a textual problem here. Some scholars and translations have followed the Greek translation of Theodotion rather than the Hebrew. They think that it makes more sense in the context. The two options are:

1. The Hebrew text that we have today (the Masoretic Text or MT), which says, “and I was left there.” This is followed by several English translations. For example:

for I was left there (ESV) (BSB, NIV, GW, NET, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB, NCV, GNT)

1. The old Greek translation, which says “and I left him there.” This is followed by several other English translations. For example:

so I left him there (RSV) (RSV/NRSV, NLT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the Masoretic Text. See Lucas, page 259, and Goldingay, page 276, but compare Collins page 362 footnote 32. This probably means that the man wearing linen had been alone struggling with the demonic spiritual rulers of Persia.

with the kings of Persia: There is a textual problem here:

1. The following versions follow the Hebrew text and say “with the kings of Persia.” For example:

confronting the kings of Persia (NJB) (BSB, GW, NET, KJV, NASB, ESV, CEV, NJB)

1. The following versions say “with the king of Persia,” using a singular form: (NIV, RSV/NRSV, NLT, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the Hebrew text and use the plural form. This could refer to the demonic spiritual rulers of the pagan Persian Empire, those who tried to influence its human rulers and leaders. The NET is used as the source line in the Display.

Daniel 10:14

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:12–14

The man in the vision encouraged Daniel not to be afraid. He told him that God had heard his prayers. He himself had come to help Daniel understand what would happen to his people in the future.

10:14a

Now I have come to explain to you what will happen to your people in the latter days,

- And I have come to help you understand what will happen to your people at a later time.
- But now I have come to you. I will explain to you the future of your people.

Now I have come to explain to you what will happen to your people in the latter days:

The common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now can mean “and” or “but.” In this context it is not a time word. It introduces what the man in linen had done since Michael had come to assist him against the rulers of Persia. He had been able to leave and come to Daniel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I have come to make you understand what will happen to your people in the future. (GNT)

Now I have come to help you understand what will happen to your people in the latter days (NET)

in the latter days: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as in the latter days is more literally “at the latter part of the days.” It refers to the future. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at the end of days (NRSV)

at the end of this age (REB)

in the last days (GW)

10:14b

for the vision concerns those days.”

- For the vision is about the future.”
- This vision will reveal events that will happen in the coming years.”

for the vision concerns those days: The wording of this clause in Hebrew is rather difficult. It literally says “for still/yet a vision for the days.” There are two ways to interpret this clause. They are as follows:

1. The vision concerned the future. It was for (or about) a time that was yet to come. For example:

For the vision is for days yet to come. (RSV)

This is a vision about the future. (GNT) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NASB, ESV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, NCV)

1. The vision itself was yet to come. That is, the vision was about to be revealed. For example:

For there is a further vision for those days. (NRSV)

For here is a new vision about those days. (NJB)
(NRSV, NJB, possibly CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.

those days: This phrase is probably parallel to the phrase in the previous verse part that the BSB translates as “in the latter days” (10:14a). Here is another way to translate this:

future days (NET)

Daniel 10:15

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:15–17

Daniel was in so much awe of the man in linen that he was unable to respond to him. He just looked down in silence.

10:15a

While he was speaking these words to me,

- ¶ While he was speaking to me,
- ¶ While he was saying this to me,

While he was speaking these words to me: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as these words is literally “according to these words.” It refers to the things that the man had been saying to him in 10:12–14. Refer back to this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

While he was saying this to me (NIV)

When he said this (GNT)

10:15b

I set my face toward the ground and became speechless.

- I looked down at the ground and could not speak.
- I looked down and was unable to speak.

I set my face toward the ground: The Hebrew clause more literally says, “I gave [or set/put] my face to the ground.” In this context this probably indicates that Daniel looked down at the ground. He was in awe of the one who was speaking and could not look at him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I stared at the ground (GNT)

I fixed my eyes on the ground (REB)

I looked down at the ground (NLT)

and became speechless: Daniel was too much in awe to speak. Avoid suggesting that he was being rude to the angelic figure. Here are some other ways to translate this idea:

and unable to speak (NET)

unable to say a word (NLT)

and could not speak (NCV)

Daniel 10:16

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:15–17

Daniel was in so much awe of the man in linen that he was unable to respond to him. He just looked down in silence.

10:16a

And suddenly one with the likeness of a man touched my lips,

- ¶ Then suddenly the one who looked like a man touched my lips.
- ¶ Then the messenger, who looked like a human, came and touched my lips.
- ¶ Then the one in human form reached out and touched my mouth.

And suddenly: The Hebrew text introduces this verse part with a word that calls attention to what follows. Older English translations often translate this as “behold.” The BSB translates this word as suddenly. You should focus attention on what happens next in a way that is natural in your language.

one with the likeness of a man touched my lips: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as one with the likeness of a man is more literally “as the likeness of the sons of man.” This phrase probably refers back to the man dressed in linen, the same one who was speaking in verses 11 and 12–14. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the one who looked like a man touched my lips (NLT)

the one who appeared to be a man touched my lips (NET)

one in human form touched my lips (NRSV)

10:16b

and I opened my mouth and said to the one standing before me,

- Then I opened my mouth and began to speak. I said to this one who was standing before me,
- Then I began to speak to him. I said,

and I opened my mouth: The Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates literally as I opened my mouth refers to the fact that Daniel was able to speak again and did so. In many languages it may not be necessary or natural to translate this phrase explicitly. See the General Comment on 10:16b–c following 10:16c.

and said to the one standing before me: In Hebrew this phrase is literally “and I spoke and I said to the one standing before me.” The BSB has combined the two verbs “I spoke” and “I said” into one verb (said). This verse part continues to introduce what Daniel said when he was able to.

General Comment on 10:16b

The three verb phrase “opened my mouth,” “began to speak,” and “said” all refer to the same action. In some languages it may be natural to combine them. For example:

I said to him (GNT)

I said (CEV)

10:16c–d

My lord, because of the vision, I am overcome with anguish, and I have no strength: Daniel told the angelic figure that he was as weak and helpless as a woman in childbirth. He had no strength and he

was overcome with anguish. There are several ways to connect the clauses. For example:

My lord, because of the vision such anguish has come upon me that I have no strength.

Sir, I am completely overwhelmed by the vision. I have no strength left.

Sir, the vision has been such a shock to me that I feel numb/paralyzed/stunned

10:16c

“My lord, because of the vision, I am overcome with anguish,

- “My lord, I am terrified because of what I have seen in the vision.
- “Master, I am afraid because of what I have seen.

My lord: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as My lord is used to express great respect. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language for addressing someone of high status. For example:

Sir (REB)

Master (NCV)

because of the vision, I am overcome with anguish:

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as I am overcome with anguish is literally “my pains/pangs have overpowered me.” This same expression is used of a woman in childbirth overwhelmed by the strength of her birth pains. See also Isaiah 13:8 and 21:3. The physical feeling is used here as a metaphor for feeling emotionally overwhelmed. In some languages there will be an idiom that it may be natural to use here. Here are some other ways to translate this:

at this vision anguish has gripped me (REB)

because of this vision, pain has overwhelmed me (GW)

this vision has brought me great distress

10:16d

and I have no strength.

- I have become weak.
- I have no more strength.

and I have no strength: The Hebrew text is literally “and I have not kept/retained strength.” The context makes it clear that Daniel was weak especially in the sense that he did not have the strength to speak well. He felt unable to talk with the great figure who had touched him. Other ways to translate this include:

and I’m helpless (GW)

so that I have no strength left to talk to you

Daniel 10:17

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:15–17

Daniel was in so much awe of the man in linen that he was unable to respond to him. He just looked down in silence.

10:17a

How can I, your servant, speak with you, my lord?

- How can I, your slave, talk with you, my lord?
- I am like a slave before my master. I am not able to speak to you, sir,

How can I, your servant, speak with you, my lord?:

This is a rhetorical question. It is literally “How can my lord’s servant talk with my lord?” The BSB has made it explicit that Daniel referred to himself as your servant and to the angelic figure as my lord. This may be natural or necessary in many other languages also.

This rhetorical question implies the answer “He/I cannot.” Daniel was saying that it was very hard or even impossible for him to talk with the angel. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

How can someone like me, your servant, talk to you, my lord? (NLT)

- as an emphatic statement or exclamation. For example:

I am merely your servant. I cannot talk with you, my lord!

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the reason why Daniel felt unable to talk to the angel. In

those languages it may be natural to follow the CEV, which supplies the information that the angel was very powerful:

I am merely your servant. How can I possibly speak with someone so powerful...? (CEV)

10:17b

Now I have no strength,

- I have no strength left in me.
- All my strength is gone.

10:17c

nor is any breath left in me.”

- It is even hard for me to breathe.”
- I can hardly breathe.”

10:17b–c

Now I have no strength, nor is any breath left in me:

Daniel told the angelic figure that he was weak and was only able to breathe with difficulty. Translate this in such a way that your readers will understand that Daniel felt extreme awe, even fear, at the appearance of this awesome figure. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I have no strength or breath left in me. (GNT)

For now no strength remains in me, and no breath is left in me. (ESV)

Now I have no strength: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Now I have no strength is literally “and now no strength remains in me.” Consider how to translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. It may be natural to translate the noun strength as an adjective. For example:

I do not feel strong

I feel weak

nor is any breath left in me: The Hebrew literally says, “and breath is not left in me.” Avoid translating this in a way that suggests that Daniel was dead or dying. He was probably saying that he was so overwhelmed that he felt breathless. That is, for Daniel, it was a struggle to breathe. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and no breath is left in me (NRSV)

and it is hard for me to breathe (NCV)

and I am breathless (NET)

General Comment on 10:17b–c

In some languages it may be natural to link the two clauses closely together by saying that Daniel felt that he hardly had the strength to breathe. For example:

I have so little strength that it is hard to breathe.

I am hardly strong enough to breathe.

I am almost too weak to get my breath (CEV)

Daniel 10:18

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:18–19

The angelic figure again touched and encouraged Daniel.

10:18

Again the one with the likeness of a man touched me and strengthened me.

- ¶ Then the person who looked like a man touched me again and strengthened me.
- ¶ Once more the person who looked human touched me and made me stronger.
- ¶ Then the figure like a man reached out and touched me again. I became stronger.

Again the one with the likeness of a man touched me and strengthened me: The same angelic figure that looked like a man once again touched Daniel. This made Daniel feel stronger.

Again the one with the likeness of a man touched me: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Again is a verb meaning “and he repeated.” The figure dressed in linen repeated the action from 10:16. There it is said that he touched Daniel on the lips. Here the text does not say where he touched Daniel. If you must make that explicit, it is best to indicate that he touched Daniel in the same way, on the mouth.

and strengthened me: The BSB literally represents the Hebrew here. This strengthening could have been the result of the words that follow (10:19a–b) as well as the touch.

Daniel 10:19

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:18–19

The angelic figure again touched and encouraged Daniel.

10:19a

“Do not be afraid, you who are highly precious,” he said.

- Then he said, “Daniel, you are greatly loved/valued. Do not be afraid.
- He said to me, “You are very precious to God, Daniel. You need not be afraid.
- “Daniel,” he said. “Do not be afraid. God values/loves you very much.

“Do not be afraid, you who are highly precious,” he said: The figure in human form spoke to Daniel as he had in 10:11a and 12a. He assured Daniel that he need not be afraid, for God valued him highly. See how you translated the command Do not be afraid in 10:12a and you who are highly precious in 10:11a.

The BSB has placed the speech introducer he said in the middle of what the man said to Daniel. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Hebrew order and place it at the beginning of the quoted speech. For example:

He said, “Do not fear, greatly beloved....” (NRSV)

The BSB has followed the Hebrew order and placed the address to Daniel (you who are highly precious) after the command (Do not be afraid). In some languages it may be natural to place the address before the command. For example:

He said, “O man greatly loved, fear not....” (ESV)

10:19b

“Peace be with you! Be strong now; be very strong!”

- Peace be with you. Be strong! Be strong!”
- Be at peace, and be strong. Be very strong!”
- Let peace come to you and be full of courage!”

Peace be with you!: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Peace be with you! is more literally “Peace be to you.” This was a common greeting wishing someone well. It includes the ideas of safety and

prosperity and general well-being, within (internally) and without (externally).

Be strong now; be very strong!: The Hebrew repeats the verb Be strong for added emphasis. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the emphasis in a different way, such as by using variety in vocabulary. For example:

Be strong and courageous! (NRSV)

so be brave and strong (CEV)

10:19c

As he spoke with me, I was strengthened and said,

- When he said this, I became stronger. I said,
- As he talked to me, I felt able to listen to the message. So I replied,

As he spoke with me, I was strengthened and said:

In some languages it may be natural to make the first two clauses into a complete sentence. For example:

When he spoke to me, I was strengthened. I said (NET)

I was strengthened: This is a passive verb. In some languages it may be natural to translate it using an active verb:

I became stronger (GW)

I felt stronger

I regained my strength (CEV)

10:19d

“Speak, my lord, for you have strengthened me.”

- “My lord, please continue to speak to me, because you have given me strength.”
- “Sir, please tell me the/your message. You have made me strong enough to listen to you.”

Speak, my lord: This is a polite command, or a request. Daniel asked the angel to continue speaking to him. He wanted to hear the message. Translate this in a way that is natural for asking someone politely and respectfully to do something. For example:

Let my lord speak (NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to indicate an object of the verb Speak. In those languages the object “your/the message” can be supplied. For example:

Sir, please tell me the message.

for you have strengthened me: The BSB literally represents the Hebrew of this phrase. The Hebrew text uses the same root verb as in 10:19c. Here Daniel indicated the reason why he now wanted the angelic figure to speak to him. He had been strengthened. That is, Daniel had received strength. It is implied that he had received strength to hear and understand what was said. Here are some other ways to translate this:

for you have strengthened me (ESV)

You have given me the/enough strength to listen.

Daniel 10:20

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:20–11:1

The angelic figure told Daniel that he was fighting against the demonic powers that controlled, or wanted to control, the kingdoms of Persia and Greece.

10:20a

“Do you know why I have come to you?” he said.

- ¶ Then he said, “Do you understand now why I have come?”
- ¶ So he replied, “Let me explain the reason why I have come.”

“Do you know why I have come to you?” he said:

The BSB places the words he said in the middle of what the man said to Daniel. This is good English style. However, in some languages, it may be necessary to place these words at the beginning of 10:20a, as in the Hebrew text. For example:

So he said, “Do you know why I have come to you?” (NIV)

Place the words he said where they would be most natural in your language.

Do you know why I have come to you?: The speaker asked a question to which he assumed the answer was “no.” In 10:21b he told why he had come, as

though Daniel had said “No, I do not know.” So this is a rhetorical question that introduces the speaker’s purpose or reason for coming to Daniel. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- as a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you know why I have come? (NLT)

You do not know why I have come, do you?

- as an introductory statement. For example:

Let me tell you why I have come.

You do not know why I have come to you, so let me explain.

he said: The angelic figure dressed in linen responded to Daniel with a question. So in some languages it may be natural to say:

He asked me

10:20b

“I must return at once to fight against the prince of Persia,

- But I have to go back to fight the Prince of Persia.
- I must very soon go and fight again against the demonic/spiritual prince of the Persian Empire.

I must return at once to fight against the prince of Persia: This verse begins the explanation of why the angelic figure had come at this time. He would soon have to fight against the spiritual or demonic ruler of Persia. This would continue the fight mentioned in 10:13a–c. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Now I am about to return to engage in battle with the prince of Persia. (NET)

Now I have to go back and fight the guardian angel of Persia. (GNT)

Soon I must leave to fight against the prince/ruler of Persia

I am about to go and take up the battle against the Persian prince

10:20c

and when I have gone forth, behold, the prince of Greece will come.

- After I have left that battle, the prince of Greece will come to oppose me.
- And as soon as I have defeated him, the demonic/spiritual commander of Greece will engage me in battle.

and when I have gone forth, behold, the prince of Greece will come: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as I have gone often refers to going into battle, that is, attacking and fighting an enemy. In some languages it may be natural to avoid repetition from the previous verse part by saying:

After that the guardian angel of Greece will appear. (GNT)

and after that the spirit prince of the kingdom of Greece will come. (NLT)

In this context it is implied that the attack is successful. The prince of Persia is defeated, and then the prince of Greece comes and attacks. Some English translations make this implication clear:

when I have overcome him, the Prince of Javan will come next (NJB)

Then after I have defeated him, the guardian angel of Greece will attack me. (CEV)

the prince of Greece: The name Greece here does not refer to the modern nation state of Greece, which did not exist until modern times. Greece became an independent nation state in 1830. The Hebrew word is “Javan.” See how you spelled this in 8:21a. Here is another way to translate this:

the Prince of Javan (NJB)

Javan was the fourth son of Noah’s son Japheth, according to Genesis 10:2. According to the Jewish writer Josephus, he was the ancestor of the Greek peoples. Josephus wrote his history of the Jewish people about sixty years after the death of Jesus.

Daniel 10:21

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:20–11:1

The angelic figure told Daniel that he was fighting against the demonic powers that controlled, or wanted to control, the kingdoms of Persia and Greece.

10:21a

But first I will tell you what is inscribed in the Book of Truth.

- But first I will tell you what is written in the book that is true/reliable.
- But before I go I will reveal to you what is written in the trustworthy book.

But first I will tell you what is inscribed in the Book of Truth: The angelic figure indicated that he would tell something to Daniel before he had to go away and fight again.

But first: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as But first here introduces the explanation of why the angel had come at this time (see 10:20a). The BSB has supplied the word first to help readers understand the flow of thought. This word is not explicit in the Hebrew.

what is inscribed in the Book of Truth: This is a passive phrase. In some languages it may be natural or necessary to use an active verb. However, the subject is not stated or implied, so it is best to leave it general. For example:

as they/one wrote in the Book of Truth

what God caused someone/them to write in the Book of Truth

inscribed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as inscribed occurs only here in the Hebrew Bible. In this context it appears to be a synonym. You may use the same word or a synonym. Here is another way to translate this:

inscribed (NRSV)

the Book of Truth: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the Book of Truth is literally “the writing of truth.” It is uncertain to what this refers. The word translated as Book is not the same as the word in

Daniel 9:2 or 12:1, which is sometimes translated as “scroll.” It is a general word for something that is written. The written content is said to be Truth in the sense that it can be trusted as accurate and therefore reliable and dependable. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the true writings (GW)

a dependable book (NET)

10:21b

Yet no one has the courage to support me against these, except Michael your prince.

- Yet in all these battles, no one takes my side against these enemies except Michael, your^(plur) prince.
- You should know that only Michael, the prince of your people, joins me to fight against these spiritual/demonic powers.

Yet no one has the courage to support me against these, except Michael your prince: This verse part is not connected to the previous verse part, but to the verse part that follows (11:1a in the BSB). In your translation, avoid suggesting that this is what is written in the Book of Truth. It is more likely parenthetical and gives some further information about the fight with the spiritual powers of Persia and Greece. Therefore, some English versions place 10:21b and 11:1a in parentheses (as in the NIV). Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

No one stands with me against these enemies except Michael, the angel ruling over your people. (NCV)

No one except Michael, the guardian angel of Israel, is on my side. (CEV)

No one helps me against these spirit princes except Michael, your spirit prince. (NLT)

Yet no one has the courage to support me against these, except Michael: In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement:

The only one who supports me against them is Michael.

Michael is my only helper/ally in my fight against those princes/rulers.

has the courage to support me: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as support means to strengthen another. That is, it means to help another to fight. Here are some other ways to translate this:

contends by my side (RSV)

stands firmly with me (NASB)

against these: The phrase against these in this context means “in the struggle/fight against them.” The pronoun these refers to the spiritual powers associated with Persia and Greece, the demonic figures mentioned in 10:20b and c. Translate this in a way that makes this clear. For example:

against these princes (NET)

when I fight these commanders (GW)

against these spirit princes (NLT)

your prince: The Hebrew pronoun your is plural. It refers to the people of Israel in general. Michael was the angel associated with Israel in some way. Here is another way to translate this:

Israel’s guardian angel (GNT)

Note that this verse part begins with a parenthesis marking in the NIV. This is possible but not necessary. However, it is necessary to indicate that 10:21b is closely connected to 11:1a. They should be translated as part of the same paragraph. A paragraph break can be made before 11:2a or b.

General Comment on 10:20–21

These verses may be difficult to understand because the answer to the question in 10:20a is not given until 10:21a. So in some languages it may be helpful to place 10:21a immediately following the question in 10:20a. The information in 10:20b–c can be moved to a position following that.

For example:

^{20a}He said, “Do you know why I came to you?

^{21a}It is to reveal to you what is written in the Book of Truth. ^{20b}Now I have to go back and fight the guardian angel of Persia. ^{20c}After that the guardian angel of Greece will appear. ^{21b}There

is no one to help me except Michael, Israel’s guardian angel. (GNT)

Daniel 11:1

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 10:20–11:1

The angelic figure told Daniel that he was fighting against the demonic powers that controlled, or wanted to control, the kingdoms of Persia and Greece.

11:1a

“And I, in the first year of Darius the Mede,

- And in the first year when Darius the Mede was king,
- Earlier, during the first year that Darius the Mede ruled Babylon,

11:1b

stood up to strengthen and protect him.

- I myself stood by Michael to strengthen and defend him.
- it was I who stood with the archangel Michael to help him.

11:1

This verse concludes the last paragraph of chapter 10.

And I...stood up to strengthen and protect him:

There is a textual problem here. A few English versions follow an ancient Greek translation that indicates that Michael was the one who supported the angel who was speaking. The two options are:

1. The angelic figure who was speaking stood up to help Michael. For example:

I stood up to support and strengthen him (NRSV)

I stood to strengthen him and to provide protection for him. (NET)

I strengthened and defended Michael. (GW) (BSB, KJV, RSV/NRSV, NASB, ESV, NIV, NET, GW, NLT, NCV, NABRE)

1. Michael stood up to help the angelic figure who was speaking. For example:

He is responsible for helping and defending me. (GNT) (GNT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the great majority of English versions.

I: In the Hebrew text the pronoun I is given prominence. Do this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

As for me, I (NRSV)

him: The pronoun him here refers to the archangel Michael who was mentioned in 10:21.11:1 Of the English versions consulted, only the CEV takes this pronoun to refer to Darius the Mede.

in the first year of Darius the Mede: The phrase the first year of Darius the Mede refers to the first year of Darius' rule over Babylonia. See 9:1a. Here are some other ways to translate this:

During Darius the Mede's first year as king of Babylon

In the first year that Darius the Mede was king (NCV)

General Comment on 11:1

In some languages it may be natural to place the time indicator at the end of this verse part, as the NLT has done:

I have been standing beside Michael to support and strengthen him since the first year of the reign of Darius the Mede. (NLT)

Daniel 11:2

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:2–4

The angelic figure who looked like a human being continued to talk to Daniel. It may be helpful to make this explicit, as the GW has done:

The person who looked like a human continued, "What I am about to tell you is the truth.... (GW)

11:2a

Now then, I will tell you the truth:

- ¶ "I am speaking the truth to you^(sing).

- ¶ "Daniel, I am going to tell you what will certainly happen.

Now then: The Hebrew compound word that the BSB translates as Now then here introduces something that the angelic figure was about to do. He was about to tell Daniel the truth. It is important to avoid indicating that what he was about to do was in contrast to what he was doing before. He had not been lying to Daniel up to this point. He had not previously been telling Daniel things that were not true. In order to avoid this implication, some English translations do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Introduce what the angel next said to Daniel in a way that is natural in your language.

I will tell you the truth: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as I will tell you the truth emphasizes that what the angel was about to tell Daniel was true and therefore important to hear. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I will announce the truth to you. (NRSV)

What I am about to tell you is the truth. (GW)

What I am going to tell you is certain to happen. (CEV)

11:2b

Three more kings will arise in Persia,

- There will be three more kings in Persia.
- After Cyrus three kings will rule over Persia, one after another.

Three more kings will arise in Persia: This clause indicates that after Darius three kings would rule Persia, one after the other. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Three more kings will rule Persia. (GW)

Three more Persian kings will reign. (NLT)

11:2c

and then a fourth, who will be far richer than all the others.

- Then a fourth king will reign/rule. He will have more wealth than any of the previous kings of Persia.
- Then there will be/appear a fourth king. He will gain more riches than any of his predecessors.

and then a fourth: The phrase and then a fourth is a short way of saying “and then a fourth king will arise in Persia.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then there will be a fourth (GW)

and then a fourth king will come (NCV)

who will be far richer than all the others: The Hebrew more literally says, “and he will enrich himself with great riches, more than everyone.” The word others probably refers to the previous kings of Persia. Here are some other ways to translate this:

will become much richer than all the others (GW)

He will be much richer than all the kings of Persia before him (NCV)

11:2d

By the power of his wealth,

- Through/By his riches he will become powerful.
- He will use his wealth to gain power.

By the power of his wealth: The Hebrew text says “according to his power by his wealth.” Many English translations understand this to mean that this king will become powerful by using his wealth. The important point is that this king will gain a lot of power as well as a lot of wealth. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He...will use his riches to get power. (NCV)

when by his wealth he has extended his power (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun power with an adjective meaning “powerful, strong.” For example:

As he becomes strong through his wealth (GW)

This king will use his riches to become very powerful.

his wealth will make him so powerful that... (CEV)

11:2e

he will stir up everyone against the kingdom of Greece.

- He will arouse/encourage everyone to oppose the kingdom of Javan/Greece.
- He will cause all the people to oppose the kingdom of Greece.

he will stir up everyone against the kingdom of Greece: This clause probably indicates that this fourth king will rouse many people to fight against the kingdom of Greece. Here are some other ways to translate this:

he will turn everyone against the kingdom of Greece (GW)

stir up everyone to fight against the kingdom of Greece (NLT)

the kingdom of Greece: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the kingdom of Greece is literally “the kingdom of Javan.” Javan referred to the land that is now Greece. See how you translated this name in 8:21a and 10:20c.

Daniel 11:3

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:2–4

The angelic figure who looked like a human being continued to talk to Daniel. It may be helpful to make this explicit, as the GW has done:

The person who looked like a human continued, “What I am about to tell you is the truth.... (GW)

11:3a

Then a mighty king will arise,

- Then a powerful king will rule
- But a great warrior will become king of Greece.

Then a mighty king will arise: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as mighty often refers to a great warrior. Commentators agree that this is a reference to Alexander the Great, who in the fourth century before Christ conquered a vast area stretching from Greece to the Indian subcontinent. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as arise literally means “stand.” Like the English word arise, it figuratively

means to come to power or prominence. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then a mighty king will come to power (CEV)

Then a warrior-king will come. (GW)

Then there will appear a warrior king (REB)

11:3b
who will rule with great authority

- and he will rule over a vast empire.
- He will have the power

11:3c
and do as he pleases.

- He will do whatever he wants to do.
- to do whatever he pleases/wishes.

11:3b-c
who will rule with great authority and do as he pleases: The Hebrew text that the BSB translates as who will rule with great authority is more literally “he will rule a great ruling.” The repetition of the root meaning “rule” emphasizes the idea. This warrior king would have a lot of power. His power would be so great that he could act however he wished. Here are some other ways to translate this:

who will rule with great power and will do anything he wants (NCV)

who will rule with great authority and act however he wishes

He will have so much power that he will be able to act as he pleases.

In some languages it may be natural to translate the concept of authority or “power” with an adjective. For example:

He will be so powerful that he will be able to do anything he pleases.

Daniel 11:4

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:2–4

The angelic figure who looked like a human being continued to talk to Daniel. It may be helpful to make this explicit, as the GW has done:

The person who looked like a human continued, “What I am about to tell you is the truth.... (GW)

11:4a

But as soon as he is established,

- But after he has gained power,
- But after he becomes king,

But as soon as he is established: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as But as soon as he is established refers to the time when this warrior king will have established himself in his powerful position. Here are some other ways to translate this:

After he has appeared (NIV)

After that king has come (NCV)

But at the height of his power (NLT)

Shortly after his rise to power (NET)

11:4b

his kingdom will be broken up and parceled out toward the four winds of heaven.

- his kingdom will break apart. It will be divided into four parts/kingdoms, each one in a different place/direction.
- his kingdom will break/dissolve into four nations. One will be in the north, one in the south, one in the east and one in the west.

his kingdom will be broken up and parceled out toward the four winds of heaven: This verse part indicates that the empire of the warrior king would be divided into four parts. See also 8:8c-d, where this same event is described.

The verbs broken up and parceled out are both passive. The text does not say who would do this action. There are at least two ways to translate this verse part:

- using passive verbs. For example:

his kingdom will be broken into pieces and divided in the directions of the four winds of heaven (GW)

His kingdom will be broken apart and divided into four parts. (NLT)

- using active verbs and a general subject. For example:

they will break up his kingdom and divide it into north, south, east, and west

toward the four winds of heaven: The phrase the four winds of heaven refers to the four directions, north, south, east, and west. Use the expression that is most natural in your language. For example:

toward the four parts of the world (NCV)

into four quarters

11:4c

It will not go to his descendants,

- But/And these four parts/kingdoms will not be ruled by the king's descendants.
- Men who are not his descendants will rule these four nations.

It will not go to his descendants: This clause indicates that the new rulers of the divided empire would not be the descendants of the warrior king. Four army generals inherited and ruled the four parts of the empire of Alexander the Great. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The empire will not be given to his descendants.
(GW)

But these won't be ruled by his descendants (CEV)

The new rulers of these lands will not be his descendants.

11:4d

nor will it have the authority with which he ruled,

- Nor will these four rulers have the same power as the first king,
- These men/rulers will not have the same power as the first king had.

nor will it have the authority with which he ruled: This clause is more literally "and not as the ruling which he ruled." It indicates that the four generals who succeeded the warrior king would not have the

power that he had. Their kingdoms would not be so strong as his empire was. Here are some other ways to translate this:

nor will the kingdom hold the authority it once had (NLT)

and it will not have the power that he had (NCV)

or be as powerful as his kingdom (CEV)

11:4e

because his kingdom will be uprooted and given to others.

- because his kingdom shall be uprooted. It will be given to others/outside.
- For his kingdom shall come to an end and outsiders will rule in his place.

because his kingdom will be uprooted and given to others: This verse part uses a different image to express the same idea as 11:4b. The empire is pictured as a plant that someone pulls out of the ground. There are at least two ways to translate this metaphor:

- keeping the figure of speech. For example:

because his kingdom will be pulled up and given to other people (NCV)

- explaining the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

his empire will be destroyed and its remnants/ remains given to others

As in 11:4b, both the verbs are passive in English. However, in the Hebrew text there is only one verb in this verse part. The BSB has supplied the passive verb given. There are several ways to translate this clause:

General Comment on 11:4a-e

- using two passive verbs. For example:

for his kingdom will be uprooted and distributed to others besides these (NET)

- using one or more active verbs. For example:

for his kingdom shall be uprooted and go to others besides these (NRSV)

for they will tear out his kingdom and it will pass to other rulers/men

Since 11:4b and 11:4e are similar in meaning, in some languages it may be natural to combine them. For example:

^{4a}But at the height of his power ^{4b,e}his empire will break up and be divided into four parts. ^{4c}Kings not descended from him will rule in his place, ^{4d}but they will not have the power that he had. (GNT)

^{4a}But suddenly ^{4b,e}his kingdom will be crushed and scattered to the four corners of the earth, where four more kingdoms will rise. ^{4c}But these won't be ruled by his descendants ^{4d}or be as powerful as his kingdom. (CEV)

Daniel 11:5

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:5–6

The angelic figure told Daniel about two kings and two kingdoms and their relationship.

11:5a

The king of the South will grow strong,

- ¶ “Then the king of the south will become strong.
- ¶ “Then the king of the southern land/country, that is, of Egypt, will become powerful.

The king of the South will grow strong: The phrase The king of the South refers to the ruler of Egypt. This becomes clear in verse 8. You may wish to include a footnote stating that the South is a reference to Egypt. Many scholars believe this particular king to be Ptolemy I. He was one of Alexander the Great's generals. After Alexander's death in 323 B.C., Ptolemy received power in Egypt. His title was first Satrap and then Pharaoh. He ruled Egypt until his death in 282 BC. He began the Ptolomaic dynasty, which ruled in Egypt until 30 B.C. All the male rulers of this dynasty were named Ptolemy. The references to The king of the South in the rest of this chapter can refer to any of these Ptolomaic kings.

11:5b

but one of his commanders will grow even stronger

- But one of his commanders will become more powerful than he.

- However, one of his military officers will gain even more power.

but one of his commanders will grow even stronger:

The Hebrew more literally says, “but one of his commanders will become strong over/against him.” This indicates that one of the Egyptian military commanders would rebel against the king of the South, the Egyptian pharaoh. Here are some other ways to translate this:

one of his officers shall grow stronger than he (NRSV)

one of his own officials will become more powerful than he (NLT)

One of his subordinates/generals will also grow strong. He will resist the king of the south.

one of his commanders: The phrase one of his commanders refers to one of the military officers of the king of the South. Here is another way to translate this:

One of his generals (GNT)

This is probably a reference to the general named Seleucus. He was one of Alexander the Great's generals and later a commander under Ptolemy. He himself came to rule a great empire now called the Seleucid Empire. He was succeeded by his son Antiochus I in 281 B.C. His family line, the Seleucid dynasty, remained in power until 64 B.C. The Seleucid Empire came to include the lands that are now known as Syria, Egypt, Iraq, Iran, and Afghanistan. These lands are all north of Egypt, and this chapter of Daniel refers to the ruler of the Seleucid Empire as “the king of the North.” Some English versions, such as the GNT, refer to this empire as “Syria.” However, it was much larger than the country now known as Syria.

You may wish to put some of this information in a footnote.

11:5c

and will rule his own kingdom with great authority.

- This commander will rule his own kingdom with great power.
- This officer will become king of his own kingdom/nation in the north and be very powerful.

and will rule his own kingdom with great authority:

There is a textual problem here:

1. The traditional Hebrew text says “and he will rule a dominion great his dominion.” For example, the RSV follows this text says:

and his dominion shall be a great dominion (RSV)
(BSB, RSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NLT, GW, NCV)

1. Other texts indicate a comparison with the dominion/kingdom of the king of the south. For example, the GNT follows these texts and says:

and rule a greater kingdom (GNT) (GNT, NRSV, NJB, REB, NET, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), that of the Masoretic Text.^{11:5} This is the recommendation of HOTTP, CTAT, and the UBS Handbook.

Daniel 11:6

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:5–6

The angelic figure told Daniel about two kings and two kingdoms and their relationship.

11:6a

After some years they will form an alliance,

- Some years later the two kings will become allies.
- After a number of years, these two kingdoms will make a treaty.

After some years they will form an alliance: The pronoun they here refers to the king of the South and the king of the North. That is, the pronoun refers to the Pharaoh of Egypt and the Seleucid Emperor. At the time they became allies, the two rulers were Ptolemy II (later known as Ptolemy the Great) and Antiochus II Theos. This took place several decades after the events recorded in 11:5, around 250 B.C. Here are some ways to translate this:

After some years have passed, they will form an alliance (NET)

Some years later, the southern king and the northern king will make an alliance.

11:6b

and the daughter of the king of the South will go to the king of the North to seal the agreement.

- The daughter of the king of the south will come to the king of the north in order to establish a marriage alliance.
- At that time, the king of the south will send his daughter to marry the king of the north.

the daughter of the king of the South will go to the king of the North to seal the agreement:

This verse part indicates that a marriage alliance was made between the two kings. The Egyptian ruler sent his daughter Berenice to marry the Seleucid Emperor, Antiochus II. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The daughter of the king of the South will marry the king of the North in order to bring peace. (NCV)

The king of the South will make an alliance with the king of the North and give him his daughter in marriage.

the daughter of the king of the South: This daughter of the king of the South was named Berenice. She was given in marriage by her father Ptolemy II of Egypt to the Seleucid Emperor Antiochus II. Antiochus had, however, previously married a woman named Laodice.

11:6c

But his daughter will not retain her position of power,

- However, she will not be able to keep her position of power.
- However, she will lose her influence.

But his daughter will not retain her position of power:

The Hebrew text literally says, “but she will not retain the power of the arm.” This probably means that Berenice lost her influence. The previous wife of Antiochus worked against her, and the alliance between the northern and southern kingdoms did not last. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But she will not keep her power (NCV)

But she will lose her power. (CEV)

11:6d

nor will his strength endure.

- Nor will her husband the king continue to rule.
- Nor will her husband remain king.

nor will his strength endure: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as nor will his strength endure is more literally “and he will not stand and his arm.” The meaning is not totally clear. An “arm” is often a symbol of strength and the pronoun his refers to the king of the North, Antiochus. However, some scholars suggest that the correct reading is that of the Septuagint, “and not he will stand and his offspring.” The two possibilities are:

1. The MT reading “his arm” (BSB: his strength) is correct. For example:

nor will he continue in his strength (NET) (BSB, NIV, NET, KJV, NASB, ESV, NLT)

1. The Septuagint reading “his seed/offspring” is correct. For example:

and his family will not last (NCV) (NCV, RSV/NRSV, NJB, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), that of the Masoretic Text. The king of the North and his power did not last. Antiochus II was killed a few years after his marriage to Berenice.

11:6e

At that time she will be given up,

- During that time she will be betrayed.
- Someone will soon betray her to her enemies.

At that time: In the Hebrew text, the phrase At that time is placed at the end of 11:6. Some translations indicate that it should be placed at the beginning of 11:7. See the RSV and GNT.

she will be given up: The Hebrew verb that the BSB literally translates as she will be given up means that the daughter of the king of the South would be killed. Historical reports record that Antiochus II himself, Berenice, her son, and her Egyptian attendants were all killed by order of the first wife of Antiochus II. 11:6 For details see Goldingay, Word Biblical Commentary, page 296.

This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

She...will...be delivered over (NET)

- using an active verb with a general subject. For example:

they/someone will turn against her

Use the form that is most natural in your language. It is good to imply that this betrayal led to the queen's death.

11:6f

along with her royal escort and her father and the one who supported her.

- She and her servants who came with her, her father, and the one who supported her will die.
- They will kill her, her father, her husband, and her attendants.

along with her royal escort and her father and the one who supported her:

This verse part indicates that other people died along with the daughter of the northern king. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Those who had escorted/accompanied her to the north, her father, and her husband died also.

her royal escort: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as her royal escort is literally “those who brought her.” It refers to the Egyptians who accompanied the princess to the north for the royal marriage. Many manuscripts have a singular form here, and you may use either a plural or singular form, whichever is most natural in your language. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the servants who went with her (GNT)

those who brought her to that country (NCV)

her attendants (NRSV)

her entourage

her father: There is a textual problem here. Some translations follow the ancient versions that read “her child.” The two options are:

1. The original text read “her father.” This is the reading of the MT, which says “the one who begot her.” However, Berenice's father Ptolemy II did not die at the same time as Berenice, but soon after. (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NIV, GW, NLT)
2. The original text read “her child.” This is the reading of some ancient versions. 11:6 This is the reading of the Greek translation by Theodotion, the Syriac and the Vulgate. See Goldingay, World Biblical Com-

mentary, page 277. Berenice's son did in fact die at the same time as Berenice. He was probably killed by order of Antiochus' first wife. (NET, RSV/NRSV, NJB, REB, GNT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the first options, in accordance with the MT.11:6 See the recommendations of HOTTP and CTAT. If your local and major language translations follow option (2), that is also acceptable.

and the one who supported her: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the one who supported her, literally “the one supporting her,” is probably a reference to Berenice's husband, Antiochus II. Historians believe that he was killed by order of his first wife Laodice.11:6 See, for example, the Encyclopaedia Britannica, “Berenice, daughter of Ptolemy II.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

her husband (NCV)

General Comment on 11:6e-f

In some languages it may be natural to combine verse parts 6e and 6f, as the NET has done:

^{6e-f}She, together with the one who brought her, her child, and her benefactor will all be delivered over at that time. (NET)

Daniel 11:7

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:7–10

This paragraph continues to describe the conflict between the northern and the southern kingdoms.

11:7a

But one from her family line will rise up in his place,

- ¶ “Then one of her own family line will take his place.
- ¶ “One of her relatives will begin to rule as king of the south.

But one from her family line will rise up in his place:

The Hebrew more literally says, “And one from the branch of her roots will arise in his place.” This verse part indicates that a relative of the murdered queen from the south will come to power. This is probably a reference to Berenice's brother, who became Ptolemy III (and thus “king of the South”) after the death of his father Ptolemy II in 246 B.C. However, you should not make this explicit in the translation. You may wish to

write a footnote with this information. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

There will arise in his place one from her family line (NET)

One of her relatives will become king in the south

one from her family line: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as one from her family line is more literally “from the branch of her roots.” This is a reference to someone from the same family line. Use an expression that is natural and clear in your language. For example:

a branch from her roots (RSV)

one of her relatives (GNT)

will rise up in his place: This phrase indicates that the relative will come into power. The place is probably a reference to the position of ruler of Egypt. The relative of the murdered queen will become “king of the South,” of Egypt. Here are some other ways to translate this.

will come into power

will become king (GNT)

11:7b

come against the army of the king of the North, and enter his fortress,

- He and his forces/army will march/go against the northern king's forces/army. They will invade the fortress cities of the king of the north.
- This new king and his men/troops will attack the men/troops of the northern kingdom and will conquer his fortifications/defenses.

come against the army of the king of the North, and enter his fortress:

This verse part indicates that the relative of the murdered queen, the new king of the South, would attack the northern kingdom. He would invade their fortress or stronghold. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He shall come against the army and enter the fortress of the king of the north (NRSV)

He will attack the northern army, enter the stronghold of the northern king (GW)

This refers to the time when Berenice's brother, having become Ptolemy III of Egypt, ordered an attack on the northern kingdom, the Seleucid Empire. 11:7 The Encyclopaedia Britannica says that this was to avenge the murder of his sister Berenice. See "Ptolemy III Euergetes." However, you should not make this explicit in your translation. You may wish to make a footnote.

the army of the king of the North: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the army means "the strength," and is often translated as the army. In the historical situation, navies as well as armies were involved, and so the NIV uses the general word "forces."

the king of the North: The phrase the king of the North refers to the Seleucid emperor. By this time Antiochus was dead and Seleucus II was the ruler of the northern kingdom.

enter his fortress: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as his fortress is probably a general reference to the defenses and strongholds of the northern kingdom. Here is another way to translate this:

capture its fortresses (CEV)

11:7c fighting and prevailing.

- He will attack and conquer them.
- He will utterly defeat them.

fighting and prevailing: The Hebrew is more literally "and he will deal with them and he will be strong/successful." The queen's relative, the new king of the South, would fight against the forces of the king of the North. He would win victories. In some languages it may be helpful and natural to make explicit who is doing the fighting, using the same terms that you used previously. For example:

This relative will make war against the king of the north, and he will be victorious.

In some languages it may be possible to combine the ideas of fighting and being victorious into one verb. For example:

and defeat them (GNT)

Daniel 11:8

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:7–10

This paragraph continues to describe the conflict between the northern and the southern kingdoms.

11:8a

He will take even their gods captive to Egypt, with their metal images and their precious vessels of silver and gold.

- He will also/even take from them their idols, their images made from melted metal, and their precious vessels of gold and silver. He will take all of these back with him to Egypt.
- He and his men will even take away the idols of the northern kingdom, the molten images that they worshiped, and the gold and silver objects that they prized/valued. They will transport all of these things back to Egypt.

He will take even their gods captive to Egypt, with their metal images and their precious vessels of silver and gold: The pronoun He continues to refer to the one who was the king of the South at that time (Ptolemy III). He would take or steal the treasures of the northern kingdom for his own kingdom. He would not do this personally but would order his soldiers to do so. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He will take the metal statues of their gods and their precious utensils of silver and gold back to Egypt

He will cause/order their gods, their metal images, and their gold and silver treasures to be taken to Egypt.

He will order his men to seize their gods, their metal images, and their gold and silver treasures, and to take them to Egypt.

take...captive: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as take...captive is more literally "take into captivity." In your translation, you may use one or two verbs, whichever is most natural in your language.

their gods...their metal images: The gods that the people of the North worshiped were in the form of metal images. These were not separate items. It may therefore be natural to translate this as:

their gods, that is, their metal images

the images of their gods cast in metal (REB)

the metal statues of their gods (GW)

Egypt: In this verse part the country of Egypt is explicitly mentioned for the first time. Egypt is the southern kingdom where the relative (brother) of the murdered queen was now ruler.

and their precious vessels of silver and gold: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as their precious vessels is literally “the vessels of their desire.” It refers to containers and utensils such as cups and bowls that were precious and therefore prized or valued by their owners. These articles were probably those used in religious rituals. Here are some other ways to translate this:

their previous vessels of silver and gold (NRSV)

their precious treasures of silver and gold (CEV)

their valuable things made of silver and gold (NCV)

General Comment on 11:8a

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in these verse parts, mentioning Egypt in the first part of the verse. For example:

When he returns to Egypt, he will carry back their idols with him, along with priceless articles of gold and silver. (NLT)

Then he will carry their idols to Egypt, together with their precious treasures of silver and gold (CEV)

He will also take their gods into captivity to Egypt, along with their cast images and prized utensils of silver and gold. (NET)

11:8b

For some years he will stay away from the king of the North,

- For some years after that, the king of the south will stay away from the king of the north.

- Then for a few years the king of the south will stop attacking the northern kingdom.

For some years he will stay away from the king of the North: This verse part indicates that there would be a few years of peace. The king of the South would not attempt to attack the king of the North. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Then he will not bother the king of the North for a few years. (NCV)

In your translation, avoid implying that after these years the king of the South would attack the king of the North. As the following verse part indicates, the peace was broken by the king of the North.

Daniel 11:9

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:7–10

This paragraph continues to describe the conflict between the northern and the southern kingdoms.

11:9a

who will invade the realm of the king of the South

- Then the king of the north will lead his men into the land of the king of the south.
- But after that the king of the northern kingdom and his army will attack/invoke the kingdom of the south.

who will invade the realm of the king of the South:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB has translated as invade is more literally “he will go.” It is good to make the subject explicit. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Next, the king of the North will attack the king of the South (NCV)

Then the king of the north will advance against the empire of the king of the south (NET)

11:9b

and then return to his own land.

- However, they will have to return to their own country.

- However, he and his army will retreat back to their own country.

and then return to his own land: This verse part indicates that the king of the North would not remain inside the territory of the king of the South. He would go back home. It is implied that he was unsuccessful in his attack. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but will withdraw to his own land (NET)

but he will be beaten back to his own country (NCV)

but he will be forced back to his own country (CEV)

Daniel 11:10

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:7–10

This paragraph continues to describe the conflict between the northern and the southern kingdoms.

11:10a

But his sons will stir up strife and assemble a great army,

- However, the sons of the king of the north will prepare to go to war again. They will gather powerful armies.
- However, the sons of the king of the north will get ready to fight another war. They will call together huge numbers of fighting men.

But his sons will stir up strife: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as will stir up strife literally means “excite themselves, stir themselves up against someone.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

His sons shall wage war (NRSV)

His sons will make preparations for war

his sons: The phrase his sons refers to the sons of the northern king, the sons of the Seleucid ruler Seleucus II. There were two sons, so in some languages you may be able to use a dual form. These sons became Seleucus III and Antiochus III. Here is another way to translate this:

The sons of the king of the North (NCV)

and assemble a great army: The sons of the northern king would call up many soldiers to form a large army. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and gather a large army (GNT)

They will assemble a large number of forces

They will get a large army together (NCV)

11:10b

which will advance forcefully, sweeping through like a flood,

- These armies will move like an irresistible flood and pass through the land of the south.
- They will advance through the southern land and overcome/overpower all those who are in their way.

which will advance forcefully, sweeping through like a flood: The clause which will advance forcefully, sweeping through like a flood contains a simile. The movement of the attacking army is compared to a flood of water that overwhelms everything in its way. The point of comparison is that nothing can stand against such a force. Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- using a simile. For example:

that will move through the land very quickly, like a powerful flood (NCV)

which will advance like an overflowing river (NET)

- using a metaphor. For example:

they/it will flood the land

- translating the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

They will advance together and overwhelm/cover the land.

11:10c

and will again carry the battle as far as his fortress.

- They will fight their way as far as the stronghold of the southern king.

- They will even reach the walled/strong city of the southern kingdom.

and will again carry the battle as far as his fortress:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as carry the battle means “make war.” The army of the North will make war and advance as far as the fortress of the king of the South. Here are some other ways to translate this:

reaching all the way to the fortress of the southern kingdom (CEV)

and fight all the way to the strong, walled city of the king of the South (NCV)

and attack an enemy fortress (GNT)

his fortress: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fortress is often translated as “stronghold.” Here it refers to a fortified city, a city protected by walls. The pronoun he refers to the king of the South, the Egyptian ruler.

Daniel 11:11

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:11–13

This paragraph describes an attack by the king of the South on the northern kingdom.

11:11a

In a rage, the king of the South will march out to fight the king of the North,

- ¶ “Then the king of the south will be very angry. He and his army will set out to fight the king of the north.
- ¶ “Then the king of the southern kingdom will be furious. He and his men will attack the king of the northern kingdom.

In a rage, the king of the South will march out to fight the king of the North: The Hebrew more literally says “and the king of the South will be very angry, and he will go out, and he will fight the king of the North.” The verb “will be angry” is in a prominent position. In some languages it may be natural to emphasize this by placing it near the beginning of the sentence. For example:

The southern king will be outraged. He will go to fight the northern king (GW)

In his anger the king of Egypt will go to war against the king of Syria (GNT)

The two Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as march out and fight together describe the beginning of the action of fighting. In some languages they can be combined into one verb or verb phrase. For example:

In his anger, the king of the south will attack the king of the north.

Then the king of the south will be enraged and will march out to fight against the king of the north. (NET)

The king of the South did not attack alone. He led his men, his army, against the North. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

In great anger, the king of the South will lead his men/army against the king of the North.

the king of the South: At this time the king of the South was Ptolemy IV (who ruled Egypt 221–203 B.C.). He successfully attacked Antiochus III and his army at the battle of Raphia. This information may be placed in a footnote if you are using such footnotes to explain the historical background.

11:11b

who will raise a large army, but it will be delivered into the hand of his enemy.

- The king of the north will gather a large army but he will be defeated by the king of the south.
- Although the king of the northern kingdom will have a big army, the king of the south and his army will defeat them

who will raise a large army, but it will be delivered into the hand of his enemy: The pronoun who refers to the king of the North. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

The king of the North will have a large army, but he will lose the battle. (NCV)

it will be delivered into the hand of his enemy: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as it will be

delivered into the hand of his enemy is literally “the army will be given into his hand.” This indicates that the northern army would be given into the hand (that is, power) of the southern army. The verb be delivered is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

they/he will be conquered

- using an active verb. The implied subject is the king of the south and his army. For example:

he will lose the battle (NCV)

the king of the south will defeat him

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Daniel 11:12

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:11–13

This paragraph describes an attack by the king of the South on the northern kingdom.

11:12a

When the army is carried off,

- When the enemy army is destroyed
- When the king of the south defeats the army of the kingdom of the north

When the army is carried off: The clause the army is carried off indicates that the army of the North will be captured. It is passive and there are at least two ways to translate this:

- using a passive verb. For example:

and the soldiers will be carried away (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

the men of the South will defeat and capture this army.

- using a noun rather than a verb. For example:

At the capture of this force (REB)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. This clause gives the reason for the pride mentioned in 11:12b, so in some languages it may be natural to translate this after 11:12b. See the General Comment on 11:12a-b below.

11:12b

the king of the South will be proud in heart

- his heart will become proud.
- he will become very proud.

the king of the South will be proud in heart: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as proud in heart is literally “his heart will be lifted up.” Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

The king of the South will then be very proud (NCV)

The king of the south will feel proud (CEV)

the king of the south will become arrogant (NET)

General Comment on 11:12a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in 11:12a-b. For example:

He will be proud of his victory over the army of the North

11:12c

and will cast down tens of thousands,

- He will kill many thousands of men.
- His soldiers will kill many thousands of his/their enemies.

and will cast down tens of thousands: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as cast down is more literally “cause to fall.” It indicates that the southern army would overthrow or defeat many thousands of men. Probably many were killed, but others were wounded or captured or fled. Here are some other ways to translate this:

he will overthrow tens of thousands (NJB)

he caused the loss/death of many thousands of men

tens of thousands: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as tens of thousands is more literally “myri-

ads, tens of thousands.” The word “myriads” is a vague term indicating a huge number.

thousands and thousands of people (NET)

11:12d but he will not triumph.

- But he will not continue to be victorious over the king of the North.
- However, the king of the south will not keep winning battles over the kingdom of the north.

but he will not triumph: The Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as will not triumph is more literally “not prevail.” In this context it indicates that the king of the South would not win a final or ultimate victory over the king of the North. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but he will not continue to be victorious (GNT)

but he will not continue to be successful (NCV)

But his victories won’t last long (CEV)

Daniel 11:13

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:11–13

This paragraph describes an attack by the king of the South on the northern kingdom.

11:13a

For the king of the North will raise another army, larger than the first,

- For the king of the north will gather/recruit an even larger army than the one he had before.
- The king of the north will return home and mobilize an army with even more soldiers than he had before.

For: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the reason why the king of the South did not continue to be victorious over the king of the North. Here is another way to translate this:

because (CEV)

the king of the North will raise another army, larger than the first: The Hebrew verb that the BSB trans-

lates as raise in this context refers to gathering a group of men to form an army. Use the expression that is natural in your language. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The king of the north will once more raise an army, one even greater than the last (REB)

The king of the North will gather another army, larger than the first one. (NCV)

the king of the north will gather a larger and more powerful army than ever before. (CEV)

larger than the first: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as larger than the first is more literally “greater than the first.” This indicates that this second army will be stronger than the one mentioned in 11:11b. It is implied that it would be stronger because it would be larger. Here are some other ways to translate this:

far greater than before (NLT)

bigger/greater than the first army

more powerful than his earlier army

In some languages it may be natural to translate this comparison using a separate sentence. For example:

It will be a larger and more powerful army than the previous one.

The first army was big/strong, but this one will be very big/strong.

11:13b

and after some years he will advance with a great army and many supplies.

- After some years, he will set out with a well-equipped army.
- After a period of years, he and his large army will advance against the southern kingdom with a lot of equipment/supplies/weapons.

and after some years he will advance with a great army and many supplies: This verse part indicates that the king of the North will march against the king of the South again. This time he will have with him the

larger army that is mentioned in the previous verse part. Here are some other ways to translate this:

After a few years he will invade with a large army and a lot of equipment (GW)

After several years he will attack with a large army and many weapons. (NCV)

after some years: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as after some years refers to an indefinite period of time consisting of some years. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

A few years later (NLT)

At the end of some years (NET)

he will advance: The verb phrase he will advance here indicates that the king of the North will lead his army forward.

with a great army and many supplies: This phrase describes the army that the king of the North gathered in 11:13a. Here the additional information is given that this army would have a lot of equipment. Here are some other ways to translate this:

a large, well-equipped army (GNT)

with a great army and plentiful supplies (NJB)

His great army will be well supplied.

The soldiers in that huge army will have all the equipment/weapons that they need.

General Comment on 11:13a-b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in these verse parts as the NLT has done:

^{13a-b}A few years later the king of the north will return with a fully equipped army far greater than before. (NLT)

Daniel 11:14

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:14–15

The king of the South will meet opposition from many sides. His army will be forced to retreat.

11:14a

In those times many will rise up against the king of the South.

- ¶ “During that time, many people will oppose/resist the king of the south.
- ¶ “About the same time, many people will turn/act/rebel against the king of the southern kingdom.

In those times many will rise up against the king of the South:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as will rise up is literally “will stand up.” Here it indicates that people will begin to fight against the southern king. They will resist him or rebel against him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

During these times many will resist the king of the south (REB)

In those times many will oppose the king of the south. (NET)

Then many people will rebel against the king of Egypt (GNT)

the king of the South: The phrase the king of the South continues to refer to the ruler of Egypt, the Pharaoh. Scholars suggest that the specific Pharaoh in view here is Ptolemy V Epiphanes (who ruled around 203–181 B.C.)

11:14b

Violent ones among your own people will exalt themselves

- Some violent men among your own people, Daniel, will rebel against him
- Some violent young men among your^(sing) own people will rise up against him

Violent ones among your own people will exalt themselves:

This clause indicates that some of the Jewish people would be among those who resisted the king of the South. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and the men of violence among your own people shall lift themselves up (RSV)

and the more violent of your own people will rebel (NJB)

Those who are violent among your own people
will rise up (NET) |

Violent ones: The Hebrew phrase is literally “the sons of the violent ones.” The people involved in the violence would (mostly) be male. So it may be natural to translate this:

violent men (GW)

violent young men

among your own people: The phrase your own people refers to the people of Daniel, that is, the people of Israel. It may be helpful to make this clear by translating as the GNT has done:

from your nation, Daniel (GNT)

will exalt themselves: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as will exalt themselves is literally “will lift themselves up.”

11:14c
in fulfillment of the vision,

- and confirm the vision.
- and fulfill the vision.

in fulfillment of the vision: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as in fulfillment of the vision are literally “to make vision stand.” In the Hebrew there is no definite article (the) and it is uncertain as to what vision this refers. There are two ways of understanding this phrase:

- these men wanted to fulfil a vision. It was a deliberate action. For example:

in the hope of realising the vision (NJB) (NJB, GNT)

- these men acted in accordance with a vision, possibly one of Daniel’s own visions. Theirs was not a deliberate action. For example:

in keeping with this vision (GW) (GW, probably NIV)

Many English versions are ambiguous here, and this is recommended. For example:

in order to fulfill the vision (NRSV)

in confirmation of the vision (NET)

11:14d
but they will fail.

- However, they will not succeed.
- But they will fail.

but they will fail: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as but they will fail is literally “but they will stumble.” This is a common Hebrew metaphor for failure. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but they will falter (NET)

but they will be defeated (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

But they will fail (NCV)

However, they will not succeed.

Daniel 11:15

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:14–15

The king of the South will meet opposition from many sides. His army will be forced to retreat.

11:15a

Then the king of the North will come, build up a siege ramp, and capture a fortified city.

- Then the king of the north shall advance with his army. His men will build a siege ramp and capture a strongly fortified city.
- Then the king of the north will march against one of the strong cities of the land of the south. He will cause his soldiers to build great mounds of dirt against the city walls, and in this way they will capture it.

Then the king of the North will come, build up a siege ramp, and capture a fortified city: This verse part describes the way in which the king of the North will conquer one of the strong cities of the South. It refers to a war practice of the time. Cities were protected by walls. An attacking army would therefore pile up dirt against one of the walls in order to be able to fire arrows into it. The tall pile of dirt was called

a siege ramp. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then the king of the north will advance and will build siege mounds and capture a well-fortified city. (NET)

He will build ramps to the tops of the city walls and will capture a strong, walled city. (NCV)

Then the northern king will come, build dirt attack ramps, and capture a fortified city. (GW)

General Comment on 11:15a

In some languages it may be natural to mention the fortified city in the first part of 11:15a. For example:

Then the king of the north will come and lay siege to a fortified city and capture it. (NLT)

Then the king of the northern kingdom and his army will come to a strongly fortified city of the king of the south. They will pile mounds of dirt against its walls and so capture the city.

11:15b

The forces of the South will not stand;

- The army of the southern kingdom will not be able to withstand the enemy.
- The southern army will not be able to keep the enemy away/out.

The forces of the South will not stand: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as The forces of the South refers to the armed forces of the king of the South, that is, his armies. They will not be able to resist or withstand the forces of the king of the North. Here are some other ways to translate this:

And the forces of the south shall not stand (RSV)

The southern forces will not be able to withstand him. (GW)

11:15c

even their best troops will not be able to resist.

- Not even their best troops will be strong enough to prevent the fall of the city.
- Even the elite/finest soldiers will be unable to save the city.

even their best troops will not be able to resist:

This phrase emphasizes what was said in 11:15b. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as their best troops refers to the finest or elite soldiers of the South. The verb to resist here refers to standing one's ground or resisting the attack of the northern enemy. Here are some other ways to translate this:

even their best troops will not be strong enough to stop the northern army (NCV)

in fact, not even his/its elite troops will be strong enough to resist the attack

In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause as a separate sentence. For example:

Even their best troops will not be strong enough. (GW)

Daniel 11:16

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:16–19

This paragraph tells of the conquests and finally the death of the king of the North.

11:16a

The invader will do as he pleases,

- ¶ “And so the attacker will do whatever he wants
- ¶ “So the invader from the north will be strong enough to act however he likes.

The invader will do as he pleases: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as The invader is literally “the one who comes against him.” This refers to the king of the North, who will attack the king of the South (Egypt). He will be able to act as he chooses. That is, he will encounter no successful defense or opposition. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The one advancing against him will do as he pleases (NET)

The king of the north will march onward unopposed (NLT)

11:16b

and no one will stand against him.

- and no one will oppose/resist him.
- No one will be able to stop him.

and no one will stand against him: This clause further explains the previous verse part using a negative expression instead of a positive one. Here are some other ways to translate it:

no one will be able to resist him (NJB)

and no one will be able to withstand his attack (GW)

none will be able to stop him (NLT)

without opposition (GNT)

11:16c

He will establish himself in the Beautiful Land,

- This king will even occupy the glorious land
- The king of the north will enter the beautiful land of Judah.

He will establish himself in the Beautiful Land: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as He will establish himself in the Beautiful Land is literally “he will stand in the Beautiful Land.” In this context it means that the king of the North and his army will invade and occupy the Beautiful Land. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and he shall stand in the glorious land (RSV)

he will take his stand in the Land of Splendour (NJB)

He will take control/power in the Beautiful Land

the Beautiful Land: The phrase the Beautiful Land refers to the land of Israel. The description of this land as Beautiful implies that it is unique in this way, the most beautiful or desirable of all lands. Here are some other ways to translate it:

the Land of Splendour (NJB)

the fairest of all lands (REB)

11:16d

with destruction in his hand.

- and have the power to destroy it.
- He will be able to ruin it completely.

with destruction in his hand: There is a textual issue here. Scholars have suggested that the Hebrew text should be corrected. The two possibilities are:

1. The Hebrew MT represents the original text. It literally says, “and complete destruction shall be in his hand.” For example:

with destruction in his hand (ESV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NIV, NJB, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The Hebrew text should be corrected to say “and all of it shall be in his hand.” For example:

and all of it shall be in his power (RSV) (RSV/NRSV, GNT, REB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), the reading of the Masoretic Text.

Daniel 11:17

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:16–19

This paragraph tells of the conquests and finally the death of the king of the North.

11:17a

He will resolve to come with the strength of his whole kingdom,

- Then the king of the north will set out with the might/forces of his entire kingdom.
- He will advance with all of his powerful army toward the kingdom of the south

He will resolve to come with the strength of his whole kingdom:

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as He will resolve is literally “and he will set his face.” This means that the king of the North would make a firm decision. He decided to advance with all his forces toward the kingdom of the South. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He will resolve to advance with the full might of his kingdom (REB)

His intention will be to come with the strength of his entire kingdom (NET)

Then the northern king will decide to invade with the power of his entire kingdom

11:17b

and will reach an agreement with the king of the South.

- He will make a peace treaty with the king of the south.
- to make an alliance with the king of the south, and the king of the north will conclude a peace agreement.

and will reach an agreement with the king of the South:

There is a textual problem here. The majority of MT manuscripts say “and upright ones/things with him and he will do.” This is not clear, and some scholars suggest the text should read “he will make a treaty/alliance with him.” This is the reading of some ancient versions and some Hebrew manuscripts. However, since “upright things” can be understood as referring to a peace agreement,^{11:17} The KJV and the GW are alone among major English versions in keeping the reference to upright people. The translation of the two options may be very similar. Apparently, instead of attacking the king of the South, the king of the north decided to make a peace treaty. Here is another way to translate this:

but will then make a treaty with him (NJB)

an agreement: In this context the word that the BSB translates as an agreement refers to an agreement between two kings or countries to not go to war with one another. Other ways to translate it include:

terms of an agreement (ESV)

terms of peace (NRSV)

peace proposal

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this with a descriptive phrase, as the CEV has done:

he will attempt to make peace (CEV)

11:17c

He will give him a daughter in marriage in order to overthrow the kingdom,

- He will give his daughter in marriage to the king of the south in order to overthrow his kingdom.

- He will give the king of the south one of his daughters as a wife. His plan will be to destroy the southern king's kingdom.

He will give him a daughter in marriage: The pronouns He and him may be confusing here. The meaning is that the king of the North gave his daughter (the first Cleopatra) to the king of the South (Ptolemy V). It may be helpful to make the referent of one or both pronouns explicit. For example:

He will give the king of the south a daughter in marriage (NET)

The king of the North will give one of his daughters as a wife to the king of the South (NCV)

in order to overthrow the kingdom: The kingdom that the king of the North wished to overthrow was the southern kingdom, that is, Egypt. It may be necessary to make that clear in some way. For example:

to destroy his enemy's kingdom (GNT)

in order to destroy the southern kingdom (GW)

11:17d

but his plan will not succeed or help him.

- But his plan will not succeed or help him.
- But it will not succeed nor will it give him an advantage over the king of the south.

but his plan will not succeed or help him: The Hebrew text that the BSB translates as but his plan will not succeed or help him is more literally “but not it [or she] will stand and not it will happen to him.” This verse part indicates that the northern king's plan to gain more power by marrying his daughter to the Egyptian Pharaoh did not benefit him. His daughter eventually chose to be loyal to her new husband and to Egypt rather than to her father. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but it shall not succeed or be to his advantage (NRSV)

but it will not turn out to his advantage (NET)

but his plans will fail

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

But those plans will not succeed or help him (NCV)

Daniel 11:18

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:16–19

This paragraph tells of the conquests and finally the death of the king of the North.

11:18a

Then he will turn his face to the coastlands

- ¶ “Then the king of the north will attend to the coastal regions.
- ¶ “So the king of the north will decide instead to invade the lands by the great sea.

Then he will turn his face to the coastlands: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as turn his face here means to direct one’s attacks. The king of the North began to attack the lands and areas bordering the sea (the Mediterranean). Here are some other ways to translate this:

Afterward he shall turn to the coastlands (NRSV)

Then he will turn his attention to the coastal regions (NET)

After that he will attack the nations by the sea (GNT)

Then the king of the North will turn his attention to cities along the coast of the Mediterranean Sea (NCV)

11:18b

and capture many of them.

- He will take control of many of them.
- He will attack and conquer many of these lands.

and capture many of them: The phrase and capture many of them here means that the king of the North would succeed in conquering many of the coastlands. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and will capture many of them (NET)

and conquer many of them (GNT)

11:18c

But a commander will put an end to his reproach

- However, a military commander will put an end to the king of the north’s arrogant aggression.
- But a certain/foreign military leader will stop him from insulting and attacking these other nations.

But a commander will put an end to his reproach:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a commander means “chief, ruler.” Here it probably refers to a foreign leader, the Roman consul Lucius Cornelius Scipio. He won a victory over Antiochus III (the Battle of Magnesia) around 191 B.C. 11:18 For more information, see the journal article “L. Cornelius Scipio: A Salvage Operation,” by J.P.V.D. Baldson, *Historia* 1972.2. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but a foreign commander will make an end to his arrogant activities

but a military leader will defeat him (CEV)

In some languages it may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. For example:

But a commander will bring his shameful conduct to a halt (NET)

his reproach: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as reproach means “scorn, taunting, defiance.” In this context it refers to arrogant and aggressive conduct.

11:18d

and will turn it back upon him.

- He will turn the king’s aggression back upon himself.
- The military leader will even insult and attack him instead.

and will turn it back upon him: The Hebrew of this verse part is difficult and its meaning uncertain. It may involve an idiom referring to the fact that the king was repaid for his arrogance. He was defeated by the Roman consul Scipio. Here are some ways that English versions have translated this:

indeed, he shall turn his insolence back upon him (NRSV)

and even insult him (GW)

and make him lose his pride (CEV)

it: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as it is the same as the word “reproach” in 11:18c. Again it refers to the arrogant conduct of Antiochus III, the king of the North at that time.

Daniel 11:19

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:16–19

This paragraph tells of the conquests and finally the death of the king of the North.

11:19a

After this, he will turn back toward the fortresses of his own land,

- Then the king of the north will return to the fortresses in his own land
- Then the king will retreat toward the walled cities of his own country,

After this, he will turn back toward the fortresses of his own land: In this context the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as turn back refers to a military retreat. The king of the North and his army would have to go back to the fortified cities in their own country. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He will retreat to strongholds in his own country (REB)

The king will return to the fortresses of his own land (GNT)

He will take refuge in his own fortresses (NLT)

11:19b

but he will stumble and fall and be no more.

- but he will fall/collapse. No one will ever see him again.
- but he will be defeated and will meet his end.

but he will stumble and fall: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates literally as will stumble and fall is a figure of speech indicating that the king of the North would be defeated and die. 11:19 After his defeat by the Romans, Antiochus III led his troops further east. He was killed while pillaging a temple of Bel in Persia in 187 B.C. Here are some other ways to translate this:

there he will meet with disaster and be overthrown (REB)

but he will be defeated (GNT)

but on the way he will be defeated (CEV)

and be no more: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as and be no more is a figure of speech that here emphasizes that the king of the North would die. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and he will be seen no more (REB)

and disappear (GW)

and that will be the end of him (GNT)

Daniel 11:20

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:20

This paragraph tells briefly of the reign of the next king of the North and of his death.

11:20a

In his place one will arise who will send out a tax collector for the glory of the kingdom;

- ¶ “Then a new king will reign in his place. He will order an officer to collect taxes for the splendor of his kingdom.
- ¶ “The next king of the northern kingdom will send out a tax collector for the sake of glory of his kingdom.

In his place one will arise who will send out a tax collector for the glory of the kingdom: This verse part is difficult. The Hebrew text may be a reference to the narrative in 2 Maccabees 3. Seleucus IV sent his prime minister or finance minister Heliodorus to seize the wealth in the treasury of the Jerusalem temple. He wanted it for the benefit of the Seleucid empire and for his own glory. Here is another way to translate this:

The next king of the north will try to collect taxes for the glory of his kingdom. (CEV)

In his place one will arise: The Hebrew text is more literally “and one will arise in his place who....” Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then shall arise in his place (NRSV)

The next king of the North

He will be followed by another king

The successor to Antiochus III was named Seleucus IV. You may mention this in a footnote if you choose, but not in the text itself.

a tax collector for the glory of the kingdom: This is a difficult phrase. The Hebrew text says “an exactor/ oppressor of splendor of kingdom.” It is uncertain to what this refers. The two main possibilities are:

1. a tax collector who wanted to increase the splendor of the northern kingdom. For example:

an exactor of tribute for the glory of the kingdom (ESV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, ESV, NLT, CEV, NCV, NET)

1. a tax collector who took taxes from Jerusalem and the temple there (the splendor of Israel). For example:

a raiser of taxes in the glory of the kingdom (KJV) (RSV, NASB, KJV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions.^{11:20} See the UBS Handbook, page 298.

a tax collector: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a tax collector means “an oppressor.” In this context it refers to someone who oppresses people by making them pay taxes or tribute to a foreign government. Here are some other ways to translate this:

an oppressor (NASB)

a raiser of taxes (KJV)

an officer to oppress the people with taxes (GNT)

for the glory of the kingdom: This phrase probably indicates that this king wanted to benefit his own kingdom. See the note above on “a tax collector for

the glory of the kingdom.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

for the glory of the kingdom (NRSV)

in order to increase the wealth of his kingdom (GNT)

11:20b
but within a few days he will be destroyed, though not in anger or in battle.

- But after several years this king will be killed, but not while he is fighting or at war.
- However, a short time later, someone will kill the king. He will not die while fighting a battle.

but within a few days he will be destroyed: The pronoun he here refers to the successor king and not to the tax collector. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit, as the REB has done:

after but a brief time this king too will meet his end (REB)

within a few days: The Hebrew text says “in a few days.” This is an idiom for a short period of time and in most languages should not be translated literally. Here are some possible ways to translate this:

Shortly after this

Soon after

Not long after

he will be destroyed: The Hebrew is literally “he will be broken.” In this context it refers to the killing of the king, his assassination. Historical records indicate that he was killed by order of his minister, Heliodorus.^{11:20} This was recorded by the ancient historian Appian. See Goldingay, page 299. However, it is not recommended that you supply this information in the text, though you may wish to mention it in a footnote. It is best to translate this without making explicit who killed the king. There are two ways to do this:

- using a passive verb. For example:

he will be killed

he will be put to death

- using an active verb. For example:

he will come to a sudden end (CEV)

someone will kill him

though not in anger or in battle: This verse part suggests that this king was to be killed in some secret and shameful way. It is recorded that Seleucus IV died when he was assassinated by order of his own minister, in 175 B.C. It was not a glorious or heroic death that people would honor.

The two ideas in anger and in battle should probably be considered as one complex idea referring to men fighting in battle. Similar English idioms include “in the heat of battle” and “in the rage of battle.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

He will not die while he is fighting in battle.

However, he will not die during the angry fighting/raging of a war.

Daniel 11:21

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:21–24

This paragraph tells of the rise of an evil ruler, one of the kings of the north. Scholars agree that this is a reference to Antiochus IV. Biblical scholars indicate that he is the “little horn” of Daniel 8:9–12, 23–25. Antiochus IV gave himself the title of Epiphanes, the Manifest One (that is, God Revealed). By using this title, he claimed to be the god Zeus incarnate. You can read more about him in 1–2 Maccabees, especially 1 Maccabees chapters 1 and 6. (In the NJB, 1 Maccabees follows the Book of Esther.)

11:21a

In his place a despicable person will arise;

- ¶ “A new king will take his place, a despicable person.
- ¶ The angel said/continued, “After that, a new king will rule the northern kingdom, a man not worthy of honor.

In his place a despicable person will arise: The Hebrew literally says “and a despicable man will arise in his place.” This indicates that the king of the North, whose death is recorded in 11:20, would be succeeded by an unworthy man. Historical records report that Seleucus IV was succeeded by Antiochus IV, an evil man who was not the rightful heir to the throne. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then there will arise in his place a despicable person (NET)

A contemptible person will take his place. (GW)

The successor of the king of the North will be a worthless man

a despicable person: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as despicable means “despicable, someone whom others rightly despise.” It refers to someone who is not worthy of honor and respect. Avoid suggesting that this was a man to be pitied because others scorned him. The focus is on the idea that he deserved scorn or contempt. It is implied that he was evil. Here is another way to translate this:

a vile person (KJV)

This despicable person is the focus of the narrative that follows. Scholars agree that this is a reference to the Seleucid emperor Antiochus IV Epiphanes. He is also the little horn of Daniel 8:9–12, 23–25.

11:21b

royal honors will not be given to him,

- He will not become king with majesty and honor.
- He will have no right to be king.

royal honors will not be given to him: The pronoun him here refers back to the contemptible person of 11:21a. Antiochus IV was not the rightful heir to the throne. Here are some other ways to translate this:

who has no right to be king (GNT)

who is not in line for royal succession (NLT)

who doesn’t come from a royal family (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause or sentence. For example:

He will not be given royal splendor. (GW)

11:21c

but he will come in a time of peace

- He will come when people do not expect it
- He will arrive in the kingdom unexpectedly.

but he will come in a time of peace and seize the kingdom: The Hebrew word that the BSB literally translates as come is a general word. Other ways to translate this phrase is:

He will come on the scene (NET)

He will suddenly appear (CEV)

in a time of peace: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in a time of peace is “in quietness.” In this context this probably means that the new ruler would gain power unexpectedly. See 8:25c, where the same word is used of the same event. Here are some other ways to translate this:

unexpectedly (RSV)

without warning (NRSV)

when the people do not expect it

11:21d

and seize the kingdom by intrigue.

- and gain power by treachery/deceit.
- Then he will take control of it by deceiving/tricking people.

and seize the kingdom by intrigue: The Hebrew text says “and he will take hold of royalty by smooth/slippery talk.” This indicates that the despicable one would gain royal power by means of flattery and deceit. He would make false promises in order to have himself made king. Other ways to translate this include:

and will gain possession of the kingdom by intrigue (NJB)

and will seize the kingdom through deceit (NET)

and seize power by trickery (GNT)

Daniel 11:22

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:21–24

This paragraph tells of the rise of an evil ruler, one of the kings of the north. Scholars agree that this is a reference to Antiochus IV. Biblical scholars indicate that he is the “little horn” of Daniel 8:9–12, 23–25. Antiochus IV gave himself the title of Epiphanes, the Manifest One (that is, God Revealed). By using this title, he claimed to be the god Zeus incarnate. You can read more about him in 1–2 Maccabees, especially 1 Maccabees chapters 1 and 6. (In the NJB, 1 Maccabees follows the Book of Esther.)

11:22a-b

Then a flood of forces will be swept away before him and destroyed, along with a prince of the covenant: There is a textual problem here. The main options are:

1. The MT is correct. It reads “The forces of the overflowing/flood will be swept from before him and will be broken, and also a leader of a covenant.” Here is another way to translate this:

The overflowing forces will be flooded away before him and shattered, and also the prince of the covenant. (NASB) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NIV)

1. The vowels of the noun “the overflowing/flood” should be corrected to make a verb that functions to emphasize the following verb will be swept away. The two verbs together then mean “utterly/completely/suddenly swept away. Here is another way to translate this:

Armies will be utterly routed and crushed by him, the Prince of the covenant too. (NJB) (RSV/NRSV, NJB, ESV, NET)

It is difficult to be sure which text the less literal translations are following. The two options are quite similar in meaning, with the emphasis placed on either the strength of the army or the suddenness of its defeat. You may wish to consider the translation of the major language in your area.

and destroyed, along with a prince of the covenant:

This verb describes what happened to the army and a prince of the covenant. In some languages it may not be possible to refer to the destruction of an army

and the killing of a man with the same verb. It may be necessary to translate this using two different verbs. For example:

the army will be destroyed and the leader of the covenant people will be killed

11:22a

Then a flood of forces will be swept away before him and destroyed,

- Mighty armies will advance against him like a flood, but they will be overcome.
- He will overpower every mighty army that comes to attack him.

Then a flood of forces will be swept away before him: This is probably a general statement indicating that the despicable one defeated powerful enemies on his way to establishing control. It is not recommended that you try to identify the army with a specific enemy. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Armies will be suddenly swept away in defeat before him. (NET)

As he advances, he will sweep away all forces of opposition. (REB)

He will overwhelm large forces. (GW)

will be swept away: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as will be swept away is more literally “will be broken.” This is a passive verb and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

will be broken (REB)

will be...wiped out (GNT)

- using an active verb. The implied subject is the contemptible/despicable man who was now king of the North. For example:

He will...defeat them (GW)

Translate this using the form that is most natural in your language in this context.

11:22b

along with a prince of the covenant.

- He will break their power and that of the ruler of God’s covenant people.
- He will defeat/destroy those armies and kill the chief/leader of God’s people.

a prince of the covenant: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as a prince of the covenant can also be translated as “a leader of a covenant.” In this context it probably refers to the Jewish high priest Onias III, who was murdered by one of Antiochus’s allies in 171 B.C. 11:22 Lucas, page 284, and Steinmann, page 526. See 2 Maccabees 4:34. You may wish to make a footnote saying that the reference is probably to the Jewish high priest of that time.

the covenant: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the covenant is literally “a covenant.” Even though the definite article (the) is not used, this probably refers to God’s covenant with the Jewish nation and people.

General Comment on 11:22a-b

There are several different ways to arrange the information in these verse parts. For example:

Armies shall be utterly swept away and broken before him, and the prince of the covenant as well. (NRSV)

He will overwhelm large forces and defeat them, including the prince of the covenant. (GW)

Anyone who opposes him, even God’s High Priest, will be swept away and wiped out. (GNT)

Before him great armies will be swept away, including a covenant prince. (NLT)

Daniel 11:23

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:21–24

This paragraph tells of the rise of an evil ruler, one of the kings of the north. Scholars agree that this is a reference to Antiochus IV. Biblical scholars indicate that he is the “little horn” of Daniel 8:9–12, 23–25. Antiochus IV gave himself the title of Epiphanes, the Manifest One (that is, God Revealed). By using this

title, he claimed to be the god Zeus incarnate. You can read more about him in 1–2 Maccabees, especially 1 Maccabees chapters 1 and 6. (In the NJB, 1 Maccabees follows the Book of Esther.)

11:23a

After an alliance is made with him,

- He will make an alliance/treaty
- A solemn agreement will be made with him,

After an alliance is made with him: The Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as him here probably refers to the despicable ruler rather than the covenant prince. This verse part indicates that unnamed nations or rulers would make an alliance with the despicable one. Here are some other ways to translate this:

After entering into an alliance with him (NET)

After an alliance is made with him (NRSV)

11:23b

he will act deceitfully;

- but will not be faithful to it.
- but he will break it.

he will act deceitfully: This verse part indicates that the despicable ruler would break the agreement he had made. Here are some other ways to translate this:

he will practice deception (NASB)

but he will be deceitful and break it (CEV)

he will behave treacherously (NET)

In some languages it may be necessary to say whom the ruler would deceive. The GNT makes it explicit that it is other nations:

he will deceive other nations (GNT)

11:23c

for he will rise to power with only a few people.

- He will gain power with only a small force of people.
- In that way he will become king with only a small number of troops/men on his side.

for he will rise to power with only a few people: This verse part indicates that at the time he takes power, the despicable ruler would not have many followers

or supporters. Many English translations reverse the order of the information in this verse part:

and rise to power with only a few people (GW)

will ascend to power with only a small force (NET)

He will become strong despite having only a handful of followers. (NLT)

and become strong with a small party (NRSV)

Daniel 11:24

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:21–24

This paragraph tells of the rise of an evil ruler, one of the kings of the north. Scholars agree that this is a reference to Antiochus IV. Biblical scholars indicate that he is the “little horn” of Daniel 8:9–12, 23–25. Antiochus IV gave himself the title of Epiphanes, the Manifest One (that is, God Revealed). By using this title, he claimed to be the god Zeus incarnate. You can read more about him in 1–2 Maccabees, especially 1 Maccabees chapters 1 and 6. (In the NJB, 1 Maccabees follows the Book of Esther.)

11:24a

In a time of peace, he will invade the richest provinces

- At an unexpected time he will go to the most wealthy parts of the province
- Without warning he and his army will invade the most prosperous regions of the province.

In a time of peace, he will invade the richest provinces: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a time of peace is literally “in quietness/peace.” It is the same word as in 11:21c and you should translate it the same way here. For example:

Without warning he shall come into the richest parts of the province (NRSV)

In an unexpected time he will invade the most productive areas of the province

He will invade a wealthy province without warning (GNT)

he will invade the richest provinces: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as invade is the general word meaning “come.” In this context it is implied that the despicable ruler and his army will enter these prosperous lands in order to rob them and control them. Here is another way to translate this:

he will invade the richest parts of the provinces (GW)

the richest provinces: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the richest provinces is more literally “the fatness of the province.” This is a metaphor for fertility and prosperity. The land in this area was rich and fertile and good for farming.

11:24b

and do what his fathers and forefathers never did.

- and do things that neither his father nor his other ancestors did.
- He will act in a worse way than any of his ancestors.

and do what his fathers and forefathers never did:

This verse part indicates that the despicable ruler would act in a way unlike that of his ancestors, the kings who ruled before him. This should be translated in a way that implies that his actions were more evil than those of his predecessors. Your translation should not imply that his accomplishments were more praiseworthy than those of his predecessors. Here are some other ways to translate this:

which is something his ancestors never did (CEV)

acting as his father or his fathers’ fathers never acted (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

He will do what none of his ancestors did.

his fathers and forefathers: This phrase is an emphatic way of referring to the ancestors of the despicable ruler. Emphasize this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

not a single one of his ancestors (UBS Handbook)

11:24c

He will lavish plunder, loot, and wealth on his followers,

- He will plunder these lands and share the goods and property among his followers.
- He will take/steal all the riches of those regions/lands and distribute them among his supporters.

He will lavish plunder, loot, and wealth on his fol-

lowers: The king of the North will give to his followers the various riches and treasures that his soldiers stole. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then he will divide among his followers all of its treasures and property. (CEV)

He will rob the countries he defeats and give those things to his followers. (NCV)

plunder, loot, and wealth: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as plunder, loot, and wealth are synonyms in this context. Together they refer to the money and treasures that the king gave to his soldiers, money and treasures that they had taken from their defeated enemies. In some languages it may be natural to describe these things with a verb or verbs rather than a series of three nouns. For example:

the goods and property he has captured in war (GNT)

He will rob the countries he defeats and will give those things to his followers. (NCV)

11:24d

and he will plot against the strongholds—but only for a time.

- He will plot to overthrow fortresses, but he will only succeed for a short time.
- He will even plan to attack and destroy fortified cities. However, he will only be successful for a short period of time.

he will plot against the strongholds: This clause indicates the king of the North will plan to capture the fortresses or strongholds of his enemies. He will make military preparations to defeat their fortified cities. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He will plan to defeat and destroy strong cities (NCV)

He will make plans to attack fortresses (GNT)

but only for a time: The phrase but only for a time indicates that these things will only happen for a short or limited period of time. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

but he will be successful for only a short time
(NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence:

But none of this will last very long. (CEV)

Daniel 11:25

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:25–28

This paragraph describes the continued struggle of the despicable king of the North against the king of the South, the king of Egypt.

11:25a

And with a large army he will stir up his power and his courage against the king of the South,

- ¶ “The king of the north will arouse all his strength and enthusiasm and confront the king of the south. He will summon/gather a large army and attack.
- ¶ “With sudden vigor the king of the north will decide to take action against the king of the south. He will attack with a large army.

And with a large army he will stir up his power and his courage against the king of the South: The subject of this clause is the king of the North, Antiochus IV. The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as he will stir up means “he will arouse” or “he will awaken.” This is a figure of speech meaning that the king will encourage himself to do something. In this context the king encouraged himself to confront the king of the South. Historical records indicate that Antiochus did go to war with Egypt in 169 B.C. 11:25 See Lucas page 285, Steinmann page 527, and Goldingay pages 300–301. Here are some other ways to translate this:

And he shall stir up his power and his heart against the king of the south with a great army.
(ESV)

He shall stir up his power and determination against the king of the south with a great army
(NRSV)

He will boldly raise a large army to attack the king of Egypt (GNT)

he will stir up his power and his courage against:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as courage is literally “heart.” This is figurative languages referring to a person’s will and desires. Use the term that is natural in your language for someone who chooses to act vigorously and enthusiastically. Avoid translating it in such a positive way as to imply that the king was a noble and courageous figure. Here are some other possible ways to translate this:

with great vigor/energy he will confront

with sudden enthusiasm he will confront

energetically/enthusiastically he will march against

the king of the South: At this time the ruler of Egypt was Ptolemy VI Philometer (who died in 145 B.C.)

11:25b

who will mobilize a very large and powerful army

- The king of the south will prepare to fight/resist with his own huge and powerful army.
- The king of the south will oppose him with an even larger and more powerful army.

who will mobilize a very large and powerful army:

This verse indicates that the king of the South will have a very large and powerful army of his own. It is implied that this army is bigger than that of the king of the North. With this army, the king of the South will fight back and defend himself against the king of the North. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and the king of the south shall wage war with a much greater and stronger army (NRSV)

who will prepare for war with a large, strong army
(GW)

who will prepare to fight back with a huge and powerful army (GNT)

11:25c**but will not withstand**

- But the king of the south will not be able to withstand/stop the king of the north
- But he will not be able to defeat the army of the king of the north

but will not withstand: This is an idiom referring to failure in battle. The phrase continues to refer to the king of the South. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

But the southern king won't be able to withstand him (GW)

But the king of Egypt...will not be successful. (GNT)

the king of the South will be defeated (NCV)

11:25d**the plots devised against him.**

- because they/people will plot against him.
- because some men will make secret plans against him.

the plots devised against him: This clause tells what the king of the South would not “withstand.” It indicates that some unnamed people would plot against the king of the South and that this would cause his defeat. This a passive clause, and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

for plots shall be devised against him (NRSV)

- using an active verb. For example:

the people who are against him will make secret plans (NCV)

Translate this in the way that is most natural in your own language.

General Comment on 11:25c-d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these two verse parts. For example:

But the people who are against him will make secret plans, and the king of the South will be defeated. (NCV)

Daniel 11:26**Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age**

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:25–28

This paragraph describes the continued struggle of the despicable king of the North against the king of the South, the king of Egypt.

11:26a**Those who eat from his provisions will seek to destroy him;**

- In fact, those who eat his royal food will betray him.
- Members of his own court/council will cause his ruin/defeat.

Those who eat from his provisions will seek to destroy him:

The phrase Those who eat from his provisions refers to people who were the king's dependents and advisers. He provided their food. This implies that he would expect them to be loyal to him. It is surprising that they would turn against him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Those who eat the king's fine food will attempt to destroy him (NET)

People who eat the king's rich food will ruin him. (GW)

from his provisions: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as from his provisions is more literally “from his delicacies” or “of his rich food.” See the note on 1:5a, where the same word is used and is translated by the BSB as “provisions.”

11:26b**his army will be swept away, and many will fall slain.**

- His army will be defeated and many of his soldiers will die on the battlefield.
- The army/men of the northern kingdom will defeat his army and kill many of his soldiers.

his army will be swept away: There is a textual problem here. The MT says, “his army will overflow.” This expression normally refers to victory, but the context shows that the army of the South was defeated. Many English versions therefore follow those ancient versions. The ancient Syriac and Latin versions have the passive form. that have the passive form, “his

army will be overflowed,” that is, defeated. The two options are:

1. The passive form is correct. For example:

His army will be overwhelmed (GW) (BSB, NIV, GW, RSV/NRSV, ESV, REB, NET, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The active form, that of the MT, is correct. For example:

and his army will overflow (NASB) (KJV, NASB)

The meaning is that the army of the South will lose the battle. Translate that meaning using the form that is most natural in your language. For example:

His army will be swept away in defeat (NCV)

his army: The phrase his army refers to the army of the king of the south. His men were defeated by the forces of the king of the north.

and many will fall slain: The Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates as fall slain is more literally “fall killed.” It indicates that many soldiers were killed in the fighting. Translate this idiom in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

and many will die in battle (GW)

Daniel 11:27

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:25–28

This paragraph describes the continued struggle of the despicable king of the North against the king of the South, the king of Egypt.

11:27a

And the two kings, with their hearts bent on evil,

- These two kings will secretly plan to harm each other.
- Both of those kings will intend evil to the other.

And the two kings, with their hearts bent on evil:

This verse part describes how the kings of the North and South would think of each other. They would each plan to do harm to the other. Here are some other ways to translate this:

And as for the two kings, their hearts shall be bent on doing evil. (ESV)

These two kings, their minds filled with evil intentions (NET)

The two kings will both plan to do evil. (GW)

with their hearts bent on evil: The Hebrew text that the BSB translates with the English idiom with their hearts bent on evil is literally “their heart to evil.” This word for evil refers to evil deeds. The two kings would both be planning on doing evil to the other.

11:27b

will speak lies at the same table,

- Even though they will sit down together at the same table, they will lie to each other.
- They will sit and eat together, but they will lie to each other to gain power.

will speak lies at the same table: This verse part describes how the kings of the North and South would act to each other. They would meet in a friendly way, but they would both tell lies. Here are some other ways to translate this:

will trade lies with one another at the same table. (NET)

They will sit at the same table and tell lies. (GW)

at the same table: The phrase at the same table refers to sharing a meal together. This implies that the kings would pretend to be friendly. They would eat and drink together, but they would both be telling lies and planning evil. However, in some cultures people do not sit at a table together to eat. In those languages it may be natural to say:

meet around a table (CEV)

sit and eat together

share a meal together

11:27c

but to no avail,

- However, their plans will not succeed,
- Neither of them will be successful.

11:27d

for still the end will come at the appointed time.

- because the end will not happen until the time God has determined.
- God has decided that things will not yet come to an end/conclusion.

11:27c-d

but to no avail, for still the end will come at the appointed time: The common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrast with the actions and plans of the kings in the previous verse part.

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

But it will not succeed, for there is still an end at the appointed time. (NET)

But they will not succeed, because the end must wait until the appointed time. (GW)

but to no avail: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as but to no avail is more literally “and not it will succeed.” Here is another way to translate this:

But it will make no difference (NLT)

for still the end will come at the appointed time:

This is a reference to Habakkuk 2:3. Here the meaning is probably that God decides on the way things will end. It may be natural to make this explicit. Here are some other ways to translate this:

God appoints the time for it to end

God is the one who has set the time for their end (UBS Handbook)

Daniel 11:28

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:25–28

This paragraph describes the continued struggle of the despicable king of the North against the king of the South, the king of Egypt.

11:28a

The king of the North will return to his land with great wealth,

- Later the king of the north will return to his country with great riches.
- After that, the king of the northern kingdom will start home with the loot he had taken.

The king of the North will return to his land with great wealth:

This verse part implies that the king of the North will take great wealth from the South back to the North. His army will loot or plunder the wealth of the southern kingdom. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The northern king will return to his country with a lot of wealth (GW)

Then the king of the North will return home with spoils in plenty (REB)

The king of Syria will return home with all the loot he has captured (GNT)

11:28b

but his heart will be set against the holy covenant;

- But he will plan to oppose the holy covenant that God had made.
- He will decide/determine to destroy the holy agreement that God had made with his people.

but his heart will be set against the holy covenant:

The clause his heart will be set against the holy covenant means that the northern king will be the enemy of God’s covenant and the covenant people. He will want to work against God’s covenant with the Jewish people and do harm to them. Here are some other ways to translate this

His mind will be set against the holy covenant. (NET)

He will be determined to fight against the holy promise. (GW)

11:28c

so he will do damage

- He will work against it
- He will accomplish his evil plans.

11:28d

and return to his own land.

- and then he will return back to his land.
- Then he will continue his trip back home.

11:28c-d**so he will do damage and return to his own land:**

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as he will do damage is literally just “he will do/act.” This probably refers to the fact that Antiochus did harm to the Jewish people before returning home. Historical records show that after visiting Egypt, Antiochus IV went to Jerusalem and took a lot of wealth from the treasure in the Jerusalem Temple.^{11:28} This was in 169 B.C. See Goldingay page 301 for more information. Here are some other ways to translate this:

And he shall work his will and return to his own land. (ESV)

doing much damage before continuing his journey (NLT)

Daniel 11:29**Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age**

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:29–30

This paragraph tells how some ships from the west would prevent the evil king of the North from invading Egypt again. Scholars agree that this is a reference to Roman intervention.

11:29a**At the appointed time he will invade the South again,**

- ¶ “At the appointed time, the king of the north will come again into the south,
- ¶ “At the time that God will decide, the king of the north and his army will invade the southern kingdom a second time.

At the appointed time: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as At the appointed time refers to the time that God had chosen or appointed. Other ways to translate this include:

In God’s time

At the time God has decided (CEV)

At the right time (NCV)

At the time God chooses

he will invade the South again: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as he will invade is literally “he will return and he will come into.” The northern king will again march with his army toward the southern kingdom, Egypt. It is good to make it explicit, as the BSB has done, that he will go toward the South in order to attack it. It may also be helpful to make it explicit that the pronoun he here refers to the king of the North. For example:

the king of the north will invade the southern kingdom again (CEV)

the king of the North will attack the king of the South again (NCV)

11:29b**but this time will not be like the first.**

- but this time the result will be different.
- However, this second invasion/attempt will not be successful.

but this time will not be like the first: This is more literally “and this latter time it shall not be like the former time.” This indicates that this second attack on Egypt would turn out differently than the first. Here are some other ways to translate this:

but this time things will turn out differently (GNT)

but he will have less success than he had before (REB)

but this time the result will be different (NLT)

this time: The phrase this time refers to the invasion of Egypt mentioned in 11:29a. This second invasion took place in 168 B.C.

the first: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the first refers to the first invasion of Egypt that is described in 11:25–28, Antiochus’ Egyptian campaign of 169 B.C. This first campaign had ended with the defeat of Egypt.

Daniel 11:30**Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age**

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:29–30

This paragraph tells how some ships from the west would prevent the evil king of the North from invading Egypt again. Scholars agree that this is a reference to Roman intervention.

11:30a**Ships of Kittim will come against him,**

- For ships from Kittim will come against the king of the north.
- The men of/from the west will come in ships and oppose him.

Ships of Kittim will come against him: This verse part begins to explain how and why this second invasion turned out differently. The king of the North was attacked by some Ships of Kittim. The word Kittim was a term used to refer to people from the islands and coastlands of the western Mediterranean. 11:30 The ancient Jewish historian Josephus wrote that the term Kittim came to be used “for all islands and most maritime countries.” See Lucas, page 286. Scholars agree that here this is a reference to the Romans, and you may wish to mention this in a footnote. Some Roman forces confronted Antiochus in 168 B.C. and demanded that he withdraw from Egypt, which he did. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Ships of Kittim will sail against him (REB)

Ships from the west will come to attack him (CEV)

The men of the west will come in ships to fight/oppose him

11:30b–c

Then he will turn back and rage against the holy covenant and do damage: After the Romans confronted him, Antiochus left Egypt and attacked Jerusalem. See 1 Maccabees 1:29–40 and 2 Maccabees 5:24–26 for a description of the events surrounding this.

11:30b**and he will lose heart. Then he will turn back**

- As a result, the king of the north will become afraid and decide to go home.
- The king of the north will retreat in fear.

and he will lose heart: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as and he will lose heart means “he will become discouraged.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

and he will be disheartened

and he will be discouraged (CEV)

and he will give up the/his attempt to invade the south

11:30c**and rage against the holy covenant and do damage.**

- On his way he will become angry with the holy covenant and take action against it.
- He will become angry with God’s holy covenant people and he will act against them.

rage against the holy covenant and do damage: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as rage is literally “curse, scold.” The idea is that the king would be very angry and would express that anger. Here are some other ways to translate this:

be enraged and take action against the holy covenant (ESV)

show his anger against the holy agreement (NCV)

So he will return and show favor to those who forsake the holy covenant:

This verse part indicates that the king of the North would go back to Jerusalem. This refers to the same journey as the previous verse part. There he would favor unfaithful Jews, those of the Jewish people who were unfaithful to their God and religion. Here are some other ways to translate this:

so he will come back and show regard for those who forsake the holy covenant (NASB)

He shall turn back and pay attention to those who forsake the holy covenant (ESV)

Since the previous verse mentions “turning back” to Jerusalem, some translations do not repeat the travel verb (he will return) here. Only one journey is involved, described with two verbs. For example:

while showing kindness to those who are unfaithful (CEV)

He will be good to those who have stopped obeying the holy agreement (NCV)

and...will favor those who forsake that holy covenant (NJB)

show favor: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as show favor is more literally “pay attention.” It is implied that he will pay attention in a positive way to these people, listening to them and helping them.

those who forsake the holy covenant: The phrase those who forsake the holy covenant refers to Jewish people who were unfaithful to Yahweh and his covenant with Israel. These people were willing to follow the pagan practices of the king of the north.

11:30d

So he will return and show favor to those who forsake the holy covenant.

- He will return to Jerusalem and favor those who have abandoned the holy covenant.
- On his return to Jerusalem he will ally himself with those who abandon the holy agreement that God made with his people.

Daniel 11:31

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:31–32

This paragraph tells how the soldiers of the king of the North would do harm to Jerusalem and God’s holy people and temple.

11:31a

His forces will rise up and desecrate the temple fortress.

- ¶ “The army of/from the north will enter the fortified holy place and defile/profane it.
- ¶ “The king of the north will send his soldiers against the temple/sanctuary fortress. They will make it unclean/impure

His forces will rise up and desecrate the temple fortress: This verse part indicates that the troops of the king of the North would make the temple fortress unholy or unclean. It is recorded in the book of Maccabees that Antiochus sent some of his men to tear down the city walls and build their own citadel within the city of David.^{11:31} See 1 Maccabees 1:31–33. In the eyes of faithful Jews, this made it unholy. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Soldiers in his command will desecrate the sanctuary and citadel (REB)

His forces will rise up and profane the fortified sanctuary (NET)

He will send troops to pollute the temple and the fortress (CEV)

The king of the North will send his army to make the Temple in Jerusalem unclean. (NCV)

11:31b

They will abolish the daily sacrifice

- They will make/put an end to the daily burnt offering.
- and will stop/prevent God’s priest from offering the daily burnt sacrifices.

They will abolish the daily sacrifice: This clause indicates that the king of the North would put an end to the daily sacrifices that the Jewish priests made to God in the temple. Antiochus did forbid these sacrifices. See the note on 8:11b and 9:27b. Here are some other ways to translate this:

they will abolish the regular offering (REB)

and he will stop the daily sacrifices (CEV)

They will stop people from offering the daily sacrifice (NCV)

11:31c

and set up the abomination of desolation.

- Then they will set up in the temple the abominable/disgusting thing that causes/brings destruction
- The soldiers will place in the temple an object that is horrific/detestable/repulsive, the object that destroys everything.

and set up the abomination of desolation: The soldiers of the northern king would place an evil object in the temple. This is also mentioned in 9:27c. See the note there. 1 Maccabees 1:54 records that in 167 B.C. “they erected a desolating sacrilege upon the altar of burnt offering.” Pagan sacrifices were offered up to pagan deities in God’s temple.

In its place they will set up the abomination that causes desolation. (NET)

Then he will set up the “Horrible Thing” that causes destruction. (CEV)

and then they will set up the destroying terror (NCV)

the abomination of desolation: Translate this phrase in the same way that you did in 9:27c. Use an expression that indicates disgust and horror. In some languages it may be natural to use adjectives and verbs rather than the nouns abomination and desolation. For example:

the abominable thing that destroys

that which disgusts and destroys

the hateful object that ruins everything

Daniel 11:32

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:31–32

This paragraph tells how the soldiers of the king of the North would do harm to Jerusalem and God's holy people and temple.

11:32a

With flattery he will corrupt those who violate the covenant,

- The king of the north will use flattery to win over some people, people who were unfaithful to the covenant.
- The king of the north will deceive with flattering words those who had abandoned/rejected God's covenant.

With flattery he will corrupt those who violate the covenant: This verse part describes how the king of the North will win some of the Jews to his side.11:32 The Jewish high priest Menelaus and his followers agreed to accept the actions of Antiochus. Other ways to translate this include:

The king will use deceit to win followers from those who are unfaithful to God (CEV)

The king of the North will tell lies and cause those who have not obeyed God to be ruined. (NCV)

With flattery: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as With flattery is more literally “with slipperi-

ness” or “with smoothness.” A similar phrase is used in 11:21d, where the BSB translates it as “through intrigue.” The idea is that the evil king of the north will use smooth and deceptive talk to win people to his side.

he will corrupt those who violate the covenant:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as corrupt means to defile or make someone unclean/impure. In this context the thought is that of causing people to become evil, or winning them over to the evil side. Here is another way to translate this:

he will seduce...those who violate the covenant (RSV)

those who violate the covenant: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as those who violate the covenant refers to Jewish people who were not faithful to the covenant that God had made with them. Here is another way to translate this:

those who have rejected the covenant (NET)

11:32b

but the people who know their God will firmly resist him.

- But those who know their God will remain strong and take action.
- However, all God's people who are committed to him will remain firm and will resist/oppose the king of the north.

but the people who know their God will firmly resist him: This verse part is in contrast to 11:32a. Not all the Jews will allow themselves to be corrupted by the king of the north. Those who know God will resist that evil king.

will firmly resist him: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as will firmly resist him is more literally “will be strong and will act.” The text does not say exactly what these people will do, and it is recommended that you do not make it explicit.11:32 Daniel does not seem to approve of the armed aggressive warfare of the Maccabees. See 11:14. Here are some other ways to translate this:

will do everything possible to oppose him (CEV)

will be strong and take action (GW)

Daniel 11:33

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:33–35

This paragraph tells what will happen to those who resist the evil king of the North.

11:33a

Those with insight will instruct many,

- ¶ “Those who are wise among God’s people will help many others know what to do.
- ¶ “Those who have insight will guide many people to understand the right thing to do.

Those with insight will instruct many: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Those with insight is more literally “those who are wise/discerning among/of the people” or “those of the people who have insight.” In this context the phrase refers to the “wise” among the Jews, that is, their leaders. The word many here refers to the ordinary Jewish people. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Wise leaders will instruct many of the people.
(CEV)

Those who are wise among the people will teach the masses. (NET)

Those of the people who are wise leaders will instruct many (NJB)

11:33b

though for a time they will fall by sword or flame, or be captured or plundered.

- However, some of them will be killed in war or burned to death. Others will be taken/made prisoners or lose their possessions. This will/must last for a short period of time.
- But for a time they will suffer. The enemy/enemies will kill some of them with swords or with fire. They will rob others of their possessions and take some of them captive.

though for a time they will fall by sword or flame, or be captured or plundered: In the English the pronoun they is ambiguous here. It could refer to “Those with insight” or to the “many” whom they will instruct. In view of 11:35a, it probably refers to those who have

insight, that is, the wise. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But for a while, some of these leaders will either be killed with swords or burned alive, or else robbed of their possessions and thrown into prison. (CEV)

for some days, however, they shall fall by sword and flame, and suffer captivity and plunder (NRSV)

But for some time they will be defeated by swords and flames. They will be captured and looted. (GW)

but these leaders will die by fire and sword, or they will be jailed and robbed (NLT)

Daniel 11:34

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:33–35

This paragraph tells what will happen to those who resist the evil king of the North.

11:34a

Now when they fall, they will be granted a little help,

- While they suffer, they will have a bit of help,
- While they are suffering such persecution, a few people will give them a little help.

Now when they fall: The words Now when they fall refers to the time of persecution of the faithful Jews. These faithful ones will suffer the kind of persecution mentioned in the previous verse part. Other ways to translate this include:

When they fall victim (NRSV)

During these persecutions (NLT)

When they suffer in this way

they will be granted a little help: The Hebrew is more literally “they will be helped with a little help.” This is a reference to human help, which is always limited.

This help probably includes, but is not limited to, the resistance of the Maccabees that is described in 1 Maccabees 2–4. Here are some other ways to translate this:

they will be given a little help

they will have/get some human help

some small help will come to them

they will be helped a little bit

11:34b

but many will join them insincerely.

- but many who join with them will do so insincerely.
- However, many will unite/ally themselves with them for selfish reasons.

but many will join them insincerely: The common Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces something that lessens the value of the “help” mentioned in the previous verse part. In some languages it may therefore be natural to translate this with a conjunction indicating contrast, as the GW has done:

but many who are not sincere will join them (GW)

many will join them insincerely: The Hebrew of this clause is more literally “many will join themselves to them with slippery words.” This seems to indicate that many people would claim to support the Jewish resistance but would not be dependable or faithful. Here are some other ways to translate this:

many who join them will not be sincere (NLT)

many will unite with them deceitfully (NET)

many who join them will do so for selfish reasons (GNT)

Daniel 11:35

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:33–35

This paragraph tells what will happen to those who resist the evil king of the North.

11:35a

Some of the wise will fall,

- Even some of those who are wise will suffer.
- Some of those who have insight will be persecuted/killed.

Some of the wise will fall: The clause Some of the wise will fall here indicates that some of the faithful and wise Jewish teachers mentioned in 11:33a would suffer persecution. Avoid suggesting that Some of the wise will fall into sin. The following verse part shows that this is not the meaning in this context. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Some of the wise people will be defeated (GW)

Some of the discerning ones will fall victim to the persecutors

And some of the wise will fall victim to persecution (NLT)

Some of those who are wise will suffer (CEV)

11:35b-c

so that they may be refined, purified, and made spotless until the time of the end: This is a purpose clause. It describes God’s purpose in allowing some of the wise to fall victim to persecution. God’s purpose is to make these people holy. Here are some other ways to translate this purpose clause:

in order to refine, purify and make them white until the end times (GW)

God will allow this to make them holy, pure, and without spot/blame until the end

11:35b

so that they may be refined, purified, and made spotless

- This will happen in order to refine, purify, and make God’s people clean.
- The persecution/suffering will test and purify God’s people. It will help them to choose what is good and not sin.

they may be refined: The Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as they may be refined is literally “to refine them.” This is a figure of speech that refers to the way metal is refined in order to test and purify it. There are several ways to translate this:

- using a passive verb referring to either the refining of metal or the testing of a person. For example:

they may be tested (REB)

- using an active verb. The implied subject may be God or the persecution itself. For example:

He wants to refine/test them

This persecution will refine/test them

- using a noun. For example:

their refinement (NET)

their testing

purified: The word purified is here short for “so that they may be purified.” Again, this may be translated in several ways:

- using a passive verb. For example:

made pure

- using an active verb. For example:

to make them pure

- using a noun. For example:

their...purification (NET)

made spotless: This is more literally “made white.” This is a passive verb and there are several ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

cleansed (NRSV)

- using an active verb. For example:

made white (ESV)

- using a noun. For example:

their...cleansing (NET)

Translate this series of three verbs in the way that is most natural in your language.

11:35c

until the time of the end,

- The persecution will continue until the end of this time,
- This will continue until this time/age comes to an end.

until the time of the end: Here is another way to translate this verse part:

until the end comes (GNT)

11:35d

for it will still come at the appointed time.

- for the time that God has appointed/chosen/determined is still in the future.
- God has decided when he will bring this time/age to an end.

for it will still come at the appointed time: This clause indicates that the end will come at the time God has appointed, but the end is not yet. It is still to come. Here are some other ways to translate this:

for there is still an interval until the time appointed (NRSV)

But the appointed time is still to come. (GW)

the appointed time: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the appointed time refers to a fixed or set time for something to happen, such as a feast day. It is implied that God is the one who has appointed the time. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit, as the GNT has done:

the time that God has set (GNT)

Daniel 11:36

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:36–39

This paragraph speaks of the success of the evil king of the North. Some scholars take this king to still be Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Other scholars understand this to refer to another evil king, like Antiochus, who has yet to come to power.^{11:35} See the footnote in the NET. It is recommended that you do not specify the identity of this king other than to refer to him as the king of the North (as he is called in 11:40b).

11:36a**Then the king will do as he pleases**

- “The king will do as he pleases.
- “The king will do whatever he wants.

Then the king will do as he pleases: This clause implies that the king will be successful and powerful. See the similar phrase in 11:3c. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the king shall act as he pleases. (NRSV)

the king shall do whatever he wants

The king of the north will be able to rule however he wants.

the king: This seems to be a reference to the king of the North. However, the events described do not all seem to have taken place at the time of Antiochus IV. It is recommended that you leave this phrase as general as possible. If it is not natural to say just the king, you may wish to use an expression that connects or compares him to the king of verse 21 and say:

the vile/despicable king

the evil king

the king of the north

11:36b**and will exalt and magnify himself above every god,**

- He will be proud and brag about himself. He will think that he is greater than every god.
- He will boast and consider himself greater than every god.
- He will proudly declare that he is greater than any god that people worship.

and will exalt and magnify himself above every god: This verse part indicates that this king will want

people to view him as greater than the gods. He will demand that people give him more honor and respect than they give their gods. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He shall exalt himself and consider himself greater than any god (NRSV)

exalting himself and claiming to be greater than every god (NLT)

exalt and magnify himself above every god: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as exalt and magnify himself are literally “raise himself” and “make himself great.” Here the verbs are synonyms and together mean that his king will give himself great honor. In some languages it may be natural to combine them. For example:

highly honor himself above every god (GW)

boast that he is greater than any god (GNT)

proudly claim to be greater than any god (CEV)

magnify himself: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as magnify himself means “make himself great” or “show himself to be great.” Here this means that this king will try to make himself look great. That is, he will try to look powerful and important. See also 8:11a where a different form of the same verb is used. See the note there on “it set itself up to be as great as....”

every god: The phrase every god refers in general to the false gods and idols worshiped by the pagan peoples of the time. Here is another way to translate this:

every deity (NET)

11:36c**and he will speak monstrous things against the God of gods.**

- He will even say terrible things about the God of gods.
- He will even blaspheme against the Most High God.
- He will speak awful things against the one true God.

and he will speak monstrous things against the God of gods: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as monstrous things is more literally “extraordinary

things.” In this context they are extraordinary in a very bad way. Translate this using an expression that indicates that these things were shocking, evil, and blasphemous. For example:

and shall speak horrendous things against the God of gods (NRSV)

even blaspheming the God of gods (NLT)

he will say awful/shocking things against the God of gods

the God of gods: This is a title for Yahweh, the God of Israel. It indicates that Yahweh is greater than the so-called gods and deities that the other nations worshiped. He is the supreme God. In your translation, avoid indicating that other gods have actual existence. See how you translated the Aramaic phrase in 2:47b and see the note there. See also the similar phrase in Psalm 136:2 and Joshua 22:22a. Here are some possible ways to translate this title:

the Supreme God (GNT)

the Most High God (GECL)

11:36d

He will be successful until the time of wrath is completed,

- This king will continue to succeed until God’s anger has finished,
- The king will prosper until God will finish this period of judgment,
- The king will succeed at what he does until the time when God will finish judging his people,

He will be successful until the time of wrath is completed: This verse part indicates that there will be a limit to the success of the evil king. He will be successful for only a certain time, the time of wrath. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He shall prosper until the period of wrath is completed (NRSV)

He will succeed, but only until the time of wrath is completed. (NLT)

He will be able to do this until the time of wrath is over/finished

until the time of wrath is completed: This refers to a time that was still future when this was written. So in some languages it may be natural to use a future tense:

until the time of wrath will be completed

The phrase the time of wrath refers to God’s expression of his anger. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

until God is no longer angry (CEV)

11:36e

for what has been decreed must be accomplished.

- because what has been determined shall be done.
- because what God has planned will happen.
- for God will accomplish exactly what he has planned.

for what has been decreed must be accomplished:

This verse part indicates that what God has planned must take place. The verb has been decreed is passive and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

for what is determined shall be done (NRSV)

For what has been determined will surely take place (NLT)

- using an active verb. God is the implied subject. For example:

God will do exactly what he has planned. (GNT)

Translate this using the form that is most natural in your language.

Daniel 11:37

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:36–39

This paragraph speaks of the success of the evil king of the North. Some scholars take this king to still

be Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Other scholars understand this to refer to another evil king, like Antiochus, who has yet to come to power.^{11:35} See the footnote in the NET. It is recommended that you do not specify the identity of this king other than to refer to him as the king of the North (as he is called in 11:40b).

11:37a

He will show no regard for the gods of his fathers,

- ¶ The king will show/have no respect for the gods of his ancestors,
- ¶ The king will reject the gods his ancestors worshiped.

He will show no regard for the gods of his fathers:

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as He will show no regard for means that this king will deliberately neglect the traditional gods of his nation. He will not honor them. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He shall pay no respect to the gods of his ancestors, (NRSV)

He will have no respect for the gods of his ancestors (NLT)

This king will reject the gods his ancestors worshiped (CEV)

The king will ignore the god his ancestors served (GNT)

11:37b

nor for the one desired by women,

- nor for the god loved by women.
- He will also reject the god that women desire to worship.

nor for the one desired by women: The phrase the one desired by women probably refers to a pagan god that women honored and worshiped, perhaps in the hope of becoming pregnant. The king would ignore or reject this god also. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- using a passive verb. For example:

or for the god loved by women (NLT)

- using an active verb. For example:

and also the god that women love (GNT)

11:37c

nor for any other god,

- In fact, he will not respect any god,
- He will reject/ignore every god

nor for any other god: There is an ellipsis here. The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as “regard” in 11:37a is implied here. This phrase refers to honoring a deity. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He will not respect any god (NET)

he shall pay no respect to any other god (NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to leave the verb implicit here, as the NLT has done:

or for any other god (NLT)

11:37d

because he will magnify himself above them all.

- for he will consider/declare himself greater than all of them.
- and proclaim himself to be supreme over all.

because he will magnify himself above them all:

The function of the Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as because he will magnify himself above them all can be understood in several ways:

1. it gives the reason why this evil king behaves as he does. For example:

for he shall consider himself greater than all (NRSV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, NLT, ESV, GNT)

1. it is a contrast to the phrase “regard any god.” For example:

Instead, he will make himself more important than any god. (NCV) (NIV, NCV)

1. it is a summary statement that emphasizes 11:37a-b. For example:

In fact, he will put himself above all gods. (CEV) (NJB, CEV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This agrees with the normal meaning of the Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as because. The

NASB is therefore used as the Source Line in the Display. Here are some other ways to translate this:

for he will boast that he is greater than all (NLT)

because he will think he is greater than any of them (GNT)

magnify himself: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as magnify himself means to make oneself great or make oneself look great. This king wanted to be seen as very important and powerful, even more so than the gods that his people worshiped. See how you translated this word in 11:36b (the second verb, which the BSB translates as “magnify himself”). Compare also 8:4d, 8a, 11a, where different forms of the same verb are used.

Daniel 11:38

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:36–39

This paragraph speaks of the success of the evil king of the North. Some scholars take this king to still be Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Other scholars understand this to refer to another evil king, like Antiochus, who has yet to come to power.^{11:35} See the footnote in the NET. It is recommended that you do not specify the identity of this king other than to refer to him as the king of the North (as he is called in 11:40b).

11:38a

And in their place, he will honor a god of fortresses

- In their place, he will honor a god of fortresses.
- Instead of the gods of his fathers, he will worship a god of war, a god who protects fortified places.

And in their place, he will honor a god of fortresses:

This verse part tells which god the evil king would honor. He would honor a god who protects fortresses, that is, a warlike god.^{11:38} If the reference is still to Antiochus IV, then this god may be the Roman god Jupiter, whom the Greeks called Zeus. Antiochus built him a temple in the city of Antioch. In your translation, consider where and how it is natural to translate the phrase in their place (that is, instead of the gods of his ancestors). For example:

Instead of these, he will worship the god of fortresses (NLT)

He shall honor the god of fortresses instead of these (RSV)

What he will honor is a god of fortresses (NET)

11:38b

a god his fathers did not know—with gold, silver, precious stones, and riches.

- The ancestors of the king did not know/acknowledge this god. But the/this king will honor him with gifts of gold, silver, valuable stones and other treasures.
- The king will honor/worship this god whom his ancestors did not know. He will give gold, silver, precious stones, and other valuable gifts to this god.

a god his fathers did not know—with gold, silver, precious stones, and riches:

This verse part continues the thought of the previous verse part. It describes how the evil king would honor the god of fortresses whom he chose to worship.

a god his fathers did not know: This phrase describes this god of fortresses. This would be a god whom the ancestors of the evil king did not know, that is, worship. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb form. For example:

a god unknown to his ancestors (REB)

- using an active verb form. For example:

a god his ancestors never knew (NLT)

a god his ancestors never worshiped (GNT)

a god his ancestors never heard of (GW)

with gold, silver, precious stones, and riches: The text does not say exactly how the king would honor the god of fortresses. The thought may be that he would honor him by building him a beautiful temple, a temple decorated with gold and silver and precious stones. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and lavish on him gold, silver, precious stones, and expensive gifts (NLT)

With gold, silver, precious stones, and other expensive things he will honor (GW)

Daniel 11:39

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:36–39

This paragraph speaks of the success of the evil king of the North. Some scholars take this king to still be Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Other scholars understand this to refer to another evil king, like Antiochus, who has yet to come to power.^{11:35} See the footnote in the NET. It is recommended that you do not specify the identity of this king other than to refer to him as the king of the North (as he is called in 11:40b).

11:39a

He will attack the strongest fortresses with the help of a foreign god

- The king will attack the mightiest fortified places with the help of this foreign god.
- The king will conquer the strongest fortresses in the name of this god from a foreign/strange country.

He will attack the strongest fortresses with the help of a foreign god: There is a textual problem in this verse part. Some scholars suggest that the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the help should read “people.” The two options are:

1. The MT is correct. For example:

He shall deal with the strongest fortresses by the help of a foreign god. (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, RSV/NRSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The MT should be corrected. For example:

To defend his fortresses, he will use people who worship a foreign god. (GNT) (GNT, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), the reading of the MT, which is the recommendation of HOTTP also.

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the ideas in this clause:

Claiming this foreign god’s help, he will attack the strongest fortresses. (NLT)

With the help of this foreign god, he will capture the strongest fortresses. (CEV)

He will attack: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as He will attack is literally “he will act against.”

11:39b

and will greatly honor those who acknowledge him,

- And he will greatly honor those who acknowledge him as their ruler/king.
- He will give great honor to those who accept him as their ruler/king.

and will greatly honor those who acknowledge him:

There are at least two ways to interpret the pronoun him and the meaning of this clause:

1. The pronoun him refers to the evil king. For example:

He will give great honor to those who accept him as ruler (GNT) (GNT, NLT, NCV, probably NET, GW)

1. The pronoun him refers to the god of fortresses. For example:

Everyone who worships this god will be put in a position of power (CEV) (CEV)

Some English versions leave this ambiguous. If you must make it clear, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The evil king will give great honor to those who accept him as their king.

acknowledge him: In some languages it may be natural or necessary to make it explicit that this refers to acknowledging the evil king as the rightful ruler. However, in your translation, avoid implying that this means that the evil king was in fact the rightful ruler. Here are some other ways to translate this:

acknowledge him as the true ruler of the country (UBSH)

accept him as their king

submit to his rule

11:39c

making them rulers over many

- He will make them rulers over many people
- He will appoint them to positions of authority over many people.

11:39d**and distributing the land for a price.**

- and he will allow them to buy the land.
- He will also reward them by letting them purchase land cheaply.

11:39c–d

making them rulers over many and distributing the land for a price: This verse part explains in what ways the evil king will honor those who accept him as king. He will give them political power and property.

making them rulers over many: This clause indicates that the evil king will give his followers power to rule over other people. Here are some other ways to translate this:

The king will appoint them to positions of great authority.

He will put them in charge of many other people.

He will give them positions of great power.

and distributing the land for a price: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as and distributing the land for a price:

1. It means that the king will distribute land for a price; that is, he will make the new owners pay for the land. For example:

and he will parcel out land for a price (NET)

And he will make them pay him for the land they rule. (NCV) (BSB, NET, NCV, NIV, NJB, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, GW)

1. It means that the king will give out land as a reward. For example:

and dividing the land among them as their reward (NLT) |

he will reward them by giving them land (NLT, CEV, REB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of English versions. However, the second interpretation is also possible. If this is the interpretation of the Bible in your local majority language, you may wish to follow it.

Daniel 11:40**Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age**

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:40–45

This paragraph describes the final battles and end of the despicable king of the north.

11:40a**At the time of the end, the king of the South will engage him in battle,**

- ¶ At the time of the end, the king of the south will make war with him.
- ¶ Near the end of this period, the king of the south and his army will attack the king of the north.

At the time of the end: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as At the time of the end does not state of what this time is the end. Scholars disagree as to whether it is the end of the world or the end of the rule of the evil king of the North. It is recommended that you leave this as a general statement. For example:

When the end comes

When it is time for the end

the king of the South will engage him in battle: The Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as will engage him in battle means “will make war with him.” The king of the South will order his armies to attack the king of the North. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the king of the south will attack the king of the north (NLT)

the southern king will wage war against the northern king

11:40b**but the king of the North will storm out against him with chariots, horsemen, and many ships,**

- The king of the north will come like a storm against him, with chariots, horsemen, and many boats.
- The king of the north will rush out against him, supported by war carts/wagons, soldiers riding horses, and many war ships.

but the king of the North will storm out against him with chariots, horsemen, and many ships: This verse

part describes the response of the king of the North to the attack of the king of the South. He will counter-attack with a well-equipped army that includes horses and men who could fight on horseback, and also a large navy.

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Then the king of the north will storm against him with chariots, horsemen, and a large armada of ships. (NET)

The king of the North will attack with chariots, soldiers on horses, and many large ships. (NCV)

11:40c

invading many countries and sweeping through them like a flood.

- The king of the north will invade countries, defeat them and pass through them like a raging flood.
- The king of the north and his army will defeat country after country. He will pass through them and overwhelm/flood them.

invading many countries and sweeping through them like a flood: This clause continues to refer to the king of the North. The phrase sweeping through them like a flood is a simile. The invasion is compared to a flood. The point of comparison is overwhelming force of the invading army. Nothing could stop it. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- using a simile. For example:

He will invade lands, passing through them like an overflowing river. (NET)

He will invade many countries and sweep through their lands like a flood. (NCV)

- using a metaphor. For example:

Indeed, his forces will flood one country after another. (CEV)

- explaining the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

He will invade countries, overwhelm the, and pass through their land. (GW)

Translate this figure of speech in a way that is natural in your language and makes the meaning clear.

Daniel 11:41

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:40–45

This paragraph describes the final battles and end of the despicable king of the north.

11:41a

He will also invade the Beautiful Land,

- He will even enter the Land of Beauty.
- He will also invade the Glorious Land.

He will also invade the Beautiful Land: This clause indicates that the king of the North and his army would enter the land of Israel. See 11:16c, where the same phrase is used to describe the land of Israel. Translate it the same way here. For example:

Then he will enter the beautiful land. (NET)

He will also invade the Glorious Land.

He will lead his army into the Land of Beauty/
Splendor.

11:41b

and many countries will fall.

- Many thousands of people will fall victim to his attack,
- There will be tens of thousands of casualties/deaths.

and many countries will fall: The BSB has supplied the word countries. The Hebrew just says “many will fall/stumble.” It is also possible to supply the word “people”: “many people will fall.” However, there is a textual problem here.

1. The Hebrew text should read “tens of thousands will fall.” For example:

and tens of thousands will be defeated (GW) (RSV/ NRSV, ESV, REB, GW, GNT, CEV)

1. The MT is correct, which reads “many will fall.” For example:

and many nations will fall (NLT) (BSB, KJV, NIV, NASB, NET, NCV, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), the reading recommended by HOTTP. There is only a small vowel change from the MT and it is the reading of some ancient versions.

11:41c

But these will be delivered from his hand: Edom, Moab, and the leaders of the Ammonites.

- but Edom, Moab and the leaders of Ammon will escape from the king's power.
- However the countries of Edom and Moab will survive, and so will the leaders of the people of Ammon.

But these will be delivered from his hand: Edom, Moab, and the leaders of the Ammonites: The verb will be delivered is passive in the BSB. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- using a passive verb. For example:

But Edom, Moab and the leaders of Ammon will be saved from him (NCV)

- using an active verb. For example:

but these will escape: Edom, Moab, and the Ammonite leadership (NET)

Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language.

Daniel 11:42

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:40–45

This paragraph describes the final battles and end of the despicable king of the north.

11:42a

He will extend his power over many countries,

- The king of the north will extend his power into many countries.
- The king's power will reach into many other/foreign lands

He will extend his power over many countries: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as extend his power is literally “stretch out his hand.” This is an idiom that in this context means that the king of the

north will come to have power in many countries besides his own. Here are some other ways to translate this:

As he gets country after country into his grasp (REB)

His power will reach into many other countries

He will conquer many countries (NLT)

11:42b

and not even the land of Egypt will escape.

- Even Egypt will not be able to defend itself against his power.
- including the country/land of Egypt.

not even the land of Egypt will escape: The clause not even the land of Egypt will escape here means that the power of the king of the North would extend into Egypt. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the land of Egypt will not escape his hand/power

even Egypt will not be spared (GNT)

including Egypt (CEV)

Daniel 11:43

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:40–45

This paragraph describes the final battles and end of the despicable king of the north.

11:43a

He will gain control of the treasures of gold and silver and over all the riches of Egypt,

- The king of the north will take possession/control of all the treasures of gold and silver, as well as the other valuable things in Egypt.
- The king will seize all the riches of Egypt, including the treasures of gold and silver.

He will gain control of the treasures of gold and silver and over all the riches of Egypt: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as He will gain control of is literally “he will rule.” Use a verb that is appropriate

for controlling wealth and previous objects. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He shall become ruler of the treasures of gold and of silver, and all the riches of Egypt (NRSV)

he will seize control of her hidden stores of gold and silver and of all her treasures (REB)

he will have control over the hidden stores of gold and silver, as well as all the treasures of Egypt (NET)

He will take away Egypt's hidden treasures of gold and silver and its other prized possession. (GNT)

11:43b

and the Libyans and Cushites will also submit to him.

- The people from Libya and Cush will submit to his authority.
- He will conquer the people of Libya and Cush and make them his servants.

and the Libyans and Cushites will also submit to him: The people called the Cushites came from the land that is now known as Ethiopia. These people, and the people of Libya, would submit to the evil king.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as will... submit to him is literally "in his footsteps." This idiom here indicates that the Libyans and Cushites/Ethiopians would walk behind the king, conquered and humbled.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and Libyans and Ethiopians will follow at his heels (NASB)

Libyans and Cushites will follow in subjection to him (REB)

Libyans and Ethiopians will submit to him. (NET)

The people of Libya and Ethiopia will be subject to his authority.

Daniel 11:44

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:40–45

This paragraph describes the final battles and end of the despicable king of the north.

11:44a

But news from the east and the north will alarm him,

- But he will be alarmed by news from the east and the north.
- However, the king of the north will hear bad news from the east and the north of his empire. The news will terrify him.

But news from the east and the north will alarm him: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as news can mean "reports" or "rumors." It refers to things that one hears from others. The king would hear some things from the east and the north that would greatly disturb him. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But reports will trouble him from the east and north (NET)

Then news that comes from the east and the north will frighten him (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to make the king the subject of this clause. For example:

But he will be alarmed by news from the east and the north (CEV)

In other languages it may be natural to make the men who made the reports the subject. For example:

But his men in the east and the north will send him news/reports and alarm him.

11:44b

and he will go out with great fury to destroy many and devote them to destruction.

- As a result, he will set out in rage to completely destroy many people.
- He will become very angry and depart to kill many people.

and he will go out with great fury to destroy many and devote them to destruction: This clause tells what the king will do when he is alarmed by the reports from the east and the north. He will be very angry and will go with his army to destroy and kill many people. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and he shall go out with great fury to bring ruin and complete destruction to many (NRSV)

He will leave very angry to destroy and exterminate many. (GW)

to destroy many and devote them to destruction: In this context the verbs that the BSB translates as destroy and devote them to destruction are synonyms. Together they refer to total ruin. In some languages it may be natural to combine them into one verb phrase as the CEV has done:

and cause great destruction (CEV)

Daniel 11:45

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 11:40–45

This paragraph describes the final battles and end of the despicable king of the north.

11:45a

He will pitch his royal tents between the sea and the beautiful holy mountain,

- He will set up his royal tents between the sea and the glorious holy mountain.
- He and his army will camp between the sea and the beautiful mountain where the Temple is built.

He will pitch his royal tents between the sea and the beautiful holy mountain: There is a question of interpretation here regarding where the king would camp. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sea is plural. However, many commentators think that it refers to the Mediterranean alone. The two possibilities are:

1. the king will camp between the sea (the Mediterranean) and the holy mountain. For example:

He shall pitch his palatial tents between the sea and the beautiful holy mountain. (NRSV) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NJB, NCV, CEV, NLT, GNT, NABRE)

1. the king will camp between the seas (the Mediterranean and the Dead Sea). For example:

He will pitch his royal tents between the seas toward the beautiful holy mountain. (NET) (KJV, NASB, NIV, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), following the majority of English versions.

pitch his royal tents: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as his royal tents refers to the big luxurious tents that the king used to stay in when he was with his army in war time. To pitch tents means to set them up. So other ways to translate this include:

pitch his royal pavilion (REB)

set up his huge royal tents (GNT)

11:45b

but he will meet his end with no one to help him.

- But he will die and no one will come to help him.
- But he will meet his end. There will not be anyone who will help him.

but he will meet his end: The clause he will meet his end here means that the evil king will die.

with no one to help him: This clause indicates that the king would die alone, without comfort and assistance. Here are some other ways to translate this:

with no one to help him (NRSV)

with none to help him (ESV)

No one will give him any help.

Daniel 12:1

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:1–3

The angelic being who looked like a man (10:5, 16, 18, 20) continued to speak. He said that after a time

of great trouble God's people will receive great and eternal glory.

12:1a

“At that time Michael, the great prince who stands watch over your people, will rise up.

- ¶ “At that time Michael, the angel who watches over your^(sing) people, will rise on your^(plur) behalf.
- ¶ Then the angel said to me, “At that time, the angel Michael, who guards/protects your people, will stand up in order to help you.

At that time Michael, the great prince who stands watch over your people, will rise up: The speech of the angelic being began in 10:20. Some translations have chosen to supply the information that the same angel continues to speak here. For example:

The angel wearing linen clothes said, “At that time the great angel Michael, who guards your people, will appear. (GNT)

At that time: This phrase refers to the time of the fulfilment of the previous prophecy, which is the time of the rule and then death of the evil king.

Michael, the great prince who stands watch over your people: The Hebrew is more literally “Michael the great prince who stands over the sons of your people.” The idea here seems to be that Michael is responsible in some way for protecting the people of Israel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

the great prince who watches over your people (NET)

the great prince, Michael, who stands beside the sons of your people (NJPS)

Michael, the great prince: Michael is one of the archangels (chief or leading angels). He is also referred to as a prince in 10:13b, 21b. See the notes at 10:13b and 10:21b and see how you translated this title there. In some languages a literal translation may give the wrong meaning that Michael was a human ruler. Some English translations therefore make it explicit that he is an angel. For example:

the great angel Michael (GNT)

will rise up: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as will rise up is literally “will stand up.” In this context

it indicates that Michael will begin to take responsibility for God's people and act on their behalf.

General Comment on 12:1a

In some languages it may be more natural to rearrange the information in this verse part. For example:

At that time Michael will arise—the great Prince, defender of your people. (NJB)

At that time the great prince named Michael will arise. He/Michael is the defender/protector of your people.

12:1b

There will be a time of distress, the likes of which will not have occurred from the beginning of nations until that time.

- There will be a time of great distress. Nothing like it has ever happened since the nation first began.
- For they will be very troubled times. There has been nothing this bad/difficult since Israel/you^(plur) became a nation.

There will be a time of distress, the likes of which will not have occurred from the beginning of nations until that time: This verse part indicates that the distress at this time will be unlike any that has happened before. It is implied that the distress will be worse. The distress or troubles will be more severe. Here are some other ways to translate this:

It will be a time of trouble, the like of which has never been since the nation came into being. (NJPS)

There will be a time of distress unlike any other from the nation's beginning up to that time. (NET)

a time of distress: The phrase a time of distress means “a difficult/troubled time” or “a time in which people will experience distress.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

a period of anguish (REB)

a time of terrible suffering (CEV)

very troubled/difficult times

from the beginning of nations: The Hebrew is more literally “from when there was a nation/people.” There are two ways to understand this:

1. It means “since Israel became a nation/people.” For example:

from the nation’s beginning (NET) (NJPS, NET, REB, NABRE, probably KJV, NASB, ESV)

1. It means “from the time that nations in general began to exist.” For example:

since nations first came into existence (NJB) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, GNT, NIV, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as this more closely reflects the specific concerns of the writer, and since the Hebrew word for “nation” is singular. The NET is therefore used in the Display. However, either understanding is possible.

12:1c

But at that time your people—everyone whose name is found written in the book—will be delivered.

- However, at that time your^(plur) people will be delivered. All those whose names are written in God’s book will escape.
- But God will deliver your people from this distress. He will save all whose names are written in the book of life.

But at that time your people—everyone whose name is found written in the book—will be delivered: The people who will be delivered are described in two ways, as your people and as everyone whose name is found written in the book. The second phrase here probably limits the meaning of the first phrase, your people. Those of Daniel’s people whose names are written in the book will be delivered. Here are some other ways to translate this:

At that time your people will be rescued, all who are found inscribed in the book (NJPS)

All of your people whose names are written in the book will be delivered.

everyone whose name is found written in the book: The Hebrew text is more literally “everyone who is found written in the scroll.” The BSB and many other translations supply the word name. In some languages

it may be natural to use plural forms here. For example:

all those whose names are found written in the book (NET)

in the book: Scholars agree that this is a reference to the book of life. In this book God recorded the names of those whom he would deliver. This is a metaphor that refers to God’s choice and decision to deliver his people. There is a similar idea in Isaiah 4:3, Psalm 69:28, and Malachi 3:16–18.

will be delivered: This is a passive verb and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

will be rescued (NJPS)

- Using an active verb. For example:

will escape (NET)

God will deliver/rescue

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

Daniel 12:2

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:1–3

The angelic being who looked like a man (10:5, 16, 18, 20) continued to speak. He said that after a time of great trouble God’s people will receive great and eternal glory.

12:2a

And many who sleep in the dust of the earth will awake,

- Many who have died and lie buried in the dust/ground shall wake/rise from the dead.
- Many people who are dead and buried will return to life.

And many who sleep in the dust of the earth will awake: This verse part is a figurative way of referring to resurrection from the dead. Death is spoken of as sleep, and resurrection is spoken of as an awakening.

There are at least two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keeping the metaphor. For example:

Many of those that sleep in the dust of the earth will awake. (NJPS)

Many sleeping in the ground will wake up. (GW)

- Explaining or translating the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Many of those whose bodies lie dead and buried will rise up. (NLT)

Many of those who lie dead in the ground will rise from death. (CEV)

many: Some scholars think that the Hebrew word that the BSB literally translates as many is another way of saying “everyone.” However, all the English translations consulted say many, and it is recommended that you translate it in this way.

the dust of the earth: This is more literally “the land of dust.” It refers to the graves in the earth, the places where dead people are buried. Here is another way to translate this:

the dusty ground (NET)

12:2b

some to everlasting life,

- Some will wake/rise to receive/enjoy life forever.
- To some God will give everlasting life.

some to everlasting life: Here the verb “will awake” is implied from the previous verse part. The verb “to receive” or “to enjoy” is implied before the phrase everlasting life. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence and supply one or both verbs. For example:

Some will awaken to receive everlasting life

Some of them will wake up to have life forever (NCV)

If you have not translated the metaphor of sleep in 12:2a literally, then here you may say:

some of them will be given eternal life (CEV)

some will enjoy eternal life (GNT)

12:2c

but others to shame and everlasting contempt.

- But others will suffer shame and eternal disgrace.
- But others will receive/experience unending/permanent disgrace.

but others to shame and everlasting contempt:

Here also the verb “to receive” is implied. The verb “will awaken” is probably implied. For example:

but some will wake up to find shame and disgrace forever (NCV)

Here are some other ways to translate this:

other to reproaches, to everlasting abhorrence (NJPS)

and some will suffer eternal disgrace (GNT)

and others will receive nothing but eternal shame and disgrace (CEV)

shame and everlasting contempt: The two nouns shame and contempt are close synonyms. They both refer to a situation in which others rightly scorn and despise someone. The adjective everlasting applies to both shame and contempt, not just to contempt. If a literal translation is unnatural or would imply that the speaker is referring to two different things, only one of which is permanent, it may be best to combine the two ideas into one. For example:

eternal disgrace (GNT)

Daniel 12:3

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:1–3

The angelic being who looked like a man (10:5, 16, 18, 20) continued to speak. He said that after a time of great trouble God’s people will receive great and eternal glory.

12:3a

Then the wise will shine like the brightness of the heavens,

- Those who are wise will shine like the sky when it is bright with stars.
- The wise people will glow/shine with joy/glory like the sky glows/shines with stars.

Then the wise will shine like the brightness of the heavens:

This is a simile. It compares the glory that the wise will receive with the brightness of the sky. The righteous will be like the skies, that is, bright or glorious. As the skies at night are glorious with light, so wise people will be glorious with the joy and honor that God will give them. There are several ways to translate this:

- Keeping the simile. For example:

But the wise will shine like the brightness of the heavenly expanse. (NET)

- Explaining the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Wise people will be radiant with glory like the bright skies.

Wise people will be as glorious as the starry heavens!

Use the option that is most natural and clear in your language.

12:3b

and those who lead many to righteousness will shine like the stars forever and ever.

- These lead many to live right/good lives. They will shine brightly forever like the stars in the sky.
- Yes, these people lead others to live right/good lives and so they will be as glorious as the stars for all eternity.

and those who lead many to righteousness will shine like the stars forever and ever: This is a second simile. Righteous people will shine like the stars forever. This is a figurative way of saying that they will receive and enjoy great glory. Again, there is more than one way to translate this:

- Keeping the simile. For example:

Those who teach others to live right will shine like stars forever and ever. (NCV)

- Explaining the meaning of the simile. For example:

People who lead many others to righteousness will be forever as glorious as the stars!

those who lead many to righteousness: This phrase refers to the same wise teachers and leaders as “the wise” in 12:3a. These wise teachers will lead God’s people to live in righteousness. In some languages it may be natural to imply this by saying:

yes, those who lead many to righteousness

many: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as many is more literally “the many.” Here it refers to all those who remain faithful to Yahweh.

the many (NJPS)

like the stars forever and ever: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the stars refers to the bright lights in the sky that the people could see at night. The stars gave light and by their positions helped to guide people who were traveling at night.

General Comment on 12:3a–b

These verse parts form a parallelism. They say the same thing in two different ways, using two similar similes. “The wise” are the same people as “those who lead many to righteousness.” If a literal translation would suggest that they are two different groups of people, it may be better to combine the similes into one. For example:

Those wise people who lead others to righteousness will shine forever like the sun or the stars.

Daniel 12:4

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:4

The angelic figure in white linen now gave Daniel some final instructions.

12:4a

But you, Daniel, shut up these words and seal the book until the time of the end.

- ¶ “But as for you, Daniel, roll up this scroll and seal it up. Keep its message hidden until the time of the end.

- ¶ “But Daniel, I want you to close this book now and keep its words/message secret. Put a seal on it until the time period of the end.

But you, Daniel, shut up these words and seal the book until the time of the end: The Hebrew text that the BSB translates as shut up these words and seal the book is more literally “shut/stop up the words and seal up the scroll.” This is a figure of speech using the image of a sealed scroll. In Daniel’s time, people generally wrote on long scrolls that were rolled up, rather than in books with many pages that could be shut. The writer would put a wax seal on the edge of the rolled scroll so that it could not be easily opened by those for whom it was not intended. He did this to keep his message secret, and this is the point of comparison here. See also the note on 8:26b.

There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- keeping the metaphor in both verbs. For example:

But you, Daniel, shut up the words, and seal the book, until the time of the end. (RSV)

And now, Daniel, close the book and put a seal on it until the end of the world. (GNT)

- keeping the metaphor in one verb and explaining its meaning in the other verb. For example:

But you, Daniel, must keep these words secret and keep the book sealed until the time of the End. (NJB)

- combining the verbs and explaining the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Daniel, I now command you to keep the message of this book secret until the end of time. (CEV)

Translate this figure of speech in a way that makes the meaning clear in your language and culture.

But you, Daniel: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a specific command to Daniel himself. In some languages it may be natural to introduce this command in a different way. For example:

And now, Daniel (GNT)

Daniel, I now command you (CEV)

the book: In Daniel’s day scrolls were mostly made of parchment (from the papyrus reed). Sheets of papyrus were glued together and wound around a stick about a foot long. See how you translated the word book in Luke 4:17, 20.

12:4b

Many will roam to and fro, and knowledge will increase.”

- Many will rush here and there in search of knowledge.”
- In the meantime, many people will roam/travel about trying hard to understand what is happening.”

Many will roam to and fro, and knowledge will increase: This verse part describes what would happen while the scroll remained sealed. People would travel seeking knowledge.

Many will roam to and fro: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Many will roam to and fro indicates that people will travel to various distant places. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Many will dash about (NET)

Many will travel everywhere (GW)

Many will rush to and fro (REB)

and knowledge will increase: There is a textual problem here:

1. The Hebrew text says that knowledge will increase. For example:

trying to gain such knowledge (REB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some scholars suggest that the Hebrew text originally said that evil will increase. For example:

and wickedness will continue to increase (NJB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the MT and the majority of English versions.

knowledge will increase: In some languages it may be natural or necessary to translate the noun knowledge as a verb. For example:

trying to understand what is happening (GNT)

Daniel 12:5

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:5–7

Daniel heard three angelic figures talking to one another by the river.

12:5a

Then I, Daniel, looked and saw two others standing there,

- ¶ I, Daniel continued to look at the vision. Suddenly, two figures/beings appeared and stood before me.
- ¶ I continued looking when suddenly I saw two more angelic beings standing there in front of me.

Then I, Daniel, looked and saw two others standing there: In his vision Daniel next saw two other figures or angelic beings. Here are some other ways to translate this:

I, Daniel, watched as two others stood there, one on each side of the river. (NET)

Then I, Daniel, looked, and two others appeared (NRSV)

two others: The phrase two others refers to two other living beings or figures who looked like men but who were probably angels. If you must indicate who these two others were, try to use a general expression. For example:

two other figures

two other people (CEV)

12:5b

one on this bank of the river and one on the opposite bank.

- One of them was standing on this side of the river. The other stood on the other side.
- They stood on the two sides of the river.

one on this bank of the river and one on the opposite bank: The Hebrew more literally says “one here to the bank/edge of the river and one here to the bank/edge of the river.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

one on this side of the river and one on the other side (CEV)

one on each side of the river (NET)

General Comment on 12:5a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the information in these verse parts or record it in a different order. For example:

Then I saw two men standing by a river, one on each bank. (GNT)

Then I, Daniel, looked and saw two others standing on opposite banks of the river. (NLT)

Daniel 12:6

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:5–7

Daniel heard three angelic figures talking to one another by the river.

12:6a

One of them said to the man dressed in linen, who was above the waters of the river,

- The man/angel clothed in linen was standing above the waters of the stream. One of the two figures/beings said to him,
- At the same time the angel who was clothed in linen stood above the river. One of the other two beings/angels asked him a question:

One of them said to the man dressed in linen, who was above the waters of the river: One of these two figures spoke to the figure who had just been speaking, the figure who looked like a man dressed in linen clothes. He asked him a question (12:6b). Identify the two actors in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

One said to the man clothed in linen who was above the waters of the river (NET)

One of them asked the man dressed in linen clothes who was above the river (GW)

In some languages this quote introducer may be too long to be natural. It may be necessary to translate it as a separate sentence. For example:

One of them questioned/queried the man dressed in linen clothes who was above the river. He said/asked...

One of them said: There is a textual problem here:

1. The Hebrew text has a third-person verb. For example:

One said (NET) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, NRSV, ESV, NJB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV, NABRE)

1. One early Greek translation has a first-person verb. For example:

And I said (RSV) (RSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow the MT and option (1).

who was above the waters of the river: This describes the position of the man clothed in linen. However, the meaning of the phrase above the waters of the river is unclear. There are at least two ways to interpret it:

1. This angelic figure was standing on or above the river rather than standing on the ground. For example:

who was above the river (GW) (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NIV, REB, NET, GW, NLT, NCV)

1. This angelic figure was further up the river, closer to its source, standing on the ground upstream from the other angelic beings. For example:

who was upstream (NRSV) (NRSV, NJB, GNT, CEV)

Scholars disagree as to which interpretation is most like correct. You may wish to follow your major or national language version here.

12:6b

“How long until the fulfillment of these wonders?”

- “How long will these wondrous things continue?”
- “When will these shocking/amazing things end?”

How long until the fulfillment of these wonders?:

There are two ways to interpret this question:

1. It asks how long it will be until these wonders end. For example:

When will the end of these wondrous events occur? (NET)

How long will it be until these miracles are over? (GW) (NET, REB, GW, GNT, NLT, NABRE, KJV, NASB, RSV/NRSV, ESV)

1. It asks how long it will be until these wonders occur. For example:

How long until these wonders take place? (NJB)

How long before these amazing things happen? (CEV) (NJB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The BSB can probably be considered as ambiguous.

Daniel 12:7

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:5–7

Daniel heard three angelic figures talking to one another by the river.

12:7a

And the man dressed in linen, who was above the waters of the river, raised his right hand and his left hand toward heaven,

- Then the man clothed in linen, who was above the waters of the river, raised both his hands toward heaven.
- The angel dressed in linen clothes standing above the river now raised both his hands/arms upward toward God.

And the man dressed in linen, who was above the

waters of the river: The subject of the clause in 12:7a, the man dressed in linen, is described as in 12:6a. It is good to refer to him in the same or a similar way here. For example:

the man dressed in linen clothes who was above the river (GW)

raised his right hand and his left hand toward heaven: The angelic being raised his hands toward heaven. This is an action that implies appealing to God. This was a customary action when swearing an oath. See Genesis 22:14 and Deuteronomy 32:40. Here the angel raised both hands, to imply that his oath was particularly solemn. In some languages this action may be more naturally described in a slightly different way. For example:

raised his hands toward heaven (NCV)

raised both hands toward the sky (GNT)

lifted his arms toward God in heaven

12:7b

and I heard him swear by Him who lives forever,

- I heard him swear an/this oath by/in the name of the One who lives forever.
- Then he took an oath in the name of the Eternal God. I heard him

and I heard him swear by Him who lives forever, saying: This verse part introduces what Daniel heard the angelic figure say. The angelic figure made an oath, a solemn promise, in the name of God. He appealed to God as his witness that what he said was true. Use the oath formula that is natural in your language.

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. It may also be natural to make it explicit that the phrase Him who lives forever refers to God. For example:

And I heard him swear by the name of God who lives forever (NCV)

General Comment on Daniel 12:7a–b

There are several ways to order the information in these verse parts. For example:

I heard the man dressed in linen clothes who was above the river. He raised his right hand and left hand to heaven and swore an oath by the one who lives forever. He said... (GW)

The angel raised both hands toward the sky and made a solemn promise in the name of the Eternal God. I heard him say,... (GNT)

12:7c

saying, “It will be for a time, and times, and half a time.”

- He declared, “It will be for one period of time, two periods of time, and a half a period.
- say, “It will last one year, two years, and a half a year.

It will be for a time, and times, and half a time: This expression probably refers to a period of three and a half year (one year, two years, and half a year). In some languages it may be necessary to translate it in this way. For example:

It will be three and a half years. (GNT)

12:7d

When the power of the holy people has finally been shattered,

- When the power of the holy people has been completely shattered/ended,
- A time will come when they will finish breaking the power of God’s people,

When the power of the holy people has finally been shattered: The Hebrew text here is difficult to interpret and the text is uncertain. It is more literally “and when he/they finish shattering [the] hand of a people of holiness” (Steinmann). “Hand” is often a metaphor for power. Here is another way to translate this:

when the shattering of the power of the holy people comes to an end (NRSV)

This clause probably means that the holy people will be persecuted until their power is brought to an end. The angelic man in linen was now answering the question in 12:6b. He related his answer to what he had said in 11:32 (“the people who know their God will firmly resist him”). English versions translate this answer in two main ways:

- using a passive verb. For example:

When the power of the holy people has been completely shattered (GW)

- using an active verb. For example:

as soon as they finish shattering the power of the holy people (NASB)

Use the option that sounds most natural in your language.

12:7e

all these things will be completed.”

- all these events will end.”
- and then these things will last no longer.”

all these things will be completed: This is a reference back to the question in 12:6b as to when these things (or “these wonders”) would end. Here are some other ways to translate this:

all these things will be finished (NET)

this will be the time of the completion of all these things

at this time all these things will come to an end

General Comment on 12:7d–e

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 12:7d–e. For example:

All these things will end when the persecution of God’s people is over/finished.

General Comment on 12:7b–e

In some languages it may be natural to report the angel’s words as indirect speech. For example:

And I heard him swear by the one who lives forever that it would be for a time, two times, and half a time, and that when the shattering of the power of the holy people comes to an end, all these things would be accomplished. (NRSV)

Daniel 12:8

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:8

This paragraph gives Daniel’s response to what he had heard.

12:8a

I heard, but I did not understand.

- ¶ I heard what the angel said, but I did not understand it.

- ¶ I heard the/his answer, but I could not understand what it/he meant.

I heard, but I did not understand: In some languages it may be natural to supply an object to either or both of the verbs heard and understand. Here are some ways to do this:

I heard him, but I did not understand. (GW)

I heard what he said, but I did not understand it. (GNT)

12:8b

So I asked, “My lord, what will be the outcome of these things?”

- So I asked, “Sir, how will all these things end?”|
- So I asked the angel, “Sir, how will all these events finally end?”

So I asked, “My lord, what will be the outcome of these things?”: Daniel asked the angelic figure what would be the end result of everything he had been hearing about. Here are some other ways to translate this:

So I asked him, “Sir, how will these things end?” (GW)

So I asked, “But, sir, how will it all end?” (GNT)

Daniel 12:9

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:9–13

In this paragraph the angelic figure encouraged Daniel to persevere. He promised that at the end of time God will resurrect and reward those who persevere in righteousness.

12:9a

“Go on your way, Daniel,” he replied,

- ¶ But he said, “You may go on your way, Daniel,
- ¶ But he replied, “Daniel, you may go now.

“Go on your way, Daniel,” he replied: The BSB places the words he replied in the middle of what the angelic figure said to Daniel. This is good English style. However, in some languages, it may be necessary to place

these words at the beginning on 12:9a, where they are in the Hebrew text. For example:

He replied, “Go on your way, Daniel...” (NIV)

The angel replied to Daniel by giving him encouragement to continue his life, which was a life of faithful service. Daniel could go and continue fulfilling the duties he was given. Avoid translating this in a way that suggests that the angelic figure was telling Daniel to go away because he did not want to talk to him anymore.

Go on your way, Daniel: You should translate this command in a positive way that implies that God was pleased with Daniel’s way, that is, his manner of life. The angel was not rebuking Daniel. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Daniel, go about your business (CEV)

You may go/continue on your way, Daniel.

12:9b

“for the words are closed up and sealed until the time of the end.

- for these words/matters must/will remain secret and sealed/hidden until the time of the end.
- For what I have told you to write will be kept secret in the book until the time of the end.

for the words are closed up and sealed until the time of the end: This verse part gives the reason why Daniel could go on his way in peace. The things he had heard and written about were not for his time. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

For these matters are closed and sealed until the time of the end. (NET)

the words are closed up and sealed: This is a figure of speech. The words that the angel had spoken are referred to as if they were themselves a scroll that Daniel had rolled up and sealed, so that it could not be read. Daniel had been commanded to do this in 12:4a. Here in 12:9b the scroll is not mentioned explicitly, but the verbs are the same. In your translation, try to use the same verbs that you used in 12:4a so that readers can see the connection and understand that Daniel obeyed the command.

Here are some ways to translate this figure of speech:

- you may keep the figure of speech in both verbs. For example:

the words are shut up and sealed (ESV)

- you may explain that the phrase the words is a reference to the words written in the scroll book. For example:

the words in this scroll/book have been sealed shut

- you may keep the figure of speech in one of the verbs and explain its meaning in the other. For example:

the words are to remain secret and sealed until the time of the end (NRSV)

- you may translate just the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

these words are to be kept secret and hidden (GNT)

The verbs are closed up and sealed are both passives. The implied actor is Daniel (from 12:4a), or possibly God himself, who caused the words to be rolled up and sealed. So there are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- using passive verbs. For example:

is closed up and sealed (NCV)

- using active verbs. For example:

you^(sing) are to keep these words secret and conceal their meaning

Daniel 12:10

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:9–13

In this paragraph the angelic figure encouraged Daniel to persevere. He promised that at the end of time God will resurrect and reward those who persevere in righteousness.

12:10a**Many will be purified, made spotless, and refined,**

- During that time, God will purify many people, make them clean, and refine them by trials.
- During that period of time, God will test many people and refine them by trials.

Many will be purified, made spotless, and refined:

These three ideas are synonyms. Their meaning is very similar in this context. The three verbs are all passives. The implied actor is God. He will purify his people, make them spotless, and refine them through the trials that they will endure. Here are some ways to translate this:

- using passive verbs. For example:

Many will be purified, cleansed, and refined by these trials. (NLT)

- using active verbs. For example:

God will purify many people. He will make them spotless and refine them.

12:10b**but the wicked will continue to act wickedly.**

- But the wicked will keep on doing wicked things.
- But evil people will persist in evil-doing.

but the wicked will continue to act wickedly: In spite of what God is doing for many people (12:10a), wicked people will continue to be wicked. This clause indicates that those who are evil will continue to act in evil ways. They will not allow God to purify them. Here are some other ways to translate this:

But the wicked will continue in their wickedness (NLT)

But those who are evil will keep on being evil (CEV)

The wicked will persist in doing wrong (NJB)

12:10c**None of the wicked will understand,**

- None of them will understand what I have told you about.
- None of the wicked will understand why these things are happening.

None of the wicked will understand: In some languages it may be necessary to supply an object for the verb understand. For example:

Those wicked people will not understand these things (NCV)

None of the wicked: The phrase None of the wicked refers back to the wicked people mentioned in the previous verse part. Refer back in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

none of them (GW)

those wicked people (NCV)

12:10d**but the wise will understand.**

- But those who are wise will understand these things.
- But those who have insight will understand what is happening.

but the wise will understand: This clause contrasts “the wicked” with the wise. The wicked people are not included among the wise. They are a separate group. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Only the wise will understand. (CEV)

only those who are wise will understand (GNT)

Only wise people will understand. (GW)

As in 12:10c, in some languages it may be natural to supply an object for the verb understand :

but the wise will understand them (NCV)

General Comment on 12:10c–d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 12:10c–d, putting the positive statement first. For example:

^{10d}Wise people will understand these things, ^{10c}but none of the wicked will understand.

Daniel 12:11

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:9–13

In this paragraph the angelic figure encouraged Daniel to persevere. He promised that at the end of time God will resurrect and reward those who persevere in righteousness.

12:11a–c

And from the time the daily sacrifice is abolished and the abomination of desolation set up, there will be 1,290 days: This clause gives the beginning point for a certain time period. The time period is equal to about three and a half years. The significance of the number of days is uncertain, and it is best to translate the number literally. For example:

One thousand two hundred and ninety days will go by after the daily sacrifice is abolished and the abomination that causes desolation is set up.

If it is not natural in your language to express such a number exactly, you may need to say something like:

The days of three and a half years will pass after the daily sacrifice is ended and the horrible sacrifice is set up

12:11a

And from the time the daily sacrifice is abolished

- From the time when the daily sacrifice is abolished
- From the time when they stop offering the regular/continual burnt offering

And from the time the daily sacrifice is abolished:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *is abolished* literally means “is removed, is turned away.” The daily sacrifice was to be removed or abolished in the sense that it was no longer offered. This is probably primarily a reference to the action of Antiochus IV in 167 B.C. See the notes on 8:11–13, where this same action is described using different verbs.

This is a passive clause and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

From the time that the regular burnt offering is taken away (NRSV)

From the time that the daily sacrifice is removed (NET)

- using an active verb with a general subject. For example:

from when they abolish the daily sacrifice

the daily sacrifice: This refers to the practice of offering a daily sacrifice. It does not refer to one specific sacrifice. So in some languages it may be natural to say:

the daily sacrifices

The same phrase is used to refer to the same sacrifices in 8:11b. Translate it here in the same way as you did there. For example:

the regular burnt offering (NRSV)

the regular offering (REB)

the set/regular offerings

12:11b

and the abomination of desolation set up,

- and an abominable/disgusting object is set up, an object that causes destruction,
- that is, from the time someone sets up in the Temple a pagan thing/idol that destroys everything,

and the abomination of desolation set up: Scholars agree that this is also a reference to the actions of Antiochus IV. He placed an altar to the pagan god Zeus in God’s Temple in Jerusalem, and pigs and other unclean animals were offered there. This is also a passive clause and there at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

and the abomination that causes desolation is set in place (NET)

- using an active verb. Try to use a general subject. For example:

they/men set up the abominable thing that causes desolation

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

the abomination of desolation: See 9:27c, where the same phrase occurs in the plural form, and 11:31c. Translate this here as you did there. For example:

the abomination that makes desolate (ESV)

the disgusting thing that causes destruction (GW)

the desolating sacrilege (NRSVUE)

12:11c

there will be 1,290 days.

- there will be one thousand, two hundred and ninety days.
- 1,290 days will pass.

there will be 1,290 days: The BSB has supplied the words there will be, which are not in the Hebrew text. The meaning is that 1,290 days would pass. You should supply the verb that is natural in your language. For example:

there are 1,290 days (NET)

1,290 days will pass (GNT)

1,290 days: This number of days represents three and a half years. However, it is recommended that you translate it literally. In some languages it may be natural to write out this large figure in words:

a thousand two hundred and ninety days (NJB)

Daniel 12:12

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:9–13

In this paragraph the angelic figure encouraged Daniel to persevere. He promised that at the end of time God will resurrect and reward those who persevere in righteousness.

12:12

Blessed is he who waits and reaches the end of the 1,335 days.

- Those who persevere/endure until the end of the one thousand three hundred and thirty-five days will be truly happy!
- God will bless those who faithfully wait throughout the 1,335 days.

Blessed is he who waits and reaches the end of the 1,335 days: There are two ways to understand this verse part:

1. It means that those who live through all the 1,335 days are blessed. For example:

Happy are those who wait and live to see the completion of one thousand three hundred and thirty-five days! (REB) (BSB, NIV, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV, REB, probably NJB, NABRE)

1. It means that those who patiently live up to the beginning of the 1,335 days are blessed, that is, those who live to see those days. For example:

Blessed is he who waits and come to the thousand three hundred and thirty-five days (RSV) (RSV, ESV, KJV, probably NASB, NRSV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), See the UBS Handbook, page 335, Miller, page 236, Lucas, page 298 (“the suffering has a time limit and will end fairly soon”), Hartman and Di Lella, page 261, along with the majority of English versions and several scholars. God counts or declares Blessed those who patiently endure until the end of the 1,335 days.

Blessed is he who waits: The people who patiently wait are Blessed in the sense that their situation is truly good, however it might appear, for God will reward them. Refer to how you translated this in Psalm 1:1, 32:1 and Matthew 5:3–11. Since God will bless anyone and everyone who waits in this way, in some languages it may be more natural to use plural forms. For example:

Happy are those who remain faithful (GNT)

God will bless everyone who patiently waits (CEV)

How good it will be for those who wait

the 1,335 days: This time period is equal to the 1,290 days mentioned in 12:11c plus a further 45 days. The significance of these extra days is not known, and you should try to translate literally.

Daniel 12:13

Section 10:1–12:13: Daniel saw a vision of an angelic man and the end of the age

In this long final vision, Daniel was told of events leading up to the end of the age.

Paragraph 12:9–13

In this paragraph the angelic figure encouraged Daniel to persevere. He promised that at the end of time God will resurrect and reward those who persevere in righteousness.

12:13a

But as for you, go on your way until the end.

- As for you, go your way till the end.
- And you, Daniel, be faithful until the end of your life.

But as for you, go on your way until the end: There is a textual problem here. Some Hebrew manuscripts do not contain the words until the end and therefore some English versions omit them. The two options are:

1. The original text contained the words until the end. For example:

So, Daniel, be faithful until the end! (CEV)

But you should go your way until the end. (NET) (BSB, NIV, NET, CEV, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB, GW, GNT, NLT, NCV)

1. The original text did not contain the words until the end. For example:

But you, go your way (NRSV) (NRSV, NJB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you include the words until the end, along with the majority of English versions. This probably means “until the end of your life.”

12:13b

You will rest,

- You are going to lie down and rest,
- You will die,

You will rest: This is a euphemism, a figure of speech referring to death. Use the expression that is most natural in your language. For example:

You will sleep

You will lie down

Then you will die (GNT)

12:13c

and will arise to your inheritance at the end of the days.”

- but at the end of all things/history you will rise/live again to receive what God has/wants to give you.”
- but at the end of time, you will rise from the dead and receive your reward.”

and will arise to your inheritance at the end of the

days: The angel promised Daniel that at the end of the days he would be given resurrection to new life and reward from God. Here are some other ways to translate this:

and at the end you will rise to receive your reward (NCV)

and at the end of time, you will rise from death to receive your reward (CEV)

and then at the end of the days, you will rise again to receive the inheritance set aside for you (NLT)

will arise: In this context the verb phrase will arise is a promise that Daniel will come alive again after his death, a promise of resurrection.

your inheritance: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as your inheritance refers to a share or portion that is inherited from someone or given by someone. In this case God is the one who gives the share or portion. He will give Daniel this share or portion when he raises him from the dead at the end of human history.

at the end of the days: The phrase at the end of the days refers to the end of history, the end of this earth as we know it. It does not have the same meaning as “the end” in 12:13a, which refers to the end of Daniel’s life.